For the Love of a Princess

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For the Love of a Princess

by StarryNap

Summary

"As C'yra slides her cold hand inside the lukewarm cocoon of Adora's own, the latter knows that this person is to be omen the most dearest thing. She feels like crying.

She feels like falling a little bit in love"

.

Or

King Adora Pendragon is to marry Princess C'yra of Half Moon in order to protect Etheria from the threaten of the Horde Empire. Little do they know the greatest adventure of them all awaits for them as they discover love, family and the danger of those who seeks to turn them apart.

Nominated as Best Fic for the 2022 She-Ra Awards

Completed!

Chapter 1: In the middle of the heart

Chapter Notes

Hello! Welcome to the Camelot AU!

This is my first writing in years and after all the love this story received on Instagram I'm really excited for all of you to know the full story.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

ARC I. STRENGTH

CHAPTER 1. In the middle of the heart

SUMMER

Had I the heavens' embroidered cloths,

Enwrought with golden and silver light,

The blue and the dim and the dark cloths

Of night and light and the half-light,

I would spread the cloths under your feet:

But I, being poor, have only my dreams;

I have spread my dreams under your feet;

Tread softly because you tread on my dreams.

-William Butler Yeats

Music that inspired this chapter: x x

❀

Adora has no idea what is happening.

There is a swirl of motion around them. Ribbons, and rose petals, and food and perfume. The ladies of the court are laughing in other rooms, and the sound of the knights´ chattering travels through the open window. There are at least six people in the room, picking up clothes, fabrics and flowers; chatting with each other in loud voices.

It´s hell on earth.

Glimmer disappeared somewhere fifteen minutes ago, and they hadn't seen Bow since yesterday. Adora knows that they are trying their best, for them, but their mind just can´t focus and it's starting to get the best of her. On good days, concentrating is not a hard task anymore, it takes a bit of effort, but they can manage. On bad days, it feels like a fog has clouded their mind, impenetrable and noisy.

Today is one of those days.

Adora returns her sight to the silver mirror, her own blue-gray eyes meet her. She can't recognize the person that looks back.

Glimmer insisted on being in charge of their formal clothes, assuring that “No Adora, darling, you can´t wear your old and dirty knight pants to your own wedding”. His hair is free from the usual comfortable ponytail and instead it´s held tightly in a heavy braid all the way down his back. There are little golden rings intertwined with the ash hair strands, and sparkling jewels crossing the entire line of the fresh done undercut in intricate designs. He is wearing a long and heavy cape draped against both shoulders with golden clasps, of a rich black and red color. Golden embroideries of winged dragons run along the entire fabric. Her vest, high pants and boots are also black and expensive, with little snippets of golden here and there.

Now, red is understandable, is the color of the Pendragon family, passed from generation to generation since the times of Uther, the Mad King. But black, black is a bold choice. It's meant for grief, for mourning. To Adora, is a sign of rebellion, a little piece of independence and control. A reminder that this is not only a wedding, it's a bargain.

Light Hope, the Royal Counselor of Camelot, had been frightfully quiet when she found out about Adora´s choice. They saw her pressing her lips in a thin line and that oh so familiar vein popping on her forehead, the same way as many times during childhood, when Adora would return to their quarters matted on mud, with scraped knees and missing teeth. Light Hope herself always dresses in black, long forgotten her cream and purple tunics, her skull short hair hidden under the dark fabric of her perpetual mourning. Yet, Light Hope had said nothing.

As a matter of fact, Light Hope hadn´t said much since Mara´s death.

Adora shakes their head and tries to ignore the little gold wing clasped on the vest.

"Adora!" Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon and High Sorceress of Avalon, bursts into the room, her lilac dress tangled around her legs. Bow, her husband, running behind her with an apologetic look on his handsome face "Adora! Are you listening? You should have been out of this room ten minutes ago!"

"What she means is" adds Bow, huffing as discreet as possible "They are ready for you. *We* are ready for you, Adora. We are here" there is a soft smile of his face, reassuring, it makes Adora want to cry. And when Adora turns their eyes to Glimmer, they can see that the determined face of her best friend has melted into the same quiet loving expression "You are not alone"

Glimmer steps in and it´s only then when Adora spots the crown that she holds on her hands. It's big and opulent, and it feels heavy on their head when Adora bows towards her friend and allows her to set it in place. It's also the same crown Mara wore on her own wedding.

There is a small gasp coming from their best friends when they straighten their back and Adora can feel their arms and hands start to tremble slightly. Glimmer takes her right hand, that little and familiar sparkle of magic dancing on Adora´s skin when their palms touch. Bow takes the other, warm and strong and there.

"It is going to be fine. We are by your side" says Glimmer, smiling "And as far as I´ve heard, she can´t be that bad. If you don´t mind the fangs of course."

Adora chuckles, shaking their head in amusement. Yet another spark of anxiety over this complete stranger threats with shake her again

Bow pulls her hand carefully and pats her shoulder, the matching earring sparkling in the light of the sun "Let´s go, shall we?"

Adora breaths deep several times before squeezing their friends' hands in return. Both of them start walking toward the heavy doors of the room holding hands. Adora looks at them for a few seconds, he sees their love pouring to each other naturally and beautifully, and for a split of a second, Adora wonders.

His eyes travel to the window at his side . The soft colors of the dawn greet them the same way as many days before. They can see the sharp edges of the mountains and all the green shades of trees. Down below they can hear the excited murmur of her beloved kingdom. She would do anything for them.

King Adora straightens their back once more and promptly leaves for their own wedding.

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Camelot does not exist.

It is not in any map or book or parchment. If you ask how to find it, the people will look at you out of the corner of their eye, and ignore you while they speak in low voices among each other.

It´s a myth, a fairytale, a legend told to the children about a kingdom that glows with magic and life. So no, Camelot does not exist, unless you know it does. If you want to go to Camelot you need to know the path for yourself or being invited by a royal member. This is important. You can´t accidentally stumble into it. There are no shortcuts. Just a member of Camelot can find Camelot.

The other Kingdoms of Etheria know about it, of course, but each one has an ambassador and they take care of both the political and travel matters. Camelot lives safely inside a shield of magic, one last gift from Merlin before disappearing forever.

Camelot has been living at war for as long as it can be remembered. At war with magic when King Uther used to rule with an iron hand and a cursed throne. At war with itself, brother against sister, son against father, friend against friend. And then the magic was free again and it flooded through its people, along every brick and stone and leaf and river, a time of golden peace fell over the kingdom. And the legend of the sword in a stone became that, a Legend.

But peace never lasts much, not when there are bigger evils outside, just waiting for the right moment to swallow them whole.

By all means, King Mara should have been grown as a cold warrior, ready to give any order necessary, shoot the arrow, draw the sword, kill the obstacle. King Mara should have grown to be every bit her father and grandfather.

She was different. King Mara Pendragon was a formidable soldier. Strong, smart, unyielding. But she was also soft. A kind ruler. A good person. King Mara held herself with beauty and strength. She was raised amidst the worst of her father's war, and saw the horrors beforehand. But she led her people with kindness and hope.

Uther raised Arthur like a dragon

Arthur raised Mara like a soldier

Mara raised Adora like a mother

But war is nothing but unjust and her time came and went in the split of a second. Mara's early death was a blow for everyone, for every kingdom and ruler, for each peasant and royal. The entirety of Etheria swayed under the weight of the tragedy . Adora was eighteen at the time, no longer a child and barely an adult. But they were smart and prepared, Mara had raised them so when the time came and the crown was placed on Adora´s head, they took the place of the King with dignity and wisdom.

It didn't make it any easier. King Adora spent their days training the knights, ruling the kingdom, battling an endless war with the Horde Empire, trying to repair the destruction that it left in its wake. Adora, spent their nights crying under the overwhelming pressure, over the endless loss. On the few free days they could find, Adora would pass the time with Madame Razz, an old lady that lived in a lonely tower, far from the castle and the town. Razz had helped raise Mara, saw her become a King and welcomed Adora to the world. To Adora, Razz was more than a simple maiden, she was family.

As the years passed on Adora´s reign, the war against the Horde Empire worsened. Suddenly and without explanation, the Horde started to use dark magic against the armies, after centuries of dedicating themselves to eradicate any trace of magic possible, and one by one the kingdoms were decimated of their knights in strange and horrific circumstances. Fear creased on the kingdoms before the imminent advance of the war as more and more refugees arrived to the neighbor towns, seeking asylum.

The rulers of the Kingdoms had joined at the Round Table to discuss the situation, but not even the limited magic nor the entirety of their armies together seemed enough to put an end to the Horde. The fall of Etheria seemed imminent

The wedding had been Light Hope idea.

The Half Moon Kingdom was a remote place, hidden from everyone, much like Camelot itself. Nobody had been there. Nobody except Light Hope, it seemed. It was a place of mystery. There, the tales telled about raw magic, untamed and wild. Their people, the magicats, were said to possess an uncanny beauty likewise their magic. People whispered about shape shifting creatures, and huge winged beasts that could only be referred to as dragons, even if those had disappeared decades ago after the Grand Purge.

Half Moon resided in a secured place, surrounded by the most dangerous rivers and an impenetrable forest. It was said a castle of a majesty beyond measure had its home in the middle of a lake, where the royal family and the last druids of the old empire lived.

Not much else was known about the royalty, except that the Queens had passed away of sickness and the only heir was their daughter, Princess C´yra, whom nobody had seen even a glance of before.

'It is in my best interest, to tell you that this is your only option" says Lady Light Hope, standing tall besides Adora´s seat "The magic of Half Moon is the only thing more powerful than the dark magic of the Horde. Joining our armies with theirs will bring everyone protection and, most important than all, a genuine advantage in the war"

"I thought Half Moon was a legend" says Princess Perfuma, twisting a tendril of loose blonde hair between her fingers.

"Under that logic, Camelot is a legend too" Bow's voice is calm but very obviously tense. Getting all the kingdoms together, in peace, around one same table had been hard enough and it had taken many years to manage. The prospect of bringing a new one, and over all, one nobody had had contact with in years was nerve racking. It felt much like what it was, a desperate cry for help.

"I still do not understand Lady Hope, how are we going to convince them to join us, when there have been nothing but indifferent towards us in the past centuries" says Glimmer, occupying the seat Queen Angella used to have in the Table.

"Your Majesty, the whole reason the Kingdom of Half Moon has hidden from us for so many years was for the hunt King Uther led against its people" Light Hope walks around the table slowly, hiding away her hands under her black tunic "Half Moon went into hiding after the Granamyr's Battle when the majority of their population was eradicated by Uther and his men. All the dragons and other magical creatures were lost in battle; the royal family barely made it out alive. The magicats and their kingdom were devastated by ours, because they were the biggest threat, your Majesties. They are the greatest source of magic of our world, the very descendants of Avalon, much before the First Ones arrived and Camelot was constructed. Half Moon taking sides would have shifted the course of the war, and Uther was not taking that risk"

Light Hope takes a deep breath, shaken. Is unusual to see this small moment of disturbance on her. She is after all, like most of Camelot, a descendant of the First Ones too. She had never talked about this story before and Adora has the feeling it was because it shamed her.

They understood. Their grandfather's past and what he did to the people of Etheria was a heavy burden to carry, and even after all the good Mara had done in her years, sometimes it seemed nothing would be enough to repair the damage.

"But the times are different now. Magic courses through our Kingdoms with a freedom never seen before. Yet the Horde Empire threatens to erase that freedom, for good, and it will happen any moment now if we don't take action. Half Moon must become a part of the Round Table. It is imperative."

Light Hope stops and turns towards the Court.

"I understand your weariness in the matter. These are strangers who haven't been seen in years, but they can become strong allies in our fight. The Horde Empire represents a danger to every creature on Etheria, and sooner or later it will include them. The benefits of this pact are huge, even if there is a risk of them turning their backs on us." Light Hope hesitates, furrowing her eyebrows together for a second before continuing "Whomever, the magicats have strong traditions, and their relationships with family are sacred, they would never turn against themselves. I believe then that a bond through marriage is the only tie strong enough to ease our and their minds over any doubt of treason. It serves as a purpose."

There is an uncomfortable murmur that passes through the table as the royals whisper between them. Adora, who hasn´t take their eyes aways from Light Hope yet, starts to feel a cold sense of dread on her spine.

'And whom, pray you tell Lady Hope, is the poor soul that will be sacrificing themselves to this noble cause?" inquiries Queen Mermista with a snort.

"Well" answers Light Hope, turning fully on Adora´s direction "That seems to be quite obvious, isn´t it my King? After a century, the breach made between Camelot and Half Moon needs to be mended."

The entire table turns toward him, but Adora has lost their breath. "*Please*" they almost beg "*I just want this one thing for myself. This one thing for me to choose. Not for politic or duty*" It overwhelms them entirely, because they know they can't say no "*I wanted it to be for love*"

"It's a sacrifice we must make."

Later at night, Adora is sitting at the edge of her bed, looking at her palms with narrowed eyes. Light Hope stands by the open window, a solemn expression over her features. Spring is coming to an end and the first vestiges of warmth start showing in the humid air.

"So is that really it? Don´t I have a voice in the matter?" Adora raises their head to meet Light Hope´s eyes, anger pouring out of them like fire "Don´t I have a choice?"

"No" says Hope, empty of all expression of sympathy "You can not choose. You're a King, this is your duty Adora. Your destiny."

Light Hope walks to the door. Before leaving, she turns once more to Adora, sighing.

"I wish you had the chance Mara always wanted for you" her voice quivers and it takes her a moment to collect herself again, returning to the same stoic posture of before "Choose a wedding present for the princess, I´ll be leaving in the morning."

The door closes as Adora's tears drip over his pants, leaving sad little dots behind.

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Bow and Glimmer sneak into their chamber roughly an hour after.

It is amusing how, after years and years of friendship, after they all have leave the mischief in the past and become rulers of kingdoms, they still can find their way back to those three little children that used to run around the castle halls, stealing strawberry tarts from the kitchens, having endless hours of sleepovers on the supposedly haunted towers.

Now, instead of jokes and giggles, the three friends hug each other as tightly as they can. They know how difficult this is for Adora, who has tried their entire life to live under their own accord, even after her mother died and she had to take the responsibility of an entire nation. How they grew up believing that, when the right time came, she would be able to marry for love and not for obligation. They know how heavy is the sense of duty inside of Adora and they also know that there is no other path they can go. War has robbed them of many things. Loyal friends and people; family, friends. Mara. Freedom.

Adora looks at their friends now, older and harder with the weight of the lost. She looks at them holding hands, looks at the matching earring on their ears and the loving looks they throw at each other. Some dark part inside Adora feels jealous of their luck.

"Have you thought about the wedding present?" asks Bow

"I do not wish to think of that. What should I even send her a present? It is not like it will be a real marriage" Adora answers with venom, not parting her sight from the high ceilings.

"Adora" stops her Glimmer "It is a real marriage. You don't even know her yet, how can you not know you won't like her? And a wedding present it's important. It may influence her decision. She needs to accept first" Glimmer appears on her vision, pink and purple hair sparkling in the night "And right now, she is our biggest hope."

"Well she shouldn't" Adora sits down abruptly, tossing the gold circlet that serves them as a crown aside "I am supposed to be the biggest hope. I'm She-Ra, I'm the king of Camelot."

"You are, Adora" Bows place a hand over theirs "But even the mighty She-Ra needs help sometimes. Mara taught us that."

Adora looks between their friends and huffs before letting themselves fall into the bed again.

"Don't stress yourself too hard over the present" adds Glimmer "Princess C'yra will know that this is a political matter. In the end, her decision will be based purely in the best interests

of her kingdom. So don’t choose something to win her over, choose something that comes from your heart."

Glimmer and Bow fall asleep on her bed shortly after. Adora spends the rest of the night on the balcony, watching the blooms of white flowers that crawl over the wall.

The next morning, Adora marchs to Light Hope's horse and hands her a single white rose before leaving.

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A week later, one of Light Hope’s ravens arrives at Camelot. Princess C’yra has accepted.

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The Court of Half Moon reaches Camelot at dawn three days later. The moment they enter the kingdom there is an explosion of color and music that startles every habitant of Camelot. There is not a single person in the kingdom that is not made aware of their presence.

The people of Camelot are not strangers to the beautiful and eccentric parades of the rest of the kingdoms, full of sparkles and magic, but this one is different. Is something they have never seen before.

The people have stopped their daily jobs and joined together in the streets to watch the newcomers pass. Beautiful dancers dressed in colorful tunics, with their faces painted the most rich colors guide the procession through the town. Their ears and tails swing back and forth graciously as they do the most complex movements while the caravan that accompany them moves forward. Little puffs of colored powders fly in the air, exploding in a swirl of sparks and inking the grounds on their pass. Thousands of petals are thrown to the people from crescent silver moon shaped baskets held by smiling looking magicats. Others carry crystal lamps that shine in various colors. There are a handful of knights in the center of the procession, dressed in tingling meshes of steel.

They look fierce, all of them, from the dancers, to the knights to the noble who walk on bare feet over the petal paths. They all have soft looking ears, some decorated with jewels others chipped in singular patterns. Their tails are adorned with beautiful trinkets that tingle as they walk, just as the bracelets that hang on their ankles.

Behind them, what seems to be thousands of warriors march in tandem, some walking, others riding enormous beasts with long purple tails and pointy fangs, their multicolored eyes shining as the lights touch them. They let out a soft but strong rumble as they pass the people scattered across the street.

At the center of the magicats there is a huge chariot with thick purple fabrics draped from the roof to the floor, hiding the princess and her companions from curious eyes. Somehow, the chariot seems to be moving on its own.

Adora can see all of these from his balcony before going down to the throne room to await for their arrival. Glimmer, Bow, the formal King Micah and the rest of the Royals are already waiting.

They step down the stone stairs in a rush, blonde hair flying behind him, a blank expression on the handsome face.

Everyone had dressed with their most beautiful clothes to receive the Half Moon court, yet Adora had gone for his usual white loose shirt and high waisted pants the only difference on the heavy red cape hanging from his left shoulder.

Light Hope will be most probably reprimanding them later, but that was a problem for future Adora. Current Adora felt like their heart was going to explode on his chest, like one of those colorful fire flowers the magicats had brought alongside with his future wife.

Adora arrives at the throne room, nodding in recognition to everyone and taking a seat at the same time the heavy door opens and Light Hope enters, the entire Court following close behind. It seemed the rest of the magicats had been left to be accommodated across the palace and town and now only a handful of knights were standing closely to the royals.

As Light Hope climbs the few steps up the throne, the multitude opens and three figures step in front.

The first one is a tall and strong woman, with strong arms and a gentle and open expression on her face. Her white hair is cut short and tossed aside, held thanks to a crimson ruby crown. She dresses in a long, slick black dress and from her elegant neck hangs a gorgeous necklace which rubies traveled all across her neck and down her chest.

On the other side there is a smaller figure, their long purple hair held up at the sides of their head with what seemed to be small pieces of steel. Their face is slightly smudged in dirt, with a pair of round eccentric looking glasses resting over their nose. They wear only loose gray pants and a cotton shirt. Adora smirks at their sight, a slow sense of calm starting to overtake him. Maybe they weren’t as different as everyone thought.

Finally, in the middle of the group, stands a slender figure. She is shorter than the others, probably an entire head shorter than Adora, but she holds herself with elegance, her head pointing firmly to the sky. She wears a long sleeved plum tunic and tight black pants with silver seams. There are bracelets in both of her ankles and her feet rest bare over the carpet, tinted in red. Her graceful hands with long black nails rest one over the other where golden rings catch the light that leaks from the crystal dome of the room. But her face is covered, a dark cloth dotted small embroidered stars covering her features and hair.

Adora, in all their nervous state, find themselves intrigued.

"King Adora Pendragon" spoke Light Hope in a strong yet welcoming tone "May I please introduce you to Princess C’yra of D´riluth III, heir to the throne of Half Moon and her royal court."

The magicats and the other two companions bow at the call, all except the Princess who keeps her place with her face firmly towards the front. Adora wonders what she is seeing. Adora wonders if it is him.

"King Adora" starts the first woman. Her voice is joyful and excited, rose coloring her cheeks. From the corner of their eye, Adora sees Princess Perfuma moving to the front of Camelot's Court, as if to see this woman better. It makes them smile "We are thankful, for your candid welcoming. The kingdom of Half Moon greets you and your people and a sign of appreciation for your hospitality we would like to offer a present. We've bought gifts, food and various treasures for you and your people, we hope it pleases you."

There is a united hum of approval from the rest of the people in the room. Adora is aware that everyone is now looking at her, so they wriggle on the throne a bit and clears their throat before answering.

"My entire gratitude…" Adora awaits for her name.

The woman blinks at them without understanding. Princess C'yra clears her throat and she turns her head towards her. Adora shifts their attention too but the princess says no more. After a few moments more she widens her eyes and turns her head back to Adora, smile flashing bigger than before.

"Oh, yes! Yes! My apologies, your Majesty. I am Princess Scorpia, from the Scorpus Kingdom. And this is Prince Entrapta of Dryl. We're Half Moon advisors. And well, of course, this is Princess Catra… I mean C'yra! yes of course C'yra, I never seem to get the second name right though but well maybe you will! you two are going to be married after all..."

Princess Scorpia goes on for a few moments more. In the crowd, Perfuma giggles behind the back of her hand. Princess C'yra shifts her feet uncomfortably, still not breaking her pose, and Prince Entrapta well, they are scribbling on a piece of paper unaware of anything that is currently going around them. Adora takes pity on them and interrupts Scorpia as kinder as possible.

"Thank you, Princess Scorpia. Camelot is eternally grateful with your kindness. Prince Entrapta" they say, regarding the Prince even if they don't seem to really listen. Adora's attention goes completely to C'yra "Princess C'yra, words will never be enough to thank you for all that you're doing for the people of Etheria. I hope from the deeps of my heart, that you can find in Camelot a safe shelter for your people and a place you can call home."

Light Hope smiles proudly at her from where she stands besides the throne. There is a soft huff of air coming from the Princess but before she can say anything, Princess Scorpia interjects.

"Oh! Princess C'yra is not to be seen by the betrothed until tomorrow at the wedding! Magicats traditions, your Majesty. I forgot to mention it, I probably should have mentioned it before, my apologies."

Adora raises their eyebrows, taken aback. By the corner of their eye, they see Light Hope nodding once to him.

"I understand, do not worry, Princess. I'm sure you're all tired from the long journey. Countess Netossa and Countess Spinerella will show you your quarters" the mentioned approach the trio, calling their attention and showing them the way "I do hope you enjoy the rest of your evening. I… I'll see you tomorrow."

Despite their best efforts the reminder of tomorrow's events bring Adora a new wave of restlessness. No matter how intriguing this newcomer is, she is still a stranger. A stranger whom Adora will spend the rest of their life with. And they hadn't even seen her face or hear her voice. Is almost too much for Adora to take. They press their lips in what they try to be a reassuring smile and hope it does not show how much she wants to run as far as they can.

There are way too many people in the room and Adora starts to feel like the air is missing.

Now that the audience is over, both Courts start to scatter across the corridors of the Castle. Adora grips the arms of the throne, holding himself back from sprinting away. Glimmer and Bow are already walking in his direction, the latter making a gesture with his hands, raising them and then letting them fall slowly.

"*Breath"*

They do as he tells him, sending their friends a tense smile. Yet there is something at the base of their head they just can't put their finger on. Is not until Adora turns their head back that he realizes what it is.

Princess C'yra is looking at her. They can't really see her, obviously, but her head is turned towards him as if she were contemplating them. Her tail moves back and forth behind her.

Adora and C'yra look at each other for a few seconds. The Princess looks back at her advisors and leaves the throne room with them.

❀

"You did amazing Adora, I'm so proud of you" Glimmer hugs Adora, rubbing their back in shooting circles.

Bow handles them a goblet of wine.

"Was it noticed that I was dying inside?" complaints Adora.

"Not at all. You just look a bit paler than usual."

The three of them laugh under their breath. The air outside the castle feels charged and electric. The first storms of summer are coming quickly.

There is a knock at the door and Light Hope steps inside. She has the same stern expression but she seems satisfied with the audience's outcome.

"The Princess and the rest of the magicats have already been accommodated, your Majesty."

"Ah, good. Excellent. Thank you Light Hope"

Bow and Glimmer look at each other in silence before standing up.

"We are going to fetch your wedding attire Adora, so it's all ready for tomorrow" Glimmer approaches them as she spoke, kissing them quickly in the cheek "We'll be back in a blink."

She holds her husband's arm and tugs from it to the doors, the apple Bow was trying to get from the basket falling sadly to the floor.

"Glimmer!" Bow pouts to his wife before looking at Adora "Eat your dinner, Adora. And no more wine!"

Her two friends slip past the door, leaving Adora and Light Hope alone in the chamber. A tense silence falls between them, filled only by the sounds of the fire cracking in the fireplace and the soft chatting of the maidens below the window.

"So" says Adora picking a piece of bread "you seem to be pleased by my performance."

She waits for Light Hope to answer but there are no sounds, so it comes as a surprise when she puts her cold hand over Adora's shoulder.

"Adora. I'm aware of the conflict you must surely be going through now. Mara fought her whole life to give you the opportunity of being happy and it pains me that her wish has been clouded by this war" her voice breaks and Adora immediately raises their hand to hold hers "But you've taken the right choice. She would've been proud of you.

Adora fixes her gaze to the table, scratching the wood with her nails. Light Hope resolves to fix the small baby hairs that had fallen off Adora's ponytail and over their face.

"How did you know how to get to Half Moon?" Hope's hands still over the crown of her head "You were there before, isn't it?"

Hope steps back, letting her hand fall to the tablet beside Adora's. They don't expect her to answer, in all truth, Adora is exhausted. She just wants to crawl back into bed and sleep.

"King Mara went to Half Moon years ago" Adora snaps their head so fast every muscle in her neck complains, but she pays no mind to it - Your mother and I met the Queens there. Mara wished to achieve a peace accord between the kingdoms, but it was pointless. Mara's father had just passed away and even though the Queens received us with kindness, they didn't trust us. You were still a child back then, barely three at the time.

"Wait. *I went with you?"*

"Indeed" Light Hope asserts "I didn't agree but Mara insisted, said it would be good. And if I remember correctly, you did meet Princess C'yra. She was just a baby, so she most probably does not remember it, but it seems amusing now."

"Yes, surely" he says, distracted. They wonder if C'yra know this, if her mothers ever told her. They wonder what happened when they met all those years ago, if the Princess cried at their sight or if she felt safe and held to them with her small hands.

'As I told you my Lord, destiny"

Maybe Light Hope, and Glimmer and Bow and everybody else are right, and this duty can become a true chance of happiness. Not from the need of a wife but even more important, for the possibility of a friend.

❀

Members of every kingdom across Etheria have gathered themselves to behold the ceremony.

Adora stands near the twin thrones, fidgeting with his fingers under the laps of their cape. The throne room is filled to the brim with nobility and outside the castle the town rejoices with the festivities.

Glimmer and Bow are at Adora's right side, a tad below her, and behind them the rest of the Round Table members await for the Princess' arrival.

Adora can listen to the murmur and giggling of a few nobles chattering between themselves. *How do you think she will look. I bet she is pretty. I bet she isn't. She's so lucky, marrying the King. They look very handsome. Oh, shush it.* Giggles. *Will she wear a dress? Maybe. What color? White? Pink? Black?*

Over the cushion next to the Priest rests a charming crown sparkling gold with iridescent gems. It belonged to Queen Guenivere, Arthur's wife, in the past and it had stayed in the castle's vault awaiting for its next owner, until now.

The trumpet's music fills the entire space, sending the room back into silence. Adora's eyes return to the open gates of the venue and their breath hitches on their throat.

The dress is red and she is the most beautiful being Adora has ever laid their eyes on.

Her thick dark hair is held in tight braids that join in a single one, which falls heavy below her hips. She wears a crescent moon tiara over her forehead that matches the earrings adorning her velvet ears and the necklaces over the soft skin of the exposed collarbones. Golden ribbons cross the front of the dress from the shoulders to her waist, allowing the long skirt of it to fall free to the floor. She walks alone through the long corridor and the people she passes by can see her exposed back over the low cut of the gown. The dress is gorgeous, a luxury that catches the eye and that will be talked about several weeks after the wedding. Yet, Adora can't tear apart their eyes from her lovely face. The soft curve of her cheekbones, the crease between the pointy proud nose and her tender rosé lips, the constellation of freckles below her eyelids. C'yra doesn't even need to open her mouth for Adora to know only the most exquisite of sounds will pour like dense honey from it. Her eyebrows are as dark as her hair and there is an infinitesimal pink scar right below the left one, testimony of

childhood mischievousness and late night getaways. Her eyes are sharp and vibrant, one of deep turquoise the other hazel gold and the determination and confidence that lives inside them bares voids inside of Adora's soul itself.

Adora can perceive a slow heat rise from the middle of their heart to the tip of their ears, it feels like summer rain coiling inside her chest and running free like a waterfall. Is beautiful and terrifying, much like the woman that walks over the stones of their castle, pulling Adora to her with the strength of an entire army.

She understands now why the magicats didn't allow her to see her until now. Adora wants to throw themselves to their knees, hold her hands and raise her a shrine on which they can pray to her every day for the rest of their lives. They know it's such an overreacted illogical reaction, they don't know her, they have just seen her for the first time. But deep inside her Adora knows this is right, this was the correct choice as Hope told him last night.

They feel as if some unknown goodness has ripped its ethereal eyes from the sky and taken pity on them for all the horrors that are to come. That it has looked at them and blessed them, even if just for the split of a second. Taking a watery breath, they send a thank you to whomever this may be. A promise to protect what has been so kindly given, guarded where it can't feel pain, or sadness or fear ever again.

They don't believe in destiny, in a path pre-made that one has to follow; they believe in choices and in hard work, in duty and in decisions. But as C'yra slides her cold hand inside the lukewarm cocoon of Adora's own, the latter knows that this person is to become the most dearest thing in the entire universe for them. She feels themselves falling a little bit in love.

Adora feels like crying.

The Priest is talking. Adora is aware of this but they can't bring themselves to hear a word she says over the roaring sound of their own beating heart on their ears and the soft breathing of C'yra besides them. She smells a bit like lavenders and a bit like leather, a mixed smell tickling Adora's nose in the most pleasant of the ways.

They wish for this formality to be over already, so they can take C'yra away from the prying eyes of the crowd and finally properly meet her. She craves now for the moment when she can start learning this person. They want to know everything about her, what she likes and what she dreads, what was her childhood like. What are her dreams and her nightmares, which books she reads, if she would like to do sword practice with them. They beg to know how that small scar came to be, and how many freckles she has on her nose and what is her favorite food. Adora resolves that they are going to ask the kitchens to prepare every single meal they can, to bring every fruit and nut and dessert across Camelot and give it to her to try.

Adora wants to be worthy of her trust and become her friend, and maybe, if the stars are still smiling to them and she allows it, maybe something more.

They hold C'yra's hand gently between theirs as all these thoughts run free and wild on his head, searching insatiable with his eyes across the Princess's face. C'yra does not look at

them, in fact, her gaze is fixed purporsely on the Priest's and nothing else, but it doesn't matter.

There's a soft sound besides Adora, who reluctantly removes their sight from their bride and looks around looking for it's source. It takes her a few seconds to realize is the Priest, who is cleaning her throat and making a small insistent move with her head.

Oh.

"Yes" answers Adora is a heartbeat, coming all rushed out of breath. And even though they don't need to add anything else, they go on- I promise, with my heart.

The Priest smiles gently, nodding and turns to C'yra, repeating the same vows before waiting for her answer. The whole room seems to be holding their breath.

"Yes. I shall" Adora was right. Her voice is smooth and husky, sure in her answer but kind enough to make Adora want to pledge her eternal loyalty. It's the proud voice of someone who is meant to be a powerful queen.

Adora turns his head to Glimmer and Bow with wide blue eyes, mumbling a *Wow* under his breath. Glimmer nods her head, her eyes glistening with tears. Bow is not better and just resolves to throw a very discreet thumbs up to them.

Halfheartedly, she wonders if everybody else in the room has noted this sudden change Adora is going through. If their heart has bursten open on the floor and they all can see the revolution that is happening inside its strings, like it has turned to dust and build again but different, meant only to devote itself for this woman with soft hands and eyes like glass. Adora thinks that they wouldn't mind it, if they knew. Even though she fought in her soul against this moment, even though its origin was not how they would have wanted, they would not trade this moment.

They think that if a war was required for them to meet, Adora would cause that same war again and again and again, just to live this precious moment one more time. Not the marrying, but the meeting.

It's a scary thought, a secret meant to be told only in the deepest of the darkness, something that should shame Adora, but it doesn't. They've always held themselves accountable for living with their heart in their sleeve, but it's precisely this that has let them keep forward since their mother's death, and now it's not different, Adora doesn't want it to be different.

As the priest reaches behind her to grab the crown, Princess C'yra lowers herself gently to kneel in the ground and Adora, who's still holding her hand, lets themselves kneel in front of her. There is a collective gasp coming from the members of the room.

Never in the story of Avalon a King of Camelot has kneel before anyone, ever.

There are alarmed murmurs all around them but Adora pays them no mind because C'yra is finally looking at them, eyes big and mouth ajar in her surprise. Her ears are down, pressed against her head and Adora feels her shiver under their grasp.

The Priest hesitates on her tracks, looking back and forth between the two, unsure. Adora doesn't say anything, just smiling in reassurance, shaking their head in affirmation.

As the heavy crown is placed over C'yra's head, the throne room fills with the chants of the crowd.

"Long live the Queen! Long live the King!"

Adora starts to get on their feet bringing C'yra, her wife, along with them, the euphoric multitude roaring in cheer in front of them.

"Is my very good honor to meet you, Queen C'yra" Adora whispers to her. They're aware this is the part where they are supposed to lean in and kiss her, but they can't find in themselves the courage to do it. It doesn't feel right, it feels invasive without C'yra's explicit permission. So Adora just raises C'yra's right hand to their face and places a soft kiss over her knuckles, lips barely even touching the skin.

A thousand more thoughts run on Adora's mind

I can't wait to meet you, and

I hope you get to trust me too, and

One day I'm going to choose you, freely. Not for duty or necessity. For you, for us, and

From now on, until death tears me apart from you, I'm staying with you.

C'yra says nothing, but her face is flushed a lovely shade of red and she seems fairly more relaxed, her smaller hand still lingering in Adora's own.

But then the Camelot knights at the bottom of the room start chanting an old victory anthem. An hymn meant for the end of a combat, when the dust has dissipated and the battle has been conquered. A chant that was used in the times of Arthur, and Uther. By the time Adora realizes this is already too late.

C'yra's face falls immediately. Her eyebrows knit together, eyes squinted, lips pressed together in a fine line. Adora can see the change on her eyes, suddenly losing all warm and going back into that tense, calculator state of before.

Before Adora can say anything, C'yra yanks her hand from their grasp, almost violently, letting them fall back over the skirt of her red dress. Adora hand follows the phantom movement weakly, shaken by it.

Queen C'yra doesn't look at them again as she starts to walk, Adora following a few steps behind, feeling the apex of their new world start to dissolve into nothing.

❀

There is a banquet. Afterwards.

The Courts are sitting, eating and cheerful talking with each other. Princess Scorpia and Princess Perfuma are next to each other, picking in a blackberry tart. Glimmer and Bow stay next to King Father Micah, who is telling jokes to a few magicats nobles all openly and happily laughing.

Prince Entrapta had wriggled out ten minutes ago somewhere, holding something that looked suspiciously like a ceiling crystal and a fire flower. Minstrels are going back and forth around the room, charming adults and children equally with their tricks and colorful clothes.

The music is loud inside the castle, and the sounds of the town's carnaval in honor of the union mixed with it in a jolly tandem.

Adora is miserable.

They barely have had time to exchange a few words privately with Bow and Glimmer before they had been taken away by Light Hope and the doors of the waiting chamber had opened again for C'yra. Adora couldn't help the betraying pound of her own treachery heart at the sight of the Queen.

"C'yra" Adora stood up, cape long ago ditched and changed to a matching baroque red and gold coat, much more comfortable and less heavy.

"King Pendragon" she addressed them, approaching slowly and stopping only a few meters away from them. She was even more beautiful up close.

"I'm so glad we finally have some moments to meet each other away from everyone else" Adora extended their hand to her, hoping she would take it, but C'yra only looked at it with a raised eyebrow.

"You have already expressed your sentiment at yesterday's audience and we are already wed. There is no need for you to keep forcing yourself, your Grace."

Adora lowered his hand again, a cold shiver passing across their spine.

"What?" C'yra chuckled, a smirk appearing on her face as she shook her head in fake amusement.

"We all know that I wouldn't be here if it wasn't because, after so many years, you need so desperately mine and my people's help. Please, your Majesty, save the chattering and do not pretend this idea was born out of the simple wish and desire of friendship, kindness or redemption."

She was so beautiful and cold it hurted. Adora was starting to feel like all their previous fears were coming back, hitting him with twice the intensity. And the unstoppable and illogical need to embrace her made it all even more devastatingly confusing.

"My engagement to you is nothing but a careful negotiation that has saved us from months of slow diplomacy, as your advisor stated clearly when she presented herself in my castle.

Though I must admit" she said inspecting her long black nails "You do know how to put on a good act. Isn't it, King Pendragon? You almost caught me there."

"C'yra, please. That's not it. It wasn't an act. And what happened in the ceremony, with the knights..."

"Is nothing I wasn't expecting, already. After all, the First One's fame precedes you all" Adora flinches. She knows she should be feeling offended, but C'yra is not wrong. Camelot's army does carry quite a reputation since Uther's time, and Adora doesn't make it easier by taking this fault as if it was hers too.

Because it is, they think, *I am his granddaughter and the King now. Their sins are mine too and it is in me to be penitent for them. Is understandable she doesn't trusts me at all.* Even if the feeling of losing C'yra already so early is turning him apart, they don't make an attempt to explain further. This only seems to fuel C'yra even further.

"There is one thing I must make clear, King Pendragon, before we walk out of here to face our own. Half Moon is not a price to win and I am not a trophy to exhibit. I am now as much Queen of Camelot as you are King of Half Moon, and I shall rule and serve both kingdoms equally. I gave my hand on my own accord because I saw the opportunity to protect my people and I seized it. I'll serve Camelot with the utmost loyalty and If your intentions are as true as you say they are, then I expect nothing less from you but the same commitment with Half Moon."

Right in that moment the gates open one last time. Princess Scorpia's head appearing from behind them, looking very nervously at both Royals.

"The guests are waiting, your Majesties."

"Thank you, Scorpia" the mentioned looked at her Queen, worrying her lip between her teeth before nodding once and leaving. It was when C'yra started to move in the same direction that Adora seemed to find their tongue again.

'I also did what was best to my people" C'yra stopped, looking at him with suspicious written all over her features xI didn't get to choose."

Queen C'yra smirked again, slithering her arm on Adora's.

"Well, then I'm glad we are on the same page. Come on now, *spouse,* our guests are expecting us."

Now they are here, sitting next to each other in the wood table facing everybody else. The lights of the candles play shadows over the windows, warming the place as they burn. C'yra eats in silence, not once attempting to start a conversation with Adora. She doesn't comment on the food or the party or anything at all. Just heavy silence draped around them like an armor.

Adora catches Bows eyes from the other side of the room. He raises his eyebrows, a mute question on them. Adora just shakes their head sadly and continues to pick weakly at their

food.

A sudden move calls their attention when a black small creature jumps to the table between them. Their fur looks soft at the touch and they have a pair of bright eyes that shine an abnormal tone of blue. The creature fixes its penetrating sight on Adora.

"Melog" calls C'yra, without looking up from her plate. Melog breaks eye contact with Adora, jumping to C'yra's lap.

Adora gulps, twiddling the ends of his sleeves between their fingers. They resolve that despise the earlier interaction, maybe they can start over again.

"I've never seen a creature like that before" C'yra looks at him sideways scrunching her nose

"A *cat?"*

"Well, I mean. Of course I've seen a cat before. Of course, how could I not" Adora feels themselves tripping with their own words "I meant, their eyes, they are so bright and pretty, like yours. I mean! Well yes, they are. It's just that I've never seen a cat with those eyes, ahem, but I may be wrong. And, oh goddess, I'm going to stop now."

Adora is mortified now. *Good work Adora. She already seems to dislike you enough for you to be making a fool of yourself in front of her.* A small chirp takes them away from the quick spiral they were falling over. The cat, Melog, has popped their head from under C'yra's arm and is now actively purring.

C'yra hums, surprised 'They like you."

Adora melts a little bit, a small weight lifting from her chest as they tilt their head.

"Hello Melog" the cat cleans their whiskers and keeps looking at them, still purring. Their eyes bright even more "Are you magic? I'm magic too."

Adora uses a twinkle of magic and let's her own eyes sparkle the same clear shining blue. Melog's pupils wide when they see her, their tail moving lazily over the Queen's dress. When Adora sits straight again C'yra is openly looking at him. Adora smiles dumbfoundedly at her before she returns to her food without more comment, shoulders more relaxed nonetheless.

That went well. At least I have the cat's approval, that's a start.

A couple of magicat maidens approach the table, bowing to both of them and bending to speak in hushed whispers to C'yra. The aforementioned stills, goblet of wine freezed midway. Adora looks at her intently, suddenly worried.

It looks as if all blood has drained from her face as C'yra stands from her chair, shaking off invisible crumbs of food from her skirt. She lay her eyes on Adora, considering them a moment.

"My Lord" And then she and the maidens all turn and leave the room, Melog following them close behind.

As many times as before that day, Adora is utterly lost. Adora spends a few moments scanning the room for their friends without success until Light Hope appears out of nowhere by their side, making them jump on their seat.

"Oh, goodness Lady Light Hope. You've scared me."

"I apologize, your Majesty. But I think the time for you to join your wife in your chambers has come."

A period of stunned silence falls between both.

Now Adora understands why C'yra had panic so sudden, because is the same reason why Adora is the one panicking right now.

"You can't be serious"

"I assure you I am, your Majesty"

"I just met her, Light Hope. She is already wary of me and with good reason given the past of our ancestors but I'm trying very hard to gain her trust. You can't just make me ask this from her now."

"It's what must be done, Adora. It's business, the Queen knows this. I'm sure that you'll know how to fulfill your duty as is expected of you."

Adora clenches her jaw, hot anger running through her veins. It's one thing to ask him to jeopardize their own right to make decisions but to suggest that a matter so delicate to C'yra's persona must be treated as an obligation is frankly humiliating. C'yra may be defensive and snarky, they may have known each other for only a couple of hours, but Adora is already fiercely protective of her and her honor and won't let a useless idiotic believe become more important than that.

"*Business.* Is that what my mother was for you then? Business?"

Adora stands violently, before the stunned look of everyone at the banquet, almost knocking the ornament chair on their way.

"I'll retreat now, but do not expect me to fulfill *your wishes* about this", they spat in a low growl, earning an astonish look from Light Hope "This shall be a conversation between me and her only. And do not dare to ask me or Queen C'yra about it, not tomorrow or the next day or never. I do not care who you are Lady Hope, if you offend her privacy in any moment I'll have you face *my* fury. Is that clear?"

For the first time in Adora's whole life, Light Hope is speechless. In fact, she looks shocked beyond measure with her mouth gaping and her eyes wide open.

Before she can come back to her senses, Adora leaves the table, the royal staff announcing her leave. One of the knights at the bottom of the room, clearly drunk out of their mind, whistles and screams *Get it, King!*

Adora, frowns, somehow even more angry now that what they were moments before. C'yra is right. They are not liking at all this new imbecile smartass attitude of their knights. The next schedule practice Adora is going to make sure to pulverize them all into the ground, lets see if that takes away their wishes of being *funny.*

"I'll be retiring to my quarters".they say to the royal guard next to the door "make sure everybody makes it safe to their own rooms too. And get that knight out of my castle, immediately. Maybe a night in the stable will teach him manners."

"Yes, my King"

Adora takes the longer path to their room, walking across the corridors of Castle Grayskull alone. Now that they are away from the bustle, Adora's mind starts to calm down again and with it, all the events of the day come running back hitting them with the whole force of their meaning.

Adora has to stop for a moment, squatting next to the stone pillars of the open corridor. There the shadows cover her and there is a pretty narrow chance of encountering anyone else. Not even the maidens walk through these corridors at night. She hides her face between their joined hands, breathing slowly the petrichor scented air.

Is groundbreaking how their life has changed completely in the lapse of just a few hours. Adora has done most of the things she said herself they were never going to do, like marry out of convenience and snapping at Light Hope.

That familiar sense of overwhelming guilt starts to press down into him, making it difficult to breath. Adora doesn't allow herself to have the things she wants. They always work inside the line following the rules strictly. Is part of the reason why having to quit the one thing she had saved for herself felt so unfair, as difficult as it was going to achieve it in the first place. Yet, somehow, defending their recently known wife, this young woman who had robbed their breath and heart away in a matter of seconds, over the woman that helped raise them feels like one of the bravest most selfish things Adora has done in a long time.

Adora opens their eyes again at the thought of C'yra, a new spark of uneasiness nestling on his chest. They know they can't hide in here forever. Adora owns C'yra an explanation about their knights behavior and most than all, an apology. She also needs to reassure her that their intentions are anything but far from what she is probably thinking now, alone in a foreign room away from home.

When Adora arrives at the doors of his chamber everything is calm. Only the fair rain that had started to fall and Adora's own ragged breath could be heard in the humid corridors. This part of the castle is far enough to drown all the sounds of the feast, cornered in the tallest and emptiest tower. She likes its privacy.

Adora tries the best they can to fix their hair and clothes before finally twisting the door knob and coming in.

The room is warm and unnervingly quiet. The fireplace has been smothered with only a few lights enlightening the made bed and floor. C'yra is sitting by the window, looking at the

drizzle with Melog cuddled on her lap.

Her ears move rhythmically, catching the sound of the door closing behind Adora, but C'yra makes no attempt to acknowledge her. Her head rests over the open palm of her hand, tail lashing lazy over the floor. She is wearing a white nightgown and nothing else, pearly white a strong contrast against the dark of her skin.

She is a small sun inside Adora's bedroom and they don't feel worthy of being in her presence.

Adora shrugges out of his coat, leaving it discarded over the oak table alongside with the crown. They clean their throat before daring to make a sound that breaks the silent spell.

"C'yra..."

"King Pendragon" C'yra raises to her feet leaving the edge of the window, elegantly detangling herself from Melog. Her footsteps are mute over the stones until she is right next to the left side of the bed, where she sits with a soft tud. Her penetrating gaze holds Adora's own without blinking once.

Adora stays roundly in their place rocking back and forth almost imperceptibly on their feet, her face solemn in the night lights. They already feel their stomach turned over with anxiety and a fog clouds their capacity of words just as that morning. Adora can't tell if it's the uncomfortable of the moment, their own spinning heart or the wine they had taken during the feast in hopes it would give her a tad more of courage.

More seconds pass by without Adora making any attempt of moving but also without turning their eyes always from C'yra. Is thanks to this that Adora can see the changes in her bearing, from cold and distant to confused and impatiente until she seems to not be able to endure it anymore.

"What are you waiting for then?" her voice bites in the quietness of the space sending every nerve on Adora's body into high alert.

"I...um"

"You didn't ask for my wedded hand just to stand there like a lost puppy, did you my Lord."

Adora flushes beet red, embarrassed. At Adora's loss of words C'yra growls, upper lip baring over her teeth and sharp fangs, potentially more and more annoyed. She tosses her long hair behind her back, the shoulder of the nightgown sliding down her shoulder, looking at Adora in a way that makes alert alarms go off in their brain.

"Can you get over with it already so I can sleep? My feet are sore and don't appreciate you acting like a buffoon right now."

The snark snaps Adora out of her slumber, advancing a few steps towards her.

When C'yra flinches at the sudden movement, almost imperceptibly Adora stops, raising a hand in front of her in a calming manner Bow sometimes uses with them when their anxiety

gets the best of them.

"C’yra, please listen to me. I’m not going to do anything you don’t ask me to do, not tonight nor ever. Trust me."

C’yra examines them thoughtfully, incredulity written all over her face. Her fangs are still out and the sharp nails dig into the coverlet. Adora gulps running their fingers over their hair anxiously. The hair tie gives away at some point, letting the fine strands of ashen blonde hair fall free over his shoulders, a few loose tendrils floating in the gentle breeze that enter through the open window.

"I can assure you, I mean you no harm. You are safe here, C’yra. This is your home now too, I promise."

"You make a lot of promises, King Pendragon. I’m starting to wonder if you can actually keep them."

That is not fair. Adora is being true with her, they have been nothing but honest with her since yesterday at the audience and all day today. They may be nervous and cautious around C’yra but Adora still conserves their pride and it’s not fond of being treated this way when they haven't said anything wrong at all. Still, they try to push aside the unanticipated irritability and be patient.

"My name is Adora. And I am not only fancy empty words, C’yra."

"Do you suggest I should believe you don’t wish to take what you now think you own, my Lord?"

"I don’t own you C’yra. You’re your own person and a formidable one that is. You said yourself earlier, you're not a prize to show and you deserve respect. I just feel responsible to let you know that I’m not making you comply with any kind of idiotic tradition that threatens your privacy. Or mine whatsoever. I’m on your side."

There are a few moments of tension going between them and then the Queen speaks again, barely above a whisper.

"What is wrong with you?"

"What?"

"I said what is wrong with you" growls C'yra between clenched teeth, momentaneously losing her temper "You First Ones are all the same, just needing to feel like a hero, aren’t you? I asked you to drop the act earlier so don’t offend me by pretending now that you seek to protect me."

"C’yra I’ve done nothing but try to defend your honor"

"Defend my honor? I am not a victim, I am the Queen of Half Moon and I need no one to protect me, not from the Horde, not from their army, and certainly not from you. We may be

spouses in name but we are certainly not friends, my Lord, we are hardly even acquaintances, do not flatter yourself of knowing me."

'It's Adora. And I do not. In all fairness you haven't even met me yet either. You're judging me for sins that don't belong to me. I didn't think..."

"What did you think this was going to be, *my Lord?* You said it yourself. This is convenient to our kingdoms because there is a greater evil trying to destroy everything we know. Did you think we would suddenly become the dearest of friends? We are rulers, not children. And this is a war, not a game. I had in understanding you above all were aware of that."

"I am, Lady C'yra, that knowledge leaves in my veins and it burns me with every breath I take. This marriage wasn't my idea either, but we are here. And I… C'yra, I don't want to live in a loveless marriage. When I saw you, when I saw you I really believed we would be fine. It wasn't the expense of your dress or the size of your army or the beauty of your face, it was you and what you transmitted to the world. I know how it sounds but there is a feeling inside my chest that tells me that we can do this, if you would let me. "

"Love?"

Adora shuts quiet. It wasn't what she was going to say, in the peak of the moment it had slipped right past their lips and into the space between them. Yet they couldn't deny that somewhere inside of them, since it was accorded this marriage was to happen, had wished that luck would bless them after all. They really had thought it may, for those now bittersweet seconds where Adora had have C'yra's hand between theirs.

"How could you even phantom the idea that I could ever love *you*?"

Adora stumbles back, limbs tangling on themselves, face contorted in an expression of raw anguish and hurt.

Every single sound inside the chamber ceases and fades away. The unmistakable tune of calm before a storm.

Adora looks at the ground, ashamed. They take a breath, then another. The world blurs around the edges and is not until Adora feels wetness on the bridge of their nose that they realize they are crying.

"You come here and act all noble and kind and understanding for the entire fucking day, as if you truly mean it, as if your kin hadn't take everything they wanted. And yet you ask me to bare my heart and *trust you?* To even consider the idea of loving you?"

"C'yra. Please, stop"

"Why, your Majesty. Am I testing your patience?"

"You are breaking my heart."

There is a small gasp coming from C'yra, like all the air has been expelled out of her lungs at once. But Adora doesn't have it in themselves anymore to look deeply into it.

After a long couple of minutes, Adora walks away from the foot of the bed. Outside a lighting bolt breaks the sky in two ceasing the drizzle just to let the rain pour on its full force over Camelot. It seems accurate, this weather, it fits with the storm that lives inside Adora's heart.

Adora grabs one of the blankets that rest in the corner chair, drying their eyes almost violently with the back of her hand. C'yra is silent, making them wonder if she is finally done punishing them for their families past. Nothing makes sense at all.

"I do not understand" snaps Adora. They know their voice is quivering and their eyes are starting to sting, and it makes them angry. But they feel hurt and vulnerable. So when princess, Queen, C'yra widens her eyes in surprise they keep going "If you can't stand me or my kingdom then why marry me? Why day yes? Why travel from so far, from the safety and comfort of your pretty castle?"

C'yra narrows her eyes, her posture is still straight and distant. However there is a crease on her eyebrows that make her look as if something deeper was causing her trouble. She regards Adora for a few seconds, watching them from head to toes before dignifying an answer.

"You now why. The political benefits of our union have already been discussed. Independent to our relationship joining our kingdoms and armies will allow us…"

"Do not lie to me" interrupts Adora. C'yra closes her mouth so fast and hard her fangs clash against each other. Her lips twist into a scowl and a small hiss fills the quiet of the room. It's clear that she is not used to being talked over and Adora feels a tiny spark of victory. Which immediately turns into despair. This was supposed to be their wife, the woman they'll spend their life with. It was obvious that C'yra wasn't happy, but they had hoped they could overcome that and eventually maybe become friends. Yet C'yra had done nothing but shut them down and antagonize her the entire day and Adora was tired.

"You could have said no" continues Adora, defeated. They squeeze the fabric of the blankets between their fingers in an attempt to ground themselves "It was me and my people the ones that asked for your help, not the other way around. Your kingdom was safe and hidden. As far as we know the Horde may not even know about the magicats existence. We may talk about politics all you want, but you and I know the truth. The magicats could have disappeared without risk of going into war. I would have never raised a finger against Half Moon neither did my mother when she lived. You didn't need to mend things with Camelot, you didn't need us at all. So, why?"

C'yra says nothing, but her ears twitch at the sides of her head and her tail moves softly over the bed. She is listening.

"I know how much my kingdom hurted you and your people. I know that the crimes my grandfather committed against you are not forgivable and they may shadow this reign and this marriage even after I die. But me asking your hand was never with the intention to use any of you nor to see you as some kind of twisted conquer trophy. It was genuinely made with the intent to help one another. And I never planned to take any kind of advantage against you, Princess. I'm aware my family's fame precedes me, but I would never put a hand on you without your explicit permission."

Adora walks towards the second door of the bedroom, the one that leads to a private room where Adora used to do cartography in their younger years and now serves them as a quiet place to rest their mind. The black cat that C'yra brought with her, Melog, is still perched on the window and its eyes follow Adora's movements in the dark.

"I'm ignorant about the true reasons that could make you accept to unite yourself with a person like me, your Majesty, but I respect them. I just hope sincerely that we can aim to have some kind of a cordial relationship in front of our subjects, for the sake of our kingdoms and of Etheria' Adora grabs the doorknob of the door. Outside, the rain had started to pour "I shall sleep in the next room, please rest assured that you can sleep safe here. I apologize for any anguish I may have brought you tonight. I let my heart speak before my mind, it was my mistake, I assure you it won't happen again. "

It truly breaks their heart. Adora feels betrayed and, above all, feels stupid. So incredibly devastated over the fact that the woman whom they had already started to swear their heart to seems to feel nothing for them but resentment and anger. What a cruel joke from the gods, to draw near Adora everything, the only thing they have ever wanted, just to yank it beyond their desperate grasp, like a payment for the pain the past caused.

They open the door and step inside. There is a tense silence hanging in the air. Adora stands still for a few moments, waiting, but as the seconds stretch longer they become more hopeless.

The studio is small but comfortable and there is a loveseat lounging next to the fireplace. Adora knows they won't be able to live like this forever, but for tonight, it's enough.

"It was the rose"

C'yra's voice raises over the sound of the rain. Adora stops, turning their face slightly towards her.

"Beg your pardon?"

The door is already midway closed, but Adora can see C'yra shape. She is now standing besides the bed, still tense but...different. There is an expression on her beautiful face Adora can't decipher.

"You gave me a white rose, as a present" C'yra continues, swallowing thickly. Adora follows the movement of her throat with their eyes "That's why I said yes."

The soft blue light of the crystal lamps and the lightings outside are the only thing illuminating the room. Adora can really see C'yra for the first time, free from the weight of her heavy wedding dress and the sparkle of the tinkling jewels.

She still wears the moon shaped crown over her forehead, but the hair has been loose of the tight braids and now falls free and wild down her back, framing her face like flames to wood. The white nightgown brushes just above her naked ankles and the sight makes Adora feel like she is seeing some secret thing not meant to the mortal eyes. The silk and lace fabric

makes C'yra look smaller, less sharp but just as lovely. Adora can see the soft curve of her breasts as her chest rises and falls with her breathing.

Their face flushes red in embarrassment and Adora snaps their sight away and back to her piercing colorful eyes. They have, after all, no right in seeing her like this.

"I don't get it."

C'yra worries her lip between her fang for a moment, considering, and then she sighs, heavy and exhausted. As the light of the candles flutters with the damp breeze, Adora can see that her eyes shine like pools of crystal water, blinking fast as to scare the treacherous tears away. It's a gesture, so small and fast and vulnerable that if Adora wasn't looking directly at her face, they would have missed it. Adora's heart makes a flip inside her chest while they witness C'yra retreat into herself again. She climbs inside the bed and turns her back to Adora, voice muffled against the pillows.

"Good night, King Pendragon"

The door closes.

✾

The hooded figure traverses the dense woods just outside the barrier of Camelot.

Their feet are quiet, barely even raising any sound at all. The light of the pink full moon that had appeared after the storm didn't enlighten their factions.

The figure stills mid track, listening, suddenly aware of the presence of another.

"They have wedded. The Half Moon and Camelot kingdoms are now one."

The shadows around the figure shift, the air dropping to a freezing state. In front of them, the darkness convulses, thickening like clotted blood until a second person steps out of it.

"So your information was true then. Good, this will please the Emperor greatly."

The woman's ebony hair wafts in the non existent airstream like spider legs. There is a ruby embedded at the middle of her red and black porcelain mask that flashes as she speaks.

"They seem to be unable to handle each though" the hooded one adds "It will weaken their reign."

"Quite the contrary" the woman laughs, low and creepy, bending down enough to pick a lonely flower bloom from a nearby bush 'It will be their love what will distract them. They are two halves of the same heart. Even if they tried, they cannot avoid it. Those two may not know it yet but they already love one another, I saw it. After all, I was there the first time they laid eyes on each other, so many years ago. "

'And then what?"the figure asks "What will happen then?"

"When the time comes" answers Shadow Weaver, joining her skin gray hands and the very moon seems to be drowned by her shadows, "it will be their love that shatters what they so urgently seek to protect".

End of chapter I

Chapter End Notes

Adora feels a lot and so do I.

So you've made it this far. Welcome to the Camelot AU thoughts dump, please sit down and take a cup of hot chocolate.

First than all, I want to thank you for putting up with this and reading this 13k+ first chapter of my fairytale/Camelot universe. It's truly been a journey to write this and I'm truly putting all my brain and love to work here.
So, here I want to talk quickly a few points that may help you understand this chapter and story a little bit better as we move forward:
- there is a lot I want to to tell and this story is going to be a full circle from beginning to end.
- The fic will be rated as Mature. When battles or implied sexual content are described I'll put a warning advice in the top of the chapter and I'll make it easy for the people that may be triggered by it to jump the scenes without having affected the comprehension of the story.
- Everybody is slightly older here. As an example, Adora here is 26 and Catra is 24.
- Granamyr is a real character of the old She-Ra show. It was an ancient 10000 years old dragon that lived in a time when his kind and humans fought for Ethernia's control after a wizard turned them against each other.
- White roses are commonly given in weddings and other ceremonies, but their meaning of hope and respect comes from a long time before. Again, as Catra defends respect over anything else, Adora giving her a white rose was what made her think Camelot could be a better place now. She has a lot of bite but also a lot of Heart.
- Adora is described here as a non binary all pronouns lesbian, much like Noelle Stevenson themselves, and that this fact does not make them a man. Just as Entrapta will be talked as nonbinary they/them. If intolerance and ignorance gets the better of you this story in not for you and I kindly ask you to leave

Chapter 2: A moment in time

Chapter Summary

> "Unbelievable. Not a single word for weeks outside of the meetings, yet here you are, making fun of me in front of my own guards. This may as well have been considered betrayal, your Majesty"

Chapter Notes

> New chapter! And just in time for my birthday! Yay!
>
> Hope you enjoy it, see you at the end :)
>
> Warnings for this chapter: slightly mentions of side character deaths.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CHAPTER 2. A moment in time

"I cannot fix on the hour, or the spot, or the look or the words, which laid the foundation. It was too long ago. I was in the middle before I knew that I had begun."

— Jane Austen, *Pride and Prejudice*

Music that inspired this chapter X X X

✾

Adora Pendragon is utterly infuriating.

Catra grumbles this to herself as she climbs the staircase of the tower. There, is damp cold because for some unknown reason no candles burn in the chandeliers stacked up the wall.

"What the hell is wrong with these stairs? I've been walking for ages" she growls under her breath, annoyed. The light fur of her arms had risen after a freezing burst of air and she could feel the starts of her hair getting fluffier as the humidity of the tower fell heavier over her.

Catra would rather eat sand than admit it, but she had gotten herself lost around an hour ago and there was no one else to blame but herself.

She was just trying to get back to the chambers, mind you, after another exhausting meeting with the rest of the Round Table. It had been a few weeks after her arrival and the following wedding, yet, the reunions with the others were still stiff and uncomfortable.

The King would sit in her chair, hair pulled up tight against their head - and honestly by the time they would hit thirty all their hair would be gone -, loose fitting white shirt tucked on the worn out leather pants, not a single piece of gold except for the circlet in their forehead. She would not look or talk directly at Catra unless needed and only about some political matter, even though they were sitting right next to each other. Then, after the meeting was over, he would stand up quickly and leave the room alone or with the Brightmoon regents, not without bowing their head towards Catra, mouth shot closed. They would not see each other until dinner and only when accompanied by other members of the table. By the time night time arrived, the King would enter into the studio room without another word.

Dawn and repeat.

It was uncomfortable and tortuous. And Catra couldn't find in herself to judge them.

The very first morning after the ceremony Catra had laid still in bed watching the night pass by. She hadn't been able to sleep at all the entire night and by the restlessness that could be heard at the other side of the studio's door, neither had the King.

When the dawn came, she heard them open the door and approach silently the wardrobe in front of the bed. Catra pretended to sleep, ears alert. There were the distinctive sounds of items scattering in and around before the King closed the wardrobe again so quietly that only Catra’s sensitive ears would be able to pick it up.

They returned to the studio right after. By the time the maidens arrived to help Catra dress, the King was already out of the room.

She wouldn't recognize it out loud but she was scared beyond belief, that first night. She was able to endure the departure, and the travel; the marry, the business, the act. But allowing herself to be open and vulnerable with a complete stranger, let alone one that had been poisoned to her eyes since young, had been too much. If fact, she had been ready to scratch the living eyes out of their head, even if she knew she would have to swallow her pride at the end.

Yet King Adora had shown her nothing but the utmost respect from beginning to end. It had robbed Catra from her breath.

Catra had sworn to herself from the very start that there would be nothing but a polite relationship between themselves. She had spent years trying to convince herself that the King and all she represented was this awful thing, both in heart and in face. Nothing more than hypocrites and liars full of a hubris that they feed by taking everything for themselves. How King Uther would chase the magicats. How he would sit on his red throne, crown high and blade bloodied. How his kin were the same, how they would hunt her as a prize, as lesser, if they were to ever find them.

After all, it was what that *woman* had told her all those nights ago, when bedtime came and she would pick her up from her mother's room and send her to her own chambers. Stories which instead of lull her to sleep would terrorize her dreams for years, even after she was banished.

The truth, at least of the last part, was very different.

Stupid stupid stupid. Catra growls, cleaning the knees of her purple pants off spider webs and dust *You still believed what that… that woman said to you. After everything that happened. How can you be so dumb.*

Catra was ashamed. She knew that she had been unjust and cruel with Adora, and even if her reservation against them could be excused, the thought of it made her get embarrassed of herself.

The first time Catra had seen her it had felt as if a cold wash of water traveled down her spine. Their pass through the town went almost in a blur in which Catra could only hear white noise and see quick motions. She knew Scorpia and Entrapta had managed to organize a whole parade with the rest of the magicats but she could not focus on it at all. Her mind had gone in overdrive with the weight of her decision.

She had held onto Scorpia while ascending the main stairs of Castle Grayskull, anxiety getting the better of herself. Scorpia had said nothing but she was Catra's friend and she knew that as much as Catra would like to pretend she wasn't nervous, the reality was different. Yet, when Catra and the rest entered the throne room, every single thought she'd had went flying out of the window.

She expected to see this imposing, proud person sitting there, in a golden throne pouring richness and overly confidence from every pore.

Instead, what Catra found was a tall person that looked as much as about to have a nervous attack as Catra did.

The first thing Catra noticed was the way they were fidgeting with their fingers again and again in a grounded motion which perked the princess's attention immediately. She wore comfortable clothes nowhere near the luxury clothing Catra had imaginated and they were sitting almost uncomfortably in the oak wood throne. Their ears were bright pink in the tips and their lips were dry and chipped from biting on them often.

She had a strong jaw and nose, decorated with a series of small white scars and sun freckles over their tan skin. Their blonde hair was messy, held up only in a loose ponytail falling around one of his shoulders. His bright blue eyes looked almost like the crystals in the dome of the room when the sunlight touched them. They were smart eyes, intense, full of wonder, nervousness and curiosity.

Catra's heart had done a strangled loop inside her at their sight. She thanked for the dark fabric Scorpia had throw over her face as she insisted that tradition was important or some dumb thing like that, it helped her now to hide her own blush.

They were sure of themselves, it could be seen in the way they hold their shoulders, but their words were heart warming and modest. She wasn't the scary nobelity Catra had taken her for, they were just a normal person, restless on their sit and shy looking in an almost endearing way.

The way he acted during the audience and all the next day just helped to prove that train of thought. Adora was exactly the opposite type of person that awful woman had convinced Catra they were. It made Catra conflicted to a point where her own anxiety and bad judgement boiled to an exploding point.

Adora could have lashed, yelled, recriminated her about her hurtful words. But he had done none of that, just asking Catra why. Just asking her to stop, with eyes so sad it made her know immediately she had made a mistake.

The thought made Catra's heart clench painfully in her chest

Scorpia had questioned her too, Catra remembers as she finally reaches the end of the stairs at the top of the tower, sometime in the travel from Half Moon to here. She had been awfully quiet the entire time since Catra's acceptance which was nowhere near normal in her. They had gone together through strategy plans, army resources, political instances, but other than that Scorpia had remained thoughtful, the crease between her eyebrows deeper with each day. Catra had patiently awaited for that moment, in which her friend would just finally break down and let the curiosity get the best of her.

"But wildcat" muttered Scorpia out of the blue, while scrunching a tiny piece of cake, the childhood nickname rolling easily from her mouth. They had been discussing the terms that had been arrived at with the Royal Advisor, all the while Catra complained about the First Ones and their hubris "why would you say yes to their proposal? You have rejected thousands of suitors before, yet you accept the proposal of the very one who you swear to hate for life. It just, it just doesn't make sense."

Scorpia scratched her short hair and looked at her in confusion. Catra scoffed, crossing her arms and letting herself fall right back into the cushions.

"First than all, it hasn't been thousands. And second, I've already told you Scorpia, it was convenient. Half Moon will sooner or later run out of resources, winters have been getting cruder with time. And we can't just stay in the dark forever. Our people deserve to live free in this world"

Scorpia's eyes were unsure, immediately giving her away in her incredulity. Catra groaned again, covering her eyes with the palms of her hands in exasperation.

"I know you are confused Scorp, but think of it this way. I'm *bored* of seeing, hearing, learning and walking around the same things every single day."

"Are you sure?" Scorpia insisted, not convinced at all

"Yes*, Scorpia*. That's it. You don't need to dig more about it. It was good for the kingdom."

"Actually" interjected Entrapta, toying with a little trinket on their hands "it was the rose."

Catra fell silent, turning her head so fast towards them she worried for a second over whiplash. She dogged knives with her eyes at Entrapta, but the last didn’t mind her at all.

"The rose?" pressured Scorpia, bless her heart, very much still confused about the matter.

"Yes. The rose King Adora sent her. Catra was going to say a very colorful no until that Lady in black gave it to her" Entrapta raised her head smiling. Scorpia gasped and looked at Catra with big soft eyes.

"Oh, wildcat, I didn’t know you had that in you."

"Shut it" she growled "That is not true."

"Oh, but it is! I studied it! The data never lies, you know that. A hundred percent of all your suitors before had given you jewels, and necklaces, and perfumes; gold, silver, those curious packages that explode in the air too, remember? Quite an interesting experiment that was." Catra hissed at the memory of her burned halls "You, understandably, probably were expecting the same from the King, or worse given their family fame. We all grew up listening to the stories of them and their kind. Except that, she didn't. Even when they so desperately need your help. She sent a single flower and nothing else."

Catra shifted uncomfortable on her seat. Many members of the Court had dismissed Entrapta before, acting like little assholes around them and their inventions, but none of those fools could really see how incredibly smart and observant they were. That was one of the reasons Catra had taken them in easily. They were exceptional, except of course when all that intelligence was focused on her.

"I still don't get it" pouted Scorpia

"White roses have a meaning. A single one gives a message of admiration, of hope. So in small words" explained Entrapta, stretching to pick a tiny pink biscuit "all those other suitors tried to pressure Catra and *purchase* her, but Adora, who was supposed to be the worst of them all, showed respect. She didn't try to buy her, she gave her a choice. The freedom of saying no. And that is something Catra highly values."

The chariot fell back into silence. Entrapta returned to their trinket like nothing even happened, Scorpia stared at the desserts and Catra looked at the trees passing by through the hanging fabrics

"It changes nothing" she said after a while "I’ve given them a chance, as mom always asked me to with people. I've given them the chance of being different but it doesn’t mean they actually are. This is still a political matter only. By marrying them I'm making sure that what happened to our people all those years ago doesn't happen again."

Scorpia gives her back that sad look that Catra despises.

"Catra… you know, what we were told since children, it's possible all a lie. You know that right? I know that their family's history is real and unforgivable. But those stories about them, about King Mara and her child, *she* told them to us Catra. And she was a liar. Light Spinner…"

"Do not pronounce her name in my presence Scorpia" hissed Catra, the fine fur on her neck standing. Scorpia back tracked, eyes widened in surprise. Catra breathed slow through her nose, dropping her eyes to the floor "I'm sorry, I shouldn't have snapped at you."

"It's alright, Wildcat" Scorpia laid her claw over Catra's hand "I know it's difficult for you. She was your nana after all."

"She was a traitor, and she deserved what she got"

The caravan passed over to a wood bridge, the calm water underneath reflecting Catra's face.

"Besides, it doesn't matter. If what you say is true, if they really prove to be different we may become polite with each other but I" Catra shuddered, scared by the weight of her own words "I could never love a First One."

Catra was a fucking hypocrite.

Entrapta was right, like always. Catra had taken the rose not only as a present or as a peace offering, but also as a chance for Adora to prove to be different. To not be what she had been told. To be someone who wanted to do better.

She had promised to herself, as she packed her things, that she would listen to what her moms always told her when they lived. Being less hard on others, trust more. To give people a chance, including herself. She thought she could do it, as she said yes in front of the Priest, as she looked into those steel blue hopeful eyes, she thought they could do it together. Find in each other a friend.

I'm sorry, mom Catra had thought at night, in an empty bed in a strange room with only Melog as company, who had close to curl outside of the studio door in silence. *You were right. But I'm trying. I really am.*

She had seen Adora over the last weeks, quietly studying them and his interactions with others.

The King was always educated, compassionate and warm. They would look at their people as an equal, no matter the range or the job or the age. She had seen how the people of the town loved them, and honoured them. Had heard how proud they were that they were their King.

Adora had grown with these people, had played and learned with them. They knew her. Adora wore his heart on his sleeve and would always try to give part of themselves to help others. Even when it implied for them to return to the chamber at dawn or to almost fall asleep at dinner. It was dumb, admirable and soul stirring. As she said, utterly insufferable.

Catra had also seen him with the rest on the magicats. They would always be comforting and cheerful, asking everyone if they felt good, if they've had any problems. Introducing them to their own court with naturality.

Catra's people would stop her on her walks to talk about something Adora had done for them or helped them with. Just a few days ago Catra had seen Adora knee deep in the mud helping a group of merchants to free a stuck chariot out of it.

It always made Catra a little bit speechless and a little bit sad.

She didn't need someone to tell her it had been her own attitude who had separated them even before they had started. She was aware. She was trying to figure out a way to make things better day after day.

Adora's friends were aware too. Catra didn't know if Adora had said something, she suspected they hadn't, but the hard looks she had been receiving from the others told her that he didn't need to. The rest of the Table clearly didn't like her.

For all instances, the first royal meeting, the very same day after the wedding, had been nothing but a complete disaster.

When Catra entered the room Adora was already sitting at the north side of the round table. She looked at her for a few seconds and then turned down her sight, faking to pay attention to the papers in front of her. The others were waiting, looking back and forth between them and then throwing a cold stare to Catra. Adora didn't seem to notice.

Scorpia and Entrapta also were there. Adora had made sure to give them their rightful chairs before Catra arrived, she found out later, not caring that neither had kingdoms of their own anymore. *We are all the same* Scorpia cited to Catra that evening. *We all deserve to be here.*

The presence of her friends by her side helped to ease her mind a little and she absently wondered if Adora had done it on purpose.

The meeting went for a long time. Most of it to organize the adding of Half Moon to the rebellion and sit bases for commercial paths and warm resources. It had gone mostly uneventful except for the strong reaction that had been caused when Adora declared they wanted to send at least half of Camelot's army back to Half Moon. Their advisor had lost all color from her face while the table exploded in surprised sermons. Catra kept her mouth close the whole time, searching Adora's eyes with her own without result.

Adora had alleged that Catra, C'yra, and the Half Moon kingdom had already brought to Camelot a great portion of their own warriors and that there was no way he would let Half Moon go unprotected. At the end it was accorded that a third of the Camelot's army would travel back to Half Moon to join the rest of the magicats and that it would be on C'yra's decision and only on hers how to organize them and their tasks once they arrived at her home. Catra's eyes stung in the edges for the rest of the reunion.

Once it was over Catra had waited for everyone to make their leave in order to go. She didn't feel ready to confront anyone at that moment. However, the second she had stepped outside

the chamber, the rulers of Brightmoon had stopped her.

"Queen C'yra" called Queen Glimmer, approaching her. She was beautiful, a little bit shorter than Catra with short pink and purple hair. Her soft lilac dress was the same shade as the wings in her back but her eyes were hard and her mouth was pressed in an annoyed gesture. Behind her, a tall man with a strong jaw and worried eyes followed up close "I'm Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon, High Sorceress of Avalon, and this is my husband, King Bow, Master Archer of Camelot."

Her voice was strangled and quick. She was definitely not happy.

"Yes, I…"

"And you, you are a complete idiot" finished Glimmer with a snarl. Catra flinched slightly under the accusing look of Queen Glimmer. There was nobody else in the corridors now which added to the feeling of being trapped.

"Darling…" tried the King, resting his hand on his wife's shoulder, sending an apologetic look at Catra's direction.

"No, no Bow. Let me say it, before I transport her ass into the void" Glimmer raised her finger silencing her husband and redirecting all her sparkling energy back to Catra "Adora is such a wonderful person. They have this big patient heart and can't even find themselves getting mad with anyone, ever. But I do. You've been here three days and you've arrived at a wrong and cruel conclusion way too fast, *Queen* C'yra. You should be ashamed of yourself."

Catra found herself at a loss, biting her tongue hard. She held Glimmer's stare, however, and didn't back track at her imposing aura. Catra still had a pride of her own and didn't appreciate other people minding on her problems, not even with Adora.

"Is you cornering me in a new diplomatic method, Queen *Sparkles?* Because unless it is I don't see how my relationship with the King is of your business."

Sparkles gaped in surprise. Her raw offended face brought Catra some kind of satisfaction. It was probably not a good idea to antagonize more people but she had a headache and pariente had never been a strength. Behind the Brightmoon' queen her husband drew a hand over his face in defeat, shaking his head in disapproval.

"Sparkles" she repeated slowly, face melting into a death stare expression "I really didn't want to believe a person would be so self absorbed in herself as to judge someone they barely know so quickly but you've really proved me wrong. I hope you enjoy staying alone."

Glimmer rested her hands at both sides of her hips, giving one last hard look to Catra before turning on her low heels and clicking decidedly with them away. Bow hesitated, looking back at Catra. She thought he may be looking something on her, based on the way he was searching her face.

"I know this must be hard on you. You are really far from home and you must have heard pretty bad stories about all of us." whatever it was he was looking for he seemed to find it,

because he let go a breath and threw her a very small smile "I get it. And Adora does too, trust me. Just… try to not be too hard on them, alright? She is a good one, and they really do care about you. If you'd give her a chance."

So now here she was, alone and lost in an icing cold tower. Catra runs her fingers over the stones of the wall, so different from the tough tapestries that decorate the corridors of Half Moon. She reaches for the handle of the only door in sight, openly swiftly to find… nothing. Absolutely nothing.

The chamber is empty, just the bare floor and a single window. It's also much smaller than the royal chamber. Catra walks to the window and gives a peak to the outside, coming face to face with only pine branches and the silhouette of the far mountains.

She is in the south part of the castle, she realizes, which is obviously abandoned. For what she knows it must also be the highest of the towers explaining the drop on the temperature compared to the rest of the castle.

Catra sighs, pinching the bridge of her nose in annoyance. She would need to walk all the way back again until she could find someone to guide her in the right direction. As much as she likes solitude and time for herself, this place feels too heavy on its silence and it makes her a weird kind of nervous.

There is a rush of air behind Catra. This time is different, dropping to a freezing like state. The sounds of drops of water outside and the chirp of birds cease at once, only static and white noise filling the empty room.

Catra is still facing the decaying window but she can't hear the jiggle of the town below, she is too high, far away in the only part of the castle nobody goes to. The fine hairs of her arms stand on point even under the thick fabric of her shirt.

She is aware that she is suddenly not alone.

Catra waits, she can feel the presence right behind her, not threatening just standing there without moving. It's heavy and tangible, she wonders if is a sorcerer, or an assassin, someone sent to erase her forever. Her nails are drawn, ready to attack. She can take it, whomever this is, Catra can take them out without a second thought, she just needs to wait for them to make a move.

There is a scratch of wood at her right and she turns towards it immediately. That's a mistake, Catra knows it the moment she moves.

The air shifts again just at her left, and the fur of her ears flutter when the chill breath of a voice calls right next to her.

"C'yra"

❀

C’yra of D´riluth III is a stubborn brat.

Adora mutters this to themselves as they fix his gloves in the armory.

They've been trying to give her space, seeing it was pretty obvious she didn't desire any other kind of contact with them. Sometimes Adora would look at her with raised eyebrows and hopeful eyes and C’yra would look taken aback, eyes a little wet and scrunching her nose as if she were to say something, then her face would shut down immediately and she would turn away from them. It drove Adora crazy.

They would, then, only talk in the meetings either to calmly agree or to strongly disagree in the kingdom's matters, which usually ended up in C’yra having an extremely reasonable point of view, swinging her tail back and forth and giving him exasperated looks from time to time, and Adora just listening at her with their mouth agape.

She is beautiful, smart, unyielding, a fearsome strategist, a just ruler but she is also a pain in the ass. Since the first moment C’yra sat at the Table she proved to be strongly opinionated and not afraid to correct the other nobles during the Table meetings which for the displeasure of mostly there, was exactly what they needed to hear. Adora had spent a good amount of hours talking in private with everyone in the Table, asking them to take it easier and being more assertive with C’yra.

In a matter of days C’yra had gone through every paper and plan of Camelot scattered both in their chambers and the library, designing new plans of harvest, commercial routers, water management and cattle raising. Camelot’s management was not wrong, their barters, pacts and jobs were well organized and efficient, but after her arrival the production of the kingdom had gone up to four hundred percent, as Prince Entrapta had let known after one long general financial discussion.

Adora knew from both the knights and advisors that C’yra had been meeting with the habitants of the town, learning the ways of the people and introducing her own delegates with the goal of combining both their methods and boosting them to their maximum potential. The Queen understood the importance of protecting the well being of the people before touching the matter of war.

The residents of Camelot had warmed up to her almost immediately. At first they had been unsure, finding strange her presence without the King by her side, but she had quickly won their trust by being kind and considerate. In return, the people had started to teach her the magic they were capable of, consisting in mostly mundane matters that made things easier for their crafts and professions, nothing that could be considered highly impressive. Yet, the Queen sat patiently, listening to them and learning what they had to teach her, not once showing annoyance or acting like she was superior either on magic or position. It had stolen the town’s heart.

Adora knew this from the amount of concerned advisors that would show up at the door of his royal office, surprised by Adora's little concern on letting the Half Moon heir go in and about around every corner of the kingdom.

Adora was getting tired of assuring these people that indeed, Queen C'yra was not only her own person but also just that, Camelot's new queen, and she had all the right to learn anything she wanted and go anywhere she wished without anyone's permission, much less Adora's.

Besides, the happiness of the people over her presence and the wonderful integration of the magicats, who would teach their magic free and unashamed, to the everyday life of their people had everybody in high spirits. It was impressive, what this extraordinary woman had done in such a short amount of time.

Adora was swept off their feet by her and it was getting kind of annoying.

That was a lie. Adora's heart did little dances every time a favorable report about one of C'yra's plans would cross his table, or when they would visit the town to hear joyful and grateful comments about the Queen on every side.

They wish their mother could be there, to teach her how to survive the devastating infatuations he had over a person who didn't wish to know or talk to them but that they were already married to. Mara's face would probably be prize winning.

Adora's mind traveled back to his teenage years, when they would stutter every time they'd see a knight across the field defeating her opponent to the ground. Or when Adora would blush pink when a maiden her age smiled at her through the mirror of the chamber. Or when she would catch the look of a naked ankle below the skirts of the pretty dancers in the street. It never went past the general awkwardness and their mother laughing light heartedly at them in the nights Adora would complain about complicated things, like feelings, with her.

"It's normal, my dear" Mara would say while braiding their hair "We can't all punch our feelings out like you do."

"But I don't want these feelings, mom. They make me look dumb when I try to talk with girls" Adora said, throwing her hands at the air in a small tantrum "Why can't I just impress them with sword fighting or something, talking is so *complicated."*

Mara snickered, her steel blue eyes shimmering in the light of the candle, making them look almost entirely purple.

"One day you will find someone that will turn your world outside down and we'll see if you don't want those feelings anymore" she said just to be greeted with the exasperated sigh of her child. It only made her more smug.

"But how will I know, mom?" Adora asked, quickly turning to her mother, young face serious. There was still baby fat around their cheeks, with the hair almost orange at the dim light. They had an still healing scar just above his eyebrow which Mara caressed gently while she was thinking.

"Well, it's different for everyone. Some people take months, years to realize they are in love. Others take a matter of moments. Some people even find more than one person to love, isn't that amazing? They are all valid, my dear, and there is no rush for you to find anyone now.

The important thing is what you feel, inside." Mara touched Adora's chest with her index, right above her heart

"You have such a benevolent heart Adora, and you are so smart, there is no need for you to pressure yourself over this. When the right time comes, you will know, you will see them and see your best friend, you will look at them and feel like every breath you take is so you can spend a second longer with them, like the blood that runs through your veins does it because they exist, like an explosion of magic tousling your hair. Maybe it will be someone you'd known for years, maybe it will be someone you crossed looks with once. But you'll know it's there, and when you feel it I want you to hold onto that feeling and not let go, for there is no more beautiful reason for living than love and being loved."

Adora rushed forward, hugging their mother tightly. It made Mara laugh while rocking them lightly over the blanket.

"You love so openly, my dear, so honestly and freely. And you are so loved, Adora. For your family, for your friends, for your people. I want you to always remember that, no matter what happens in your future. That you are worthy of all that love too."

Now, years later, Adora misses the embrace of her mother mostly in moments like this. They remind themselves every day what her mother told him that day, like a good luck omen for rainy days. Mara's kindness had given Adora hope and now in this moment of their life, it was the reason Adora could breath deep and be patient.

Catra was, still, a stubborn brat but she was also gentle and just, and for Adora she was worth all the time she needed to feel safe with them. Even if it didn't mean loving Adora, they would accept whatever Catra could give her, even if it was just a sometimes confusing exasperating look

Adora finished wrapping her arms as she left the armory, heading to the open yard destined to the knight's practice. They can see them warming up and running across the grass following the energetic instructions of the general standing right at the edge.

"Sir Lonnie!", Adora calls, a smirk already forming on their face as their friend turns to meet them.

"Well, isn't it the King themselves", answers Lonnie, punching them playfully in the shoulder. "Where have you been? Can't spare a few moments for us now that you are all settled down?"

"Jerk". Adora fixes her ponytail absently checking over the field. There is a scrawny looking knight knocking against training elements and water buckets as he desperately tries to carry the spears. "Seriously? Kyle?"

"Hey, we can't all be magic legendary warriors with mighty swords", Lonnie defends with her hands at each side of her hips. "Besides, Rogelio is much happier since we allowed Kyle to come back after the fire incident. Look at him, he is not even grunting that much."

It was true, Adora could see the tall figure of Rogelio helping Kyle up with his task, all the while they communicated on quick signs with their hands.

"At least is helping the others" continues Lonnie, "to learn sign language. Kyle is actually not completely useless when it comes to teaching them and I can't manage to do it all on my own anymore since you ranked me as General. And Rogelio loves him, so I can't complain that much as long as he is not actually in the field."

Adora hums approvingly actually satisfied with the way Sir Lonnie had decided to manage the knights. After their coronation it had become more and more difficult for Adora to attend to her responsibilities as knight and the actual practice he could go through were scattered. Naming Sir Lonnie as her General and second in command in battle had been one of the greatest ideas they had, as they were good friends and Adora could trust her.

"Tell me then, Lonnie. Have *you* found someone recently?". Lonnie fidgets in her feet, a low blush appearing over her ears telling Adora everything they need to know. She smirked, wiggling her eyebrows in amusement. "Wow, who is the fortunate person?"

"Oh don't be an ass" returns Lonnie, shoving him aside. "Her name is Starla, dumbass. I met her last month after the Salineas shipment arrived. I kind of came out of nowhere and she got startled and punched me in the face."

"My goddess, Lonnie. Who knew that knocked you down would be the key to your heart" says Adora, squatting from the fit of laughter. After a few moments he is able to process the name correctly. "Starla? Isn't she one of the Star Siblings?"

"Indeed" agrees Lonnie, scratching the back of her neck "I really like her, you know? She is funny and smart and she does have a very strong right."

Adora rests his hand over Lonnie's shoulder squeezing twice in reassuring.

"I'm glad to see you happy, my friend. It was about time"

Lonnie returns their smile, genuinely, before it melts into a mischievous look once again.

"By the way, Starla says her sister Tallstar has been glued to the hip to Prince Entrapta lately. Isn't that one of the advisors of your wife? ". Adora feels their face fall slightly and can see that Lonnie notices by the way she knits her eyebrows together. "Touchy matter, uh?"

"I just have a lot in my mind lately", Adora bends to grab one of the standard swords from its rest hold, looking at his reflection on the bare blade for a few seconds. "Allow me to punch my feelings out for a bit, will you?"

Lonnie still has a calculatory look on her face but her lips break into a smile as she bows to the king in mockery.

"Be my guest, your Majesty" then turns to the yard to call for everyone. "Hey, Kyle! Why don't you show the King those news sword tricks you've been learning?"

❀

"C’yra"

Catra hisses, throwing her claws blindly behind her and jumping two feet away from the window. She squats near the floor scanning the room with her sharp eyes, but there is no one there.

She looks around quickly, in the high ceilings and every corner but besides her the room is completely empty. She stands again, ears perked in high alert adrenaline still rushing on her veins, and looks through the window expecting to see someone or something that has jumped, and still, no one there. By all means, the window is too small for anyone to have gotten in and out so damn quickly. She had reacted in a matter of seconds she would have seen something.

Unless of course, there was some kind of magic involved, hiding them away from her senses. Catra raises her hand, breathing in slowly as her mothers taught her, putting all her energy on it. The world reduces to a pinpoint.

There is a familiar twinkle inside her chest, a pull, a tug running from her ribs to her cheeks and then there is bright purple light glowing from the inside of her wrist, pouring free in the skin of her open palm.

The hum of her magic surrounds the entire tower in gentle waves. She can feel every rock, every bloom and moss; every drop of water and every whisper of air. If there is something living in there, she'll know it. Her magic goes on for a couple of moments, looking, searching. Yet as her spell ends, it comes back to her with nothing.

Catra exhales, eyebrows furrowed in confusion. This place is creepy as it is, and now this thing has made her unease. She is sure she heard something her ears never lie.

Catra steps away from her spot, avoiding the small flower that has grown behind her bare feet, an usual side effect of her magic.

"C'yra"

Catra yelps, jumping in the air in her fright. She turns around again and again, looking desperately or the source of the voice but the tower is still empty. The temperature had dropped more, if that is even possible, making the sweat in her face start to lighty freeze.

"C’yra. Don’t be afraid."

She is now near the open door, walking backwards carefully. There is nobody there. Catra made sure, yet she can feel again that presence right in front of her, dropping over the chamber. Her sight is perfect in both light and dark but there is no shape there, just a bone chilling feeling right in front of her face. Is with her breath held that she realizes she can’t see the light pouring from the window anymore.

"C’yra"

Catra runs. The long minutes climbing up the stairs of the tower transforms into mere seconds as she lashes out of the room and out of the tower, somehow managing to not misstep and fall over her own face.

Catra can't hear the voice anymore over the loud beating of her heart on her ears. She doesn't stop until after she finds herself into a new corridor. It is much warmer there, cozier, and from the walls are hanging both the dragon of the Pendragon's and the moon shape of the Half Moon banners. Catra can hear movement around her, probably from the castle staff doing their daily chores, and she smells freshly baked bread nearby telling her she is now close to the kitchens.

Still, there are goosebumps running down her arms and spine, and she knows her tail is puffy and restless. She runs a hand over her damp hair, looking back at the stairs. An old maiden walks around the corner in that moment and almost crashes against the immovable figure of Catra standing there.

"Oh goddess! You've scared me, child!" the maiden says, taking a hand to her chest in surprise. She looks up and then takes a second look, noticing who the person she has almost run over is. "My Queen! Oh my apologies, I hadn't seen you there! -she laughs, studying Catra's blank expression- Are you feeling well, your Majesty?"

Catra looks at her concerned eyes and then back at the bottom of the tower's stair, gulping. It takes her two tries but finally her voice comes through.

"Was it you in the tower just now?" she asks her. Her voice shakes just a little. "Were you or someone else the ones calling me up there?"

"What?" the maiden follows the directions of Catra's eyes, comprehension falling on her eyes. "Goodness no, your Majesty. That place is haunted, and terribly so! nobody goes there, ever."

"Haunted?" laughs nervously Catra, dusting off her clothes and fixing her moon crown as she starts to calm down.

"Indeed" the maiden affirms, shaking her head surely. "There are voices and specters up there, your Majesty, everyone in the castle knows it. Some children used to go up there and play around and they would always run back crying and assuring they had heard or seen something. Nothing alive lives there, and it's better not to mess with those matters, that's why King Mara banished it from using" her voice trails a little before picking up again. "Besides, it's also not really safe anymore, the roof is falling after so many years of poor maintenance. It would be for the better for you to not go up there at all, my Queen."

Catra continues to look at the open arc of the stairs, trying to piece together what she had heard and what the maiden was just saying. She believed in ghosts, of course, lost souls were as real as curses and magic. But it didn't mean it was less terrifying or that Catra was really that happy to encounter them.

"Queen C'yra? Oh, you are so pale! Do you want me to go look for the King?"

"No!" she almost yelled, pulling herself out of her trance, "No, thank you. Thank you. I'll find my way out now."

She walks two steps up front before turning her head back at the maiden with her ears turned down.

"Could you please show me how to get to the yard?"

❀

Catra walks through the horses' stable. It's big, clean and quiet, with only the tranquil presence of the animals to make her company. She has had time to calm herself after the earlier scare, spending the last hour offering small pieces of hay to the steeds.

Her curiosity makes her almost want to go back to the tower and investigate more about that presence. Scorpia knew more about apparitions than her, so she would bring up the matter during supper anyway. But the fact that that seemingly ghost had apparently known who she was, was reason enough for her to leave the matter rest a bit.

She knew Camelot was old, and most probably cursed, with all the things that had been lived between its walls. And she wasn't new to grisly encounters, having grown up in the place she had with people that took pride in studying ancient magic and befriending feral magic creatures. But for now, it could wait.

There is a sudden outburst of noise from outside the barn that calls Catra's attention. She hides behind one of the pillars, covered by the shadows and cubs of hay in time for a myriad of people to enter the space she was just in. The hands of the workers glow a soft blue as they use their magic to carry a beautiful white stallion to the center of the clean hay over the floor. The animal looks in great pain, struggling to stay still on their side as the people walk around quietly and efficiently to make them comfortable.

There is a second rush of movement as someone else enters the stable, steps hurried. It hasn't been that long but she could recognize the rhythm of those feet anywhere.

"What happened?"

A young looking person with a dark stubble and a low hair bun raises their head at Adora's call. They are kneeling besides the horse holding a clean cloth over the bloodied wound on its back leg. Adora rushes near them, throwing himself on their knees besides them.

"We took Swift Wind to his usual morning walk" explains the stable's head, changing the clothes quickly once it has damped in blood. "We didn't realize there was a water snake nearby. He got scared and ran right into the brambles. I think they may have caught his leg and he hurt himself by pulling from it. We rushed him here as soon as we could."

Catra peaks her head a little more from her hiding place, seeing the worry washing over Adora's handsome face.

They wait for the stable's head to take away the current cloth before ripping out their glove with their teeth and placing the palm of their hand over the exposed angry wound.

The energy of the stable shifts as it always does when there is magic involved, but instead of getting heavier it becomes lighter in a way it makes Catra almost check if she is not actually floating on her place. It’s so warm that the last of the cold inside Catra’s chest disappears completely.

Adora’s hand starts glowing golden and then brighter and brighter until it becomes a shimmering tornasol light filling every corner of the stable. It stays like this for a couple of minutes until it eventually lowers down into a soft yellow radiance.

The yellow light disappears as Adora raises her hand. The horse is calm now, resting in the ground, his breathing even. Catra returns her eyes to his leg and there, where no mere seconds before was a wide wound, is nothing but smooth healthy skin.

"You have magic" Catra says, getting out of the shadows and approaching the group. She can see Adora jumping over the sound of her voice. Her eyes widen a little at the sight of Catra and she stutters for a few seconds before answering.

"Well, yes I do." she says, getting up "It would be kind of embarrassing of me otherwise."

Catra doesn’t say anything, walking until she is standing right next to Adora. She is so close to them she can smell the thick scent of her sweat, something that is indiscutible metal and the strawberry tarts of that morning breakfast. Their arms brush against each other as she looks down to the animal, ignoring the sudden blush on her cheekbones.

The horse shakes his head and then stands on his own. It's a gorgeous animal, of a spotless white that almost seems to glow in rainbow colors in the late morning light, towering on all its height over them.

Catra reaches to him and caresses his crib, using a spot of magic to tranquilize him from the situation's stress. She is aware that Adora hasn't taken her eyes from her in all these time but she makes no comment. The rest of the stable men have scattered across the barn, checking the rest of the horses and cleaning the items used while they transported the hurt horse. Catra can see them throw them a discrete surprised look. She also notices that two knights have walked in and are now waiting patiently behind their king.

"So" says Adora, after a little while "do *you* have magic?"

Catra turns her head towards the King, mildly offended for that awful joke, but they have their eyebrows lifted and there is a genuine curious expression on her face. She is serious. She is trying.

"Of course I have magic, cabbage head" huffes Catra, rolling her eyes "It comes with the name, *magic*- cat. Seriously.'

Adora widens their eyes in shock and there is a few seconds of silence that start to stretch between them, which stresses Catra out. She doesn’t know what to expect next.

To her astonishment, Adora *snorts.* Actually, honestly snorts. It's a ridiculous sound and it takes Catra completely for surprise.

"Unbelievable" laughs Adora, high pitched and dumb, looking at Catra with soft eyes "Not a single word for weeks outside of the meetings, yet here you are, making fun of me in front of my own guards. This may as well have been considered betrayal, your Majesty."

Catra looks at Adora speechless, trying to decipher if they are serious or offended, but there is a reassuring smirk on his handsome face and their blue eyes are glowing with amusement. Catra raises her sharp eyebrow towards them and hums.

"My apologies for disappointing, but there is just so much a Queen can take. And I am not making fun of you, *my Lord,* I am making fun, whomever, of that ridiculous turnip looking poof you have for hair. Is that real, or is it holding itself with magic and magic alone?"

The guards that stand behind Adora shift awardly, looking between them back and forth. She can hear them cackling in the yard outside as she waits for Adora's response.

There is a new stunned look on his face and for a split of a moment Catra gets nervous she has gone too far. After all, Adora is right, they have barely talked to each other at all until now and the last time they did Catra was unnecessary cruel to them. It doesn't make her proud.

"Turnip..." Adora gasps, running a hand over his hair "You can't… you can't just adress me like this. I'm the King, what are my guards going to think of me now?"

She pats her puff of hair and laughs again, obviously following the joke. Catra lets out a relieved breath, and she is not sure if she is living a fever dream or if she just had a stroke in the tower and is now having a weird projection, but she decides to just go with it.

"Please , they have sworn loyalty to you, I'm sure they can keep a little tiny secret. And if they don't, well, you can just use that little magic of yours and turn them into toads."

Adora covers her eyes with their eyes as her shoulders shake with the contained strength of laughter.

This is so weird. Catra thinks, the start of a bubbling chuckle rising inside her. *She is so dumb.*

"I'm afraid my magic does not work like that, my Queen."

"Well then, as Prince Entrapta would say, that would make for a fine experiment, don't you think? We can't risk the good reputation of Camelot's finest hair.

Catra and Adora look at each other and giggle.

Catra tries to ignore the tingling feeling of Adora calling her *My queen* and turns her sight back to Swift Wind. He is trotting around the stable proudly as if the wound had never happened. Catra marvels in her magic as she realizes that she is actually here, standing side

by side with Adora, and she wasn't really planning on having a confrontation today but here they are.

Adora shifts, turning completely towards her. Catra panics slightly.

"C'yra…"

"Would you like to walk with me for a while?"

Adora let's his mouth fall open before coming back to their senses. He smiles at her softly.

"Lead the way"

❀

Adora and C’yra walk through the gardens of the castle together.

The gardens are not empty, there are a couple of people going in and out of the castle carrying provisions and some children enjoy the midday sun while playing in the grass.

They’ve been walking for a while, following the path of flowers, talking about Etheria’s magic. Adora feels a lot of things right now. Excitement, confusion, nervousness, and a tiny spark of apprehension.

After so many days C’yra is here now, making him company and talking easily with them. Some part of herself feels like C’yra is going to lash out and leave again but she can see the way C’yra is holding herself now, less tense though her ears still twitch a little and she plays with her fingers as she walks.

Adora can’t yet grasp the reasons why this sudden change but the quick beating of their heart can’t be denied. Something that feels like hope starts to pool on the bottom of their stomach.

"So" says C’yra, fidgeting with a loose strand of hair that had fallen over her face "your magic is focused on healing."

"Hmm. Yes, in part" Adora thinks for a little, trying to pick the right words to explain "My mother used to say that it was more like giving back life, you know. It was me who decided to learn to canalize my magic into healing. When I was little I would make flowers bloom everywhere or feel when someone was sick or tired, but with time it also gave me strength, speed and better senses if needed. I thought it would be good, if I learned to use that raw, *uncooked* magic into something good, something that could protect others."

C'yra stays quiet, considering his words. The shimmering sunset fabric of her cape reflects the sunlight. She seems lighter on these clothes, more comfortable to move around and bounce softly on her feet every time they pass a wet stone floor.

Adora is contemplating the wild look of her loose hair when Catra turns her head to them away. They lock eyes for a few moments before tearing them apart.

"How does your magic work for you?" asks Adora to save them both from the tension.

Catra smiles, small and grateful, before clearing her throat softly to speak.

"I work more with my surroundings, I guess. We never were taught to *canalize* our magic into something specific, so we usually utilize magic for everything, even mundane chores. I suppose that's why others consider our magic untamed. If we are talking about what I'm comfortable with, then it is the ambient. I can feel, hear, sense and see things much better than others, especially if there is magic involved in it. And I'm dry fond of interacting with magical creatures, it's always been easier for me."

"Like Melog?"

"Like Melog" affirms C'yra. Her gaze glasses a little then goes back to the present "My magic is not really different or more special from yours."

"But it is" interrupts Adora. C'yra looks at them in incredulity, twisting her pretty mouth "I'm being true. Since you arrived, since all of you arrived, Camelot feels different, freer. I see more and more people doing magic and being happy about it. And there are much more ancient creatures roaming around. You've been here a few weeks and everything feels much better already."

As Adora ends her speech she realizes with dread that maybe she just went a bit out of the line there. Their forehead wrinkles in worry as they look for C'yra's expression but hers is not angry. She looks shocked, yes, yet there is a pink blush kissing her cheeks.

They must have stayed staring for too long because suddenly C'yra raises her hand and pokes her once, quickly in the middle of the forehead.

"Thank you" her heterochromic eyes shine like honey and fresh water, and if Adora looks closer she thinks she can see the Draco constellation on her freckles.

Oh, wow. Wow. Goddess help me, thinks Adora, dumbfounded. They resume the walk he hadn't noticed they had stopped and he has to check if their knees haven't turned into pudding because they can feel wobbling with each step.

"I always wanted to be able to do Foresight" adds Adora as they brush their fingers over the white petals of some roses "Light Hope, my advisor, always said that it was one of the more powerful magical talents there could be. The ability of looking into the future."

He gets distracted by some of the earlier children running to them. One of them, tooth gapped, covered in mud, offers a wild flower to C'yra. She smiles immediately taking the gift as the children leave running again and giggling between themselves. It's domestic and beautiful.

"My mom could do that. Foresight" C'yra says she caresses gently the lilac petals of the flower. Adora turns her sight back to her, surprised. Her ears are twitching a little and she is looking firmly to the front but she is calm. Adora doesn't answer, waiting patiently for her

while they walk through the yard "It wasn’t a common thing in Half Moon either and it’s not something the person can control. It just comes out of nowhere."

A patch in the sky clouds above their heads and the softest of the drizzles start falling from it. It’s not bothersome, it’s actually kind of warm so nobody in the yard tries to hide from it. Adora watches as the children start to chase each other around the mud.

C’yra doesn't seem to notice the drizzle either. There are small drops of water stuck on her long lashes, but her mind is far away in another time, in another place.

"I only saw it once. She had been sick for a few weeks and the physician had made her take bed rest. It wasn’t easy to convince her, she had always been stubborn and didn’t like not doing something, but she was getting weaker so she ended up accepting" C’yra and Adora walk below the branches of a willow "That day she had been better, a tad more energetic. My mother sat by her side in the pillow, braiding her hair. And she was just looking at me, holding my hand between hers. I don’t remember what we were talking about, I’ve tried but I can’t."

C’yra takes a watery breath as to compose herself. Adora catches herself reaching for her with their hand lowering it down before she notices.

"Then out of nowhere her eyes glazed over, like she was gone. She was still looking at me, but she wasn’t *looking at me,* do you understand?"

C’yra stops, looking at Adora with hooded eyes. She is sad and tired. Adore realizes that these last weeks mustn’t have been easy for her either. This is the most they have ever talked and Adora certainly wasn’t expecting to trust them with such a delicate matter so suddenly. But C’yra had done it, and they weren’t risking it right now, so instead of saying anything they just nod once, sending her a reassuring smile. C’yra looks satisfied with it, returning to their walk.

"She was like that for a long while. My mother had already explained to me what Foresight was, so we weren’t really worried for her. When she finally returned to herself she just smiled at me the sweetest she had ever done in her life and said “*Juniper”,* nodding her head happily." C’yra scoffed light heartedly "It was my grandmother's name, which doesn't really make sense. But she kept calling me that until she fell asleep. We never didn’t push and I never got the chance to ask her, after."

C’yra’s voice dies down as they reach the stone arch that divides the gardens from the main yard. Adora stops, biting her lips. She feels tender now after C’yra’s story. It’s obvious that her mothers meant a lot for her and that she misses them deeply.

"Thank you, C’yra, for trusting me with that."

"Thanks to you, for listening, turnip head"

Adora looks up at her mischievous smirk and the little tip of a fang that peeks out of it. The drizzle has finally gone down, Adora suspects it has a lot to do with C’yra’s emotions, so seeing the hot summer sun appearing right over their heads is comforting.

Adora smooths a lock of hair that has escaped of their ponytail, tucking it behind their ear. C’yra’s eyes follow the movement. There is so much they want to say to her right now, especially about that first day. They know that things are not exactly good between them, but for the first time Adora feels like they are both stepping in firm ground. Their chat has given them the confidence they needed so badly.

"C’yra, listen"

"What is that?" cuts them off C’yra signaling to a point in Adora's blouse, right over her heart. She follows the direction of her finger struggling a little with the folds of fabrics to see better.

It’s the golden pin, a little dragon-wing thingy that Adora has had since forever. They hold it between the pads of his fingers, brushing the worn out gold.

"Oh, this? I don’t really know where this came from to be honest. I’ve always had it, ever since I was a child. I like to have it with me it calms me down, if that makes sense" is not until they return their sight to C’yra that he notices the conflicted almost pained look on her features "C’yra? What 's wrong?"

"That wing, it was my mother’s crest" her voice breaks at the ends, slender fingers shaking "She would give them to her advisors and other trustworthy allies of the palace, so we would always know who was reliable, who we could trust with our lives. How the hell do you have that?"

Adora's mind goes blank trying to piece this new information together, as C'yra grows more and more restless.

"Oh!" exclaims Adora, realization drawing in their face "I think I understand now. Your mother must have given it to me then, but I was too young so that's why I don't remember it."

"What are you talking about?" deadpans C'yra. Adora panics and goes into immediate control damage, not knowing where exactly they have gone wrong.

"I mean, that one time my mom met yours. In Half Moon. Light Hope told me about it. We were barely toddlers. I guess, I guess that's why my mother always insisted on me taking excellent care of it" they end, almost hysterically

C'yra's face is blank. She looks directly at the pin and the pin only, mind miles away.

'Did you…? You didn't know" the last part is not a question. Adora understands the queen's shock. They haven't had an opportunity to talk about it, or anything at all, until now. And it seems to be a strong matter for her, something so personal to her own mothers hitting her in the face out of the blue. Adora craves to reassure her "C'yra? Help me a little here, alright? I want to do it right, for us. Is that fine? Do you want me to give it back to you?"

"No" she answers promptly, snatching her eyes from the trinket "I just need a moment, I think. Excuse me."

Adora watches helplessly as C’yra turns, the edges of her purple vest sparkling in the sunlight as she disappears behind the stone arch.

The small wild flower lies forgotten over the floor.

❀

"So that’s what happened"

It's the day after. Adora is perched over the window on Glimmer and Bow’s room, playing with a small stuffed animal they had mistakenly taken with them.

She received them at the barrier earlier in the day, eager to meet her friends after days without seeing them. And also eager to dump on them what had happened a day prior their arrival. She had tell them the basics, omitting what C'yra had tell her about her mother's foresight. That has been told in confidence and there it would stay.

"So, let me see if I get it. Oh, I hate horses" grunts Glimmer, sitting in the bed while rubbing her sore feed "You spent weeks not talking to each other and all of sudden you both have a heart to heart impromptu chat about magic that drives you closer just for her to freak out when she sees your pin."

"Because it was her mother's, yes" Adora nodes, pouting.

"Ugh" Glimmer flops into the mattress, rubbing her forehead "Adora, why did you have to marry the most complicated princess of them all?"

"Hey!" Adora throws her a pillow without spite "If I recall you agreed with the idea".

They banter for a bit until Bow steps in between, hushing his friends.

"It’s good, Adora! You managed to have a civilized conversation with her!"

"I’m just conflicted" they answer him, flopping back to their previous position "I was starting to think we were on good track and then she shut me down again. You both know I had no idea where this pin came from! Now I don't know how to proceed."

"Well, did you talk to her last night?" Adora squirms in his place avoiding Bow's look.

"I kind of slept in my mom's office yesterday. So, I really haven't seen her?"

Bow looks very much at the edge of screaming. Even Glimmer, who is shooting bursts of sparkles from her fingers, stops at their words

"Oh Adora, you're one of the smartest persons I know, I swear. But sometimes… don't you think it would be all cleared off much easier if you, you know, actually talked to each other?" Bow has that eyebrow twitch he gets when he is done with his friends. "Remember that little magic spell called *communication* ?"

Adora huffs and then groans into their hands, defeated.

"I don't like feelings. I would rather talk politics than this" the trio stays un silence, listening to the flow of people downtown.

"I still don’t like her. She is a brat" calls Glimmer from her position in bed.

Bow and her go into their own argument about not judging people and people being idiots. Adora stops listening to them as she gets distracted by looking through their window.

C'yra is walking down the main street, right in front of the orphanage's gates. Princess Scorpia is chatting with the orphanage caretakers as she and other magicats deliver them baskets of food and blankets. Meanwhile C'yra is gifting small honey pots and jars of candy to the children surrounding them, smiling and talking with them.

It had become a necessity, the orphanage, as the war against the Horde worsened. Adora had seen the increasing reports as the amount of refugees increased and the foster homes scarsed. The castle could take in just a limited amount of people so it had turned quickly into an emergency. She had worked as fast as she could at the time, helping himself with some of the build until it was ready. It broke Adora's heart.

She knew the orphanage was working, that the children were well and protected and even the majority of them were getting adopted. But it didn't make it easier, for anyone.

An, oh so small, child walks to C'yra, she has little antlers and a pink cotton dress. She can't be more than four. C'yra's smile becomes almost blinding. She surges forward and holds the little girl between her arms, carrying her on the dip of her own hip as they talk. The little girl is carrying a She-Ra doll, Adora can see it as she raises those tiny arms to pat C'yra's cheeks playfully.

Adora is so enthralled by this little interaction that she barely notices his friends approaching her. They feel their arms surrounding her, giving her a comforting hug.

"I wish mom had told me about this. All of this" Adora confesses, hugging her friends back "I knew she kept secrets from me but it would have made things so much easier now."

"Don’t be too hard on yourself, Adora" says Glimmer, resting her chin over their shoulder "I don’t think even Mara could have foreseen this, but I’m sure she would have told you to trust yourself."

"Just talk to her" adds Bow "It will be fine"

The three of them stay there holding each other until the bells of the town sing again.

❀

When Adora enters their chambers C’yra is already there.

She is sitting with her legs crossed, going through a huddle of paper scattered across the table. A few plates of food wait in front of her, barely even touched. Next to her elbow rests the same tiny worn out She-Ra doll from earlier.

Adora stands besides the door fidgeting on his toes. C'yra's soft ears twitches before her eyes drag to their face, eyes shot up.

"Adora" she almost sounds surprised as if she didn't really believe they would be actually there. It almost fly past him that C'yra hasn't adressed him as *my lord* or other formal title since their meeting at the stable.

"Where did you get that?" Adora asks, pointing at the doll, as if he didn't know the answer already. C'yra widens her eyes in honest surprise, looking back a forth between the toy and Adora.

"From a child at the village" she finally says, holding the small doll between her fingers, gently pulling off errand pieces of hay from its fabric-made hair. "In the orphanage. She wanted me to have it, she insisted on having it. She said it was because I'm pretty and that it would keep me safe."

"You *are* pretty"

Adora blushes pink, immediately mortified.

Adora, get a hold of your tongue for once, please, she scolds herself. C'yra, however doesn't mocke them for it, merely chuckling under her breath as they settle the doll at top of some of the paper.

"It's you isn't it?", she asks as she signals at it with a swish of her wrist, the pupils of her feline eyes slightly bigger.

"It's She-Ra" Adora extracts herself from the door, walking to the chair next to C'yra and sitting on it with a flop

"Yes, so it's you" she repeats, slowly. Her ears are flat against her head as she watches Adora fumble on their chair, mouth pressed in a firm line and shaking their head in negative.

"She-Ra is the name the kingdoms of Etheria gave my mother on the battlefield. After she died, the title was passed to me. Talking about the mighty *She-Ra* warrior helps the people to get the strength they need to live in a world at war. Me being that for them is the least I can do" Adora reaches for the doll, focusing their attention on the details of its armor as they speak. 'She-Ra is a symbol. For the people. It gives them hope"

"It is you who gives them hope, Adora, not a title or a legend. You" C'yra's voice is gentle by her side. When Adora gazes back at her, her face is open, it almost looks like the look she gave to the children earlier. Comforting, reassuring but sure and confident as well. The more Adora looks at her the more she is convinced she is saying the truth.

C’yra extends her hand, hesitating just a second before placing it delicately over Adora’s. Both hold their breaths as their skins slide one over the other, one warm and soft, the other colder and hardener from years of sword training.

It’s the first time they have touched since that fatidical day, and much like their conversation the day prior it brings an electric feeling down Adora’s entire body. Before he can say the small speech they had prepared on her way back, C’yra beats him to it by rushing her own words into the space between them.

"I was wrong. That first night" her eyelashes rub over her skin as she blinks slowly without breaking eye contact. She almost seems out of breath like she can’t get the words out fast enough. "You don’t want to be a hero for your hubris, you just want to save your people. It was wrong of me to snap at you the way I did, and to push you away for so long."

"You were scared" he replies, too astonished to say something more.

"I was. But it doesn’t excuse my attitude. I misjudged you. I came here full of a prejudice and resentment that didn’t belong to me, even after you showed me nothing but kindness and love. And I’m truly deeply sorry for that, Adora."

Adora is speechless. She was hoping she could reach C’yra, somehow convince her to speak to them and then apologize for pushing too hard on her. Instead here they are, with C’yra’s hand tight against theirs and she being the one apologizing instead.

"I’m sorry. That it took me so long, Adora. I’m sorry for everything", her tail is restless behind her, she is nervous. From the edge of their eyes they can see Melog appearing from under the table and slipping into C’yra’s lap, their magical mane shining a glimmering purple. "I know it doesn’t excuse my words, but… when I was younger I was taught by a horrible person that you and your family were the monsters of our nightmares. Even after she betrayed me and my family and my kingdom, I could never truly forget all the ideas she put in my head. I don’t know what would have been of me if I hadn’t had my mothers. But even now, it is hard for me to trust, words don't work for me, actions do. Yet...It wasn’t right of me to judge you over that."

"But Utter…" Adora tries, but C’yra is already shaking her head

"You are not proud of your ancestors’ decisions, Adora, I know that now. You’re different to them, so much different. You care about Etheria, about its magic and its creatures. You care for your people, you care for *my* people. I’ve seen it. You don’t think you are more than others just because someone put a crown on your head and called you king. You took your privilege as a responsibility with those who rely on you and worked to be better for them."

"You are thinking too high of me" Adora's voice breaks in the middle.

"I'm thinking what it is, Adora. You've been so patient with me these weeks. Even yesterday after I left you in the garden, you didn't push me, you allowed me to have my space. I'm grateful for that", C'yra takes a breath. In the meantime Melog raises from their position and jumps to Adora's lap, curling in a tight ball and purring. "You are a good person Adora."

Adora feels exposed. Not in a bad way, in the kind of way that makes you feels standing at the edge of the see without on bare feet, or at the top of a mountain looking at the expanse of green below your feet. Both terrifying and exciting.

"I want to try this, if you're still up to it. Us, being friends, I really want to, Adora. If you can forgive me", the small flame inside Adora's chest roars to life once again, singing loudly between their ribs.

"I forgive you, C'yra" Adora turns her hand upwards, entangling their fingers together "Thank you."

"Catra" she says, softly.

"Excuse me?"

"My friends call me Catra. Is less pompous" she is looking at their joined hands with her ears now pointing to the front. When Adora starts to let go she just squeezes them tighter.

"Catra it is then" the room falls quiet except for the cracking of the fire and the purr of Melog. Adora realizes this must be a huge step for Catra. She had lost and been betrayed for people that were important to her, so it mustn't be easy for her to let anyone else in again. He feels like now he can understand her a little bit better and the thought of them just getting closer with time brings him hope.

"So" starts Adora again, searching her with their eyes while wiggling their eyebrows, hoping to make her relax a little, "are we friends now?"

"This doesn't mean that I like you, dummy" Catra answers, snarky but without bite. "But yes, if you would accept me"

"I do" answers Adora immediately. There is a huge goofy smile already stretching across their face. Catra rolls her eyes and returns to her lecture, not once letting go of their hand

Still, there is something that buggers Adora.

"I want to apologize too" Catra raises her head in surprise, she looks like she is about to speak when Adora does again before the words escape them. "I didn't do things exactly right either, Catra. By all means, I should have started by going to Half Moon myself to speak to you and ask you to come with me. Not just sending Light Hope and a flower."

"I liked your rose"

"Yeah", Adora laughs without energy, playing absently with Catra's fingers. "Bow explained to me, their meaning, after that first meeting at the Table."

"You didn't know it meant that?"

"No" over their legs Melog's mane is changing between blue and pink. "My friends told me to give you something from the heart. I...I grew those roses in the balcony, when I was ten, it

was the first thing I remember my magic did. I just thought you would like them… Catra? Are you alright?"

Catra's eyes are watery and she sniffs lightly as she passes the back of her other hand on her nose. The smile, homever, hasn't left her

"Yes. It's just… your castle is dusty and haunted."

"Oh, yes. And a lot" affirms Adora, giggling.

"There is nothing to apologize for, but if it makes you feel better, I forgive you too, Adora" they sigh in relief, looking into her precious eyes again. "Let's start over, alright?"

There is a knock in the door and a knight enters the chamber, taking in the scene of both of them next to each other, holding hands.

"Your Majesties. The summer festivities have just started. The knights are already guarding the barrier and the village and Queen Glimmer has given her approval over the protection spells."

"Thank you, Sir Juliet" calls Adora, nodding. The knight bows once and leaves.

"I've never seen a summer festival before" throws Catra. She is looking at Adora from under her eyelashes with an expression wanting to be between indifferent and curious. Adora smirks, raising to her feet.

"Would you like to see one now?"

"Are Regents allowed to go fool around in a party?" Catra jokes, standing too.

"I may be a King, Catra, but I'm not a rules snob" he reaches the door before offering their hand to her. "You coming?"

Catra pets Melog's head as she passes them and takes their hand, flashing both her fangs in a toothy smile.

"Wow, mischievous aren't we?"

"Oh, let me tell you about that time I stole Swift Wind after curfew and rode all the way to the swamps. That's how I lost my mollar."

Melog curls around the doll as the door closes again.

✾

The gardener and the stable head are walking quickly down the village street. Their footsteps are rushed over the floor slabs as they follow the increasing sounds of the music in the main square.

"Walli, Wait" gasps the stable head out of breath. "How are you so quick?"

"Spite!" calls the gardener, crossing the corner. "Hurry up or you will miss it."

"Uf...wait. What am I seeing again?"

They almost run her over as she stops abruptly in the entrance of the square, hunching behind a tree as if they were spying something.

"Remember what you told me about the king and queen finally getting along? Well, look over there."

The round yard of the main square glows in oranges and yellows. Some children are jumping in the puddles left from the summer rains, eating mangoes and other season fruits from the merchants around.

Paper lamps and small balls of magic float around the place and some of the giant panthers the magicats had brought with them are tinkering with them as the florist put colorful flower necklaces around their necks and ears. A huddle of street musicians are playing a cheerful piece as some couples dance.

Right at the center of them are the queen and king. They've ditched their royal attires for some simple cotton white blouses and pants, with their hairs loose and tousled, and their feet bare as they turn around and around in circles at the rhythm of the music.

The king laughs as the queen guides them expertly through the dance, the tips of their blonde hair brushing the dusty floor when the latter dips them easily at some point of their steps. The high pitch of the king's voice as he bursts into a fit of laughter calls the rest of the village attention, who points at them with big smiles and heartfelt cheers from the multitude.

Adora's hands rest over C'yra's shoulder blades, trusting her to hold him securely between her arms, and even after they straighten again and the music starts to speed up they just stand still for a few seconds, out of breath and laughing between themselves, foreheads slippery from sweat and the humidity of the air.

The gardener and the stable head watch excitedly as the king suddenly twirls the queen when another piece of music starts, winning a surprised yelp from her as Adora brings her back and holds to her waist with a goofy smile on his face. They tease each other, safe inside their own personal bubble, enjoying the warmth of the festival alongside their people as the night goes on.

❀

Adora finishes buttoning up their night shirt as Catra enters the room from the separated restroom. She is already in her nightgown, fabric lightly wet on the shoulders from her hair after the bath she had taken to clean the dirt and sweat of the festival.

They glance at each other with pink cheeks just to snatch their gazes away immediately after. Melog is cuddling in the bed, purring happily.

Adora closes the wardrobe's door while Catra climbs to the mattress and nuzzles into the blankets. It's already very late into the night and Adora can feel their eyelids heavy with sleep even if the adrenaline and excitement of the evening is still pumping into her veins.

They are already walking to the studio's room when Catra's voice stops her mid track.

"How long are we going to keep doing this?" Adora turns to her, without understanding.

"Doing this?"

Catra is curled on the left side of the bed with only her golden eye and ear peeking out of the blanket.

"You, sleeping in a chair in another room."

Adora rolls on her ankles, unsure.

"I can go to another chamber if you'd like" Catra groans, wiggling more towards the edge.

"Adora, don't be an idiot. The bed is huge."

Wow , they think, for the millionth time in the day. This is a big step, the biggest of a myriad of big steps today. Catra is allowing her to enter into her safe space, she is actually trusting her. Their head hadn't stopped spinning since Catra had low dipped her at the festival and now it feels as if it would just take fly and disappear into the starry night.

"Are you sure?"

"Stop making a fuzz and get in already dumbass"

Adora gets into movement so quickly she trips with her own feet and almost falls on her face. Catra chuckles at Adora's clumsiness while they carefully slip into the sheets.

"This doesn't mean I like you", murmurs Catra without moving. "I just saw that sad excuse of a couch you've been sleeping in and felt bad for your spine."

"How consideraded", huffs Adora.

She lies stiffly on her back, counting the lamps that hover over their heads. Long minutes pass before Adora can't hold down herself anymore and calls Catra's name again.

"What is it?" Catra's voice is rough and low, most probably already halfway asleep.

"Do you think your mom saw this? With her Foresight?" they let their eyes drift closed, shielding themselves from the low light. "Do you think that's why she gave me the pin?'

"So when the time came, I would know that I could trust you" -finishes Catra in a whisper. Clearly she had already thought about it. "I don't know Adora, but if that's the case…"

Adora let's her mind drift away, lulled by the sounds of Catra's voice and Melog's purr.

"...then I'm glad that she did"

❀

Adora wakes up with the light of the sun in her eyes.

It’s late, probably around noon, they know this by the way the sun enters the chamber and projects shadows over the bed.

This is new. They had never slept in, in their life. His sore, sleep deprived column kind of thanks it.

She rolls over her back, cleaning her eyes with the back of their hand, listening at the waking castle move around then. There is also a soft sweet hum besides them that makes him turn his sight.

Catra stirs by her side, almost completely at the opposite edge of the bed. Her hair is a bird nest over the pillows, with her tail entangled between her bedsheets and a foot hanging from the side of the mattress. She seems to be deeply asleep, occasionally twitching her nose like she is dreaming, so Adora tries to get up the bed as quietly as possible.

Melog stretches on their spot besides the window, jumping down to get close to him. They purr as they scent her legs, mane bright pink.

"You sleep fight" says Catra, groggy and half asleep, eyes still closed with her arm thrown lazily over her head.

Adora snorts softly, scratching a spot just behind Melog's ear and looking with sleepy eyes for his shoes.

"You drool" she shots back. There is shuffle and then a thud as the pillow Catra throws her without force crashes against their head.

"Jerk"

"Prat"

The sound of their laugh travels outside of the open window and into the colorful evening.

An hour later, just in time for the Round Table weekly meeting, Adora and Catra walk into the room side by side.

Catra feels everyone's curious and judgmental eyes on them and gets stars to get self aware until Adora rests their hand on the small of her back, guiding them together to their seats.

There is a stunned silence broken only for Bow, who gets up and calls for attention to start the reunion. He looks proud and relieved.

Catra ruffles with her quill and turns to look at her now, finally, friend.

Adora smiles.

Catra smiles back.

End of chapter II

Chapter End Notes

Hello there again! Hope you enjoyed these almost 15k new chapter. They are Friends! Wahoo!

Shouts out to my friends Nox, Walli and Serena who made a cameo apparition on this chapter ;) And extra love to Walli (AlohaRyda on AO3/Twitter/IG) and Serena (ArtifexSerena Twitter/IG) who made together a BEAUTIFUL piece of Queen Catra for my birthday!!! (https://twitter.com/ArtifexSerena/status/1391528162773848065?s=20) I love you guys so much <3

Chapter three may come a bit later than next sunday because I have to work on my thesis jsjs but now that these two are actually working on their issues together the true plot can begin ;)

Chapter 3: At the gates of Camelot

Chapter Summary

> “And if Adora stays awake a little bit longer at night just to hear the soft hum of her breath until it lulls them to sleep, who is there to blame them?
> After all, Adora is in love”

Chapter Notes

> It 's finally here! After a long hiatus, chapter 3 is finally ready, Hope this 16.5k chapter is enough to say sorry for that long wait. Thank you so much to everyone that was patient with me. After all I’m just a one person adult and life can get complicated sometimes.
>
> CHAPTER WARNINGS: From this chapter on the subjects of magical war and its consequences are to be touched more, but nothing in a graphic or heavy matter and more just as in a plot development. In this chapter there are mentions of refugees, towns destroyed and magical horror. There is one entire scene that talks about refugees and runaways, which I’ve marked with (*****) to be easy to skip. Please be aware of this and take care of yourself!
>
> Now, onto the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CHAPTER 3. At the gates of Camelot

WINTER

love makes one generous. look at us. We'd known each other so briefly that instead of sleeping we lay whole nights, open, in the lamplight, and gazed, on traded stories.

j.m @hqpoet // Twitter

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x

✾

Adora is in love.

This is an understatement. It is so much more, a deep aching devotion that has tangled alongside their own flesh and bones until everything they breathe, think and feel is her, her, her, *her*.

What started as a mellow spark the first time they had seen her, a little bit over seven months ago, has now grown into an immense fire inside their soul, not devastating or frightening, but honeyed and pleasant, setting aflame every nerve and thought.

They have never actually been in love before, there was never the time or the place, it was never the right person. If anyone would know, they would probably tell him that he was jumping into conclusions way too fast. That they were being too hopeful and naive, only strongly infatuated by this new person who shares their home and their warmth, but nothing else.

But she knows, Adora knows that she is in love with her.

They know it in the way their heart shudders almost painfully inside his chest, in the hitch of their breath on their throat, in the sudden loss of words, in the crimson blush over their cheeks. Every time, every single moment she is near and even when she is away. At dawn or at the darkest time of night. Adora knows.

They know it when she laughs, when she is snarky and sarcastic, when she is angry and when she is sad. It's in the way her long wild mane floats like a halo over her head, it lives inside the crystals of her feline eyes that get oh so big when there is something interesting or exciting; in the curve of her lips when she smirks, in the soft spot below her ears and in her restless tail that always gives her feelings away.

And if Adora stays awake a little bit longer at night just to hear the soft hum of her breath until it lulls them to sleep, who is there to blame them?

After all, Adora is in love.

He can't really tell when it happened. When, between the journey from stranger to friend, it became something so much powerful.

After they came clean and started to allow themselves to be honest and open, everything got better. It was as if they had known each other their entire lives. They had been inadvertently almost glued to the hip during these months, learning each other with such ease it was as if they already knew it all from the very beginning.

Catra would show Adora magic, old books, art and how to speak with the wildlife that had slowly arrived and set on the edges of Camelot. Adora, for their part, would show Catra every corner and secret passage of Camelot, bring her almost every fruit, bread and dessert to try, and invite her to train together when they could.

They would walk and joke together through the village and visit the orphanage side by side. Adora would try to teach Catra how to ride horses and Catra would hate it. Catra would make fun of their hair and Adora would throw a snowball to her face. They would chase each other around the corridors of the castle, laughing and blushing until their hair was a mess and their

breathing was ragged like two children playing in the palace grounds. Sometimes, even, Adora realizes she already knows what Catra is thinking before the other says it and so the other way around too.

It wasn't an easy journey, however. Both of them would still get into arguments and disagreements with each other. Especially at times when the sense of duty weighed too heavy over Adora's head and would make her reckless with her own safety. Or when Catra would be too harsh on herself and push into work until her own limit was reached.

On those days they would be tense and sharp around themselves and others, it would be long and tiresome and worrying. Nevertheless, at night and every time, Adora and Catra would gravitate onto each other again, shoulders dropped with apologetic eyes. Both would snuggle on the bed, foreheads pressed against the other, quiet murmurs of understandment passed underneath the rumpled sheets.

It was a work in progress, a long learning, sharing a life together. It was patience and happiness and compromise building trust between themselves. Yet, it felt like the easiest thing they had done their entire lives. And they were doing it, together.

Like they are two pieces of the same star, orbiting each other endlessly.

Adora realized it during a sparring session at a warm autumn noon, barely a few months after their first meeting. He and Catra had taken into doing combat training at least once per week in the knights yards. Adora was prolific with swords, but practicing physical combat was just as comfortable and Catra was an extraordinary fighter.

That day they had been using sparring poles against each other. Left, right, down, up. Right, right, right. Left, down, left. Again.

Adora could feel his shirt sticking to their back and Catra's forehead shone pearlescent for the sweat. Yet, both wore matching smiles as they turned around each other with practiced ease. It was another kind of dance and they were just as good at it.

It was in the middle of a turn that Adora saw it, an entrance. Catra shifted on her bare feet and then her never failing feet slipped. It happened so fast that if Adora hadn't been completely enthralled with her, they would have missed it. As soon as they noticed, homever, Adora threw their entire weight over the pole, looking to throw Catra into the ground.

In all honesty, they should have known. Catra never misstepped.

Catra's eyes shone in contained victory at the same time she twirled again, rounding Adora and swifting the pole right under their bent knees. Next thing they knew, they were face up to the clear sky, their own pole laying defeated beside them.

Catra's flushed face appeared on his camp of vision. She was bright against the blue sky as she chuckled until her eyes squinted shut with amusement.

"Hey, Adora"

"Catra" Adora pushed the loose strands of damp hair out of his face, panting. "That was cheating"

"It really wasn't" purred Catra, lowering herself a little to their position on the grass. "Maybe if you weren't such a clotpole you may have noticed earlier"

Adora huffed looking up at her and smirking. "Clotpole?"

"That's what I said"

"That's not a word"

"It is"

"I bet you 50 draconians it's not"

"Deal" Catra rolled her eyes but her expression was fond. The sun behind her created a makeshift ethereal halo around her head and Adora felt the soft caress of her tail as it wrapped itself around their wrist. Catra drew closer to Adora, poking them on the middle of the forehead. “Dummy”

Every single feeling that she had felt on the day of their wedding came back with a blast. Adora´s heart stopped for a few seconds as she looked at her best friend and then started again with the full force of a hurricane, like a dam had broken down and was now flowing free, spilling down her skin and into the ground. *Oh,* they thought, *So, it is you.*

Adora thought it would go away, a silent crush on a beautiful smart woman that was his wife. It just grew stronger.

It made Adora freak out a little, this sudden realization. If it was possible to love someone so deeply, so intensely so quickly. Even if Adora knew from the very beginning it was bound to happen sooner or later, they had thought it would be months or years into the future for it to happen. That they would be able to bask in the glory of their new found relationship before immersing into the deeper turmoils of deeper feelings. It seemed that their heart had its own schedule.

There was worry inside Adora. That this devotion would break them apart as easy as they had managed to fall together. But there was also content and calm. Adora didn't want to push those feelings into Catra, they knew that even if she didn't feel the same for them, she did want to be their friend. They had seen the way Catra had unfold herself in the last months, how she had become more and more open and sure and happy. How she had started to consider Camelot her home too.

They would lay awake at night watching the shining ceiling over their heads, the one Catra had enchanted one night to make it look like the starry night was right inside their chambers. Adora and Catra would blow all the candles and lamps and spend hours side by side, arms and legs pressed tight against each other, pointing at the moving stars and naming the countless constellations, learning them and each other in quiet comfort. Then they would turn to sleep at each edge of the bed, facing each other instead of away.

On nights where the battle's horrors would chase Adora's dreams and she would startle awake in fear, Catra would curl gently her tail around her ankle, not speaking, just keeping it there in silent reassurance until morning. When Catra would jump awake in the middle of the night, eyes watery with unshed tears, Adora would hold her hand in the blanketed space between them, not moving close, just caressing the soft skin with their thumb until her eyes grew heavy and she would drift back into a peaceful sleep.

It was the kind of private proximity that would let the other know " *I'm here"* . In those moments, they wouldn't be a king and a queen, they would only be Catra and Adora.

Catra trusts her. And so, Adora is happy.

It 's enough.

❀

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The air in the Round Table is charged with energy.

The princesses and other rulers have been sitting in the same room for about four hours now. There are maps scattered across the dark wood of the table, small documents and papers with even smaller dots splattered here and there.

Tiny flags with the Horde Empire symbol stain the charts in a nauseating amount. They mark all the places the Horde has attacked in the last years and left nothing but irreparable destruction. The more they see it, the more they realize the flags are too close to each of the seven kingdoms.

“The south routes of Plumeria are still open for emergency resources” Glimmer is standing up, quickly going through bright looking notes that float in the air. She looks exhausted even with her pink wings illuminating her soft skin. “Brightmoon’s physicians and other medical care are also ready for any call needed. We will be using the Moon stone to transport them where it’s needed. Given I can’t teleport that many people at once Prince Entrapta has found a way to use the magic of the stone into bigger spells ”. Glimmer smiles at them in recognition which makes Entrapta flush in pride.

“Half Moon’s rescue brigades managed to recover villagers from Elberon after last week's attack” adds Catra. She has pulled her hair in a ponytail and there are purple bags under her eyes. Adora squeezes her knee gentle from under the table, receiving a quick flip of tail in return. “We still don’t know the extent of the town’s damage, but the people will camp in the Sea Elf Village for the next days. Queen Mermista allowed them to enter as refugees in Salineas” she nods at Mermista from across the table. The mentioned nods back, tapping her fingers over the wood.

“They will be safe there, but we are quickly reaching our maximum. Sea Hawk has been in charge of managing provisions and he thinks we will pull through the winter, but I’m unsure what will happen if more refugees arrive”.

“Half Moon can aid you with extra agricultural resources" says Scorpia. She is sitting next to Princess Perfuma and to Catra, her usual cheerful energy is always deemed lightly when there are meetings. “Queen Catra and I already discussed this matter. We can provide you with enough provisions in case of emergency”.

“Wouldn’t that risk Half Moon?” interrupts gently Perfuma, but Catra is already shaking her head.

“Brightmoon, Salineas and the Kingdom of Snows are already acting as refuges. And Camelot is sheltering most of the magicat population for the winter. Half Moon is running right now as a resource supplier alongside Plumeria. Now that the summer drought is over, our farmers are spending the winter at home and only managing the distribution of food. Prince Entrapta designed an efficient system for them. We will be fine”.

Perfuma smiles, satisfied. Adora looks at Catra with proud eyes, like she always does when Catra speaks. She blushes gently under their attention.

“What is the plan of action right now against the Horde?” Princess Frosta asks. She is young, barely seventeen and already in charge of a kingdom. It reminds Catra a little of herself. “They’ve been uncharacteristically calmer these months. It’s not normal”

“You are right Frosta” Adora voice raises, a bit raspy after so many hours. They are all equal here, but Adora’s presence is undoubtedly that of a natural leader. Is a breath of fresh air every time they speak, even when they look as tired as everyone else. "And I'm afraid we aren't the only ones who have noticed it. The people are talking, they are afraid a big blow is going to happen soon"

"Aren't we all?" Glimmer, now sitting, rubs her eyes with two fingers as she continues. "My mother has been trying to find out if there is a hidden reason for their retreat but she hasn't been able to find anything, not even with my father's tracking spell. So far, it seems as if they have really been ordered to cease big attacks and are only targeting the surrounding villages"

"We suppose it may be due to Half Moon' army joining us," Bow adds. Catra looks at him in mild surprise. “Thanks to the magicats our forces have increased both their strength and number in a noticeable way. By now the Horde must have already noticed it. If they really retreated because they’ve seen themselves outnumbered then that gives us the advantage for now”.

“That gives us time to understand where their dark magic is coming from”, Adora scratches their chin, beautiful grey eyes glued to the map in front of her.

The chamber continues the meeting until we’ll past midday, after which all the members leave in groups.

The story of the Horde Empire is well known for every habitant of Etheria. No matter how hidden or how away someone is they all know it.

About 200 years ago, General Anillis Kur betrayed the First One's King and formed a huge army with loyals and fanatics from all over the continent. In his madness, he saw all magic as an impurity for the world, a danger that needed to be burned and erased from the root. He tricked the last of the druids by offering them protection and safe passage through Albion in exchange of immortality and got rid of them soon after they gave it to him. He became Emperor Horde Prime, the madman.

He remained dormant for many years, building a terrifying army capable of attacking the seven kingdoms. After Arthur's passing and Mara's ascend to the throne, Prime attacked again, stronger than even and more determined to end once and for all all the magic and goodness of the land.

His sudden use of dark magic was confusing and scary. Especially because it meant that there were etherians working with him, betraying everyone else.

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Catra hadn't been witness to the destruction of Prime yet, outside of destroyed villages and runaways of the war. But she knew how heavy it weighed on everyone's shoulders, and now in her too. These was her people now too.

Adora's warm hand slips into hers, bringing her back from the sea of thoughts she had been swimming into. They smile at her, squeezing gently her fingers.

"Are you alright?", their eyes are a bit hooded for exhaustion but they are still cheerful and kind with her. Catra squeezes his hand back.

"Yes. I'm ready to pass out in bed until noon if I'm honest", Catra fixes her coat tight with her free hand. She turns a little towards him, pulling gently from their joined hands. "You coming?"

Adora hesitates, rubbing his thumb over her knuckles a few times before answering.

"Actually, Princess Perfuma asked me to take a few nobles around the town. It won't take long but I can't say no"

Catra blinks in surprise, letting go of their hand and retrieving her hand back.

"Oh. I see". Adora looks apologetic and Catra feels bad for the sudden wave of annoyance that overtakes her, so she breathes deep and holds her breath as she nods, forcing a small smile on her lips. "It's alright Adora, go ahead. I'll be in the studio"

Adora opens and closes their mouth several times and then just nods back, saying their goodbyes and turning on their heels to leave behind the rest of the Table members.

❀

Catra worries her lip between her fangs as she looks through the windows of the desert corridor. Adora is down there, with his stupid handsome face, escorting a few nobles from the

Plumeria kingdom around the town. They are all pretty, with flowing soft dresses and flowers braided on their hair. Their hands are soft and they smell like perfumes and scented oils.

Catra hates them.

She doesn't really hate them but she is pretty much about to run out of patience and jump all the way down there just so she can hiss at them and see them run in fear. They have not necessarily done anything wrong, most of them are really nice, yet Catra can´t help a low menacing growl escape her when she watches how they surround Adora, draping themselves all over her as they walk. One of them trips in an incredibly fake way just so Adora can react and catch her between their arms. The Plumeria noble giggles, *giggles,* and holds herself into Adora´s strong bicep the rest of the way.

Catra doesn't consider herself a violent person but she feels like is about to scream out of sheer frustration. She wishes she could be somehow mad at Adora and it always seems impossible. Adora is too kind, too giving, sometimes too dull, to understand what those girls are doing. Or maybe he knows and is letting it happen. Somehow, that new thought festers inside Catra's chest in a nasty way.

She follows them with her eyes until they are lost from sight.

Catra jumps elegantly from her place taking in the long expanse of the place, paying special attention to the Pendragon and D'riluth standards that hang from the walls.

The castle is warm against the chill cold of winter. Snow had just started to fall outside, so little that it melted before touching the floor but that freezes the air in the same way.

Catra wasn't fond of the cold, in any form. It would hurt her feet and she would always be sneezing no matter what. As soon as Adora had noticed this, they had asked to start the fireplaces of almost every chamber in the palace no matter that they and their people were more used to this type of winter. He had also asked the kitchen to bring Catra hot beverages every morning. Catra didn't know what would warm her more, the drink or the gesture.

On one particularly cold morning while visiting the silos, Adora had placed their own heavy red cape over Catra's shivering shoulders. They had joked about it and then started a snowball fight on their way back, but Catra remembered the fast beat of her heart against her ribs as she snuggled in the cape for the rest of the day.

Catra remembers this as she walks down the corridor slowly. She knows what all these feelings mean, she has never experienced it before, but she saw them reflected on her mothers faces every time they looked at each other.

Catra knows what is happening inside her heart and she wants to bang her head on her palms over and over.

Adora is precious to her. They had won her trust with kindness and understanding and patience and soon had also won her heart with stubbornness and mischief. They are smart, strong and confident and Catra is completely undone by her.

“Having a lot on your mind today?” Adora’s voice tears her out of her thoughts as she spins to meet them. They walk with sure steps towards her, a smirk plastered across their face and raised dark eyebrows. They look up and down at Catra, widening their smile.

“Adora”, she fidgets on her feet, uncomfortable . There is something weird about their walk and expression. Is not the usual soft looks she loves, is calculator and distant. “I thought you were escorting the other nobles”.

“Oh! you were looking at me then”, Adora tilts her head, clicking their tongue against their teeth.

"I wasn't- I didn't- Uf. We just saw each other, dumbass, you told me" Catra throws back, flushing all the way to her ears. Adora just chuckles, crossing their arms over their chest.

"Wow, didn't think it was going to get such a rise out of you, darling" the mirth in their eyes shines maliciously. “Missed me that much?”

Catra considers them for a moment and then straightens her posture, ears high and alert. She slithers smoothly until she is right next to them, tail entangled on one of their legs. “I did, but you see” she tangles her hand at the base of the hair, pressing her mouth right next to their ear, “you are not my Adora”.

Catra pulls from the ponytail at the same time her tail tugs, making them lose their balance and promptly throwing them to the floor. They groan loudly when their back connects with the cold stone, shining a dark green shade before melting into a new shape. Instead of Adora’s eyes regarding her from the ground a pair of sharp yellow eyes return her gaze.

“Did you have to be that rough, darling?” says Double Trouble, rubbing their sore head. Catra scoffs, kicking them lightly on the calf.

“What the hell are you doing here?”The shapeshifter stands up, brushing their tail back and forward over the floor and fixing their hair. “Also, that was the worst impression you’ve ever made. Adora is nothing like that”

“Oh, kitten, darling, please. You know me, that wasn’t acting, I was just proving a point”

“Proving a point”, repeats Catra, rolling the letters over her tongue.

“You”, they finish, popping the last letter with practiced annoyance, pointing at her with a slender long finger. Catra’s nails unfold and retract unwittingly. “I’ve been watching you for the past weeks, darling, you know what I’m talking about”

“Creep”, she slaps their hand away, turning her back at them.

“So you don’t deny it, then”

“Shut up or I’ll have you thrown from our castle” Catra resumes her walking, highly aware of their muted steps following hers.

“OH! *Your* castle. You really do have it bad, hum?”

"It's not like that. We're friends, I am so grateful we are friends but that is all. Adora doesn't want me, not like-" she regards the smudge look on their face and scoffs, pushing them out of her way lightly with her shoulder. "Forget it"

"That's good then" Double Trouble sing songs, besides Catra with their hands on their back "They have so many possibilities, so it's appropriate you are feeling that way".

Catra slowers her step, not turning to face them but suddenly incredibly alert again.

"What do you mean?"

Double Trouble picks at their nails without looking at her, tail flicking back and forward behind them.

"Adora is young, smart, noble, incredibly handsome. Without forgetting, she is a king. She could have any woman they wanted in the entire kingdom" Catra snaps her eyes back at them, stopping completely. Double Trouble smirks, raising their hands in a peace signal "Don't look like that kitten, after all, *you're just friends* "

Catra wants to scream and cry all at the same time but she doesn't give them the satisfaction. Double Trouble has always been like this ever since they were a teenage thief on the streets of Half Moon, always looking right across Catra's bullshit. And they know now, the feelings Catra had been trying to push down for the last weeks. This is just a strategy to get the worst of her and admit it outloud.

Double Trouble watches her go through a myriad of emotions without loosing their smile once, hands resting at either side of their hips and feet tapping rhythmically over the floor.

"You have always had such a hard time with your feelings, kitten"

"How did you get here, to Camelot?" She interrupts them, desperate to change the subject before scratching their face off. Double Trouble takes mercy on her and resumes their walking as they answer.

"I arrived with the last magicat's caravan. I heard there is going to be a tournament and could not let the opportunity pass me to see my kitten again" they say it in a tone that tells Catra that they are deeply enjoying giving her a headache.

"You could have been useful, you know? Given there is a war going on", scolds Catra as they both arrive at the split corridor. Double Trouble laughs, twirling on their tippy toes.

"Honey, you know that's not how I work"

"I don't care what you do with your time but one day I'm going to require your *work* " she says, voice becoming that commanding tone that makes everyone in the room be quiet and listen. "And if I find out you've done undesirable treats with undesirable sides, I'll have you crop by the neck. Are we in an understanding, *darling?* "

Double Trouble's eyebrows shoot up their forehead in surprise and they let an amused smile fall over their mouth.

"You really have grown, haven't you?"

Catra doesn't say anything else, maintaining eye contact with them until Double Trouble turns to the left side of the corridor, waving her out in a sly manner.

"Think about what I said" they yell in the emptiness of the corridor without looking back "I'll be seeing you later then, your Majesty"

❀

Catra is reading a book in the loveseat of the studio when Adora comes in.

It’s a cartography book, an item she had taken interest on after Adora showed her the countless of gorgeous and precise maps they had done during his younger years. It had taken a lot of time for Catra to finally convince Adora that they were not only good, but excellent. That they are actually a wonderful painter, for what they should be exposed in the royal library not left to dust. Adora had thought about it for a while but eventually came to terms with it and accepted Catra’s idea, to the point where the maps that the Round Table uses are of Adora’s creation.

Right now, on the desk of Adora’s studio rests a fair amount of paper with small drawings of many places in Half Moon that Catra had described to her. They weren’t exact but Adora had insisted and Catra had accepted when she saw the idea made them happy. Catra had also promised to take Adora to all of these places once the war ended and they could visit her kingdom in calm.

Adora approaches Catra with her hands hidden behind her back. There is a blush over her cheeks and nose and she reeks like flowers. Catra tries, she tries very hard but she can’t help pressing her lips in a thin line. Melog jumps at the sight of Adora and is midway to greet her when their mane changes colors from light blue to green.

“So there you are,” says Adora with a sprint in her step.

“Here I am”, Catra closes the book without marking the page, leaving it beside her on the couch. Her eyebrows are raised in a stern expression that takes Adora a bit aback. She immediately realizes something is off. “You were gone for a while. I take you had fun with your Plumerian friends”. The jealousy spills out of her mouth like venom. Catra curses herself again for letting Double Trouble' words fester in her mind

Adora looks confused for a second and then her face brightens again, shining blinding like the sun at the mentions of the plumerian. Catra feels like she is about to cry.

“Yes, I did. Actually-“ she fumbles with her hands and it’s only then that Catra realizes they are holding something, hiding it from sight behind their back. “You know how I’m not very good with small delicate things, right? Well, I asked them if they could help me with something for you and I think we managed to make it look at least a little bit decent”

Her palms are red from the cold and there is snow in her fingers but there is a daisies' flower crown resting between their hands. Some of the knots are loose and in other parts there are small voids where the flowers have loose petals. It kind of looks like it is going to fall apart and it's absolutely perfect.

Catra unfolds her legs from underneath herself, bending forward a little to take a better look at the crunched thing. There is a song that grows stronger and stronger and she kind of feels like she just ate an entire hive of bees by the way her stomach is turning. She can feel tears welling in her eyes and if Adora doesn't keep talking soon she is pretty sure she is going to end up being a royal sobbing mess.

"Winters are very crude here, as you already noticed, and I know you miss flowers. I can make them grow but I just- well, I thought I could make it something more for you than just a table decoration. I tried alone but that was such a bad idea, believe me" Adora chuckles though her cheeks are getting redder by the minute. Catra feels so absolutely endeared by this person that if she is not careful all these feelings are going to spill out free and wild everywhere. "I asked Perfuma and then Perfuma asked her royal florist. Why does the princess from the flower kingdom need a florist? And then the florist asked the sisters and I think they kind of kidnapped me for a few hours and this is like my twelve try but it was getting really late and I really *really* wanted to come back to you, I'm exhausted of anybody else. Do you like it?"

Adora pours all of this so fast that they look dizzy afterwards. She is such a dumbass, with their weird poof of blonde hair and their red cape and good heart. *I'm so in love with you,* Catra thinks, dooming herself. *I fucked up so bad.*

She is still holding the daisy crown as gently as she can when Catra finally stands up and approaches both with a trembling smile. She rests her hand over hers and takes the crown, placing it gently over her own head.

"Clotpole" Catra says in a whisper, curling inside Adora's open arms, hiding her face on the crook of their exposed neck. There is warm and comforting, helping to make the embarrassment of the earlier jealousy wash away. Adora returns the hugs just as tightly, mindful of the little flowers as she buries her nose on Catra's hair.

"Still not a word" she mutters, making Catra muffled giggles tickle them. She can't even remember why she was so angry about.

Melog returns to the couch and so do they, cuddling against each other next to the fire. Catra picks the book and reads out loud.

❀

The next day, Adora walks alone through the empty space of the castle yard. The ground had been cleared of snow as much as possible and several barracks and tall tents surround the circular space destined for the tournament.

The snow storm had finally died down and the cold was less rash now. Frosta had said it would be bearable for the next few days, so everybody would be able to enjoy the festival without freezing to death.

Catra is gone for the day, locked inside the art gallery with the royal painter to make her official portrait. Is to be hanged right next to Adora's. She complained the entire way but Light Hope insisted it was a formality and Catra couldn't say no at the end. Adora new the portraits made by the royal painter were exquisite but sitting still for hours wasn't exactly fun or easy.

So here they are now, without her company to keep them on their feet as they walk back to the castle entry. Adora is almost there when two people walk out at the same time and almost crash against them.

"Oh goddess! King Pendragon! I'm so sorry, we didn't see you there". Is Princess Scorpia, with Princess Perfuma hanged from her arm. They are both clothed heavily against the cold and their cheeks are painted red, though Adora suspects it's for different reasons. He smiles brightly, raising his eyebrows to Perfuma and earning a soft chuckle in return.

"It's quite alright, Princess Scorpia. Do not worry"

"Is Princess C'yra not with you?", asks Perfuma, looking around the yard for the mentioned. Adora sees Princess Scorpia squirm uncomfortably in her place, avoiding Adora's eyes completely.

"She is with the royal painter", Adora explains, tussling the cold drops of the air's humidity off their hair.

"Ah. Is that day uh?" Perfuma turns to Scorpia with a smile and notices immediately the same thing as Adora. She gives her a quizzical look and then seems to grasp something that Adora can’t. Perfuma pats the back of Scorpia’s hand and extracts herself from her side gently. "I have to supervise some deliveries, honey. Could you please accompany Adora back inside? You've barely had time to meet each other".

Scorpia snaps her black eyes to Adora and then back to Perfuma, pouting lightly.

"I wouldn't want to impose…"

"No, please, by all means" Perfuma walks pass Adora and pushes her gently towards Scorpia, a tense smile adorning her factions in an almost menacing way. "Be good, both of you, I take my leave now. Adora"

She addresses Adora and then walks away with a sprint in her step. Adora and Scorpia look at her go and then turn to each other, air thick and heavy between them. Scorpia shifts on her feet and Adora smooths the tousled hair of her ponytail over her shoulder, pulling the heavy coat closer to her body in an attempt to keep warm. After a few moments, Scorpia clears her throat and signals to the corridor back to the castle.

"After you, King Pendragon", Adora hesitates but goes ahead shaking their head at her words.

"Just Adora, please. You are my- you are Catra's friend after all". Scorpia seems to study their face as they march inside the warmth of the palace, the tip of her pincers clicking against each other. Whatever is that she finds on their eyes seems to calm her enough to relax her posture.

"Catra- C'yra, has you on high esteem. She talks a lot about you" says Scorpia, dragging her black boots against the carpet on the floor. Warmth spills inside Adora's chest and ribs and she knows there is a blush over her cheeks but she pays no mind to it.

"Does she?". Adora thinks Scorpia can grasp the spark of joy inside their words because her pupils dilate even as she huffs under her breath.

"Yes. It 's- new. A lot of things have happened in her life, is not easy for her to allow herself to care about people" she squints her eyes at them, studying them again like she can't understand what is in Adora that, to Catra, is different. "But she cares about you. A lot. Even if she doesn't always show it or much less says it. She has a much bigger heart than she seems"

They have stopped walking and Adora just stands there in awe, blush deepening over her skin. Scorpia's words seem to caught her finally because the latter sputters, scratching the back of her head nervously.

"Er- I shouldn't have said that. That's just for Catra to talk about, I'm sorry. I struggle with boundaries sometimes"

"It's quite alright, don't worry. I won't tell her what you've told me" reassures her Adora."But thank you, for telling me that"

The mortification drains a bit from Scorpia's eyes, but her eyebrows are still drawn together.

"I'm just asking you to be patient with her. She feels a lot, she's just not good with wording it sometimes".

Adora resumes her walk and Scorpia follows. She really tall, basically an entire head taller than Adora and her pincers and tail can seem intimidating at the sight, but her manners are soft and even nervous around them like she doesn't really know where to put herself. Adora knows the princess is still not very sure about him, given they are always calmer than her usual cheerful overflowing attitude when Adora is in the room. But knowing Catra has talked about them with her, who is a person Catra trusts, brings a soft feeling inside their chest.

Adora whistles, unable to contain the joy that has characterized the last months next to Catra, ignoring the confused look on Scorpia's face and choosing to speak again to alleviate the awkwardness.

"Catra told me you grew up together in Halfmoon". Scorpia expression breaks into surprise and a faint smile dances on the corner of her lips as she reminisces about past memories.

"We did. Catra's moms took me and Entrapta in after the Horde Empire devastated our kingdoms. I was about ten, I think, and Catra was just eight. She was such a weird thing- not that your Majesty is weird or- you know- a thing. But she looked like a wild kitty, all fluffy hair and gapped teeth and hard looks". Scorpia snickers and so does Adora, evoking younger Catra in their mind, just as strong tempered and mischievous as the wonderful woman she is now. "She didn't really speak to us at the beginning, she shouted to the Queens that she didn't want more friends and ran away. It took almost an entire year for her to warm up to us enough to start talking. After that step everything went easier".

They pass the throne room and the corridors right next to the kitchens, so the air fills with the smell of freshly baked potatoes and hot stew. Scorpia's stomach grumbles but she continues her story.

"She was amazing, she is amazing. It wasn't difficult to fall in love with her", her cheeks flame hot red and she stutters, avoiding their gaze at all costs. "I mean- obviously that was years ago, and she always drew the line between us being friends- Still, she never seemed content enough. We would study and spend time together. She helped me with my speech and handled every single of Entrapta's experiments, but there was always a quiet sadness inside of her, almost as if she was missing some essential part of herself. I was jealous of that void for a long time but as the years passed I understood it didn't mean she loved us less. I don't think even she knew what was missing from her".

Scorpia's eyes become sad and she doesn't look at Adora but they grasp the change in the conversation immediately.

"I don't know how much she has told you about this, but after her moms' death that sadness grew stronger. A lot of bad things happened because of bad people. She started to distrust people more and more, and to fold inside herself tighter. She never stopped being a gentle and just regent but I was starting to get really worried about her own self." Her eyes travel to Adora from head to toe and back to their eyes, pushing the words out. "She's better now, here. I was afraid of the reasons why she accepted you but Catra truly seems happy by your side. I guess you were able to fill that void none of us could understand after all".

Adora smiles brightly, clasping suddenly Scorpia's upper arms between their own.

"Catra is right. You really are a wonderful friend" Scorpia seems almost taken aback by the sudden proximity but mirrors Adora's smile and the tension between them falling completely. She rushes forward and Adora finds themself enveloped in a bone crushing hug, feet dangling a few centimeters above the floor from where Scorpia is lifting them.

"She trusts you so take care of her, alright?" says Scorpia putting Adora gently back to the ground. Adora nods, chewing on her own words, considering, before answering with open honesty.

"I will. She is, quite probably, the best thing that has happened to my life. I care about her. I won't let anything hurt her, I promise"

Scorpia holds her gaze, scrunching her nose and adds in the most serious tone she can, "I'll be watching you"

Adora throws her head back and laughs heartily, palming Scorpia's shoulder a few times.

"Wouldn't expect anything else", they point behind them and towards the kitchens at the same time Scorpia's stomach grumbles again. "Madame makes the best stew in the seven kingdoms. Want to accompany me with some?"

❀

The royal painter prepares his tools as Queen C'yra sits straight on the seat across from him. She is so stoic in her place, with her eyes miles away from the room.

The room is in silence, with only the crepitate of the candles to make them company. Outside, the sounds of the town preparing themselves for the tournament fill the morning air.

The painter waits patiently for the queen to turn around but she seems so deeply lost in her thoughts that at the end they have to clear their throat gently to call for her attention.

“My Queen?” She finally turns to them, eyelids hooding her mismatched eyes. It seems as if she hadn’t slept much last night.

"Yes" she blinks a few times, as to clear the mist over her eyes and takes a rigid position over the chair.

The painter hesitates, unsure on how to start. They did King Adora's portrait on their time, when she became king with barely eighteen and the loss of their mother still waving over her. The painter is not strange in portraying sadness.

So, he starts to sketch with easy practice the outline of her pose and the details of her stern face. About an hour passes until the queen speaks again.

“May I ask you a question?”, the royal painter turns surprised to the queen who looks more alive and alert now, ears pointing up and tail rushing across the floor in slow motions.

“Of course, my queen”

“Have you ever been in love?” her voice quivers at the end. The painters widens their eyes at the question and then immediately their face softness, placing the brush back into its place before answering.

“Yes, I have, my queen”

“How do you know then-“ she gulps, playing with her fingers but without breaking eye contact. “How do you know that is really love and not just mere infatuation? How do you know it’s not too soon?”

“It’s never too soon, my Queen”, the painter’s voice is kind as they address Catra, pulling her out of the dark anxious spiral she is falling into. “When do you know it’s love? When you notice how quiet and dull things feel without them. When you notice you can listen to any and everything they have to say and be engaged and interactive despite not knowing anything about it” Catra’s mind derives into the cartography books scattered around her own desk and it sinks into her heart alongside the gentle words of the painter. “When you can’t remember things before them and can’t think of anything after without them. When you feel like you’re in love, you’ll know. Could be a month, could be years. There is not a certain time that must be fulfilled first. It happens whenever it does, is one of those things that you’ll know whenever that may be.”

The queen's eyes shine in unshed tears and then turn to the portrait hanging in the wall right next to her, the one with king Adora's bright young eyes and uncomfortable pose. Her expression shifts and then *melts* completely into the most endearing look, one that belongs to unabashed love between two people that have chosen each other.

That's the look, think the painter as he quickly grabs their tools again and gets to work.

“Thank you” says the queen softly and when the painter looks back at her, she is looking back, without losing the gentle expression on her eyes. “I’m sorry, I didn’t ask your name”

“No worries, my Queen” answers the painter, smiling. “My name is Serena”

“Thank you, Serena”

✾

The day of the tournament is surprisingly sunny.

There is still snow in the streets and the roofs of the houses but the village's people bask in the unexpected winter warmth. Ambulant merchants sell fresh baked bread and gift goodies to the kids that run around the main yard.

Inside the circle structure where the tournament is to take place, a myriad of people have already gathered themselves, eager to save a seat and watch the knights go into amicable sword fight for the rest of the morning.

On the right side, a few meters away, all knights and their paladins fix themselves to get their armor, helmets and swords ready. Is a friendly competition but a competition nevertheless and everybody is aiming to be the named winner.

Catra walks with fast feet towards the royal seats at the middle of the barricades. The white fabric of her skirt tangles around her legs and she huffs in annoyance. She wears the daisy flower crown that Adora gifted her and that Perfuma helped her enchanted, so it doesn't die, before snatching Scorpia from her side. So now she walks side by side just with Counselor Light Hope and a handful of guards.

The Counselor is serious, tense as a violin's cord by her side. Her feet touch the ground so lightly that she almost seems to be floating and to be honest, if Catra can be sincere, it's a little bit unnerving.

Adora is not with them. He had announced his participation in the tournament at last night's banquet, to everybody's delight, and as a part of the traditions of Camelot's old times. For so, that morning before dawn, he had slipped out of the warm comfort of their shared bed and dressed themself with the white and grey undergarments meant to be worn below the armor.

Catra wasn't fond of waking up so early in the morning but she raised too, leaving Melog to sleep over the crumbled blankets. She had approached Adora quietly, helping them buckle the group of belts and laces in silence. After, she combed and braided their long blonde hair tight against the crown of their head and falling free over the undercut and shoulders.

The air inside the room smelled like lavenders and burned wood from the fireplace. In the mornings they would usually banter around with each other, Adora would crack a bad joke purpose just to see Catra roll her pretty eyes in fake annoyance. That day, homever, it was calmer almost in a homely way. Catra wasn't nervous, this wasn't a real fight anyway and she had seen Adora actually excited for this day to come. Adora was always up for a challenge and, to be honest, Catra knew they were perfectly capable of bringing everybody to the ground much to Adora's fluster when she told them so.

Once they were done and Adora picked the last of her stuff to go, Catra stopped her by tugging a little from her thick shirt. She grabbed her wrist softly and quickly wrapped a sparkling piece of fabric, the same one from the light cape that Catra uses on normal days. Adora stared at her in awe, rubbing her fingers over the soft piece of clothing once Catra stepped away.

"It's tradition to give knights amulets when they go to battle, isn't it?" Catra murmurs, signaling weakly to the cloth almost as if to take importance from the deed. "I know is not a real fight but you and your people really have a thing for traditions, so it's so give you luck or whatever"

Catra thought Adora would tease her about it but all they did was smile, all white teeth with that silly little gap between them, and pull her in for an embrace.

Catra can still smell their scent on her long hair.

Light Hope, Catra and the guards make quick work of arriving at the platform. A few trumpets play, announcing their arrival and making the crowd start to cheer. There is a rain of colorful pieces of paper and small flags with Camelot's coat of arms there. There are people of the seven kingdoms there, mostly refugees from the villages who appreciate the joyful distraction. The children of the orphanage are nearby, at Catra's insistence to let them join the festivity but away from the fight, entertaining themselves with the circus athletes and the minstrel performances scattered on the square.

Catra sits in the wooden tall and frankly uncomfortable chair while Light Hope fuses herself in the background. It brings a relieved breath out of her given Adora's advisor really makes her feel unnerving sometimes. From her place, Catra can see Scorpia and Perfuma a few seats

away and completely enthralled with each other. Scorpia hasn't said anything but Catra knows her and the red blush on her cheekbones betrays her. It makes Catra smile.

On her left side, Queen Glimmer and King Bow are already watching the sparring ground, murmuring between themselves until Catra arrives. Bow smiles gently at her but the queen doesn't, throwing her a cold gaze and a crooked eyebrow before looking away again. Catra holds the need to sigh or to hiss, she is not sure. She, whomever, knows that is probably justifiable for the way Catra had treated Adora after the wedding.

But that was months ago, Catra can't help but chew to herself, grabbing the armrests of the chair with a bit too much force, *Adora and I talked it out, we are friends.*

Friends.

Catra just pouts stronger.

A juggler is doing all sorts of tricks in the middle of the circle, announcing the soon start of the contest.

"Come closer! Come closer! The tournament is about to start!" they scream, their colorful clothes jingling with each movement. "Who would be our winner? Who will be the brave warrior that wins the Queen's gift?"

This calls Catra's attention, pulling her out of her thoughts. The words round her mind again and she turns her head sharply to her side, trying to tamper her rising panic enough as to not be noticeable at all.

"A gift?", whispers Catra to Bow, next to her. The King nods almost imperceptible, a kind smile on his face as he greets other nobles arriving at the platform. Behind them, Light Hope cleans her throat.

"It is tradition for the queen of Camelot to determine the gift for the tournament winner" answers Bow, finally turning to her. On his wife's face, a sinister smile starts to appear much to Catra's dread.

"I didn't know that", Bow's eyes widens as he fully turns to her.

"But- Adora asked Glimmer to explain-" his own words catch him and he looks back at Glimmer, whose expression is back to that of a composed regent and less of a petty crime sinner. Bow looks conflicted beyond measure but Catra just breathes deep once, twice, reminding herself who she is and where she is at and that she promised her Adora not to kill their friends.

She feels her brain almost fuming trying to find a proper getaway for this newfound information and as she does a new thought occurs to her.

"But what about before? When there wasn't a queen?"

"There hasn't been a tournament since Arthur's time, over 50 years ago" Bow's eyebrows furrow a little as he recalls Camelot's history. "Mermista put on the idea of bringing the

whole gift thing back and Adora thought it would be a good idea, to lift the spirits"

Catra chuckles a little bit hysterically, looking around the cheerful place and its people.

"What am I supposed to do? Kiss the winner?"

"It can be whatever you choose, so don't worry-"

"A kiss! The Queen has chosen a kiss for the winner!" screams the juggler, appearing out of nowhere in front of the wooden platform.

The crowd cheers in joy, chanting Catra's name and chattering between themselves for their favorite. Catra loses all the color on her face, incapable of turning back on her words now. The juggler gives a twirl, looking at her directly to the face. Their left eye shifts and a reptilian yellow eye winks at her.

"Double Trouble, I swear to-", she fumes, angry beyond measure.

Double Trouble limits themself to laugh and go back to their dance, walking out of the sparring ground. Besides Catra, Bow giggles awkwardly and Glimmer is beet red trying but failing to hold back her laughter from the look on her face.

Catra makes the mistake of looking towards the competitors direction. Adora is already looking back at her.

She wears a steel and silver armor, much different to the golden pieces of She-Ra's one. The chain shirt underneath the breastplate shimmers in the dim light of the morning and a tiny piece of Catra's amulet escapes from behind one of her gauntlets.

The winged helmet hiddes mostly of their face, but Catra can still distinguish the way their eyebrows are shot up and their eyes shine with surprise, mouth agape through the gap of the helmet. When they realize she is watching, their expression melts into a soft look that Catra can't read but that makes her limbs and chest ache. Before she can study them more, Adora closes the visor of their helmet and walks back to the others.

With that particular armor she looks so much like the other knights and competitors. Is only for the red and gold dragon on her shield that she distinguish from the rest. Yet, Catra recognizes her from the cadence of her walk and the infinitesimal fraction of movements when she passes by. And it's probably because all Catra breathes, thinks and lives for the last couple months has been them, but there is some kind of comfort in the fact that no matter how crowded or messy, Catra would be able to find her from miles away.

A scrawny looking young man with hay colored hair is running around in a circle trying to balance both Adora’s shield and her standar sword, and Catra can hear Adora laughing loudly at him at the same moment she pats him in shoulder so hard all the items go scattered over the floor.

More trumpets go off calling for everyone’s attention. Queen Mermista stands up from somewhere near Catra and that makes her attention finally torn apart from her best friend and

onto the public again. Mermista' deep blue and gold sari are stunning and she looks proud on her stand, knowing that every single look is now focused on her. Catra likes this member of the Table, she has the same dry sarcasm and straightforward kind of mind as her.

"The seven kingdoms tournament is an ancient tradition born in Camelot. It's been over five decades since this friendly sparring happened". Mermista tosses her black hair, making the sapphires and diamonds of her tikka jingle against each other. She takes pride in the fact that this festivity was her idea, and with good reason, it seems to be a complete success. "I, therefore, mark the Etherian Tournament as started. May the best knight win"

The roar of the crowd grows even louder, if possible, and a couple firecrackers explode above them producing a ringing sound for a few seconds. All the competitors have been divided in small groups of four each, making the process of elimination much easier that way. The rules per se are quite simple, one point for a hit on the outside of the thigh or the ribs; two points for a hit in the breastplate; and four points if the sword is completely knocked off the hand. The first contender that reaches seven points wins the round and advances to the next sparring. There is not really a big danger on it, except for a few bruises and scrapes. Still.

Catra is tense on her seat, she knows. Bow must perceive her apprehension too because after a short while he taps on the back of her hand twice to call for her attention.

"Everybody expects for Adora to win so there is nothing for you to worry about". He is a kind man, with soft factions and a short beard. She likes him actually, though you would never catch Catra admitting it out loud, and she knows he means well but his words just send Catra spiraling for the next hour.

If Adora doesn't win it means she will be forced to kiss some stranger. Of course, she is the Queen and she can decide where the hell to place the kiss. The head and the cheek are always popular opinions among people.

If Adora does win, whomever, it will mean that Catra will be presented with an opportunity and a decision. Just as the other options, Catra knows that she is allowed to choose and that Adora would understand it. After all, Catra is not foreign to the sudden feather-like kiss in the forehead when Adora feels particularly feisty or excited. Yet, on the other side, not *kissing* Adora feels wrong and absolutely terrifying. It's also going to be, probably, her only chance ever to do this even if it is in front of dozens of people. It is also a completely selfish desire, given Adora hasn't shown any kind of interest of that type on her.

All these thoughts travel and crash around her head so fast it makes her dizzy.

The contenders come and go smoothly, charging against each other with force and sometimes clumsiness. Catra thinks each sparring is fairly quick but time passes in a strange way when one is deeply submerged in their thoughts, and by the time she really focuses on the present again the sun is almost all the way up their heads.

Bow is right, because of course he is. Adora is really swiping the floor with these people. There are even a couple of times when Catra sees that Adora misses on purpose as if to try to extend the time of that particular combat. Is probably not noticeable for anybody else unless

they have a falcon eye or spend as much time with Adora as Catra does. But in all honesty, all these people represent little to none threat to Adora at all. She is just unmatchable.

Around the second hour there is a break from the fight. Most of the crowd's voice is raw from all the excited screaming and yet it doesn't die down. After many combats there is only one more pair for the grand final round, Adora against another knight, after Adora had defeated Sir Lonnie in an exhaustive fifteen minutes sparring. When Catra glances she can recognize the knight as the head physician of the kingdom and prince of the Northen Reach Island, Sir Azrael. Next to where Sir Azrael stands now, taking a breath and chucking a flask of water, a shorter person with colorful earrings is easily carrying about ten heavy looking swords on their arms while chatting at full speed. Catra recognizes her as the blacksmith and knight's wife.

They are good people and Catra is kind of relieved that Adora is going against Azrael but also kind of horrified when she realizes that the main show of the competition is quickly coming to an end.

Catra feels the urgent need to stand up and sprint to Adora but she can't, it goes against the rules to show any kind of interaction between her and Adora for as long as the competition lasts. So for now all she can do is stay by and wait for the long minutes of the break to wear off.

Double Trouble twirls right back into the arena, this time shapeshifted as a tall woman with rich dark skin and dark eyes. Their bald head is adorned with turquoise tattoos that travel all the way down their neck until they loose on the hem of their purple tunic. They move in that way that Double Trouble knows is going to be a cataclysm, and now every single look is focused on them and them only. Catra doesn't know where Double Trouble saw this person but it serves its purpose to quiet everybody down.

"Attention everybody, the sparring tournament is just a tad away from being over". As they talk, Adora and Sir Azrael step at the same time into the circle. They both look heavy and uncomfortable under all that armor but their breathings are even.

"This competition has passed in almost the blink of an eye, isn't it? But I bet none of us can wait to see who the lucky winner is going to be", Double Trouble continues, still shifted, and they turn slightly towards Catra to send a cheeky wink in her direction. If they were both younger, say about fifteen and around the time when this reptilian dramatic diva creature slipped into Halfmoon Kingdom for the first time, Catra would have stuck out her tongue to them. Now, in front of entire Courts and a village full of people, Catra allows herself only to wiggle her finger and strike them lightly with a rush of lighting right on the backside. Double Trouble hisses in protest but keeps going with their monologue. "Here I present to you your finalist champions, Sir Azrael of the house of Quinn and King Adora Alexander of the house Pendragon. May the Albion's ancestors guide your sword one last time"

Double Trouble walks out of the arena and if Catra had been following with her sight she would have been able to see them shift this time in a youngling with high antlers and sit right behind Queen Mermista, counting the bag of golden coins they had been collecting as the bets raised. But Catra is not paying attention, she is fixed with clenched teeth at the two competitors that bow to each other before taking their positions on the ground.

A scoff and Glimmer is talking for the first time since the beginning of the fight, bend a little so she can see directly at Catra's face as she says, "Nervous much, your Majesty?"

Catra returns her gaze from the corner of her eyes and there is an unspoken argument right there, with Bow in very middle. Glimmer's smug expression slowly lets into a different one because of whatever she sees inside Catra's eyes. She makes a manner as if she were to question Catra, and if she can see clearly all the turmoil going on right now inside her then that is the very last thing Catra wants her to do.

Luckily for both parties a horn resounds loud and piercing very different to the choiring sound of the previous trumpets. Adora and Sir Azrael bow to each other as a gentleman's courtesy, gifting the public from a second of held breath.

Sir Azrael charges so quickly and with so much force that Catra truly doesn't see it come and that is impressive given how sharp her senses are. Adora, however, does see it and they raise their shield to meet the incoming sword making a hard and vibrating *clank* noise. Adora pushes Sir Azrael away with a grunt but it is not long before the knight goes in again, meeting Adora's own sword in the middle just a few centimeters near their shoulders.

This confrontation is different and everybody noticed it immediately. All the previous sparrings had been easier, some of them even funny when the knights were principiants. In all the combos with Adora and Sir Azrael both had acted composed and clinical, with knowing movements and quick steps nearly as if it was just another training session. Now, both of them are attacking each other with uncontainable precision, the jabs of the swords barely brushing the giving points zones but never really hitting them before the other stops them.

Catra is, in all honesty, a little bit lost here. She has yet to meet Azrael in person but she does know that Sir Azrael and Adora are old friends who met at knight lessons. She doesn't understand why both of them are being so rough against each other now

She throws a quick glance at Bow next to her but both him and Glimmer are as absorbed with the fight as everybody else. Damn it, even Double Trouble still shapeshifted, is completely mesmerized wit(their eyes glued to the arena. Catra turns to look at Azrael' wife and finds them wearing a proud and excited smile on their pretty face.

Both Azrael and Adora keep throwing hits over the arena. Their feet mark deep creases on the dirt below them where the grass and the snow have given away. Adora surges to the side and hits Azrael right on the leg, scoring a new point, only for Azrael to lock the sword with hers and pull up, hitting Adora on the arm in the way. Someone somewhere in the public announce with a rasp scream a current tide of three points between both competitors.

Azrael hits the shield against Adora's, knocking both items to the ground. Now they are both fighting only with their swords. Sir Azrael is tall, even taller than Adora, so it comes with no difficulty that, when Azrael distracts Adora by yanking the shield away, the knight's swords connects painfully against the breastplate robbing Adora of her breathe and earning two points at the same time.

Adora yanks the helmet off and tosses it aside, grunting low on her throat and hardening her grip on her sword. The leather band that holds their braided hair gives away, letting the waves

of golden hair damp in sweat and mud fall free over their shoulders and back. It's not a life or death fight, even if it feels like it, but the snarl on the lips and the look in Adora's eyes is as determined and serious as with everything she does in her life.

Adora surrounds Sir Azrael, twirling just in time to stop another blow but unable to stop the shove of Azrael's full body against hers, throwing them both several centimeters back. The hold they both have on their respective swords is so strong it makes their upper arms tremble with the effort of holding each other away. Azrael steps away, removing too the helmet and throwing it away. The black hair spills out from the tight ponytail.

In the village, behind them and almost an entire universe away from this moment, somebody lights a firecracker which explodes in the sky with tremendous force. The acute sound takes Catra for surprise who let's a low yet ungraceful shierk out. Light Hope looks at her with disapproval even if nobody else in the Court seems to notice. Adora, whomever and still in the middle of the fight, does notice and immediately snaps their head to Catra with eyebrows shot up in concern.

Azrael uses the distraction and spins, elbowing Adora fully in the mouth. The crowd lets out a harsh gasp and Catra sprints to the edge of her seat, holding to the armrests until her knuckles go white. Adora shakes their head, spitting a gush of blood and smirking.

That is when Catra sees a flash of something else in their eyes, something she has seen on the times Adora is doing something dangerous and enjoying it. In front of them, Azrael cleans the forehead from sweat and smirks two.

This is why they are both attacking with so much fire, understands Catra. Sir Azrael knows that Adora can take it and is going with everything for it.

Oh, thinks Catra realization sinking in, *They are putting a show*

Catra almost wants to stand up and hit Adora herself.

Adora throws her shoulders back, chuckling, this time taking a hold of the sword with both hands. Azrael, who has been training with Adora since toddlers, seems to understand the cue and grips the sword in the same way. If Azrael manages to hit Adora in the chest again the seven points will be reached and Azrael will win, and given it has already been proved the knight has a height advantage that end doesn't seem far away. Adora's only hope now is to completely knock Azrael's sword off.

Catra does the math, just as everyone else of the present people and so does Adora.

When she charges for the last time the movement is slow, unlike all the other attacks, and it reaches Sir Azrael easy, too easy. Sir Azrael's eyes are suddenly scrunched in confusion as if what Azrael thought was about to happen, probably more push and pull, wasn't this at all.

Azrael raises the sword to stop Adora's blade but before it can happen Adora turns away, lowering, taking a hold of Azrael's wrist and pulling. The knight huffs in surprise when Adora yanks Azrael up front and Adora doesn't waste more time on it, raising the sword and hitting Azrael's own with the flat surface, sending it teetering away.

A stunned silence falls over the place, shocked by the abrupt end of it all. Catra doesn't even know how much time has passed since the sparring began or how much time goes by during that silence. Just that the sun is midway down.

A beat, then two and-

"The Kings wins!", yells Double Trouble and the crowd turns back to life, going insane in joy and cheers. From the sky small colorful petals fall, thanks to the excited plumerians and magicats around, that saunter gently to the grass below.

Adora straightens and so does Sir Azrael who blinks still in surprise to them. Adora smiles, clapping Azrael on the back and raising both of their arms to the sky, cheers increasing for Azrael too. Adora bends a little and whispers something to Azrael's ear who laughs abruptly and loud, clapping Adora too on the back.

The knight's wife approaches running and jumping to her partner's arms, yelling in joy and pride and victory.

Catra is mildly aware that she is somehow now standing up and that Bow is trying to call her attention by pushing something inside her hands. She looks at it and realizes it is a vivid green laurel crown. When she looks back up, Adora and Azrael are already walking towards the platform she is in, shields, helmets and swords still forgotten in the ground behind them. They seem to be chattering about something amusing because they are cackling when they finally reach her. Adora shoves Azrael, their friend, up front without wickedness urging for Azrael to "Take the damn crown already"

The knight is so tall Catra has to stretch her neck to look at Azrael's eyes. Azrael takes pity on her and bends just enough so she can place the laurel crown securely over the ears and head.

"Congratulations, Sir Azrael. You did a great job" Catra says with honesty, smiling kindly and now, thank goddess, much more composed.

When Azrael straightens again, seeing Catra directly at the face, Azrael looks back at Adora and then returns, the look on the eyes becoming knowing and even mischievous. Cold sweat travels down Catra's back and then Azrael *winks* at her, doing a little courtesy before jumping the steps back and going back to the blacksmith that waits.

Catra looks at them both embracing each other and yell " *Beer for everybody!".* They blacksmith raises her head and smiles, waving excitedly to Catra and pointing to something behind her.

Bow has pulled Adora to the center of the platform and he and Glimmer are congratulating him as they wait for Catra to turn back into reality. Light Hope basically smash a golden wreath into Catra's hands and urges her to do her duty and close the tournament, twirling Catra's slack body around and towards the friends trio.

Adora looks feral, with her hair matted in mud and her face smudged with dirt and blood from her split lip. She *smells,* metall and thick sweat and frankly a little bit disgusting. And

she is panting a little, her hot breath leaving in small puffs of steam against the cold breeze.

She has never looked more fucking attractive.

Catra scrunches her eyes, taking in the sight of them, trying to ignore the liquid warmth that pools in the low of her abdomen.

“You are such a clotpole. What the hell, Adora” she complains between clenched teeth. Adora breaks into a full laugh, so hard that it goes on for a few seconds and even pulls a few tears out of her eyes. Catra stomps her feet on the wood floor, annoyed. “Seriously, cut it out, you are a walking show off”

Adora wipes their teary eyes, noticing the lack of actual bite inside Catra’s words. They grow more sober the longer they look at her.

Is with a formal expression that Adora bows to Catra, one knee in the ground the other bent and Catra is so close to let the crown fall for how flustered she is right now is not even funny anymore.

She manages to let it go right over their head and then pulls quickly from their ear to bring them back to their feet. Adora complains with a series of *Ouchs, ouchs,* but she is wearing a shiteating smirk when she looks at her again and Catra answers by kicking them lightly in the sheen, her foot hidden away by the long skirt.

“What’s with you and kneeling? Don’t laugh! Stop it. Stop it! I can’t stand you. You are sleeping with the horses tonight”

Bow cleans his throat as discreetly as he can, and tries and fails to make a sign with his eyes to Catra. When Catra’s face drops, unamused, he just sighs signaling now with his finger to Adora. At Catra’s still loss, Glimmer steps closer, carrying a smile in such a way that she may be very well just plotting how to get rid of Catra and hide the body. In its place she just says.

“The promised gift, Queen. Everybody is waiting for it”

Catra is going to put a dead mouse on her pillow.

But it’s true. Everybody else has their eyes fixed on both of them, some curious others expectant other’s plainly impatience. Catra gulps for the sudden attention in such a supposedly private moment, her tail betraying her true feelings by tapping nervously.

Adora walks more into her space, calling for her attention by playing with the white ribbons of her dress and speaking at least.

"Catra" they whisper, so very close to her face their breath makes her eyelashes flutter. "You don't have to do this, a brush in the forehead will suffice for them, I’m sure"

Catra laughs nervously, playing with the ends of their drenched hair, trying to ignore the looks of everyone else.

"What? Don't you want to kiss me?" She jokes halfheartedly, knowing damn well that she may as well be walking into an intense heartbreak. So it comes with surprise when Adora blushes deep red and adverts at all costs her eyes.

"I didn't say that", murmurs Adora, dragging the words pitifully. Catra is so stunned that she automatically freezes in place, which doesn't help Adora, increasing their panic as they start to speech dump every thought on their head. "Of course I want but I promised you I wouldn't do anything you didn't want it and you are my best friend-"

They probably aren't even aware of all the things they are saying which is one of the things Catra finds more endearing about them. They are honest, always, even when they don't notice it, even when they don't allow themself to have things. There is a type of raw honesty in Adora that makes her wear her emotions on her sleeve. She uses them as a catalizer to be good for others, to be there for them, it's what makes her a great king.

They are always so kind and infuriatingly selfless, and Catra loves them. She loves them so much she feels like being tucked on warm blankets during the early hours of the morning. Like being surrounded by the ocean not drowning on it but floating above the gentle waves, holding her safe and secure. Like being chosen and being protected and being wanted. Adora feels right. Adora feels like home.

Their words barely make it through her brain and there is this knowledge that Adora *does want to kiss her* , but she chooses to look into it deeper for later.

"Adora" Catra interrupts them, brushing her fingers over a scratched cheek bone and smoothing her thumb right between their chin and the edge of their lips. She presses herself impossible tightly by rubbing her forehead against theirs. "Be quiet a moment"

Catra kisses her.

It 's…

...peaceful.

Like everything with Adora is both soft and electrifying at the same time. Every single nerve on Catra's body is alight but not in an uncomfortable way, like when she has anxiety attacks. More like she suddenly feels she has grown wings and has the capacity to fly.

Adora's lips are dry and chapped from the cold wind, and she tastes like copper and sweat. Their breath hitches when Catra brushes the slit on their lip but besides a surprised huff they don't turn apart. Their nose is pressed against the curve of Catra's cheek, puffs of breath caressing the lukewarm skin there in the gentlest of the ways.

Catra doesn't know how to do this or if she is doing it properly but it feels incredible. After a few seconds, she parts from them, smoothing her thumb again and again over Adora's upper lip, watching how their eyes are still closed and how they lean towards her as if chasing her lips.

Catra feels herself red. Red on the cheeks, red on the neck, red on the heart. Her ears are going crazy with the stimulation just as her tail, which flashes everywhere over the floor behind her. She can hear the crowd absolutely *thunder* around them. Someone is clapping, someone is whistling, *that may be DT.* The only thing Catra can hear, yet, is the tud of her own beating heart against her chest and the cadence of Adora's breath still pressed against her ribs.

Catra makes the smallest of the movements and that is when Adora finally regains a hold of their body, throwing themself forward so quickly that Catra doesn't stand a chance of stepping away. Adora gets a firm hold of Catra's slim waist and pulls her in again, drawing in their lips together once more.

It's fervent this time. Adora kisses with the full inexpertis of someone who hasn't done it before, and so does Catra, but that doesn't make it less burning. Their teeth clank swiftly when their mouths clash against each other, the sharp end of one of Catra's fangs catching the fragile skin of Adora's lip. Unconsciously, her tongue shots out and calms the upset lip which grants her the smallest of the whimpers. Catra arches her back under Adora's firm grip, managing to hold up just by grabbing herself from Adora's strong deltoids.

When they part ways for the second time Catra can see the hot steam coming from both their mouths. She blinks very slowly to them, unable to say anything at all. Adora sees this and then their sight travels to the ground, flustered. They know what that means. Adora blinks and then laughs, a giggle escaping from under their tongue.

"Why- why are you laughing again?" asks Catra, half dazzed half curious. Adora points with her head to the floor

"Flowers"

It's true, under Catra's feet a myriad of small blue flowers have sprouted from the ground, surrounding her in a small fairy circle. Catra mumbles unintelligible, mortified for letting her own magic betray her like this. Around them, the courts clap with vigor.

Adora embraces her, resting his chin over her head, cushioned between one soft ear and the hair there. Catra hides her face on the angle that exists between his neck and the shoulder, feeling suddenly too open to be in front of so many people. Even though the crowd does nothing but cheer for them. Adora hums low on their throat, likely understanding Catras overwhelm. They rock her slightly from side to side to lull her and press his mouth closer to her ear, calling for her attention with a soft murmur.

"Thank you", Catra's tail flickers at the sound of their voice.

"For what?", she answers so quietly only Adora can hear it.

"For trusting me on letting me have this from you". Adora breathes in deeply, tightening their arms around her neck and shoulders. "Thank you"

❀

They aren't allowed to stay together much longer after that. Catra holds Adora hand the entire time they greet each and everyone of the Court members present, and after, to all of the public that wants to salute de regents and receive their blessings. Most of them cheer for them, smile and even congratulate them, much to Catra's increasing alarm but Adora just accepts them all with a gentle smile and no more comments.

Catra needs to speak to Adora. She actually tries a few times but is always interrupted by someone new arriving. By the end of the procession, Adora's free hand and arm are full of flowers and colorful gifts. Glimmer and Bow had excused themselves too, much earlier, the Queen just sending a quizzical glance at Catra before disappearing in a rush of sparkling fabric and pink ethereal feathers.

Before Catra can turn to Adora, Light Hope appears out of thin air, her dark veil framing her eyes and face in that way that makes Catra anxious, assuring that "Adora is needed immediately to supervise the rest of the activities of the tournament, like the racing and shooting competition".

Adora doesn't even have time to say goodbye much less even clean himself from the remains of the last sparring, managing only to throw an apologetic look towards Catra's direction before being pulled by his advisor in a handful of strongly armed guards.

Catra is left basically alone on the platform, a little bit unsure of what to do with herself now. Her lips still tingle from the kisses and her knees are trembling so bad under the skirt of the dress that if she wasn't resting most of her weight in the wooden chair's backrest she would probably wobble down the floor. She feels the urge to sit there in the very ground or to run away back to their chambers where she can make herself small inside the sheets with only the comfortable weight of Melog sleeping on her back. But as the town's bells rumble announcing the late evening, Catra remembers that she promised to take the tea with Scorpia before the banquet, so she snaps herself from her own head dusting off her dress and walking right back into the palace, accompanied also by her own handful of guards and other magicats nobles.

The tea room is a considerable small room, or as small as a room can be inside that huge castle. It has white stone walls and a small table in the middle. Its only window faces west so the light on the sun showers the chamber in the most pleasants of the ways.

Scorpia is already waiting there, seated in one of the table's chairs that look maybe too small for her tall figure. She is alone, departed at some point from Princess Perfuma's side. There a couple of small cups, plates and silverware scattered in front of her as well as a tray full of little tiny desserts, a habit acquired from living for so many year with Entrapta.

Catra says her goodbyes to the court and enters the chamber on her own. It's warm in there, helping the ache that the cold brings to her feet. When Scorpia spots her, her face lights up like a hundred candles, waving her arms in the air as if they weren't barely three meters apart.

"Wildcat! You made it!", Catra flops on the chair unceremoniously, snatching immediately a strawberry cake and gobbling it up in two scrunchs.

“Of course I did. I promised it, didn’t I?”

Scorpia hums, drinking a bit from her cup and looking at her from up the rim of it. Catra drums her nails over the polish surface of the table, charged silence building up between them.

“So-“ starts Scorpia at least, cleaning her throat a few times, “the tournament”

“Scorpia”, mildly growls Catra, in warning. Scorpia shots her pincers up.

“What? Everybody is wondering the same”

“Everybody- ”. Catra takes a shaky breath as the events of that day hit her first slowly and then with full force. She tries to compose her expression but she knows Scorpia can see the inner turmoil as clear as water. “Listen, Scorpia, today was- it was a competition alright? I offered a price and fulfilled it, that’s all”

If Scorpia’s death stare and raised eyebrows have anything to say about the matter is that she definitely isn’t buying Catra’s horseshit. Catra throws her a crumb of bread, hitting her full on the forehead.

“Don’t you dare give me that look, Scorp. I mean it, Adora and I are friends. She is my best friend, we've only been together for six months. Today meant nothing, is not possible”

“But Catra”, murmurs Scorpia, covering Catra’s anxious hand with her own pincer. Her eyes are now worried and even a little sad. “You love her”

Catra’s pupils turn into pin points inside the eyeballs. She slips her hand away from Scorpia, choosing to hug herself in a vague attempt to calm her own emotions. She looks through the open window, to the winter scenery of Camelot that lives in peace for that day.

“Don’t be ridiculous”, she says between a sigh and a sob, fluttering her eyes closed for just a second. “It doesn’t matter anyway, Adora doesn’t want me in that way. I’m just their friend, that’s all”

Scorpia bends her head a little, searching Catra’s glance with her own black eyes.

“I don’t think you realize the way Adora looks at you when she thinks you are not watching”, Catra presses her lips together in a firm line shaking her head from side to side, unable to actually believe the words coming from her friend's mouth. Silence falls between the two again and it makes Scorpia, who looks like she wants to add something else, backtrack on her words. Her eyes cross with how hard she focuses while thinking and it almost makes Catra laugh with the absurdity of everything. "Do you want us to talk about something else?"

The air on Catra's lungs leaves on a relieved huff. She sniffs and pats Scorpia's pincer twice.

'I do. Thank you Scorpia"

Catra notices a rose pendant hanging from her friend's neck and it makes her pay more attention to Scorpia. She still wears that worried friendly look so characteristic of her, but her

cheeks and the point of her ears are pink and she has small white and lilac flowers stuck on the strands of her shirt white hair. She also smells very strongly like flowers and, more obviously than everything before that, there is a red lipstick mark right over her right cheek.

Catra can avoid but to chuckle, resting all her weight back to the backrest of the chair, arms crossed over her chest as she catches Scorpia's eyes again and very very slowly and deliberately raises an eyebrow.

"What are you keeping from me, Scorpia?". Scorpia immediately flushes crimson red, giving herself away. She also chokes lightly with the piece of bread she was just having, worsening the coloring all the way to her neck and shoulders.

"N- No? No. No. Me? Pff, no. You know I can't keep a secret. No. No", if Catra squints her eyes a little she thinks she will be able to actively see the steam coming out of Scorpia's ears. Her eyebrows just shot up higher, incredulity very clear on her expression.

"Oh really? Good then", Catra picks a blueberry from one of the dessert's toppings and pops it in her mouth, the sour liquid exploding against the roof of her mouth in a satisfactory way. "So how is Princess Perfuma?"

"Oh, great, she is so great", Scorpia's dreaming voice spills out. She realizes what she said very quickly, turning her head to Catra with wide eyes. "I mean- I mean of course she is great- good- nice! A very nice princess yes"

Catra laughs loudly and without ill, wrapping her hand again over Scorpia's pincer and squeezing a little. Once the laughter dies down and Scorpia stops stuttering, Catra's tail flicks her leg, making her turn her entire attention towards her.

"I'm just glad you are happy, Scorpia". Scorpia absolutely beams at her words. At this, Catra adds half jokingly. "Even if it's with a flowers Princess"

"Look who's talking", shots back Scorpia and both friends break into a new fit of giggles.

There is a disruption outside the room, a couple of yells and then the heavy doors are bursting open giving away to the same skinny knight of before. He is panting heavily, blond hair in disarray as he looks first at Scorpia and then at Catra with his mouth ajar and body unmoving.

"Your Majesty! Your Highness!"

"What is it, Kyle?", says Scorpia, sprinting forward on her seat. Catra doesn't move from her place, still too surprised by the sudden outburst to start processing. The young knight, Kyle, turns to Scorpia holding the latch of the door so tight to not fall on his knees.

"At the gates- at the gates of Camelot! There is a knight from Glenmar!" He gulps, completely anxious, before continuing his sentence. "They were attacked, all of them. All of them are gone"

❀

Scorpia and Catra enter the throne room in a rush.

There is a circle of people already there. Two physicians, Sir Juliet, princess Perfuma and an ill looking young knight who is sitting in a low chair near the throne are all pressed together, the four before hovering over the knight with rushed whispers. Light Hope observes in silence near the wide windows, hands clasped together and close to her ribs. Her expression is cold and distant, like she wasn't there at all.

Adora is also there, now free from the armor but still wearing the tight grey pants and white shirt from earlier. His hair is unmade, resting over his shoulder and back. He has their eyes fixed in the scene in front of him, with the dark eyebrows knitted together and the muscle of their back and arms popped from the strength with which he holds themself. They don't hear them enter the chamber.

Scorpia rushes next to Perfuma's side, entering the scene and helping the rest to tend the knight's wounds. Adora looks upwards and then to the door, taking in the sight of Catra still standing there and out of breath. Both move at the same time to the other, meeting in the middle. Catra rests her open palms on Adora's shoulder blades and Adora brings their hands up to cup Catra's jaw, leaning until their foreheads and noses are pressed together.

"What is going on?" asks Catra in a low voice, careful not to be heard by the group. Adora shakes his head in confusion, not turning apart.

"I don't know yet but is not good"

There is a gasp on the other side of the room and the knight whimpers, making them shift their attention to the group. Both get much closer and Catra can now appreciate how truly shaken this knight is. Their black hair is matted and in weird angles and they have a ton of scratches splattered across their translucent pale skin. They kind of look like they fell in a pool of mud, with small leaves and sticks still stuck on their clothes and broken armor. The knight's is trembling so badly their teeth click against each other with an audible sound.

"She- she" stutters the knight, clenching Perfuma's hand, who is squatting next to them, between theirs. "She took them, she took them all"

"She?" Interludes Adora as gently as he can. Still, the knight's eyes shot to their face with mild terror for the new sound, trembling getting worse if possible.

"It's alright, honey. Breath", whispers Perfuma and a soothing pink light shimmers from her hands to theirs, traveling all the way up their arms and to their chest. After this the knight seems calmer, more composed and less terrified. Perfuma checks up on them and dares to push forward with the sweetest of the tones "Do you know who *she* is?"

"The Shadow", behind Adora, he can hear Catra’s breath stopping, her grip on Adora’s hand turning vicious. "We thought it was a cloud, but it was bigger, thicker somehow. I- I don’t know how to describe it, it moved, yes- it moved so fast, like it was running, clouds aren't supposed to do that. Clouds aren't supposed to *breath"*

The look on the knight’s face travels far away, eyes misted in terror.

"It surrounded us, the entire village. We were in the way of taking the people to the kingdom of Snows. The Mystacor sorcerers were there too, helping, and then suddenly they disappeared. Just blue light against the black fog. It was so quiet, so so quiet, we thought there would be sounds but we couldn’t even listen to our own intakes of breath. And then she- she appeared, in the middle of the darkness and *she took them"*

"I don't understand" Adora doesn’t let go of Catra’s cold hand for one second but she tries to bend to the poor knight’s height. They look at Sir Juliet with quizzical eyes but she seems as confused as them.

"We already sent guards down there. There were signs of fight and magic residues but that is all. The village was empty"

"Did she capture them?"

"No!" the knight surges upwards, holding onto Adora’s arms with uncanny strength. Catra gasps, pulling from their hand on reflex. Adora can feel the trim of her magic traveling up and down their own arm, ready to protect them if needed. "She stood there and she moved her hands as if she were carrying something and the shadow moved with them. And, there was this bright light and she stole them" the knight gulps, looking directly into Adora's eyes "I think- I think. I think she stole their souls"

Scorpia shrieks at the same time Catra stumbles back, losing her previous grasp on Adora. When they turn to look at her she is a sickening shade of green, cold sweat all over her forehead. Her pupils had reduced to mere pinpoints inside her colorful eyes and her ears are folded down and tight against the sides of her head. She is scared, very much so. This knowledge awakes a new wave inside Adora, the sheer need to protect what is precious.

Adora raises quickly and holds both of Catra’s clammy hands between theirs, running their thumbs on shooting circles over them.

"Catra? Love?” The endearment nickname slips right past his lips but nobody seems to notice it, especially not Catra, who still looks at the knight in shock “What 's wrong?"

"It's her," she answers. Her voice, different from her body, does not tremble at all. She looks at the knight and then at a point above their head. "Scorpia"

The mentioned is standing now too, her eyes also wide and shocked. From her position, Perfuma places a calming hand on the inside of her knee, looking back and forward from Adora to Catra and back.

"Oh, goddess" Scorpia’s voice does tremble and she covers her mouth with her pincers.

"Who is she?" questions Adora, finger still caressing the soft skin of Catra’s hands. She is returning their hold with such strength that her nails dig a bit on their skin.

"Shadow Weaver"

The name pulls another gasp from Catra's chest. She is still silent, lost in a point on Adora's chest and definitely not there. In the ground the knight let's themself fall right back into the chair, exhausted beyond measure.

"Light Spinner?" presumes Sir Juliet, stepping in. "Morgana's last apprentice?"

Adora has no idea who she is talking about but the mention seems to pull Catra out of the spiral in her mind and she tugs from Adora's hold.

"It's her", her eyes are wide, filled with unshed tears and red rimmed in the edges. There is a lump in Adora's throat. He has never seen Catra like this before and her fear seems to slip inside their own heart, constricting it with force. "Adora. They are telling the truth. About the souls, about everything"

"How can you be sure?", asks Perfuma, now cradling Scorpia's arms between hers. Catra's eyes travel to hers for the split of a second, tongue heavy and cottoned.

"Because I saw her do it" she explains, voice shattering "She tried to take mine"

End of chapter III

Chapter End Notes

Hello! Thank you so much for reading!
Hope you enjoyed this chapter! I don't know exactly when chapter four will drop but is partially written now and it's going to be ✨exciting✨
- Glenmar is an actual location in Etheria, mentioned in the 80's show
Kudos, comments and shares are deeply appreciated. See you soon!

Chapter 4: The love that binds us

Chapter Summary

"Catra" she breathes out, shaking.

"I know"

"What do we do?"

What can Catra tell her? It could be bad. It could be good, though what part of a war is ever good.

"I don't know Sparkles. I don't know"

Chapter Notes

Welcome to chapter 4!

Oh dear. This one is a long boi both in length (20.6k) and the plot. A lot of things happen in this chapter so I really recommend you to get comfortable and maybe take little breaks in between.
WARNING FOR THIS CHAPTER
In this chapter themes like the war, attacks to villages and refugees are more involved with the plot. Please be aware of this before digging in
1.At the beginning of the chapter there is a scene where SW emotionally attacks Catra, which I've marked with (******) at the end/beginning of the scene.
2.At the end of this chapter there is an implicit sexual scene which I've marked with (^^^^^)
As always, if these scenes contain themes that may trigger you or it just doesn't appeal you to read them you can skip them without problem. It won't affect the understanding of the story. Please take care of yourself.

Hope you enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CHAPTER 4. The love that binds us

How meticulous she is for love

and how reckless she is

for everything that is not love

- Olivia Gatwood, *Ode To The Unpaid Electricity Bill*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x

✾

Princess C'yra runs across the corridors of her palace.

She still wears the black robes as a sign of mourning. It's only been a couple weeks since her mother's pass, the wound is still too fresh, too painful.

She is barely sixteen, but the weight of the loss already hovers over her shoulders and heart.

The lights inside the palace have gone all off, submerging the place in thick darkness. C'yra's eyes are sharp and she can see in the darkness as if it was a clear day, but this time is different. As much as she tried she can't see past her nose and the air that surrounds her feels so heavy it's choking her.

The only reason she's able to get anywhere is because she knows her home as the palm of her hand.

Scorpia and Entrapta are already out, dragged from the comfort of their beds at the rim of dawn by a frantic Catra and a confused and young Double Trouble, who had shifted as an imperial guard and sneaked them out before the chaos had blown up.

Catra turns to the right, and it's just a few meters more, just a little more so she can reach the throne room where her mother must be. But the darkness feels sticky against her skin and the peach like fur of her ears, holding her in place with the force of a thousand armies.

She knows Halfmoon is in danger. The bells of the village had woken her up, war firecrackers exploding against the starry sky in sparkling shades of red. She left her bedroom in a rush, the guards nowhere to be seen. Her mother, who after the death of her mom had spent most of her time working until late, wasn't neither in the main chamber nor in the royal studio.

Yet, Catra can't do anything. Her magic is powerful, controlled by years of practice next to her mom's guidance, and yet is still not strong enough to break free from the grasp this dark magic has over her.

The shadows grow, slipping inside her mouth, her ears, wrapping themselves like kraken tentacles around her wrist and ankles so strong and piercing that if she is alive to see another day they will leave purple and rose bruises.

There is a sudden shift where the shadows seem to stop, the silence so loud that if Catra stays any longer she will drive mad. Then, a red light emerges from the depths of the mist, shining brighter and brighter, making the shadow's arms break and open, giving way to a tall figure with purple robes and ebony hair.

Catra sobs against the mouthful of mist in her teeth, trying as hard as she can to stutter

"Light Spinner"

The Supreme Priestess, and her nana, regards her in contemplative silence not making any attempt to move further or to take the shadows away. Those don't seem to harm her, just float suspended in time around her, waiting.

*****

Light Spinner clicks her tongue, finally approaching her after a few tortuous minutes, just to brush a strand of hair out of Catra's face and cup the side of her face with a vice-like grip.

"Oh, little princess" her hold turns harsher, squeezing the bone so hard Catra is afraid it may snap and break "You disgraceful insolent spoiled child. Always hold high when you are nothing but a disappointment, a weakness, a distraction"

Catra whimpers, confused and hurt. All the limbs on her body feel exhausted and sore, the tentacles still holding her tight against the floor. Light Spinner snatches her hand away, letting Catra's head fall back, now completely muffled.

"I should have gotten rid of you years ago, but your mothers always protected you, I never stood a chance to get near you. But your mom is not here now, is she?" her tone turns cold as ice piercing inside Catra's mind and heart. Her green eyes seem to flash against the green of her flesh. "I never wanted to poison her, but she didn't give me another choice. Her foresight was too dangerous"

Catra's eyes open wide at her words and a bubble of pure wrath starts to make way inside of her. She starts to struggle against the shadows with all her strength managing to snap some only for them to move right back onto her. Light Spinner considers her with a death stare.

"Your magic is strong but is not enough. It never is. It wasn't enough before and it won't be know" the shadows seem to rack in the edges and completely fold, glacial as they start to grip onto the skin of Catra's cheeks. "I guess you would not be a complete waste of time, after all. Your magic will give me the last piece of strength I need"

The mist grips impossible tight and then sizzles, a show of raw electricity coursing through Catra's body and into her chest, wrapping itself inside something important, something essential and then tugging. It feels like her insides are being torn apart. Blackness starts to slip inside her eyelids and the back of her eyes, submerging her into a devious void.

*****

Before the unconsciousness can take her completely, another light rises from inside the shadows, right at Catra's side. It becomes brighter and brighter like a sun ray and then implores like a newborn star, chasing the shadows again.

There, about ten feet away, stands Empress Ziba. The gold of her armor reflects the light still pouring from her raised hands. Her ears are pointed forward in alert with her adorned tail

flicking on the air. She growls, low on her throat and completely menacing to Light Spinner who steps back, surprised by her sudden apparition.

Catra falls to the ground, coughing and gasping desperately for air. Her mother starts to walk towards her, arms still up and without taking her sight away from Light Spinner for a single second.

"Stay away from my daughter, traitor"

Light Spinner wiggles her fingers and a shield of dark magic builds itself around herself, protecting her from Ziba's possible attacks.

"So you succeed, Ziba. Well done. You were always the strongest of both". Ziba hisses, furious, circling Light Spinner

"You don't get to think or speak about my wife, ever again. You thought you could come to my kingdom and betray me and my family, but it's over" Ziba's golden earring clicks against the other as the Aure of her magic surrounds her completely too "I warned you, Shadow Weaver, to not tempt my fury. Ever! And now, you will burn for your sins!"

A blast of golden magic crashes against Shadow Weaver's shield, cracking it right in the middle. Weaver tries to react but Ziba is already attacking again, taking down the barrier completely. Weaver yells, frustrated and rushes forwards, heavy mist forming from beneath her and ready to attack Ziba.

She doesn't see Catra standing or approaching, by the time she sees her Catra is already mid jump with her steel cutting nails unfolded and stretched in front of her. Catra scratches right across the face, from the right side of the forehead across the nose and all the way down the left side of the jaw.

Light Spinner, Shadow Weaver, lets out a bloody scream right at the same time Ziba throws panother blast vaporizing the last of the shadows away. Weaver falls to her knees, cradling her face between her palms, whining.

Before either Catra or Ziba can make any other movement, new shadows are born from underneath her and swallow into nothing, disappearing.

Catra collapses and she would have hitted the hard floor if hadn't been by Ziba moving quickly and catching her inside her arms. She brings them both next to the wall, cradling her as Catra hides herself inside her neck like when she was just a kitten.

"It 's alright. You're alright now, sweetie", coos Ziba, rocking them both from side to side. "It 's safe now. You are safe"

Catra holds onto her mother, afraid she is also going to fade away.

"You are safe"

❀

Adora holds Catra the entire night.

She isn't sure when or how they arrived at their chambers, she only knows that there was a dark void pressing against her ribcage and the faint sound of Adora's voice ringing in her ears and then suddenly there was nothing until she felt the soft quilt of the bed behind her.

Catra remembers Adora guiding her gently to the dressing room, coaxing her to change her clothes. Remembers gripping Adora's wrist and they assuring her "I'm here, just at the other side of the door". Remembers changing into her nightgown and stepping out and onto Adora's open arms again. She doesn't remember what happened with the knight or with the rest of the group but if Adora is there it must mean they are alright. She just can't focus her head into that for more than a second.

She remembers a memory, pouring out of her freezing lips and onto Adora's hands. A point in her life she had wished she had never needed to go back to. Is exhausting, speaking about it with eyes aching with treacherous tears.

Catra is laying now with her back over the mattress, arms resting just above her head mingled with the strands of her wild dark hair. Adora lays over her, arms tangled around her ribs, head pillowed in her chest so their ear is pressed directly where the drums of the heart sounds louder. The weight of their body presses Catra down, calming down the waves of anxiety that come and go. The fabric of her nightgown is as soft as Adora's own shirt, lulling them both to fall into deep sleep at any moment. The exhaustion is evident in both of them but both refuse to succumb to sleep, clinging to the last of their energies to stay together just a little longer.

Catra watches the constellations on the ceilings glimmer, showering them with its gentle light.

"My mother passed a year after" she whispers, blinking away new formed tears. "After my mom passed away, it was really hard on her. I don't think she ever got over it. I think she died of sadness"

Adora says nothing, infinitesimally tightening her arms around her torso.

"I resented her for so long" sobs Catra, letting the tears fall free down her cheeks. "She had me. Why wasn't I enough?" She takes a shaky breath, lowering her arms and tangling her finger on Adora's hair, absently brushing off the knots there. "I understood it much later and I'm glad they have each other now. But-"

Her hands still, fangs biting against her lip until she can taste blood. Adora nuzzles her with their nose, waiting patiently. After some long minutes Catra takes deep breaths a couple times, collecting as much courage as she can. She is glad she can't see Adora's face now or she would have never dared to confess all of this at all.

"It scared me. Loving so much that it can break you. It terrified me, still does" she can feel Adora's breath lowering to a stop but she continues before cowarding again. "My mothers were the last people I truly told that I loved them. And sometimes- sometimes I think that I'm cursed, that she cursed me. That if I say someone that I love them I will lose them"

Understand, please understand. She begs in the back of her mind, nails now digging into the muscles of his back. She waits for it, the backlash, the moment Adora will stand up and retreat and the only thing she can do is hold onto them.

“I rather let my actions prove my lo- What I feel, Adora. Because if I say it out loud- I can’t- I just can’t”. Catra clenches her eyes closed, waiting. But the pain and the loss never comes, instead there is just Adora, seemingly trying to bury themself deeper into her chest as if they hadn’t nudged their way into Catra’s heart already.

“You don’t have to Catra” he whispers, voice calm and gentle. Catra can’t help but to wrap her tail around their calf. “They will know. I’m sure of it”

Catra gasps in between her tears, holding onto them. Adora let’s her cry, they stay silent all the time just breathing to a rhythmic course that Catra ends up following until she feels that there are no more tears for her to pour. Catra hiccups a couple of times trying her best to recover her breath.

"Can we stay together? Tomorrow? I- think I need it" she asks Adora. Guilt overwhelms her but she still asks. "I know how selfish asking that is. I know that we are Regents but I- I-"

"Catra, the love that binds us is more important than the power we wield". All the air left inside Catra’s lungs leaves in one breath and she wants to sing and scream at the same time but she can’t move. She can just lay there, surrounded by Adora’s warmth and smell and her entire world crashes down and rebuilds itself. "I'm staying with you, Catra"

The last candle inside the chamber burns out, covering in the starry darkness of Camelot’s nights. Catra starts to knead the sore muscles of Adora’s shoulders, purring without noticing.

“I’m not letting her hurt you again, Catra” mumbles Adora right before slipping into a restless sleep. “I promise”

❀

The War Room is slowly filling with the members of the Round Table. It's very early in the morning, Catra and Adora have had barely two or three hours of sleep and are swinging in their feet with exhaustion. Most of the time they are resting their weights against the other which is welcome, given they both refuse to part from one another for more than ten minutes.

Catra is very quiet that morning, still soft and exposed after her breakdown last night, though she only allows Adora to see it. She had nuzzled into Adora's neck before leaving for the meeting, a motion that Adora knew it was to scent them though they had chosen to not make any mentions about it. They are now standing side by side in the room, greeting all the members that enter and go to their seats, hands glasses together. Catra fidgets nervously with the rim of her pants, very aware that she will have to talk about Shadow Weaver in front of all these people. Adora just squeezes her fingers gently, rubbing circles on the bones of her knuckles.

As the amount of people start to wear off, Scorpia and Perfuma approach the pair, wearing matching sympathetic smiles. Catra seems to agitated lightly as they get closer but both keep a good arm away from them. Scorpia makes a motion to raise her pincer but thinks about it better and stops, searching with her eyes Catra's.

"Do you feel like hugging right now, Wildcat". Catra would be mortified by being referred to with her nickname in front of Adora if it wasn't because Scorpia's thoughtful action makes her all bubbly inside. She shakes her head in negation, blinking down treacherous tears, but smiles nonetheless. Scorpia's eyes fill with understandment and she steps back but now away. Perfuma smiles too, very very gently.

"Did you sleep well, honey?", she asks Catra, making an effort to divert her mind from the anxiety. Is very probable that Scorpia had already talked with her about what she knows of Shadow Weaver, so the gentleness comes appreciated.

From the other side, Glimmer and Bow make signs towards Adora, asking him in silence to join them for a minute. Adora grimaces, unsure, and pulls gently from Catra's hold to call for her attention.

"I'm going to go talk with Glimmer and Bow for a second" Catra looks mildly alarmed but Adora looks quickly at Scorpia and Pefuma's patience eyes and return his sight to her. "It's alright, Cat. I'll be right over there"

Catra hesitates, throwing a look between annoyance and despair to the Brightmoon Regents directions and then nods, letting go of their hand with reluctance. Adora gives her a quick kiss on the cheek and jogs to her friends, hugging them swiftly.

"Sir Juliet gave us your message last night" mouths Glimmer over his shoulder, patting them in the back. "I've made some investigations, they really are terrible news"

"We crossed with Perfuma in the way here. She said Catra seemed really taken aback" adds Bow, placing his warm pal over their shoulder. "How is she doing?"

Catra, Perfuma and Scorpia are still talking in lower voices, the couple managing to rob her a smile for the split of a second. Still her eyebrows are knitted together in the middle.

"I can't say much. Is Catra's privacy" Adora answers to their friends "I think she may say some things today. It's hard on her but I got her. She is home now. She will be alright"

Bow and Glimmer share a look, a silent conversation passing between them so fast Adora can't decipher just assume its meaning. Adora rushes to speak before they can ask something more.

"I know it sounds crazy but I-"

"You love her" affirms Glimmer with a smirk. Bow mirrors her smile. Adora sighs in response, gluing their eyes to the ground.

"Am I really that obvious?". Bow laughs above their head.

“A little. But we also just really know you very well”

Glimmer looks at Catra while Adora is distracted. She is still talking with her friend and Perfuma, playing nervously with her tail which is fluffed for anxiety. Her eyes are tired and the wild hair has been tied away in a braid to keep it away from her face. She looks much different to the upright proud version of herself that Glimmer has itched into her mind. Younger and more vulnerable and more like a person instead of a sculpture. Catra throws little quick glances to the three of them, or more specifically to Adora, as if she couldn’t wait for him to go back to her side. There is wonder in her eyes every time she sees him, and softness and trust and sometimes that is definitely love. Adora may not be able to see it yet but Glimmer does, after all she sees the same look on her friend’s. And for the ninth time since Glimmer met Catra she wonders if maybe she judged her wrongly, though she would never admit it.

When Glimmer turns to look at her husband he is already looking back, with his eyes content and wise. He knows all of this already, he has always been the smarter one of the three, at least when it comes to feelings. And now all those late night talks where Bow asked her to be gentler with Catra make sense.

Adora is still not looking at them, just playing with a small rock against their boot as they seem to be submerged in thought.

"Do you think it is too soon?", Adora asks, unsure. Is Glimmer who answers this time, letting the sweetest of the tones spill in her voice.

"Adora, love has no limit of time”, she says, earning a surprised look on Adora. “It happens when it happens, and it will always be right if it makes you happy. And I think that she makes you happy. I’ve never seen you trip on your feet or smile as much as when you are around her”

Adora giggles, rubbing their eyes with two fingers to try to take the exhaustion away.

“I- I think that she likes me too, I think I’m important to her”

“Has she said anything?” Asks Glimmer, a bit unsure on where to step. Adora shakes their head but their expression doesn’t sour.

“I respect her boundaries and her fears, Glim. She doesn’t have to say anything” Neither Glimmer and Bow can really grasp the true meaning behind those words but the conviction inside them makes them get a sense of relief. Adora finally looks at their eyes and adds. “I know”

Glimmer let's her hand rest over their cheek, patting the skin there. They are so tall almost as tall as Bow, they've gotten stronger with the years built as a knight and a king but this way, with their shoulders dropped upfront and their eyes soft and their stubborn look, Adora is still that ten years old child with limbs too long for their body and broken nose that Glimmer met all those years ago.

"Catra has done you good" she says, grabbing Bow by the waist so she can bring the three of them into a hug.

*We are happy for you, for both of you" whispers Bow in their ear, holding them tight in his arms.

There is a small sound next to them and the trio part to discover Catra standing next to them, hands resting one above the other. She seems hesitant, looking around the already cramped room and then back to them again.

“The meeting is about to start,” Catra explains, looking only at Adora now. Adora turns away from Glimmer and Bow and slips their hand back into Catra’s. The adoring gaze between both doesn't go unnoticed by their friends.

"Are you alright?", he whispers to Catra. Glimmer and Bow turn to their seats already so Catra murmurs under her breath.

"I have a bad feeling"

Adora catches the sour look on her face and smoothes a strand from her face, scratching the underside of her ear in the way. Catra holds their hand in place with her own, her tail wrapping around Adora’s ankle.

“It’s going to be fine, Catra, nothing bad is going to happen” assures Adora even if they can’t really promise something like that. Adora shakes that thought off, caressing the angle of her jaw. “We have each other”

❀

It 's bad.

Glenmar is devastated. Besides the young knight, that was sent to Plumeria for recovery, there are no more people left in the village. The remaining things left by the Horde's army have been robbed by runaway thieves and scavengers.

Glenmar is barely a day away from Camelot. Is too close to home.

The Horde army has come and left but the shadow of it's pass still lingers heavily. The surrounding villages are in process of evacuation, most of them traveling to the Kingdom of Snows for their safe keeping. Still, the uncertainty of not knowing where the Horde may attack next is nerve wracking.

The Round Table contemplates the maps and reports in silence. Catra's tail is still wrapped tight around Adora's leg and Adora has linked their ankles together in an attempt to ground them both. Bow is currently reading the knight guard report in a dim voice.

"Emperor Prime hasn't sent any messages claiming the attack" he says, almost crushing the lilac paper with the strength of his hold. "Our armies have searched the locations near

Glenmar and Camelot but there have been no finds. If they are out there they must be hidden by some kind of magic".

He seats again, holding Glimmer's hand in the way and squeezing it. The movement doesn't go unnoticed by Catra, who unconsciously moves her leg closer to Adora's.

"So this is the reason for the sudden use of dark magic by the Horde" reasons Mermista, tapping with the pads of her fingers over the parchment she was reading from.

"I don't understand," says Frosta, frowning, "wasn't the Horde's whole goal to erase all magic from Etheria?"

"It wouldn't be the first time Prime uses magic for his own benefit" answers her Adora, tense "He found a Sorcerer not only powerful enough but all one disposed to betray Etheria and Albion. I guess it wasn't hard taking a decision"

Frosta squirms uncomfortably in her place to which Perfuma puts her hand over her to settle her. She also looks at Catra's direction, who has been unnaturally quiet for the entire meeting, and asks in a calming tone.

"C'yra? What can you tell us about Shadow Weaver?". She was there when Catra had the breakdown and, by the little things Scorpia dared to tell her, she knows it is a hard item for her. Even now, Perfuma sees the way Adora immediately goes rigid next to her, almost as if they were waiting to jump in and intervene if Catra asked. The latter, however, doesn't give any clue that she is shaking by it though her ears flip in alert when Perfuma refers her with her full name and she throws a single grateful nod.

"Shadow Weaver is an old time Druid", she starts, looking around the entire table to make sure everyone is paying attention. "She's been around for a long time now, she has a lot of knowledge and she is very dangerous"

Catra makes a pause, gulping. Adora lowers his hand discreetly and links his pinky with hers where her hands are resting over her lap. Catra breaths in and continues.

"She worked at Halfmoon as the highest Priest for many years until she betrayed us and tried to take me. At that moment my mother managed to defeat her and she disappeared. We never heard from her again until yesterday." Catra looks down at the Glenmar map and then up again. "Shadow Weaver harvests magic from the souls she takes. It makes her more powerful than you can even imagine. It's very obscure magic, nothing like you have seen before"

"Does she-", Perfuma's voice comes strangled so she tries again. "Does she kill them? These people?"

But Catra is already shaking her head, eyes focused.

"Magic can only reside on living elements. Even the runestones you all use to canaliza your magic requiere you, living royalty, to work. Whatever she does to those souls she must keep them somewhere where they are safe from harm"

“But if she takes the souls, and she needs these people to be alive, then where are the bodies?”, inquiries Glimmer. Catra’s cheeks are pale and she is sweating lightly but remains impassive.

“My mother supposed that whatever Shadow Weaver uses to steal the souls it absorbs the body too, given it needs the living host to work”

“Is there a way to reverse it?”

“I don’t know”, Catra grimaces as if in pain and rests her back in the chair again, looking much more exhausted than at the beginning. “My mother never managed to find a way. And after her passing nobody in Halfmoon brought up the theme again. I’m sorry”

"It's alright, C'yra is much more than what we knew ", assures Perfuma, smiling.

The war room falls into a heavy silence again until one of the knights guarding the doors scoffs, crossing his arms over his chest and murmuring to the other one.

"Well, what could we expect from one of Morgana's apprentices"

"Morgana was not a monster", interrupts Adora, snapping to life with a new found fire in her eyes. The whole table turns to look at them and the knight steps back, clear sudden fear flashing on his eyes. Even Catra, who is right next to Adora, widens her eyes in surprise. "She helped raise my mother in kindness and taught her to control her magic. She was a good person with magic abilities that lived in a time where her own father tried to torture and erase anyone that practiced magic. She wasn't born evil, she was just as victim of the circumstances as everyone else. Regardless of the decisions she took in desperate times, Morgana was my great aunt and Mara loved her and I will not tolerate for her already stained memory to be dragged by the actions of an actual monster".

If a pin were to fall on the floor it would sound just the same as a tower clock bell exploding. The entire Court is speechless. The Knight who spoke shuts his mouth so quickly his teeth clank against the other. Catra just wants to drag Adora out of the room and kiss them senseless, prudence be damn.

The tension is broken by the gates open with force, a breeze of fresh air filling the room. Lady Castaspella, High Sorceress of Mystacor and Glimmer's aunt, walks in alongside a couple of Mystacor magicians. Their expressions are grim which only manage to turn the stomachs of everyone into knots.

Glimmer stands up in a swirl, teleporting immediately right next to her aunt and holding onto her hands.

“Aunt Castaspella, what are you doing here?”

Castaspella rubs her thumbs over Glimmer’s knuckles, smiling though it doesn't really reach her eyes and it looks kind of forced. The usual joy that characterizes her is not there today and she parts from her niece a little to approach the Table in quick steps.

“Queen Angella sent me,” she explains.

Glimmer offers Castaspella her own seat but she denies as she pulls out a parchment out of her deep blue tunic and extends it over the table’s surface. It shimmers with magic as red droplets rise from it, hovering over a place in specific and slowly moving forward.

“King Micah casted a true sight spell over the locations near the seven kingdoms. It’s a spell that allows you to see specific things even if they are hiding from sight with magic barriers. It doesn’t work with big things, like palaces or towns, which is why Camelot is secure inside the barrier, but armies are easy to spot on. It’s a wide amount of land so it took a while but it finally came out with results”. Castaspella flickers her wrist and the spots in the map get nearer, taking almost the entire table. Up close, Catra can see they are actually little figures, marching at equal pace across the Whispering Woods. “There is a Horde army currently marching to Thaymor. Micah couldn’t detect any sign of dark magic or of Shadow Weaver’s presence but we don’t know what kind of magic she might be using or if it helps her hide from true sight. What we know, however, is that at this pace the army will be arriving at Thaymor tonight”.

“Thaymor is barely three hours away from Brightmoon”, whispers Glimmer, a shaky hand covering her mouth as she sits right back on her chair. Bow stands up, resting a hand on his wife’s shoulder and getting closer to inspect the map.

“This is the second attack on a village in two days after months of inactivity. What is happening?”

“Shadow Weaver is harvesting magic”, says Catra, whose eyes don’t part from the tiny red lights moving over the wood. “These villages are some of the biggest ones scattered around Etheria. They must be planning something big enough that she requires as much magic as she can get. Magic is complicated, it drains you out when it doesn’t come from yourself. And she has been doing this for years now. She is looking for powerhouses, for people with enough magic to be of use for her” Catra stops when the weight of her words and the meaning of that may mean. By the look of everybody else they are thinking it too.

“We can’t let that happen” breaks Adora, mirroring Bow’s position and walking close to them. “We need to rush the evacuation of the last villages immediately. Nor Prime nor ShadowWeaver can penetrate the magic barriers of the kingdoms, if we manage to safe keep everybody inside those limits Weaver won’t have where to attack and it will give us advantage, as little as may be”.

“Adora, neither Camelot or Salineas or Brightmoon can hold more refugees. And the Kingdom of Snows is almost coming to a maximum. I don’t know if we can-”

“Plumeria will take the newcomers from the villages” Perfuma interrupts Bow, face so serious it is strange to look her in the eyes. It is suddenly reminded to everyone that she is an actual ruler, not only a peacekeeper. “We may not be as big as you but we are strong and smart, and we are well hidden from everyone else, both by magic and the earth herself. Nobody knows these woods like us, not even you all, much less a group of Horde Soldiers”

The rest of the Court seems willing to protest but Catra stands too then and joins Perfuma on her speech, shutting everyone out.

“Halfmoon will help accommodate the villagers too”. Scorpia gives her an astonished glance and even Entrapta stops describing everything in their journal to look at her with newfound interest. Adora gives a worried look to their best friend, scrunching their nose in uncertainty.

“Are you sure? Is important to keep Halfmoon out of the Horde’s hands, you are the last of Albion-“

“A kingdom is not formed by a place but by the people that built it and made it strong. Most magicats are already here, Adora, there is no logic in letting one of the most secured Kingdoms to be empty and rot when there are people who desperately need it” she declares, to Adora and to everybody else. She can’t see it now, but the look on the Court changes. The ones that still felt mistrust towards her now feel admiration slipping inside their pores, the ones that already had faith feel respect. Adora’s chest inflates with pride, smiling and nodding in affirmation. Catra nods back. “I’ll give the word to my Commanders and they will start the evacuation to the villages in need immediately”

“What is going to happen with Thaymor?”, asks Mermista. The tired annoyance that is usually her facade has dissolved a little and it can be seen the true worry she feels right now. “We can’t send them to evacuate on time. Even if we send armies now the Horde will be there no much after, and there is no way we can use the Moon stone to transport so many people at once”

“Then we defend it” affirms Bow. Glimmer snaps her head up to look at her husband straightened on his place next to Adora, looking every inch the King he is. “I’ll lead it. We take a portion of our armies alongside Mystacor sorcerers to help manage the Moon stone magic and we defend Thaymor until all the residents are transported inside of Brightmoon barriers.”

“What if Shadow Weaver is there?” questions Catra.

“We hold her down too”

“You saw what she did to Glenmar” Catra is starting to feel very at the edge. She appreciates Bow, she even likes him, and the idea of him being in danger. Glimmer face is absolutely broken too.

“I'll go with you,” she says, breathing hard. Bow denies her with a firm expression.

“No, you need to stay here. Camelot is completely out of limits right now. The Moon stone is directly linked to you, you need to be here. You need to be safe. *I* need you to be safe”

The air in the war room is chaotic. Bow and Glimmer are now discussing in low voices while guards shout orders to each other. The rest of the Round Table is up and going around too, most of them getting ready to part to their own kingdoms and prepare the arrival of new comers or to send aid and food in case of need.

Catra tries to search for Adora's eyes but she has her eyes turned down and onto the maps, not once looking back to her. Just as Catra tries to walk over them, Bow leaves the room with a knight and Glimmer, who is still trying to convince him. Light Hope makes an attempt to get near them at the same time Adora shoots their head up and follows them with their eyes until they all disappear out of sight. Then they turn back, ignoring Light Hope completely, and says to Catra still without seeing her directly in the face.

"I need to speak with King Bow for a second. Stay close to Juliet, Catra"

And then Adora is gone, disappearing right behind the Brightmoon rules. Light Hope looks as frustrated as Catra feels and walks out too in a swirl of black robes.

A nasty presentiment coils inside Catra's guts and she turns to Sir Juliet, who is waiting patiently behind her, saying in the most commanding voice possible.

"I want you to tell me where does Adora go after they finish talking with them." Sir Juliet's eyes narrow at her tone so she adds in the most honest tone possible. "It's important".

Sir Juliet regards her in silence and seems to see the urgency in her face because she nods and leaves the chamber too.

Catra falls onto a chair with a hoarse sigh and waits.

✾

"What are you doing?"

Adora stops on her motions, belt halfway buckled around her waist. She doesn't turn to look at Catra but she doesn't move either. Catra steps forward, pressing.

"Adora, what are you doing?". Her voice breaks in the end but she is too busy holding back a scream to mind it. Adora sighs, finally, *finally* turning to her, eyelids dropped and mouth pressed in a firm line. The lines of her forehead mark creases when she frowns.

"I have to go Catra"

There is a swirl of emotions on Catra's precious eyes, from rage to terror to sadness. Her hair is tousled for the wind, she probably ran all the way from the war room to the armory once she found out what Adora was planning. Truth is, Adora didn't have the guts to look at her face and say they were leaving for Thaymor too.

Adora turns away from her again, unable to hold her gaze anymore, guilt curling nasty and festering in the bottom of her belly. She doesn't hear Catra move but suddenly there are a pair of arms around her chest and a face pressed tight on the space between her shoulder blades. Catra is trembling like a leaf to the air and her voice is strangled when it comes out

"You don't have to do this" she begs, hands pressing firmly over Adora's chest. They stop breathing for a second, lungs aching from the lack of fresh air but not wanting to make any other sound either "Stay"

Catra knows what she is asking. She knows that is the most selfish thing she has ever asked in her entire life. She knows the position she is putting Adora into, because Adora cares for her but also cares for their people. And still, she asks for it.

Adora feels her heart break into pieces.

“I can’t”, denies Adora shaking her golden head and her voice trembles too but her expression is hard. She is not changing her mind. “I can’t, Catra, you know that I can’t. Bow is going too. I can’t let him go alone. I’m the King, I have to do this. Is my duty”

“I thought that the love that bound us was more important than the power we wielded”

Adora inhales sharply, completely taken aback by their own words thrown back at them. Guilt fills Catra’s guts but she doesn’t apologize or take the words back. She hopes that, somehow, it will help make Adora change their mind.

But they don’t. They turn away completely, slipping out of Catra’s hands like sand and finishing putting all the elements of their armor. And this time is the golden one, the one that catches the light of the late evening in rainbow-like reflects. With their hair up in a tight ponytail and the crowned helmet hiding their lovely factions, they don’t look like Catra’s Adora anymore. She looks like someone else completely. She looks like a goddess, an ethereal warrior, beautiful and powerful and beyond Catra’s reach. She looks like someone Catra loves who leaves again.

“Why would you say that then, just to get away after?” questions Catra, lip trembling as she tries to contain a wave of tears.

“You know why, Catra” answers Adora in a broken whisper.

Catra can’t deal with it. She just can’t. So instead of standing there alone, Catra storms out of the armory, leaving her behind too.

Adora sighs, a sharp intake of air that burns inside their lungs like freezing water. Yet, Adora doesn’t follow. She can’t. She knows that Catra is terrified, that she doesn’t want to lose them, and neither does Adora. They are afraid too, they are always nervous when leaving for a battle. But now is much different, now is terrifying, because now Adora has someone she wants to return to.

And is this exact same thought that makes Adora collect herself and walk out there, because she needs to protect what she loves, all of it, no matter the cost.

❀

The way the knights and warriors from all the kingdoms are capable of organizing themselves in a matter of a couple of hours is surprising. When Catra walks out and into the huge stairs that lead to the main gates, everybody is already ready and waiting. The shining surfaces of their shields and armors reflect the light of the cloudy midday.

King Bow is already in the yard speaking in a soft low voice with Glimmer. He wears a slightly lighter armor, with a thick leather gauntlet and a chain coat that jingles with magic every time he moves. Glimmer looks exhausted, stubbornly maintaining a strong look on her face all the while Bow holds her hands and kisses her on the forehead. The moment is so tender and private that Catra parts her eyes from them and scans the yard for someone else.

She spent the last hour walking up and down the lonely tower, batting away the feeling that someone was watching her and sobbing in anger.

She is mad with Adora. She 's furious. The mere thought that Adora is so willing to leave everything and everyone behind, to leave her behind, just to fulfill some royal duty makes her blood boil inside her veins and the back of her throat fill with acid.

She even considered not going down at all. To let Adora go and face the consequences of his decision alone. But, in the end, she realizes that she can't. Danger has never been as high as today. If Catra let's Adora go, if she lets her pride take the best of herself and if something happens out there she would never be able to forget herself.

She knows that Adora is right, too. That their people need them. That in this moment, they need to see beyond themselves. So Catra swallowed her anger and her fear as best as she could and went out there, to the cold and grey day.

Catra looks without actually seeing at everyone's faces until she spots them, Adora, fixing the chair on Swift Wind. They have taken out the helmet for a moment, so Catra can see the knife cut angle of her jaw and the way their ears are red from the cold. There is a sword hanging from their hip, with the handle’s end adorned by a deep blue gem and white gold bathing the entirety of the blade. Under the light of the winter’s day Adora’s hair looks almost white. Their expression is very solemn, steel blue eyes vibrant against their skin.

Adora scrunches their nose, their eyeliner flickering, and then they raise her head to meet Catra’s eyes with surprise on theirs. It’s fair, after what happened in the armory. Catra can feel the fur of her own ears and tail standing on point, moving like wild against her best wishes.

Adora’s chest moves with their breath and both they and Swift Wind walk side by side until they are right in front of her. Catra shifts on her feet, cold slipping through the seams of her coat.

“Adora, I-”

“I know” Adora interrupts her gently, letting go of Swifty’s belt, who bends his head and bumps Catra softly on the shoulder. She always thought he didn’t like her, given the amount of times he threw her off when Adora tried to teach her how to ride horses, but maybe she had been wrong this whole time.

Catra scratches the side of his face not letting her eyes drive away from Adora’s face. She looks impossibly soft. The words of Scorpia ring on her head again *“I don’t think you notice the way Adora sees you when she thinks you are not looking”*. Catra is looking now, she sees as clear as day the realization hitting her in the heart like the thorns of a rose.

Catra tries to speak again but her voice is gone, miles away from that small place in a yard full of soldiers. The only thing that comes out is a shaky breath and something that sounds almost like a whimper and almost like a sob. Adora's eyes melt even more, if possible, and they bring their hand up to Catra's face nestling it in the cup of their clothed palm. The fabric brushes against Catra's skin and she wraps her own hand tight around their wrist, holding Adora in place for as much as she can.

"I'm sorry, Catra"

Catra thinks she manages to mumble " *why are you sorry"* even if the only thing that comes out are babbles because Adora hums, tensing their hold on her cheek a little bit more.

"I promised you that I was going to spend the day with you. I'm sorry I couldn't make good of my promise." Adora's thumb caresses the skin near her eyelashes. They try to relieve the tension with a tiny smirk. "Maybe when I'm back we can try those horse riding lessons again. Told you Swifty likes you"

Every time Catra thinks she can't fall in love more with this person and every time she is proved wrong. Catra chuckles and she finally finds her voice again.

"You are such an idiot, Adora"

"Yes. I know" they answer, smiling.

They look at each other's eyes for a good while and the Adora's eyes flash with something. She takes her hand back, fumbling with the folds of her red cape until she finds what is looking for and, after a little more of struggling, extracts a small thing out of it. Catra can't see what it is but then Adora is taking her hand, extending her cold fingers with theirs and letting the little thing fall into her palm.

Catra catches sight of the worn well loved surface of a golden wing.

"Keep it" Adora murmurs, closing her hand over the small trinket. Then, she brings Catra's hand over her own chest, right over the place where her strong beating heart is, locking her eyes with hers in burning and raw vulnerability. "It's already yours"

Catra gasps at her, speechless. Her fingers bend a little and hold to the fabric of Adora's cape, raising on the tip of her feet so she can get nearer to her.

"Adora-"

"I'm sorry Adora but we are ready to go", calls the voice of Bow and when both look up they see him already up and mounting his horse. His usual cheerful expression is stone serious.

Catra tries and fails to keep Adora in place because they are already stepping away from her grasp. Before they leave completely, however, Adora leans in all their tall figure and kisses the side of Catra's head with fluttering lips.

She barely has time to bask in the warmth of their proximity because next thing Adora is mounting Swift Wind, calming him with sweet coos.

Glimmer gets near Catra, unconsciously holding herself into her coat. Catra doesn't even make a remark about it because she is also pressing herself next to her. They both need this now, as they watch together at their best friends and spouses march to the center of the arcane circle on the floor.

Adora regards them both with hooded eyes, helmet tucked beneath their arm. She opens her mouth and closes it a few times, weighing her words carefully until she settles on a solemn

"Take care of each other"

Glimmer's grip tightens but Catra only has eyes on Adora. The words boil on her tongue, rotten sweet, but she can't push them out of her. She wants to run off and throw herself off a cliff onto the sea, or bury herself deep into the dark earth of the woods. Anything, anything at all except stand there in shock without even a chance to follow them on their path.

The arcane circle shimmers with an intense shade of pink, activated by the Mystacor sorcerers that are traveling with them, and its light surrounds the army, completely covering them in the same bright color.

Adora and Catra don't leave each other's sights until the light starts to flicker and then in an instant the entire army is gone, transported as closer to Thaymor as they can, taking Catra's entire world with them.

❀

Catra and Glimmer walk next to each other around the corridors of Grayskull palace. They didn't plan it, they aren't even talking to each other. But both Queens stick to each other's sides and don't part. A small truce on their usual rivalry, only surpassed by the beating fear of having the ones they love taken away and in danger.

Catra can't shake off last night's knight's story. She can forget it or bury it in her mind as she so desperately tries. It's only those words and the images of her past that travel on a tortuous dance. If Glimmer wasn't next to her, like a buzzing bee if you ask her, Catra would probably collapse on the floor and cry. But she can't do that. She is a Queen, they both are. They have obligations that need to be complied.

Catra can hear Adora's voice in her head. *"This is my duty"*. She understands them. They are the only reason why she is still standing and not snuggled in bed waiting for her beloved's return.

Is she even mine to call beloved, Catra asks herself, bitter.

Glimmer must feel her growing frustration because she clears her throat the best she can and asks with that little proud voice of hers.

"Why are we going back to the throne room"

“I’m going to the throne room. You can do whatever the hell you want”, snaps Catra. She regrets them as soon as they go out. As annoying as Glimmer has been with her for half a year now, it isn’t her fault, nothing of this. So Catra clenches her jaw and backtracks. “I’m sorry. You are not at fault for this. I’m just angry”

“Yes?”, scoffs Glimmer in a strangled tone, crossing her arms over her middle. “You are not the only one. I wish I would run away to them right now”

Catra throws a sideways glance at her and sees her cheeks painted pink with the same rage that fills Catra. It makes her feel some kind of relief, as little as it is. And also some strange need to offer solace to her.

“Well I would like to obliterate the place to the ground. You are not special, Sparkles”. The banter, on an usual day, would have gotten Catra and Glimmer into a small fight of prides, but right now it serves its purpose and manages to rip a smile out of Glimmer’s lips.

She squints her eyes immediately after, going back into a nostalgic look that Catra can’t stand. So Catra stops them right there in the middle of an empty corridor and speaks quickly and lowly before anyone else can come in.

“Listen, I know what you are thinking. Run away and meet them there. I want to do so to, believe, I can barely fucking stand being left behind here right now. But those two let us here because they trust us and they need us to be here, alright? You aunt or whatever herself said there wasn't a track of Shadow- of that woman with the army. They are going to be *just fine* ”

The more the words come out the more they sound like she is trying to convince herself of their meaning instead of Glimmer. She, nonetheless, looks at Catra with raised eyebrows and a surprise grimace.

“So you do have a heart after all” Glimmer throws. Catra hisses at her low on her throat and starts walking again with renewed force.

“Goddess, Sparkles, go find a well to swim in”. Glimmer follows her close behind until she is able to catch up on her.

“Pretty sure that say doesn’t go like that”

“Do you want me to tell you how it really goes, Sparkles?”

“I’d rather not”

The queens walk in blessed silence for about fifty meters more and then Glimmer opens her mouth again, making Catra need to suppress a groan.

“So why are we going to the throne room?”

“Good grief”, complains Catra but she ends up answering anyway. “Vice Counselor Pompoled from one of the independent villages is here with a request. I need to attend to him. I also have an announcement for the Courts that can’t be delayed anymore”

“An announcement” presses Glimmer but Catra shakes her head. She can already see the beautiful decorated doors of the throne room.

“Yes Sparkles” she clicks her tongue and adds.

Glimmer seems recelous but curious. When Catra arrives at the gates that open slowly in her presence, she mocks an educated bow, signaling inside with her head.

“Let’s go then. You will find out in no time” they enter together, the trumpets announcing their arrival. "Just let me get this over with and then we can dwell together in our shared misery, alright?"

"Fine" she spats.

There are a myriad of people in the wide chamber. A few Camelot's nobles, guards, Light Hope and of course the Vice Counselor and his caravan are already waiting there. Scorpia is inside too, thank goodness, standing near the right thrones as Catra requested her in a message a few hours ago.

Perfuma is not with her. She parted to Plumeria right after the meeting, as the majority of the Round Table, to prepare for the rescue and arrival of the newcomers. Catra feels a little bit bad for asking Scorpia to stay behind, but she really needs her there now.

"Come with me" whispers Catra to Glimmer as they both walk the path towards the matching thrones, the people in the chamber bowing as they walk by. "Remember that nobody knows about the Thaymor mission so try not to look so dead inside"

"Say that again and repeat it to yourself three times" Glimmer shoots in the same low voice.

Catra climbs the three steps up to the platform and waits until Glimmer is standing next to Scorpia, they greet each other kindly, before sitting down again.

"Lady C'yra!" speaks immediately the Vice Counselor, without waiting to be given the word.

Is a small ridiculous man, with a round belly and a tight green button down that seems about to burst open with each breath. He is so white he looks almost red, with round cheeks too and the smallest of noses bright with skin oil. He is in his sixties, if the smoothness of his bald head says anything, with a silly beard that goes from the sides of his head and around all his chin. There are hairs that burst out of his pointy ears and nose and his teeth are corn yellow when he smirks. The clothes he wears are expensive, with threads of gold and silver and a cape of fur that makes Catra's hands clench over the armrests.

Overall, he looks like a rich man with pretenses of greatness that is about to give Catra a headache. Next to Catra, Glimmer makes a small noise that confirms that she is thinking the same thing.

"Lady C'yra" he repeats with a squeaky voice. He licks his lips when she focuses her eyes on him and that makes Catra shiver in disgust. "So glad you can finally join us. I am Vice Counselor Pompoled Baron the first, from the greatest Noremia City, coming in the name of

the Sorian Court. I am here to gather the resources Camelot must provide us with. I am expecting to march from here with two thousand soldiers-"

"Vice Counselor", interrupts Catra, doing an excellent job on not grimacing at him. He looks offended, as if surprised that Catra had dared to interrupt him. "Thank you for your energetic presentation. We are all so glad Noremia has made an appearance during this war. But there's an announcement of immediate urgency that I must give first. You will be given word after I allow it"

The Vice Counselor sputters, his face starting to go red with frustration. He only steps back when Sir Azrael, who has come back from resting from yesterday's tournament, walks out and as discreetly as possible pushes him back to his place in the side.

Light Hope approaches Catra from the other side of the throne, the one that connects with Adora's equal one, to murmur in her ear.

"Your Majesty, I think it would be more convenient if you let the Vice Counselor to do as he wishes, specially without the King here right now"

"Thank you, Lady Hope", answers Catra back, tense. "But I will be taking advice today only from Queen Glimmer. If you don't mind"

Light Hope always looks at her with a dispassionate expression, Catra is not foreign to the fact that Light Hope doesn't like her even if it was her whole idea to go to Halfmoon for help in the first place. But today that usual stone-like facade breaks for a millisecond and her eyebrows twitch with anger. Her eyes travel to a point in Catra's vest, right where Catra has clasped Adora's pin. Light Hope's pupils go pinpoint small. She doesn't comment more or fight Catra's decision, she can't. The only thing she does is straighten and walk away from the throne and nearer to the windows behind it, looking in silence to the room's amplitude.

Catra clears her throat, reclining in the throne as she takes the sight of everybody else quiet and waiting for her. She shares a look with Glimmer, who still looks confused but nods in encouragement anyway.

"Thank you. Now, as most of you know I've decided to open Halfmoon to receive the remaining refugees of the small villages surrounding the kingdoms. However, for the moment I am needed here in Camelot so I will not be able to supervise Halfmoon's activities in the time that comes." She pauses to catch her breath and also to throw a quick glance to Scorpia. "I've decided to name Princess Scorpia Crown Princess of Halfmoon. She is already supervising most of the decisions that happen in the kingdom and there is nobody else I would trust more with this endeavor"

There is a stunned silence in the chamber and then the noise comes back to live. The nobles gasp loudly, the guards chatter between themselves as if they weren't on duty. The Sorian Court explodes in unintelligible murmurs. Light Hope doesn't move but her face becomes colder. On her side, Glimmer whispers astonished under her breath "Fucking hell" so low that only Catra's extraordinary hearing can catch it.

Scorpia is watching Catra directly at the face, mouth agape and eyes sparkly from actual tears. She is covering her mouth with her pincers and the little flowers in her hair slip a little from her white hair as she moves. Catra leans on her seat and nods, smiling with deep honesty to her friend. Scorpia smiles bright and wide and amazed and is surprising how much she is holding herself back because Catra can see just how bad she wants to step in and hug her. On the choir balconies of the room, Catra gets to see the glimpse of Entrapta's purple hair, no doubt scribbling on their journal as much of this social interac as they can. They must catch Catra's glance because there is a sudden thumbs up that appears from behind the balcony and then disappears again. It makes Catra huff in laughter, how much these dumbasses really mean to her.

"Excuse me" comes in the undesirable voice of the Vice Counselor. He waggles right in front of the throne again. Even when Catra frowns down at him he doesn't stop until he is firmly planted in place, giving Catra a look of pure disdain. "This is unacceptable. Instead of making foolish decisions like this, matters of actual importance should be attended to. I've come here to demand the royal guards that our greatest city Noremia deserves, not to see a couple of girls bouncing around titles like candies"

Catra blinks at him, speechless.

"He is an asshole" whispers Glimmer quickly by her side. She sounds as angry as Catra feels but she has had her own share with idiots like this and it helps her keep her calm better. "Don't let him get into your skin"

Catra breathes in and out a couple of times, collecting all the fragile calm she can before answering.

"I beg your pardon?"

The Vice Counselor sorbs his nose, clicking his tongue along the way.

"Is Camelot's obligation as the center kingdom of Etheria to provide us with enough soldiers to safekeep our lands until this foolish war of yours ends. Just as it is a courtesy to consult with all the land's rules before deciding on giving a new title. Someone should have made you aware from this in advance"

"Noremia is high and hidden in the Northern Mountains, Vice Counselor. This is the first time you and your Court make an appearance in eight years since King Mara's death. And King Adora has made no mention about any agreement with you" answer Catra between her teeth. Glimmer gets closer to her and Scorpia, before merry and excited, is now looking at her feet uncomfortable by the Vice Counselor's words.

Catra hasn't had a good day. Many things have happened in the last 48 hours between her feelings and the war. Adora is gone to fight heavens know what and they have had only three hour of sleep and a tough reckless head. So Catra is not happy, she has no patience and she doesn't appreciate a pathetic cretin insulting her friend or herself right now.

The Vice Counselor makes it worse.

"Ah, yes" he scoffs, mockingly, looking around the throne room as he swings on his ugly little feet. "I've been made aware that the King is not here. But I expected for you, Lady C'yra, to be more reasonable. I understand you haven't been here for long but putting a kingdomless *princess* , as you may refer, on the throne of one of our strongest assets is not an appropriate choice. If I may propose-"

"You may not and that's enough" commands Catra, standing from the throne. Immediately all the knights apposted around straighten and the Sorian Court falls into silence. "I remind you, Vice Counselor, that I am not a simple girl. I am the Queen of Camelot *and* the Empress of the Halfmoon Reign and you will address me and my people with the respect that is required. Have I made myself clear?"

The vice counselor's eyes widen at the sudden change on Catra's tone but he nods in agreement, face gone ghostly pale. Catra knows how he sees her right now, in the same way the nobles of Halfmoon looked at her when they thought she was just another spoiled princess and she proved them wrong. Catra takes advantage of his momentary stumble and presses on, satisfaction pooling deep on her chest.

"I also remind you that you are in no position to declare what I must or mustn't do in my kingdom. I find Princess Scorpia worthy of being Crown Princess and you will accept this without complaint. Say you understand"

The Counselor seems to choke on his tongue as he nods again.

"Say you understand, Vice Counselor Pompoled" repeats very slowly Catra.

"I understand my lad- my Queen, your Majesty. I understand"

"Good" Catra straightens her shoulders, shaking the loose wild mane of hair over her back "And last, your petition is denied. I am not sending more knights to a rich town that has been, is and will be secured from the pains of the war. This is my last word about it".

The Counselor seems completely indignated at this, huffing in a way that makes his nostrils flop. He closes his hands into fists again.

"I must protest! If King Pendragon were here-"

"The King is out there fighting in a war of which you and your people have cowarded from. Putting their life at risk to save innocents, not hiding away in marble halls with expensive wine and silver clothes. Do not presume to know what her heart may speak. I warn you, Vice Counselor, don't play that card here because believe my words it will not end well for you."

The man actually *shivers.* He hit a nerve and is now truly seeing how dangerous can Catra truly be. He squirms pathetically, bowing one, twice, tripping on his own shoelaces as he tries to escape the sharpness of the glance he was trying so desperately to overcome mere minutes ago. He passes a hand over his neck, subconsciously rubbing it.

"So sorry- so sorry. My apologies to you, great Majesty. Yes. It won't happen again, I assure you"

“I’m sure it won’t Vice Counselor” Catra looks at him dead in the eyes, lowering her voice again. “Don’t you think you have someone else to apologize to?”

His eyes squint with confusion until Catra makes a small sign towards Scorpia, who has been following with her full attention the entire exchange. Next to her Glimmer has her hand pressed delicately over her mouth, her ears red from trying to not burst into laughter and she seems to regard Catra under a new proud light.

“Of course, Princess Scorpia-"

“Crown Princess”

“Crown Princess Scorpia. My deepest regrets, you Highnesses. It will not be repeated”

Scorpia, bless her heart, raises her hands in a peaceful motion and smiles.

“Thank you, Vice Counselor Pompoled. You may keep your head”. The man wheezes in contained terror and Catra has to hold a cackle when Scorpia looks at Catra with raised eyebrows and her mouth in a perfect “O” shape like she can’t believe she actually said that. She is enjoying this and Catra is too.

Catra looks back at the Vice Counselor who is trying to scatter back in between the rest of his court and she is now the one who scoffs. She sits down on the throne again, folding one leg over the other.

"Now, if you have a reasonable request I will be glad to listen. If not, Sir Azrael will show you the gate out".

❀

"Thank you. Thank you, thank you, thank you Wildcat! I'm so excited. I will not let you down, you'll see" is saying Scorpia in a loop, her arms thrown around Catra's middle as she lifts her from the ground some good five inches.

The only thing Catra can do right now is hold for dear life to her spiky shoulders and dangle her feet in the air as her lungs protest for air.

It's late evening after a couple of long hours answering to court requests and making official Scorpia's new title. Catra has also sent several letters around the kingdoms to let her decision be known and commanded her guards to do as Princess Scorpia asks them.

There is not much time to celebrate, though, Scorpia will be parting, by her own decision, back to Halfmoon for a few months to supervise the arrival of the refugees and getting the villages and the palace up and going at full force again. She said to Catra, however, that she will wait until the end of the week and ask Princess Perfuma if she wants to join her.

Catra agrees to this, still a bit nervous of letting Halfmoon's location be known by others but trusting Scorpia's natural instincts with people.

Scorpia finally let's Catra down on the floor, bubbling with uncontained happiness. Her mood crashes completely with Catra's feelings at the moment, yet it does feel like a breath of fresh air that distracts her from reality. Catra has made the count, by this hour Adora and the rest must already be on Thaymor yet there has been no communication at all. Glimmer, who is waiting for Catra a few meters behind, has a sour worried expression that reflects her thoughts.

“I already told you, Scorp. You grew in Halfmoon, you know it as well as I do. There is nobody better fit for the job than you. It’s a strategic step, don’t take it out of proportion”. Scorpia keeps beaming at her, looking at her with that knowing look that says that she knows Catra is full of bullshit. She ends up winking at Catra, giggling.

“Of course Wildcat of course”. Outside, the bells of the village start to sound and Scorpia jumps in surprise, realizing just how late it is. “Oh dear. I need to go write Perfuma right now. I mean, for the very important political matter of course. Thank you so much Wildcat!”

Catra sees her tripping on her rush to reach her chambers and she shakes her head in endearment. Glimmer walks towards her now, smoothing the fabric of her skirt with her hands.

“That was nice. What you did for her”, she says without looking at Catra.

“She is my friend” answers Catra, shrugging and looking at the point where the tall figure of Scorpia disappeared through. “And she deserves it”

Glimmer remains quiet, pensative.

“You have a better heart than I thought, " confesses Glimmer. Catra snaps her attention to her, taken aback to which Glimmer only pouts, crossing her arms. “If you let it get to your head I’ll erase your memory”

Catra huffs, looking back at the empty corridor that leads to the chambers and starting to walk “As if you could”

There is a better ambiance between them after that. Less tense and snarky but still charged with the imminent worry. Catra leads them both to the tower she shares with Adora, not even asking Glimmer. They just walk up the infinite stairs and into the already warmed room, closing the door behind them. Catra has asked the guards for them to not be bothered at least for the rest of the night, so when they arrive Glimmer flops into one of the table’s chairs, dropping her pink and purple head into her hands with a sight.

Catra doesn’t join her. She steps into the carpet of the floor and then all the way to the balcony, greeting Melog in her way who raises from the unmade bed with a “mrrp” and jumps into her open arms. Their mane is grey, so dark it almost looks black against the smooth of their skin. Glimmer doesn't know that Melog is emotionally attuned to Catra, but from her spot on the table she only needs to guess.

The air suddenly electrifies, flickering the flames of the fireplace in blue and green tone. In the middle of the chamber, between Catra and Glimmer, a purple bubble of magic forms itself

from nothing and just stands there floating for several seconds.

“ -tra. Catra?”

It is Adora’s voice. It sounds far away and interrupted by jumps of unstable magic, but it’s theirs.

Catra and Glimmer rush to the bubble, careful not touching it so it doesn’t dissolve. Melog jumps from Catra’s arms to the ground, circling the space where the bubble is floating and meowing insistently.

“Adora? Where the hell are you?”, almost hisses Catra, holding herself from Glimmer's dress. On the other side Adora chuckles.

“Don’t sound so happy to hear me”, he jokes. The signal is going and coming so it’s not easy to make sense of his words. “We are here- Evacuation- Begon already- No sign of the Horde yet but there is something I don’t like- Bow is coming- Bow!”

Catra and Glimmer share a look, hearts on their throats. In comes the accelerated voice of Bow, cutted off just as Adora’s.

“Glimmer- sweetheart- We are alright- Just wait- a little more- " the bubble shakes a little, making their voice go loose. Glimmer shoots her hand to the side and grabs Catra’s own with unholy strength.

"Catra? Glimmer? Are you there?" Returns Adora's voice.

"Yes. Adora, what is going on?" presses Catra, squeezing Glimmer's hand with equal strength. The bubble shines brighter and shivers. The message time is running out.

"Is going to be fine" assures Adora but Catra can hear through his tone. Adora is tense, like they were waiting for something to happen. Adora hesitates before speaking again. "Catra I need to tell you- if something- To happen- I-"

The bubble shines brighter and brighter and then pops, dissolving into iridescent sparkles and then into nothing. Catra tries to hold onto the last strands of Adora's voice before losing them away too.

Both queens stand there, unmoving and holding onto each other's hands for a while. Melog sits on the place the bubble was and meows sadly, looking between that space and the door as if they were waiting for Adora to come any time now. The sight makes Catra's heart clench painfully on her chest.

"They said they are alright" murmurs Glimmer, holding her breath. Catra blinks quickly, fighting back the stinging tears from falling away.

"Adora also said they have a bad feeling about it"

"But they said they are going to be alright" insists Glimmer and grimaces but she doesn't let go of her hand. She looks so anxious right now, nothing like the stuck up queen she thought

she was. This is the first time Catra can truly understand Glimmer and who she is. A ruler yes, but also a worried friend and spouse and companion. Someone that loves.

Catra presses her lips together in a firm line, biting the inside of her cheek so hard it almost draws blood.

"You know Sparkles? You and I are much more alike than you think"

Glimmer turns her head to her, glancing for the first time to Adora's winged pin resting in the fabric of Catra's vest. She looks up and onto her scrunched nose and sad mismatched eyes with a, not for the first time, spark of hope.

"Are we?"

"We are"

❀

Catra and Glimmer drag the blankets of the bed and nestle themselves in the love seat inside the studio.

It's warm in there and if Catra focuses just enough, she can catch the lingering smell of Adora's scent on every corner of the room.

There haven't been any messages or signals about Bow and Glimmer and Thaymor, so they throw their winter shoes to the side -Catra hates them anyway- and with the same clothes of the day climb to the couch and watch the logs of wood being consumed by fire one by one.

Catra is thankful, she didn't think she would be able to stay in the main chamber with the enchanted roof full of constellations Adora likes to silly name at night. She suspects Glimmer understood this without words because it was her who pulled them both and Melog inside and closed the door behind without questions.

Melog is now curled on Glimmer's lap, purring softly and sleepy. Yet Catra, with all the last two days exhaustion, can't find in herself the courage to fall asleep. Not right now. She just holds the tip of her toes with her fingers, tail circling herself in a makeshift embrace.

"What does that mean to you? What Adora said" Catra whispers at the second or four hour there. Glimmer frunces her eyebrows, confused, to which Catra adds. " *Take care of each other"*

Glimmer breaths in, more alert. She alternates her sight between Catra and the fire, not once stopping petting Melog. When Catra thinks she is not going to answer, and she is not going to insist, Glimmer does.

"It was a thing our mothers used to say to us when we were little. *Take care of each other* , every time we would run to the Woods or to the towers. Or when they were out in battle. We were too young to understand the real meaning behind it. That it wasn't just a motherly saying but more of a `` *If we don't make it, know that we love you and keep going, together"*

Glimmer takes a break, obviously shaken. Catra is now looking at her openly. "When Adora's mom died, when Mara died and my mother stepped out of the throne it was when we truly understood it. And when we realized we weren't children anymore"

Catra doesn't know what to do with that. Everyone has suffered for the war, everyone has lost someone. Adora talks about Mara in high hopes always, she has said to Adora what a wonderful person she was and how much they loved her. They have also talked about the grief of losing her, about the fear and the loss and the unbearable weight.

Catra wishes she had met this Adora, tiny and mischievous, and then younger and shy, and older and sadder. She wishes every day their paths had crossed earlier and that Catra would have been able to grow with them and to hold their hand in every moment of their life. And now the chance of doing that for their future staggers from the threads of the Fates.

"I wish I had met her. Mara", explains Catra doing the impossible to distract herself. Glimmer sighs and relaxes over the many cushions in the couch.

"I think you would have liked her. She was a great woman"

The flames creek waking Melog up from their slumber. The space has gone melancholic as if only can go when one reminisces about the past. Glimmer does look at the bridge of tears and Catra is suddenly very aware that if she starts crying Catra will follow soon enough and she can't allow that right now.

"So" Catra starts, voice a bit gone. "When did you realized you were in love with Bow?"

Glimmer blushes bright red and to Catra's surprise she bursts into laughter. Melog wakes up completely and gets up off her lap offended, kneading the place besides Catra and snuggling there.

"Seriously?" Wheezes Glimmer still half choking. "We are doing the whole slumber party talk?"

"Oh, go to hell Sparkles", groans Catra without a bite, pushing Glimmer's feet off the couch with her own. Glimmer wipes the laugh tears that have fallen down her cheeks and chin. She raises her hands in surrender.

"Alright, alright I'm sorry. I'll answer" she tucks herself under the blankets again and thinks for a bit while chewing her lip. "I think it was when I was eighteen. Adora had just named him Master Archer and he tripped on his way up to be given the title. I remember I laughed and he saw me and laughed too, there in front of everybody. And then I knew that I only wanted to be with him for the rest of my days. To nobody's surprise he already knew, he was just waiting for me"

Catra can help but smile to her memory, a fizzy feeling collecting on herself.

"Until eighteen? What took you so long?"

“Well” Glimmer confesses, embarrassed. Even her nose goes pink. Pink over pink. “I sort of had an infatuation with Adora before. It obviously never got to anything, they probably don’t even know about it, but it was long to shake off”

Catra doesn’t take offense to this but it does make her flush too, dragging her eyes back to the fireplace and muttering under her breath. “Yes well, who doesn’t. Is not hard to believe”

Catra feels Glimmer looking at her with that wondering gaze of hers. Her hair on the back of her neck raises with anxiety but Glimmer doesn't make a comment or a question.

"I bet your wedding was *the happiest day of your life* as some say" tries again Catra. Glimmer takes the bait for now and scoffs, shaking her head.

"Are you kidding? It was horrible. The flowers were a mess and the courts were sitting where they shouldn't and I was stressed and annoyed the entire day. No way it was my happiest day, I wish I had just run away with Bow but my parent insisted so much I couldn't say no"

"Wow, such raw honesty. You really are a whole wife now, aren't you?" Both marvels and mocks Catra to Glimmer. She bats a few sparkles in her direction.

"Watch it, kitty" Catra sticks her tongue out to her and Glimmer raises her middle finger in return. Only for both to dissolve in a fit of giggles right after.

"So when was your happiest day? And don’t give me that *Every day is an important day,* horseshit you know what I mean" Glimmer rolls her eyes at her words but answers anyway.

"To the date? It was when we were much younger, at one of the Harvest Festivals. He was going through his transition and his voice was still a little raspy” Glimmer’s voice becomes dreaming and nostalgic. “We ate caramel apples and he taught me how to do archery and I failed miserably. It was amazing”

Catra finds herself smiling fondly at her and the story. Glimmer notices it but Catra doesn’t retread, which wins her a matching smile from Brightmoon’s ruler. Catra starts petting Melog’s soft black fur. Under the light of the fire it looks almost purple.

"I wonder which was Adora's happiest day" she whispers absently. If Glimmer hears her she doesn’t let it know.

They spent another fifteen minutes in comfortable quietness. Outside it starts to snow very slowly and Catra suspects it may be her fault.

"So when did you realize you were in love with Adora?"

Catra snaps her neck back to Glimmer so fast she can actually hear her joints protesting for the whiplash. Her eyes are as wide as a frightened deer and she can actively feel her own pulse speeding up in alarming manners.

Glimmer leans on and places a hand on Catra’s forearm. There is a soft lilac light that shimmers from under her palm. At the same time Catra can feel her heart calming down and the shiver on her breath she hadn’t noted had started even. They stay like this until Catra is

completely settled again and then Glimmer takes back her hand, a wordless apology in her eyes.

"Don't worry. You don't have to tell me anything" she assures her. There is a hesitation in her face, like she is debating something with herself, but at the end she ends up with "I know is not my place to talk, but I think you should let them now"

"Why?", asks Catra in a low voice, taking her eyes back to the dancing flames.

"I think you know why" whispers Glimmer softly. Catra flinches at the familiarity of those words. She does know why. "Adora is an open book, after all"

Catra hugs herself tightly, letting her words shower over her, warm and frightening.

"Yes, they are"

❀

They do fall asleep at the end. Or more like they fall into a pitiful state between consciousness and unconsciousness for a few hours.

Catra wakes up with a hiss, confused.

Glimmer has snuggled to the side of the loveseat. Her eyes are scrunched tight, eyebrows knitted together. She is mumbling and from the tips of her finger are coming the smallest of the sparkles.

Melog is awake, passing back and forward on the carpet next to the fireplace. Their back is raised and their ears are folded back on their head, meowing low on their throat. They are obviously upset.

Catra is about to get up to them when she feels it too. Is low at the beginning and then grows like a crescendo, high high and high until it is basically unbearable.

The hairs of her nape and arms raise on point. Her tail and ears become wild, moving to all sides as if trying to catch the origin of the feeling. It builds and builds and then stops completely, submerging everything in a heavy quietude.

There is a white sound that breaks the silence and then the unmistakable sound of an explosion far away. The walls of Castle Grayskull shake, fine dust falling from the ceilings and coating its sleeping habitants in grey.

Glimmer awakes with a yelp just to find a wide eyed Catra already up and freezed in place. They look at each for a millisecond and then throw themselves to the locked door, bursting it open with their hands or magic they are not sure of. Catra charges against the window and opens it in a rush, walking out and into the balcony. There is a fine carpet of snow over the stones of the balcony and the bush of sleeping rose bulbs. The white fresh snow bites merciless on the exposed skin of her feet and cheeks.

Catra holds herself from the railing, following the direction of the sound until she spots it. She can see the column of black smoke against the dark ink sky.

It is in the direction of Thaymor, rising higher and higher as the seconds pass by.

Glimmer, who had followed Catra all the way there, gasps. She steps on her skirt and slides in the cold floor, not falling over just by the quick hand Catra shoots her without even paying full attention. Glimmer holds into her, gripping her arm so hard it should get painful yet Catra can't feel the way her nails dig into her skin.

"Catra" she breathes out, shaking.

"I know"

"What do we do?"

What can Catra tell her? She wants to throw herself from the tower and run all the way on foot there. She doesn't know what is going on, there hasn't been more communication. It could be bad. It could be good, though what part of a war is ever good.

This time is Catra the one who reaches for Glimmer's hand,

"I don't know Sparkles". Glimmer holds to her fingers too. "I don't know"

❀

Nobody sleeps a notch after that.

The wave of magic had been so strong that the entirety of Camelot had woken up from the blast. It had happened just a couple of hours before dawn so most people moved quietly around the houses, shelters and the palace itself. Yet nobody dared to go out and start their usual daily activities.

The rumor that the King had gone to a battle slipped from a tired maiden and spread across the village like fire on hay.

So Camelot was in silence, waiting.

At some point, Catra is vaguely aware that she changed her clothes into a long nightgown and Adora's red coat, the same they enchanted so it would always be warm during the winter. She remembers going through the motions stiffly, like one of Entrapta's inventions. She can't look at herself in the mirror.

Glimmer is still sticking by her side, both checking her and distracting herself of her own sickened worry. Her cheeks have spots of red on them and the rims of her eyes are colored in crimson.

The guards look at them as they walk through the castle. None dare to make questions or to ask about the daily obligations. Everybody knows to respect the waiting time, they have gone

through this enough times. So Glimmer leads Catra to the emptiest room in the palace and guards them there.

Perched as they are now on the windows' rests of the library, the only ones that look to the main yard, Catra thinks of her mothers. Of the pain on Empress Ziba after her wife went away, of the sadness as life wore her away. Catra shivers, fist pressing against her lips to keep a scream inside.

This is what it means, she realizes, loving so much while living in a world that can rip you apart. Catra doesn't know if she wants this for herself.

It's about five in the morning when it happens.

There is a horn that resounds across the entire village, announcing the entry of newcomers. Glimmer, who had been going around with a book, lets it fall to the ground unceremoniously. Catra doesn't give her enough time to question why they are going through the main gate and not the arcane circle, she just sprints to her feet and yanks her across the library and down the endless stairs. They are going so fast Glimmer loses her slippers halfway and she also forgets completely that she is, actually, very capable of teleporting wherever she wants inside of Camelot's limits.

When they arrive at the main gate of the palace it is already open. Several guards are posted there, both curious, worried and ready. There are also healers with hooded eyes walking outside, patiently waiting for the final arrival of the brigade. Light Hope is there too, dressed in her never changing clothes, with a stone expression that hardens when she sees Catra arriving.

The sea of people open to let Catra and Glimmer pass. They all look at them expectantly, and with reason, nobody really knew about the mission or the kings' departure. Catra can feel the wonder and the empathy in their eyes when they see her and it's not the first time that she wonders if her feelings haven't really spilled out of her heart and into Camelot's very stones already.

She waits at the top of the outside stairs with her breath held. There is a heavy mist surrounding the palace after the earlier snow so she doesn't really see them come. It's only when the hot breath of the horses becomes steam against the freezing cold that Catra can really start to distinguish their shapes.

They come out of the mist like espectres, sunless huge figures advancing in the slowest of the passes. One by one they break the mist and enter the space of the main yard.

It's just the army, Catra realizes, there are no villagers with them and she can't remember if that is a good or a bad thing. All the knights look exhausted, most with bandages and covered in mud from head to toe.

From the bottom of the brigade a horse advances before the others. Catra recognizes Bow immediately. He is wearing the hood of his cape to protect him from the frostbite though the edges of it are slightly burnt. He is covered in ashes and a few scratches are scattered on his face but he is alive.

By her side, Glimmer gasps and then she is pretty much flying down the stairs, the iridescent surface of her wings shining bright so different from the dull color and down look they had had the entire day. Catra walks down the stairs too, watching Glimmer yank Bow out of his horse and into her arms.

An nauseous feeling accumulates on her stomach and Catra scans the crowd with more urgency than before. She is vaguely aware of the rushed conversation between Glimmer and Bow a few meters away from her.

“Bow! What happened? What are you covered in ashes? ”. Bow huffs as Glimmer latches onto his neck almost dragging him to the floor. He pats the back of her short hair gently.

“The Horde attacked us almost the second we arrived. It was almost as if they were waiting for us to attack the village. We pushed them back long enough to enter the town and start taking the people to Brightmoon”

“Was Shadow Weaver there?” Asks Glimmer. A shiver goes down Catra's spine. She balls her hands into fists, feeling the sharp nails break skin.

“No. The attack was lead by Commander Hordak”

“Prime’s second in command?”

“Yes. He was very confident in himself and his plan. It seems he knew we would be looking and targeted Thaymor as bait to attract us. Our message got cut off when they advanced on us”

“But why didn’t you send a message after? I, we, were so worried”. Bow brushes Glimmer’s bangs out of her eyes. Around them, Camelot’s healers have started to approach the still coming knights. Adora is nowhere to be seen.

“I’m sorry. We managed to evacuated everyone on time but we didn’t know if the Horde was using magic and we didn’t want to risk for them to track our messages”

“Is that why you didn’t use the circle to come back either?” Bow scrunches his nose and shakes his head.

“No. One of the high priestesses got hurt. Using magic to come back would have been too much for her. She is alright, but we couldn’t jeopardize her health that way. We escaped once the las villager was send to Brightmoon”

“I saw the explosion, Bow. The entire kingdom did. What happened there?”. Bow widens his eyes and struggles with the bag held to his hip, finally fetching an arrow broken on pieces from it.

“My explosive arrows worked! Prince Entrapta helped me with them, just that they were a *little bit* more intense than expected”

“A little bit?” Repeats Glimmer, now exasperated. Bow scratches the back of his neck, embarrassed.

“They kind of obliterated Hordak and half of the Horde army to the sky”. Glimmer blinks a few times, processing the words as she takes the pieces and inspects them carefully. They still shiver with contained magic.

“Hordak is dead?” She asks, incredulous. Bow nods, his expression turning serious again.

“That’s when the Horde retreated completely and we got out of there” Bow surrounds Glimmer’s neck with his arms, bringing her into a hug. “But we are here now. Don’t worry”

“Where is Adora?”, interrupts Catra, unable to keep quiet much longer. Bow turns to her and seems to see her for the first time standing there with her bare feet and hair covered in snow.

“I’m sorry Catra”. Catra’s heart stops on its tracks and she feels her lungs compressing under the weight of her own breath. Bow exhales and continues. “I didn’t see you there. She is riding in the back. They insisted on guard from there”

That’s when the last knight finally enters the yard and Catra can see the figure of one last horse making his way towards them.

All air leaves Catra’s lungs in one blow. There is Adora, riding Swift Wind in a lazy march across the castle’s yard. His head is bent down, the red cape covering their blonde hair from the snowflakes falling from the sky. He holds the reins tightly, patting Swift Wind on the neck to sooth him. The gauntlets and leather gloves are gone, so their red scraped knuckles exposed to the cold.

They raise their head and seem to be looking around at the myriad of people in the yard until they lock eyes with her. Is only there Catra notices the tears running free and warm down her own cheeks.

Catra is running, *when did she start running?* Dodging horses and people, crossing the too many steps that separate them at full speed.

Adora has barely dismounted Swift Wind when Catra crashes against her, arms crossing around their neck, holding on to them with all the strength she has. She is drenched in mud and dirt and ash. There is a trace of blood on her nose and a wide halfway cured wound that crosses the bridge of the nose and the angle of her jaw. Their armor is scratched in a few places, as if sword blades would have hit against it, and she smells like metal and leather. Her hair now that is free of the heavy helmet, is a complete mess falling over her back in matted chunks and smeared by sweat over her forehead after the hair tie had given up by the pull at some point, darkened at the ends from dirt and dried blood.

She is wounded, she is exhausted, she is alive.

She is so beautiful.

The helmet clanks near their feet when Adora let’s go of it to lace her arms around Catra’s back, leaning so she does have to stand on her tippy toes all the time. Catra sobs in the crook of her neck, pressing herself to the wide expanse of her body as tight as she can so maybe

like this she will be able to fuse them together and never be parted again. Adora hushes her sweetly, rocking them both side by side while they wait patiently for her tears to subdue.

Huddled in that small safe space and after so many years Catra finally understands her mother. *“This is worthy”* she thinks, her lips and nose brushing the skin of Adora’s neck. *“It is worthy. All of it. Just for a second on this, anything else is worthy”*

People come and go around them, knights taken to rest or to be checked up by the healers. At some point Glimmer and Bow also slip away, giving them space and taking the job of giving the battle report to the Table.

Catra parts from Adora’s embrace reluctantly, wanting to look at their eyes because she needs to believe she is real and there. Adora holds Catra’s face between their cold hands, thumbs running soft circles across her wet cheeks in the gentlest of gestures. They are smiling sweet and endearing, relief clear in their handsome features.

Adora bends over, placing a watery kiss on the bridge of Catra’s nose.

"Hello, my love"

Catra makes a sound, a mix of laugh and sob that rips from her throat as she clings to their hands.

"Hey, Adora"

Adora lowers their hands to rub them up and down Catra’s arms in an attempt to warm her further, noticing just how few and definitely not winter appropriate they are. Their fingers brush the winged pin held there.

“Aren’t you cold?”, they ask, half concerned, half teasing.

“You need a bath”, answers back Catra, playing with the ends of their cape. The way they fall into their usual gentle banter makes Adora laugh.

Catra pushes their foreheads together bringing her hands, that are shaking now uncontrollably, at either side of Adora’s neck.

"Tell me" she whispers against their chapped lips.

"Hum?", wonders Adora, eyes falling shut as they breathe her in.

"What you were going to tell me through the message", explains Catra. She waits until Adora flutters her eyes open again to repeat it. "Tell me"

Adora’s expression melts. They look at her in a way Catra never thought she would be enough for. In the same way people fight, and enchant and curse and go to war for. In a way that is both innocent and respectful, that holds both relief and want, and desire and admiration. It's rain and fire. Life and destruction. Tears and sweat. Blood and spit. It's rotten wood in salt water and blooming bulbs among the moss. It’s the waves reaching at least for

her, dragging her in and in and inside and in its center, instead of cold sharp rocks, is Adora's heart.

"I love you"

❀

"Stop wriggling around"

“It burns”

“Of course it burns clotpole. You have an open wound. Now stay still”

Catra and Adora are guarded from the rest of the world inside their chamber. The gentle snow has progressed now to a full blown storm, obscuring the day into night. The air had erased any proof that a lighthearted tournament had taken place barely two day ago. The town is quiet, not a soul outside except for sorceresses and knights that look out for the barrier. They are protected from the outside cold by their own spells. Inside the castle the rest of the day progresses in calmness. There is an unspoken relief that hangs from the air.

After a good boiling hot bath, Adora had cleaned and dried themself from the dirt and the blood. Then Catra had almost forced him to eat, sitting right next to him and taking big gulps of the stew herself too. In all true, Catra doesn't remember eating at all since the festival and she is starving.

Adora had grimaced in silence the entire time, muscle pulling painfully with each moment. Which brings them to this exact moment, with Adora sitting on the furthest edge of the bed and Catra standing between their legs while dabbing a clean cloth soaked in ointment across their wounds. They have been here for the last twenty minutes while Catra roams Adora’s face and hands, tending gently to the sore broken skin.

Catra applies the medicine over the wound in Adora’s nose, sweeping gently until it is covered by the pearlescent substance. The skin shimmers for a few seconds and then stitches together, closing in a pale pink scar. Adora’s hand goes to nibble at the cured skin, eyes pulled with marvel.

“Wow. That some good ointment”

“It’s made with Halfmoon’s herbs. But it can’t erase the scars away” Catra slaps her hand away swiftly. “Stop touching it, it’s still working”

Catra checks the injury on Adora’s jaw with light motions and then pulls her hands away, chewing on her lips as she frowns.

“You are a healer Adora, why didn’t you use magic to cure yourself?”. Adora scrunches her freshly healed nose, looking at the ceiling.

“There were others that needed my help more” they admit in a breath. They are obviously very confident in the rightness of his decisions but it doesn't stop Catra from getting low key

angry again. She grabs Adora's chin between her fingers and bends it down so they are looking at her eyes again.

"You need to look out for yourself too". Adora tries to part their eyes from hers but Catra just tights her hold. "Adora, all that nobleness will be of nothing if you are dead"

Adora still looks incredulous, frowning so deep that the wrinkles that form may get itched into their skin.

"But everyone else would be alright"

"I wouldn't" insists Catra, moving her hand from holding to their jaw to stroke the baby hairs behind their ear. "What would I do with myself without you?"

Adora seems to not know what to answer to that. Their eyes battle in silence for a couple moments until Catra gives a step back, draggin one hand over her face and hair.

"Alright. Off" she says, pulling from the fabric of their shirt. Adora's eyes go comically wide, turning all shades of red until they look like a pomegranate, stuttering.

"Wh- What?"

Catra pulls from the garment more insistently, avoiding giving second thoughts what she is asking.

"You are covered in bruises. If you insist on not looking for yourself then I will"

"Shouldn't you at least ask me my favorite dessert first?", jokes Adora while starting to sweat. Catra just narrows her eyes at her.

"Strawberry tarts" Catra rests her hands on her hips, waiting expectantly. "Shirt. Off. Now"

"Alright, alright", mutters Adora, giving in.

Adora crosses her arms taking the shirt off in one swift motion and Catra has to catch the ointment vessel midair after accidentally dropping it.

Adora's narrow waist comes into view and then the bruised skin of their abs and ribs that makes Catra hold her breath. The fair blonde hair on her armpits is a little damp for the sweat and the bath, though their skin smells clean and fresh. All the strong muscles of her arms flex when she moves, this is the first Catra truly dimensions just how strong Adora really is. They are always so gentle and kind you would rarely consider that this person can actually crush you to the ground.

As the shirts go out Catra realizes she didn't really think this through and she almost runs away but luckily Adora is wearing linen wrappings over her chest, hiding the rest of it from sight. This way Catra can see bruises scattered around the collarbone, the upper arms and the dip of their navel.

She gulps loudly, so loudly Adora hears her and they lock sights. Catra is suddenly very aware that she is wearing a nightgown and only a nightgown. Adora seems to realize it too because they drop their shoulders forwards a little and avoids her sight at all costs. Catra breathes counting to ten on her mind and once she is sure her hands are not going to shake she gets near to the bruises, skin barely brushing skin.

“Wha- What” *fuck* “what happened?”

Adora subs their shoulder, taking a look at the sore skin on their torso.

“A very big man thought he could take me down with brute force”, Adora scoffs, rolling her eyes. “Easy to say I proved him wrong”

Catra frunces her lips together, considering the damage of the bruises.

“So I wasn’t the only one dealing with assholes, uh?”. Adora squints his eyes, confused. He takes one of Catra’s hands, the one that is not holding the ointment, squeezing her fingers softly.

“Are you alright?”.

The surprise is clear in Catra’s face. There is Adora, with their heart exposed and bathered in wounds and they still jump on worry at the mention of some pathetic man threatening Catra’s easy of mind. Catra sighs, smirking back at them.

“Of course I’m alright. Come on, who do you think I am?” Adora smiles right back.

Catra pushes her bare hand right on the center of Adora’s collarbones and focuses. Adora’s mouth falls open when a lukewarm energy travels from Catra’s hand to Adora and travels in golden ribbons across their entire body. The bruises turn redder and then greenish and yellow until they finally disappear completely, leaving behind only the ghost feeling of tender ribs and sore skin.

“That was healing magic”, says Adora, amazed. Catra flushes under their wondered eyes.

“I know it's kind of your thing but I’ve been practicing a little. Guess it came in hand after all”. Catra retreats her hand and inspects the now gone bruises, nodding satisfied with the results. “There. You are much better know”

“Yeah” agrees Adora, catching her hand before it can drive away completely. They bring it right back over their heart, mirroring their own motion from before. "I really think I'm a better person because of you"

Catra’s first visceral instinct is to slap her. Or slap herself. One of the two. Or both.

She can feel Adora’s steady heartbeat under her palm. They are not even nervous anymore, once the words left their lips it was as if an invisible weight had been raised from their shoulders completely, freeing their lungs and limbs and mind. Catra, on the other hand, is still a complete mess inside. Not because she is turning away from this, but because she still can’t believe it’s actually happening.

"How long?" she asks, holding to Adora's shoulder, careful of not prickling Adora with her nails. Adora leans and searches for her waist, bringing her closer with gentle hands so she is almost entirely pressed to their own body.

From this position Adora has to look up to meet her eyes. Catra brushes their bangs back, running her finger over their slightly crooked nose and the expanse of their dark eyebrows. Adora's steel blue eyes are full of that honesty that characterizes them.

"Catra, I think my soul has loved you my entire life. I just needed one second of that first day to know it. I'm sorry it took me so long to tell you. I didn't want you to think you needed to correspond me without having a choice and voice in the matter".

Adora's precious eyes are actually swimming in tears now and Catra feels her own respond equally. When Adora sees this their hand raises up to cup her reddened cheek.

"Catra, if the gods asked I would give my soul for you. I would let you take my own sword and push it inside my chest. I would rip myself apart and merge into you if that meant you would be happy and safe"

"Fuck" manages to push out Catra before letting the treacherous teardrops leave the edges of her eyes. Adora's thumbs catch each one, smearing them over her cheekbones. They giggle at Catra's curse but don't pressure her into saying something else. In fact, Adora waits patiently with his nose pressed on her chest until the small drops relent and Catra can think a tad more clearly again.

"I had words. Before" she starts. She tries, she really tries, but her voice breaks in the middle. Catra doesn't even know if she can do this, if she has enough courage to do it. But Adora has already proved to her one and a thousand times that they are not going anywhere no matter her answer. She breathes in the familiar smells of their chamber. " I think I've lost them. I don't know when or where but I could never find them again, not even for myself. I want them, so much Adora, I want to give them to you. I want you to hear them from me. But I don't know if I have enough strength to say them"

Catra may have stopped crying but the vulnerability was still there, fears and wants spilling out of her, finally free from their golden cage and onto the winter air and Adora's pale palms. Adora who is looking at her with so much love written on their factions that overwhelms her.

"I don't need them", they whisper, even daring to gift her the smallest of smiles. Catra whimpers, shaking her head.

"But you deserve them"

"I don't want anything that may hurt you, Catra"

"It doesn't hurt me, Adora. It scares me. Because is *so much"* Catra looks at her with pleading eyes and she can see the spark in them, the understanding, the slow joy. It encourages her. "I never realize how devastating would be to lose you until I almost did"

“You are not going to lose me, Catra. Nothing bad is going to happen as long as we have each other” Adora’s fingertips dig into her waist as she pulls her closer. “No matter what happens now or in the future, I will always be yours and you will always be my best friend. And you will never be alone again”

Catra buries her face on their unbrushed hair as if it would somehow hide her away. Adora hums content, occupying himself on detangling the knots on her wild hair.

“You must know. Surely you must know”, murmurs Catra against the skin of their head. Adora stops moving at show he is paying attention. “That what you feel I feel too, even if I can’t *fucking* say it. You are my entire life”

Adora gives a shaky breath. Even with all that open love and confidence, Catra knows there is a small part of him that finds relief in her words. That’s all that matters, because Catra can’t live a single more second without Adora knowing how loved they are.

“I know. I promise, I know” Catra leans back just enough to see their face. “Catra, love is not measured only in words. Because if that would be the case I don't think there will ever be word or poem or song or sonnet big and greater enough to truly describe the way on which I love you"

That’s when Catra kisses her.

It’s their third kiss but it feels like the first all over again. Just better, more private. It’s just them inside this little space in the world.

They also do it much better. Before it had too many teeth and the fags clipped accidentally against the skin or the noses bumped against the other. This is much softer, confident. From this position Catra’s nose settles on Adora’s cheekbone, and Adora lips catches Catra’s upper lip between theirs.

There is a cheesy saying in Etheria that implies that kissing the person you love feels like magic. Catra has always scoffed at it, crossing it out as cheap poetry for bards’ melodies. Today however she can understand what they truly mean with this. She can feel the drizzling emotions on the bottom of her toes and stomach and her head feels light even though her hair is standing on point everywhere in her body. It is also an appropriate saying, given that when Catra and Adora part to breathe Catra can see bind weeds and tiny flowers that travel from their position all the way to the headboard of the bed and over the wall.

Catra is about to comment on it when Adora brings her in one more time. And honestly who is Catra to desist this?

^^^^^

At some point the kiss grows in intensity.

Catra opens her mouth to regain her breath and Adorar uses this split of a second to hesitantly shot their tongue out and slip it inside. The way the damp surface presses dangerously against the tip of her fangs is exhilarating.

It's a bit awkward because neither have ever done something like this before and for so they are just going through the motions.

Catra tries something she must have read somewhere some time. She slides her own slightly rough tongue over Adora's and then presses up, licking the roof of their mouth at the same time she presses down with her fingers over the dips of their collarbones. Adora actually whimpers at this, the breathy sound escaping their throat and going inside Catra's, making her smirk inside the kiss in unspoken victory.

Adora grunts, a low rumble that vibrates below Catra's hands. They shot forward suddenly, getting a hold of Catra's thighs and pulling her in until she is sitting on their lap completely, knees straddling either side of their waist, arms locked around their neck and tangled on blonde hair. Catra arches her back, letting all her weight fall back, sure that Adora's arms are there wrapped around her own torso and keeping her from falling down while they keep kissing.

Catra slides over Adora's legs, inadvertently rubbing against the hard of their exposed abdomen. Catra inhales sharply, a sound that is between a gasp and a moan that burns inside and makes her skin flush crimson all the way from her cheeks to her shoulders.

Adora hears it too and she leans away a little to look at her face with concerned eyes. Catra makes a small sound of protest, following the motion. When she can't find their lips again she starts peppering a path of fluttering kisses across their nose, cheek and ear. Adora sighs at this, starting to drift back into the warm comfort of Catra's embrace before forcing themself to snap back into reality for just a second more.

"Catra", they call. Catra's tail is flickering in the air behind her excitedly and her chest is vibrating softly, when Adora rests their hand over it they realize that she is actually purring. "Catra, wait"

"Mmh?", mrps Catra. She retreats slowly, blinking her eyes slowly open to look back at Adora's unsure face. And, goodness, she is so beautiful Adora almost falls right back into the inviting warm of her half open mouth. But they need to know, they need to ask first.

"Are you sure?". Catra dips her head to the side, slightly confused. Her breath is ragged by the excitement and it takes her a few seconds to grasp the meaning behind their words. Adora keeps going. "Whatever you want to give me I'll cherish it forever. It doesn't matter what it is. If it happens today, tomorrow, in months or never at all. Even if it is just one time, or a thousand or none and for as long as you want it. I need you to know that, that the choice is yours and I will do and give you anything you ask me"

Catra holds Adora's chin in her hand, locking their eyes together. Her eyes are soft and wet with gratitude on the edges yet her gaze is sure and confident.

"I want to give you everything for the rest of my life, Adora. There is nobody else I would do this with. Please allow me to give this to you". Catra answers. Adora's face breaks into that smile that lights up her eyes until they almost look vibrant blue. Catra smiles back but her brows furrow lightly, searching on their face for any trace of doubt or discomfort. "Are *you* sure? Do you want this?"

“Me? ” Catra thinks, though she doesn't say it. By the look inside Adora's eyes, they must already have followed that track of thoughts.

"I am. I do" affirms Adora immediately and this time their voice doesn't quiver. The pure joy that reflects their face calms the rising fears inside Catra's chest. Adora must realize that Catra is going through a small inner turmoil too because they reach for her hand and interlock their fingers together, raising their joined hand to kiss lovingly her knuckles. Their palms are a bit clammy with sweat and nervousness which Catra finds endearing to the core. "You are everything I've ever wanted, Catra. I just ever thought I could have you"

Catra smiles in relief, confidence starting to build up again inside of her. She leans in again, peppering gentle kisses all over their nose, their wide forehead she is always making fun of, the sides of their head, down to their soft cheeks and jack and all the way down their long neck. She settles there, nibbling the fragile skin with her lips and teeth, basking in the small encouraging sounds that leave Adora’s mouth with each tug.

Adora's hand lowers, brushing the crumpled hem of fabric of Catra's nightgown and traveling under it. Their hand caresses over the naked skin of her thighs and all the way to her hips, calloused fingertips barely brushing near her warm center. Catra stops breathing next to their neck, waiting. With their hands resting in the dip of her navel, Adora can feel the cadent rise and fall of her belly and her skin getting goosebumps.

Catra nuzzles the space where their neck meets their shoulder, pressing her palm to Adora’s shoulder blades. This way she can feel all the small and wide creases and dips of old scar that are scattered across her lover’s back.

“Lovers”, whispers Catra against their skin, smiling. Adora shifts a little, kissing the top of her head.

“Hmm?” Catra shakes her head without dropping the smile.

“Later” she tugs from the ends of Adora’s head “Keep going”

“So bossy”, teases Adora but complies anyway.

One of their hands moves up to her side while the other travels down the creases of her spine, stopping right at the base of her frizzled tail. Catra can sense another moan starting to build when Adora’s thumb rubs right on her ribs, tickling her. Instead of a moan, the thing that comes out is a loud and unceremoniously embarrassing snort.

Catra’s leans away, her hand flying to her mouth as her eyes go wide with surprise. Seriously, this is the first intimate moment she has with Adora after so much and that has to come out, Catra is mortified. Adora is looking at her with the same wide eyes, freezed midway on their caresses.

Catra is unsure if to apologize, or climb out of their lap or bury her head behind the bed. But then Adora starts pouting for some reason. Catra is incredibly confused until she realizes that Adora is not really pouting but holding back their laugh.

They hold each other’s glance up to the point where they can’t hold it back anymore and both dissolve into a fit of laughs, so hard and intense by the time they subside their flanks hurt.

"We are ridiculous", Catra mourns between giggles, covering her face with both of her hands.

"Nah, I'm ridiculous. You are beautiful" replies Adora, looking at her with round eyes full of wonder. Their pupils are so dilated their eyes almost look entirely black.

Adora reaches for the wraps around their torso and takes them off in quick movements, immediately holding to her waist once they are done. Catra loses herself to the sight of Adora open and exposed in front of her. Of the trust put into her hands right at this moment.

"You're the greatest thing in my life, Adora"

Catra kisses them again, deep and slow and wet, stealing the last of the laugh from their lips. Adora continues the path they were following. Luckily Catra’s nightgown is loose enough that Adora just needs to tug a little from the laces for it to fall open behind her shoulders and back. Adora hesitates for a second and then fully moves their hand up, cupping one of her breasts on their palm. Their thumb presses softly against her brown nipple and stays there unmoving.

After a few seconds of waiting, Catra opens her eyes and takes a look at Adora. They are looking at her breasts with a little bit of too much focus. There is even a drop of sweat that runs across their eyebrow from how hard they are thinking right now. Catra bumps their head, calling for their attention.

"Hey. Come on. Don't get all shy on me now. It's just my breast not a battlefield"

Adora blinks at her and they relax a little. Their fingers on the other hand caress her ribs from under the pearl folds of her gown.

"I just don't know what I'm doing", they explain, shrugging, all pink face and neck.

"Neither do I" admits Catra, wriggling a little on her position. "Just- I don’t know- Just roll with it"

Adora’s eyes turn abruptly mischievous and a low cat smirk stretches on their face. Catra blinks without understanding but before she can ask anything else, Adora moves, tightens their hold on her waist and rolls them over. Catra’s neck and back crash softly against the plush bed with a huff.

She is barely recovering her breath by the time Adora is already settling between her spread legs. Adora rests their weight over their forearms, hovering over her face. Their hair is soft and a bit puffed, framing their face in a golden halo that falls in long strands around Catra's, guarding her inside the peaceful safety of their shared breaths.

"Like this?". They tease her, rubbing their nose against Catra's to make her laugh.

Catra giggles, cupping their strong jaw on her hand. She takes one of Adora's hands and brings it to her lips, and unspoken confession on them.

"Kiss me again" she whispers.

Adora does, soft lips against hers. Catra slowly guides their hand through her body. Down past her breasts and sternum.

"Again"

Down. Around her navel and the curly dark hair.

"Again"

Down. To that liquid warm space only she knows and that now is Adora's.

"Again"

^^^^^

End of chapter IV

Amazing art by Jacks and Walli/Serena :”3

Chapter End Notes

:”3

This chapter is dedicated to the many love languages that exist.
Verbal language is only 7% of our entire language and many people show their love in different ways. In this story Catra and Adora have had different stories while growing up which makes them emotionally wiser. While Adora shows their love primarily through words of affirmation, Catra shows hers with Physical touch, and both share showing love through acts of service. None of this makes one love the other more or one being more than the other. They love each other equally and, don’t worry, they are both now on the same page (finally). Catra still has to work through the fear of feeling vulnerable with her love, but Adora knows Catra loves them and Catra knows they love her :)

“The love that binds us” is a direct quote from the show Merlin (2008), which is a main inspiration for this story.

This chapter was Long and deeply personal to me and a bit draining too so I need to rest my head for a bit. Next chapter will probably be ready in about two weeks but good news! Next is your “beach episode” chapter. It’s going to be so refreshing so keep an eye out for that!

Check out my amazing friends' fanart and please give them all the love. I love you both so much!

As always thank you so much for your support! Comments, kudos, bookmarks and shares are deeply appreciated! Be good!

Chapter 5: Rosemary

Chapter Summary

"There is a story my mom used to tell me" murmurs Adora, lowering their voice like she was telling a secret. Catra snuggles even closer, taking in each of their words with longing. "She said that important people in our lives sometimes carve so deep in our lives they mingle with our very souls. People that meant something for us, people we loved. And that those people are so bright that they become a part of our lives again and again and again. No matter how many years pass or how different our worlds look, we are always entangled together"

Catra smiles, gently. "Do you think that's us? That we've been in each other's lives again and again?"

Adora looks at the freckles on her cheeks and flushes pink. "I think we have. I think we do"

Chapter Notes

Welcome back! It's been so long but hiatus has been good for me, I really needed it so thank you so much for your patience as always and *drums* welcome to your "beach" episode! Where there is no beach but anything bad happens either. This chapter is pure teeth rooting fluff so I hope you enjoy it

As always, there are scenes with implied sexual content on it and they are all highlighted with ***** at the beginning and end, so if you don't feel like reading that content you can skip without issue. Be safe! See you at the end!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CHAPTER 5. Rosemary

SPRING

I love you. I love you. I love you. I'll write it in waves. In skies. In my heart. You'll never see, but you will know. I'll be all the poets, I'll kill them all and take each one's place in turn, and every time love's written in all the strands it will be to you.

-Amal El-Mohtar, *This Is How You Lose the Time War*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x

❀

Adora Pendragon has had a happy life.

She had a loving wonderful mother that raised her with love and patience and strength. Grew up being surrounded by people who supported her, understood her and encouraged to be better.

Even in the admists of war, Adora was able to find joy and comfort in every one of the things that surrounded them. Friends and family. Brave and loyal people that made things good and worthy.

She has had a good life.

But Adora Pendragon is sure that there hasn't been a single happier moment in her life than waking up at the edge of dawn and to find herself surrounded by the warm softness of her wife sleeping next to her. In caressing with the tip of her fingers the bridge of her nose until her lovely mismatched eyes flutter open, sleepy and soft and happy.

Of running her fingers over the creases of her spine all the way down to her hips where the linen sheets crumple around. Of the feeling of her bare breasts pressing against the skin of their ribs because of how tight Catra holds them in her sleep. With one leg thrown over their hips and her head nestled on their neck and yes, she drools a little bit, but Adora loves her so much is a welcome blessing.

Sometimes they shift around and it's Adora the one who ends up snuggled into Catra's chest. Especially on days where things are just too much and their head can't support the weight of it all, Catra is there to hold them in the security of her embrace.

But today is not a bad day. Today is not even a half good day. Today is a good day. Wonderful, excellent actually.

*****

Adora has never been as happy now with their hand working relentlessly and their head buried between Catra's spread thighs, in the place between the mount of curly soft hair and that damp space that Adora treasures so close to their chest. With her lover's legs resting securely over their shoulders, restless hips held in place by just one of their arms, and her back arching out of the bed sheets as she sings in soft moans and whimpers high pitched and joyful before flopping back with a relieved sigh.

Adora parts from her gently, slipping their fingers out slowly and soft, giving Catra time to get used to the sensation. They offer one last swip with their tongue before letting go completely from the small nub with a soft pop, taking in the lovely relaxed expression on her face. Adora lifts their head, cleaning the clear wetness that drips from their chin swiftly, just to place sweet kisses over the shivering skin of her lover's thighs.

Catra is barely recovering her breath when Adora moves up, letting their weight rest partially over her. She is still trembling over the bed with aftershocks, small puffs of steam barely visible in the dim yellow light of the morning. This way Adora can feel the rapid rise and fall of her chest against their own, quick and fluttering like a hummingbird, and can nuzzle the side of her face with their cheek to reassure her while she gets slowly back to her senses.

Catra tangles her elegant fingers on the blond strands with known habit, eyes shut as she breathes in Adora's musky scene, a mixture between night sweat and the clean smell of their hair. It grounds her enough to open her eyes just a split, taking in the warmth of the chamber and the pinks and oranges with which the sun showers them both. She holds herself with steady fingers to the expanse of their damp slightly scratched back, fingertips brushing old scars as she sighs.

"You are too good at this" Adora laughs against the side of her head, where she places one more kiss before traveling over the entire length of her ear.

“Well, practice makes the knight”, they whisper. Catra takes the bait immediately and groans, rolling her eyes even if Adora can’t see her. She starts prickling at the skin of their sides and underarms, wriggling under Adora.

“Ugh. Get off, you absolute big headed moron”. It 's useless. Catra is very strong on her own and she has sharp nails but she is also sleepy and loose and barely has energy left to banter. And Adora is just too tall and big and comfortable right now.

“But I thought you liked my hea-“, Catra slams her sweaty hand over her mouth, lips pressed in a serious pout but eyes full of mirth nonetheless.

“Don’t you dare finish that sentence, Adora”.

Adora smirks under her palm. Catra can pretend as much annoyance as she wants but she just can’t deny how weak she becomes every time the corners of Adora’s eyes wrinkle in just *that way* that lets her know how happy she is feeling right now. It warms her from the bottom of her belly all the way up her ribcage, lungs and heart. And when Adora starts pressing tiny kisses all over her palm with their mouth, Catra dissolves her serious stare into a full blown smile, so wide it hurts her cheeks. She has been smiling so much in the last few months she is sure now there is a spark of a smile permanently attached to her face.

Catra windraws her hand, tugging from Adora’s arms until they move as she wants them to, ending on Catra now straddling their waist and Adora’s back resting in the heated spot she has left behind. Both of their breathings have even out now but the blushes remain boiling red in both their noses and cheeks.

Catra takes in the look of Adora displayed below her, with their arms up over the pillows as their eyes look at her with familiar fondness. Catra brushes the strands of hair that have fallen over his face following its length all the way to the tips. Is longer now, obscured to a honey color by new days of spring sun. She lets the pads of her fingers follow the path that she now knows from memory. Over the smoothness of the forehead and the low arch of the dark eyebrows, down the fragile skin of the eyelids that looks almost lilac under this light. Pass the crooked nose with the creased scar that healed months ago and into the soft peach lips that

don't stop smiling even once. Adora presses a quick kiss in her fingers before she moves forward.

Catra travels above the sun freckles that live below their blue eyes and cheekbones and all the way the sharp strong angles of their jaw and chin. Her hands and eyes fly over their long neck and collarbones, taking in the reddish love marks her own teeth and lips left there the night before. And when Catra arrives at the round shiver of their breasts Adora holds her breath, heat unavoidable pooling low on their belly. Catra catches the shift of her expression and smirks, satisfied, but there is a beautiful shine in her eyes as she keeps going without a word.

Her hands pass over the ribcage and down the sternum, tracing lovingly every scar and every bruise, every mark and burnt and scratch that scatter her body. A testimony over her lover's body of who they are and why they are fighting for. Of peace in a world of war. And with every touch and caress Catra has given she also has bent and placed a kiss over their warm skin, the unspoken confession loud in Adora's heart strings.

I love you

I love you

I love you

Adora’s sighs in content, running their fingers in the hair that nestles behind Catra’s ears and that never quite settles after brushing it. They marvel at the way the sun makes Catra’s skin look almost golden. In the stripes of slightly darker skin that run on her upper arms and waist and in the light stretch marks over her thighs that Adora likes to run her mouth over again and again until Catra is either giggling or whining.

Catra finishes her wander over Adora’s body when she arrives at their stomach, letting her hands rest just below their navel for a few seconds. She leans over and kisses the center of her chest before letting herself fall completely, half on the bed half over Adora, nestling herself in the crook of her neck. Adora immediately wraps her arms around her, nuzzling in the many soft pillows that Catra had insisted to have over the bed and that was actually a pretty fantastic idea.

*****

“Good morning”, she whispers, as if they hadn’t been up for a while now, running the pads of her fingers over Catra’s spine and arm.

“Good morning”, answers back Catra, voice a bit slurred by the sudden sleepiness the comfort has brought her.

It’s a sunday and the kingdom is barely awake. The spring sun has finally started to warm so the windows are open letting the sounds of the town roll in with its gentle noises. There is indistinguishable chattering coming from below the tower for the few people that walk in and out of the castle. The smell of fresh baked bread fills the chamber pleasantly, making Adora’s stomach grumble. Catra laughs at this, stroking their abdomen in slow circles.

“Hungry?”. Adora hums, stretching under her but not losing their position with Catra held in their arms.

“Yes but I’m not ready to get up yet”. Catra turns her head a little to look at her and sees them scrunching their nose, eyes shut closed as a tiny pout starts to appear in their lips. “I really, really don’t want to have meetings today. Or court duties or knight practice. I just want to stay right here with you forever”

Catra laughs under her breath, placing new kisses below their ear, nipping gently to the skin there. “Well, you don’t have to”

Adora stays quiet processing the words in their head. Catra waits patiently for her watching her eyes unfocus as she tries to understand Catra’s words, just to frown deeply when they come with nothing.

“What?”

Catra chuckles, rising from her position to settle with her elbows at either side of Adora’s head so she is now hovering a few centimeters above their lovely face.

"You don't have to do any of it today. No meetings, no Court, no knights. Anything at all", she whispers, bumping their noses together. Adora still has that pretty confused look on their eyes that makes Catra smug with mischievousness.

"But" starts Adora, chewing her lip as she thinks."It's not my birthday"

"It is not", affirms Catra, smiling. Adora widens her eyes, a new thought flashing on her mind.

"Am I dead?"

"No, dumbass", she huffs, rolling her eyes. Adora is brilliant, she is so smart and cunning but she also can be the biggest goofball Catra has ever encountered.

Adora smiles again caressing the sides of Catra's ribs in sweet motions. "I'm sorry, my love. I don't understand".

Catra feels herself turning pink. Her tail flickers up to brush over Adora's nose and then lowers to wrap itself around their knee. Every time Adora calls her something along the lines of *my love, beloved,* it makes her heart give a flip inside her chest with the immensity of overwhelming love that pours out of it. Nobody has ever treated her with such gentleness and love before, not even her friends and family, Catra is still getting used to accepting that she actually deserves all of it. She actually has to take a deep breath and shake her head to be able to focus again.

"I asked Light Hope and Sir Juliet to take care of Camelot's matters for today. Unless is an emergency we should have the entire day just for ourselves"

Adora's eyes open almost comically again, taken for complete surprise. Catra wiggles her hips next to them, waiting with raised eyebrows for their response. It takes him a while, his

mouth opening and closing as they think. Finally a slow impressed smile spreads on his face, one of his hands going to Catra's hair to tangle their fingers on the loose curls that hang from her exposed shoulders.

"You *asked* Light Hope?", asks Adora, lifting their eyebrow. Catra growls playfully at them, her ears twitching with amusement.

"Fine. I let her know"

"And how did she take it?"

Adora remembers Light Hope upright norms on doing everything along the line, no shortcuts, no breaks for diversion and of course no free days to rest. She had taught Adora from very little that being a prince and later a king carried an undodgeable responsibility, from the moment of his birth to his very death. No matter Mara's pleas of taking things lighter, Light Hope was always very strict, especially things she is completely sure to be right about, and she doesn't take in grace to be corrected or to be told *No.* The mere thought of Catra marching up to her and telling that " *No, we are not working this day"* is absolutely hilarious to Adora. Twelve years old Adora would have been terrified, twenty seven years old Adora is amused and proud.

"She looked about to implode. I'm afraid your advisor truly doesn't like me", says Catra. Her expression is satisfied but in her tone there is a small hint of awkwardness about the last sentence. Adora knows Catra, she can pretend all she wants but she actually does care. Adora lets one of his hands fall on the top of her tail, scratching lightly the fur there. Catra relaxes immediately, her ears dropping to the sides of her head.

"Is not that she doesn't like you, my love. She is just really-"

"Cold?" offers Catra when Adora struggles with his words. Adora breaths in relief, nodding.

"She was more flexible before, when my mom lived"

Adora's eyes grow sad like they always do whenever Mara comes into the conversation. Catra watches them in solemn silence and then leans towards them, kissing them open mouthed and slow. Catra catches the sweetness from their throat with her tongue, letting herself be held amongst Adora's wide arms. They turn apart soon after, once the sadness has tampered a little inside Adora's heart and both their lips are red and plush from the kisses. Catra presses her forehead to theirs letting Adora feel the length of her body draped over them with their hands, a grounding motion they both do when things get just a little bit too much.

"I'm here", whispers Catra against their lips. Adora sighs in response, grin returning.

"I know"

They stay like this until the sun is higher in the sky, brightening the chamber in golden light. Adora giggles suddenly, awakening Catra from the slumber she had fallen into.

“I can’t believe you actually got us a day for ourselves. I think my last free day was when I was like eight and I can’t even remember that part of my life”. Catra chuckles in return, making herself comfortable over them.

“Yes, I am pretty amazing”. However, she does open her eyes reluctantly, petting the baby hairs that grow just over Adora’s undercut. She takes in the lilac bags below their beautiful eyes and frowns, concerned. “You need a break Adora, we both do. We can’t keep running kingdoms and fighting wars while being exhausted. I don’t want to keep seeing you collapse in bed bone tired and without having even a second for yourself in the entire day. So we are taking at least today, just twenty four hours to clean our heads. Is that alright?”

The look that Adora gives her is full of fondness. Her eyes soften as they shine with grateful unshed tears, the smallest of the wrinkles appearing in the edges from years of smiles, now all for Catra and only for her.

“I love you so much, Catra”

Catra smiles around a watery laugh, peppering joyful kisses all over their face and ears making Adora burst in a fit of her own laughter. She covers them entirely in her kisses, sometimes quick and goofy, other times slow and purposeful. Catra shifts and climbs down her love’s body, taking her time to make them sigh in content. Adora loses themself in the sensations until Catra slips completely from their grasp, making them open her eyes and raise her head in time to look at Catra kneeling closer to the feet of the bed, pushing away the crumpled sheets there.

“Hey, don’t go. Isn’t staying in bed until late part of the resting deal?”, murmurs Adora, extending their hands to coax her back. Catra takes their hand, placing an encouraging kiss over their knuckles before making herself comfortable between their extended legs. She rests her head over Adora’s thigh, her wild mane of hair tickling over their calves.

“It is. I’m not going anywhere” she assures them. There Adora’s scent is deep, heavy, and she dares to look at them directly in the eyes as they lick their lips in anticipation. “I’m just not done with you yet”

❀

Camelot loves Catra.

It’s not unknown or strange whomever you would ask to would agree. Camelot loves Catra, Adora is aware of this, she is able to see it every single day that passes next to her. Is not just their people, who are always loyal and kind, it’s the land itself, the water, the crops, the animals, the sky, the very stones. Camelot bends itself down to Catra’s sweet feet and Adora thinks it couldn’t be more fitting because Camelot is her home and Catra is her entire heart.

It’s a beautiful day, one of the most beautiful days of the entire season. The flowers are in full bloom and there are birds singing in the balconies. It’s like a scene that came to life from one of the fantasy tales of the bards. People are walking in content around the town, enjoying one of the few quiet days that are so very scarce these times. There are no talks of war or loss or

fear today, just families and friends and couples taking the morning sun. It feels so much like what Adora tries to achieve for their people. Peace.

Catra walks next to her, her usual attire put aside in order to wear a white flowy dress so bright against her skin that it almost looks as iridescent as a pearl. It matches Adora's own white shirt and contrasts with their black pants. They wear no crown or jewel or gold today, except for the little wing that Catra refuses to live without. Like this, they almost look like just another couple passing by.

Of course people recognize them basically immediately. The golden hair and mismatched eyes are not easy to miss. Yet there are no exaggerated bows or caravans. Just respectful nods, some surprised looks and the occasional little squeal of children that recognize them. Adora is thankful for that.

Catra is talking with her with fervent excitement, telling the story of when she, Scorpia and Entrapta played a kind of explosive joke to the Halfmoon guards when they were younger. She is laughing, that squeaky high pitched laugh that makes his stomach twirl in joy. Adora likes seeing her like this, relaxed and happy without lines of worry marking her precious face.

There is a sprint on her step and her tail lashes behind her while she holds herself in Adora’s arm and hand. It’s been a few months already and Catra is slowly allowing herself to be more open and affectionate with Adora in front of others. Adora had never tried to start anything outside of the privacy of their chamber, respecting Catra’s times for as long as it needed. And there certainly were both knowing and incredulous glances thrown at them the first time Catra had turned and kissed Adora in front of the Court and the castle staff. She was red in the face and almost ready to run out of the window but she held her hand and kept her head up and proud. Now it warms Adora’s heart to see her grow and heal, confident of them together. She is so proud of her.

If someone would have told Adora a year ago that this is what her life was going to look like, hand in dear hand with the greatest person in the world, happy and sure and in love, Adora would have probably laughed and rolled their eyes in incredulity. Adora in all their life has had only one wish and that was to truly fall in love and to be able to stay with that person for the rest of their life. Just one wish, one selfish desire engraved in the walls of their heart. And then there was duty and then hope and then despair and now they are here and Adora has everything she has ever wanted.

There is a tug from their hand and when Adora lifts their head he realizes they have stopped walking. Catra is looking at him with a fond expression in her eyes, waiting for Adora to come back from the path he had drifted into. Adora flushes, a little embarrassed. Is not an uncommon thing for Adora’s mind to swirl in places and it always bothered him, not being able to focus on one thing without extra effort. But where others would scoff away or get offended, Catra was patient and understanding, never once making them feel like they were less or wrong for it. Adora feels their own expression melt away and is with a shake and Catra’s new found sweet smile that they realize they were drifting again.

“You are looking at me like that again. With that face” whispers Catra, brushing Adora’s bangs out of their face. Adora gently grabs her hand and keeps it pressed against their face,

stroking slow circles over the back.

“What face?” They ask, lost in the way Catra’s eyes twinkle with mirth.

“ *That* face. Like I’m, I don’t know, some great thing”

“You are”, affirms Adora, kissing the top of her knuckles. “The greatest”

Their words are rewarded with a faint pink blush over her dusted freckles and the flick of her tail against the back of their knees. Catra pulls lovingly from Adora’s earlobe, a tiny smile ghosting over her lips. “What is going on inside that brilliant mind of yours today?”

Adora shrugges, smiling back. “Just you and how much I love you”

Catra's face is priceless every time Adora says that, it always goes from pink to bright red and her ears go crazy. Adora would never say it outloud but they are adorable and always look so soft, a funky contrast to her flustered expression. Adora laughs as he leans to kiss the bridge of her nose, stealing the scrunch there away.

Behind them the roadside stands are coming to life, selling a myriad of trinkets and food to the people that pass by. When they turn apart Catra immediately tugs her towards the sellers, attracted by the delicious smells and colorful pieces. It doesn’t take them long to gravitate in the direction of a blacksmith merchant. In the wood tables are a great number of different types of weapons, all beautifully engraved with jewels and gemstones. There are other things there too, like bracelets and pendants and delicate rings with even more refined designs on them. The work of the metal is precise and highly skilled. Is immediately obvious that the person who did these designs knows their talent well.

A woman comes from behind a purple curtain when Catra and Adora approach. Is a big woman, half a head taller than Adora with big strong arms the size of Catra’s head and an equally strong torso. Her hair is red, as red as living fire, held in place behind her head by an intricate braid tangled with small rings of metal. Her green eyes regard Catra and Adora swiftly as she rests her hands smudged in dark oil at either side of her hips.

“Well greetings there, young fellas. How can I help you today? Giving a look to our precious trinkets, uh?”, the woman’s accent is heavy, probably from the north, near the mountains. And it’s also frankly obvious that she doesn’t recognize the people in front of her at all. There is a strange satisfaction that swells inside Adora’s chest at this and she takes an immediate liking of this woman. They like people that treat them like a simple person.

Catra must be thinking the same because she smirks, brushing her long hair behind her shoulders. She starts to inspect the daggers and swords with a clinical eye, humming in approval when she sees something she likes. Adora just stands behind her wife, a proud rosy face that brightens when the blacksmith gives them a satisfacted look of endorsement.

“Nice dress”, the woman teases, arching a red eyebrow to Catra.

“Thank you. I would still kill you on it”, answers back Catra, without even looking up, just the twitch of her ear as a giveaway of her mirth. The woman looks completely taken aback by

surprise and Adora's grin just grows wider.

Catra must see something she likes because her tail twirls in the air next to Adora's legs and she leans over the table to inspect one item in particular from up close. Adora looks over her shoulder, looking at what it seems to be a leather whip. The handle looks to be solid metal with a head of white stone carved in the form of a cat's skull. It's dangerous and beautifully done. Adora stands near her, not saying anything but also completely sure that Catra absolutely loves it.

Catra straightens, pulling the most stone cold expression she can so the blacksmith doesn't realize so quickly that she is absolutely besotted by the whip.

"How much are you daggers?". The blacksmith looks at her unimpressed, flicking her wrists to the mentioned weapons.

"One hundred silvers each for the pretty lady and her handsome companion", says the woman, winking. Adora truly has to press her fist over her mouth to stop herself from snorting and only because Catra seems to be having tons of fun right now. Catra hums low in her throat, pretending she is thinking it over before pointing at the whip.

"What about that one?". The woman's eyes flash, nodding.

"I see you are a person of taste after all. Three hundred silvers, a pretty expensive one I'm afraid". Adora frowns a little. Three hundred are much lower than what is actually worth, especially with a work so detailed like this. The woman doesn't see this and adds. "Better snatch what ya like now, we are traveling to Brightmoon next week"

Adora is about to ask who *we* is, when a crashing sound comes from behind the curtain and a funny looking man comes out of it. He is a halfling and much shorter than the woman, barely reaching her ribs, with hay-like short curly hair and round glasses atop his button nose. From the top of his head two antlers curve out, tangling themselves with strands of his own hair. He also has strong arms and under the rolled sleeves of his cotton shirt there is a collection of beautiful looking tattoos of diverse flowers traveling all the way up and down. He looks like a nice middle aged man and he glances quickly at them with a kind look and an even kinder smile before turning to the woman whose eyebrows are shot up on her forehead.

"What happened?" She asks, mild concerned and mild resigned. The man shifts on his feet, looking back and forth before smiling and apologizing.

"I'm so sorry, my honey. I tripped with the gemstones. Nothing broke, though! Well, maybe some of them cracked a little, but nothing we can't repair together".

The woman sighs, rubbing the bridge of her nose. Catra turns her head a little to Adora with an amused smile that they mirror. The man looks on the verge of a nervous attack when the woman sighs again, patting the top of his head with gentle motions.

"Ya are such a clotpole, ya are lucky I like ya"

Adora has barely started to process her sentence when Catra grabs them by the front of the shirt, tugging rather excitedly as she turns to them and points at their nose with a triumphal “Ha!”

Adora blinks once, twice to her without understanding. Catra rolls her eyes, pointing at the couple behind the table as she keeps tugging from the shirt.

“Clotpole. Is a word. I told you so” Catra slapps, actually pretty hard, Adora in the upper arm almost jumping on her place from excitement. She extends a hand, nudging them right in the side. “My fifty golden draconians, please”

Understandment drawns into Adora, remembering that sunny day when Catra kicked their butt, the first of many, and they made a bet over Catra's favorite nickname. Adora sighs, shaking his golden hair in amusement as he reaches for the satchel they had brought for their walk, taking out of it a small velvet red bag. Adora counts quickly and places the fifty gold coins inside Catra’s extended palm, tickling her playfully in the sides as he does so. The man has already slipped away, probably off to clean the mess, so now it is only the woman again looking at them with confusion on her face.

“You got lucky”

“You say that because you don’t want to admit I’m always right. Shame on you Adora”, jokes Catra, wiggling her head with a cunning smile on her lips. There is a sharp intake of air in front of them and when they turn the woman is gripping the edge of the table, green eyes wide and face pale.

“Adora? King Adora?” Her face grows even paler as she turns her eyes to Catra. “Queen C’yra?”

The three of them stay in silence until Adora raises her hand and waves two times with a goofy smile. “Hello”

The woman's face turns as red as her hair and she looks back and forward between both of them with a horrified look on her eyes, mind swirling in raising panic for all the teasing jokes she had just thrown at them. Catra's expression is complacent where Adora's is mildly apologetic, trying without success to tranquilize the woman with a swirl of his hand. Catra leans over the table and takes the neatly folded whip, inspecting it from close before the stunned gaze of the blacksmith and then nodding quite satisfied. She shakes the item in front of her face to completely call her attention, pointing with her head towards it.

"You have a wonderful selection, blacksmith. I'll be taking this". Catra extends her hand and lets the whole fifty golden coins fall over the freckled hand of the woman. Then she turns to Adora and hands them the weapon, asking without words to save it inside the satchel with a spark on her lips. Adora huffs and does as they are asked, reaching to take Catra's hand into theirs again once it's done.

On the other side, the woman passes her eyes over the golden coins completely speechless. She looks around the table and back at them, stuttering at the loss of words. Catra blinks at

her a few times, a slow knowing smile forming on her mouth. The blacksmith keeps gaping for a few seconds more before snapping back to life and mumbling in a high pitched tone.

"But, your Majesties, this is way too much. This way more than all of this table together" She looks now very much near the edge of tears. Adora throws her a gentle look, running her thumb absently over Catra's knuckles over and over again.

"You know? Your work is truly damn good. You are asking us to underpay for all of it" Adora signals at the money with one finger "That's what you truly deserve"

Still the woman looks conflicted. Catra steps in again, calling for the woman's attention as she cleans her throat. "Look, think of it like this. The three hundred silvers for the awesome whip and the rest for making me win this dofus' bet. What about it?"

Adora squeezes Catra's hand softly, dropping it just so they can wrap their entire arm around her waist. The woman now looks completely moved, dissolving herself into endless words of gratitude, reaching behind her to call for the man from earlier and eagerly shove the jingling coins into his shocked face. Adora steps even closer to Catra, resting his chin over her soft shoulder to nuzzle in her warm cheek with his own. Catra hums in response, wrapping her arms and tail around Adora to keep him close.

"That was nice" whispers Adora against her neck, eyes closed, letting the warmth of the sun above them drive any rest of the morning cold away. Adora feels Catra shrug below them, pulling gently from one of the blonde strands of hair that had fallen over her own shoulders.

"The least I can do. They need it so much more", Catra tugs from the strand to bring Adora's face closer so she can turn and smack a quick kiss on the side of their face. "Besides, winning is my biggest reward *and* I got an amazing whip"

Adora chuckles over her shoulder. "I can't wait to see what exactly are you going to do with that"

Catra straight up jabs him in the ribs, slipping out of their embrace to roll her eyes with an annoyed huff, ruffling her wild hair against her back. Her tail smacks Adora in the leg, making his smile progress into a smirk that Catra reflects.

The smell of food surrounds them both, filling their nostrils with a pleasant scent. Adora's stomach grumbles with it, reminding them both that they had longed a little bit too much in bed and had actually skipped breakfast. Catra shifts towards the food, throwing one last cheerful look to the joyful blacksmith that waves happily back at them, before starting to walk. Adora, however, stays in place shifting her weight from one foot to the other in an unusually shy motion after so many months spent together.

"I really want to show you a place today” Cara arches her eyebrows, curious, without saying anything, just letting Adora recover their thoughts and keep going. “It's a little far from here, into the woods. But I don't want to scare you by suddenly taking you there without telling you first"

Catra turns to Adora completely with a frown, now confused. Her hands are a little bit sweaty from the heat of the spring and her ears flicker. She is not nervous, she would walk on fire for Adora, but her curiosity boils with their words.

“Are you stealing me away, sir?”. This pours a chuckle out of Adora, who shakes their head and moves to get closer to her. They raise their fingers to Catra’s heart, brushing with the pads the cold surface of the wing pin that rests safely there.

“It’s something else. I’ve been thinking about it for a while but it seems that today is the perfect day. It’s- important”. Their eyes are gentle, sweet in the edges. Catra recognizes the raw sincerity in their voice, the small tremble in the vowels. It really is important for him. She wraps her hands over Adora’s, nodding once with a tiny smile.

“Alright, let me go with you”. Adora returns the smile, tugging from their joined hands and outside the cheerful town.

❀

“Careful” says Adora, holding Catra’s hand tightly as they climb the last round rocks up into the woods. Catra doesn’t really need it. In fact, she could have sprinted up in a matter of seconds, but the warm weight of Adora’s hand on hers was just too good to let it go.

They finally reach the top of the hill with a relieved sigh and Catra is able to take in the beauty of the clear that extends seemingly everything in front of them. It's surrounded by willows and pines with multiple berry bushes everywhere the sight falls over. They are so high in the woods there is a cool mist that sits around their ankles, making the leaves and grass shine with humidity. This way, it looks almost as a perfect circle hidden inside the woods and in the middle of it all a lonely dark tower covered in moss and wild flowers rises to the clear sky high high and strange, carved stone in untouched nature.

Catra throws an unsure look to Adora but she seems to be beaming at the sight of the tower, taking in the fresh smells and clear air. Her hand is securely grasped on Catra's own and a blush crawls it's way on Catra's cheeks, glancing from the edge of her eyes to their joined hands. Adora had kissed her long and sweet before adventuring into the woods, caressing the bones of her knuckles and the dips of her lower back with soft wandering fingers. And then Catra had followed Adora in a hassle, foggy mind as they stepped outside of the village and into the deep of the woods, heart on the base of her throat and hot tears prickling at her lashes. She had never envisioned being able to love someone so much yet here she is, in bare feet and bare heart resting all her trust and love on the secure hands of the greatest person in the world.

Everything that has ever happened has led them here. Every decision, every mistake, every victory. Pain and loss and wins and mistrust and leaps of faith. Every wall succumbed to the strength of the pull they have on each other and Catra is sure that she would do it all again exactly the same way if that meant standing here besides Adora, adoring her. And in every timeline and life and world, she will always choose her. Again and again. It’s poetic, is dumb, terrifying and exciting and overwhelming and Catra embraces it all with open arms.

She wants it all, every single thing as long as is with Adora. She wants the meeting and the growing, the choosing and the resting. She wants the friend, the family, the wife, the mother. The sickness and the wrinkles. The silver stars in fair hair and thin skin in wore knuckles. She wants it all, whatever they chose together she will do it, whatever that comes from their love Catra will love it. And when Adora turns to her with golden eyes shining in joy she knows they feel exactly the same.

Adora unlocks their hands in order to brush Catra's free bangs out of her face, leaning just enough to press a sweet kiss over the bridge of her nose, a gesture that somehow feels so much more intimate that all their lovely nights pressed together. Catra just holds herself to the loose ends of their shirt, tugging gently the ribbons there in a grounding motion. And they only turn apart because Catra's sensitive ears catch the smallest of the sounds, a brush of movement in the tower in front of them and a disturbance of the birds that sat atop of it, even though when she narrows her eyes she can't distinguish any living creature.

Adora smiles softly, caressing the baby hairs on Catra's neck, pressing tiny kisses on the side of her hair and ear to soothe her.

"It's alright", they assure her, mindful of Catra's rising thoughts. "Nothing is going to hurt you here"

"And where exactly is here?", mutters Catra under her breath, weary looking at the lonely tower. The more she sees it the more both out of place and natural it looks.

"A good place, promise". Adora tugs from her hand to motion them both forward but Catra digs her ankles into the soft earth and raises her eyebrows, unsure. Adora just rolls their gray eyes, massaging slowly the fingers of her hand in an attempt to coo her. "Promise. I would never bring you if I thought it was dangerous".

Catra's gaze is still unsure but she squeezes Adora's fingers and they take it as the only sign they need to start to guide her over the moss path and to the tower. The heavy door is swollen by years of water and time, and it creaks menacingly when Adora pushes it open. Catra expects to meet with the smell of fungus and decay but the inside of the tower is clean and warm, a notorious contrast with the exterior.

There is a fire crackling in the furthest wall and a pile of logs waiting patiently next to it. A few items are knocked over the place, fabrics and robes pulled aside over chairs and half melted candles sticking to the table. Stone stairs start from the left side and climb up to the top of the tower, losing themselves from sight midway. There are numerous crystals hanging from the low roof, catching the light of the flames and reflecting odd forms over the walls. Catra is inspecting the sun mural carved on the stones of the floor when the smell from the fire hits her and it's only then that she realizes there is something cooking in there.

It's a house, a lonely house inside an even lonelier tower habited by someone that is surely very much alive. Catra turns with a questioning frown to face Adora, who seems to search with avid eyes among the shadows. Catra sees the incoming movement just in time and ducks down. Adora, unfortunately, doesn't and receives a mouthful of broom bristles right in the face.

Catra turns to the origin of the movement as Adora sputters, bating away the broom with her hands and an indignant squeal. In front of both spouses there is a small old woman, gray hair in disarray that goes in every single direction. Her skin is wrinkled and rich, hands slim as they hold with strength the broomstick, ready to swing again if necessary. She wears a purple dress, old and a bit broken in the seams, but that once was a beautiful piece. And from her nose hang a pair of round crystal glasses that make her gray and purple eyes look even bigger.

Catra looks at the woman in awe, her brain trying and failing to pull the pieces together. She is sure she knows this woman. She has seen her before, somewhere but Catra just can't distinguish where. Adora recovers from the surprise and the sudden hit and steps forward a little, taming the wild golden hair that had been disturbed by the ofensor broom.

"Razz", whines Adora as they address the woman, "What was that for? It's just me"

The woman's squinted eyes widen in delight and she lets go of the broom in order to squeal high pitched as she throws herself into Adora's arms.

"Mara! Oh Mara dearie. It's you! It's been so long!". Catra gasps in sudden shock, locking from the small figure of Razz to Adora's eyes, who is already looking back with a pained expression. Their smile, however, remains kind and almost apologetic.

"Razz raised my mom, and then helped raise me until I wasn't a baby anymore. She confuses us sometimes". Razz tightens her hold on Adora's arms and they let out a shaky breath. "Most times"

Catra understands and there is a grieving tug inside her chest at Adora's trembling voice, but she throws a smile to them and it seems to relax Adora enough to part a little from Razz vice grip and grasp her fragile hands on their own.

"It's me, Razz. Adora". Adora's smile is watery but there is a loving stare on their eyes that shows how deeply they care for this woman. "I'm sorry it took me a while. I'm here now" Razz laughs a cracked sound, rubbing their fingers with her thumbs in soothing circles.

"Of course you are, Mara dearie. You promised we would make pie after all. I have it ready already!", she points to the pot near the fire from where the rich smell is coming from and throws a toothy smile to Adora who mirrors it with practice patience.

"That's wonderful Razz". Adora rests their hand on Razz' back and guides her towards Catra who hasn't moved at all from her squinted position. Catra jumps up again in a swift motion, pulling nervously at the fabric of her skirt. For some reason, being in the presence of this woman feels like seeing a mentor after many years, she just wants to get it right. Adora takes in her nervousness and blinks slowly at her, pointing at her with their finger. "I've brought someone with me. This is-"

"Catra, dearie!", lets out Razz before stepping at full speed and grabbing her hands gently. Her eyes are even bigger now, inspecting Catra's factions with intent. "Look at how beautiful you are. And so tall. Aren't you a beauty, sweetie?". Catra looks at Razz with astonishment

and then back at Adora, trying to understand, but they wear the same confused expression as her as they shake their head.

“I haven’t seen her since mom died”, they whisper. Catra returns her eyes to the top of Razz head and down her eyes, squeezing her brain. But nothing comes, just the feeling of meeting again an old lovely woman, like stepping in a lake's watetr after years of being away.

"Do you know who am I?" Catra asks, keeping her voice soft and curious. Razz rolls her eyes in a motion that is so much Adora that it robs Catra of her breath.

"Of course I do dearie, of course I do. Now come, it's time to eat" Razz pulls Catra of the hand, reaching to grasp Adora's and pull her too towards the fire. Both of them share a look but Adora just shakes his head in confusion and lets Razz pull them together into wood chairs before dissapearing behind the logs, seemely looking for something.

Catra leans towards Adora, lacing their fingers together as she calls for his attention. "Adora?"

"Humm?", Adora snaps out of his thoughts, turning his head to Catra with hooded eyes.

"Does- does Razz have Foresight?" Adora blinks at her a few times like his mind is far away and is taking him a while to piece the words together. When they do, Adora furrows her brows and glances at Razz figure, who is now taking out a beautiful looking pie and cutting it into pieces.

"Actually, I don't know", Adora sighs, squeezing Catra's hand into their lap. "Could explain how does she know you"

"It could"

Both fall into heavy silence, just looking at Razz come and go around the chamber. She is a funky small thing but the way her shoulders rise and fall and her gaze roams around the place speaks of how much wisdom she really carries. Catra turns her eyes from her and back to Adora and is not surprised to see the melancholy on those blue eyes and the small tremble on their rose lips. Catra presses her own mouth together in a firm line, leaning until her forehead is resting over Adora's upper arm and her other hand is cradling Adora's elbow gently.

"Are you alright?"

"Yes. It's just-" Adora takes a breath of air, letting go of Catra's hand so they can quickly clean their eyes. Catra tightens her hold. "Sometimes I really miss my mom"

"I know" Catra assures them, placing small kisses over her shoulders. "She loved you a lot"

"She did", finally Adora turns to meet Catra's gaze, smiling. The pain is still there but is better, sheltered by waves of love that shake Catra's soul. "She did"

"There you go, dearies. You both need to be strong" Razz places two copper plate filled with pieces of blackberry pie and then pokes Catra in the ribs, who huffs in surprise "Especially you"

"Me?" questions Catra, wiggling unsure on her place. Adora is already devouring the dessert but they pause a little to kiss her in the head.

"Yes, you". Razz affirms and explains and says no more when she lets herself fall into the opposite chair from them, taking a bowl full of nuts and starting to clean them with quiet precision. Catra looks at Adora but they only shrug, caressing the side of her face in soothing motions.

They eat in silence for a while, just the sound of the forks against the plates and the fire crackling next to them. The pie is delicious, the most tasty thing Catra has ever had and now she understands why Adora is always stealing pastries from the kitchens. Razz is cleaning the nuts almost cheerfully, inspecting them carefully and throwing the bad ones back to the fire until the entire place smells like them. Adora finishes her slice and leaves it over a near table, cleaning her throat to speak. They are nervous but the air inside the tower is calm and welcoming and soothes their anxiety even if just a little.

"Umm, so, Razz, have you been fine?", they ask, blindly looking for Catra's hand for comfort.

"Of course, Adora darling, of course" next to Catra, Adora sighs in relief. Catra knows this is incredibly hard for them, they haven't seen their nanna in years and it seems just now Adora has collected the strength to do this and trusting Catra to being by their side to do it fills Catra with an unlikely feeling of pride. Or it does until Raz adds, "Baking pies and waiting for your mother to pass by some time, that girl"

Adora's breathing stops abruptly and Catra, who hasn't taken her sight from her lover in all this time, sees the tears starting to form on the corners of their beautiful eyes and it breaks her heart.

"Oh, Razz. You know- you know mom, Mara, you know she is-" Adora is starting to spiral, taking watery breaths as they try to focus. It's too much, tol quickly. Catra surges forward and holds their chin on her hand, rubbing reassuring circles on their skin to ground them down. Adora looks at her and her lungs start to feel better, slowly calming by Catra's presence. Catra knows Razz hasn't taken her eyes from them but she doesn't turn to see what expression she wears. This is about Adora right now.

It takes them a few minutes but Adora finally comes back to themself, gifting Catra a thankful smile before turning back to her nanna's thoughtful gaze. "Razz, I want you to think about moving back to the palace"

"Palace?" questions Razz, eyebrows lost on her hair when she widens her eyes. She doesn't make a remark about the slight panic and Catra thanks her quietly.

"Yes, back to Camelot" Adora is toying with the hem of her shirt. Her face is solemn, like she has been thinking about this for a long time. She keeps shooting glances at Catra, expression apologetic every time. " *I'm sorry I didn't tell you about this before"* they seem to say. And Catra keeps smiling back, small and gentle. " *Don't apologize"* her eyes say " *I understand. I'm here for you".*

"There is an empty tower in Castle Grayskull, we could clean it up and you could do everything you do here there. We will bring your stuff, and there are lots of berries around. You don't have to change anything"

"But that's Mara's tower, silly. Why would I move when she is there?". Adora's teeth clash against each other when they close their mouth, Catra can see distraught bubbling up in their face as the seconds pass.

"Razz-"

"Razz?" Catra surges forward, placing a calming hand over Adora's folded ones and the other hovering near the woman's arm. "Just think about it, alright? You can stay wherever you want, go wherever you wish. We just would be really happy to have you there, near"

Next to her, Adora lets out a harsh breath and squeezes tightly Catra's hand, rubbing the pads of her fingers. Razz sees the small gesture and her gaze turns incredibly soft and her eyes seem to focus in reality for the split of a second when she regards Catra's face completely.

"You've really become a splendid woman, haven't you little girl" Catra's wide eyes flash with the flames light and she feels small again under the wise look of this woman. This must be what Adora feels under her gaze. Before neither of them can add something, Razz clasps her hands together and stands in one movement, maybe too agile for her age, bowl of nuts left forgotten on the floor. "Alright, alright. Now eat more! I'll go bring you some capes, it's going to rain later and your clothes are too light"

She turns on her place and sprints up the stone stairs, humming to herself all the way up. Catra allows herself to fall back into the creaking chair, letting out a long sigh. She feels the warm skin of Adora's hand resting over her hand again and press gently. There is a tiny smile hanging from her lips, and she still looks sad but there is gratitude too.

"Thank you", she whispers. There are a lot more words carried with that gaze, passing between both back and forward. It's a sweet reassurance, not feeling alone when reality crashes against you. Catra shivers under the weight of Adora's eyes, a natural response of her body to her raw emotions, but returns the smile anyway.

"Of course" she murmurs back in the quiet calmness of the room. Catra lets herself fall against Adora's side, nuzzling the side of her neck. She loves that spot, it makes her feel both protected and protective and she thinks there is not a better feeling than that. Adora leans towards her too, placing her lips over the crown of her head, whispering in the thread of a voice.

"I love you"

Catra smiles, hidden between the small braids on Adora's hair. "I know"

✾

They stay with Razz during most of the lunch hour. She gives them a pair of heavy black capes, the material thick and comfortable. It smells a little bit like moss, probably after spending a long time tucked away. Razz teaches Catra to distinguish between good and bad berries and makes Adora knead pie dough until their hands are tired. They don't talk about Mara anymore and Razz, by some grace, doesn't confuse their names either, so by the end of the visit Adora looks and feels much more relaxed and Catra's heart sings in relief. Eventually, both spouses excuse themselves gently and say their goodbyes to her, asking her to think about their proposal. Razz ruffles the hair atop Adora's head when they bend to her height and she departs from them with a wide smile, referring to them by their true name with a twinkle in her eyes. Then she turns and places a kiss in Catra's cheek, patting the other side with her wrinkled hand.

Adora guides Catra outside the clear where Razz's tower is and back into the surrounding woods, helping her detangle the waves of her dress every time it gets clasped on the branches. They trip a few times in return and Catra keeps them up with a strong hand on their side and muffled laugh on her lips. They walk together for about an hour, enjoying the living creature that is Etheria's earth, the shimmering lakes and ponds, the small and big animals walking around them and through the day. For a while, a pair of dragonflies accompany them in their walk making Catra feel like inside a bard's song.

They arrive at a second clear, this one filled with small flower's and green grass that reaches just above their ankles in some patches and all over their waists in others. Adora chases Catra for a few good meters until they both collapse in a fit of giggles in a mush spot in the ground, hair tangled in knots and feet dirty by the soft earth around. As they look up and into the intense blue sky Adora feels so young, so free, surrounded by the smell of dew and the rays of the sun and the warmth of Catra's body pressed next to theirs. She hears the sparkling laugh that leaves Catra's throat and sees her extend her arms as if she were to touch the sky with her fingers and hold the clouds on her palms.

Adora feels their expression quiver and melt while they see her, their chest jumping happily inside their ribcage. Here it feels like they are in their own little barrier below Camelot's trees, away from years and years of war and pain and loss. Catra looks as what she always should, happy and joyful and relaxed

Catra turns her head to her locking their eyes together, grey against blue, silver against gold, and she scooters closer to her, curling to her side when Adora circles her shoulders with one arm.

"What?" asks Catra, eyes bright and alive. There is a nice breeze in the space, the perfect weather for a perfect evening and even though there are natural noises of the woods Adora knows they won't be interrupted there. It's too far away from usual paths and Razz doesn't leave her own clear, never. So Adora sighs and brushes the length of Catra's small nose, teasingly booping her with her fingers before answering. "I was just thinking"

"Wow", mocks her Catra and Adora pokes her in the ribs with a playful pout.

"Don't be mean"

"Alright, alright. Tell me what you are thinking about". Adora hums in the back of their throat, bumping their noses together.

"There is a story my mom used to tell me" murmurs Adora, lowering their voice like she was telling a secret. Catra snuggles even closer, taking in each of their words with longing. "She said that important people in our lives sometimes carve so deep in our lives they mingle with our very souls. People that meant something for us, people we loved. And that those people are so bright that they become a part of our lives again and again and again. No matter how many years pass or how different our worlds look, we are always entangled together"

Catra smiles, gently. Her tail comes up and brushes Adoras forearm. "Do you think that's us? That we've been in each other's lives again and again?"

Adora looks at the freckles on her cheeks and flushes pink because she knows exactly how many there are on each cheek and nose. She had counted them enough times in the dim light of the dawn. "I think we have. I think we do"

Adora feels a little embarrassed, cheeks spotted in pink as she tells the fairytale. But Catra doesn't laugh or make a joke, she seems to really think about it and then her face breaks into a kind honest smile, nodding. "Yeah, I think we do too" she pokes Adora's forehead right in the center, smile turning into a smirk. "What do you think we were doing, in those lives?"

Adora considers it for a second, raising her hand to the base of Catra's ears to scratch softly at the soft fur there. Almost immediately a purr fills the clear and Adora smiles. "I think you had these cute little ears there too"

Catra rolls her eyes and tugs from her earlobe without really meaning it. But then they turn softer, a new thought traveling through her mind. "Do you think we got to grow up together? That time?"

Adora tries to hide a sniffle and fails, pressing their foreheads together. "Yes I think we did. Breaking havoc where we went"

Catra laughs, enveloping her arms around Adora's waist. "It doesn't matter" she says "Whatever we did or where, I'm sure of one thing"

"And what is that?" asks Adora.

"That I always carried you in my heart"

Adora lets out a watery sigh, lips trembling uncontrollably. Catra cooes her into her arms, rocking them from side to side as softly as she can in that position. Catra is still working on it, letting go, freeing the words she wants to say, she means to say. And Adora is always there to catch it, always patiently, always lovingly. There is so much love inside Catra that, no matter how anxious and scared she can get, she knows that the journey will be worth it, that a life besides Adora will be worth it. And she knows that Adora will be there, will always fight for them, will not back away. If Catra is certain of something, it is of Adora’s love.

Catra runs her fingers through Adora's hair, careful not to pull as she works in untangling the knots that formed after running around the forest for most of the day. The hair of their undercut has been growing slowly the last couple of months, curling in odd directions over her nape, and Catra likes to press the pads of her fingers in the skin there and laugh softly when Adora ties her hair. Now, Adora giggles inside the crook of Catra's neck when her hands tickle her, holding Catra closer to their chest.

"Thank you for taking me with Razz today", says Catra to them, face still buried in their hair. "I know how important she is to you"

"She is", assures Adora, parting a little from their embrace to look at her face, "And so are you"

Catra's cheeks are sore of smiling so much in the last couple of hours, days, months, but she somehow manages to smile even wider, and pepper little kisses all over their face.

"Well then, thank you for letting me be a part of your family too"

Adora seizes her hand and places a small kiss in the tips of her fingers, resting it carefully against their face right over the Thaymor' scar is. "You always were Catra, from day one"

Catra mirrors the pink blush on their cheeks, nuzzling on the soft moss below them. There was a time, almost a year ago, where Adora never thought she would have this. A time where dreams and wishes of unconditional love and gentle touches seemed to have flown out of the window and crashed in a million pieces. When Catra was standing by her side and yet she was so, so far away, hiding behind walls and sharp words and cold eyes. Now she is laying here, in a green square with grass on her hair and dimples on her cheeks and eyes bright and dilated as if they hadn't made love to each other the entire morning.

Catra seems to be following their thoughts because her flush redness and her ears twitch, pressing herself as close as she can to Adora's side. There is a purr on the back of her throat, sweet as honey. "I've always wanted to have a family of my own", she says, and when she catches her own words her voice goes quiet with embarrassment. "I'm sorry, that came out of nothing"

"No, tell me" soothes her Adora in the most quiet voice she can muster. Catra bites her lips, catching her bottom lip against her fang, nervousness pouring out of her pores but she keeps going, not once leaving Adora's eyes.

"I grew up surrounded by love, Adora. I saw how much my mothers loved me, and how much they loved me. And when I grew up and got older I understood that I was lucky, that many people don't have what I got." Catra takes a breath when her voice breaks, trying to focus. Adora keeps brushing her ears, reassuring her. "And when they were gone and I became queen, the only thing I could focus on was on thinking *I'm going to give the best of me so nobody lost anyone again.* And I stopped wanting something for myself for so long, but it was always in the back of my head. I wanted what my mothers had, what we had as a family. I wondered if I would be ready, if I would be a good"

“You would. I think you would be the greatest mother that can exist” immediately assures Adora, tangling their fingers together. Catra can feel her pulse on her ears and the rush of her blood on her veins. Both go quiet, shy glances that edge in embarrassment, but Catra can see the honesty in Adora's eyes, the love, the patiente. There is no pressure or command there, just the gentle feeling that says that Adora would be there, that they want to be there, embrace them and everything that comes. Catra sniffles, warm drops falling across her cheeks and into the ground and Adora is immediately there, rubbing them out with her fingers as they keep pouring out of her wife's eyes, apologetic words falling from her lips as she tries to calm her down. Catra bats her hands away, laughing between tears that only manage to deepen the worry frown on Adora's forehead.

"I'm alright, I'm alright" chokes out Catra, wiping the tears away with the back of her hands. When she looks back at Adora her eyes are rimmed in red but her expression is loving, so much so that Adora's heart squeezes in their chest. Catra pokes them in the nose once and adds, “I guess I’ve never considered that possibility could be real. I never thought I would love someone that much and I didn’t want to get my hopes up- I’m glad I was wrong”

It's not the entire words Catra wants to say to Adlray, wants to gift them with, but they are big, important. Enough. Enough to make Adora's lips quiver with contained sobs and their soul to explode. Catra waits for them to recover enough before turning her smile into a sly smirk, pulling from Adora's earlobe.

"There is just a slight fail in your logic, dummy", Adora wrinkles her eyebrows, confused. Catra takes pity on their dumbstruck face and laughs. “How can I be the greatest mother if you are right there too?”

Adora's blue eyes glimmer like crystals with their own tears yet joins Catra in the middle of her laugh. “Charmer”

“Well, heavy is the head that holds the crown”, Catra brings both her hands up, cupping Adora's jaw between them, rubbing circles on the high of their cheekbones. "I'm so happy you had Mara. And Bow, and Sparkles, and everyone else. I'm glad you were loved, that you weren't alone. And I'm glad that even if we didn't get to grow together, we are here now"

Catra brings their faces closer, lips pressing ones against the others in a slow but longing kiss. She pours the sweetness of her mouth into Adora's throat and the low whimper that she receives in return make shivers travel town the length of her spine, raising the small hairs in the nape of her head. Adora's breathing shakes and speeds up as they press with new fire into her and it's Catra who has to collect as much self control as she can and pull them apart just enough for her to be able to talk again.

"Wait, wait Adora". The latter stops immediately on their tracks, opening their eyes to study the expression on her face.

"Are you alright?" and the kindness with which they say it almost breaks Catra's control all over again, but she manages not jump right back into their arms and sits down, bringing Adora along with her.

"Yes. But there is something I want to give you before". Adora watches as Catra recovers their forgotten satchel from somewhere behind them and searches inside of it with a determined look in her eyes. Finally , she pulls what seems to be a small piece of purple clothes, wrapped against itself as if enveloping something inside. Catra places it over Adora's extended palm nudging it in her direction. "Open it"

Adora undoes the loose knot of the fabric and takes in the treasure inside. The small trinket catches the sunshine over a blue jewel in the form of a crescent moon, the smallest of black pearls sheltering each side of the jewel inside their silver pockets. It’s a small thing, thin and pretty so delicate and will probably break in two if held too tightly. But today, under the golden light of the evening, Adora can take in the beauty of it and it’s meaning in full force.

"I spoke with Sparkles" explains Catra in a shaky voice, "She said you have traditions in Etheria. That it's the reason why she and Bow wear her mother's earrings. That it represents a bond between people who-" Catra licks her dry lips quickly, taking in each and every single one of the flickers in Adora's expression. "-who love each other"

Adora didn't answer, too absorbed in the thin ring. It was a bit big, probably wouldn't fit in Adora's ring finger, and it was cold to the touch like it had been locked away for a long time.

"It was my mom 's. Family heirloom if you want to see it like that. My mothers never used trinkets to symbolize their love, but, it reminds me of them and I want you to have it". Catra is shivering, light trembles shaking her body and she curses quietly her nerves for betraying her. She tries to keep them at bay, and presses her hand over her chest, right above the winged pin nestled there. “It’s because of you . *It’s for you.* It’s for us”.

Adora slices gingerly their pointer finger inside the silver arch, ring resting perfectly and now warm over the sky of their scarred finger. It seems to shiver a moment with a trum of magic, the thinnest of the blue lights surrounding it before calming down. A new sensation covers Adora from head to toe, it feels soft, comfortable, like an embrace, and they let out a puff of air in their surprise when the feeling travels to their chest and pools in their ribs. They can feel Catra's hands in their hair, brushing strands and braids aside and gently behind their redden ears. She isn't looking at the ring but directly at Adora's face, grinning.

"It will protect you, wherever you are, it will keep you safe"

Adora's fragile self control snaps like a violin cord and they surge forward, grabbing Catra's face between their palms to bring her quick and passionate to their lips. There is a shocked squeak and then a surprised huff when Catra's back connects back with the mush earth. She looks up at Adora's face, pink with sunset and blush, eyes so wide they almost look black between a thin ring of bright blue, lips parted just slightly letting see through the white of their teeth and the glistening of their tongue when it shoots up to wet the dry skin. She can feel the smooth surface of the ring against the skin of her cheek where Adora is cupping it before leaning down and towards her. And is with a joyful smile that Catra lets her arms envelope around Adora's neck and allows herself to surrender between their arms.

❀

*****

There is a bright tug inside Adora that pulls stronger, stronger and stronger, constricting her lungs until she can't keep her eyes open any longer and her breath becomes hiccups of pleasure. The pull tightens and then breaks, spilling like rain, like waterfall, like a volcano. And with it, the fragile tension of the treasure between her arms breaks too mingling with their force like stardust.

Their supernova lives, shining brightly against the blue sky and then dies down, sauntering like a feather back to ground.

Adora pants heavily on the smoky crook of Catra's neck, shivers still running up and down her entire body making her hips stutter once, thrice before settling in. Above them, the leaves of the evergreen trees cover them both with their shadows, hiding them from the rest of the world.

It takes Adora a while to recover her senses, content in just peppering the column of Catra's neck with lazy open-mouthed kisses, taming the blooming violets on her skin with the smooth flat of her tongue. With time Adora is able to open their heavy eyelids, lifting from their place in the deeps and creases of her collarbones to look at her face completely. Catra looks precious. Still too far gone, but with her eyes shut close, red lips open in short staccatos of hot breath and her tail firmly wrapped on Adora's calf, she looks like a pleased deity lying in white and yellow blooms.

There is a loud purr that rumbles across the entire clear, competing in beauty with the birds' songs and all those small shifts of sound that are Etheria. The clearing of fresh grass they had fallen into has burst to life, filled to the top with a multicolor of wild flowers under Catra's shaking hands. The evening sun is golden and it almost looks as if the last sunny patch had decided to land right over them. Adora is not sure who's magic is doing it but it is beautiful and it's theirs.

Catra comes back slowly. Adora realizes because of the deep sigh that comes from the depths of her exposed throat and the way she taps lightly the side of Adora's bare bicep, a gentle and familiar sign between both of them. Adora slips out slowly, reverently, kissing the mewls and sighs of her lips all the way until Adora ruffles the white layered skirt of the dress back in place from where it had been tangled over her hips.

Her long elegant legs, that had been wrapped around their waist, now fall at either sides, trembling and spent resting on the patches of soft moss scattered over the ground. She is still open and wet and soft and vulnerable and Adora cradles her in the insides of their arms, holding her close to the skin of their chest where she can swim in the waves of her pleasure in calm, tucked away from the sudden chilling breeze of the exterior.

*****

It 's easy. It's so easy to love her. It comes as easy as breathing, as their heart beating. Right in this place, in the damp nest that is her body and theirs pressed together, is the only place where Adora can truly allow be their own self. Where they don't have to be a king, or meet expectations, or put their life on the line. Where Adora can just exist. It’s both a paradise and

a torment. A gift and a punishment. And Adora holds with all the strength of their scarred fingers onto these precious moments, as if life were to tear it all away from them in the next second like a tsunami and a tornado and a disaster. Yet every day comes with sunshine and blooming roses in their balcony, safe one next to the other inside the love they've built together. And every night ends with dark skies full of twinkling lights and sweet gasps of desire tangled in cotton sheets.

Just for now, just for this day, nothing bad can happen. Because they have each other.

There is a new breeze that crosses the clearing, a cold indicator that the night is coming. Adora reaches between them to place the lace open fabric back to its place, covering the lovely and loved swells on their wife's chest in an endearing gesture that seeks to keep her warm. Catra shifts below them, taking a deep inhale of breath a few times before stretching lightly. Her purrs are still there but are now more like low rumbles that lull Adora into a deep calm. She is only able to keep awake because of the rhythmic thud of Catra's tail against the grass and the strong beating of her heart right below their ear. Catra brushes her long fingers over their bangs, her black nails lightly scratching their scalp in soothing motions.

"Hey, Adora". Her voice is low, a little raspy after a long time of just high pitched whines and silent screams. Adora moves a little, hovering their face just barely above hers, brushing their noses together in the way.

"Welcome back"

Catra hums, her hips moving in small circles below Adora's. It doesn't spark a new fire but it does make Adora giggle when her tail brushes on the skin of their ribs. Adora brushes their thumb over Catra's bottom lip, pressing softly over the plumb swell skin, red and soft kisses. Catra blinks slowly at them for a while, her ears flickering over her head as she takes in the expression on their face.

"What?", she asks in a whisper, caressing Adora's throat slowly. She is so lovely.

"Marry me" blurts out Adora, words crashing against each other in a rush. Catra's eyes go big and wide, pupils overpowering the colors of her eyes. Even her ears stop moving, pressing against the sides of her head. Adora wiggles a little and keeps going with a sure and joyful voice, a warm feeling curling on their heart. "Marry me again. This time it is *me* asking *you* . No because of our kingdoms, or plans or the war"

"Then why?" asks Catra, her voice cracking in different places by the emotions. Adora takes her hand and presses it against their lips, smiling.

"Because I love you"

Catra laughs, wiping the few runaway tears that run down her eyes. She extends her hand and pokes the center of Adora's forehead, nodding. "Alright"

"Yes?" breathes out Adora, like they didn't actually expect for her to agree. Catra rolls her eyes, sticking out her tongue to them.

“Yes you big goofus”. Catra wriggles until they are both sitting in the grass, looking up at the progressively darker sky. The night moon is starting to come out, letting the first stars sparkle out. Catra tugs from Adora's hand, beaming “Let’s do it right now”

Adora sputters, turning pink and then bright red as they scratch the back of their head in a nervous gesture. She doesn't let go of Catra's hand “Right now? But I don’t have a- a Priestess or music or-"

“We don’t need it, Adora. We already did all that. This time is just for us, just the two of us” Catra bursts into giggles and she looks almost ethereal against the light that slowly turns from golden to purples. Adora can't help but kiss her again, robbing the squeaky laugh from her parted lips again and again.

"What do we do? What did your mothers do?" asks Adora, voice starting to raise in a high pitched tone out of sheer excitement. Catra furrows her eyebrows, thinking so hard her eyes almost cross in concentration.

"I don't really know" she looks back at Adora's patient eyes, shrugging. "We can do our own thing, we have tokes and each other. I need nothing more"

"Then let me give you a promise" murmurs Adora, tangling their fingers together. "It doesn't matter what happens, it doesn't matter what they try to do to us. I'm not leaving. You'll look out for me and I'll look out for you, for this day and all those that came before and that will come after. And whatever life throws at us, I'll be there. And we'll have each other. That's my promise to you".

Catra is crying. Adora is crying. They are both softly weeping on each other's hands, damp trails leaving paths over their cheeks. It's a good cry, that kind of cry that appears when your heart is relieved, when the weight of the world is lifted from your chest, when you feel so unequivocally happy your body can only shake and rain inside itself.

Catra nods, sniffing, her tails tracing circles on the ground but she doesn't let go of Adora, just pulling her as close as she can to whisper back. "Then I promise you this, that you will never be alone again. That no matter what, you won't have to carry the weight on your own. That I'll always stand by your side, when we disagree, when we agree, when none of us know what to do. I'll be there. I'll protect you, and you'll protect me. And there won't be a single day where you aren't loved"

Adora pulls her into their open arms, holding her tightly against their chest as their joined tears keep falling. Tiny laughs leaving in hiccups from their lips. The winged pin and the moon ring are warm against their skins.

The sun falls completely and night arrives.

❀

It does rain, just as Razz predicted, slow drops of water that fall into the earth as night covers completely over Camelot. The thick wool capes Razz gave them serve their purpose, hiding

them from the water as they walk in hurried feet back to the castle. It’s not a strong rain, barely even a drizzle that refreshes the woods and cleans the air from the hot clouds of spring. The people in the castle are bursting with life when they arrive, going in and around on their daily chores as most of them refuge from the rain. It’s a good omen, with the crops being planted soon and the rivers being filled after a long time of being frozen. The people of the kitchen murmur between themselves when they see them chase each other in wet capes and damp hair, cheerful whispers that follow them all the way through the rooms and out through the doors.

There is a hot bath waiting for them when they arrive at their chamber. Someone has made the bed and lit the crystal lamps and there is a warm dinner waiting patiently over the table. Adora makes the mental note of personally thanking the maidens in the morning.

Catra marches towards the bath, softly waving to the food to keep them hot for a longer time. Adora follows her without a word, watching her taste the water with the tip of her fingers and turn around to grab dry clothes from the wooden cabinet near the fireplace. She joins Adora soon after, next to the bath, with a cheerful smile on her lips. There is mischievousness there too but the corners are wavery, the day's tiresome unavoidable hanging from there. Adora smiles back at her, nuzzling the side of her face with their nose, taking in her smell, musky with sweat and earth but also sweet like the tarts they had eaten or the strawberry flowers they had laid over. Adora feels her hands reach for the ribbons of the cape, fastening them quickly with her fingers, letting the heavy fabric fall unceremoniously over the floor. They feel her finger drip down, untucking the white shirt from their pants and pulling it over their head in a slow motion. Adora helps her by raising their arms, just to let them fall right into her waist as Catra folds the shir and leaves it over the closest chair. They stand like that for a few moments, with Adora barefoot and only on her pants and Catra resting her head on the swell of her breasts, white dress wrinkled from a long day. Adora starts to untie the lace, roaming her hand in the skin of Catra’s back it appears, exposed and out of the soft fabric. She can feel the shivers running down the creases of her spine and the sigh when the entire piece of clothing falls to the floor in a mesh of white. This feels so intimate, so private. It always does, undressing Catra. No matter if they are bathing, preparing to sleep, giving to each other, this is Adora’s favorite part, the gentleness of taking out each layer that covers her skin, untying braids of soft hair, ruffling the fur of her ears until they flicker against their fingers. Skin pressed against skin. Catra won’t say it out loud, but this is her favorite part too. Being able to press the palms of her hands against Adora’s muscles, brushing her lips over the goosebump skin of their shoulders, placing strands of blonde hair out of their handsome face, marveling in the soft loving expression in their eyes, golden with the reflection of the flames.

Adora steps out of their pants in one swift movement, falling crumbled and dumb somewhere near the bath and it makes them both laugh. Catra enters the warm water first, sitting in the furthest edge of the bath, motioning Adora to come in and nestle between her legs. Adora snuggles over until their back is pressed against Catra’s chest and their head is resting on the crook between her head and her neck. The water is delicious, warm and just a little soapy. It smells like lavenders and jasmine, taking away the dull cold ache the rain brought inside their bones. They lull each other into a sweet rest, allowing their muscles to relax and their breaths to even together. Above their head, Catra jawns, the arms that envelop Adora starting to relax

around their waist and Adora knows she is going to fall asleep any minute now. *That's alright* , Adora thinks, *I got her*. *And she got me.*

Adora thinks that they are also going to fall asleep very soon. That's alright too. They will nap now, and then they'll dry out and have dinner in bed. And after that they will snuggle together, with Catra's head in Adora's chest and Adora's arms wrapped around her shoulders. Melog will join them at some point in the night, making themself as tiny as they can in the space between their bodies, sharing their warmth.

They will do all that, eventually. But right now, there is a thought that crosses Adora's mind. She doesn't know why or where it came from but it is as sudden as it is strong, enough to shake the sleep a little bit and call for Catras's attention once again.

"Finn"

"Hum?" wonders Catra, already half asleep.

"Finn, I like that name. It feels- right", explains Adora in a soft voice. They don't see it, but they can feel Catra smile against their hair.

"I like it too"

"You do?"

"I do"

End of chapter V

End of Arc I

Chapter End Notes

') And nothing bad happened. Ever
This concludes the first of the three arcs of the story. Next chapter "Wheels of destiny" will be published on August 31th, so keep an eye open, we are quickly arriving to the true plot of this story.
Thank you so much for all your support and until next time! Be good.

Chapter 6: Wheels of Destiny

Chapter Summary

"Walk me to our chambers, will you?", she asks Adora. She grips Adora by the arm, grip just a little bit too tight. Catra keeps looking around them, face stone cold that doesn't let anything slip, but Adoras knows her better.

Adora takes both of Catra's hands in hers, calling for her attention with a simple tug. "Catra what is happening?"

"I believe there is a traitor. In Camelot"

Chapter Notes

Hello Hello! And welcome to Arch II of our little adventure “Courage”. As I said previously we are so close to the peak plot of the story and I can’t wait for you all to read what I have planned.

As always, potential implicit scenes are marked with ***** to be easy to skip.

Worth to say this story is not beta read and English is not my main language. I apologize for any probable grammar mistakes
See you at the end!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Arc II. Courage

CHAPTER 6. Wheels of destiny

SUMMER

But dreams come through stone walls,

light up dark rooms, or darken light ones,

and their persons make their exits and their entrances as they please,

and laugh at locksmiths

— Sheridan Le Fanu, *Carmilla*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x

❀

The world starts to fall apart in the first week of September.

They should have seen it come. The makeshift peace that had been gifted to them after the defeat of Hordak was temporary, a needle falling frozen in momentum before crashing against the floor with an acute ring. Still, people hope. They hang on the loose strands of joy before darkness consumes them whole. Villagers, refugees, knights, soldiers, they all roll with their lives with their eyes fixed up and their hearts trembling. The regents of the seven kingdoms come and go, working hard to keep their people safe and protected in the middle of a war. Still, they don't see it come.

Camelot's king and Queen bore themselves to the bone for their people. They all can see it, the dark bags, the expecting eyebrows furrowed in confusion, the tight sighs of relief when another day passes and everything is alright. They see the kind words and their helping hands. The king's pants drenched with mud from where they helped the farmers, the queen's hands calloused from her she harvested and built safe corners around the kingdom. The people see it all. But they also see the softness, the gentleness in their touches. The loving looks, the caresses on cheeks and hands, the laughs and jokes and loves. It's refreshing, they don't notice it but their love is healing, creating. The crops have never been fullest, the weather never that perfect, the kingdom never that golden. Their love spills from each other and pools down and into the cracks of the earth, to the very heart of Albion and out again in the brightest of magics.

Maybe this is why they don't see it coming. Their love shines so incandescent that drowns anything else.

It's around mid morning when Adora slips out of bed, bare feet jumping lightly over the cold stones of their chambers. Her hair is longer now, longer than it has ever been, hanging just above their hips in gold locks. Adora would have cut it by now but Catra likes to sit behind them for long minutes and braid it all away from their face until it falls on intricate patterns over their back, silver rings attached to it that make it look regal and practical.

Adora looks around the room, spotting their day clothes folded over the chair next to the fireplace, tippy toeing all the way there to pull up undergarments, pants, shirt, a long red coat that protects them from the soon to come autumn air. Behind her and still in bed, Catra rolls across the mattress, nuzzling in the lukewarm blankets. The sunset's light paints the bare skin of her back in oranges and reds when she stretches, long spine arching in a perfect angle before falling down with a satisfied huff. Her tail is wriggling excitedly on the sheets and her hair is a complete mess but her cheeks are spotted in red blush and her breath is even as she rests her hands over her sternum. Adora watches her, they watch and watch and keep watching until the last belt is strapped in place and Adora is fully clothed but still barefoot. She takes in the picture that is Catra, soft over the blankets with her eyes half close as the sun enters through the windows. There is a strange tug inside Adora's chest, a tud tud like drums that they have been feeling for the last couple of weeks. Is weird, not bad or unwelcomed,

just weird like Adora was expecting something to happen with held breath. Adora steps closer to the bed, smiling through the sensation.

“You look happy”, they say with a small smile on their kiss bitten lips.

"Well, I am. How did you know?" she smirks, arching one of her eyebrows

"You are purring", answers Adora in a sly tone, the sweet rumble growing in intensity as they point it out.

"Uh? Oh" Catra smiles, open and bright. She lays with her head at the foot of the mattress, arms open, tail moving happily. Adora walks towards her head, kneeling in front of that side of the bed and into the ground. This way, Catra is looking upside down from her side, pointy teeth flashing when she sees them. Adora slides the tips of her fingers across her nose, caressing the freckled skin with light touches. Catra scrunches her nose, giggling.

"You are my best friend, you know," murmurs Adora, smiling fondly to her. The corners of their blue-gray eyes narrow when they smile. Catra smiles back, her eyes filling with tears. "I love you"

Catra can't help for the tears to spill free, running through the sides of her head and pooling at the base of her ears as she looks up at Adora. The words are there, at the base of her tongue, tangled on her vocal cords. She wants to say them, she wants to scream them at the world. There is light inside her chest, bright smiles, blue eyes, golden hair, gentle kisses. But there are also flashes of red, cracked faces, black hair, poisonous words. The fear gets the best of her and her throat constricts when she tries to speak.

"Adora… I…"

"I know" they interject, without stopping smiling. Adora angles their head, kissing the bridge of her nose as they always do when Catra is feeling overwhelmed. "I understand it's hard. Take your time. You don't need to say it, I know".

Catra sobs even more. She crosses her arms behind Adora's neck, it's a bit of an awkward pose but it holds her in place close to her. Adora's hands roam over her arm and the soft curve of her belly, soothing her.

"Stay", Catra says in a whisper. Adora hums happily, peppering the left side of her face in butterfly kisses, the little hairs that have escaped her braid tickling her cheekbones.

"I wish I could. But one of us has to be at the meeting. Why don't you sleep the rest of the day?"

"Is not fun without you" pouts, actually pouts Catra, letting go from Adora's neck to throw dramatically her arms to the side. "I can't sleep without you here"

Adora smiles adoringly to her, eyes soft. They chuckle a little under their breath and brush Catra's hair out of her face. "We weren’t sleeping, exactly-"

Catra throws her a pillow, fabric crashing softly against the side of their head and Adora lets go a surprised squeal when Catra rolls and starts to smother them with the pillows again and again, messing up their braids in the way. Adora is still laughing when Catra huffs with mirth and stands up the bed, hips swinging as she reaches the night table and fetches her comb.

"Come on, clotpole, help me with my vest"

Adora helps her put her pants and shirt, tying the ribbons of her purple vest tight on her back as she fixes her hair into something more like tamed waves than a bird's nest. Adora reaches behind her and places a sweet kiss on her neck, getting a bright smile in return and a gentle hand coming to caress their cheek.

There is a large turmoil and then the bells of the castle start to ring violently, the beautiful sounds crashing on themselves with the frantic rhythm. Adora and Catra freeze on their movements, looking through the open window at the confused people below, the sky darkening from gold to pitch black in a matter of seconds. Catra extends her hand blindy and Adora catches it, holding onto each other with a strong grip. It doesn't take much for someone to start banging on their door, quick knocks relentlessly against the wood. Adora is mildly aware of Catra murmuring a command and the doors opening wide. A couple of knights stand outside, helmets barely put, swords drawn, eyes frantic. Sir Juliet is leading them, her usual alway neat hair tangled from where she ran up the tower to give them the news. The bells keep ringing, their acute voices shaking everybody's bodies to the core, hurting Catra's sensitive ears. Adora steps forward, not once letting go of Catra's hand, eyes so cold that they almost look purple.

"What happened?". For the first time since Adora met her, Juliet hesitates, her mouth opening and closing a few times, all the blood of her face gone.

"It's Salineas, your Majesties"

❀

The sky is red, extending over their heads like fallen autumn leaves in the middle of a fire. The regents of Avalon's seven kingdoms observe at the top of a hill, rocks sea-whitened by salt and time. The heavy breathing of their horses is the only sound that can be heard as they stare the destruction at their feet.

Salineas Port is completely destroyed, the gate that separated it from the sea and served as magic barrier has been burned to its foundations. The mermaid statutes are broken in pieces, big leftovers of blue crystal floating sadly with the waves. Behind the gate, the village is burning, heavy columns of thick black smoke rising to the red sky, uncontained and violent. Everything is in silence. There are no screams or cries, just deafening silence and the crack of the palace roof as it collapses on itself and falls into the white sand.

The hood of Catra's cape covers her face and hair, sheltering her of the ashes that fall like gray snowflakes when the wind shifts directions. She holds herself tight to the black horse she is sitting over, taking comfort on the animal's warmth and rhythmic breathing. Next to her, Adora is stone cold over Swift Wind, his blonde hair floating gently from where it

escaped the black hood. His knuckles are white skin against bone for how tight he is gripping the lash and his dark eyebrows are heavy over his eyes, that under the red light look almost completely black. There is raw anger coming out of him, shaking the ground in snaps of electricity and making the grass below the horses' hoofs turn brown and die.

Catra wants to lean in and hold their hand but she is petrified in place, frozen by the smell of burning wood and powder. She feels sick. There is acid curling in the base of her stomach and her throat and she feels tears prickling on the edges of her eyes. So no, Catra doesn't move, she barely can breathe.

Glimmer and Bow are riding their own horses, standing next to Adora. Glimmer skin is almost green, and even if it had taken quite the amount of magic from her to teleport them all here, the dizzy tone on her face has nothing to do with any type of spells. Bow is holding her hand between his, eyes rimmed red and exhausted. To be fair, nobody had managed to get even a blink of sleep in the last day or so. Everyone was exhausted.

Adora exhales and the puff of hot air makes them look like a dormant golden dragon, waiting to awaken at any moment and breathe fire. "What about the villagers? And the refugees?"

"Sea Hawk and his float managed to take Queen Mermista and a handful of survivors away. They have been taken into Brightmoon's grounds already but-" hesitates Sir Juliet behind them, eyes dark and tired "We've sent recognition knights already but there is nothing in Salineas. Not more people, nor bodies. Just nothing" She throws a quick glance to Catra and adds, "There are traces of Shadow Weaver's magic everywhere, your Majesties"

"Goddess", whispers Glimmer from her side, her shaky hand covering her mouth in mourning. Catra inhales sharply and Adora is immediately there, leaning over their horses so they can place a soft hand on the small of her back, soothing her creasing panic with small reassuring circles.

"How did they break through the Gate? It shouldn't be possible", insists Adora, teeth clenched together. Juliet and her knights look uncomfortable, shifting over their horses with low glances.

"It seems the explosion came from the inside. The Horde must have slipped inside Salineas at some point when the refugees were entering too. They set everything in motion. Once the Gate was gone, the army was already waiting to attack"

Catra's ears flicker, mind motioning into thought at the Knight's words. She frowns, looking back at the destroyed Gate with a pensive look. The white marble and stone does seem to have been blown out from the very inside of the city. There are traces of magic everywhere, in the sky in the ashes in the air. The earth speaks to Catra from where she stands, it whispers to her about a single strike of magic, so powerful that the magic crystal of the gate shuddered and then crashed into a boiling blue sea. The magic is black, red like wine or blood or both, thick like smoke over mist. It was Shadow Weaver herself, she got inside the very walls of Salineas and blew the village to pieces. She allowed the Horde army to enter, she stole every single soul she could place her hands over. It was her, her smell stinking everywhere in the fallen kingdom. This is odd, for her to take first hand action. She would usually appear just after the battle had been won and never before, tricking plans and moving threads like

puppets of her wishes. This sudden bold move speaks loudly, but Catra can't be sure what it says. Maybe she was desperate, after losing so many Horde forces on Thaymor' Battlefield. Maybe she was confident, maybe she saw the chance. But it doesn't makes sense, refugees' travels and paths are always a secret, always changing, always held secure between the walls of the Round Table. She shouldn't have known at all where they were crossing through. Unless-

Swift Wind snaps his head to the sides when Adora pulls from the leather reins, turning to face the rest of the Court with a dark expression. Everybody immediately falls into full attention, waiting. There is something about Adora when she is like this. In all her goofines and kindness, there is something in the kind of power she holds when she straightens her shoulders and raises her chin, and suddenly there is a King, standing in powerful glory and rage, voice low and commanding. It's almost like an entire different person except that it isn't. It's just Adora, Catra's bright golden sun, being another part of themself that makes no one doubt when they are King of Camelot.

"We must go back to Camelot immediately. Perfuma, take care of Mermista in everything she needs, please. Anything she wants we will provide it. I'll send tropes with food into Brightmoon to help with Salineas' survivors. Nothing about the war is to be commented outside of the Round Table, our people already know about Salineas and if they know what Shadow Weaver is doing there will be panic. Send for your High Sorceress and Priestess immediately, all the barriers around the kingdoms must be fortified as soon as possible. No one goes in or out of our grounds without being notified and approved. Nobody. We are closing the gates of Avalon".

Nobody complains. Nobody dares to say no or opinion differently. Even if they were to, everybody is too busy trying not to choke in the ashes and the tears to even speak. Adora seems to be vibrating on her white fury, eyes flashing like cutting steel as she addresses everyone. Her gaze roams around each face and then turns back to the Port. Nothing can be done about Salineas now, Catra knows. The Horde had already taken everything they wanted, there are no relics or people to save. Just desolation and silence.

One by one the regents start to turn and ride back into the arcane circle to return to Camelot. Some speak among themselves, some are completely quiet. The defeated feeling had fallen over everyone like a burning blanket. Anger is boiling in their cores and the skies turn so dark the red spills into nothing. They had slipped, felt comfortable in that makeshift peace, closed their eyes to rest a bit too long and now Salineas was gone and everything they had ever fought for was in danger. This hadn't happened in decades, a Kingdom hadn't fallen since Dryl and Scorpion, back to Uther's times. This was a reminder, a slap in the face. A *wherever you are, we are coming. I am coming.*

Catra follows Adora back down the hill. She feel sick, a nauseating feeling coiling in the bottom of her stomach. Her skin prickles everywhere where the fabric touches her and shivers rasp down each bone of her spine with every move. The air suddenly is too heavy, the ring inside her ears too loud and she starts seeing black spots obscuring her vision before she feels herself slipping away. A strong pair of arms catches her seconds before she falls down the horse and when Catra blinks against the dizziness, Adora's face comes into vision. There is worry and low key panic written all over his lovely face and if Catra looks too deep into

their gray eyes she can see the true sentiment buried beneath the king's duty: fear. Adora is scared.

"Catra" starts Adora, eyebrows almost touching each other for how deep they frown. Catra waves her hand slightly but snaps it away when she sees how hard she is trembling.

"I'm alright. It's just the smoke". It's obvious that Adora doesn't believe her, both battling silently with their eyes. And then Adora's look changes as they start fumbling over Swift Wind. Before Catra can protest or say anything at all Adora is already down their horse and jumping over Catra's, gently taking the reins from her cold hands. Catra's back is now resting on Adora's front and she gives herself a second to enjoy it before turning her head a little and scowl at Adora.

The banter doesn't last long. Adora looks at her with such a kind, pleading gaze that Catra's pride dies down immediately like flames in a storm and she surrenders the reins completely into their hands. It's alright, this is Adora, and to be frank Catrad hasn't been feeling exactly like herself in the last weeks, always with her head in the clouds and her stomach in a knot. Adora leans and kisses her softly on the skin of the cheek that isn't covered by her hood, warm breath hitting against Catra's eyelashes.

"Just let me stay close to you, today. Yes?"

And how can Catra deny her, when Adora is all soft touches and kind words and strong presences. She loves her so much, Catra would allow Adora to carry her soul with bare hands down the underworld if she wanted.

“Alright", Catra accepts, leaning completely on Adora as they rife quietly back the arcane circle, Swift Wind following at their side, the ruins of Salineas burning behind.

❀

The room of the Round Table is heavily hot with tension. They’ve been sitting and walking around for hours, planning, tracing new routes, considering provisions, armory. Most Sorceresses of every kingdom had already been sent for, high alerts immediately on after the news of Salineas. Outside of the castle, the town is completely empty. People mourn in silence the loss of the Sea Kingdom, holding to their friends and families with shaky fingers and hopeful looks towards the barrier that has been covering Camelot in soft iridescent light.

Evening is falling, drowning Etheria in oranges and lilacs before the sun sets completely and the night moon rises to join its companion. Adora rests her hands on her own neck, containing a strangled sigh as she looks over and over again at the maps scattered over the table. Their bangs have escaped from the braids Catra had made that morning, falling over their face in soft blonde curls. They swear they can smell the smoke still lingering in the strands and they try to bury the thought again and again. The image of Salineas, a beautiful place full of magic, music and the greatest commerce, a place Adora had run around and met the people of, broken and burning like a candle, in the blink of an eye. The failure hangs rotten and acid on Adora’s shoulder and heart but she can show it, not yet, not with Mermista, stoic smart Queen, now mourning her people and home while Adora was still secure in the

walls of her castle. Adora knows it’s not her fault, it’s nobody’s fault. Shadow Weaver took advantage of their hope of peace, of their efforts of creating something good. That’s how evil works. But still, the feeling of having been doing nothing while Salineas suffered wasn’t an easy feeling to shake out.

Adora’s hand comes up to clean out the sweat forming on their face, fingers brushing the golden circlet on their forehead, as they look around the chamber. Most of the people have already left, taking a few hours to rest, eat and go back to their own kingdoms. Nerves are already peaking, but they can't do more than fortify and wait. Glimmer and Bow are sitting in a corner of the room, going again and again on plans to help the Salineans and rolls of magic spells across their laps. Glimmer's pink wings flutter and stand on point with anxiety and Bow's eyes are red from exhaustion but their smiles are still kind when a pair of knights hands them goblets with fresh water and bread. Adora keeps studying the room and their eyes finally fall on Catra. She is passing the chamber nervously, tail brushing over the floor. Melog had somehow sneaked inside a while ago and is now following Catra everywhere she goes, stuck to her ankles with their bright blue eyes worried. They meow low and reassuringly, rubbing their head on her leg when Catra stands still, seemingly fighting a new wave of dizziness. Adora's heart clenches painfully on their chest at this. She hates seeing Catra like this, unsure and anxious and scared, all covered in layers of strength. The curse of a queen in the middle of the fire.

Adora drops the map on her hands and approaches Catra with steady steps, looking as she takes in their presence when her ears twitch. Adora is by her side in seconds, taking her hand between theirs and bringing it to their lips lovingly.

"Have you had anything to eat today?"

Catra's nose scrunches at the mention of food but her usually sharp eyes are misted and unfocused. "Adora"

"Catra? Is everything alright?" Adora asks, worry drenching their voice.

Catra looks at the few people still scattered in the room, the few knights, some sorceresses. Her ears are pressed together against her skull and locks her arm with Adora’s, inhaling. There is a crease on her eyebrows and her ears, even when folded, are twitching in a way Adora has come to recognize as a nervous tic.

"Walk me to our chambers, will you?", she asks Adora. She grips Adora by the arm, grip just a little bit too tight. Adora is confused, and is noticed, but they just smile small and sweet and nods once. Both spouses walk through the castle, pressed tight against each other. Catra keeps looking around them, face stone cold that doesn't let anything slip, but Adoras knows her better. The tightness on her shoulders falls visible when they reach the safety of their bedroom, even Melog shakes his black mane and climbs to the table to stretch.

Adora takes both of Catra's hands in hers, calling for her attention with a simple tug. "Catra what is happening?"

"I believe there is a traitor. In Camelot"

Adora blinks. Then blinks again. Her voice dies in her throat as she looks at Catra's serious eyes. The words start to sink in as the long seconds pass by. So close to her face Catra can see the paleness on her cheeks, the red rim on her eyes, but her eyes are hard, steady and sure. She has been thinking about this, probably since even before Salineas fall. Still, the thought of danger, of treason, of evil right inside their home is hard to digest, hard to not be afraid.

"Wha- what do you mean?" Asks Adora and her voice breaks in the middle without being able to stop it. Catra's eyes spark with inner fire yet her hands are gentle as she guides Adora into the table's chair. She walks from side to side in front of her, the pads of her foot soft over the stones. Melog sprints and curls over Adora's lap and their mane is purple and red, a clear mirror of Catra's feelings.

"Think about it, Adora. This is abnormal, it doesn't make sense. Refugee routes are a secret between the regents and the knights and generals are told about them until they are about to leave. We were supposed to use that secrecy to protect our people and yet, somehow, the Horde found their way between them and used it to take Salineas down from the very inside" her tail is crisped and their ears alert over her head. Adora watches her in silence as she keeps talking. "This wasn't a random attack, Adora. Salineas is Etheria's primordial food resource, is the center of all our commerce, merchants passage, barter. With Salineas fallen the resources are going to be extremely limited, specially with so many people inside the very kingdoms. They are caging us, Adora"

"Plumeria is still strong, and Halfmoon's crops were excellent this year Catra" offers weakly Adora, but they already know the truth behind those words and so those Catra.

"I know. But the routes we used to provide all that food to the kingdoms forcedly required to pass through Salineas. The new routes that we planned are too exposed, too far away. We are bound to have problems with thieves or even more attacks. It was war yes, but it was also politics. Someone knew the harvest season was over and they blew out Salineas before the food was shipped. Someone knew how to enter Salineas without being detected. Someone knew when to attack".

It makes sense. It all makes sense. Adora lets her head fall over her hands and a deep sigh escapes her lips. Catra stops her frantic walk in front of her, resting her hands over Adora's.

"I don't think Thaymor was random either, Adora. There is a reason why Shadow Weaver didn't attack with them and that's because it was a test. For us, for our army. They expected losses on their forces. These months peace wasn't a retreat. They were waiting."

Adora lets out a harsh sight, trembling slightly on Catra's hands. Catra kneels in front of them, gently parting Adora's hands from their face. Her eyebrows are knitted in concern. "Adora? Talk to me, love"

Adora tries but all that comes out from their mouth is a shaky breath. Catra cradles their face between her palms, rubbing circles under their eyes. "This is not your fault, Adora. This is nobody's fault. Shadow Weaver has been living for a long time, she is smart", her voice quivers a bit at her mention and Adora places their hands over her hips to ground her. "But we are smarter, Adora. And we are together. And while we have that, everything will be fine"

Adora nods, slowly, and allows their foreheads to rest against the other. The fire on the chamber crack and Camelot is in silence. Dark clouds hide the moons from sight and not a single star outside their bedroom can be seen. Tonight is for mourning, tomorrow is for action. Adora raises her hands and rubs them along Catra's upper arms. Her gray eyes are sad and concerned, and Catra knows the guilt will hang over their head for a while. That's just how Adora is, as much as Catra tries to convince her otherwise.

"We need to tell the rest of the Table", offers Adora but Catra is already shaking her head.

"No". Adora frowns, confused, to which Catra holds her even more tightly, speaking with her eyes.

"You think the traitor is a member of the Round Table", finally understands Adora and the sheer panic of this implication brings their world upside down.

"Yes. I don't- You know these people Adora, you grew up with them. But it's the only explanation" she rubs her fingers on the back of Adora's hands. "We need to be careful, and we specially can't let them all know we've come to this conclusion. We don't know what they have planned."

"So what do you propose?", asks Adora, hanging to each word of her wife. Catra is a blessing. Adora would truly be lost without her.

"I have an idea. There is someone that can work for us under the water, maybe with their help we can uncover what is going on. It won't be easy, this is dangerous. All of this is so dangerous, but I think we can do it. I'm sure of it"

Adora nods in acceptance, immediately trusting any of Catra's idea. Whatever she needs, whatever she thinks, Adora is by her side. She shudders still when she thinks about this, about not trusting the people that are supposed to be their family, over the thought of someone that is supposed to be their friend stabbing them in the back. It breaks Adora's heart in pieces.

"What about-" Adora starts, unsure, but Catra's gaze is gentle and patient. "What about Glimmer and Bow?"

Catra's eyes harden and Adora feels their heart shattering a little bit more, but then she seems to relax in Adora's hold and she, miraculously almost, nods. "Yeah, yes. I think we should tell Sparkles and Arrows, as long as they keep their mouths zipped too"

Adora's eyebrows disappear between their bangs when they widen their eyes and they can't hold back a relieved silly giggle to escape out. "Have they gone into your skin, then? Told you they were nice"

Catra rolls her eyes and huffes but she answers Adora's dumb smile with one of hers. Her eyes are still and always serious though. "Is not that, I just- I feel good about them, *goddess if you tell them this I swear Adora,* I think they are safe", she throws her shoulders back as she stands up wiggling on her feet a bit. "I have a good feeling about them"

Adora stands up too, kindly helping Catra stay steady on her feet. There is a tug on their soul at that moment but Adora tucks it down inside their heart because if they look too far into it may break them both. Catra's eyes unfocus for a second and then she flushes, her mind snapping into reality just as Adora. They look at each other in silence for a moment without saying a word. None of them move until Melog jumps down Adora's chair and between them, rubbing their head on their legs as they meow. It helps to bring them back into the present and Adora bends a little to pick them up into her arms and cradle their fur. Their mane is back to blue and pink and that's enough for Adora for now.

"Let's have dinner with them tonight", offers Adora to Catra, referring to the Brightmoon's regents. "We can eat here and will talk about it. What do you think?"

Catra's ears flicker and she smiles, nodding. Her face is pink. Outside, rain breaks loose.

❀

Glimmer and Bow are shaken when they break the news to them. They don't need proof, the thick column of smoke that still raises in the sky even miles away is enough. Both sit quietly and listen to Catra's conclusion with wide eyes and mouths pressed tight. Yet their faces are kind and understanding when they look at her and Catra is grateful for their trust, honest and palpable and real. Adora stays by her side the entire time, eating in small mouthfuls of the stew and giving long gulps on water. Their face looks better, with more color on the peach cheeks. Their expression is still shattered by shock but their eyes are warm steel, already cooking plans and strategies behind them. Catra's chest swells with pride every time she sees him this way. She knows how painful and heavy guilt can hang out of Adora's neck, yet he has become kinder with himself, less strict. They open themself to help, to allow themself to be helped, not only give it. Even in the midst of war, seeing Adora grow in himself like this is one of Catra's greatest prides, greatest loves.

Catra plays with her fork on her plate of food, lightly scowling at it. It's her favorite, well cooked salmon with rosemary, fresh bread and baked potatoes. Yet she can't bring herself to take even a bite of it. It tastes...wrong, not bad it's delicious, but for her it tastes wrong. Everytime she tries to eat her stomach turns into knots and her heart drums in her throat. There is also a light headache at the base of her nape and her cheeks feel a tad too warm. She distracts herself by drinking small gulps of water and taking little bites of the center of the bread. Catra looks around the table at her friends, lips pressed together. Glimmer and Bow are discussing strategies and possible spells to reinforce Camelot's barriers and tract the traitor. Melog jumps from chair to chair, tickling them on the arms with their whispers and tail. When Catra turns to look at Adora, he's already looking back at her, gaze falling to her plate and back to her eyes. There is concern in the silver of their eyes and Catra reaches for them and holds their hand, squeezing lightly. After everything that day has brought them to all is understandable not having an appetite. At least, that's what Catra tries to convince herself with, making an effort of ignoring how her hunger had been all over the place lately.

Glimmer shifts on her seat, lowering her glass delicately over the wooden table. It's still raining but her soft voice is well heard in the privacity of the chambers. "This person you want to ask help to, Catra, are they trustworthy?", her eyes are tired, it hasn't been easy to

wrap her head on the idea of a loved one betraying them all but she and her husband had taken the truth with nothing but bravery. Catra smiles at her even though her eyebrows are knitted together.

"I've known them since childhood. They are very talented and like to put on a show even if most of the time they work for money and they are sometimes kind of an asshole" Catra bites her lip, toying with the hem of her handkerchief. "But I think they will be up to help, even if just for the thrill of it all"

"So they are your friend", concludes Glimmer, smirking gently. Catra feels herself flustered, the edge of a banter in her tongue, but in the end she just exhales in surrender, rolling her eyes.

"Yeah, I guess they are"

The four of them try to fall into easy themes but the weight of the day is too heavy over their tempers and by the time the food has been eaten, or pushed away and for other day for Catra, and the candles in the table are halfway consumed, Glimmer and Bow's eyelids are already half closed by exhaustion and they lean even the slightest against each other. They agree to meet early the next day, they still have to figure out how to raise stronger protections around Camelot anyway, and both pairs say their goodbyes in soft whispers and even softer hugs. Catra hears their rhythmic steps walk down the stairs of the tower and is only then that she allows herself to bend over the door and breath deep and away all the anxiety. Being inside the warmth and comfort of their room brings her the only sense of safety she can feel in those moments. Melog rubs their little snout on her hand and then slips inside Adora's studio where they like to curl and sleep on most rainy days, away from the damp air and closer to the heating crystal lamps there.

Adora is gentle that night. She always is, no matter if she's kissing sweet paths over Catra's skin or holding her down with steel grip, there is always gentleness on the way they touch and look and hold and taste her. But that night is even more, it pours out of Adora's pores in reverent caresses across Catra's skin and honey words whispered in her ears. In kind hands parting her legs and long fingers tangled together over silk hair. And after, Adora holds her over their chest, calloused fingers rubbing absent figures on her back and belly again and again. Her gaze is locked on the constellations on the ceiling, eyebrows furrowed as they dive deep into thought. Catra has seen him like this before, lost inside their own mind, and she knows better than anyone to wait patiently until she comes back on her own terms. But Adora stays quiet the entire time, even after they sigh loud and heavy, even after they snuggle closer to Catra and bury his nose on her damp hair. Adora stays quiet.

It's alright, Catra is more than content to cuddle next to her wife and snooze off into a comfortable sleep on their arms. Catra is already mostly asleep when she opens her eyes again, wriggling kind of uncomfortable on her spot in bed.

"Adora?", she whispers just in case they have already fallen asleep. Luckily Adora's caresses resume immediately, stirring next to her.

"Yes, love?". Their voice is somehow even softer than their touch and Catra feels like her heart is going to run away down the stairs in loops. She turns a bit on Adora's hold, facing

them in the darkness of their room, lilac light barely illuminating their factions. Adora’s little smile just grows in sweet confusion when they see the pout on Catra’s face.

“Darling? Are you alright-“

"I'm hungry". Adora’s eyes wide in surprise. They stare at each other for a few seconds, Adora confused and Catra pleading.

"Do- do you want me to bring you something from the kitchens?" Catra nods. Adora’s eyes go impossibly bigger as she wiggles into a more sitting position, bringing Catra along with her. Their voice is careful as they speak. "Okay- Um. This is new"

"I know. I want chicken"

Adora in all honesty sputters, eyebrows skyrocketing and losing into their bangs. Catra waits patiently for their brain to catch up. "But you don't like chicken"

"Adora", simply says Catra, an almost dangerous tone slipping into her voice. Adora chuckles nervously, throwing their hand up in a surrender motion.

"Chicken it is. Alright, alright, I'm going", complies Adora, standing in a rush from bed and sneaking into their blue coat quickly, tripping with their own feet all the way. They look kind of ridiculous, with their blonde hair a mess atop of their head, barefoot over the floor and only their luxurious coat covering them from the night. Catra chuckles from her spot, nuzzling into the warm pillow Adora had left behind. Adora stands next to the bed in a dazzle, admiring the silhouette of the love of her life tucked in white blankets and wild hair. Catra smiles brightly at her, the hint of a tease on her fangs when she speaks.

“ ‘Dora”

“Hum? Oh yes! Chicken", Adora squeaks, snapping back into reality and rushing across and out the chamber, the high pitched ring of Catra’s laugh following her behind.

❀

Adora slips out of their chambers very early in the morning. She kisses Catra's forehead gently, earning a lovely sleepy smile in return, and walks swiftly out of the tower. When Catra wakes up the next time is a few hours later, the sky turning pink with the rising sun. The smoke from yesterday has dissipated completely, leaving only blue skies and lilac clouds. Catra stretches on the mattress, standing in unusual wobbly feet and approaching the dresser.

She feels sensitive today, everywhere. On her neck, her arms, her chest, the swell of her breast, the curve of her sides, tiny goosebumps that travel through her every time the fabrics touch her. It has nothing to do with their love making last night, it's a new feeling Catra has been getting used to in the last weeks. She brushes her teeth and stands in front of the mirror, looking at her on the smooth surface with an unreadable expression. She has thoughts, she's

been having thoughts for the last weeks. She hasn't dared to breathe life into them more than a fast glance but Adora has noticed too lately.

Catra shakes her head, slicking all her hair back. *Later,* she thinks, *Just a few more moments of blissful ignorance.*

The corridors of the palace are quiet though most of the staff is walking around, doing daily chores in silence. Catra steps out of the tower and looks around at the place. Adora said they were going to visit the barrier limit today but she doesn't really know where exactly they went. She walks without course for a few minutes, only the sound of the steps over the carpet as her companion. The sky is clear but the day looks gray and cold, making her shiver under her fine clothes.

Catra walks a few meters more, crossing the corner on her way to the stables when she comes face to face with Bow and Light Hope. The King wears a heavy pink coat over his white cropped shirt and his thick hair is even shorter now, probably cut the night before. The single drop-pearl earring on his ear shines with the light of the day and catches on the gold details of his vestiment. He seems surprised to find Catra roaming around the castle but his face immediately melts and he steps forward.

"Catra, hey. Adora said you were resting", he raises his arms slightly, a silent question in his eyes and Catra somehow complies immediately, stepping closer and letting him embrace her gently in a quick hug. Over his shoulder Catra can see Light Hope expression, stone as always between the black layers of her tunics. She looks tired today and Catra realizes maybe she is not as cold as she has been thinking. Light Hope doesn't speak, but she does address Catra's presence with a swift nod of the head.

"I'm heading to Glimmer and Adora's, they are already checking the barrier spells", says Bow when they turn apart.

"The Mystacor Sorceress are here?" wonders Catra, tilting her head. Bow nods in affirmation, scrunching his nose.

"They arrived a little bit before dawn. Castaspella is with them too" Catra looks at Light Hope, still stiff and far away a few feet away from them. She doesn't add anything.

"Alright", accepts Catra, looking back at Bow. "Let's go"

Bow smiles and starts walking in the opposite direction, talking to her in a low voice about his new achievements with Prince Entrapta. Catra takes a big brave step and hooks her arm on his, causing him to stumble on his words and look back at her with surprise painted all over his eyes. Catra resolutely doesn't look at him back, tightening her hold. She turns her head towards Light Hope, who has started to walk away from them in ghostly silence. The sad black silhouette brings Catra memories. Standing in a courtyard full of snow, leaving flowers on her mom's grave, cold nights weeping in her room. Of her mother roaming the corridors of Halfmoon, no jewels or candles, just the curve of her sorrow after losing what was loved. And Catra remembers that they aren't the only ones on losing something, someone. As much as Light Hope seems apprehensive of her, as much as she is inexpressive and pragmatic on everything, Light Hope loved too once and lost too once.

Catra bites her lips, fang catching on the skin, before calling out for her in a high voice. “Lady Light Hope”. The latter stills on her tracks, turning back at the Queen with a questionable gaze. “Thank you, for everything you’ve been doing so far” continues Catra, “I know we don’t get along, but Adora really appreciates it and so do I”

For the first time since over a year, Light Hope shows some kind of emotion: Surprise. Next to Catra, Bow looks at the exchange with a shocked expression and something that almost looks like pride. Catra would scowl at him if she wasn’t busy. Light Hope seems to recover on those seconds, shaking her shoulders before speaking.

“Of course, Queen C’yra. Anything for Camelot”. Is not exactly a warm loving answer but it’s a beginning and Catra takes it.

Light Hope turns once more and disappears among the shadows of the opposite corridor, not even a sound left behind. Catra allows herself to sigh and it is then that she notices that Bow’s eyes seem to almost sparkle. Catra flushes under the attention, shifting on her feet.

“What?”. The cute expression on Bow’s face melts a little and his eyes turn softer. He still holds steady Catra’s arm around his.

“I can really see why Adora loves you so much”

Catra feels herself turning red from head to toe and she can’t help but growl under her breath, snapping her sight everywhere but to him. She hears him giggle a little and she prickles him gently in the arm with her nails as a not so serious warning. “Whatever, Arrows. Just take me to Adora already. This whole feelings-thing is getting me dizzy”.

Bow laughs the entire time as they walk to the very limits of Camelot, to the north where the mountain's shape is clearer and the clouds are almost touching the ground. He holds it together for the first part of the travel, almost sweating on his effort of not giggling, but after the fourth time Catra trips with the flower's stems that grow every time she takes a step on the ground, he breaks down and lets out a squeaky cackle that calls every person that is walking by attention. Catra scowls at him every time but not even her menacing hisses make him stop and by the time they reach the group of people gathered in the barrier, his cheeks are colored with mirth and his black eyes sparkle.

Adora catches a glimpse of them first, jogging next to them in quick steps. It's cold up there and so her cheeks are spotted in red and her lips are chipped for the dry air. The white coat they use today is long enough to brush their ankles with a thick wool shirt underneath that keeps them warm enough. The simple braid they have on today is a little bit in disarray from the strong wind but their smile is wide when she looks at them jump the last few stones and arrives at the meeting point.

Catra sighs in relief, shooting forward and definitely ignoring the myriad of flowers that bloom beneath her feet, so she can throw her arms around their neck and kiss them right in the mouth. Adora makes a surprised sound, something between a squeak and a hum, and returns the kiss just as excited, draping their arms around Catra's middle and lifting her lightly from the ground. Catra is aware that they are surrounded by.people, sorceress, high Priestess, Glimmer somewhere, an Bow is still standing awkwardly behind them, but while

the kiss last she doesn't mind them and when they part from each other Catra only uses the impulse to snuggle in the crook of Adora's neck and purr gently there.

Adora breathes a soft sound out of his throat, placing his hands on Catra's back and rocking them together very slightly from side to side. "Good morning to you too", and then is an even lower voice, just for Catra's ears, "You are in a very interesting mood lately"

"I missed you", complains Catra as only explanation, ear flat against her head when she scowls at herself for her own words. But Adora just smailes, burying their face in her hair.

"I missed you too. The whole three hours" they joke. Over her shoulder, Bow smiles kindly at them and then scatters away in search for his own wife, a sprint on his step. Adora looks down the hill they just walked in, taking in the path of the newly formed tulips so high they brush their knees. "What's with the flowers?"

Catra low key growls against her neck, tail puffing in annoyance. "My magic is out of control lately"

Adora frowns, gently separating from their wife to look at her in the face. They brush their hands over her face, feeling the way her forehead seems to be just slightly warmer than usual. "Maybe we should see a physician"

"No. No" denies immediately Catra, big eyes flashing with discomfort and something too close to fear. Concern washes thicker on Adora's chest. "I'll manage"

"Catra-"

"I'll tell you if it's too much, alright? Promise", Catra takes a hold of Adora's hands on hers, squeezing the calloused fingers against the soft pads of her own. Adora seems doubtful, hesitating on their place. Finally, after a few moments, Adora nods slowly, eyebrows still scrunched as they look at Catra from head to toe. Catra feels heated, flustered in a way only Adora's stare can make her feel, so full of unabashed love and reverence and even desire. She blinks slowly back at them, nudging them with her hip as she nods at the barrier.

"How is it going?". Adora looks like she is coming out of a dream, weighing the question before answering with bright excitement.

"Excellent. Come see"

You can't really see the barrier. Is a colorless thing, a wall of pure raw magic that surrounds every single one of Camelot's lands, hiding it from the direction and gaze of any other that walks by. The main path, that arrives at the gates of the kingdom, is the only way to actually access Camelot. And even that path is hidden away by its own magic, allowed only to the people who already know where it is and royal members of the court. Catra looks at the expanse of the nature around them, green pines that grow tall to the sky, thick clouds that weigh heavy over their heads with a damp feeling, clean cold air, the shadow of the high North mountains showered in fresh snow.

There are groups of people scattered each few meters from each other, their long silver and gold tunics shimmering with magic. Catra and Adora approach Glimmer's group, who has the sleeves of her dress rolled over as she studies a piece of paper in front of her. Catra approaches the barrier, where the hum of magic is a strong pull in her soul. She extends a hand to it, unsure, until her fingers touch something solid and invisible and suddenly the air shivers and the barrier starts to color in soft purple waves where she touches it. Catra can't help but laugh, marveled in the trum of magic that runs from her arm to the barrier and back. This is old magic, sister to her own, born from druids and nature itself and it doesn't take much imagining Merlin himself raising the barrier around the kingdom, Albion's force on it's whole splendor. When Catra turns away from it she sees that the group is looking at her in silence.

"It's great" murmurs awkward Catra, rubbing her upper arm.

"It is" Adora looks halfway surprised, halfway completely in love. "It seems to like you"

Catra shurges, resting it from importance. "It's similar to Halfmoon's magic" she draws closer to them all, distracting herself from their gaze by peaking into Glimmer's scroll. "So, what's the plan?"

"Glimmer designed a new protection spell. It will fortify the barrier from attacks and other undesired eyes. After this only Camelot's court members will be able to grant any kind of access or leave. It seems kind of harsh, but it is what it is for now" explains Adora, running his finger over the intricate arcane circle on the paper. Catra blinks at Glimmer, arching a perfect eyebrow at her.

"Designed?" She teases, smirking. Unsurprisingly, Gimmer sticks her tongue to her, flipping her pink and purple hair in her direction.

"Yes, Catra. Designed. I am *good* at it thank you very much". Glimmer places the scroll in tve extended hands of one of the Mystacor magicians. She gets closer to the barrier, walking by Adora's side first and pretty much dragging them with her. "Adora, please stop doing doe-eyes at Catra and stand here for a minute. Everybody else to their place too"

Adora looks apologetic at Catra and goes with their friend, pressing both hands over the surface of the barrier, Glimmer and the other sorceress following at the sides. The barrier reacts to Adora too, soft golden light pulsing on the sport where they touch. Catra looks at them all with newfound interest and she is barely aware of Bow standing next to her to look with equal curiosity. Glimmer looks at Adora and nods, pressing just slightly against the magic wall. The translucent surface glows and then seems to expand. From the hands of each one of them grows the same symbol on the scroll, only bigger and bigger until they occupy the entire space as they touch each other. The circles sizzle when they draw close and the spark at the meeting, the entire barrier vibrating with its force. Catra watches as the barrier shakes, taking solid form for the split of a second until the circles collapse into themselves, sending a myriad of colors that travel the curve of the wall and lose themselves among the heavy clouds. Silence falls again, only broken when the magicians take away their hands and move further the barrier. Catra releases the air she didn't notice she was holding, marveled.

"Wow", whispers Bow, just as shocked.

"Yeah", she answers back, not once taking her eyes away from Adora, who seems slightly out of breath. When Adora comes back to her side, taking her hand again, Catra can see the shine of sweat between her eyebrows.

"This takes too much energy from you. I want to help", says Catra. Adora is already shaking their head, brushing her loose hair behind the short fur of her ears.

"It is not much, I swear. It 's just… heavy. Like carrying a heavy rock and throwing it away". Adora rests her hand on her side as they sigh, a strange look on their eyes. "I don't want you to force yourself too much".

Catra frowns, catching Adora's nose between her fingers and pinching rather strongly. Adora lets out an indignant " *Ouch!"* and rub the sore tip that quickly turns red.

"I'm not some damsel, Adora. I'm stronger than all of you" Catra growls, offended. Adora raises her hands, flinching.

"I didn't mean that! I know you are! I just- I don't know" Adora and Catra's eyes battle silently. Most people are already far away, getting ready for the next shot of spells, it won't be long for them to call Adora back. "Please?"

There it is again, the hidden words none of them dare to look too much into. Catra feels the skin of her back brizzle and the fine hair of her arms stand on point. Adora also looks like she is going to sprint out of her skin, breath held.

"Alright" finally gives up Catra between clenched teeth, face unhappy but understanding.

"Thank you", exhales Adora, relieved, and he leans forward to gather her into his arms, squeezing gently her shoulders. "You can stay as long as you want, we have to go through the entire thing so it’s probably going to take the entire day”

Catra parts from their embrace with flopped shoulders, tugging from Adora’s braid on her way. “I have to check up through a ton of armory scrolls anyway. I might as well do that now. Maybe I’ll ask Light Hope’s help after all”

Adora’s eyes widen almost comically making such a dumb expression Catra snorts. “Don’t look so happy. She has a very antique way of handling politics, can’t promise we’ll come out unscarred”

But Adora is already beaming at her, rubbing her hands over the skin of the back of her hand. “Doesn’t matter, or we'll. It does matter, but I’m glad you are trying”, the edges of her eyes turn down, nostalgic. “She is not that bad. Just a bit thick to get with”

“She is a statue”, murmurs Catra knowing the laugh that it will bring from her wife. Adora pokes her in the forehead, pouting.

“Come on, don’t be like that. You have also a temper, I’m sure you are more alike than you think”

“I highly doubt it Adora, I do have blood through my veins”

Adora is about to pick up the tease but Glimmer shouts her name, highly annoyed and menacing, from down the hill, urging her into position once more. Adora waves her arm back, turning to Catra to kiss her one more time in the lips. “Gotta go now. You staying?”

Catra wants to but she can see a knight approaching her at rhythmic speed, bowing down once they reach them. “Queen C’yra, there is someone here to see you”

“Someone?”, questions Adora, unsure, but Catra shakes her head, reassuring.

“Most probably the letter I sent”. Adora’s eyes shimmer with understanding and she nods, leaning for *just one more kiss* before jogging right back into the group, ignoring Glimmer’s snarky protests in order to shoot a beautiful smile at Catra.

Catra answers in kind, dropping her arms to hug herself as she watches them go. There is a sudden rush of air and a sultry voice in her ear as the newcomer knight whispers at her. “She is sweet. I guess my acting did was off that day, *kitten”*

Catra hisses and jumps, rolling on her ankles so she can face them completely. The knight blinks and their eyes change, turning into reptilian greens and a sly smile full of pointy teeth. Catra balls her hands in fists, holding herself back from crawling them in the face.

“Do you get satisfaction from doing that?” she barks, angry. Double Trouble only cackles, throwing their head back in amusement.

“You’ve always been jumpy darling, even since kids”, they eye her better, arching their eyebrows as they study her. “But now more than ever. Something new you want to break to me?”

“What about your nose?”. Double Trouble doesn’t even have the decency to look frighten, they just bend over themself and wheezes, slicking all their yellow hair back their head in one swift motion.

“Feisty as ever. Well, here I am, at your service”

Catra frowns at them but composes herself quickly, brushing the fabric of her clothes off any dust that could have cling into her. “About time”

“You send me a letter last night”

“As I said, about time”, Catra insists, crossing her arms. “So, are you going to keep complaining or would you like to know about the greatest show of your life”

Double Trouble looks immediately hooked, slithering closer to her. “Interesting. What is the role about?”

Catra smirks to them, starting to walk back to the castle. “Come with me. We have a lot to talk about”

✾

Adora is already in bed when Catra comes back to their chambers and starts to undress completely out of her day clothes in front of their shared mirror. Adora's muscles are sore after a long day of working and their magic feels spent inside his bones, so he allows himself to fall flat against the headboard of the bed, nuzzled in the cotton sheets and wool blankets as he watches his wife brush her hair out of the moon crown and stretch in front of the fire.

Catra looks...softer, somehow. Adora has been noticing small changes on her body and her temper in the last several weeks. It's not strange for them to pick up these new discoveries, after all, all Adora breathes and lives is Catra, they know her deeply inside out and so, they notice. They are all good changes. There is a newfound lovely roundness on her face, soft curves on her cheeks and lips, and on her breasts and the sides of her body. Her cheeks are always rosy and warm and her eyes spark with the warm light of the crystal lamps or the rays of the sun during the morning. Her hair and fur seems to be softer too, almost liquid silk when Adora runs their fingers through it, and her entire aura in general sparks with warmth and love. Even in the middle of chaos and mourning, Catra looks healthy and happy.

Adora looks at her fondly from their side in the bed and when Catra finishes, they see her walk slowly towards the bed, marveling at the dips on her hips and the stretch marks on her thighs. Lately she had taken a liking for sleeping in the bare, nestling only in the sheets and Adora's natural warmth, purring softly until they both fell asleep. Adora opens their arms to welcome her inside them, laughing when Catra basically jumps into them and cuddling immediately against them, tucking them both below the soft blankets.

"You look beautiful" Adora says to her in a low voice, all the honesty and love he can collect pouring out of it. Catra hums as her purrs start to rise, her tail coming up to wrap itself on Adora's calf and press them closer together.

"Getting soft on me, your Majesty?" slurs out Catra, eyelids already closed. She breathes in Adora's scent, smoke and citrus, relaxing completely inside their embrace. Adora blushes when he feels Catra's breath against his neck, pressing his lips against the bridge of her nose.

"I don't know I just-" stutters Adora. Catra's ears flicker, suddenly alert. "I don't want to be away from you, at all. I feel like I should be protecting you somehow". Catra remains quiet next to them and Adora starts to wiggle on their spot, unsure. "It sounds crazy I know"

"It doesn't" assures Catra, voice very much awake again. She still doesn't look at them directly, burying her face further into their shoulder. "Lately I've also been feeling anxious away from you.

Adora scratches on the base of her tail, blunt nails sending shivers down her legs. Nose still pressed on her hair, Adora sighs. "You smell good. Sweet". He stops to think for a minute and the next time he talks his voice is trembling, almost breaking as the words come out. "Catra-
"

"Not tonight" interrupts Catra. Her voice shivers as she says it and her hold on Adora's waist tightens. Catra's ears fold into her head and Adora holds her closer to him in an instant, trying to brush away the sudden distress with their touch. "Just- not tonight, alright?"

Adora sighs, heavy in their throat, but nods without more words. Catra relaxes, tension slowly slipping out of her shoulders and soon enough she is purring again against Adora's chest, the soft vibrations enveloping them in calm. Adora fixes their gaze on the crystal lamps. They think of the barrier, of the closed routes, of the kingdoms closing their gates and of the columns of black smoke rising from Salineas against a red sky. They think of a woman covered in shadows and of Catra shivering in the cliff of the destroyed Port. She is scared. Adora is scared too.

Adora let's their hands fall from Catra's shoulders down her spine, rubbing circles in the small of her back. It helps them both calm down. No matter what, they are already here. Adora presses their lips on the side of her head, voice dropping just for Catra's sensitive ears.

"You'll be safe here. We all will". Adora hears Catra sniffle gently against their skin. It still amazes them, the way Catra let's herself be so vulnerable around them and only them. Is a side of her only Adora sees and they treasure it so close to their chest it aches. "I love you. Now and tomorrow and at the end of the word. I love you and I'll love everything about you, always"

Catra doesnt speak, but her tail wraps stronger to Adora and her purr increases in depth. The way she presses gentle kisses over their neck speaks loud enough. Even with it all, Adora feels happy, they feel so happy they cry silently as they feel Catra finally drift into peaceful sleep. Adora pulls her closer and watches the lamps burn out, something that feels like an omen floating in the air.

❀

Mermista joins the Round Table again a few days after Camelot is closed down. She coped with sadness the first hours and then rage for the next of the week and it seems she bothered Former Queen Angella until the later literally sent her off from Brightmoon alongside her fiancé-but also-not her fiancé-it's complicated, Sea Hawk.

Nobody really noticed until she stormed inside the War Room with a strong step, brown burrowed and neat blue hair floating behind her like wild seafoam. The rest of the Table only watched in amaze as she stomped to her chair, the funky man with lovely doves eyes glued to her ankles, and demanded to know the current plans to take down the Horde Empire once and for all.

It was a relief for everyone, actually. With Princess Scorpia off in Halfmoon and at least half of the rest of the regents managing their own barriers and armors, the Round Table was almost empty. Only Bow, Glimmer, Catra, Adora, Frosta and Perfuma were sitting there, Prince Entrapta somewhere around the castle toying with new stuff thanks to Bow's own invention room. Mermista focused and, to be honest, revengeful energy was a breath of air into the regents. After seeing Salineas destruction with their own eyes, seeing its Queen standing tall and proud even with all the pain and sadness of her fallen home.

It doesn't take her long to start shooting snarky comments and railing people up the wall and Glimmer feels a new spark of hope blooms inside her chest. With her, the long hours of the

meeting feel like a gush of air and in the next second everyone is standing, stretching their legs, ready to go back home through their own arcane circles or to go look for lunch. Glimmer watches Perfuma run and wrap her lean arms around Mermista, loudly expressing her happiness at having Mermista's bold aura back with her friends. Mermista flushes, complaining all the way, but Glimmer can see the softness on her eyes and the way one of her arms comes up to pad Perfuma's back gently.

Bow is talking with Sea Hawk. She likes to see them chatting like the old friends, and something more in their teenage years, they are. They cheer each other up and after the last couple of days, they really deserve it. Glimmer let's her sigh roam around the room, falling over Adora and Catra pressed together in a corner. After a few awkward not so good months, those two had been glued to the hip the entire time, never leaving the other side and always sharing heavy looks charged with silent words only they both knew. It wasn't difficult seeing the path they sprinted into and it came as no one's surprise when their political join became a love one. In all of Glimmer's hesitation, seeing the way Adora shined with happiness was enough for her. It also helped seeing Catra unfold into a true version of herself. In the way she allowed her walls to crumble down when Adora was at her side and also in the small details that were inevitable Catra's. Her kindness and her mischievousness, her stubbornness and her intelligence. You wouldn't catch Glimmer admitting it out loud, but she had grown to love her too, even if she was insufferable on her best day.

So now Glimmer looks at them with a crease on her eyebrows. They seem off lately, minds miles away from the rest of the room. Glimmer saw Adora's hand sneak under the table to hold into Catra's when the conversation drove into Shadow Weaver. Everything about Adora screamed safety lately, from the way they lean their body towards Catra and the gentle brush of their fingers when they accommodate a strand of her hair back into its place. And on the other hand, everything about Catra screamed comfort, from her straight and proud usual posture to the softness of her eyes and the gentle way she moved everywhere.

Now Glimmer observes as Adora wraps her arms around Catra's waist, resting her back against their front, rocking them slowly from side to side as they look through the window. They are murmuring to each other, soft voices indistinguishable from Glimmer's position. But she can see the way Catra picks in the fabric of her black pants and how she laughs under her breath when Adora whispers a surely terrible pun into her ear.

Their small peaceful bubble breaks when Bow approaches them, calling Adora for their planned meeting with the rest of the knights. Glimmer catches the way Catra's shoulders flop forward when she untangles from Adora but she calms down when Adora bends and kisses her swiftly in the lips, in the back of her hand, saying quick goodbyes before following Bow outside the chamber with matching serious looks on their faces.

Glimmer waves them goodbye too and takes the ruffles of her dress so she can stand up easily. She would use a hot bath and a tasty meal before going through endless political reports already waiting for her at the table of her room. Glimmer groans, stretching until she can hear the satisfying pop of her bones. She is already halfway through the empty corridor, carpet muffling the sound of her steps, so in her defense she doesn't even hear her arrive.

“Glimmer”, whispers Catra from behind her, holding a little piece of her dress between her fingers. Glimmer almost screams from the fright, turning quickly to face her, but the squeal dies in her throat. Catra’s eyes are hooded and shy, tail swishing behind her. It calls Glimmer’s immediate attention, not only for the quivering almost vulnerable tone on her voice but because she called her for her right name and, coming from Catra, that’s wrong.

“What’s going on?” She murmurs back, tugging gently from her hand to bring them closer to the shadows of the corridor. There is nobody coming but by Catra’s posture Glimmer understands she needs the presence of a safe space.

“I need you to help me get something. A plant, actually”, Catra explains, deadpan as she looks directly into her eyes. Glimmer tilts her head to the side, confused.

“A- plant-“ she repeats, almost to herself. Catra doesn’t even roll her eyes at her hesitation and it makes Glimmer frown. “What kind of plant?”

Catra stays quiet, seemingly thinking about it twice, thrice, mortification drawing in her face. “Catra?”

“A barley branch”, she finally barks out. Glimmer stands there, motionless, just looking at each other. It’s so quiet that a pin dropping would sound like a million explosions inside the walls.

“Fucking hell”, eventually swears Glimmer, running her hands across her face. Catra’s ears go flat into her head, she is sweating when she shoots a hand and holds Glimmer’s, pulling them away from her face.

“Just- don’t say anything. *Don’t say anything to Adora yet* . Just- can you get it?” Her eyes are pleading but there is a flash of something strong and nearly thrilled there. “Please”

Glimmer blinks, snapping from the sudden surprise. “Alright. Yes. Absolutely. Fuck” Catra is only looking at her, waiting. “Fuck, alright. Adora will be busy with Bow until late. You go to your chambers and I-“

“No. To yours” says Catra, rubbing her upper arm with her other hand. Now her gaze melts into something more. Something loving. “I don’t want Adora walking in. Please”

Glimmer wants to oppose but she can’t, this is about Catra first, after all. “Okay, you go there and I’ll meet you soon”. Glimmer starts to move away but stops at the doubt that still lives in her eyes. Glimmer places a hand on her arm, magic thrumming between both in a gentle path. “I won’t say anything I promise”

Catra just sighs, relieved. “Thank you”

Glimmer checks for the corridor to be still empty and walks away in wobbly legs, the world suddenly upside down.

--

Glimmer and Catra have been sitting on the hard floor of Glimmer's chamber for the last hour. It's not comfortable at all, but after walking in circles around the table and the foot of the bed, it had been the one place they had both slipped into. Catra is sitting with her face between her knees, tail wrapped around herself, holding the tip of her toes with her fingers as they wait for the long minutes to fly out. Glimmer is flopped besides her, with her back on the side of the bed, legs stretched in front of her. It didn't take long for Glimmer to find what she needed and she was pretty sure Catra would have been able to do this exact same thing countless times already. But she hadn't, almost as if she wanted to push it aside for as long as she could, so she could focus on the imminent war hanging over their necks. Yet, another part inside Glimmer's mind tells her that Catra just didn't want to do this alone.

The barley branch is sitting so in the floor, scarce meters aways from them. The clock is ticking and Glimmer doesn't shoot a glance to it, because if she does it she may just break and Catra wouldn't appreciate that right now. Glimmer risks a look to the woman next to her, all black pants and thick red shirt, hunched over herself as she waits. Curled up like this, she looks years younger.

Glimmer tries to interpret her emotions as best as she can. She is scared, Glimmer notices, but she is also waiting with short breath and Glimmer would swear it's excitement, the one that it's buried all the way down there. Or maybe she is just reflecting her own emotions, because let's be honest, Glimmer is trying to not vibrate with her own nervousness and excitement. These are her best friends, her family. Even when the circumstances that surrounded them were definitely not ideal, this was so much stronger. Not a spark but a full blown fire. Hope. The promise of a brighter future. A beautiful wish.

Glimmer extends her hand and places it over one of Catra's, her right pink wing coming up too to cover her in a makeshift embrace. Glimmer sees the way Catra sighs and her body relaxes just a little. It's been a while now, Glimmer realizes, so she takes a deep breath and turns her head, watching the little plant on the floor, covered in the midday's golden light.

"Catra", Glimmer whispers, voice quivering with emotions.

"Hum?", murmurs back Catra, her breathing deep and cadent, feelings at bay for a moment more. The hold of Glimmer's hand against hers tightens just slightly and her voice is the softest she had ever spoken with when she says next

"You already know"

Catra sighs again, deep in her throat, as she finally raises her head and rests her chin over her bent knees. She looks at the branch too, between tears and a smile locked in her pretty face she says, "Yes. I know"

The barley rests peacefully over the stone floor, golden and healthy, and from its little nobs, the smallest of the flowers are blooming one by one.

End of chapter VI

Chapter End Notes

Don’t ask me about baby logistics, just enjoy the ride!
Little Finn is coming, Hallelujah!

UPDATE: went through your comments and I would like to ease your minds! Catra is happy for having Finn and she is definetly not getting cold feet. She wants to have this baby and with Adora! who is the love of her life! But we know how these characters are, they internalize everything 😅 Actually, Adora and Catra would have found out together that very day if Salineas hadn’t happen but it did (because I love DRAMA) and now their minds are divided between the war so close to home and a possible enemy at their home. But they love Finn above anything else. It’s just a scary situation for them right now. But they are happy! Pinky promise!

Fun fact: barely was utilized for many years, since the times of Egypt, as a pregnancy test given it’s blossoms react with urine, making them bloom. So it’s considered one of the first tests every existed, how amazing is that?!

Next chapter “The sword in the stone” is to be posted on September 14th. Keep an eye open!

Comments, kudos and bookmarks are always appreciated. Be good!

Chapter 7: The sword in the stone

Chapter Summary

> The woman looks at Adora, weighing them with her eyes and her smile fades into a neutral knowing expression. “So it is time”
>
> Adora blinks a few times at her, confused, “Time for what?”
>
> Serenia smiles again and the gesture somehow makes the waves in the water still when she speaks. “It was prophesied a long time ago that the sword would raise again when Albion needed it most”

Chapter Notes

> Hi, welcome! Hope you’ve had a good time on these two weeks!
>
> Last we saw each other we had the news of certain kitten coming, wonder what is going to happen next.
> So! It’s time for another long chapter! Lots of things are about to happen so buckle up everybody, hold your breath and into it!
>
> As always scenes with implicit sexual content are marked with ***** in case you would like to skip them. It won’t affect your understanding of the story.
>
> See you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CHAPTER 7. *The sword in the stone*

I had no answers. I could find nothing to say.

Since I had no words

to bring the woman I loved so much,

I gave her all my tenderness.

— Leslie Feinberg, *Stone Butch Blues*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x

❀

“Catra”

"Shush". Glimmer runs down the staircases behind Catra, the pink ruffles of her dress tangling on her legs, going almost as fast as her. Catra scowls but in her defense she would be going much faster if her body hadn’t gone into an immediate protection state. Now her steps, even if as graceful as ever, are gentler, jumping from stone step to stone step with soft momentum.

It's been three days. Three days of avoiding the Queen of Brightmoon. Three days of hushes and exasperated looks between both. But as much as Catra tries, she just seems to not be able to lose her. A hard endeavor, considering they are living in the same castle and that they have to see each other every day during war meetings. And Catra is just tired, her body is getting used to the new changes slowly, too slowly, and her mind has just been chaos non stop, thoughts spiraling against each other, trying every minute to find bravery. Adora had noticed the sudden change in her emotions, because of course she had, but she hadn't said anything content in just showering Catra in affection and reassurance every single minute of every single day. It made Catra hold back treacherous tears and bite her tongue. She knew Adora was being patient, waiting for Catra. " *When you are ready* " they had said last night between the space in their bedsheets. But she also knew the way their mind was already raising, in the way their cheeks would be pink and their eyes would shine every time they saw her come in, all white teeth as she smiled brightly at her. In the soft, reverent touches she would give to Catra and Catra only. She and Adora would look at each other from their sides of the table, gaze heavy with unspoken words and silent understanding.

And the worst part, the worst most incredibly beautiful part, is that they are happy, both of them. It was something in Catra's eyes, she supposed, because suddenly Adora was a nest of joy, bright at all times, trying to bury the smiles and light of unspoken news below duties and strategies. And Catra was her equal, as much as she tried to be more quiet about it. Catra was so unbelievably, completely, absolutely, incandescently happy she was about to either laugh or cry herself to death. By this point, it was a miracle that nobody else had noticed already.

"Catra!"

"Damnit Sparkles, you couldn't be more discrete if you tried, do you?" hisses back Catra between the tips of her fangs, lowering her voice into something more private. When they get to the end of the stairs, however, Glimmer grabs Catra gently by the wrist before she can slither away and turns her around, resting her hands on her friend’s shoulders.

"Catra", she repeats, softly, searching Catra’s eyes with her own sparkling ones. Glimmer can feel her trembling under her hands and her eyes are wet. "Catra, honey, you need to tell Adora".

"Would you stop, already?" spats back Catra out of pure reflex. The heartbreak in Glimmer's eyes makes her flinch in shame.

"Cat-"

"I said stop" growls Catra, baring her teeth to her. Immediately after her face falls, ears drop down as she squirms in her place. "I'm sorry I didn't mean to yell".

Glimmer shakes her head, rubbing circles on her shoulders. "It's alright, I know this is extremely stressful for you. But Catra, she has the right now"

"Of course she does. What do you think I've been trying to gather the courage to do? Do you think I don't want to break it to her? To see her dumb face when I do? She loves me, she loves me so much I can't hardly believe it" Catra lets out a breathless laugh, clenching the fabric over her chest just above her heart. "And I know she is going to love them so much too. I know she has always wanted to be a mom, to have a family. To have a family with *me* "

Catra huffes and falls quiet. She thinks in the blooming barley branch locked away in their chambers and her heart trembles, both joyful and small. She tries to tamper it down by hugging herself, rocking over her ankles. Glimmer is quiet, listening. "It's so soon Glimmer", Catra is shivering visibly now, shaken by the honesty of her words. "We are in the middle of a *war,* for goodness sake, a fucking dangerous war. We were supposed to wait."

"I know. I understand, Catra. But it happened" Catra folds her ears, her tail tight on her own leg and Glimmer feels a new wave of endearment for this snarky person in front of her, suddenly so shaken by the prospect of being a mom. It ruffles Glimmer's feathers with tenderness. "Catra, listen to me. I know it's scary, but you're having a baby. A *baby* . Yours and Adora 's".

Catra's pupils, before mer black pinpoints, grow at the mention of Adora and the edges of her mouth ease into a tiny smile before her expression falls again. "They are going to be so small, Glimmer. So small in the middle of a battlefield" she looks at her hands, the way her black nails shiver and her sight gets blurry. "Ugh. What is happening to me?"

"You are freaking out and your body is freaking out with you", Glimmer covers Catra's hands with hers, squeezing. She searches her mismatched eyes with a question in her lips. "Catra, what are you really afraid of?"

"I'm afraid of Shadow Weaver", Catra finally admits after a few minutes, voice so low Glimmer has to step closer to hear her properly. "I'm afraid about what she could do, about what she can do. She has threatened my family once before. My mother, my mom- She just, Shadow Weaver made me feel as if the only thing I knew how to do was hurting people. I trusted her and she betrayed me and it took me so long pulling her out of my mind. And with Salineas fallen and the possibility of a traitor among us, I just feel like she is back. Like she is closer than ever." Catra takes a look at Glimmer and the queen's expression is so tender and open she feels confident to keep talking. "I know how stupid it sounds but I feel that the longer I can keep them to myself the longer I can protect them from the outside world".

Glimmer shoots forward and embraces her in her arms. She is shorter than Catra and her wings tickle her in the face when they draw closer. Catra stiffens but Glimmer doesn't push, she just places her arms around her and stays there, waiting for Catra to make the move. The respect in this movement makes Catra's last resolve go away and she melts into her friend's arms. Her magic, before chaotic and anxious, starts to feel calm and peaceful again and Catra

couldn’t bless more the way Glimmer manages her own magic because after three days of being lost on her own thoughts, she feels like stepping into grass again.

"You are loved, Catra.” Says Glimmer into her ear, holding her closer when Catra’s breath hitches in her throat. “It’s not going to be like that time. We are all in this, together. You are not alone, we are your family. And we are going to stand by your side and look for you. Both of you". Catra snuggles closer to her neck and Glimmer smiles. "That’s what we do after all, us best friends, look for each other. Even if I'm aware you are perfectly capable of obliterated everybody on this castle without blinking"

Catra laughs at the absurdity of everything, stepping back so she can clean her eyes and nose with the back of her hand. “Yeah I can. Thank you, Sparkles, I think I needed that”

“Of course. Besides” adds Glimmer, poking her in the side. “That’s my nibbling right there. You wouldn’t think I would let you off without help”.

Catra snorts, bating her hand away, but there is no more bite in her. She drums absently her fingers over her belly, humming. “I am happy, Glimmer. I am really, really happy. Even if I’m a fucking mess”.

“No swearing in front of the baby”, Glimmer laughs with her, placing her hands on her hips and smiling, “You are one of the strongest people I know, Catra. I understand what you are going through, and that this is not the most ideal situation, but you are going to kick the ass of this too. And Adora will understand too. Do you really think Adora doesn't know already? She adores you, And even though you haven’t told her yet, she’s been unnaturally bright the last couple of days. Even for them."

"I know.” Catra sighs. “I know she notices things. She is smarter than people give her credit for. And she is their mother too, so she is at least definitely considering it. I know Adora is waiting for me." she looks back at Glimmer, and her tail curls happily over the floor as it always does when she talks about Adora. “I really got lucky, hum?”

“We are the ones that got lucky. Imagine if you had stayed in Halfmoon all those months ago. We wouldn’t be standing here and with everything that is happening, Adora would certainly be grimmer and just deeper and deeper inside their own head. You saved her in ways I don’t think you understand yet.”

Catra looks close to tears again but she keeps it together, cleaning her throat a few times before trying to speak without breaking. “And all for a rose”

“And all for a rose”, Glimmer helps her compose herself a little, fixing the loose strands of her hair. “I won’t tell you when to tell Adora, but I can assure you, you will give her the best gift in her life. She has always wanted to be a mom and she loves you so much. I don’t think there could be a better way to give her a little bit of hope.”

Catra brushes Glimmer's nose with her tail, making her sputter from surprise, bubbly laughter coming from both of them. But Catra is smiling and she nods, accepting Glimmer's words and love inside her heart.

"Come on, let's get something from the kitchens" statements Glimmer, tugging softly on her hand. Catra scoffs, smirking even as she goes along.

"The oh so powerful queen of Brightmoon, pickpocketing desserts. Scandalous"

"Goddess, that kit is going to be a menace with you as a mother", complains Glimmer, already imagining the headaches. Catra kicks her lightly in the sheer, sticking her tongue out.

"Adora is going to raise them too genius"

Glimmer turns, dramatically widening her eyes and mouth, making Catra roll her eyes for the ridiculous look in her face. "Dear gods"

❀

Catra feels much better after her heart to heart with Glimmer. It may be actually allowing herself to feel, to let all the feelings she had been bottling up finally pour free into someone she could trust. It may be Glimmer's own calming magic, still circulating on her veins and body.

Catra is much more aware now than ever of her own body. All the little clues that had been chasing her and changing her made now sense. She had been in a constant state of denial for so long, it was so strange to get in tune with herself. She could feel her own magic vibrating, multicolor and bright, shining strong and gentler than ever. And if she concentrates just enough, just a little bit more of focus, she thinks she is able to feel them, there inside herself, a spark of life. It's still small, probably not bigger than a small plumb, but she can already feel the soft beat of new magic in there. She absently wonders how they will look, once they are here. They will probably get her ears and tail, maybe they'll have blonde hair or some soft caramel tone. Maybe their eyes will be golden, but she wishes with all her heart for them to be gray-blue, big and round, with eyelashes so blonde they look white. A button nose, tiny hands, soft cheeks, the smallest of the ears. They will look like Adora and like her, how marvelous that is.

Catra looks at the sky outside the windows. It's a new day and everyone is exhausted. People's nerves are on point, the closed up gates of the kingdom don't help to build confidence. This hadn't happened since Uther's times and the memories of the devastating war still hang over people's heads. Maybe a little bit of happiness would be good for everyone, not only them.

" *C'yra"*

Catra stops in her tracks. She doesn't jump or turn or move at all, just the occasional twitch of her ears and the fuzz of her tail. The corridor is empty. She hadn't taken the usual path from the kitchen to her chambers, instead deciding to take a shortcut through the gardens and yes, the foot of the abandoned tower. She hadn't been inside the place since her first months in Camelot, but she couldn't lie on the fact that she had roamed around the place near the tower, peeking through the staircases, walking away on quick steps every time she heard a light noise. Catra wasn't afraid, of course not, but she wasn't kin to weird unknown stuff

either. Yet here she stands, one hand in the small of her belly, the other one in a fist at her side. She holds her breath, eyes closing without her consent.

“ *C’yra”.* The voice calls, closer now than before, right over her shoulder. Catra turns sharply, claws unfolded, fangs shining white and dangerous. There is no one there.

“What?!”, snaps Catra, her voice loud and raspy. It echoes in the empty walls and disappears into silence. Catra hisses menacing and starts walking again, as fast as she can, away from the corridor. She can feel a jolt in the bottom of her stomach and the nausea doesn't wait to make presence. Catra's sudden anxiety makes her arms and shoulders ache, all that calm she had gained from Glimmer slipping out of her fingers. Her stomach rolls and tugs and even the core of her magic shakes. She can't see anyone else but she knows she is not alone. Someone is watching her, someone is following her.

"We are okay" murmurs Catra between her teeth, her jaw clenched almost painfully on how hard she has it closed. The corridor seems to be going on forever and it's only when she starts to see the high candles in the roof that she realizes that, to walk into the library and up her own chambers, she has to forcibly walk right in front of the stairs of the abandoned tower.

" *C'yra".* Catra shakes her head and ignores the call, already distinguishing the door and the few steps that lead to the huge library. She can also see the high black chandeliers with lit candles and can start to feel the warmth coming back to her. She hadn’t noticed how cold it had gotten until now.

"We are almost there, just a little bit more and we'll be out of here. Don't worry". She knows how weird she must look right now, pale and frizzy, hair on point, ears shot to the front in alert and seemingly talking to herself. But the words ground her enough to keep her calm and not run or sprint. She doesn't trust her feet right now. And besides, she is not only murmuring to herself, not anymore. "Let's go see Adora, peanut"

" *C'yra* "

"Leave us alone", hisses Catra, chewing each word with a barely contained growl. The library is right there. But suddenly there is a breeze of freezing cold air and the candles next to her blow out completely, the smoke swirling and dying completely. The glacial void that is the stairs of the abandoned tower face her right on the other side. It’s dark, even though it’s the middle of the day, it looks as if no matter what no light was able to penetrate the thick darkness. Catra can barely see the first steps of the staircase before they lose themselves into the shadows and if Catra strains her extraordinary good eyes just a little bit too much, she thinks she can hear the shiver of a figure moving there.

Tears well in Catra’s eyes at its sight and her breath hitches in her throat. She knows she should probably check it isn’t something dangerous but her feet are rooted in place and she can’t move. There is an intake of air somewhere in the stairs and a tug in Catra’s belly and she bolts up front and away.

“ *C’yra”,* the voice follows her as she gets near and near the door. There is something moving behind her, just beyond her reach. Catra reaches the door and flings it open, stepping into the comfort of the library with quick steps. “ *C’yra, please be careful”* .

The door shuts close.

❀

Adora has been going through so many letters, the pile is almost as tall as him sitting down. The stock, homever, is perfectly organized and structured. Adora had a method, a plan, a strategy to go through so much stuff in the less time they can. Sadly, as much as Adora plans and prepares themself, dyslexia is not always the kindest, and it's been taking him at least twice the time they usually take to go through the papers and scribble long answers in return. Everybody is concerned, everybody is sending letters to the king. Farmers, workers, other kingdoms, village leaders, knights armies.. They all have questions and suggestions and Adora can only groan and push further. Nobody tells you this but being king is so much more than using pretty crowns and swinging a sword. It requires mental ability, social skills, and intelligent moves. You need to know how to act, speak and even look the correct way. And Adora is good at it, Mara taught him well, but they are also more a punch and action person before a scheming one.

Catra is much better at this. She is smart and cunning, always ten steps further than everyone else. She has always quick answers and the determination of a lioness and honestly, if there wasn't an endless war on their ankles, Camelot would be seeing one of its golden ages under her ruling. Not for the first time, hell, not even for the first time in that day, Adora feels their chest puff with pride and delight. Adora can't remember what handling Camelot's reign alone was like and they certainly don't want to remember. Catra does it all with grace, her management of stuff like economics, politics and health security is impeccable. She had sent to build large shelters and storage rooms for food months ago and though in that moment seemed borderline excessive, now it seemed it was the only thing that kept the life inside Camelot afloat and in peace. She had personally taken into supervising the orphanages, visiting downtown two, three times a week. And even though she had let the army stuff to Adora, her strategy of armory management and even magic lessons with the magicats had increased their effectiveness and strength over four hundred percent.

And, on top of that, she still ruled Halfmoon with brilliance and strength. A good deal of her magicats had moved into Camelot after their marriage. Mothers, children, scholars, physicians and fighters, those who she had refused to leave behind after her moving out, who she seeked to protect inside the magic of Camelot. The rest of her Court, politicians, farmers and other workers had stayed or turned back into Halfmoon, and they were those who now helped and protected with the same kindness to the new refugees and wounded. It was a strong charge for Catra, ruling two kingdoms. Adora had helped, since the early stages of their friendship when Catra started to trust him more and more. Adora had traced an entire mercantile route, established the construction of high barriers and strong gates, talked with most magicat generals and organized entire fields of knights practice. Together, Camelot and Halfmoon had become Etheria's pillars. It got easier after Catra named Scorpia Crown Princess. It lifted some of the charge in both of them and allowed them to focus on how to take down the Horde Empire, not only resist it.

Adora flops on their chair, head accidentally banging against the rest, making Adora groan. Their eyes are exhausted and their head hurts a little from trying to make sense of so many

words for such a long period of time so Adora really needs a break. There is a sound like ruffled paper and when Adora peeks at the table she finds Melog sitting right over the letters envelopes. Their mane is a soft shade of pink and they mew and chirp when Adora pays attention to them sitting there. Adora straightens again, coming in to scratch the little cat under their chin.

"Hi, Melog", Adora cooes to them, smiling. This is a great distraction, Melog is always warm and snuggles with Adora, and always without fail helps them to shake the tired mist from their eyes, especially when Catra is not there. "You've been very pink lately. Are you happy?"

Melog meows, loud and high, tail waving behind them excited. It warms Adora's heart, mainly because he knows Melog is connected to Catra's own emotions, and if Melog it's happy it must mean Catra is too. The thought of their wife brings Adora's mind into overdrive again and they lean towards the cat, whispering to them as if they weren't alone inside the chambers. "Do you have any secrets I should know about?"

Melog's purr stops and they look back at Adora with an unnatural serious expression, tail freezing midair. Adora sighs, scratching them gently in the back of the ears. "It's okay, I'm not going to push", Melog blinks slowly at them, waiting, and Adora takes it as a good sign. "I just want to know if everything is fine."

Melog seems content enough with this, purr resuming and tail waving again as they give Adora a quick and very sure nod. Adora smiles tiny at them, eyes soft. "Okay. That's enough for me, I'm happy with that."

Melog must sense the light quivering on their voice because they stand on their back legs and jump to Adora's lap and chest, snuggling next to their neck as they nuzzle the side of their jaw and ears, purring, chirping and meowing in reassurance. The pink tones of their seem to deepen and Adora's arms come up to hold their light weight against his chest. He can't help the small tracks of tears down his cheeks but they are good, warm, even as Melog comed to paw them away with their soft black beans. The tickle of fur against skin makes Adora laugh just like when Catra's ears flick him in the nose. It's great, laughing.

"I'm alright, Melog. I understand her and I'm so proud of her. She is really the strongest person I know" assures them Adora, running their fingers through their back. "I'm happy, seriously, really, really happy. And I'm so, so excited too." Adora's breath trembles. The purr increases even more, vibrating through his lungs and heart. Adora giggles, a bit choken on the tears. "You are such a weird house cat, you know that?"

Melog hits them lightly in the nose with their tail, nails prickling a little as they stretch and then jump off them, swaying back to their spot in the plum cushions next to the bed.

"Are you giving my cuddle rights to my cat, Adora? How heartless of you"

Adora turns, still sittin on the chair, to look back at the door. Catra is standing next to the open door, hips and shoulder leaning over the wood frame and a sly smirk in her lips. She raises her eyebrows when Adora realizes her presence and giggles at their stunned face. Adora just saw her that very morning. They saw her bath and brush her hair and change into

fresh clothes. She had ditched her fitted vest a few weeks ago and got to use loose shirts with large sleeves, half of them that had belonged to Adora in a past not so long ago. Now Adora sees the light that catches in the bracelets that keep her shirt close to her wrists, and the soft fabric of her pants, she looks comfortable and beautiful just standing there.

Catra catches the glint in their eyes and her smirks turn into more of a soft smile, walking the few steps that separate the door from the table until she is standing next to Adora. Adora opens their arms inviting her to sit with her, and she does, except that instead of playfully jumping on Adora's lap like she is used to, Catra sits gently, making herself comfortable over Adora's legs and the armrest of the chair and nuzzling into their neck. Adora's right hand comes up, rubbing Catra's shoulders and back until the oh so familiar purr starts to appear. Adora buries his nose on Catra's hair, blowing with his breath the baby hairs there.

"You smell like peanuts", giggles Adora without thinking. Catra shoves them without real force on the shoulder, smirking in return.

"I stole some from the kitchens with Sparkles"

Adora looks at her with mirth surprise, raising their eyebrows up their bangs. "You convinced Glimmer to commit the crime of a petty thief with you?"

Catra sticks her tongue out, crossing her arms over her chest in mocking offense. "Believe it or not, my sun, Sparkles is so much more of a criminal than you think"

Adora fully snorts now, coming to kiss Catra loud and wet on the cheeks until she groans and pushes their face away with a yelp. Adora keeps smiling, all white teeth and goof smirk, ruffling the fur on her ears. "So you had peanut cream pie"

"Not exactly", answers Catra, snuggling further on Adora's arms but with a slight frown on her lips. Adora thinks for a moment and then tries again, feeling a new wave of giggles push against their lips.

"Was it a jar?"

"It was a jar"

"Okay". They look at each in silence, Catra with a *Don't you dare laughing* look and Adora barely containing the giggles. In the end Adora manages to hold it back enough to guide Catra's head back into their shoulder, shit eating grin widening when Catra can't see it anymore.

"So, no chicken today?"

"Ugh, I hate chicken", complains Catra with a disgusted expression and Adora can't help but cackle out loud.

"Are you alright?" asks gently Adora, after the giggles subside. Catra is a bit tense in the shoulders but she relaxes at Adora's voice.

"Yes" then, to add to her explanation, Catra says, "This castle is so weird sometimes, I'm still getting used to it"

"Yes, it's definitely really spooky when it wants", agrees Adora. Catra seeks to still be tense, so Adora presses their lips into her forehead. "But I assure you nothing here can hurt you. It's just ghosts playing bad jokes".

"I'm not a scared kitty cat, Adora" Catra seems to think hard about it but in the end nods, accepting Adora's words. "But alright"

They stay there for a little while, Catra purring in their arms and Adora brushing off the few knots on her dark hair. Melog has drifted to sleep on their cushing, their breathing slow and rhythmic as they drift into sleep. Catra shifts on Adora's hold after a bit, turning to take in the stock of papers and open letters scattered over the table. She leans to take one, studying it with hooded eyes before she frowns.

"Have you been going through all of this on your own?", she asks. Adora nods, rubbing the sides of their head.

"Yeah, I've been here for a couple hours now"

Catra looks back at them with an arched eyebrow. "Doesn't your head hurt, dummy?"

Catra knows about the dyslexia, of course that's why she likes to divide the papers with Adora and go through them all together. She hated seeing Adora in any kind of pain or discomfort. Adora's eyes go soft and kind in the middle, running their finger over the curve of her cheeks with a soft caress. "It did. It's better now that you are here"

Catra blushes, cheeks coloring red quickly and she hufs. She nestles on Adora’s shoulder, mind zoning out for a good minute. Adora let’s her go through it, rubbing the low of her back in the place where it always bothers her. Catra starts playing with the ribbons of their shirt, sighing deep in her chest. “Can we talk tonight?” she asks, small and shaky. Adora’s surprise makes their breath catch in their throat and when they speak it betrays them, miserably squeaking and making them gasp.

“Yeah. Yes! Yes of course” Adora kisses her forehead, still trying to recover their voice in the middle of a fit of coughs. “Anything you want”

Catra has the nerve to laugh at them, poking Adora in the forehead before sliding out of their arms and up again. Leaning towards the table to study the scrolls. Adora admired her with kind eyes but pressed lips trying not to read too much into the way her body curves and softness, or the way she seems to unconsciously nest her middle with her arms as she reads the papers. Adora blinks back warm tears and clears their throat.

"There's correspondence for you too", says Adora, pointing to a stock of letters in a separate corner of the table. "One of them has the Halfmoon's crest on it"

Catra hums, rocking in her ankles. "Must be Scorpia. She likes to send me weekly reports. I'm sure they would be daily reports if I hadn't convinced her otherwise", murmurs Catra

while picking the mentioned letter, cutting it open with her nails and starting to read.

Adora watches as her cheerful expression falls and sours completely. Her pupils contract as she scans the letters on the papers and her nose scrunches with anxiety. Adora is on their feet in an instant, reaching their wife with careful steps. Catra is as tense as a violin cord, ready to snap in any second. So Adora doesn't touch her, just approaches enough for their warmths to meet and they only speak when Catra's ear twitches in their direction in recognition.

“Is there something wrong?”, asks Adora in a slow but firm voice. Catra's upper lip retracts, fangs flashing dangerously for a second and when she answers is between clenched molars. The veins of her neck pop with tension.

“Fuck. *Fuck.* Halfmoon’s commercial routes closed”, her voice sounds strangled and distant, miles away from them. Adora blinks in surprise, obvious confusion draws in their face.

“What do you mean closed?”

“It seems one of our recognition teams found tracks of Horde squadrons close to the route we use to pass the provisions. The people are scared and the Court is refusing to pass through it until we assure them it is safe.” Catra hands the letter to Adora, not looking at them but to a point close to the door. “The Court is getting nervous. Scorpia says she has a plan but they are simple not listening”

Adora goes through the letter, almost hearing Scorpia's frantic tone on each word. They look back at Catra, a light horrified look on their face. Catra's expression is stone cold now, eyes hardening as the gears in her brain work. A bad feeling starts to coil inside Adora's stomach. “I trust Scorpia, of course, I wouldn't have named her crown princess otherwise, but she has also just been crown princess for a few months and she is not used yet to diplomats. And politicians can be complete fucking assholes"

Adora wonders where all that happiness and warmth they were living in has gone. Absently, Adora wonders if this is how their mother used to feel, torn between her home and her family and the responsibility of keeping them all safe.

“She can’t do this alone”, Catra is still talking, determination drawing in her features like an ice wall. “Adora-”

"I'll go" blurts out Adora. Catra's face goes on a journey as she slowly makes sense of Adora's words. She goes from determination to stunned surprise to fear to sadness to anger, to nothing, cold, calm nothing that falls on her features. Her hands fall to the table, knife cutting nails carving grooves in the dark wood.

"What?", her voice is low and controlled, devoid of any type of emotion and it makes Adora shiver. They almost wish she was angry, yelling and snapping instead of that numb stone tone full of nothing because, somehow, that's less terrifying. Adora is so terrifying of losing her, of losing anyone. So they hold their breath, lungs aching for the effort, and dares to keep speaking, as fast and without quivering as they possibly can.

"I'll go. To Halfmoon. I designed that route, I can help Scorpia create another one and also keep an eye on the Horde"

It seems reasonable. Damnit, it's completely reasonable. Adora is also King of Halfmoon, the routes and security and people per se, everything, is a shared responsibility. Adora knows that Catra's own duty as a Queen is heavy on her, even if she doesn't show it in the same way Adora does. She internalizes it and keeps it inside herself. But Adora is there too, there for her, just as Catra is there for Adora. They are friends, lovers, partners. They share kingdoms, a life together. A family. The more Adora thinks about, the more they are sure this is the right call

"Those provisions are essential, Catra. Our people, the people of Etheria, need that food to keep the commerce running. Scorpia mentions here that she has a plan to pass the route through the Crimson Waste desert. I can help her keep your Court calm so they can listen to her and accept the route. Just that. It will be politics, boring, long politics but just that. No battles, no danger. I'll even take Sir Lonnie and her squadron with me". Adora searches frantically for Catra's eyes, waits for her to see the truth on those arguments and realize it's correct. But this is Catra, most important, this is Catra *about* Adora. They should have seen the fall come.

"No" finally states Catra. It's quick, simple. A single word. She is still refusing to look directly at Adora, eyes glued to the other wall. She is not blinking, scleras turning red with the pressure. She takes a breath, then another, she speaks again with the same monotonous tone. "No. Why do you always have to be like this? Why do you *insist* on putting yourself on the fire line again and again and again and again"

Her lips press together until they turn white and the tip of the fang that always catches on her bottom lip bites down so hard Adora can see it actually drawing out a little bit of blood. Adora steps in, absently raising their hands to avoid her from hurting herself. "Catra-"

"Don't touch me, Adora"

Adora snaps their hands away as if the order had burnt them. It hurts just as much, in their skin and their heart. Adora really has to make an effort to not break into ugly sobs. But they hold on, keeping the raising doubt and hurt at bay. Is in the way Catra is holding herself, like she was stopping her own body from crumbling into pieces. Understand falls on Adora and the tang in the hurt fades away. They do take a step back, placing their hands back and into the table. "I'm sorry. I should have asked"

"No, no. I'm sorry, Adora. You can, it's alright. I just-", Catra is looking at them now, eyebrows scrunched in remorse. She extends a hesitating hand to Adora, unsure if touch or not. Adora meets her half way, now more confident, entangling their fingers together and squeezing gently. The gesture seems to bring back Catra completely to reality because she blinks slowly a couple of times and the stone cold expression melts down into raw worry and forced resolution. "I'm Queen of Halfmoon, this is my job, this is my responsibility Adora"

"I know. I know you are and I know you have all the capacity to do this flawless Catra. This is not about that, this is not me thinking I'm better than you or thinking of you as second best. Just-" Adora tugs softly off her hand, bringing their tangled fingers up to their chest. Catra's

eyes are pleading but so are Adora's, both holding a wordless conversation between the space in the middle. Adora tries to find the words, tangling with their mind and their tongue. Catra is listening, but the resolution still lives in her eyes. Desperation fills Adora and they place a hand on Catra's cheek, lowering their voice until it is nothing more than a whisper. "Let me go in your place"

"Why? Because it's your duty?", says Catra, nuzzling her cheek into their hand. She doesn't say it with bite or anger, it is more of a resigned tired tone that makes Adora ill on their stomach. They never wanted Catra to feel as a duty for Adora, not in the slightest.

"No. Because it's important to you" Catra opens her mouth to talk but Adora quickly places a finger over her lips, quietly asking her to wait. "And because it's important to me too. They are also my people now, Catra. There is duty, yes, but it is so much more than that. I love your people, I love every single creature and magic and stone. I love it all, and I want to help protect it, Catra."

She seems speechless, almost near to tears trying to assimilate Adora's words and accept them inside herself. And she does, oh she does. But there is still so much stubbornness in her. She hasn't changed her mind. Adora sighs, raspy and low, bringing their other hand so they can now cup Catra's jaw between them. It does the trick, the anxiety slips Catra's shoulders even if just a little and now Adora can actually coo her into looking into their eyes and not run away from them. Adora wants for her to see it all inside their sight, honest and vulnerable and real. "Catra, you've done so much for Camelot. So much for me. And now that Halfmoon needs us now you don't have to do it all alone. You look out for me and I look out for you, remember. Please let me do this for us, for our people, for your home."

"You are my home", whispers Catra under her breath, so tiny and vulnerable Adora thinks it wasn't even meant to be heard. Adora brings her in for a kiss, one on her lips another on the bridge of her nose, nuzzling them together. Catra holds herself into Adora's shirt, nails cutting slightly the fabric of how strong she holds it. Adora can feel the fight inside her, the pull and tug in her brain. Adora waits for her patiently, rubbing her upper arms with their hands, rumpling a bit the red fabric of her shirt.

"And the Horde? They were seen close to Halfmoon. What if Halfmoon's location has been compromised? What if they try something? What if this is another Salineas?". But Adora is already shaking their head, parting off her so they can look at each other back again.

"They were seen miles away, not even close to Moon Lake or to Avalon lands. I'm sure, *I'm sure* if they had wanted to attack Halfmoon they would have done it by now, with how vulnerable they think Etheria is after Salineas. They wouldn't just have left it all there without trying something. They are conquerors, Catra, that's how they work. And if I'm there, I'll be able to protect everyone if the Horde as much as tried to smell Halfmoon's limits"

Catra's eyebrow furrow and actual annoyance and unhappiness drifts into her features. "If you are so sure of all this, why do you insist on going alone? Why does it always have to be you?", she holds Adora's hands with her own, a troubled gaze attached to her eyes. "Why won't you just let me go with you"

The way Catra is looking at them tears their heart in the middle. It makes Adora want to accept, to nod and say *Yes, yes, yes. Fall inside my chest and never leave.* But then there is also the feeling of Catra's middle pressing gently against their own abdomen and Adora is trembling, dizzy at the mere thought of bringing Catra outside the security of Camelot's limits.

"Because- because I need you to stay here" Adora feels their eyes go so sad it nearly makes them break into tears. Adora rubs her cheeks with their thumbs, looking at her directly in the eyes. "Catra, I can't- If something were to happen to you on the way there-"

"You'd be sad"

"I would die" breathes out Adora in a broken confession. Catra's eyes fill with tears and a gasp hitches in her long throat. She seems unable to talk at all, Adora is almost unable to keep going. "So please, allow me to do this one thing for you"

There is that understandment between both again, that unspoken confession Catra hasn't said and Adora hasn't asked but both know and finally the fight seems to leave Catra completely and she throws her arms around their neck, flushing them together. She hiccups and sighs while Adora rubs her back, her own tail coming to comfort Adora as well. "It's going to be fine, love. It's not a battle and I'll be inside Halfmoon the entire time"

"You promise?"

"I promise"

Catra tightens her grip, blowing a breath of heavy air out of her mouth. She leans out just enough so she can see Adora directly in the eyes, eyebrows knitted together and expression hard. There is a fire burning bright and consuming in her blue and amber eyes, a spark of life and fight that lives in there and Adora throws themself to those flames, like salted sea logs in the fireplace.

"You need to be protected" says Catra between her teeth, tongue coming out to wet her dry chapped red lips. She grabs Adora's chin between her fingers, not hard enough to hurt but firm enough so Adora's undivided attention is on her. As if it were to be somewhere else. "Listen to me Adora, I need to know you will be safe, that you will have a way to protect yourself. And I'm not talking about pretty swords, and chained shirts, I'm talking about magic, your magic. I'm talking about you using magic to take care of *yourself.* Because if you don't then I will just go straight behind you, Adora, believe me I will, and I will drag your ass back here with my bare hands."

Adora feels like chuckling nervously but they can see the solemnity tin Catra's statement so they just nod, not blinking not tearing their gaze apart from her, no for even a second. Catra looks unsure still, not trusting Adora on putting the laser first. Adora scrunches their nose, thinking, and finally an idea occurs to them.

"Actually" Adora says with a new glint in their eyes "I think I have an idea about that"

❀

The torch Adora holds burns with blue flames, illuminating the path in front of them with soft tones. This way, the infinite stairs that lead down, deep below the castle, look less dark and menacing. Catra holds Adora's hand as they walk down. Her sight allows her to see further, the stone walls empty of tapestries, the leaking ceilings, the slight cold mist around her feet. It almost looks as if it was leading to a dungeon. She can feel the change of pressure the more it goes on and on, both of them stepping out of Castle Grayskull and into the very insides of the earth. The air changes its smell, now heavier, humid, like a field of night burgeons.

Adora hasn’t explained herself, asking Catra to trust them as they guide them both down. And Catra had accepted it, too numb still to fight it out. Walking feels like a dream or a nightmare and Catra thinks that if she focuses too much on Adora leaving she will start to scream, to crawl on the walls and blow things up.

Slight sparkles sizzle from her fingers and she presses further on Adora's side, doing breathing exercises until her magic tampers down. Adora feels her and he kisses her in the temple when they get to the bottom of the stairs. Catra knows why Adora is doing all this, proposing himself to go to Halfmoon, taking her to goddes know where so Catra can be sure they will be fine. She knows it all. It doesn't mean she likes it.

The ceilings wear down at some point and the roof becomes raw stones and rocks, shining with underground water, untouched by hands. Somehow, Catra knows that they are no longer in the castle. But she feels they are inside Camelot's lands. The ground is dark earth, cold to the touch. It's dark, too dark, and no breeze passes here. It looks pretty much like the insides of a cavern but she can't be sure. Adora's face is still sure and confident, like this was the usual path to their rooms instead of a hidden place.

They walk for a while more until the caverns narrow so much they have to pads one by one, Adora helping her all the way down even though Catra insists she can do it on her own without tripping. Still, Adora's strong hands are always there, guiding her around the serpent paths until they come to an end and the carven opens up again into a huge extent of land. The ceilings are high, so high that Catra has to make an effort to see the ends and it makes absolutely no sense. There are no plants or animals, just black earth and stones and, most important of it all, there is a vast lake in the middle. The water is blue, not a clear blue tone for the reflection of the ceiling, just blue so bright and alive that it shines on its luminescent existence. A thousand stars seem to shine on the surface, twinkling when Catra approaches further with her tail curling in curiosity. And the water looks like a swirl, moving as if it had waves which is theoretically impossible but here it is. When Catra looks closer she can see the flow of the water and another impossibility, because instead of fall into the lake, the water actually flows out of it and up over the rocks and stones until their path is lost somewhere deeper in the cavern where they can't walk anymore.

"Where does it go?"

"I don't know" answers Adora, shrugging. "The flow crosses Camelot and goes all the way into the woods, but it continues outside of the limits so I've never follow it"

Catra kneels next to the limit of the water, Adora mirroring her at her side. She is not particularly fond of large bodies of water, never has, but this lake is different, this whole place is different. To start, nothing makes sense. This place is too big to be down the castle, too tall, too huge. The water flow is wrong, the air doesn't exist. But there is also the feeling of magic, strong, overpowering magic. It drums inside the walls, the ground, the water. Is raw and untamed and stronger that anything Catra has ever felt, even after living in Halfmoon. And it is also not scary at all. Is comforting, quiet. It's right. Like this was the way the world was supposed to feel. Free. Uncaged. Alive

Catra hovers her hand over the water, not touching, just waiting there. The stars reflect in her eyes. She is about to turn back to Adora when the top of a woman's head raises from the water and smiles at her.

Catra yelps, snapping her hand back and jumping backwards and away. Adora catches her midway, holding her back into place to stop her from scattering away. When Catra looks at them their eyes are as blue and bright as the water and they have a reassuring smile on their lips. Adora rests their hands over Catra's, shaking her head and pointing back to the water with a knowing look.

"This is Serenia" she explains with a calming voice. The woman seems to stand on something, upper body now completely out of the water. "The lady of the lake"

Catra looks back at the woman and stares. By all means, she is blue because it seems that's the only color here. Blue turquoise hair, wet and heavy, so long that it falls down her back and into the water, mingling there like they were one. Her face is also a soft shade of blue, plumb cheeks and lilac lips as if she was dying from hypothermia, yet she looks healthy and well. She doesn't wear any clothes but her nudity is almost ethereal to the eyes, like if you were seeing the sky and not a body. She looks at Catra with navy blue eyes and then at Adora, a smirk forming in her lips.

“ *Adora* ” the woman’s voice is just as she looks, barely real, like wind in the trees and mist in the mountains. Yet Catra can catch the honest emotions on her perpetual kind but wise face. She looks like the kind of entity that holds the world in her hand and chooses not to break it into pieces. Even Adora flushes lightly, delighted, like she was seeing an old friend after a long time of being apart.

“Hey”, Adora answers simply.

Serenia returns her eyes to Catra studying her in silence, yet Catra doesn’t feel attacked or uncomfortable. She does feel a little overwhelmed, given the woman is looking at her like she can see the very roots of her soul and she has to tamper down the need to curl over her middle and keep the little life in her hidden away. Somehow the woman seems to notice this slight shift in her posture, barely a few millimeters, because her eyes twinkle and her smile widens. Catra feels suddenly overly protective, the hairs in her neck on point and her tail shot up in alert. She clears her throat and returns the gaze to the woman, opening her mouth a few times as she tries to think of something to distract them all. The woman seems to take pity on her because she starts to talk, in that same fenomenal voice.

" *I am not human, Queen C'yra. I am a personification.* "

Catra wriggles next to Adora, frowning. She still feels in high alert around her. "Of what?"

" *Magic* ". When the woman sees the confused look in her face she turns to Adora, blue eyebrows raised as she waits. Catra looks at Adora too, who is rubbing the back of her hand with their thumb as they take the exchange with patient eyes. It takes them a bit for surprise to see two pairs of eyes now on them, but they catch the cue a few seconds later and start to explain.

"There is a legend. It says that thousands of years ago, before Etheria was Etheria, a star fell out of the sky and into Albion. The earth was untouched by humans or any other hand, and so the star fell in love with it and bore a home there. The earth and water made the star a shelter and kept her safe within it for many years. And when the first Ones arrived to the land, in a time when they still venerated and respected earth and its magic, my ancestors, the Pendragons, found this cavern and the star's lake and with their permission and the promise of always protect it, they built Camelot over it" "This is why Camelot is considered sometimes the heart of Etheria, all magic that exists on it travels through here. Even Halfmoon'".

Catra blinks at them, surprised and delighted by the story. She has always liked this kind of stories and living inside one of them feels sometimes like a dream. She looks at the woman, the star, less recellous than before and by the expression on her face Catra knows she is aware of the current curiosity in her heart.

"It 's true then. The legend", Catra murmurs, eyes widened. Adora nods, visibly more relaxed now that Catra is less anxious.

The woman looks at Adora, weighing them with her eyes and her smile fades into a neutral knowing expression. *"So it is time* "

Adora blinks a few times at her, confused, "Time for what?"

Serenia smiles again and the gesture somehow makes the waves in the water still when she speaks. " *It was prophesied a long time ago that the sword would raise again when Albion needed it most"*

Adora and Catra share a look and Adora sighs, pressing her lips together. "Yes. Yes, I guess it is time"

Serenia stands in silence, just thinking and staring with that unsettling smile and then sinks again into the water, disappearing into the blue swirls. Catra frowns at the space where she was and then at Adora, who raises a finger as if asking her to wait.

"That sword, Adora. It wouldn't be-?"

"You'll see" offers only Adora.

Eventually Serenia surges from the water again. In her extended hands rests a long sword, the blade a deep blue color, golden handle, a column of ancient runs in the length of the blade that read a single word. *Excalibur,* in gold dusted words. In the center of the handle a blue

gem that looks frightening like Adora's eyes glimmers with the water that drips out of its surface. Serenia offers the sword to Adora, who hesitates one moment before grasping the handle and raising the sword to themself. It's strange, but the sword seems to recognize Adora. The blade vibrates when Adora touches it, powerful magic dripping out of it as it recognizes its owner. The magic gets so strong that Catra thinks she can see Adora shining with it, all white magic and golden hair.

The magic calms down eventually and the sword goes still in their hands. Catra looks uno at Adora with a dark blush on her cheeks and bright eyes and when Adora looks back at her their gazes share a charged look. Adora clears their throat, clearly flustered too, and puts the sword into the scabbard attached to their hip. Even guarded there, Catra can feel the magic on it.

"Are all myths here real?", she asks, a little exasperated. Adora giggles, a bit breathless after the burst of magic, but their cheeks are colored in a soft shade of pink and they nod.

"Most of them?" Catra arches an eyebrow to her and Adora looks a little embarrassed. "Alright, fine. A few nice twitches here and there. But the sword and everything it represents and the power it carries, it's real. All of it" she scratches the back of her neck, thinking. Catra is hyper aware of Serenia still looking at them with the same expression in her face. "Merlin hide the sword here after Arthur died"

Now is Catra's turn to look shocked, mouth agape in a perfect "O" as she assimilates Adora's words. "Wait. Merlin? Like, actual Merlin?"

Adora laughs, looking at her like she was the most adorable thing in the world. When Catra scowls at them, Adora gently grabs her arm and places a kiss inside her wrist. "Yes, that Merlin. My mom got the sword when she was old enough and the war got worse. And then - then when she died, I came here and gave it back to Serenia. I knew the power it held and wanted it to be safe instead of walking around with it". Adora guides Catra's hand and rests it over the sword. The jolt of magic takes Catra by surprise and she gasps for the flood of power that washes over her. "This is the true symbol of She-Ra, Catra. It's only been used in times of great need. Serenia is right. We need it right now".

Adora drops Catra's hand and contents on cupping her jaw, eyes kind. "I'm taking Excalibur with me. There is nothing better I could take to Halfmoon. I will be fine" she brushes her finger under Catra's eye. "Believe me"

Catra works in a raspy breath and gives up completely. She knows she needs to stay in Camelot. That's the reality. Adora is trusting her, asking her to take care of their kingdom, of herself. *Of their little, vulnerable and unspoken baby.* And she trusts Adora with her entire heart. So she just complies and allows the weight of her head to fall against Adora's head. "I'll always hate watching you leave"

They stay pressed together until Catra realizes Serenia is *still there,* watching them with a glint in her eyes. Catra tugs Adora's sleeve and gives her a look when they pay attention to her. Adora blushes and parts from her, standing up as they shake the dirt off their clothes and slick their blonde hair back in place, baby hairs sticking out in odd ways.

“Thank you, Serenia. I will take good care of it”

“Wrong, Adora”, answers back the star, a mysterious smile attached in her teeth. Yet her eyes are serious, hard as the stones that form her home. *“The sword will take good care of you”*

Adora looks slightly confused, hesitating in their place. They search Catra's gaze but she is not looking at her. Catra’s eyes have gone all soft in the sides and she looks at Serenia directly at her unnatural eyes with determination and something that can only be gratitude. “That’s all I care about”

Adora's sight softens with understanding and let’s the odd interaction pass. They help Catra on her feet too, careful as they start walking through the pebbles in the floor and towards the entrance again. Catra stops for a moment, turning to see Serenia has disappeared back onto the water. She takes in the blue lake and the flow of water that makes her so curious and after some seconds makes a movement to return to walking, Adora already waiting for her at the start of the narrow corridor that leads back to the castle. Catra has barely given a few steps when a cold hand seizes her wrist. It's gentle on its touch, almost like it wasn't touching her at all. Catra snaps her head back and sees Serenia there, leaning over the edge of the lake as she watches her with blue flamed eyes. She looks wet yet somehow her touch in Catra's skin is dry. Catra shifts and leans towards her too, confused. Serenia's eyes flash and focus on reality, wise mind catching up with the present.

“ *Queen C’yra, you are the keeper of Camelot’s greatest treasure”* Serenia says and her voice is both vibrating with strength and low enough to only be heard by Catra. Catra who holds her breath and widens her eyes, suddenly feeling completely exposed. *“Be strong and be careful who you trust”*

Catra shivers, thinking of the strange interaction she had that morning in the tower. It's almost the same words and she wonders if it's Serenia the one she has been hearing all this time. Serenia leans closer, so close her nose barely misses Catra's and when she speaks there is no breath coming from her mouth.

"The heart of Etheria lives in the eyes of its last dragon" Serenia murmurs in a voice so deep it echoes inside Catra's head and chest. *"If the heart falls, Etheria falls, remember that"*

And then she is letting go of Catra's arm and she is gone. Catra returns with shaky feet at Adora's side, who is giving her a curious look. "Is everything alright?", they ask.

"You didn't see that?" Adora leans to see the lake behind Catra and then back to her, shaking their head in denial.

"See what?"

"Nothing", gives up Catra, entering the corridor. "Why does everything here have to be so weird?". Adora chuckles and follows her close behind.

✾

It takes them a week to put everything in order for Adora's leave. Catra writes back to Scorpia letting her know the decision of sending Adora to help with the provisions. Scorpia writes back basically the same time she gets the notification, obviously relieved on having Adora's support during the commerce season. Catra can feel her excitement through the paper and even though she can't share it, it does help her feel more at ease about Adora going to Halfmoon. He won't be alone and, maybe he is right after all, everything will be quick and well.

Catra opposed at first on telling the Round Table about it, with the fear of a traitor and the current radio silence from Double Trouble, but in the end she had to accept it was practically impossible to hide it from the Court. Adora took it on himself to explain to the Table the urgency of making those provisions pass through the routes. He also organized a small group of knights, led by Sir Lonnie, to accompany him during the traveling. Together they would do search rounds to keep look for possible Horde tracks and keep an eye on them until the provisions were all sent and secure.

Catra had made Adora promise her, back in the privacy of their chambers, that he would not leave the limits of Halfmoon no matter what. And Adora had fought it for a little but accepted nonetheless. This was mostly a political and diplomatic matter after all and he trusted his knights enough to secure the barrier of Halfmoon until it was all done. Catra had also asked, made, Scorpia promise to keep close to Adora at all moments and keep her alert of any change or emergency the second it happened.

Perfuma offered to accompany Adora but had to decline at the last minute, having to manage her own route of commerce and the start of the harvests for autumn. It was a sweet gesture and a small disappointment when she couldn't make it, but in exchange, Adora promised Catra to write her daily letters to let her know the advance of the provisions and, even most important to Catra, that Adora was well.

Catra buried herself in work, sending letters to Halfmoon's Court to let them know they would have to *behave* and she was also very displeased with their response to Scorpia's commands in the last weeks. Answers didn't take long to arrive, begging forgiveness and promising they would act their best with both Adora and Scorpia. Catra had let very clear in her messages that Adora wouldn't sugar coat the event in Halfmoon and that any slip in their behavior would have consequences. Catra was a benevolent queen but there was a limit in everything and she didn't possess the patience for stupidity and hubris in times like this, or never, to say the least.

Catra also sat for long hours with the other Regents to determine where and how the provisions would be divided. Adora had already started sketching new routes to each of the kingdoms with the details of the plan Scorpia had sent them. It would make their stay there easier and quicker. Catra knew Adora wouldn't say it, but they were excited to meet Halfmoon. Catra had talked about it for well over a year, telling Adora her favorite places and hidden spots, about the food, the music, the colors, the people. Catra had seen them pack in one of their satchels their cartography tools and knew that when they were back there would be a new collection of paintings and maps to add to their scrolls.

Still, it wasn't how Catra had wanted them to go there, and without her. She tried to stomp it down, but she was moody and easily irritable those couple of days. Catra had to admit she had pushed too hard, stayed up too late, eating too little, to Adora's increasing worry and Glimmer's disproved stare. She hadn't scowled her in the last days but her lilac eyes spoke to thousands. Adora had taken on themself to tend to Catra as best as possible, cooing her to leave work for the morning, brushing their finger below the dark bags in her eyes, sitting next to her until the stew was completely eaten, helping her bathe when Catra was too tired to open her eyes longer. Everything in Adora was soft lately. Voice, touches, stares. Like they were apologizing for leaving. Like they were compensating for something else.

Catra had tried to tell her many times. In the morning, midday, and night. And every time she would fold over and distract herself with something else. Adora would look at her with kindness and help her with whatever she would be doing or just sit in silence by her side as she read. Catra wanted to take them by the shoulders and shake her in frustration. " *Stop being so wonderful, Adora, seriously, you're impossible",* she had thought out loud once while storming from the studio, angry with herself. Adora had snorted and knocked the ink bottle over Melog's back, gaining an indignant screech. It had been a whole mess. And now the date of Adora's departure to Halfmoon was closer than ever and Catra was just stuck. Adora didn't even look impatient. They had taken into sleep curled around Catra's middle, nestled in the crook of her arms with their head resting over the side of her breast and their ear and cheek pressing against her belly. Their hand would surround Catra's middle, holding her against them gently, even in their sleep. Catra would spend a few extra hours awake, petting Adora's soft hair away from their face, feeling the warmth of their breath against her skin, just thinking and smiling and sometimes even humming, very low in the night.

And suddenly, the week is over and Adora is leaving tomorrow.

Catra has been curled in the loveseat of the studio for the last hour. She is tired. She has worked herself to the bone the entire week to make everything the smoothest as possible. Everyone in Halfmoon is aware of Adora and her squadron's arrival. Glimmer has managed to build an arcane circle strong enough to send them at the very ends of Halfmoon's limits, so they won't be traveling on foot and horse and it will be safer. Adora will be off for around a month and the notice of their mission has expanded like gunpowder through Camelot. By this point, discretion is completely out of the window, a thing that Catra does not like but has to live with.

Most of the Table had agreed with the plan. Everyone except Lady Light Hope. For the first time since Catra had met her, when Adora announced her leaving to Halfmoon her face had contorted completely into a grimace. She had gotten mad. The stone face had cracked in the middle and she had turned immediately to Adora, quickly talking about how her responsibility was there, in Camelot, not off and away. How her going away would leave Camelot unprotected by the King. And she had turned to Catra too, menacing fury in her eyes but without saying anything. The stab of guilt had caught Catra in the heart and she had curled in shame, already feeling at fault for putting Adora in the slightest danger. And then Adora had gotten mad and it had been a sight to behold. Adora being angry wasn't a common occurrence, but when it happened, it was like a natural disaster. Like a hurricane and a fire tornado lashing against each other. Adora didn't even raise her voice. She had very slowly and clearly asked Light Hope to retreat and sit back down the table. Light Hope had snapped

like a bow's cord and stormed out. When Catra questioned Adora for it later, Adora's eyes actually got sad.

"When we lost my mother it was Light Hope the one that organized the mission", Adora brushed Catra's forehead with her lips, reaching her in to give herself strength. "I think she has always blamed herself for it, but she doesn't speak with anyone about it, especially not me. I guess she is scared too. I've never seen her like this before but this is the first time I'll be gone for so long. And she raised me after mom died, after all. She must have very strong emotions right now to snap like this' '. Adora caught Catra's look and held her tighter. "This is not your fault, love"

Catra watches the flames of the fireplace dance around the logs. Melog is cuddled on her belly, kneading very, very gently over it with their little paws, nails retracted so as to not hurt her or the peanut. Catra had stared at herself that morning in the mirror, right after Adora slipped out to give the last check to the knights with Bow. Her clothes weren't as tight as usual, vest and leggings gone with the spring. The new shirts and pantaloons she had started using were loose and comfortable enough, but under them, she was definitely starting to show. It was small, a gentle curve in the lower of her belly, but it was definitely there. Only a moron wouldn't be able to see it.

She hums under her breath, mind far away as she waits. Another fifteen minutes pass before the door opens and Adora walks in, holding something in one hand. Catra looks at her from the seat, tail twitching happily at her sight.

"Where have you been?", she asks. Adora kneels by her head and kisses her upside down, smiling. There is a strange vibration in their body, like excitement and nervousness.

"Around. I asked the Court to reunite in the Round Table". It calls Catra's attention and she sits up to look at Adora straight in the eyes.

"Why? We already had the morning meeting".

"Something important. I've been waiting until today to do it". The vibrations in Adora's body increase and they tug from Catra's hand until she stands, guiding her out of the studio and across their room. Melog stretches and scatters to the bed, curling on the blankets as they see them leave. Catra follows her in silence, eyebrows so tight together that her head starts hurting. Adora always tells her important matters, and even if they didn't they would always let her know about things. They were supposed to spend their last day together and now the uncertainty is making Catra wriggle.

"You haven't tell me any of this"

Adora looks at her with the edge of her eyes scrunched, apologetic gaze in them. "I know, I'm sorry. It's not bad, I swear"

"Then just tell me now". Adora shakes their golden head to Catra's frustration. She tried to catch a glance of the object of their hand but Adora's palm is bigger and blocks its form from her eyes. The corridor that leads to the War Room is right there and soon enough the heavy black wood of the door comes into sight too.

“We are almost there” breathes out Adora and Catra can smell their sweat. It only helps her to make her more suspicious.

"What are you planning in that weird brain of yours?". Adora has a sudden sprint on their step and they tug from her hand gently, their blunt nails against her skin raise goosebumps up her arms. Adora doesn't answer, they just open the door and slip inside beside her.

The Round Table chamber is packed when they arrive. There are, indeed, most of the present members of the Table. Glimmer, Bow, Perfuma, Frosta, Mermista, Castaspella, Nestossa, Spinerella. But there are also all the members of Camelot’s Court, ambassadors of the other kingdoms and the mountain villages. A bunch of knights and generals. Their chattering lows and dies when both walk in, watching them with expecting eyes. Light Hope is not there. Catra’s nerves skyrocket and her stomach twirls. She hasn't seen her in the entire week and she somehow wishes she could make amends with her before Adora leaves.

“Thank you for joining in after such short notice”, starts Adora, smiling. "I know you all have questions and I'll be glad to answer them after this announcement"

Glimmer walks to their side, squeezing Catra’s upper arm. “Is everything alright?”, she asks, genuinely concerned. She has been delightful the last few days, hugging Catra with her consent when she sees her feeling down, asking in low voices how are she and the peanut doing, understanding her inner conflict. Catra squeezes her hand back, also looking with quizzical stare at her wife.

“Yes”, Adora affirms. She turns to the rest of the room. She is still holding that mysterious object in her hand. “As you know, tomorrow I’ll be leaving for Halfmmon to supervise the last harvests and the safe keeping provisions routes. I know it has been a rough couple of weeks and we are all doing our best with the situation in hand. We are in crisis and it is necessary for me to take duty with our allies. Halfmoon is now part of us, all of us, and they need us right now". Adora pauses to take a breath, studying the room to make sure everyone is paying attention. "However I’m aware some people are nervous for my quick leave” Catra sees Adora look at some specific point in the Court crowd and she wonders what has Adora been hearing around them. Whatever it is, Adora’s eyebrows are slightly crooked in annoyance but their silver eyes shine with determination. “So to ease everyone’s mind, I’ve taken a decision”

Adora leans and takes Catra’s hand, placing the strange object on her extended palm. The gems on their ring sparkle with the light when they take back their hand. Up close, Catra can see what the object really is. The Royal Seal. A silver dragon carved on the silver surface, frozen in the middle of taking fly in a field of roses. A symbol of power reserved to Camelot's King only. Glimmer gasps and holds her up with a firm grip. Catra feels dizzy.

"For as long as I am absent I'm naming Queen C'yra, King Regent of Camelot"

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At night, Catra turns off all the crystal lamps and candles, leaving only the dim light of the ceiling’s constellations and the night moon entering the window to illuminate the chamber.

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She takes out the gold circlet off Adora’s forehead and undoes their braids, allowing the silk hair to fall in waves over their shoulders and back. Then she unfastens their white shirt out of the gray pants, slowly and deliberately taking each piece of clothing off until Adora stands in front of her, naked, golden and iridescent under the night. She guides them towards the bed, cooing them to rest over the plush pillows and just stay there and observe as Catra takes off her own clothes, even more slowly, and climbs over them cradling their lap with her soft thighs. Her palms hold her own weight as she rests them over their collarbones, and Adora's own hands cup the sides of her hips, rubbing circles in the skin there. In this nightly space their heated breaths are mingled, hair tousled to the side with the movement, eyes bright and alive when they look at each other.

"Catra". Adora's voice is raspy, breathless.

"Don't speak". Catra whispers, wriggles over her, straddling her hips with her spread legs. Her ankles dig in the mattress below them, the blankets quickly warming with the heat that spreads from their pressed bodies. She takes out the last pins out of her hair, letting her thick dark hair fall free down her sides, creating a curtain between the world and them.

Adora sits, self control be damned, flushing them together in one swift move, making her gasp in surprise and delicate delight. One of their hands holds Catra close by her neck, caressing the delicate bone that protrudes there. The other one spreads over Catra’s belly, feeling the rise and fall of her body as she breathes slowly, basking in the warmth of her butter soft skin. The intimacy of that caress robs them both of all the air in their lungs. Catra's heartbeat speeds up like a hummingbird, so strong that it echoes in the insides of their bed and into their ears. Catra wonders and wonders. If Adora paid closer attention, if her hearing was prodigious, inhuman. If the world was just a little more quiet and peaceful. If they would be able to hear the singing of a third heartbeat nestled between both.

Catra swings her arms around Adora's neck, resting her hands over their shoulder blades. Her expression is heathen, charged with emotions. Her ears are low on her head, yet not all the way down, and her tail switches from side to side on the air, alert. Adora bends to place a reverent kiss, able to reach only up to her sternum. The tenderness of Catra’s small breasts at either side of their cheeks is unmatchable. Adora slithers the hand in her neck down her back and over her bottom, bringing her as close as possible. The slide of Catra’s core over Adora’s navel rips something between a moan and a sigh from both of them and Adora takes advantage of the movement to latch their mouth to Catra’s bare neck.

Adora takes their time there, sucking, niping, taming the blooming skin with the tip of their tongue as Catra rocks herself over their lap. The motions make Catra's grown tummy rest against Adora's abdomen and the hand that is still protectively wrapped across her belly tightens just slightly, caressing swirly patterns over it. The headboard of the bed starts to bloom in small pink and white blossoms.

*****

"I love you" Adora whispers, kissing the bridge of her nose.

"I love you", a kiss over her freckled shoulder.

"I love you", a kiss on the swell of her nipples.

"I love you", a caress on her navel.

"I love you", says Adora, looking at her face, with huge eyes and tears stuck on their eyelashes, and Catra knows. She knows Adora doesn't only mean her. That the words are not only for her.

Catra is sweating, shivering, sensitive and vulnerable in Adora's hands. And Adora meets the flip on her soul in equality, heart torn open and beating on their hands. Catra slides her hands under Adora's jaw, bringing their head up so their gazes are hooked together again, the kindest of the expressions in her face.

“I miss you already”, and then, whispered against their lips, said in secrecy before they melt back into one. "So please, come back to us"

✾ x

Autumn arrives with Adora's leave. The air is chilly and the trees are slowly progressing to yellow and red. The squadron leaving for Halfmoon is already packed up and fixing their horses before leaving. The purple circle in the floor that Glimmer and the rest of the Mystacor magicians is done, beating with magic as it waits to be used. Scorpia would already be ready to receive the squadron in Halfmoon. Everything is ready.

Just a few people are standing in the yard. Some knights and curious staff of the castle, waving their loved ones and their king goodbye. Sir Azrael is standing at the top of the stairs, tall and quiet. Adora had asked them to take personal care of Catra's safety while she was away and Catra hadn't fought it. She likes them.

Swift Wind is chewing some last minute piece of hay while Adora embraces Catra, fixing the collar of the red coat Adora had enveloped her into to avoid the bite of the breeze. They don't wear the heavy armor, even though Catra insisted, just a chainmail shirt under their leather vest, thick gloves with golden vambraces and their red cape thrown over their shoulders. Excalibur hangs from their hip, hidden away but imponent as ever. Catra saw the looks and gasped murmurs of the people in the castle when Adora walked out with it by their side. The air had changed. Adora was right, there was something hopeful and magical about the sword.

Glimmer and Bow approach the pair, looking gently between both and waiting patiently until Adora is done with the coat to join in their space. Glimmer has a serene expression but she can't avoid the worrisome lines that slip around her eyes. While Bow is clearly taken aback, hesitation written all over his face as he rests a hand over his friend's shoulder.

"Are you sure about this?" he seems to think about it and then adds "You don't have to do this alone, one of us can go with you."

"I am. I need to go the rest of the way by myself" Adora smiles, patting his hand in reassurance. "Besides, I'll feel better and more focused if I know you three are here"

"You've never been away from Camelot for this long. How are you going to make it without us?", half jokes, half whines, Glimmer. Adora chuckles, resting their arm around their friend's shoulder, squeezing her upper arm in the way.

"Well I'll guess I'll have to manage". Bow surrounds them all with his arms, bringing the four of them into a warm and comforting hug. Catra hasn't said anything but she finds herself relaxing into the embrace, a tiny smile appearing in the corners of her mouth. They all smell like home and she can't stop a low purr to start rumbling in her chest. Bow turns to look at her with stars on his eyes, mouth already half open to gasp or squeal or both. Adora jabs him in the ribs before he can do any of that and Catra rolls her eyes in return making the group fall into a fit of giggles.

"I love you all, so much" says Adora, a bit strangled, squeezing them all closer to her. She looks at each one of them, teary-eyed, putting on a brave face. Parting from loved ones is never easy. "Take care of each other, alright?"

They all part reluctantly. Glimmer and Bow give individual last hugs to Adora and then walk further away, allowing them some more seconds of privacy. Adora holds Catra's hands between hers, looking directly at her blue-amber eyes. Catra's ears flicker, fighting back the rush of emotions that overtake her.

"Just- stay alive, clotpole", she says, doing her best to not break down at the last moment. This is all very much familiar. The cold weather, the backyard, the circle full of magic, the departure. All too close to almost a year ago. She is trying to think of the fact that Adora is going to her home, to Halfmoon, a place she knows and trusts and loves. It's the sole reason she isn't jumping over Swift Wind right now. Adora doesn't laugh at their usual nickname, holding Catra's gaze on hers the entire time. She seems to see right through her. Catra can see the way Adora's chest moves when they inhale, locking their eyes together.

"Catra, the very air that I breathe reminds me of you, because it's *you* who keeps me alive. Your essence travels down my blood. You are carved in the roots of my very soul. You always have, even when I didn't know it" Catra flusters completely, completely exposed to the sheer strength of love she never thought she would have. Adora is blinking quickly, their beautiful beautiful eyes shining silver, "I guess I must have done something very good in another life, if the gods thought me worthy of having you".

Catra wants to howl, to hold into the sleeves of Adora's undershirt and bury them into the earth so they never have to go. Holding Catra's face between her hands, Adora bumps their noses together and whispers so low Catra almost doesn't hear her. "I love you"

Catra is now hyper aware that she has somehow lost time. She has spent so much time trying not to overwhelm herself or Adora she missed the mark on enjoying the time they had with each other, on basking in the joy of a love they created together. Her tail shots forward, wrapping around Adora's arm, keeping her from moving away. The newfound urgency in her heart beats like a wild horse and she grabs quite strongly into Adora's waist, rumpling the vest between her hands.

"Adora, listen to me. We- I- We are going to-"

"Don't tell me" interrupts Adora, never changing that sweet, calming tone of hers. Catra clenches her teeth.

"Why not?"

"Because if you do I will not have the strength to leave" the sincerity in Adora's voice takes Catra completely aback. Adora's eyes are swimming in tears and they look both incredibly happy and nostalgic and nervous, all at the same time. They know, of course they do. "Tell me when I'm back. Tell me when I'm coming home"

Adora leans and Catra meets her halfway, tasting the salt in their cheeks and lips one more time. Adora cradles Catra's head between both her hands, rubbing the base of her ears as she kisses her. It's slow and deep. Adora pours all the sweetness of their throat into her mouth, damp tongues sliding against each other and the back of her teeth. Neither Adora or Catra care that everyone may be staring, this is theirs, the shared pants of breaths and the tender nips at each other's lips. They only part because they have to, nuzzling their noses together when they do, taking in the gentle red shade of the other lips. Catra presses their palms together, walking besides Adora as they take Swift Wind's reins and guide him to the circle. Lonnie and the squadron are already there, checking for last second changes, definitely not peeking as their regents lean into each other one last time before letting go of the other's hand.

Adora doesn't ride Swifty, choosing to stand next to him at the front row of the circle. The purple charcoal in the ground starts to shine brighter. Adora doesn't take her eyes off Catra's. "A month. Just a month. I promise"

The runs in the arcane circle start spinning, coming to life. The shapes of the knights start to fade in the edges as the magic starts to build in. At the top of the stairs that lead to the castle, Light Hope's figure can be seen looking down the yard too, hidden away by the shadows of the door and the dark of her clothes. Glimmer and Bow wave, holding each other as they see them start to disappear away. Adora is submerged in thought, holding her wife's colorful gaze in hers.

"I love you" Adora says and then hesitates for a moment, silver digging into Catra's soul. "Both of you"

The circle shimmers completely and they are gone.

End of chapter VII

Chapter End Notes

We are meeting Halfmoon! Finally!
Gosh we are speed running into the peak of this story and I can't wait for you to see what's prepared. I'm honestly such a nervous wreck I've been preparing this story for almost a year can't believe we are here
BABY UPDATE: by this chapter, Catra is about 2 and a half months pregnant (about 10 weeks) and as you can see they both already know about it but ✨war✨
Next chapter "Kings and Fools", will be updated on September 20th! Keep an eye up for it!

Comments, kudos and bookmarks are always appreciated. Be good!

Chapter 8: Kings and Fools

Chapter Summary

There it is, the dam breaking free.

All the emotions Adora has been trying to keep at bay, locked away so she can do her job, her duty, so she can fulfill her destiny as a king as she was always taught. All of it comes crumbling down like sand with that single thought and suddenly Adora wants to run away, to hop on Swift Wind and ride for days until she is back in her loves' arms. The golden star on her heart throbs, making her breath hitch because she can feel Catra there. She can feel them there.

Chapter Notes

Hello! We are finally meeting Catra's kingdom and I'm so excited for it. Sadly, our time on Halfmoon is short for plot reasons but it's a lot to tell so I've divided it on two parts that contain the entire Halfmoon sub arc. You'll see

Thank you so much for all the support in the last chapter! I'm so nervous for this arc but it makes me so happy to see so much love!

Warning for this chapter: mentions of a minor character's death (Mara), the scene is marked with ***** at the beginning and end

The second part will come on September 30th. See you at the end!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 8 part I. *Kings and Fools*

AUTUMN

I felt that thread that had come between us,

tugging, tugging at my heart - so hard, it hurt me.

A hundred times I almost rose,

almost went in to her;

a hundred times I thought,

Go to her! Why are you waiting?

- Sarah Waters, *Fingersmith*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x x x

✾

A month turns into two and Adora is not happy about that. Don't get her wrong, she loves Halfmoon, she adores it with every cell of her body. But she loves Catra more.

And how not to love Halfmoon. Adora has never set foot in a more beautiful place, Catra wasn't kidding when she described the wonders that were her kingdom. It made Adora feel guilty of Catra leaving it to move into Camelot. Adora would gladly live and grow and die in the red and blue and yellow and green halls of Halfmoon.

When the arcane circle transported her and Lonnie's squadron they had found themselves at the edge of a huge gate, nothing like Camelot's gray stone and brown wood. By all means, this gate was at least a hundred feet tall, formed by the biggest orange stones they had ever seen, bits of gold adorning them in the most beautiful of the patterns and green veins of life climbing over them as if the gate had formed itself from the very earth. The peak of the gate was round, an arch that should have been impossible to build without earth's magic itself. On each side of the gate, the equally tall statues of two magicats had been carved in stone, built from the very mineral formations, no constructions or new building, just two hand carved figures probably from hundreds of years ago. They were drenched in rich colors, blues so blue Adora thought she had never seen color before, green bright like jade and emerald, reds like spilled wine. Their expressions were serene, gentle, with their hands cupped and curled together in the space where the arch was formed, and from that cocoon the bluest water fell in a waterfall to the ground below, scattered in tall flowers of pompón looks and bright orange petals. Adora stood out there, so impressed by the sight that they were rooted in place, Lonnie and her knights just the same.

Eventually, the sound of life had brought Adora back to the present and she walked with careful step, mindful of not stepping in the beautiful flowers, as she guided Swift Wind right in front of the waterfall. This was it, the barrier. Adora had raised a hand and very, very slowly, pressed it into the water. She waited for the cool, the rush, but nothing came and when they took their hand back, it wasn't wet at all. Adora smiled, turning to her knights and nodding in approval, walking right into the water with a confident sprint. She didn't even bother to mount Swifty. Adora wouldn't disrespect Halfmoon's ground by walking for the first time on it without her own foot.

It was the right call. Lonnie almost crashed against Adora's back when she and the others walked out the water. The sun painted Adora's hair almost red, silver eyes shining as they took in everything around them.

It 's breathtaking. That was Adora's first thought. It's so beautiful there is no wonder why the magicats had kept this treasure hidden for so many years, out of the prying, greedy eyes of anybody else. Halfmoon rises above the earth in natural formations and bright colors,

surrounded everywhere by wide water canals that look between green and turquoise under the morning light. And there is the sun, reflected in everything around them. They had walked right into a bridge, its steps traveling down at their sides wrapped in long pods, down to evergreen ground and round silver stones, letting the expanse of Halfmoon to shine completely above them. Adora had leaned over the railing of the bridge, looking down at the clear water. Life had exploded in front of their eyes in the form of dozens of fishes, tiny, big and enormous and of all imaginable colors. Turtles of the side of horses swam calm and lazy in their rainbow like homes, followed by younger ones and purple and pink newts and lizards. Long stems of palm trees grew tall, tall, tall, so much it almost reached the size of the sculptures at the entry. Long rows of tropical and selvatic plants surrounded the kingdom in a perfect circle, high mountains so green they looked like gems and some other so pink that they looked like millions of butterflies nestled together to reach the sky. Adora gasped as a sudden flock of birds flew right over their head, the soft and long feathers of their tails brushing their heads when they passed by, beautiful, with green and white and red scattered across their bodies, they looked like small dragons furrowing the clouds until they were out of reach.

Lonnie had nudged Adora on the side, signaling to the stairs down the bridge and towards the houses placed around the canals. “Let’s go, we need to go to the palace”

As they walked down the white and terracotta streets, people started to peek out from the stone houses, painted in red, orange and deep blue, with the seams and details of each facade adorned in gold. Curtains of rich fabrics draped on the doors and windows floated gently with the breeze, their ends embroidered with figures of the most curious animals. Magicats carrying baskets full of ripe fruits and cereals stopped on the tracks of their daily lives to look with wide eyes full of wonder as the king and their squadron walked by. There were also Salineas refugees and other villagers from around the kingdoms, all with shining eyes and mouths agape. All of them wore clothes just as colorful as everything in Halfmoon, long skirts and dresses and wide pants and cotton shirts embellished in flowers and animal on mid run patterns, either painted or embroidered. The weather was warm, no cold breeze at all even when it was autumn, so some people would walk around without any type of clothing covering their chest. Their skins were painted, swirls and lines designed across their faces, down their necks, shoulders and chests. Jewels, gold and shining feathers adorning their hairs, headdresses, clothes and sandals. Adora waved shyly at them, earning some delighted smiles in return and little waves back from small kids hidden behind their parents’ legs. Adora’s heart throbbed.

Over the canals, barques were starting to pull over, filling their floors with spices, flowers and trinkets to barter with the merchants. They had also stopped to look at Adora’s procession, murmuring between themselves and pointing. Adora wriggled on their shoes, beed red as they felt the stares of the people. They had turned to look at Lonnie when a handful of magicat kids shot forward, standing on their tippy toes to look at Swifty with curious glances. They were small, barely reaching Adora's knees and hip, and their cute little ears were twitching with excitement. One of them had placed a hand up, Swift Wind coming to meet them midway, his noose huge in comparison with their palm. The smaller one was still hidden behind their sibling, the matching stripes on their fur telling everything Adora needed to know, thumb on their mouth as they looked at Adora with huge amber eyes. Swifty

huffed, sending a breath of warm smelly air towards them. It made the child laugh. Adora laughed with them, breathless and tear eyed.

By the time they reached the palace the sun was high and bright over their heads, the entire town alive with movement and laughter. Word of the arrival of the king had spread into every corner of the kingdom and they had all walked to the serpentine streets to catch a glance of them. There was also a sense of relief washing over the settlers, hope sowing in their hearts at the sight of Camelot’s and new Halfmoon’s ruler. The stairs of the stepped pyramid-palace rose high over their heads, taller even than the highest towers of Camelot, adorned in golden stones and red and blues paintings, with plants of huge leaves and statues of panthers in solemn expressions framing all the way up. Scorpia had welcomed them at the bottom, going for an immediate hug that cracked all the bones in Adora's body, undoing herself in thank you's. Later, after her excitement and frank relief was tampered even if just a little and the horses had been taken to feed and rest, she had shown them their chambers one by one until it was only Scorpia and Adora walking together in the corridors.

The light of the sun showered the hallways and the cool breeze made the plants that grew everywhere dance gently against the colored stones. Adora's eyes were lost in the huge murals across the walls. Black and amber jaguars, birds and feathered dragons painted over the stones , others created by tiny pieces of porcelain, jade, shining stones and sea glass until forming a unique mosaic full of life and color, showing the life and core of Halfmoon as free and wild as it always had been. Scorpia talked the entire way, pointing at each room to explain what they were. War room, chambers, armory, kitchens, chambers, chambers, galleries, gardens. Adora had listened to her as best as she could, mind a thousand years away. These were stones of Catra's childhood. The long tapestries of her life. The breeze that filled her lungs. The earth that kissed her feet. Adora loved it. All of it.

"Hum?", said Adora, realizing that Scorpia had made him a question.

"How is Catra doing?", repeated Scorpia without losing her cheerfulness. Adora felt himself pulled to reality suddenly, stuttering when they answered.

"Oh! She is fine, great even! Yeah, she 's okay". Scorpia didn't seem to notice the strangle of their voice, smiling brightly at the words clapping her pincers together in delight.

"That 's great! I was worried she had gotten upset by my letter", mumbled Scorpia, scratching the side of her cheek. Adora smiled at her, shaking their head.

"She isn't. And neither am I. It's not your fault, Scorpia. You are doing a great job" when Scorpia grimaced, unsure, Adora raised his hand, pinky finger extended towards her. "Pinky promise"

Scorpia had laughed until they reached the last door of the corridor, a huge door embellished in blue stones and carved serpents. Scorpia pushed it open with ease and motioned inside, letting Adora step into the expanse of the regal bedroom.

"This was, *is* , Catra's chamber," Scorpia explained. "She made it very clear in her letter that she wanted you to stay here, so here it is!"

Adora didn't answer, too absorbed in taking everything in to formulate a proper sentence. Scorpia slipped away after a while, letting Adora to her own devices as she whistled down the corridor. The first thing Adora had noticed was that the chamber was clean. Not in the free of dust type of way though it was also clean in that matter. More like clean from objects, from things. There was a large circular bed in the south wall of the room, big enough to fit five of them over the mattress, a myriad of small pillows neatly placed over it. The room was as colorful and vibrant as everything in Halfmoon, with deep blue walls and a yellow and red carpet on the floor. The ceiling was painted a faint tone of lilac with swirls of white that almost seemed like clouds mid run. There were drawings and paintings done by hand over the wall, all of them the same characters, a golden dragon and a black panther chasing each other in a playful manner. Some of them were doodles, clearly done by young hands, and they progressed until being full masterpieces. When Adora rested their hand over them, she knew Catra had painted them, a product of dozens of sleepless nights. Yet, besides them, there were no other personal items in the room. No clothes in the wardrobe, no trinkets in the drawer, no books on the shelf. Catra had packed her entire life and moved it to Camelot like she didn't expect, in the moment, to ever be back.

Adora let himself fall over the chair, no daring to disturb the bed or the hammock hanging next to the huge square windows. The mosaics that climbed over the high stones of the room reflected the colors from outside, painting the chamber on rainbows. They would need to go back to Halfmoon someday, thought Adora, after the war was… better. Halfmoon's winters were calid, nothing like the freezing of Camelot's. They could split their times between their kingdoms half a year and half a year. Adora would do anything just to see Catra move around back into her own home. For her to show them all those hiding spots and fun activities. To be able to stay together, to raise-

Adora stopped her thoughts, tugging from the ribbons on their cape. *Soon* , Adora reminded himself, *I need to make sure everyone is safe first.* He went through his satchel, looking for ink and paper, determined to write to Catra even if they had seen each other barely a few hours ago. The time ahead of them was long.

Now, Adora sits in the high scalons of the palace, watching the sun set behind the thick leaves of the trees that surround and hide Halfmoon. He is rubbing Excalibur's blade with a piece of cloth, absently cleaning it out of dust and debris. There hasn't been a need to use it, thank the stars, but Adora has taken it as a grounding motion in his time away from home, away from Catra.

There are tiny lines marked with ink in Catra's window frame, one by each day away. Adora has been putting them after sending his messenger birds to her every night. It's already the last weeks of November and today is the last day of the harvests before winter. After this, the provisions will be divided, packed and sent through the newly designed routes to their respectives destinations. After this, it would be time to go back home.

It had been hard work, those last two months. Where Scorpia and the resident magicats seemed excited to have Adora between them, the Court was a different story. Catra wasn’t joking, without her to put them at bay, the Court was mostly distrustful and sharp, frowning in concern at Adora’s presence between their own royalty. Adora had to pull every bit of courage to stand up as a King and gain their respect and, most importantly, their trust. Lonnie

and the squadron had taken a recognition trip after arriving at Halfmoon, finding only old tracks of possible small Horde squadrons but nothing that indicated a possible attack at all. Still, the Court refused to allow the provisions to start traveling, locking them under key inside huge chambers. Adora had grimaced. If Catra had been there, she wouldn't have been pleased at all.

Adora didn't hold them in an ill manner. The way the Court acted wasn't that far away from the way Catra had acted at first arriving at Camelot. Suddenly allowing a Pendragon to trespass their barriers and rule over them was a shock for them all. For most of the part, Adora had been quiet, supporting Scorpia's plan of taking the routes through the Crimson Waste, which would be a longer passage but a safer one. The Horde didn't care about the desert, their armors and weapons were inadequate for it. If Halfmoon knew how to take advantage of it, the safety of the people of Etheria during the crude winter would be secured. Adora let Scorpia explain the entire plan, only intervening when describing the routes was necessary. She didn't try to impose over Scorpia at all, always respecting her title as Crown Princess, something Scorpia was sure to show how grateful she was about later. The Court had resisted at the beginning, tampered only when their comments towards Scorpia started to scalate too much and Adora sent them a warning gaze, standing in their place. It wasn't missed by her the way the royals eyes widened and even their tails puffed, glances traveling between Adora's face and the handle of Excalibur hanging from their hip.

After that, the rumor that *King Adora carries the mighty Excalibur,* wasn't far to scatter through the kingdom like wildfire. *It is them . The mighty She-Ra is here.* Adora had never liked it, being this kind of untouchable superior being, held high above anyone else, all because of a title or a throne or a bloodline. But it made things easier. The Court started to relent when they saw the people's support and admiration, and a full week after Adora's arrival they gave in and finally accepted Scorpia's plan, not without making Adora promise they would stay in Halfmoon until everything was done.

Adora hadn't had another choice. Catra knew that too. And during the next long weeks of more work and diplomacy, Adora fell in love with Halfmoon and its lands, its rivers, its waterfalls, its lakes, its people. Spent the days with politics and war and the evenings walking around the hundred gardens hidden across the kingdom, sometimes even climbing the high trees to catch a glimpse of the living city below them. Sometimes it would be for learning new dance steps with the villagers, snorting as she tripped with her own feet. Or to feed the unique animals that lived only in Halfmoon, black panthers with their spots blue, pink and yellow, animals that looked like a mix of various others and that didn't make sense at all but which bright colors were impossible to ignore. Or to play new games with a ball alongside Scorpia.

And Adora could say the nights were for Catra, but that wasn't true. Nights were for writing long letters to her wife, yes. But in reality, every single second of every single day was for Catra. No matter if Adora was riding down the perimeters of Halfmoon to check up the barriers alongside the High Priestess and sorcerers, or helping the farmers harvest the cereals and vegetables, knee deep in the mud. Catra was always there in the back of their head, like a warm shield holding Adora together when they felt like a million pieces breaking apart under the weight of their own name.

How amazing it is. To love someone this much. To be devoted to someone this way. To wish to spend every single minute of every single day next with someone else, not by duty or convenience, but by the simple fact of loving. Adora can't believe their luck. To have found the one person that holds their heart, that saw it as it was without the power and the titles, with the faults and the mistakes, and still wanted it, still accepted it, still willingly placed it on her chest to have and hold and protect.

Adora can see his face reflected in the surface of the powerful sword, eyes bright blue as their reflection returns their gaze. They can see a sparkle right there, in the bottom of his eyes. A warm feeling starts to spread through their chest but it's... different. Is not heated like the sun shining on their face, nor hot like sweat from hours of harsh training. It's like a star, like a small ball of golden light and energy growing inside their soul, rooting on their heart, blooming against their ribs. It starts tiny and then becomes bigger and bigger until it overcomes any other feeling, any other need, any other thought. Yet it's not oppressive, or scary. It's like Adora doesn't know how to breathe, how to beat, how to exist without this light anymore. The star grows and so does the spark in their eyes. The more Adora thinks about Catra, about Catra at home, about Catra happy and healthy. About Catra opening and loving. About Catra changing, slowly, in mind and flesh. About her body softening, curving, accommodating, guarding, protecting. How incredible it is. How incredible Catra is. A queen, a friend, a strategist, a lover, a king, a wife, a mother-

Adora gasps, the thought slipping without permission. Her reflection looks back and it's there that Adora notices for the first time that she is crying and that maybe the sun is not the only thing glowing at the top of those stairs anymore. The warm tears drop down their eyes into the blade, blurring their vision completely for a few seconds. She has to make a real effort to not let go of the sword as she wipes the tracks of tears with a trembling hand, a lost battle because they just keep coming, pooling and spilling down without permission. Adora ends up fully sobbing up there, alone at the top of the palace’s infinite stairs, watery sobs mixed with strangled laughter and honestly, it's all a little bit chaotic.

There it is, the dam breaking free.

All the emotions Adora has been trying to keep at bay, locked away so she can do her job, her duty, so she can fulfill her destiny as a king as she was always taught. All of it comes crumbling down like sand with that single thought and suddenly Adora wants to run away, to hop on Swift Wind and ride for days until she is back in her loves' arms. The golden star on her heart throbs, making her breath hitch because she can feel Catra there. She can feel *them* there .

She thinks she has been able to feel them there from the very first day, but her heart was so full of love and happiness already she didn't notice until later, when Catra started to bear the softness of it all. And Adora can feel Catra in her chest like a second heartbeat, like their hearts had pressed and fused together to become one until their heartbeats were pulsing together, strong and rhythmic like drums. Adora can feel Catra in every cell of her body. Sometimes Adora swears she could feel her wake up and fall asleep. On times where a sudden bubble of joy sparked on Adora’s chest she could swear it was Catra laughter the origin of it. And when she was sad Adora’s heart would clench until rob her of her breath. It’s always been like this, since the very first moment, their souls exist mingled together.

But there is a new feeling now too. A new love.

It's a firework spectacle living in her soul.

A spark of life born from their love.

She can feel them too. Sleepy, nestled and happy. Living and growing and just existing, perfect and loved inside of her body, inside of their hearts.

Adora’s time in Halfmoon is coming to an end. A week, maybe two more. Her job there is practically done. Camelot is closer every single day, Camelot who guards Adora's entire world. There is no need for Adora's heart to hide its joy any more.

Their sobs come to an end eventually, letting behind only that numb feeling that always comes after a long cry. Adora feels better. They have never been good with addressing their own emotions, with taking care of them. It has always been action first, bottling all up until it bursted up. But today is not stressful, today is good. Adora’s heart feels so full and happy it has to find a way to pour it all out and into the world. Good tears, indeed. Adora knows he is meant to cry again, when he travels back to Camelot and lays eyes on Catra, they know they will. There will probably be lots of tears in the months to come, all of them good too, and Catra will tease them endlessly for it but Adora hadn’t realized how much of a crier they actually were until this moment in their life. Adora would cry a thousand more if it meant to have this again and again.

By the time Scorpia finds her to get dinner the sun has already set and Adora's eyes are red rimmed and puffy. The surprise in Scorpia's face is evident and it takes Adora some good minutes to convince her that everything is well, that they are alright. It doesn't seem to convince Scorpia, though, because she eyes them the entire time with a crease on their eyebrows. She will probably end up writing to Catra to show her concern and that's alright too, Adora appreciates having someone that care about them. All the same, Adora will probably tell Catra on that night's letter themself. There are no secrets between them and if Adora is going to cry for an hour because they miss their family then Adora themself is going to let Catra know about it first hand.

Adora stands from the stairs, guarding Excalibur back to its place next to her hip. The blade shimmers and vibrates, steel hot against the fabric, like they were picking up something Adora doesn't. But she doesn't pay it any attention.

Adora just wants to go home.

❀

The first time her kitten kicks, Catra breaks the glass she is holding. It clunks into the floor of hers and Adora's chamber and crashes in dozens of tiny pieces, dangerously close to her bare feet.

It's small, so infinitesimally small that if Catra wasn't completely and absolutely attuned to them, she would have probably let it pass as a swift cramp on the lower of her abdomen.

Catra waits. One, two, three minutes, ears ticking as she keeps as still as possible but the kitten doesn't move again.

Catra sighs, flicking her fingers so the broken pieces shine in purple and pick themselves from the floor and into their place again, glass intact again and water mess gone. She walks away from the fireplace and close to the table, leaving the cup there to pick up a bundle of worn out letters in its place.

They are Adora's, every single one from the day she left to Halfmoon to now, two months later. She wrote to Catra that very first night, complaining that their barriers wouldn't allow them to contact by magical voice and undoing themself in love words for Halfmoon and everything about it. It made Catra's heart ease just a little, laughing with the lovely and goofy words, making it a little bit easier to spend her nights alone when she read about how Adora had lost themself in the huge gardens and had a fight to pick with a ten feet tall colorful bird when they tried to steal her lunch.

One letter per day, the edges of the papers worn out of how many times she had read them again and again. It hadn't been easy finding out Adora had to prolong their visit for an entire other month. She had been gutted and by Adora's tone on that particular letter, they had been too. Actually maybe angrier. Catra had advised them on how insufferable the diplomats on Halfmoon's Court could be, so she understood the frustration. Didn't make it easier or happier, but until Adora was back into her arms she would have to suck it up and wait. She was both a queen and a king now, after all, she had a ton of extremely important responsibilities to look up to and distract herself with.

Catra had answered in return every letter, letting Adora know how Camelot and the other kingdoms were going. After a couple of days, Adora had written back saying as kindly as possible that as much as she appreciated the war report, she wanted to know about her family, *thank you very much* . It had ruffled Catra's fur completely and she almost didn't even answer back but ended up giving up. So now, she did gave the kingdom report, but she spent most of her time chattering nonsense like what dumb thing Sparkles had done or what invention had Entrapta blown up this time.

By unspoken accord, Catra didn't mention their baby at all in the letters. The words of Adora asking her to wait until their return had turned into her mantra and she lived in the reassurance that hidden and secret, the little kit was loved and wanted and waited with longing by both. She knew, however, that the yearning was eating Adora alive, something she noticed when Adora started to ask if she had eaten peanut butter pies that day. It quickly became a silly little code between both. Adora would always end her letter with *"How were the peanut pies today?"* and Catra would reply with *"They were great. Think they may be being baked bigger though"* and so, and so. It was stupid. The single most dumb, silly thing Catra had ever done, and that considering leaving-her-kingdom-to-marry-the-unkown-love-of-her-life, was thrown somewhere there too. But it was also the most wonderful, happy thing she had ever lived so far.

It also helped ease both of their minds, even if just a little, that if anyone were to intercept their messenger birds nobody would know about them, at least, outside the Kingdom. Catra had made her best to be as discreet about it as possible but by the last week of November her

own body had made it impossible to hide anymore. She had dropped the notice to the Round Table a month after Adora's leave, mostly so they would all swore secrecy in the matter. She knew congratulations were expected but didn't see the storm of excited squeals and hugs coming her way. Meeting that day be damned, Catra spent the next two hours from arms to arms to screeches of delight to flowers to brinds and *no Mermista, absolutely no wine for Catra.* Perfuma almost squeezed her half to death with her embrace, slim arms stronger than she looked. Even Sir Juliet gave up her up-right military stand to give her a delighted smile. Glimmer hugged her softly, already knowing about it, but bubblier, more excited. Bow was straight up crying. Catra had looked for Light Hope's face and met an indifferent stare, void of any other emotion. She knew she resented her for Adora's parting from Camelot but the rejection still hurted.

How the rest of the kingdom found out was still a mystery. But Catra was pretty sure it was one of the kitchen workers. She was stealing a few strawberry tarts at night, coat forgotten on the chair, only nightgown on and sleeves rolled up, when a maiden carrying a tray of bread caught glance of Catra leaning over the table and she gasped, letting go of the tray with a metallic clank. It startled Catra, especially when the old woman rushed by her side to see her in the eyes and then smiled. *Old people just- know things. It's weird.* Said Glimmer that night, after convincing Catra of having a sleepover with her and Bow. Cara had sulked the entire night, tail puffed in anxiety, and by the next morning the entire kingdom knew. Evening audiences went from hours of meeting with the town's people to Catra accepting gift after gift from them. From packages of aromatic herbs, homemade cheese and bread, colorful sea glass, bards' songs and roses, dozens of roses, lupines and cotton blooms, that were too close to trigger Catra's allergies and that dressed the hallways and corridors of the castle in pinks, yellows and reds. It was all so much. Catra couldn’t help but smile at the thick sweet smell as she walked through. Luckily, the news seemed to have stayed inside the walls of Camelot and, besides their rulers, no other kingdom was aware of it. It was still nerve wracking to say the least.

Catra curls on the love seat in Adora's studio, the room quiet and too clean now that Adora is not there to scatter maps and ink everywhere. She caresses the rim of Adora's last letter, avid to read Adora's hopeful words of parting back to Camelot in a few days. After so long, harvests are done and provisions are in their journey to the respective kingdoms. Adora sounds more relaxed now that all the diplomats are done and finished and she doesn't have to deal with the court's nonsense. Her thumb brushes over the long letters, spiky and excited and so different from her own handwriting, smudged with spots ink that didn't quite dried properly before their writer started writing again. It mustn't be easy for Adora, to sit after a long day of work and focus their brain and their dyslexia into writing long detailed letters. Catra had insisted for Adora to rest some nights, that there wasn't a need to write every day, Adora had refused. Secretly, Catra felt relieved by it.

Catra is halfway through Adora’s adventure with the canals' boats and a giant turtle when that tiny movement comes again. Catra stops breathing, clutching the letter with a firm grip. A heartbeat passes and then another soft pad, so soft only Catra’s acute senses can pick it up, tiny and hesitant. Like the twitch from a very sleepy kitten. Catra smiles. "Oh. I see” she brushes one of her fingers over the curve of her belly, tail coming up to wrap around it with the movement. “Do you miss your mom? I miss them too"

There is a little flip and then some even smaller twitches. Catra huffes as she finishes reading the letter. “Someone is a sleep fighter, uh? Wonder where do you get that from”

The movement repeats, like they were answering her, and then stills, an intense feeling of sleepiness filling her. Catra yawns without thinking, placing the stock of letters carefully besides her in the seat. She places a hand at the side of her belly, rubbing the spot where she felt the movements. She watches absently the fire, flames reflecting on her amber and sapphire eyes. Melog has come to cuddle next to her, nuzzling with their wet nose the other side, purring gently against her skin.

Catra had never understood it. When she was younger she would see people with their partners having childs, bearing them, carrying them, adopting them. Why? Why bring such small fragile creatures to a world in war? Why forming families when it could be all taken away so easily? Catra was a young queen at that time, she had grown surrounded by love and then stripped out of it by love itself. Had seen her mom go and her mother slowly fade away in grief, leaving Catra, leaving their daughter alone with the world's weight on her shoulders. Catra had loved and then had lost everything. She was already a queen, all her people relied on her, she didn't need more to worry about.

And then Adora.

Adora, bright like a sun, with her silver eyes and her white roses. Adora with a choice and a liberty Catra hadn't felt in years and she found herself incapable of saying no. Adora with kindness in their heart and strength in their hands. And suddenly, the descendant of the very bloodline she swore herself to hate was the same person who carried her heart against theirs. That young Catra would have clawed, screeched and thrown herself off a cliff, but this Catra wouldn't have it any other way. She understood now that it was worth it. The fear and the worry and the struggle. It was all worth it because Catra knows Adora loves her, that they choose her everyday at dawn and every day when the sun falls. That they want her and that they need her. That they put everything and anyone before themself and still, Catra is their priority. That they would rather sacrifice weeks away than see Catra in any kind of danger. It's all worth it for those tender moments in the mornings, and those gentle gazes that speak thousands. It's all worth it for the feeling of infinitesimal small feet pressing inside her belly as a part of Adora's heart grows in her.

Melog is fast asleep on her side and so is her peanut, she can feel them in the very strands of her magic, twitching lightly as they sleep.

"What are you dreaming about?" she wonders outloud, tracing the curve of her stomach with gentle fingers. "Are you dreaming of dragons? Of tiny fairies and sea creatures? Or are you dreaming of high towers and golden staircases?" Catra sighs, allowing her eyes to fall close. She is wearing a warm soft coat to protect her from the autumn chill and one of Adora's night shirts, her smell still lingering in the fabric. Oranges and leather.

"Are you dreaming about your mom?" she asks again, without getting a response. She should be going to bed but she is already way too comfortable and half asleep to dare to move. "I dream about your mom every night. Maybe we are dreaming the same thing"

Catra brings her knees to her chest as best as she can, all things considered, and wraps herself with her tail, letting sleep overtake her completely not before mumbling.

"Almost there, peanut. Almost there"

❀

... and I had no idea I needed to bless the harvest but I think I did it well. One of the Old Priestess taught me how to hold the candles over the plates without dropping them but it was nerve wracking because everybody was looking at me. It really puts your life into perspective when you have to stand in the middle of the water and do that with tons of people around. The Priestess was satisfied though. They gave me a flower crown and everything. And a bunch of kids asked me to hang them from my arms and carry them around. That was nice. I don't know how you can do that every harvest and not sweat, but of course, you are wonderful in everything you do. Maybe next time we can do it together?

By the way, your Commerce Minister is a prick. Please let me fire him, love, I'm so close to snapping and throwing him out of the palace myself. Did you know he was the one with the brilliant idea of closing the routes and also the one who instigated all that shit towards Scorpia? She is too nice to kick him out of the council but he is such an ass with women, especially women on power. I'm so tired of him.

You know what? I'm going to fire him. If you agree only, of course. I'll do it on my last day. A goodbye gift for the ass.

I miss you.

I miss your smile. I miss the gleam in your eyes. I miss you beating me at knight training. I miss your laugh so much. I miss laughing with you, sleeping with you, existing with you. I even miss you drooling and kneading at my side with your nails. I just miss you.

How has your day been? How is our everybody doing? Counselor Seppho says the provisions will start to be packed tomorrow so we will check that out and they should be on their way soon after. It means I will be here for about a week more, maybe less. It means I'll be home soon.

Can't wait to see you again. We'll have peanut pies together, promise.

I love you

- 'Dora

❀

Catra is signing a long scroll when the gates of the throne room open, letting in a portion of Camelot's Court in. Some of these people have been there since Mara's time, maybe even

before, some ancient and laid back others wiser, open to hear and accept the new ideas from the young rulers.

Catra is having kind of a headache. She arrived at the chamber just to be greeted with uncomfortable news by Glimmer. She is also nauseous and tired. Sleep hasn't been coming easy lately and she just can't find a comfortable position to sleep in without Adora there to cradle her and the baby, so the loveseat in the studio has had to make it for the last couple of days.

Into the throne room come four people, a tall man with a grey beard and red pants, a shorter one with a puff of fine blonde hair and a red runny nose, a slim woman with a high feathery hairstyle and lastly, an older woman with a pointy chin and a green expensive dress. They walk inside with long measured steps, knowing themselves royalty and of importance. Catra doesn't even raise her eyes to meet them.

"Countess Natvia, Baroness Diomira. Minister Grivan, Baron Alos", she says out loud, lending the scroll back to Sir Juliet and finally, and only when they are standing in front of the steps that lead to the twin thrones, turning to look at them with a stern expression. "Took you long enough to show up. Thank you for joining us at least"

Next to her, Glimmers clicks her tongue in disgust and hardens her stare to the four royals, scrunching her nose in a displeased manner. Their upright expressions seem to waver for a second at Catra's cold tone but the taller man, Minister Grivan, steps further and bows lightly towards her.

"Is there something we can do for you, Queen C'yra?"

"I would like you to explain to me some *irregularities* , Minister. The four of you", she leans to the side and Glimmer gives her a new scroll, already open, through which she scans quickly before speaking again. There four royals look at each other uncomfortably. "I've received today's information about the finances and it seems a large percentage of the gold destined to provide Camelot's orphanages has been ordered to be taken away and put into your personal endowments' ', Catra pauses, returning her steel cold eyes to the group. "Care to explain?"

Nobody speaks. Catra folds one leg over the other and drums her sharp nails against the restarms of the throne, waiting. Finally the Minister clears his throat and nods.

"We took it as our emergency endowment, your Majesty". Catra's drumming stops.

"You what?"

"Is a protocol move to preserve royalty welfare", squeaks out the man, fastening the knot of his expensive collar. The other three break into a sweat when they take on Catra's face. "Salineas has fallen. The war is imminent to affect Camelot too, we must persevere"

"And your idea of perseverance is stealing the resources destined to the real victims?"

"We are also victims!", screeches Countess Natvia. Catra snaps her attention to her, hissing.

"Do you know what the meaning of orphanage is, Countess?". The woman shuts her mouth close, her white pale skin coloring in deep red. Catra growls low in her back, not allowing her true disgust to show on her face. The bracelets on her ankles twinkle when she moves.

“It doesn't matter what you thought. The facts here are that I gave a royal order to where those resources should go and you four, even though you possess great amounts of gold on your arcs thanks to your titles and you receive a salary given to you by King Adora, decided to steal from it and used to buy what?” Catra looks now at the Baronnes, clenching her jaw, “Do you call that green monstrosity you are wearing an emergency war supply, Baroness? Because if that’s what it is I might be completely wrong in my view of what an emergency means.”

The Baroness huffes, red as a beet, and she stops in the carpet with her foot harshly. “You can address us like that! We deserve respect!”

"I deliver respect when I consider that respect has been earned and so far you haven't done anything but prove otherwise".

The Baroness steps back and she looks frustrated to the Minister. In fact, the three of them look at him like they were saying " *Do something* ". The Minster gasps and shakes his shoulders, desperately looking for a way out to justify this whole mess.

“Your Majesty" he tries, voice so condescendant that it makes Catra's ears twitch. "It's just- you are not using the King’s crown as is tradition. Yes. The confusion is understandable. We may have- misunderstood the importance of your command”

Next to Catra she can hear Glimmer mutter under her breath as she drags a hand over her face. Catra shifts on her seat, smirking viciously to the man.

“Tell me, Minister, do you need to see a crown to know when to show respect to your superior in command? And why doesn't it seem to be a problem for the rest of the Court?” the Minister chokes on his tongue, losing all the blood on his face. Catra's smile just sharpens. "Either you like it or not, it doesn't matter to me. Because today I am your King and you are my subject. And after that I will remain your Queen, and you will do as I say without trying to pathetically fool me" Catra leans back on the throne, her tail shifting from one side to the other. "I will not risk the safety and welfare of Camelot's people just to satisfy the tantrums of a few rich".

The Minister steps back and practically runs to the others, cowardly hiding behind the skirts of the Countess. Catra's ears twitch, satisfied, until Baron Alos takes the Minister place. He holds his hands in a calming motion, like he was speaking to a frightened animal and not his King.

"Your Majesty, we are so sorry to have damaged your plan for the orphans. I'm aware that your... *condition* may make you more sensitive to this kind of stuff. Women can feel very vulnerable to this type of situations"

Glimmer takes a sharp breath, purple bright eyes widening. Even the guards across the chamber shift uncomfortably. Behind Cara, Sir Azrael grunts. Catra doesn’t even blink, she

regards the Baron with a cold gaze, scowling as she talks.

"Baron Alos, I suggest you choose very well what you are going to say next". The Baron opens and closes his mouth a couple of times, hesitating, and then thinks about it better, scrunching on his place as small as he can and backing away. “Smart choice, Baron”

Catra drums her nails once more for a few seconds and then tosses her thick hair behind her back, held in place and out of her face by a beautiful veil Mermista had definitely-not-kindly gifted her a few weeks ago.

“Countess Natvia, Baroness Diomira. Minister Grivan, Baron Alos, I’ve decided to relieve you from your obligations inside this Court. You are not to step into this room again unless it is for a real urgent petition”, the four of them gasp and yelp, angry faces contorting at her words. But Catra’s expression doesn’t give them a window to speak. “You may retain your titles but be aware that all the money that was taken from the orphanage will be paid out of your own salaries until it is completely covered. Do not speak Countess, I haven’t given you the word”, she snaps, and the woman clicks her teeth together, words dying on her throat. Catra turns to the Minister, eyes like stone. “Minister, given your great interest in emergency protocols, you will be sent to Brightmoon. I’m sure Queen Glimmer will find a proper work for you that satisfies this… altruistic need of yours”.

Glimmer cracks her knuckles, smiling mischievously to him. “Oh, I sure will”

Catra smiles at her before dropping it, straightening in her seat. “This is a royal statement, ordered by King C’yra of Camelot and will be completely effective after the approval of King Adora Pendragon once they are back from their travel”, the scribe on the chamber rushes to write down everything, scroll filling with inked words. Catra nods once they are down, regarding the four royals one last time. “Be grateful. What you have done is a disgrace to Camelot and will stain your name”, her tails taps against the floor, displeased.

“I also suggest you to start showing more respect towards your future heir or believe when I say this, it will be King Adora the one who will have you all on a plate in the wait of a blink”. Catra scoffs at the horrified look in their faces. She nods to the guards, who start to approach the group in quick steps. “That would be all, you are dismissed”

It seems as if they were to explode into protests but then take in the guards waiting to escort them to the doors and think it better, storming out of the chamber. Catra’s shoulders relax a little and she turns to Glimmer’s seat, whispering to her in a soft voice.

“Sparkles, could you-?”

“I’ll see it gets done” she assures her, patting her hand. Her pink eyebrows knit a little, and she leans forward even more. “Bow must be waiting for you already, are you sure you don’t want me to accompany you?”

“I’m sure”, reassures Catra, locking her eyes with Light Hope’s figure, who has been roaming quietly during the audience. Glimmer follows her gaze and makes a sound of understandment. She gives Catra's hand one last squeeze and stands from her place to slip out of the throne room. Catra watches Light Hope moving to leave too.

"Lady Light Hope" Catra calls, wobbly on her feet as she stands from the throne. It had gotten better after she hit the four month mark but her gravity center is still all over the place. "A word?"

Light Hope stops in her tracks and turns to look at her, eyes unsurprised and void as always. Catra walks to her, one hand curling around her belly, the other flexing by her side in nervousness. She can feel her peanut shifting inside of her, reacting to her anxiety. She breaths deep a few times until she reaches Light Hope, tail swishing behind her.

"Yes, your Majesty?", asks Light Hope, voice calm and impasible. Catra eyes her a few seconds, considering, and then turns to the gate.

"Walk with me"

Catra moves forward, looking at Sir Azrael and nodding. They nod back and start following them quietly just a few feet behind. Light Hope follows too, not looking at Catra at all, with her hands folded one over the other over her waist. She is really tall, almost as tall as Sir Azrael, and her short hair under the veil makes her look regal and important.

Catra clears her throat, focusing herself on stroking her bump as they walk down the halls of the castle. "I would like to apologize, Lady Hope"

It calls Light Hope's attention and for a second she even seems surprised. She tilts her head towards Catra, eyebrows raised. "Apologize, your Majesty?"

"Yes" affirms Catra without stuttering. "I'm aware I haven't been fair with you these past months and I would like to apologize. I've been dismissing your advice and barely even consulting anything at all with you and that was arrogant of me. You are Adora's advisor after all and you raised him too. He wouldn't put so much trust of you if he didn't knew you deserve it "

Light Hope remains in silence as they keep walking, her face not even twitching after Catra's speech. They are going through the east corridors, down to the physicians quarters. Catra has an appointment that day and she is supposed to meet Bow, who insisted to death to accompany her, in the gates down there.

"I appreciate your words, your Majesty, " says Light Hope, startling her lightly. She turns towards the advisor but her eyes are firm upfront and she doesn't even flatter her step as she keeps walking. There is, however, the tiniest twitch on the corner of her lip as she talks. "I haven't exactly tried either. Is not in my blood trusting outsiders after so many years of keeping our kingdoms aparts. I think you above all can understand that"

Catra grimaces, remembering her first weeks in Camelot and the way she had treated Adora back then. "I guess it's important then to understand that our families' sins are not ours to bear" Catra hesitates, chewing on her lips before continuing "Help me understand, Light Hope. If you don't trust me then why did you bring me here? Adora said it had been your idea to join our kingdoms this way"

Light Hope's eyes seem to shine in the flash of a second. "You know why, your Majesty. We talked about it when I presented you the King's proposal on your Kingdom"

Catra's tail lashes violently against the carpets. "Because it was convenient" She hates it, she hates thinking hers and Adora's story started like that. Adora had consoled her time after time, assuring her that the start didn't matter, it was the rest what made their story. Still, Catra sometimes had to sit hours besides the white roses on their balcony until she reminded herself that, even then, there had been love.

"It was convenient", agrees Light Hope. Her expression hasn't changed but her silence is heavy with her thoughts. She looks like she is weighing them and Catra feels inexplicably nervous by it.

"I never thought she would fall in love with you," Light Hope adds. The confession makes Catra's voice tangle in her vocal cords, eyes widened with surprise, and she looks back at the woman next to her with her breath held. Light Hope doesn't even blink. "Political unions aren't always the most adequate place for romantic environment"

There is an undertone in her voice that Catra can't place and Light Hope doesn't elaborate more. They walk down the hallways in silence, with only their steps and Sir Azrael soft breathing behind to make echo in the walls. Catra's fingers brush the fabric of the tapestries in the walls, looking at the dragon enveloped in roses embroidered with beautiful handicraft. There are roses too, embroidered in golden thread across the length of her purple tunic, the sleeves of her shirt and the bottom of her soft pants. It's loose enough to accommodate her baby bump and allow her to move freely without the swirls of a skirt around her legs. The roses and the starry veil on her hair reminds her of Adora's roses and the ceiling of their chambers.

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"Light Hope, can I ask you a question?"

"Of course. You are the King". Catra hums, slightly uncomfortable, but she pushes through it and asks anyway.

"How did Mara die?". This time, Light Hope does have a reaction. She trips. The length of her dress tangles with her legs and she trips lightly with her own feet, straightening up again an instant later. Doesn't matter, Catra saw her, it made her look more… human.

"Did Adora not tell you?", questions Light Hope and she seems almost upset.

"I don't think Adora likes to remember his mother that way". Catra shakes her head, resting both of her hands in the low of her abdomen, looking for comfort in the warmth of her kitten. There is a tiny jolt there at the mention of Adora and Catra smoothes the kick with her thumb.

Light Hope's face constricts horribly and Catra feels a pang of guilt in her gut. She is about to backtrack when Hope's shoulders drop and then raise and her eyes melt into stone again. Catra bites at her lips nervously.

"It was in battle, of course. King Mara never walked away from the war, no matter the risk", her voice leaves her throat between clenched teeth. “The Liberation of Arrowfort had been fought over for many months. The Horde Empire was retiring, she didn’t need to stay there but she did” she pauses, reminiscing. “Nobody knows what happened there, but we found her sword and her helmet laying in the ground and we knew”

Catra thinks about it. About the pain and grief that everyone must have felt. Camelot, Light Hope, Adora. She shudders.

“Light Hope, you know-“ she tries weakly, “you know about what Shadow Weaver does. Maybe there is still hope-“

“There isn’t”, she interrupts rather harshly, though her tone softens down when she speaks next. "This isn't like that. Mara did die, we found her. The river washed her back a few days later, it was too late".

Catra's eyebrows scrunch painful and she lets out a shaky sigh. "I'm so sorry, Light Hope " Her ears press down against her skull with grief but Hope doesn't flatter, cold and distant as ever. "You must have loved her a lot"

"Love has no business in war, Queen C'yra" she states coldy yet there is an expression in her eyes that Catra can't place. "But- I would have done anything for her. Anything. Anything to have her back"

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They remain silent until they arrive at the end of the last hallway. Crossing the gate is the physician's quarters, this is where they part. Light Hope looks down at Catra in all her height, taking in the way she wraps herself around her baby.

"How far are you?"

"Almost five", answers Catra mechanically. This is the first time Light Hope has ever acknowledged her and Adora's child existence. Though, to be fair, this is also the first time they have talked at all since Adora left for Halfmoon.

"Does she know?", questions Light Hope and Catra's ears peak in attention.

"In a way"

"In a way?"

"The way that matters" affirms Catra. Light Hope doesn't make another comment, just holding her gaze in hers.

The heavy door opens and out walks Bow. His face splits into a wide grin when he sees Catra and then wavers into a frown when he takes on Light Hope's figure standing next to her. He raises his eyebrows to Catra, a silent question on them, but Catra just shakes her head lightly and steps closer to him.

"King Bow" addresses Light Hope, leaning respectfully towards him. Then she turns back to Catra and bows too. "Here we part ways, your Majesty". She straightens up and turns to make her leave.

"Thank you, Light Hope. For talking with me", says Catra before she can split away. Light Hope doesn't turn to look at her but tilts her head in recognition anyway, disappearing into the shadows of the hallways.

Bow squeezes Catra's shoulder gently with a kind reassuring smile on his lips. "Still trying to get to her?"

"Yes" Catra's tail comes to wrap against her own ankle, ears twitching as she considers the place where Light Hope went through. "She reminds me a bit of my mother, after mom died. So much grief in someone's shoulders"

"Well, at least you are trying. I don't think anyone has ever done that, except for Adora". Catra shrugges without answering, still thinking.

Bow ends up getting distracted because he gasps and leans over a little, mumbling with a high pitched noise to Catra's bump.

"And how is the little nugget doing". Catra makes a sound between a snort and a yuck, rolling her eyes so hard they strain.

"Ugh, don't call them that"

Bow pouts, in all his tall frame and strong arms, actually pouts to her, his eyes big and shining. "But you call them *peanut* all the time!"

"I'm their mother, Arrows. I have privileges", she teases, poking him with her nail. Bow giggles.

"Oh! I have something for you", he exclaims, roaming around the contents of his satchel until he fishes a small square, soft and of a cream color. He extends it to Catra, who takes it with shaky hands. When she examines it from up close she can see it's a blanket, neatly folded and clean. "Well, it's for the baby, but it's a gift for you".

"Did you make this?", questions Catra, blinking back the warm tears that had pooled in her eyes. Bow doesn't notice, he just nods, proud and happy.

"Knitted it myself!", he points to a strange spot on the blanket where the knots seem a little weird. "Glimmer helped a little too. You already have that little She-Ra ragdoll, we figured they would use something from us too". He sounds so cheerful and happy and Catra is holding back to not start fully sobbing. Bow does notices then and he searches her eyes, a small concerned crease on his eyebrows. "Catra? Are you alright?"

"Yeah", croaks out Catra, struggling. "I hate you all so much, don't talk to me"

Bow laughs out loud, enveloping an arm around her shoulders, loose enough to allow her to slip away if she wishes but also firm enough to squeeze her reassuringly.

"We love you too", he nudges her gently towards the door, helping her over the stairs leading there. "Come on, the physician is waiting for you. And it's *my* turn today, I didn't got to heart the heartbeat last time so we are definitely not arriving late"

"Sparkles insisted on being the first one, your loss", jokes Catra with a smirk. "You two and Adora are going to be insufferable through this, aren't you?"

“Oh definitely”, affirms Bow, but his eyes are very soft in the edges and it matches his smile. “She has always wanted to be a mom, Adora is going to be over the moon”.

Catra doesn’t answer, she doesn’t need to, but her tail does swish happily behind her and she brings her arm, the one that is not holding the tiny blanket, to wrap around Bow’s arm.

Bow does get to hear the heartbeat this time.

✾

...by the way, you can fire my Minister because I just fired yours. And another three. I'll explain when you are back but you are probably not going to like why I did it. I know you have this heart of gold of yours, but these people are assholes and showed their true colors when you were gone. I really don't have the patience today to deal with such horseshit.

I tried to have a heart to heart with Light Hope, yes I know what you are going to say. You are right, she just might not be that bad. I suck at talking with people though, never let me do that again.

Peanut pies are good. Great. Very healthy and sweet. Melog likes to snuggle next to them, I think it may be because of the warmth. I've been thinking, when you are back, I believe I would like to take peanut pie to Razz. I think she would be happy to know. Maybe she will even teach us one or two things. About, baking

This is so dumb. We are so dumb.

Also, since when does Arrow Boy knits? He's been trying to teach me for hours now and I don't know how to take that. But at least I'm better than Sparkles, she sucks.

Get home already, will you?

~ Catra

✾

Adora is definitely, positively, not lost.

Seriously. She isn’t.

She turned to the left instead of the right, yes. And she didn't exactly know where she was going when she took that last minute short cut. And she should have arrived in the chambers

hallways by this point already. And she hasn't been to this part of the palace in her entire time here.

But she isn't lost and that's important.

In all honesty, Adora got distracted. Somehow, after going into a recognition ride around the barriers of Halfmoon and entering the castle through a different gate, Adora had found himself in a completely new chamber, for him. It was full of books and loveseats, more like a study but huge. And in the center of one of the vibrat walls, hung a tapestry.

Someone had handmade it, a beautiful mix of reds and purples and golds, with three shapes standing on it, holding each other in a loose but regal embrace. Catra looked young and tiny next to her mothers. Adora had looked for long minutes at the lines of her soft, young face, the waves of her embroidered hair, her hands laced with her mother's. It's beautiful, a beautiful piece of art. Adora decides to commission the original artist to create a copy of it so they can hang it in Camelot, next to the other royalty portraits. After all, this is part of their family now too.

Adora had spent long hours looking at the tapestries in the chamber, taking in the scenes of Halfmoon's story. Its building, from being a quiet hidden place among the rivers and the lakes, built over the last remains of Avalon. Its golden age, when the seven kingdoms worked in peace and harmony and Etheria's magic ran free and untamed across every living creature. Scenes of rich harvests and huge banquets, and ballrooms full of people from every corner of Albion. The war. Uther's betrayal and the persecution of the magicats. The fall of the dragons. Halfmoon hiding behind walls and barriers, away from everything and everyone else. Queens and Kings and Regents along the years. Empress Ziba and Queen Tlalli, Catra's mothers. Catra's birth and there Adora had to take a breath. The Queens' death. Catra taking the throne. The tapestries went on and on until Adora was deep inside the palace and away from known paths. But there was a last one, at the very end, new looking and beautiful. It was them, Adora and Catra, holding hands on their wedding day. Catra’s red dress against the blue of Adora’s coat shimmered with golden threads. Adora didn’t remember Catra telling her any of this, so she figured she might not even know. Maybe it was a Scorpia thing, it certainly looked new enough to be just a few months old. Adora fixed his eyes on the image of their hands joined together, standing side by side. It had been so little ago yet it felt like an entire lifetime.

And that's how Adora got definitely-not-lost among the beautiful gardens. She walked through tall purple flowers with golden centers and huge green leaves that looked almost like roofs over her head. More colorful birds tweeted around the plants and the high fountains that looked like tiny waterfalls inside the palace. The sound of the drops of water against the virgin stones was calming, a lullaby from Halfmoon's earth and Adora found themself enchanted. She walked around like her feet knew these paths, as if her heart knew where to guide when her head could not.

The gardens end, giving up to high hallways with crystal roofs, allowing the light of the sun to enter and shower the inside in golden shimmers. Adora walks in quiet steps, not wanting to disturb the peace and calm of the place. She watches marveling at the way the light hits the

stones and the flow of water from the fountains, reflecting rainbows and sparkles into the ground.

Adora is brushing the edge of a soft leaf next to their leg when they catch with the edge of their vision the rush of a small tail running and hiding back into a thick bush of green. A little magicat. Adora tilts their head, surprised and a little amused, and walks towards the spot with a sprint.

"I wonder where that little tail went", she sing-songs, approaching the leaves. "Maybe it's right... here!"

Adora parts the leaves and finds nothing. No little magicat, not even traces of one in the soft damp earth below. Confused, Adora straightens and looks around, in time to catch the errant foot of a second kid running away. It makes Adora burst into soft giggles, shaking their head, making the braid brush softly against their back. She starts following the sound of their soft steps, in part to find the way back to the main corridors, in part because there is some visceral tug inside Adora that leads her to follow them down.

The corridor ends and gives a turn to the right, leading Adora into a second corridor, this one wider and just as illuminated and beautiful as the previous one. She can't see the blur of the kids anymore but there is only one way they could have gone so Adora keeps walking further, searching with her eyes and enjoying the warmth of the midday inside the castle. Adora is arriving at yet another turn of the corridor when she hears them. Giggles. High pitched bursts of bubbly laughter and squeaky yelps, as if the kids were chasing each other, enveloped in their own free and happy time and space. Adora rushes to the next corridor and comes face to face with two things: a dead end and a giant open gate. And absolutely no kids.

Adora hesitates, a strange feeling creeping on the back of his neck. She can't see the kids, yet she is sure she saw...something. Adora gulps, unnerved, approaching the gate with unsure steps, it's the only possible way anyone could have gone through. There are two senior guards standing there, one at each side of the gate's frame. They are tall, taller than Adora and their faces are peaceful to be guarding for goddess know how many hours this lonely corridor. *Maybe the gate is an exit,* Adora thinks and he walks a little bit quicker to them. The guards turn to look at him and their calm stoic expressions break into open surprise. They blink and then turn to look at each other, eyebrows raised as they hold a silent conversation among themselves.

Adora squirms, a little bit uncomfortable, and rubs their upper arm with their hand, shyly waving to the guards as greeting. "Hi. Hello", he says, smiling. Past the guards and the frame of the gate Adora can see a second garden, even bigger than the others like a small jungle inside the palace's walls. This one seems different, charged with energy and the drum of magic and Adora's very core feels attracted to its insides.

Adora is suddenly very aware that she has been staring so she clears her throat and pushes their shoulders back as she has seen Catra do countless times before. It helps them gain a little bit of confidence back. "Sorry. Have you seen a pair of kids running around here? They were playing in the gardens but I don't know where they went".

The guards stare at her speechless for a few moments and then look back at each other. One of them turns again to her and the wrinkles around their eyes deepen when they smile, shaking their long silver mane in negation. "I'm sorry, Your Majesty. Nobody has come and gone from here, no one besides you".

Their voice is deep with a thick accent that fits their exterior completely, yet their expression is soft and honest and though Adora appreciates it, the words of the guard just makes her even more confused.

"Are- Are you sure? I swear I was following them just a second ago"

"We are sure, my Lord", answers the other guard, just as tall and strong, silver flickers of hair mixed with the red of their mane. Her voice is gentle and sweet and she regards Adora like a grandmother would do with a young grandchild. "Nobody can come or leave from this place without us noticing. Maybe they went somewhere else?"

Adora nods absently, looking back at the inside of the new gardens. The guard's voice falls into a subspace away from Adora, like they were underwater and not right in front of him. The garden is pulsing, bright and alive in Adora's eyes akd the water that runs inside of it seems to be murmuring, singing to Adora to come in, *come in.*

"What is this place?", questions Adora, half expecting to have interrupted the guard. There is a funny expression on their faces but they don't seem offended. Quite the contrary, the guards almost look amused at Adora's curiosity.

"It's the Queens' Garden, your Majesty", explains the first guard, patiently. "The first place from where our ancestors built Halfmoon. It's our beginning".

Adora's eyebrows shot into their bangs. That explains it, the trum and pull of the garden inside Adora. This place drips magic itself. It's almost sacred.

Adora steps forward, barely even brushing the invisible line that divides the corridor from the garden and stopping before crossing it. There is something so pure inside this place Adora almost feels wrong by stepping into it. Adora is about to turn away when there is a blur of movement from inside and the sound of a faint squeaky giggle. The kids.

Adora eyes the guards, trying *and failing* , to mask her expression as best as possible from their eyes. If the kids had somehow passed through the guards without being noticed it probably wouldn't be good for them to snitch them over. After all, this doesn't look like a place for children to make their playground.

Adora squares his shoulders, raising their chin a little bit and looking at the guards with stern eyes. "May I come in?"

The guards' curious look melts into a bright smile and they both step aside in tandem, bowing slightly towards her. "Of course you can, your Majesty"

Adora feels relief though he tries not to show it too much and in a swift wave of courage he steps inside the garden, totally not looking back at the guards to see if they are watching.

"Thank you". The guards don't follow Adora with their gazes, they just stand there keeping the gate, so Adora relaxes and fully walks inside the garden.

It’s huge. Bigger than any other garden Adora has seen in Halfmoon. There are purple leaves that rise higher than Adora’s head with yellow flowers of thick smells. At ground level, there are blue and pink bulbs with green spiky leaves and orange thorns. The stones of the ground are deep black, obsidian shining with the damp that comes from the high waterfalls and the deep blue clean water. Everything in there smells alive and fresh, petrichor filling Adora’s lungs completely. Adora walks through the garden, caressing the velvet softness of the plants and pressing their hands over the soft dark earth until it stains the under skin of their nails. In the right of the garden there is a wall with the most beautiful mural, golds dripping from the sun and into the earth down, bursting in rushes of emeralds and rubies and lapis lazuli flowers, leaves and lakes. Birds in mid fly surrounding panthers and serpents and elephants. It’s so beautiful Adora has to press his hand over it to make sure it’s real.

In the North wall, two statues rise from the ground, carved in the very stone by expert hands. The first queens of Halfmoon wear sweet expressions, eyes closed and smiles resting forever in their stone mouths. The water has made their surface smooth and shiny with time and the lines of their dresses fall frozen forever in time in a soft silhouette down the floor. Both statues have their hands raised, cupped one over the other with their heads bent a little towards it, like they were offering something to the very sky and light that slips from the open ceilings.

Adora stands in the middle of it all with their mouth open, marveling at the beauty of it. This is a place Adora would spend his entire life in. Every single rock and plant and drop of water pours out pure, uncontained, free magic and Adora’s own is dancing inside their souls in happiness and excitement. It almost feels like coming back home.

A soft hush followed by a string of crystalline giggles brings Adora back to the present. He looks around, looking for the source of the sound until his eyes focus on the hands of one of the statues. They are wide and big enough to be able to hide two small children in it, high enough from the ground so that they go unnoticed at first sight. It's exactly the type of place Adora would hide in.

Adora steps close to the statue, knocking in the stone with their knuckles while leaning in one of the sides. “I must admit, that’s an excellent hiding place. Couldn’t have found one better myself”, Adora waits but there aren’t more sounds. He presses further. “But I’m also pretty sure you aren’t supposed to be up there. How did you even pass the guards unnoticed?”

Nothing. No giggles. no movements. Adora worries a loose rock with the tip of their boot, considering. It’s probably not Adora’s place and the kids seem to have been doing this for a while now. Still, something in Adora just needs to do this. Maybe it is the bubbling feelings inside their chest or the need to get back to Catra and their family already. For any reason, Adora finds themself unable to walk away. Adora walks away from the statue and close to a plain stone. It’s high enough that Adora could stand in there and peek at the hands of the statue.

Adora is climbing the rock when she hears a hush and a small laugh coming from the spot and Adora smiles, mischievous. Once up the rock, Adora bends a little their legs, preparing to

give a small jump and surprise the kits. *One, two. Three!* Adora jumps on their tippy toes, looking right into the statues before falling back gently to the ground. There is nobody there.

Adora feels a shiver go down their entire spine, the light of the sun going out by a huge cloud passing by. Adora stands there, shaken, turning and turning around as they look for anyone else but there is just no one. Adora is alone inside that huge garden and the sound of the giggles is no more, almost as if it hadn't existed at all to begin with. There are only thick shadows and silence. Suddenly Adora is feeling very overwhelmed, short of breath inside that damp reduced space. Adora wipes a hand over their forehead, cleaning a rush of fresh sweat that comes from anxiety.

Adora looks through the bushes, on the tall stems and between the flowers, over the statues and behind the waterfalls. Each step is more frantic than the other, but there is just nobody there, not a single soul but Adora and his mind. With a last circle to the garden, Adora walks right across the door and back to the fresh corridor outside, holding to their knees so they can slowly regain their breath. There is an uncomfortable rush on their ears, like a slap of water feeling their mind. Their head feels heavy and dizzy, pulsing painfully against their temples. Adora almost feels like fainting, confused by the abrupt change in their emotions. His heart is drumming painfully inside his chest, against his ribs, kicking into Adora's throat. They don't understand, their body is having a reaction and Adora doesn't understand why. Actually, Adora doesn't even notice the voices until their ears pop and their mind starts processing the fact that the guards are talking to him. Adora pants a few times, breathing in four seconds, letting in it for four and out for another four.

"...your Majesty"

"I'm alright, I'm alright", calms them out Adora, straightening as best as he can. The guards eyes are worried, looking back at the garden with confused gazes and then back at Adora. "It's just...I thought I had seen something there"

One of the guards places her hand on Adora's shoulder blades, helping him sit down near one of the fountains. "There is nothing there, your Majesty. Just old magic."

Adora nods, understanding the guard's words as they push their bangs out of their forehead. His hands are shaking badly, and Adora wipes them from sweat in their pants. Adora is not strange to ghosts, it's bound to happen in places so old and Camelot has tons of them, everywhere. But for some reason this feels personal. An unnerving feeling has slipped into Adora's bones and now all the relief they had gotten from finishing the works on Halfmoon and the day to go back to Camelot coming in closer, have banished, tampered. Maybe it is because Adora is exhausted. It hasn't been easy, being away from home, away from Catra, *especially* now.

Adora looks at the gate of the garden and then back at the guards, not even bothering to seem composed and regal. The guards' expressions are kind and they give Adora enough confidence to smile a little and ask with a low voice. "Could you please show me the way back?"

By the time Adora arrives at the dinner hall Scorpia is already there, looking nervous as they search among the Court multitud. Her face brightens visible when she spots Adora walking in

and she sprints to her with a wide white smile. Adora returns the grin easily. They feel more composed now, even if the guards had to escort him practically all the way back, eying him with every once in a while to be sure Adora was alright.

Scorpia arrives next to his side and envelopes them in a huge, tight hug, almost lifting Adora from the ground with the strength of it. Adora giggles, out of breath when Scorpia finally deposits them back to the ground.

"Hey, Scorpia", cheers Adora, struggling to get their breath back. Scorpia blushes, bringing both her pincers near to hear face in an apologetic manner.

"Oh, I'm sorry! But I'm so glad you are here! Thank you so much for staying for the Autumn Banquet" Scorpia says in a rush. "I didn't know if I could handle all the Court by myself"

"You are doing great, Scorpia", assures her Adora, patting the back of her spiky shoulders. "I'm just glad I could help"

"You've been amazing these months". Adora blushes, grasping the bottom of a wine goblet and drinking a little sip out of it. Their nerves are still everywhere and Adora needs the distraction right now. They can think about what happened earlier, later. "So, how's your last weekend at Halfmoon going? Any ghosts chasing your ankles?"

Adora turns to look at her with wide eyes and a pale face. Scorpia seems to catch on their expression because she shifts on her feet nervously, scratching the back of her neck. "I'm joking. Catra's moms always used to say that to us, because there seem to be a lot of actual ghosts around. Though I never saw any

"Oh", says Adora, laughing nervously. "Yeah, um- it's going great thank you Scorpia. It's nice to get to know Halfmoon without so much work"

"Yes! Halfmoon is usually a very peaceful place", Scorpia seems to let the uncomfortable moment pass, drinking from her goblet too. "Did you tell Catra you are coming back?"

"I sent her a letter this morning", Adora's eyes immediately go soft in the edges at the thought of Catra, the last of their anxiety slipping away like sand between their fingers. Both of them stay in silence for a while, looking at the people of Halfmoon walk and eat around.

The banquet had been a private Court event for many years but Adora had insisted on inviting all the people of Halfmoon. Everyone needs a little bit of fun during these times.

"I think I'm just excited to go home", admits Adora to Scorpia, smiling softly. There is a rush beside them and then the figure of the Commerce Minister walks from behind, his pointy eyebrows raised and a mocking smile on his pale lips.

"I'm sure we *all* will rejoice that day. Your Majesty", he says, voice thick and drenched with alcohol. Adora frowns, placing her own goblet back to the table.

"I assure you all of us will enjoy some surprises that day too", answers Adora, crossing their arms over their chest.

Catra is always following Adora's arms with that movement and Adora is sure it's because it makes them look stronger, if the blush on her wife's cheeks has anything to say about it. On the Minister, however, it seems to be threatening because he steps back a bit, snatching another goblet from the table with a click of his tongue and walking away is a rush. He doesn't even address Scorpia, at all.

Adora follows him with her sharp, silver gaze, biting down on her own bottom lip in displeasure. She can't wait to fire him in a couple of days.

"I'm glad Catra has you", says Scorpia out of nowhere. Adora turns to look at her with a surprised expression and Scorpia blushes under the attention. "She always seemed...lost, when we were growing up. Like something was missing in her. But after she met you, after she *really* met you, well, I've never seen her that happy before", Scorpia shakes her shoulders, cheeks and ears red. "I didn't really liked you at first but I'm very happy you love her just as much as she loves you"

Adora's expression melts away again, playing with the ends of her sleeves in a shy manner. "How could I not?", she says and she can feel the pick of tears on the rim of her eyes. "She means everything in the world to me"

Scorpia looks at her curiously, a sweet small smile on her lips. There is a sizzle outside of the chamber and then something that sounds like an acute explosion. Adora startles, hand already on Excalibur's handle, ready to jump out at the second. But next to her Scorpia is beaming, bumping Adora in the shoulder to call their attention and pointing to the gates, where the excited multitude had started to walk through to watch the dark sky being illuminated by bright colors.

"Come, the annual autumn fireworks are about to start." explains Scorpia. Adora relaxes when the words sink in, looking now curiously and increasingly happy through the frame of the door. "And that's a once in a life sight you can't miss"

❀

When Glimmer finds Catra, the latter is tightening the last knot in a red ribbon around a beautiful white owl. All her long wild hair is held to the side in a thick braid, keeping it away from her face, errands strands flying across her cheeks with the cold breeze that slips inside the top of the birdwatch tower. Catra turns to her, flicking her ears towards her direction in recognition.

“What are you doing?” asks Glimmer, stepping carefully in the cold stone so as to not slip down the floor. Catra pets the white owl head a few times, giving them a treat before letting them free into the air. Glimmer can see a piece of paper wrapped in one of their legs, the one with the red ribbon on it.

“Last letter to Adora”, she explains and it’s notorious that her spirits are lifted. Her cheeks are pink and warm, enhancing the beautiful freckles scattered across her cheekbones and nose, her multicolored eyes shining with happinesses. Even her tail is flicking gently behind her, curling in the air and down the floor several times. Glimmer can see her cradle the side of her

belly with one of her hands, unconsciously rocking herself side to side like she was lullabying the baby into sleep. The image made Glimmer smile, “She’ll be back in two days but we made a deal before she left, therefore the letter”

“A deal”

Catra smiles, small and mischievous and happy. “About certain kitten”

Glimmer snorts**,** rolling her eyes. "You are both ridiculous, you know that?"

"What? Are you jealous, Sparkles?", bites back Catra, crossing her arms. There is a pause and her expression contorts into something very near to pain and she pants out a few times while holding onto the frame of the windows. Glimmer transports in a second next to her, placing a hand on her back and another on her shoulder, helping her remain standing as she looks at her with worried eyes.

"Woah. Hey, don't take it so at heart kitty cat", she jokes, chuckling nervously. Catra hushes her and pretty much flips her, slowly but surely regaining her breath back. She breathes deep a few times and then shakes back her hair.

"They got me right in the kidney", she explains to Glimmer, calming her down. "I'm fine. They get like this every time I bring Adora up".

As if it was an answer there was another series of faint kicks, this time gentler for the tiny kit, and Catra chuckles with delight, rubbing the sore spots with the pad of her fingers.

"Yes, I know you are there peanut". Glimmer giggles by her side, leaning towards them but not touching the bump without asking first, as of respect.

"They sure are excited", she says after placing a finger in the most prominent part and getting a soft *thud* in response. "Are you sure you are fine?"

"Well, my back is killing me if you would like to trade spines". Glimmer snorts, crossing her arms over her chest and shakes her head strongly.

"No way in hell. A few more years for me, thank you very much". Catra sticks her tongue out to her, smacking her in the face with the point of her tail. They stand there bickering with each other until a soft purple glimmer coming from the outside pours through the window and into the watchtower. Catra and Glimmer look at each with raised eyebrows and then almost throw themselves against the window, eyeing the turmoil downstairs.

“Is that the Arcane Circle?” Catra leans against the window frame, studying the yard. The circle shimmers and shines brightly. Someone is coming through.

“But- only royalty can pass freely through it, and I have to activate it first”, Glimmer leans over Catra’s shoulder too, squinting her eyes. “Could it be Adora?”

Catra shakes her head. “She isn’t supposed to come back today”, there is visible anxiety dripping from Catra’s voice now. Glimmer sizes her by the hand and pulls her gently down the bird’s tower, helping her as she walks down the stairs in wiggling feet. She could have

transported them directly down there but Glimmer isn't taking any chances with the baby and Catra's nausea.

There are already a couple of people around the circle. Guards, knights and sorceress eyeing the magic gate with hesitating gazes. They turn to see both Queens as they step out of the tower, eyebrows raised while they expect orders. Catra shakes her head and moves her hand down in calm, silently ordering everyone to step back. The circle keeps shimmering, pink aura of magic waving as the rush of magic starts to come to an end.

Two people step out of the circle. A tall woman, maybe taller than Adora, all in pink. Pink hair, pink clothes, pink wings. And a man next to her, shorter with black hair tied neatly behind his back, a thick salt pepper beard and wide strong shoulders. The woman has a determined expression on her face while the man looks serious but softer, scanning the small group that had gathered around them to see.

Next to her, Glimmer gasps, rushing forward to embrace her parents in a strong grip.

"Mom? Dad? What are you doing here?"

"Glimmer", greets her mother, Queen Angella. Her father, King Micah, squeezes the three of them on his arms, almost lifting them from the ground.

"Hi kiddo"

Catra looks around as the family greets each other, nodding at the people in reassurance. Everyone bows to her and starts to scatter around, allowing them from so moments of needed privacy. Catra steps closer, nervously playing with the sleeves of her coat. Queen Angella must sense her because she raises her head and locks her eyes with hers. This is the first time Cara has met them in person, even after over a year of living in Camelot. Somehow, being under the gaze of this strong woman feels a lot like being under the gaze of her mother when she was little.

"Queen Angella, King Micah", Catra manages to greet them. The three rulers of Brightmoon turn to look at her back. Queen Angella smothers the fabric of her cape, leaning forward to speak to Catra.

"Queen C'yra-", she looks like she is going to say something else but her voice dies in her throat as she takes in Catra completely. Catra refuses to lower her own gaze but she knows her eyes are focused on her belly. King Micah, who has finally let go from his hug with Glimmer, seems confused for a second, looking at his wife and then back at Catra a few times.

"What is- Oh. *Oh".* There it is. His eyes turn impossibly soft and his entire face breaks into a big, kind smile. "Oh, how beautiful"

Catra flushes under the warm attention, ears pressed to the back of her head, and she searches for Glimmer's gaze who returns the look with a reassuring expression. King Micah steps to her and for some nerve wracking moments Catra thinks he is going to hug her too. They seem like kind and good people but they are also basically strangers too and the thought of letting

them so close to her and her kit out of nowhere makes the peach fur of her neck start to frizz. But he doesn't, King Micah stops in front of her with his hands calmingly resting one above the other. He is a little bit taller than Catra and he is also careful on not stepping too close into her personal space, which she appreciates.

“You know, I met Adora when she was this tall”, King Micah says, voice soft, signaling to a point barely below his knee. “She was such a little menace, but also such a sweet kiddo.” His expression is sweet as he reminisces and the words make Catra relax just a little more. She likes hearing about younger Adora, even if it is through someone else's eyes. Micah smiles widens and Catra finds herself smiling back. “I always thought they would be such a wonderful parent and look at you two now”

Catra feels herself a little bit teary and she blames it completely on the baby. She is tougher, she doesn't cry. And still Catra nods to the king, cleaning the rim of her eyes with the sleeve of her coat. "Thank you", Catra whispers to him very, very softly but she knows that he hears them, because his smile sugars even more.

Queen Angella and Glimmer walk towards both of them too. The former Queen's gaze is calculating, like she was considering all that Catra is in just a few seconds. It can be seen from miles away how strong this woman is, it makes Catra straighten her back and wait. But Queen Angella's expression also ends up melting and she gives Catra the tiniest, sweetest smile that makes Catra's inside swell a little with pride about herself and her kitten. *Look at this little thing Adora and I made,* she wants to say out loud. *It's greater than any of our kingdoms could ever be.* By the look on Angella's face, she knows what Catra is feeling.

“Is Adora back?”, she asks, gently.

“Not yet. They’ll be here before the week ends”. Angella nods at Catra's words, flipping her long pink hair to the side.

“Wonderful. It’s important we meet with them as soon as possible too”. Glimmer and Catra share a look and the first turns to face both her parents with her eyebrows scrunched.

“Is something going on?”. This time it is Micah and Angella who look at each other before answering.

"We have an idea. Of how to take down the Horde once and for all", explains Micah, his kind voice very serious. “But we need Adora”

Glimmer and Catra stand there speechless for a good couple of seconds. Catra weighs the regents' words again and again, thinking out of hee shock. She comes to reality first and tries to keep her face stoic and calm but her tail gives her away.

“Why Adora?”, she asks, silently cheering herself for keeping her voice without trembling.

“Adora is a Pendragon, a First One. There is ancient magic running on her veins. Adora holds an amount of power they can't even measure." Explains Micah. "You know she can heal, right?”

Catra nods. "What does that have to do with anything?"

"Emperor Prime" statements Angella, brow furrowed."We've been hiding under our own barriers for too long. After Arthur's death, after Uther, after the magicats persecution, we allowed the Horde to erase the magic of everything that wasn't under our barriers, we allowed Etheria to die. Emperor Prime used our absence to poison Etheria, poison Albion. He infected it. It started when he destroyed the Scorpion Kingdom and kept going and going. He is not going to stop."

"But, here is the thing", continues Micah. "Magic cannot be destroyed. No matter how much he tries, magic is the very root of the earth. There is always going to be magic around long after we are all gone. So, we think that what Prime is really doing is keeping all that magic for himself. He… consumes it. That's how he's been living for so long now"

"And that's why he needs Shadow Weaver so much", spits Queen Angella, infuriated. Catra shivers under the mention of Shadow Weaver and Glimmer takes her hand, squeezing gently. "She knows how to harvest that magic and use it not only for her but to keep him alive

"It would be too much", interrupts Catra. "Nobody can hold such amounts of power, they would die"

"You think Shadow Weaver uses some kind of vessel, right?", questions Micah.

"That's what my mother thought, yes."

"Well, given the current location of the Horde Empire, we think Shadow Weaver and Prime may be using, not only the Black Garnet, but the entire Scorpion Kingdom to hold down the magic"

"That's why you said he infected Etheria", whispers Glimmer, worrying her lip between her teeth. Her parents nod, serious.

"Wait. If all of this is correct, what is Adora supposed to do with that?", interrupts Catra, breathing quickening. Micah places a calm hand over her forearm, calming her immediately. She can see now where Glimmer learnt it from.

"She can heal, Queen C'yra. She can heal Etheria"

"If Adora channels all that magic in a different way, in boosting magic instead of cells, she would be able to increase it. And we mean all of it." adds Angella, taking Glimmer's hand.

"If we can get Adora there and help them heal the land he stole-"

"Then we could free Albion's magic. We could Etheria", ends Catra, out of breath.

"Exactly"

Catra feels her whole world spinning. After so many years, after so much pain, it seems as if all the answers were being handed to her on siñver plate. A reason, a resolution. A plan. An actual way to end the nightmare.

"Why Adora?", pleads Catra, without being able to stop it. It seems to be the only thing she can focus on right now. It may be because her heart is always with Adora, or because for some fucked up destiny it seems that Adora is always the one that needs to throw herself on the fire. Or maybe because their baby had started moving again, restless on their mother's anxiety. Catra doesn't know, she doesn't care. Glimmer turns to look at her and her expression goes from clear surprise to something very much like pity and Catra despises it besides her best efforts. She doesn't want pity, she just wants for people to stop throwing Adora side to side.

"The very core of Etheria's magic rests on Adora's hands' ', explains Micah patiently, after a ñong shared look with his wife and a nod of understanding. "We don't know why but Camelot has always been the very center of it. The Pendragon bloodline has always held the balance of Ethernia's magic, ever since the very beginning of the kingdoms". Catra knows why, Adora and Serenia explained it. Serena said it to her. *The heart of Etheria lives in the eyes of its last dragon* . Without Adora, everything they had so carefully built would be unprotected. She had to bite her tongue to not speak. She felt like Serenia' swords had been meant only for her and so, she would keep it in secret from the others, at least for now"

"First it was Arthur and Merlin. And then Mara. But none of them ever used their magic to heal. It was always war and battle and destruction. Until now, until Adora. Because she is kind. Because she wants to heal. Her people, her home. This isn't only something a Pendragon can do, but something only Adora can do", finishes Micah, eyes soft towards Catra.

Because is the way Adora is, it's left unspoken between the four of them yet loud enough for everyone to hear. Because of course she is. She is on Halfmoon right now, proving that.

"If we do this. That would mean we would need to go into the Horde Empire", says Catra, shaky and pale. "We would need to confront them. Emperor Prime, Shadow Weaver. Face to face once and for all. Finish it. Finish *them* "

"We also have a plan for that", immediately assures Queen Angella and her expression is open and kind and, most important of all, hopeful. "We will go in, together, and we all will help. Adora won't have to do this on their own. She won't be alone". The Queen's pale eyes bore into Catra's own like warm rain.

She can picture that. A place without war, without fear, without barriers, without hiding away. A place where they can raise their child in peace. Catra sighs and squares her shoulders, eyes and posture high and determined.

"I'm listening"

End of Chapter XIII part I

Chapter End Notes

Angella and Micah are joining our story, finally.
Secrets and lies are unfolding, what will they bring upon us all. I gotta say, someone has been lying from the very beginning

BABY UPDATE: By this point the story Catra is about 18-19 weeks

Do you like our each chapter music? You can check up the official Camelot AU playlist right here! (https://open.spotify.com/playlist/2H5i8V1Jy7QtRrWOC7fxLN?si=11d37deb951f4910), six hours of amazing music carefully curated by your truly. Probably will add even more music with time! Also, I'm working on a secret project for this story that I'll announce soon in the future!

Hope you liked this chapter. Kudos, comments and bookmarks are always appreciated. Be good!

Chapter 9: Aconite and Rowan

Chapter Summary

Adora's heart constricts at the thought of Catra.

Where is she right now? Is she sleeping? Is she walking through the gardens?

Is she in the yard, waiting for Adora to come home?

Chapter Notes

Hello and welcome. We've reached the point of no return and not gonna lie friends, I'm freaking out about this chapter a little lot, I've been freaking about it for a month, so let's just get into it.

Warnings for this chapter: Graphic descriptions of battle, wounds and mentions of blood. Mentions of refugees and survivors
There is a particular scene where Adora gets slightly injured on her upper arm. I know it may be a triggering topic so I've marked it with ***** to be able to skip easily.

I promise, everything will be alright. Take your time.

See you at the end

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 8 Part II. *Aconite and Rowan*

There was more to say, but for once we did not say it.

There would be other times for speaking,

tonight and tomorrow and all the days after that.

He let go of my hand.

— Madeline Miller, *The Song of Achilles*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x (warning, volume increase) x x

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❀

Adora is bleeding.

She limps through the empty corridors of the palace, one hand pressed tightly against her side, the other firmly grasping around the handle of Excalibur, who's blue blade shines in magical light, providing her with a dim light. The iridescent shimmer barely allows her to see her surroundings.

The side of her head troves from where the stones that fell from the ceiling hit her, sticky red blood plastering the hairs of her bangs over her forehead and ears. She is covered in gray ashes, all over her ragged clothes and dirty face, making her look frantic. Her winged helmet is nowhere to be seen and the smooth surface of her armor is scratched in places, both by spells and other swords, deep dents over their right shoulders from where the hits got her too hard. The leather gloves on her hands are broken and long gone, torn by the effort of lifting fallen stones and fighting her way out from crumbled chambers. She can feel her hair matted against the back of her skull and neck by sweat and by mud, the careful braids she had done that very morning tangled in painful nods. Her eyes sting for the fire, the harsh wind and unshed tears Adora is barely holding back.

Outside there are screams, yowls of fear and desperation as the people of Halfmoon try desperately to leave, to run away, to escape. Anywhere. But there is nowhere to go. The sky is red as the barrier around Halfmoon that burns out and crumbles into the ground, painting the black clouds in sparks and sickening white lightning. The water of the canals is shaking, distraught by its people's fear. The main gate of Halfmoon with its monumental marble statues it's broken in pieces, a monstrous mirror of Salineas Port weeks ago. The quick and devastating march of the Horde's army across the remains that once was the bridge thrums on the ground with the strength of its thousand soldiers, shaking the very earth, killing the green and the blue and the purple on its walk.

Adora is panting, clenching their teeth as they swallow the pain on their ribs and their head and their ankle. She is sprinting down the corridor, blindly crossing through the paths she has been walking on for weeks now, letting her feet guide her by instinct and nothing more. She is alone. Adora is completely alone in there.

She needs to get out of here and she needs to get out now.

But she can't.

People are still running, people still have a chance, a chance to survive. As little as it may be, Adora still can save them. She needs to prioritize them, now more than ever. Halfmoon can't fall. Adora will make sure of it, Adora *promised* it. This is Catra's home, this is the place where she was born and where she grew and lived. Where she laughed and where she cried. This is the place where she and her family kept their people safe. Months ago on their first day together, Adora didn't only promise to protect Catra, she promised to protect them all. And now it's all breaking like glass into sand, with Adora's hands impotent and unable to do anything but watch.

Adora’s eyes burn with the lights, the explosions, the dust falling from the ceilings. The North Chambers are dead silent, empty. The refugees and magicats that hide there are gone, souls ripped off in colored sparkles as their bodies disappear with the mist, stolen away by the black figure that hovers over them huge and menacing as it grows in power with each soul.

She needs to get out.

She needs to get out and, oh goddess. Catra.

Catra’s heart is going to break.

It happened too quickly. Adora was preparing Swift Wind, packing the few goodbyes gifts Scorpia and other magicats had given her during her stay there and the rest of the ítems inside their satchel. It was midday and sunny, the sun shining brightly over their heads. Adora could hear the laughing of children on the square and the knight's horses eating as they prepared to leave. The sound of the market in the main yards, alive and full of people looking to buy groceries and other trinkets for the rest of the day. It was like any other sunday.

Adora's heart was in her throat, the excitement of coming back home starting to overwhelm her completely before she could even ride Swifty. Catra's last letter rested warm in the pocket of her undershirt, secured over her heart by the chainmail and the chest of her white gold armor. It had arrived that very morning, at dawn, and Adora consumed it with her eyes until her brain and heart knew every word, every space and point. It had fueled Adora with happiness and something that could only be described as joy. The sweet autumn breeze ruffled their light hair and Adora could feel the soft weight of Catra's ring in her finger, well loved and precious. Precious, so precious, like the skin of her wife's, like the life they had created together and that Adora couldn't wait to meet with her own heart wide open.

It had truly been the perfect weather.

And then the baby hairs in Adora's neck and arms raised on point and a white nose cluttered her ears. She had raised her head up and into the sky, watching the flocks of birds flying away in a hurry and the banks of clouds stop their curse through the air. And in a sudden flash of green light, the carefully constructed barriers around the kingdom cracked like broken glass. There was a heartbeat where everyone held their breath, waiting. A rush of electricity sizzled over the sky and the protection spells were destroyed, all at the same time, runes glowing bright and exploiting in neon colors like mocking mirrors of the banquet's fireworks. In less than ten minutes, the barrier was gone and Halfmoon was exposed.

The screaming came no much longer.

It was a roar and a second explosion and Adora turned in time to see the main gate blowing up in red fire and smoke. The wave of energy sent them all to their knees, the horses getting scared and running away from their reins. Adora barely had time to let go of Swift Wind before he snapped up and away from the sound of the explosion, frantic and terrified. On the streets below, the Halfmoon's habitants wailed in terror and started running in every direction, barely picking up their elders and children, bare feet crashing against the terracotta ground or throwing themselves to the turquoise water of the canals to try and escape away.. A

thousand and more Horde soldiers marched through the destroyed gate, all black armors and red flags.

Adora and the knights squadron looked in horror as the army advanced, swords drawn as they started persecuting and surrounding the people around. Adora sprinted back to her feet immediately, ready to shout orders when a black mass seemed to overtake the gate, like a smoke cloud but thicker, darker, pulsing with energy as if it had life on its own. The soldiers stood still as the cloud grew bigger and bigger and denser, overtaking the entire entrance. The shadow didn't move, enveloping frantic people on itself. There was a moment suspended in time and a dozen of lightning inside the dark cloud, followed by muffled screaming and shouts. And after, just silence.

"Fuck", had muttered Adora, shaking themself from their frozen state and turning to the squadron. "Shadow Weaver is here. We need to evacuate, now!"

Lonnie was standing right next to Adora, eyes big and frightened. The tight dreadlocks in her head we're starting to look grey and when Adora looked up she saw it was for the ashes that were falling softly over them like snow. Adora had grabbed Lonnie by the shoulders, shaking her a few times to get her back into reality.

"Lonnie! We need to evacuate!". Lonnie turned her eyes to them, breathing hard a few times and nodding.

"Yes, yes." She turned to the other knights and pointed with her head to the direction of the market and the rest of the houses. The knights looked just as stunned but collected themselves and scattered around, mixing with the running people and pulling them in groups towards the direction of the circle. Lonnie turned back to Adora, holding her sword so hard her knuckles were trembling. "What do we do?"

"Get everyone as safe and far from the Horde as you can. We can't travel to Camelot until everyone is here, they are almost over us is just too risky" she looked around, watching the roof of the watch tower catch on fire and the high Halfmoon banners fall into the ground. Adora gulped heavily, searching with her eyes until she spotted the thickest part of the purple woods. "Tell the knights and as many Halfmoon warriors to take everyone with them to the woods. Horde soldiers are not used to this vegetation, it may protect them. I'll go to the palace for Princess Scorpia and the rest of the Court. Lonnie, you and the rest of the squadron go to the market and the downtown, be sure nobody stays. No packing, no hesitating."

Lonnie nodded, expression hard and professional, initial shock washing away and giving place to bravery. "What do we do about Shadow Weaver?"

Adora turned their head down, to the start of the streets where the cloud walked, floated, slowly and unhurriedly, taking souls like crashing flowers with her foot. "Avoid her. We can't jeopardize the civilians' safety. Do not engage her, Lonnie, am I clear?". Lonnie seemed to hesitate but accepted, signaling to a couple of knights and running down the hill.

Adora had started running immediately after, following the paths to the palace with quick steps, picking people up and signaling them to the woods with long shouts. When Adora arrived at her destiny the palace was burning up, high columns of smoke rising from the

windows and into the bleeding skies. It looked as if the top floor had been exploited from the inside out, the fire dripping like hot lava into the remaining floors. People were running everywhere, picking a few personal items, tripping on their feet, shouting. Adora had climbed the high steps into the palace, finding as many people as she could and sending them out, quickly.

By the time Adora had taken everyone out, two young sorceress aprendices had managed to suffocate the fire as best as possible. Adora had charged them to guide the people into the woods while she finished scanning the chambers. In the village, the silence was starting to fall like a heavy blanket over them all, only a few strangled shouts and yells heard before going down too.

Now Adora scans the last chamber of the floor, eyes sharp to catch any movement both enemy or friendly. She doesn't know how much time has passed, it feels like a lifetime and also like just a couple of seconds. The room is smoking and blackened, pieces of furniture thrown to the side and glasses from the windows smashed on the floor. It looks empty, so Adora steps back and trips with something. It’s a piece of fabric, charcoal and ashes after burning down. Adora inspects it up close and then her throat closes as she makes up the destroyed figures of Catra’s family tapestries, lying in the floor broken and gone. Adora fights a wave of hot tears and their heart pangs painfully against their ribcage. They stand up from where they had kneel, leaving the chamber and back into the hallway without looking back.

It might be the pain in her temples because she doesn't see him coming. A huge Horde soldier, bear-like built with a black armor and a flail on his hand, crashes against Adora with the full force of a steel wall, sending her tethering over the corridor and slamming painfully against the hallways of the castle. The back of her head connects against the stone wall, expelling all the air out of her lungs and darkening her sight in black spots. Adora gasps, losing her grasp of consciousness for a second before coming back to her senses in time to see the soldier charge towards them again with full force. Adora grunts, using the palms of their hands to impulse themself and get out off the wall, spinning over their ankles and swinging with their entire strength Excalibur towards the soldier's breastplate. It crashes loudly, bending the steel like paper with the hit. The soldier mutters in surprise and rage, snapping his hand up to try and grab Adora's wrist. Adora draws Excalibur away, surging forward and placing her bare hand over the man's shoulder. Golden magic envelops Adora completely, making the hair of her head turn almost white and her eyes shine bright blue. The man’s eyes widen in surprise as Adora gives a raspy yell, raising her hand and with it the entirety of the soldier’s body and then shooting it forward, sending him flying through the mess of rocks and broken mosaic and out of the crumbling palace completely.

*****

Adora exhales, leaning over Excalibur as a makeshift cane as she tries to regain her breath. There is a gruesome, cool pain in the side of her left forearm and when she turns her head to inspect it she can see a broken piece of glass has broken skin and is bleeding, red drops slipping uncomfortably down her arm and the curve of her elbow. Adora grimaces at the wound, taking a better look at it to see if she can bandage it and be good to go. It’s deep, however, adrenaline may be protecting them from the immediate pain but it will be a problem

later, especially because Adora still has to fight her way out. The silver voice of Catra rings in her memory with a promise made before leaving. *Take care of yourself, Adora, please.* Adora sighs, biting down hard on her lips to not cry. She can't start thinking, she can't get distracted because if she does she is going to lose her focus completely and she can't afford that now. With trembling fingers Adora picks the little pieces of glass still embedded on their skin and then places their entire palm over the wound, breathing very deep before letting her eyes fall closed. This time, the golden magic only shines on her hand and arm, wrapping the skin in warm energy before turning down again. Adora exhales in relief and raises her hand to find only smooth skin where the wound used to be.

*****

Adora straightens her shoulders, breathing through their nose a few times before climbing a few stones fallen on the way and exiting the palace. The infinite stairs that lead down are mostly broken by blows of defensive magic from the magicats and offensive hits from the Horde. Adora looks at the sides and finds the place completely empty besides herself, a cold sweat traveling down her back with it. Absently Adora wonders where the sorceress and high priests of Halfmoon are and the thought of their possible faith gives her chills. Adora finds good ground to scale down the stairs, careful of not mistepping and going falling down the rest of the way. They sigh with relief when their feet touch the familiar earth below and Adora is searching again, looking through the abandoned and destroyed houses, stores and warehouses around the palace to make sure nobody is being left behind.

Rows of houses have collapsed on themselves, wood and stone mixed together in what before were homes. The colorful plants that surrounded the buildings are dead and grey, as if by taking its habitants magic the core magic of Halfmoon had been taken too. The silence in the yard is loud in Adora's ears as she climbs the remains of one of the houses, fine splinters scratching the palms of their hands and ash covering their golden hair in silver. There is nothing inside, just material belongings abandoned in a rush and broken glass from where the windows have given up. Adora is about to turn and leave when she hears a soft rustle and then the tiniests of sobs. Her entire blood goes cold inside her body as Adora looks around the lonely house, stepping carefully to not startle away. Adora stills next to a messy nest of what once was a bed when she hears it again, soft and scared, the unmistakable ring of a cry coming from between the rumpled blankets.

Adora kneels into the ground, leaving Excalibur on the floor next to him as he lifts very gently one of the blankets. A small feline green eye looks right back, followed by tiny baby cheeks drenched in tears and the most messed red mane. Adora gasps under his breath, raising his hands up to demonstrate they mean no harm at all.

"Hello", Adora calls in a whisper. The magicat child, who is holding their small tail between their hands, shivers and tries to bury themself further into the nest. Adora coos gently at them, trying to imitate the soft sounds Catra sometimes makes when she is sleeping or when she is comforting one of the kids of Camelot's orphanage. It's a bit awkward, but the rusty chirps call the child's attention and their ears flicker at Adora in recognition. Adora smiles softly at them, resting her hands back in her knees as they look at each other. She knows she must look like a fright right now, bruised and covered in dirt and blood, but the child doesn't look scared anymore but curious.

"Hello", tries Adora again, "it's alright sweetie, I'm not going to hurt you"

The child seems to consider her words and then peaks a little outside their nest, sniffing in the air with their little nose. Whatever they smell must give them confidence because they scramble outside from the blanket and stare at Adora. They can't be more than five and outside of dirty clothes and a bruise on their chin they seem completely unscarred. Adora sighs in relief, still not moving forward but calling their attention again with a small flick of her hand.

"We need to go, sweetie. I can take you somewhere safe, but I need you to take my hand first. Alright?"Adora extends her hand, waiting patiently for the kid. The small one looks at her palm, at her eyes and then back around the house, a distraught frown crossing over their eyebrows.

"Mommy?", they ask hesitatingly and their voice is a bit raspy and unsure. It breaks Adora's heart. Adora, who is about to become a mother too and is kneeling in the destroyed ground of a kingdom she failed to protect.

Adora gulps, trying to clear her throat before speaking. "I don't know where your mommy is but I can help you look for her. We just need to go first"

The kid regards Adora's hand with sad eyes, cleaning their nose with the tiny back of their hand before nodding and extracting themself of the entire tangle. They, however, completely ignore the hand and throw themself to Adora's arms, sniffing gently against the gold of her armor. Adora lets out a watery laugh, surrounding the child with their arms and rocking them gently from side to side. They stay like this for a short while but Adora has to part from them at some point, smoothing their wild mane with their hand.

“Alright, sweetie, hop hop”, Adora says signaling to herself. The kid understands, nestling on Adora’s side with their little head hidden on her neck and their small legs barely wrapped over their waist. Adora grabs the handle of Excalibur and stands up, walking outside the remains of the house. The child is so tiny they weigh basically nothing to Adora, not more than a handful of grapes.

Adora and the little kid walk outside of the debris of the streets, down the canals and into an opening of the purple woods where the leaves are thick and the branches are twisted in odd ways. Adora has to dodge a little to cross them but she doesn’t mind, holding the child tight against her chest as she finishes scrambling through the woods and comes out through the other side, into a small field with pink grass and tall trees circling it and keeping it secured for a short while. There are a myriad of people already there, about fifty to sixty people both magicats and others that had been able to escape the attack to Halfmoon and shelter in the woods. Just a handful of knights both from Camelot and Halfmoon are there, matted in ashes and dirt and bruised all over for fighting their way out. Some of them are sitting in the ground catching their breath or tending to others wounds with quick hands and clean bandages. It’s so little people, compared to the actual expanse of Halfmoon. Adora doesn’t know if the rest of the knights have managed to take out more.

Scorpia is kneeling on the ground in front of a group. Her cheekbone is bruised and there is a gash of a sword in her left shoulder but she is untouched otherwise. She had single handedly

taken out at least a dozen of people from Halfmoon in one go and had only accepted to stay in the field when the sound started to go down. She catches Adora entering the place and rises to her feet, rushing to them in a hurry. Her usual black and red clothes are torn in some places and burned in others. Her white hair is grey, falling matted and limp over her eyes as she moves. The pink rose pendant Princess Perfuma had gifted her many moons ago still hangs from her neck.

"Adora! Thank goddess", exclaims Scorpia. She stops a few feet apart, looking at the small magicat in Adora's arms.

Adora smiles back, wobbly and weak, guarding Excalibur back into their belt to give Scorpia a one arm hug. The little magicat wiggles on their arms, sniffling, and Adora can feel tiny warm tears against her neck, between the leather and steel. Adora sighs, looking back at Scorpia in the eyes.

"I'm alright. The palace, the market and the downtown are empty", she says, grimacing.

"Oh", whispers Scorpia, brushing her pincer softly over the child's back. It's not a motive for celebration. It just means the rest are gone. Adora's eyes sting with tears and she breathes a few times as she looks at the people around, at their dropped shoulders and ash covered clothes. Scorpia places her pincer on Adora's back, trying to cheer her with a tiny smile.

There is a sudden squeal that startles everyone and Adora turns her eyes up. A magicat woman with a green and yellow dress and a wild mane of red hair stands in a rush from a group of people. She looks with big bright green eyes at Adora, filled with tears and a small spark of fear and hope.

"Sizzie?", she whispers. Adora has seen those eyes before. She rubs the ears of the child gently, calling for their attention.

"Hey. Look who is there". The child squirms and raises their head from Adora's shoulder, looking at where she is pointing.

"Mommy?". The woman gasps, tears running free down her tanned cheeks and runs to Adora, who hands them to her with shaky hands. Both mother and child embrace each other tightly, laughing and hugging each other as close as they can. Adora smiles, brushing off a few tears from the corner of their eyes with the tip of their fingers. The mother looks back at her and gives her a swift, honest hug, patting Adora's cheeks with her child still pressed against her chest.

"Thank you, your Majesty, thank you so much" Her ears flicker in the same way Catra's do when she is relieved. Adora feels so overwhelmed with emotions that she can only nod, lip wobbling as she watches them nuzzle their noses together and go back to the rest of the survivors. The little child's eyes meet Adora's as they walk away and they give her a big, toothy smile before hiding back on her mother's neck.

Adora stands there without moving, mind raising miles away, back at home. She wonders about Catra, what she is doing right now. What did she have for breakfast? Is her hair up

today or in soft curls down her back? Has she been sleeping well? Is she reading in the library or walking in the towers?

Is she singing to their little baby, songs that will lull them to sleep after they are born?

"Adora", murmurs Scorpia, a concerned look in her eyes.

"Yes", answers Adora absently, cleaning her hands on the fabric of her pants from the dirt and blood. "I'm alright. Why don't you let me take a look at that?"

They turn fully to Scorpia, placing a hand over the wound on her shoulder and pressing down. Their magic tickles and shimmers, curing the wound back together. Again and just like with her arm earlier, there is only smooth skin left behind.

"Wow, thank you", Scorpia sighs gratefully, rolling back her shoulders before seemingly looking for the first time fully at their face. "You are hurt too. Why don't you-?"

"I'll be fine", interrupts Adora, ignoring the frustrated looks from Scorpia in order to scan the woods. Scorpia seems to understand that she is not going to win that battle because she drops her shoulders, pointing at a treacherous path in the North.

"I've talked with some magicats. If we take that way we should be going in the direction of Camelot. Is going to take a couple of days but we can make it. We were just waiting for you".

It 's true. The magicats and other people are packing the few belongings they could grab inside their satchels, some helping others stand, others carrying big baskets filled with as much fruits and berries they could find in the woods for the trip. The magicats eyes are full of sadness. Adora looks at them trying to not look back at what once was their home, she can see the pout on the children's mouth and the pressed lips in the youngsters and adults. But they gather themselves as best as they can, resolve never waving, hope never dying. They have survived once, they can do it again.

Some knights look at Scorpia, who nods in approval as they start to walk into the makeshift path, walking over the leaves on swift and quiet steps. Scorpia turns to follow them too, ruffling her hair out of her eyes.

Adora could go. The path is right there, the fires and the Horde soldiers behind them. She could hide under the protection spell that the young sorceress has casted over them and walk away with Scorpia and the survivors. She could leave Shadow Weaver and her horrors behind. She could follow the path until her feet hurt but she is back in Catra’s arms. She could cradle her close and tell her how much she loves her. She could kiss her hands and cheeks and the curve of her belly. She could go home.

Another scream inside Halfmoon rips the air behind them. There are still people there, magicats and sorceresses fighting back the Horde with all they have, holding them back enough so others can leave. They are still there. Adora makes a decision.

“You go”

Scorpia stops in her tracks and turns to Adora with a frightened expression. “What- what do you mean?”

Adora gulps, their face paling even more. Every muscle and bone on their body aches and they are tired, Adora is so tired. But she squares her back and blinks back the sadness, looking at Scorpia with all the bravery and confidence of a king, “I have to get the rest of the villagers out. You go. You know the path to Camelot, they will open the gates for you. Go”

Scorpia hesitates, unsure of her place as she looks from the caravan of people to the unmoving figure of Adora. There is a sweat breaking on her forehead and she fidgets with her hands as she shifts on her position. “Adora, I don’t-”

“Please”, says Adora and the way it comes out is almost a plea. Her golden and scratched armor jingles against each other and it takes a huge amount to focus for Adora to not let the shaking make her teeth tremble as she speaks. “I need you to go. We don’t know how much advantage we have. The Horde could roam the woods anytime now. I need you to look for the survivors, to take them to Camelot. I need you to tell them what happened. I need-” Adora chokes on her words, unable to keep going on with her thoughts. *I need you to take care of Catra, I need you to be there for her.* Adora exhales. “I’ll see you there, alright? But you need to leave, now”

Scorpia doesn’t look sure at all and is starting to get Adora a little frantic. Inside the walls of Halfmoon they can hear a couple more explosions and loud shouts. Adora bites their lips nervously, begging to Scorpia with their steel eyes. Whatever Scorpia sees in them seems to make her understand and she nods, approaching Adora in order to give her a tight hug.

“I’ll see you in Camelot”, murmurs Scorpia over them. Adora gulps back a new rush of tears, nodding against Scorpia’s spiked shoulder.

“I’ll see you there”, she parts from Scorpia, giving her a reassuring pat on the upper arm and turning back towards the edge of the woods, following the remains of the canal walls and climbing the scattered rocks back to Halfmoon’s ground.

Adora crosses the remains of the market at full speed, following the sound of the fighting. There are baskets forgotten on the floor and colored powders scattered in the stones that make the soles of their boots turn into makeshift rainbows as she sprints through the empty streets. There is a harsh, loud crash a few meters away and when Adora turns the corner she finds herself face to face with a whole Horde squadron pushing back a small group of Halfmoon warriors. The magicats are dressed in full battle clothes, with skeleton masks sculpted in white stone over their war painted faces, painting covering their eyes and noses and down the length of their necks. Their manes look like wild fires under the sun, adorned with long green and red feathers and jeweled rings. The breastplates on their chests are adorned in turquoises and jades, catching the light of the sun and the magic in sparkles of color. Down their arms and chests and legs there are swirls of paint, some simulating animals’ spots, other curved lines the the flow of water, others spiked triangles like bursting flames. Some of them carry dented swords or huge wood and copper spears that look deadly even by looking at them. The ones that aren’t hand in hand in combat with the soldiers are riding enormous black panthers who roar menacingly and loud over the sound of the explosions.

One of the Horde soldiers hits one of the warriors right in the mouth with the handle of their sword, grabbing them by the hair and yanking them away. A second warrior, riding one of the panthers, jumps down and clashes her hand in the ground, yelling as if she was carrying something very heavy. From her palm, orange light is born, spilling in the cracks of the ground and expanding like lava in every direction. There is a beat of silence and then a vicious crack that calls the Squadron attention. The roots and branches of a nearby tree gain life of their own, twisting on themselves and shooting forward like harsh whips. They get the Horde soldier, wrapping themselves thighs against their wrists and ankles until they let the warrior go just to yank back on themselves and throw the soldier a hundred feet up and away with a blood curdling scream. The warrior that had been grabbed twists in the ground, jumping light on their feet. The blue painting on the swirls of their body and palms shine brightly and the canals shake with force, all the water being lifted by an invisible force over itself, forming a stilled blue wall that makes the Horde step back for a second. The warrior smirks, fangs flashing from between their lips and then makes a movement like throwing something heavy away, the water moving with them and hitting a third of the soldiers with full force, only gurgles and gasps being heard as they are washed away by the magic. Adora can see a third warrior, throwing spears from the back of a panther, yelling in defiance every time she hits. Her magic is literally on fire, pink flames bursting from the floor in semicircles and crashing violently against the Horde, pushing them back as much as she can. A fourth warrior, standing in the high of a immense rock, takes something small from in between their clothes, brown and of an odd shape and it's only until she puts it in her lips and the skull shaped figure can be seen that Adora understands it's a whistle and she has only seconds to cover her ears before magicat blows with the entire strength of her lungs. It's terrifying. It sounds like a thousand war screams together, vibrating so high and intimidating that the very earth shakes in fear. The eyes of the soldiers widen in terror, looking everywhere to try and catch where the sound is coming. The fourth warrior takes advantage of the sudden distraction, raising her hand and closing it in a fist. Immediately, a dozen of giant panthers run forward, charging against the squadron and pushing them from side to side until some of them turn away, scattering in behind the remains of a few fallen buildings to shield themselves from the Magicats.

Now Adora can see the warriors are placed almost in a half circle around some ruins. She looks closely and sees a small group of villagers hiding between them, waiting for the squadron to turn away so they can escape. The warriors relax for a second, not seeing Adora watching them from the other side, to turn to the people. On the hill above their heads, another squadron of Horde soldiers blast a tall building, sending a myriad of large rocks down the hillside, right towards them. The warriors don't see it coming. Adora does.

She runs so swiftly on her feet that it almost looks like she is flying, arriving at the center of the group so quickly the warriors barely have time to take in her presence when Adora is already shouting, inhumanly loud and piercingly "DOWN!".

Everyone throws themselves to the ground without a second thought, the panthers coming back unscarred to cover the villagers with their own bodies. Adora raises Excalibur to the sky and then lowers it into the ground, swinging hard to the side. A powerful wave of magic crashes against the biggest parts into little pieces like they were clay, still falling at full speed in their direction. Adora embeds Excalibur in the grass below their feet, eyes brightly blue, bringing her hands towards her chest like she was carrying a bird. The world around them

shifts and shrinks, as if reality and colors had been shrunken into Adora's hands. The very sun bleeds out, gold falling in between Adora's fingers like liquid silk. In the cracks of the ground, white and gold magic shoots like firecrackers with a sizzling sound, raising the fine hair of everyone present. The universe holds its breath alongside Adora and then she extends her arms to the sides in a swift, wide motion, so charged with energy that it looks slow. The golden magic shines from inside her chest and into reality, born like a star in the galaxy over the palms of a king. A stellar nebula, a protostar, a red giant and finally a supernova, huge, huge, expanding like mist and light and everything in between around them all. The magic dome grows around them like a shield and everything inside it glowing slightly with the power. Adora's hair slips completely off the braids, floating on their back like underwater, golden to white to incandescent. The shine of her armor looks otherworldly, untouchable and magnificent under the light. Adora themself is a star, standing in the middle of the destruction, guarding everything around them. The rocks crash violently against the dome but it doesn't wave or tremble, in fact, everything inside it is quiet and peaceful so different from the heavy silence of the outside. The rocks keep coming, clashing against themselves and other parts of the yard but never coming even close to hurt them. The light in Adora's eyes flickers and with it the gem on Excalibur's handle and another wave of magic comes rushing right from the below the ground, raising high like a meteor and exploding in thousand of sparks, obliterating with it the rest of the rocks coming into dust and then into nothing.

Calm is restored slowly, the wind settling the debris as if nothing had happened. The few members of the Horde squadron that had hidden away are running in all directions, anywhere but *away,* as far from Adora as possible. Adora looks at them with her eyebrows knitted together, a snarl forming on their lips. Still glowing for magic Adora shoots a hand towards them and then, one by one, closes her fingers down. For each finger one of the soldiers is lifted from the ground by nothing at all but sheer magic, held high over their heads and then thrown shamelessly away and into the water left inside the empty canals. Not even the animals had waited to stay.

Adora pants, allowing her magic to slip away and fold inside herself once more. This way she can feel again all the places where her body is not happy with her but she pushes it aside, turning to the warriors and the people to check on them. Everyone is looking at her with wide eyes, hair tousled by the wind and the attacks and the magic, cheeks spotted in a flush. Adora doesn't have time to feel embarrassed, she throws herself to her knees besides them and starts checking each and everyone of them for wounds.

"Here, your Majesty", says an older magicat. A Camelot knight is nestled between her arms, there is a wide wound that comes from their left temple all the way down their right shoulder and Adora grimaces in pain with just seeing it. The knight trembles in the woman's arms and shakes violently once, thrice, before their entire body shifts and contorts and changes, leaving behind green skin and blonde messed up hair.

"A shapeshifter", murmurs the woman in awe. Adora doesn't even pay attention to it, barely registering that she doesn't recognize this Camelot's knight. She places her hands over the wound and closes her eyes, pushing the same golden magic inside the open gash, cooing it to knit itself together until there is not even a trace of a scar behind. The older woman and the rest of the survivors breathe in relief, passing a damp cloth over their forehead. The shapeshifter opens their eyelid just a slide and Adora meets a green reptilian eye looking back

at her without understanding. Adora smiles and then turns to one of the warriors, the one still riding over the panther.

“Take them to the purple woods. Go North, towards the Crescent Waterfalls. You should meet Princess Scorpia at some point”

“What about you, my king?”, asks the warrior, placing a hand on her chest and bowing lightly to Adora in a sign of respect. Adora presses her lips in a firm line, cleaning the sweat of her forehead with the back of her head.

“I’ll take a look at Uppertown, if there are still people there we need to get them out. You four stay with the caravans at all costs, do you understand?”, the warrior nods gravely and turns to the other warriors and the rest of the people with a serious look, signaling them to quickly gather themselves before the Squadrons are back.

Adora is about to stand up when a large hand sizes them by the wrist and they turn startled to see the shapeshifter knight look at them with wide eyes. “Wait” they rasp out, their hold turning almost painful in Adora’s arm. “Wait- you can’t- you need to get out-“. The shapeshifter wheezes and tries very hard to keep talking but exhaustion is too hard and their eyes end up rolling to the back and they fall unconscious once more.

Adora shifts, confused, but stands up to allow the magicats to put them in a makeshift stretcher and carry them along with them while they gather their strength again. The four warriors stand in front of Adora in a straight line, joining their palms together and bowing deeply towards her. Adora’s cheeks go red but she joins her palms too and bows right back at them, a mutual signal of respect from a warrior to another. The magicats look a bit surprised but they smile, all sharp teeth and war paint, and turn to help the people walk down the rocks and towards the canals.

The same old magicat from earlier approaches Adora too. She is very tiny so Adora has to bend a little when she motions them to come closer. The woman rubs her hand with something in the floor and then reaches on her tippy toes to Adora’s face. With wrinkled fingers, the woman paints a wide blue line from ear to ear, crossing the bridge of their nose and the base of their silver eyes, down the arc of their chin. Then, with even gentler fingers she paints a half moon in the center of Adora’s forehead, very much like the one in Catra’s crown. The woman steps back, dragging the blue paint down Adora’s palms and fingers and squeezing their hands together in a reassurance gesture.

“You are one of us too”, says the woman in a thick, low accent. Adora looks at her with big eyes pouring with emotions and they gasp, unable to do or say anything else but stare at her. The woman pats the side of her face and the caress reminds Adora so much of Razz that it robs her of her breath. A warrior helps the old magicat climb down the rocks and join the rest of the group, shooting back one last grateful stare to Adora before disappearing behind the debris.

Adora picks Excalibur up and she can see her reflection on the smooth surface of the water. The paint makes her look commanding and unyielding and brave and a wave of pride bursts in Adora’s chest at its sight. Even with wild ash blonde hair and dirt and blood all over her

face, somehow this small gesture makes her feel much more powerful than any gold or silver crown could ever do. The small moon in her forehead almost seems to wink back at her.

Adora jogs up the hills that lead to the place where the Arcane Circle is. She hasn't seen Lonnie since the beginning of the attack but as much as she looks there is nothing but destruction and emptiness all around them. Adora squats down when she arrives at the top, hiding behind the tall vegetation to get a better look of their surroundings and the sight takes her breath away.

Dozens of Horde squadrons are waiting in long rows all around the Arcane Circle. All of them carry heavy weapons, swords and sables and other intimidating objects of destruction that look like they could break a wall in two. Their black armors shine like flies' bodies under the gold sun and the bleeding red sky, huge helmets covering their faces in pointy factions, making them look like underworld demons. Yet, none of them move an inch, as still as a cold candle. Adora doesn't even doubt her movement, she presses a hand on the ground and pushes down, magic traveling through the stones below the squadrons situated at the east of the hill. The stones shake lightly, imperceptibly, and then explode from the inside out, making the soldiers lose their foot and fall down the hill in a tangled mess. By the time the rest of the squadrons are turning to the commotion Adora is already up on her feet, swinging with full force to the south squadron.

Sword meets sword, armor meets armor. Adora crashes on her own against the dozens of soldiers like a thunder and a cataclysm, taking them out one after the other with expert steps. The blade of Excalibur shines bright with each hit, vibrating with the hold of magic as Adora moves from side to side like a flash of light. One of the soldiers tries to grab her from the hair, sword already raised to chop it over her head. Adora sees it coming and she spins in her ankles, lowering her body just enough to impulse herself and kick the soldier right in the abdomen, sending him tethering away from her. It's a hand in hand combat movement Catra taught her months ago, between chuckles and sweaty kisses. It may as well just have saved her life.

Adora elbows another soldier right in the mouth, knocking the helmet off with the blow and sending him crashing against the ground. Then she clashes the flat of her swords against another one's shoulder, disarming him in one motion and pushing him like he weighed nothing towards another incoming group. Adora is about to turn and confront them when the air charges with electricity and a sudden wall of lightning hits her full force. Adora feels the energy travel from the soles of their boots up their legs, torso, arms, neck and head, and she yells strangled in pain as it curses through her entire body, sending her crashing on her knees and palms.

The squadrons jump away from her to avoid the discharge of black magic, regaining their positions in the long rows as if nothing had happened at all. Adora pants heavily, gripping Excalibur with white, bloody knuckles as she looks up. At the edge of the cliff, a dark figure stands, tall and menacing, regarding Adora with an annoyed posture. She wears a red porcelain mask over her head, carved in swirls on different runs all over the surface. It's unnerving, completely, as she seems to look at Adora with something like disappointment and annoyance.

Adora hears a shake of the earth and she watches in horror how another squadron of soldiers comes to replace the ones Adora had just taken down. Just like that, like nothing had happened in the first place. They all now surround the circle, rows tight and waiting. Over the Arcane Circle, the purple runes are now deep red, like spilled wine or blood, and they pulse, poisoned with dark magic. Adora's mind catches up and she gasps in desperation, realization washing over her like a curse.

The Arcane Circle. The only direct gate between Halfmoon and the other kingdoms. They are going to use the Arcane Circle, all of them all the soldiers and squadrons and weapons and her, *her,* the Shadow. This was their plan for the very beginning and there is only one place they can come through if they do. To her home.

The Shadow moves, slow towards her position, hands up as if she was going to speak. But Adora is already sprinting. As everything they do in their life, Adora's mind reaches a conclusion and she takes an immediate decision in a matter of seconds, following the beat of her heart with a sole mission, to protect.

Adora pushes through pain and exhaustion and desperate tears falling from the edges of her eyes. Dodging soldiers arms and hands and, miraculously, also hits of lightning that try to stop her. The Arcane Circle shines a sick red and she knows, she knows that if she is just a second too late it will all be lost.

"Stop her!", yells a voice, raspy and low and ragged but it doesn't matter because Adora is formidable in everything and right now there is only one mission in her body and only one thought on her mind.

I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. Adora thinks, frantic as she grasps Excalibur firmly with both hands, the blue blade shining strong, so strong it vibrates in Adora's grasp like an earthquake. Adora is so close to the Circle, just a few feet more, just an inhale of air more. Once this is done there is no turn back. She is surrounded and tired, she won't be able to get out. Adora tightens their hold on the handle, raising it over her head as they step inside the magic spell. *I love you. So much.*

Adora embeds Excalibur in the very ground with a loud yell, the blade crashing against the stone as it receives the full force of the hit, breaking the circle and with it it's arcane spell. The red runes shine just a second more and then shrunk into themselves, dark magic spilling out of them in pools of black. Adora feels it before it happens, the cracks in the core of the sword, the stillness before the fall, but she can't hesitate now and with one last push inside the stone, Excalibur breaks into pieces.

No Adora , Serenia had said, weeks ago, with a mysterious smirk, like she knew this was bound to happen one way or another. *The sword will protect you.*

The magic explosion hits Adora right in the face, light and colors washing over her, throwing her hair over her back, pushing her away with the wave of energy. Adora tries to hold on but there is nothing to hold onto and she feels themself flying back and away, head hitting viciously against the ground.

Everything goes black.

❀

Adora comes back to themself with a sharp pain and a ragged breath. Her throat feels full of sand and dirt. She can taste copper and salt, blood and tears mixed against her teeth and tongue where she bite too hard. She has landed on her back, over the ash covered lilac grass, silver eyes facing the smoked sky.

Everything hurts so fucking much. She can feel her bones bruised and protest with pain. The palms of her hands burn from the bite of sharp rocks. Her ribs trob, probably one or two broken after the hit sent her flying away. There is a sharp pain at the base of their head making everything sound numb, like being submerged in freezing cold water. Long minutes happen where the insides of Adora's ears finally pops, and even longer seconds pass by before Adora realizes she hasn't actually lost her hearing. There are no sounds in the kingdom. Not a single voice or crack or whisper. Just heavy, overwhelming, deafening silence that falls over Adora's chest and head like an ax.

Halfmoon is silent.

She looks at her right side, where a heavy weight rests, and she can see the scratched handle of Excalibur, its broken blade catching the light of the sparks of fire that surround them. It has broken into pieces and Adora is just holding a large portion of it, chipped and useless. Adora exhales, shaky and devastated. She has failed. She has failed them all. Her eyes are teary, drops falling out of her eyes and down her ears but Adora can't avoid it. She is fully silently crying in a matter of seconds.

There is a ruffle above her and the sound of footsteps approaching and Adora inhales deeply, raising her head enough to see the tall, dark figure of Shadow Weaver standing in front of her. Her arms are folded behind her back, her ink black hair floating like the fire clouds in the sky over her head. She wears a deep red dress and it doesn't seem like fabric but waves of magic itself to be dressing her. She doesn't look human. Except for her face. Her porcelain mask is gone and this way Adora can see the scarred skin. Three deep scars cross her face entirely, one from her left mist-white eye all the way to her ear, another from her right temple over her nose and down her cheek, and the last from her cheek down the corner of her lip allowing the tip of her sharp teeth to be see through the long healed wounds. They are claw wounds, done by a young Catra years ago.

Shadow Weaver smiles when she sees Adora staring, wide and vicious, as she unfolds her arms and triangles her fingers together. "Adora", she greets them, prolonging the syllables into a thick word.

Adora snarls at her, spitting a gush of blood in her direction, silver eyes burning with rage. "Shadow Weaver"

The woman, the thing, looks at her unimpressed but her smile slowly slips out of her face and her eyes harden, and that only provides Adora with enough satisfaction and fuel. She tightens her grip on the remains of Excalibur and raises to her elbows, giving a last swing with it towards the woman. It 's useless. Adora's magic is in complete disarray, exhausted beyond measure after hours of fighting and destroying the arcane spell. Shadow Weaver gives a flick

with her hand, powerful after stealing so much magic, and sends the broken sword flying out of Adora's grasp and meters away, too far for Adora to even attempt to scramble to. Adora curses under her breath, clenching her teeth hard together as they let their own weight fall to their elbows. Adora is too tired to stand, but she won't show any kind of surrender in front of them, never.

Shadow Weaver seems to read her thoughts because her smile returns and she hums, leaning her head towards Adora in recognition. "You fought bravely, Adora. There has always been greatness in you. You have always been destined to be part of something beyond anything you can imagine"

"Fuck you", growls out Adora, nails digging into the loose earth below. Her ribs are screaming with each movement but the ball of boiling rage coiling in her gut is stronger than the pain. Shadow Weaver sighs heavily, like she was a disappointed tutor talking to a child, and shakes her head side to side while clicking her tongue.

"Adora, my child. The fire that lives inside of you has always been admirable. But please, let's be reasonable", Shadow Weaver extends her arms, signaling to the fallen kingdom. "You were never meant to win, Halfmoon was always destined to fall. Always".

Adora chokes on her breath, scattering as little as she can to get away from her. But Shadow Weaver follows, fake patience and condescending smile never waving from her face. When the pain gets the better of them, Adora stops, turning again their head sharply to the woman. "Why? Why did you do this?"

"Halfmoon is placed in the last remains of Avalon, Adora. You know this"

"These are innocent people!", exclaims Adora completely distraught. "Children, elderly, families. Don't you care about any of that?". Shadow Weaver tilts her head to the side, regarding Adora with a bored look.

"Sometimes small sacrifices must be made to achieve the greater good"

"Small?!", yowls out Adora. "Are you even listening to yourself?"

Adora bites back a sob, rolling her head to the side when a new wave of pain overtakes her. On her left hand she can feel a soft warmth, the only gentle thing in her right now. It's born like a small kiss in her skin and starts extending towards her fingers, all over her palm and wrist. It's a soft energy, white and kind, golden light expanding over her arm and chest until it cradles the very strings of her heart. Adora opens her eyes just a slit, looking down at her hand with a confused stare. Catra's wedding ring, well loved and bright, seems to almost glimmer, the blue half moonstone shimmering for the blink of a second. Adora's heart constricts at the thought of her. Where is she right now? Is she sleeping? Is she walking through the gardens? Is she in the yard, waiting for Adora to come home? Adora sobs.

"You don't have to suffer like this Adora", slithers Shadow Weaver, snatching back her attention. Adora closes her fist and bends it back, hiding the small gift from her prying eyes. "You have always been smart, you know what is best. Join it, *join me*. You don't need those pathetic princesses, you never have, so leave them all behind. You possess more power than

you can even phantom. We could do great things together, we could bring Etheria to its rightful glory once and for all. All you have to do is take my hand." She extends her hand towards her, burned by old magic years ago, turned charcoal black over ash grey.

Adora remains silent for some stunned moments and then snorts. She chokes on her own breath and honestly snorts, loud big cackles of mocking laughter shaking her entire body, ignoring over the sparks of pain from her ribs, leaving her completely out of breath. Shadow Weaver's eyes harden and she steps back a little, watching Adora mock her there in the ground below her. Adora's laughter finally comes to an end, struggling to breath deep without squirming uncomfortable because of her wounds. Adora's blue steel eyes lock on Weaver's and they smirk at her, a cracked grin with raised dark eyebrows.

"Oh, I pity you", spits out Adora, low voice drenched in disgust. Shadow Weaver's eyes go big on their sockets and her entire expression shifts, contorting as if Adora had slapped her.

"What?", she asks and her voice is tained in offense. Adora smirk grows bigger.

"I. Pity. You", she repeats, deliberately slowly. Waver grinds her teeth. "You praise yourself for being and possessing some mighty wisdom but you know nothing. You know nothing about friendship, or loyalty or kindness. You know nothing about love", the ring in Adora's hand grows warmer and they inhale. On her back in the grass she can almost imagine the feel of Catra's weight against their chest, the soft purr of her throat, the curve of their baby against their bodies. "You only know about your hubris and your nauseating trip for power and that, I promise you, that will be your final doom."

Shadow Weaver scoffs and turns violently away, opening and closing her fists furiously on her sides. She shakes herself alert and the shadows that surround her tremble with her. Weaver runs her black inked hands through her hair, smothering the waves back and straightening her shoulders back.

“This is the fault of that insolent child. Her influence has rubbed on you way much”, she mumbles. Adora growls, scratching at the ground with her fingers. “I should have never let you be together for that long”

“What are you talking about?”

Before Shadow Weaver can answer there is a new movement in the edges of the clear and a second figure crosses the mist and shadows, walking with sure steps towards them. Shadow Weaver smiles, tight and unreal, crossing her fingers together as he approaches them.

“Ah, Minister”, Weaver greets Halfmoon's Commerce Minister. The man walks with slow and sure movements, his long tunic pristine after hiding away during the attack, sure of his security while dozens of magicats and refugees ran in terror. He walks next to Adora’s form still lying in the ground and he smiles at her from his place, her yellow teeth stretching with his malevolent smirk. Adora’s breath hitches on her throat, anger overcoming any other thought as she starts to place all the pieces together. “Thank you so much for lowering the barriers. Made everything so much easier”

“My pleasure, my Lady” he says, his gray tail brushing on the dirt below. He looks so pleased with himself Adora just wants to stand up and crush the bones of his face. But as much as she tries, her bones just won’t answer her. The man studies her there in the ground and seems suddenly aware of Adora's state. His hazel eyes flash with something else and it drives a shiver down her entire spine. “Though, I would have preferred to have the *Queen* to be present, but this will suffice too”

Adora's eyes widen open and she scrambles in the ground desperate and furious. Her muscles are completely exhausted and Adora ends up crashing right back into the ground when her knees give away. The man chuckles at her, picking on his teeth with even more yellow sharp nails. Adora grasps a handful of grass between her fingers, turning to look at him with red eyes.

“How?”, hisses out Adora. The man doesn't seem intimidated at all. In fact, he looks almost bored, kicking a loose rock with the heel of his feet.

“I used Princess Scorpia's Royal Seal. Poor thing, doesn’t even know where her head begins or ends”. The Minister scrambles on his tunic, fishing out a small object. A golden seal with the Halfmoon's crest carved into it. He inspects it up close and then throws it away, uninterested in it any longer. "It was simple. I just had to write an official letter to the Halfmoon's sorceress in Princess Scorpia's name asking for them to take down the barrier just enough time to let a caravan of *innocent refugees* go in. They didn't even bother to check it up, everyone was so sure you would keep them safe, *my Lord* . And it was so much easier to get rid of them after they were done."

Adora plants her hands firmly against the ground, trying to ignore the sting of his words, raising just enough so she can see him directly in the face. "You complete asshole. You betrayed your own people, and for what? Did she offer you freedom? A free pass?" Adora bites her tongue with the effort, trying and failing to call her magic back to her. Adora fixes their eyes on him, studying him. She thinks about her time there, on the way he would diminish Scorpia on every opportunity, on the way he had talked about Catra. It 's true. It was simple. "Power? Did she offer you Halfmoon's throne, *Minister?* "

The man presses his tongue against his yellowed teeth, looking down at Adora with obvious anger. "Women in power are unnatural", he states. "Halfmoon is the most powerful magic realm on the entire of Etheria. We have enough magic to conquer it all, to be the greatest kingdom ever seen for any kind. Magicats would have their rightful place in history, a place your grandfather Uther Pendragon ripped us from! But what did those stupid queens made? They decided they wanted to play the best friends game and make alliances and keep us all hidden and submissive to Camelot. But not anymore. I! I will take Halfmoon to it's golden age. I will save our history in the place it was always meant to be!"

"What are you going to save? You've traded them all already, just for an empty palace and a hollow crown" , asks Adora, coldly calm. "You are pathetic. She will get rid of you when she doesn't need you anymore"

Adora signals to Weaver with their head, letting it rest against the moss. The Minister looks about to explode in anger, beet red against the gray fur of his cheeks. "We have a deal, you stupid child. I'm too important now, nobody can dismiss me"

"No, she is right" sizzles out Shadow Weaver, reaching from behind the Minister and grabbing the fabric above his chest with long pointy fingers and a vile grip.

The shadows that surround her grow, thick and slimy dark tentacles that slide through the ground like limbless arms. The air shifts completely, for a cold breeze to nothing, absolutely no air that makes Adora struggle to inhale. The shadows grow so high that they cover the sky, submerging the three of them into darkness. The Minster eyes go wide, the yellow around his hazel pupils gets bigger, bloodshot as Shadow Weaver's hand presses into his chest, rumbling the fabric there and causing him to gasp. He struggles on her grip, but the tentacles snap and hold down to his limbs, keeping him standing in place like a grotesque mock of a stringless marionette. Adora lays in the ground, freezed in shock and fear, panic slipping through the core of her bones and the stuck breath on her throat. She presses a hand against the wound on her side, palm dampening in sweat where the pieces of Excalibur caught her when it exploded away. Inside the ocean of darkness in front of her, only the red eyes of Shadow Weaver can be seen, no body or hair distinguishable anymore, just a shapeless form like a black hole holding a grown magicat up like it weighs nothing.

Adora locks eyes with the magicat and he looks back at her frantic, panicked, kicking in the air as the strands of shadows seem to slip past his skin and muscle, inside the cavern of his ribs, and *squeeze* . Adora looks away, unable to keep watching. In front of her, the shadow slips under the skin of the Minister, poisoning his teeth, his nails, his blackshot eyes. A point inside his chest starts to glow, bright green, the only light point inside that madness. The Minister's soul. He must feel it, the grip in him, because he struggles harshly, scratching the black mist with his nails.

"You can't do this!", he wheezes out, looking everywhere, yelling as best as he can. "We had a deal!"

"You were promised to be part of a new world. And that's exactly what you will be", the voice of Shadow Weaver seems to cole from every corner of the reduced space. "You won't die, Minister, you will come to be something more. Emperor Prime will be so grateful for your compromise with his cause"

"You bitch!", growls out the men, his face getting paler by the second. "I am the King of Halfmoon!"

"No, you are not", whispers honey thick the sorceress. "Halfmoon doesn't exist anymore"

Adora can hear an acute sound over the shouting, like a steel blade being bent too hard, like a bell stuck in one single ring. The sound crescents more and more and the it's suck all together with a single dry pop. Silence falls down once again, the shadows retrieve on themselves and grey light falls onto Adora's face once more. She tears her eyes from the patch of grass where she had locked them, panting heavily now that the sensations start coming back to her body. Shadow Weaver is back to being more of a solid body, though her face looks healthier, brighter, more powerful. Adora feels sick to her stomach.

"What a nasty little man", spits out Shadow Weaver, cleaning her hands down her sides.

"You are a monster", musters Adora through her teeth, choking a little on her own saliva. Shadow Weaver looks at her with a condescending stare, pressing her lips together like she was disappointed. Adora snaps her gaze off her, refusing to look at the way the Minister's magic makes Weaver's grow stronger, blacker.

Adora looks around her as best as she can. The smoke and mist is too heavy so she can't see much, but she takes in the burnt patches of grass around her, the debris scattered around, little pieces of stone and glass. Heavy columns of smoke rise to the sky in the north, in the same direction where the palace and the main market used to be. The mist clears a little, just for a second, and Adora can see the columns of Horde soldiers formed straight and quiet, waiting for orders after destroying it all. Adora can't see it anymore.

She looks to her other side, following with her eyes the path of charred grass and deep scoops of earth. The place where the Arcane Circle used to be is completely destroyed. The stones that formed the ground lifted and pushed aside by the strength of the explosion. There is a piece of Excalibur deeply pushed inside the center of the circle from where Adora pushed it into, it's sharp broken edges glistening with the light of the fire that sparks lightly from where the arcane lines used to be. It's totally gone, useless. Nothing will be able to come through and nothing would be able to pass across. Camelot is safe. Catra is safe.

Weaver follows the direction of her stare, studying the remains of the circle with a scowl in her lips. She sees the last waves of purple and pink magic come from it and disappear completely, and with it, the last way for the Horde to attack Camelot. Shadow Weaver clicks her tongue, displeased.

"A smart move Adora, I must admit" she says, lowering to her knees next to Adora so their faces are only inches away. "But look at what you've done. Excalibur is broken. The last gift of your mother, the most precious relic of the Pendragons. And all for what? A scrawny little girl who will never be able to protect your Kingdom?"

Adora feels a painful tug in her heart, guilt mixed with rage. She collects a good amount of saliva and blood in her mouth and spits it right into Shadow Weaver's face, the red liquid slipping down her nose and forehead. The black shadows tremble around them, making even the ground below Adora's body to shake with it. But Adora doesn't relent, they hold the sorceress stare with burning blue eyes and a snarl in their red slit lips.

The thought of Excalibur still digs into her mind, cruel and merciless. But there is also the voice of her mother, soft words spoken many years ago when she explained to Adora about the sword's legend, about it's supposed power. Young Adora had been amazed, afraid to even touch such a precious object. But her mother had placed their hands over the blade, smiling soft and wise as always. *It's just a sword, Adora.* She had said, like she was sharing a secret only meant for both of them. *The true magic comes from you.*

"It's just a sword", repeats now Adora to Weaver, limiting their chin proud and without regrets. "It will never be more important than my people. Never be more important than my home". Adora breathes deep, not taking her eyes away, she wants for the words to get into Weaver's brain and make a hole in there forever. "Never more important than Catra"

“You are willing to give your life so freely for a bunch of useless unworthy strangers?”, hisses Weaver, incredulous, eyes burning back to red. “Why? You are perfect, Adora, you could be the greatest King ever known by Etheria. And yet- Why would you give your life away for *her?”*

"Because I love her. More than anything else, I love her" blurts out Adora, heart in her throat. The ring is still soft in her hand, caked in mud and dirt. It envelopes Adora in a calming warmth against the cold of defeat. “You would never understand it. Of course I would give my life for her. I would pull the blood out of my body to keep her healthy, I would give her my lungs so she could breathe, I would lay my bones in the ground so her feet wouldn't touch the cold. This? This is nothing. I would choose her first again and again. I would do it all for her in the blink of an eye because I. Love. Her”

Shadow Weaver looks at them with flat eyes, the edge of her scar torn lips twitching just slightly with rage. She doesn't break though, but she does flops her shoulder, twitching her tongue against her teeth in a disappointed sound, shaking her head as she runs her fingers over the dark smoke strands of her head.

“Oh Adora", she chants and the tone of her voice makes a frozen goosebump run down her back, her cheeks paling, her eyes watering. Weaver looks at her with knife cut eyes, pinning her in place with the sheer weight of her stare. "I guess erasing both of your memories when you were children wasn’t enough.”

Adora's heart stops. Everything stops. All that carefully constructed confidence Adora had built in the last minutes comes crashing down. The sky roars open above their heads and a tiny, soft drizzle starts falling over them, warm drops hitting against Adora's cheeks like tears. “What- what are you talking about?”

Shadow Weaver's eyes narrow, regarding Adora with a thoughtful look and a slow catlike smile. “Adora. Do you really think you two only met once when you were nothing but rug-rats?”

Adora looks back at her, speechless, elbows digging in the mud as they try to straighten up just to slip right back into the ground. The rain keeps coming down, drenching their face, mixing with the tears that fall from their eyes and heart. Adora stutters, unable to speak over the loud ringing in their ears. Shadow Weaver looks at the conflict in their face and just smiles, picking at her nails with a calm gesture, taking her time to rip Adora's heart apart.

“You were together for years, Adora. The Queens took you in when your mother brought you to Half Moon to protect you from the war and you grew up here until you were ten."

Adora can barely make sense of her words. Her head feels submerged in fog, dense and unbreakable. Their heart is beating so hard and fast inside their chest it hurts, crashing against their ribcage, drumming below the skin, brushing the last letter carefully folded and hidden.

Adora's mind is running free, looking desperately for the missing pieces they didn't even know were gone. Fragments of childhood play like theatrical satires, so many days and nights of younger years but none the ones she is looking for, none the ones that matter.

Adora has never hated, it isn't in her nature, but here it is now, a cold burning fire that creeps from the center of their abdomen over their throat, pouring out of their chapped lips in an agonizing whimper. She wants to sprint to her feet, wants to take Weaver's head and shake it, demand it to return it, everything she had stolen from them.

The shared jokes, the held hands, the long years apart. She wants to scream and wail and pull off her hair, golden locks falling down the earth so maybe their memories can grow back again, like roses sprouting in spring. She wants to run, through the lakes and the rivers, down the mountains and valleys, sprint into their shared room and hold Catra between her arms, small and soft and cunning and smart and sweet and lovely. She wants everything and she has nothing.

"I always knew there was greatness in you, Adora. But that girl, she latched into you like a scum, a leech. I should have also taken that stupid brooch she gave you". Adora whimpers again, closing her eyes firmly together, grinding her teeth together so hard they may chip. All the muscles in their body are pull tense, held in high alert as the pieces of her life unfold and come back together.

And then it all falls into place, calm and peace falling in Adora, conflict still there but tamed. Because it is there. It's right there, in the back of her mind. The sparkling laugh of a girl she loves as they chase each other in a secret garden. The shine of gemme like eyes brightening up when she sees them. It's always been there, following Adora inside her dreams when she used to lie awake in bed, wondering what was missing in her as she grew up. It's in the way the strings of her heart refused to belong to anyone else until she arrived. It's in the jolt of her soul the first time they saw each other again. *It's you, it's you* , it sang. *My heart, my soul, my home. It's always been you.*

"We were children", says Adora and she is proud of how steady her voice comes out. "We were just children, how could you do something so cruel?"

“Adora”, slurs our Shadow Weaver. She brings a hand down, brushing the skin of Adora's chin in a makeshift calming matter. Adora snaps her head away. They know the true embrace of a mother, Shadow Weaver can't trick her. “Erasing your and her memories from that time was the most merciful thing I could have done".

"You took me away from her", accuses Adora.

"It made you grow into what you are now, Adora, all thanks to me”.

“No”, they snap, making Shadow Weaver's expression harden once more. “My mother made me who I am, my friends, my people… and Catra, she did too even if I can’t remember. She was with me all the time and I always loved her. No matter what you did or what you will do, I’ll always do”

Shadow Weaver hums, snapping her hand away from Adora's face. She looks back at the destroyed circle then up at the burning sky and down to Adora once more. “It doesn’t matter now” she states, coldhearted. “You won’t be able to protect her anymore. Nor her, not your kingdom”, there is a brief hesitation there, a moment where a thought occurs into Weaver's mind and she bends to Adora's scratched armor, reaching under the folds and snatching

Catra's last letter. Adora goes completely stiff, frozen in fear. “And nor that little kitten of yours"

Adora trashes on the ground violently. She doesn't care about broken bones or sore muscles. She is going to stand up and kill her. She is not going to allow her to place a single finger on her family. But Shadow Weaver places a hand on Adora's chest and pushes down and the grip feels like steel and rock heavy on Adora's lungs, keeping them rooted in place. Adora tries to call for her magic, anything, anything at all. It doesn't matter if it destroys her in the end, but nothing comes. As if all of it had been spent on a last desperate effort to protect. Shadow Weaver looks at them struggling on the floor and her expression is carefully built, something between reprimand and satisfaction.

"Would you like to know how I knew? A birdie told me, let me clear it out for you Adora”, Shadow Weaver leans towards Adora’s bloodied ear, hand still pressing hard on their chest. Her breath is cold and smells, like rotten lilies and burnt electricity. Her voice is slow and thick as Shadow Weaver whispers the name of the traitor in Adora’s ear, pronouncing the words carefully enough so they can catch every single one of them. Adora’s eyes fill with betrayed tears, hot and furious, biting so hard on the insides of her cheeks to keep a scream at bay,

“No”, Adora’s eyes spill with the tears and she scatters over the mug, desperate. The betrayal sinks deep inside her chest, unforgiving and biting. “No, no, no. No”

“Do you see now, Adora? It was predetermined, all of it. You weren’t even supposed to be here. It was C’yra the one that was supposed to fall, not you. But you just had to love her too much, didn’t you”

“Stay away from her, stay away from my baby. Stay the fuck away from my family”, half growls half yells Adora, completely out of breath, using her entire strength to try and stand up. It 's useless. Shadow Weaver parts from them again, tilting her head to the side. The shadows around her head shift, spilling down the ground and around Adora’s body.

“You and your Rebellion were always destined to fail, no matter what. Your mother escaped me once but I won’t make the same mistake again", she says, low and menacing. She extends her hand to Adora once more, "You still have a choice Adora. Do it wisely"

Adora looks at the palm of her hand, at the red lines that run like lava veins under the burned down skin, at the long knife cutting nails that curve just slightly in the ends. She looks at it with hate in her eyes and a leap in her heart and turns to look at her right in the eyes, steel blue against green-red. "It doesn't matter what you do to me. You are not going to win", Adora balls her hands into tight fists. The surface of her wedding ring is warming up even further, if possible, vibrating like a tiny bell in Adora’s skin. "She is so much more stronger than you think"

Shadow Weaver looks all kinds of disappointed, as if Adora had denied her a candy and not the safety of her entire Kingdom. She sighs heavily and the pressure on their chest increases painfully. "As you wish, King Pendragon"

The shadows grow again until they cover everything on Adora's camp of vision. There is the skip of a beat and Adora can see nothing, the grey sky slipping out of vision until everything is pitch black. The entire air left in her lungs leaves in one swift exhale, lungs constricting with the effort, ribs burning like fire. Shadow Weaver's eyes glow bright red, the rotten smell thickening, sparks of lightning making the fine hairs on Adora's arms to raise on point. Weaver's nails dig into the center of Adora's chest, passing through golden armor and thick layer of fabric like it was nothing, reaching the skin and *squeezing*

It hurts. Adora can't breathe and her heart is beating way too fast and it hurts, it hurts so much a new wave of tears start falling from the red rim of her eyes. Shadow Weaver grips at the strands of her very soul and pulls, one, two, three times as she tries to rip it all away from her. Adora resists, clenching her teeth, arching her back off the floor with the strength of the tug, refusing to relent, to give up. The sorceress above them grunts, pressing harder, pulling stronger. Adora can't see her face but they know she is struggling. Adora chokes as she tries to speak, black spots starting to appear in her vision, conscious slowly slipping away. She raises her arms with the last of her strength, grabbing the place where she knows Shadow Weaver's is, forcing her to turn her eyes to theirs.

"I won't be your weapon. I won't let you control me", the tug pulls harder and Adora gasps, losing her grip as her head rolls back in the ground, small rocks digging in her scalp and shoulders. The black spots grow and she lets her eyes fall closed, the last strings of reality slipping away with the pain. There is a bright glow from outside her close eyelids, a blue light that raises from her chest and she knows it's her soul. Adora has never felt so helpless.

She thinks of Catra, because if she is going to be taken away she is going to do it with her in her heart. The twinkle sound of her laughter, the way ears twitch when she is asleep, the constellations of freckles on her cheeks. Thinks of the way her hair tousles to the side when she brushes it, on the thick curls that fall freely when she doesn't. Thinks of the curves of her bare feet against the moss, on the length of her hands as she spars. Thinks on the way she adores wearing pants because it makes her feel free and fast but also loves her dresses because it makes her feel like she can fly. In the way she curls around Melog in the night, her loyal friend for many years to count. Thinks in the way she teases, she pokes her tongue out, she gets mad and mischievous and angry and sad. In the stolen kiss in the edge of her mouth when she smirks and the flash of her fangs when she knows she is right. In the way she makes love, like a feather or a battle, loud and quiet, always loving in every touch and every surrender. She thinks on the way she carried herself so carefully around their baby, even before they knew even before Adora had to leave, but that was there as she curled on herself, as she sang under her breath. Thinks in the way she loves, like a firework, sharp and overwhelming and colorful and full of life. Adora thinks in the way Catra holds to their promises like a lifetime and now her worst fear is taking them all away. Adora sobs. She is so sorry and she is going to miss her so much.

The start of unconsciousness reaches Adora, licking her arms and head like a tsunami, like an earthquake. Adora won't give up to them but she knows they are inevitable. The ring in her hand is shaking violently now, squeezing her finger viciously. The blue glow flickers for a moment, hesitating, reached by the warmth of the jewel for one last agonizing second. Is there where Adora hears it. The whisper.

" *Adora* "

It is soft, soft and candid like a candle. Golden light mixes with the blue, burning the ends of the shadows, chasing them away. Above Weaver growls and gasps, surprised.

“Adora”

" *Mom* ?"

Adora asks, and they don’t know if they do it outloud or it’s all inside their head but it is there, the sound of her mother’s voice calling out for her.

" *Adora, it's alright. I've got you"* calls Mara’s voice and she sounds like she is thousands of miles away and barely centimeters close at the same time. Adora twitches, wanting to go towards it but unable to move a single muscle, *"You can let go* "

The ring vibrates like a thousand bells, loud and unyielding and now there is another light, pink and white eating the shadows alive. Catras’s voice, from a memory that feels millenniums away, crashes against Adora’s fogged mind, *It will protect you,* she had said, *If I’m not there.*

"What is this?!", Adora hears Weaver’s decaying voice scream, barely audible over the ringing and the singing and the rush of water on their ears.

“Let go, Adora, you are hurting yourself”, repeats her mother, this time more urgently. Adora shakes, or at least makes the attempt, her head from side to side, biting into her lips until she tastes blood.

" *I can't" ,* she answers desperately. *"I can't. I have a family mom, I can't"*

"You will see her again. You will see them both again, I promise. But for now you must let go" and Adora swears, she swears she can feel the caress of her mother's hands at either side of her face. The ring grows impossible tight in her hand and snaps. *"Let go, baby* "

With one last breath and Catra's name in her lips, Adora allows the white mist to take over. There is a new explosion, like a star being born in the middle of that field. Blue, gold and pink light grow and expand, burning the shadows that overwhelm the place into nothing. The light shines brighter and brighter and brighter and then folds into itself with a white nose and a soft sizzle. Everything falls silent. Adora is gone.

In a sunny yard miles away, Queen C'yra clenches at her chest painfully and collapses into her knees to the ground, confused and scared, barely held by the quick hands of her friends surrounding her. There is a scream stuck on her lips that comes as a harsh sigh, as a heartbroken sob. The white roses on her balcony shake and die.

The sun sets.

❀

5 hours earlier

The knights knock softly on the King's chamber door. They wait for a few seconds before hearing a faint *Come in.* Both knights straighten up and enter the chamber with careful steps, trying to not prey into the colored murals or the open windows, quiet movements to not disturb the peace inside the room, focused only on finding the King.

She is sitting in a stool next to the pristine made bed, golden head low as she reads the last part of a letter with the Queen's elegant writing on it. Their hands seem to be shaking lightly as she keeps reading, so absorbent on it she doesn't even hear the jingle of the knights approaching. They look at each other with raised eyebrows and wait a few moments before clearing their throats to call her attention as gently as possible, careful of not startling them.

"My Lord" says one of them, softly. She raises her head at the sound and the golden rings that keep the thick braids of her hair in place twinkle against each other harmonically. There are tear tracks staining their face and their blue eyes are soft, so soft around the edges it makes her look years younger.

"Yes?"

The knights look at each other in surprise, unsure. The King smiles softly, nodding once in their direction still holding the letter gently between his hands. The second knight recovers their posture, confidence coming back at the King's reassuring stare.

"The roads are clear, my Lord. The provisions caravans have retired completely to their respective paths. Sir Lonnie is already in the Circle and says the rest of the squadron is ready to go".

The King smiles openly now, standing. She folds the papers of the letter carefully, lovingly in two, as if it was a treasure, and guards it inside the open side of their armor, right above her heart.

"Good. Let 's go home." The King grabs her satchel from the ground, walking with cheerful steps towards the door. "I want to see the loves of my life"

✾

...Sparkles will have the Arcane Circle ready for you to come back. And I'm aware the kitchen is baking so much strawberry tarts for you, it's ridiculous. I am, absolutely, not letting you eat all that in one go Adora, do not insist.

Sleeping is not the same without you here. Melog misses you.

I've missed you.

Because here is the thing, the root of the truth that you already knew.

You are going to be a mom. We are going to be moms. And I need you here because who else is going to hold them to sleep, and kiss their little ears and love them

unconditionally other than you.

You are coming home and I've decided to say it right now, you picky dumbass. So, this whole scattering away for two months? Don't do that again. Don't let me let you do that again.

I'm serious. I've spent enough time without you.

We are waiting for you, all of us.

Sparkles. Arrow boy. Melog. Me

and Finn

Don't be late

— Catra

End of chapter XIII part II

Chapter End Notes

Gosh. I swear she is not dead. I PROMISE you, Adora is not dead and they are not with Shadow Weaver either. They are just...not here. Something happened there but she is alright she is just somewhere else. It will make sense, I promise that too.

Writing this was...a true nightmare. It hurt me. This plot has been planned since the very beginning of the story and it's one of the major plots of our entire fairytale, but it still was so hard to write. I've grown so fond of this characters and just want to make them happy but this twist was as I said written from the very very beginning and now we are here.

I know you might be a little upset, especially because I know you are all thinking in Catra and Finnie right now. Don't worry, they are alright and everything will be okay. Remember this is a story with a happy ending and it's going to have such a happy one. Just hang in there with me a little.

Aconite represents caution, misanthropy and death. Rowan symbolises courage, wisdom and protection.

Next update, chapter IX, will be up on October 7. We are two chapters to come to end Arc II after which I'll make an announcement of a secret project I'm working on and also will take a little break to prepare the chapters of the next and last Arcs which are the more complex on the entire story. More details will come in time

As always, thank you so much for reading. Comments are always deeply appreciated.
Be good!

Chapter 10: White promises

Chapter Summary

These are pillars of Catra and Adora's entire lives. Each other.

Chapter Notes

Hello! Happy October! How are all of you doing?

Today we are taking a journey to the past, seventeen years ago in Halfmoon. As you read in last chapter the secret has been released and today we are going to learn what happened all those years ago with our dear characters.

Warnings for this chapter: on this chapter there is a particular scene where Shadow Weaver is emotionally and physically abusive towards a young Catra, as it's an important part of the story it can't be easily skipped so please be aware of this before reading. I've marked it with *****

Alright! Are you ready? Three, two, one, see you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CHAPTER 9. *White promises*

Anything seemed possible –

the world was not only doable, conquerable,

but lovable:

it showed its weaknesses and you knew

it would submit to you.

You saw your own charm reflected in its eyes.

-Alan Hollinghurst, *The Line of Beauty*

Music that inspired this chapter X X X X

✾

Halfmoon, 17 years ago

I'm going to tell you a story.

The colorful murals of Halfmoon look golden under the light that slips through the bindweeds in the roof. The yellow and black jaguars, made of small bright stones, are huge over the walls, breathing life into the corridors. Somewhere nearby, the sound of natural fountains carved in the ground itself fill the warm air, dampening the earth and it's evergreen plants. There are a myriad of multicolored birds flying around, vivid reds, blues and yellows, long iridescent green tails that make them look like feathered dragons when they fly. Even the tall ink black columns of the palace are surrounded by life, nests and other animals that have made their homes in the inside of the trees that live around them.

Here there are no guards, a couple only, patiently guarding the entrance of this single secret garden. They are imposing to young eyes, with long big manes of grey and black hair, long pointing ears that look so soft and so alert, ringed tails and purple armors, they hold their spears next to them dutifully, never once quivering in their places. Yet, under all that military pose, their blue and green eyes are gentle, almost mischievous as they look at the little prince walking with determination in their eyes and steps towards the chamber. Her little hands are worrying the seams of her purple shirt and her small golden ponytail bobs over her head with every step. The guards part to let her pass as they see her approach, not a question made, just gentle smiles attached to their faces in greeting. After all, they heard the young princess slip inside the garden through the roots in the ceiling a little while ago. And goddess forbid parting them both from each other side.

The little prince walks in with their head held high, hand behind their back when they see the guards standing there. Their face is as stern as it can be but there is an obvious pout on their lips and a crease on their eyebrows that show just how worried they actually are. They have freckles in their skin and their hair has darkened to caramel after so many years under the Halfmoon sun. The prince gives the guards a squeaky little "Thank you" when they move to let them pass and marches in without a second word.

The chamber is huge next to little ten years old Adora, but if you ask her, she is tall for her age. Besides, this is much more like a garden than a room. Her and Catra have spent many hours here, running around the black stones and red earth, climbing the wide tree trunks, hanging upside down from the branches. They have scratches and small scars in their knees and palms to prove it. Adora even has a slightly crooked nose and small window for their lost front teeth after falling from one of the trees and into the moss a few weeks ago.

Adora looks around the garden, steps soft over the damp stones below their bare feet. She looks between the blue and purple brushes, neon butterflies surrounding her head when she accidentally scares them away. Her eyebrows are knitted together, worry and guilt falling over them. She arrives at the bottom of the first queens' statues, looking up as best as she can to peek on the cocooned space that forms its joined hands. There is a soft sound coming from it, muffled by the stone of the statues but perfectly distinguible for Adora's ears. Is the sound of someone softly sobbing. Adora grunts, unable to see into it, so she turns to a flat rock

behind her, a little taller than her, and climbs it with confident hands, finally standing at the top of it to get a much better look.

“Catra! Catra I know you are here!”, Adora calls, her voice ringing inside the chamber. “Please, I miss you”

“Go away!” The tiny voice is as fierce as it can be with the shaky quiver of tears in it.

Adora sighs, wobbling over the rock precariously. Still, falling to the ground would be worth it because Catra needs her right now and there is no way she is leaving her. Adora separates their legs a little, bending their knees to take impulse as they count on their head. *One, two, three!* Adora jumps up as high as they can and it's miraculously enough because she finds Catra there, nestled inside the extended palms from one of the immense queen’s statues, her pretty ears pressed down on her head, face buried on her knees as she hugs herself tight with her arms and tail. Adora lands in the ground with a soft thud, cleaning their palms off the red earth with the fabric of their black small pants. They approach the base of the statue with big strides, stretching their neck as much as they can and looking up the length of the stone.

"Can I climb to you?", asks Adora again. It's loud enough for Catra to hear her but not too high as to be a yell because she knows the high pitched noises bother Catra and make her ears hurt, even if she never says it.

"No" a sniff "You are gonna fall and knock another teeth"

"It will grow back", defends herself Adora, hesitating a second to think about it. "Eventually"

Catra doesn't answer and Adora takes it as a sign to go up. They hold to the folds and solid edges of the statues, their hands small enough to fit perfectly on the spiky corners. The stone is cold and a little bit damp by the fountains but as Adora keeps climbing up and closer to the open ceiling it starts to get warmer. Adora struggles for a bit. She is used to chase Catra around and follow her to the most strange and far hiding places around the limits of Halfmoon. And, now with ten years of going around and growing with Catra, Adora has started to build some good strength of their own. Still, they are no way as agile and flexible as Catra, so it takes Adora's some good minutes to finally reach the top of the statues hands and slip inside of them, their feet immediately pressing against Catra's legs inside that reduced space. Catra doesn't help her but Adora can see the turquoise of her eye peeking through the dark strands of her hair, following Adora's movement until she is sure Adora is well inside the hiding spot.

Adora returns her gaze and smiles. The stretch of their smile highlights the freckles on their nose and the dirt in their face. There are some loose leaves stuck in Adora's hair, making her look a little bit ridiculous and wild. Catra doesn't answer the smile, snapping her head back between her bent knees, making herself as small as she can in there. Adora's smile slowly slips away. She extends a hand to her friend, looking to touch her but stops. As much as Catra is pushing her away right now Adora knows that what she really needs is reassurance and love. So Adora shifts inside the stone hands and scooters right next to Catra, her entire side pressing against hers in one movement. Catra stiffs and for a moment Adora thinks she may hiss at her but she doesn't. Instead, Catra lifts her head from her knees and wipes away the

tears from her face with the back of her hand, almost angrily, annoyed with the treacherous drops that fall from her eyelashes. Her hands are already small compared to Adora, made for swift movements and quick scratches. Adora likes the feeling of her hands inside of theirs, like the way her own small fingers wrap around the slim bones of hers. It makes her feel like somehow Adora is protecting her and that Catra is protecting them right back. Adora doesn't understand these feelings yet, she is not meant to. She will, much later in life. For now, this bubbly and warm emotion on her face is the reason Adora laughs everyday and that makes them feel like they could make cartwheels on the main yard. For now, they are so intertwined together Adora doesn't know where one ends and the other starts. For now, this is enough.

Catra lowers her hand harshly, turning to look at Adora with an obvious upset stare. Oh right, she is mad.

"What are you doing here Adora?". The side where they are pressed together frizzes a little with magic, pinching Adora's skin lightly. It's a bit uncomfortable and a clear show of Catra's unhappiness, but Adora doesn't move away or even grimaces. Catra has been getting so much better at controlling her magic, no longer making vases and cups explode in firecrackers-like purple lights when she is openly laughing or angry. Besides, Adora knew Catra would never hurt her at all.

"I've been looking for you everywhere", murmurs Adora, looking apologetic and sad. Catra's ears perk up at the sight and her eyes melt a little, less sharp and upset. She scoffs however, turning her head away from Adora to lock her gaze in the garden below them.

"That's not what I asked". There are dark red spots on her cheeks and under her eyes. The baby fat that still lives there makes her look cute even as mad as she is and Adora has to hold back the need to nuzzle their own cheek on hers until she laughs.

"I've missed you", repeats Adora, softly. There is honesty in her voice, tangible in each of her words. Adora is that way, honest and open, especially with Catra. She knows this, which is why a pang of guilt crosses her chest and she shrinks into herself, her tail coming to wrap around her ankle tightly.

"We saw each other this morning," mutters Catra between her teeth. Her fangs hace finally stopped growing though she is still getting used to not biting herself when talking. "Besides, I thought you were having such a great time with your new best friend", there is venom in her voice and Catra shrinks even further, ashamed by it. But the image of Adora running around the flower fields with that magicat girl still lives in her eyes and she can't help the way it burns in her belly. Catra doesn't even understand why, it's actually very irrational because Adora is allowed to have other friends besides her, but she is very, very sure that it is for the fact that visiting the flower fields on blooming day is an Adora *and Catra's* thing. They've been attached to the hip since before they could remember, they have hiding spots, child secrets, traditions together. Finding Adora already there with someone else feels a little bit like a betrayal.

"That's not true and not fair, Catra". Adora answers and it's obvious that the mere thought that Catra may actually believe that, has upset them. Catra flops her ears down her hair, her bottom lip starting to wobble again as she holds back tears. Adora panics, searching Catra's gem eyes with her silver ones. She doesn't want Catra to cry, ever, just considering it makes

her feel terrible and she is sure that if Catra starts crying again, Adora is going to follow her soon after.

"Catra, I'm always going to be your friend", whispers Adora, taking a leap of faith and holding Catra's hand with hers. Catra doesn't move away and her lip stops quivering. A good sign. "I will always look out for you and you will always look out for me. Nothing could ever change that"

It 's so simple.

Catra peeks out at Adora from the edge of her eyes, slowly but surely meeting their eyes completely. Her eyes shine a little and her voice is barely above a whisper. "You promise?", she asks

It's such a simple promise.

Adora beams at her, more confident, leaning until the bridge of their noses press together. "Of course. I promise"

It's going to keep them together forever.

Catra leans further into Adora, resting almost completely over her. She doesn't even notice Adora's arms coming to cradle her in a hug because her purr starts to build up a second before, strong and calming, a gentle purr that Adoras has heard right beside them in their sleep for almost their entire life.

Catra relaxes around Adora, stretching her legs in front of her to bring them back to life after being numb for so long. She doesn't stop purring, not even after they shift into a more comfortable position with their back resting on the statue's palms. Catra's magic changes too, from electric and fiery to a calm flame, tickling the skin of Adora's forearm and hand from where they have joined their hands together. They look up together, at the green of the roots and branches that crawl over the structures of the open ceilings. Catra is still deep in thought, still uncomfortable and down after running away when she saw Adora at the fields. Adora can feel her like this next to them, and they search inside their mind for a thought that has occurred to them not long ago.

"You know? One day I'm going to be King of Camelot", Adora states, a slow, mischievous grin widening on her face.

Catra returns her eyes to her face, blinking several times in confusion. "Yeah. I know", she says, articulating well each word like she was promoting Adora to get to the point. Adora doesn't take the bait.

"And! you're going to be Queen of Halfmoon", states next Adora, poking Catra right in the button of her nose. Catra hisses at her without bite, beating their hand away from her face.

"Duh", Catra rolls her eyes so hard they may as well just get stuck in there. "What's all of this about?"

Adora keeps smiling, looking around swiftly as if someone were to listen to them in that garden that has become just theirs. They lean towards Adora, murmuring their little secret just between them. "Well. When we grow up, let's get married"

Catra leans back, looking at Adora with wide eyes. Her ears flick like crazy on her head and her pupils grow the more she looks at Adora. "What?"

"Married! Like your moms!", beams Adora, clapping on her knees with her palms. "Marr'age is for people who love each more than anything. Right?

Catra just nods, unable to speak. She can feel her cheeks getting warm with the second, red spots forming on them for a completely different reason than crying. Adora nudges further, holding her hand between theirs tighter. "Well, I love you more than aaanyone else in the whooole world", Adora snickers, prolonging the a's and the o's. It makes Catra giggle. Adora looks at her with a soft expression on their young face. "What about you? Do you love me?"

The blush on Catra's face deepens and she squirms shyly in her place but she nods anyway, collecting and showing as much confidence as she can. "Of course I love you, dummy", she agrees in a whisper.

This time it's Adora's cheeks the ones that go from a peach dust to a deep pink, all the way over their a little too big forehead and ears. But she doesn't relent, she tangles their small fingers together and shakes them in excitement. "Then let's do it!"

Catra looks at her curiously. This is her best friend, her partner in crime -many windows broken and vases in pieces-, her entire world. They have grown together and laugh together and cry together. They've drawn panthers and dragons over the wall of their shared chamber. They have twin beds that they never use because they always end up sleeping cuddled together in the hammock of the window. Catra is too young right now to understand it, and so is Adora, but she is sure of one thing and that is that she wouldn't want to spend the rest of her life with anyone else. "Okay"

Adora's face turns into a small sun, bright, so bright it challenges the actual sun over their heads, and the day moon and the entire stars. Their face brightens up as if Catra had just given her somethin invaluable. "Yeah?!"

"Yeah, dumbass", giggles Catra, smacking them lightly in the nose with the tip of her tail. Adora laughs, scrunching their nose as they do and that small window on their teeth for the missing teeth looks as endearing as everything in them. Catra's ears twitch lightly, happiness overwhelming her too. She sees the way their hands are still joined together and how Adora is now humming happily next to her, eyes silver under the light. "And what happens after? After we get married?"

"Weeell-", considers Adora, scrunching their nose and they frown as they think. "After that no one will be able to take me away from you", they come to a conclusion, smiling satisfied to themself and then at Catra. She returns the smile in kind.

"I like that"

"Me too! That's why I suggested it", Adora raises her other hand, tapping her temples with a cheeky expression. "I'm very smart"

Catra huffes, rolling her eyes and tapping them right in the middle of the forehead with her palm. "Yeah, sure clotpote"

Adora grins at her, nestling her head in the crook of Catra's neck. She likes how she smells, like damp earth and lavenders and a little bit of sweat for running around. Catra nuzzles into her head too, messing up the small ponytail with her cheek. There is a silly thought pulling on Catra's brain and she needs to get it out before it digs too deep.

“My moms kiss"

“Hmm?”wonders Adora and Catra regrets talking at all immediately because Adora rises from her place in Catra's arms to look at her face. Their face is calm but quizzical, waiting patiently for Catra to explain. Catra squirms, face red.

“Kiss. You know, that’s what married people do. My moms do it all the time”. Adora's eyes widen when she understands Catra's words, their ears so red they look like cherries on their tanned skin.

“Oh, umm… Isn't kissing like, umm, for grown ups?”

“I mean...it was your idea, dumbass, all this. I just thought…”, Catra looks back at their hands, biting her lips with her fangs. The tip of her fingers sizzle in tiny purple sparkles. Her heart is beating like crazy inside her heart. “I don’t know”

They fall into heavy silence again, Catra's tail tapping in the stone of the statue rhythmically, Adora deep in their own thoughts.

“Hey, Catra”

Catra turns to her, ready to snarl at her face and then she feels them, a pair of tight closed chapped lips pressing hesitant and shy right in the corner of her mouth, much more on her cheek than anything else. Catra’s eyes are wide open so she can see the way Adora’s nose is scrunched, dark eyebrows furrowed, the little pout she makes as she smooches Catra almost comically. They are making such a ridiculous face Catra would have started giggling if it wasn’t for the shock. The little kiss is as quick as is chaste and before Catra can do something Adora is already leaning back, with a cracked white smile and that dumb window from where the tooth should be.

“There”

Catra and Adora look at each other dumbstruck, each one various tones of pink and red, until Catra snorts, followed right back for Adora both dissolving themselves in a fit of loud laughs and crackles. Catra pushes Adora's face away, covering her mouth with her hand to help tamper down another huge fit of giggles.

"You are so dumb, Adora!", she exclaims

"You asked! Gotta get it right!". Their laughter can be heard everywhere in the garden, even outside and into the ears of the guards, who look at each other with knowing gazes.

Adora shakes her pants from the earth that had fallen over them, pulling from the hand that still holds Catra and nudging her towards the edge of the statue. "Come on, Catra. It's almost time for dinner!"

Catra scoffs with mirth, letting go of Adora's hand so they can securely hold to the edges of the statue and start climbing down. "Do you ever think of something that is not food?", Catra questions them, leaning over the edge of the statue with her head propped on her hand. Adora grunts a little, careful of not losing their foot as they reach the base.

"Well, I think about you". Catra flushes all the way up again and her nose twitches with the embarrassment earning her a shit-eating smirk from Adora. Catra leaps and jumps down the statue in quick motions, falling softly and gracefully on her feet right next to Adora.

They push each other around playfully for a good couple of minutes, reaching every time closer to the open gate and back into the palace. Adora stops Catra before they can actually leave, pulling gently from her purple shirt to call for her attention.

"Do you want to see what I was doing in the fields?"

Catra feels that uncomfortable pang in her chest again and she rolls on her ankles, clicking her tongue against her teeth to look as uninterested as she can. "I guess so"

Adora hops in her place in excitement and fishes from inside the pockets of her pants for a bit, taking out a small bulb off them and placing it on Catra's palm delicately, closing her fingers over it lightly.

"Here", Adora says, taking her hands back as she rock back and forward on her feet, blush never leaving her face, "the girl you saw is the farmer's daughter, she was helping me pick up a flower for you"

Catra opens her hand, looking down at the small thing in there and the sight makes her throat tight in a knot.

Is a white rose

It's small and a little bit squished, the soft velvet petals bend in some places from where Adora squeezed it in the pockets of her pants. There is no stem on it, cut short by knowing hands so the little flower looks almost like a pendant inside the small hand of eight years old Catra. She caresses the rim of the petals with her fingers, mindful of nor poking it with the sharp ends of her nails. Is such a simple thing and yet Adora rose at five in the morning that day and slipped away and into the flower fields so she could find the first rose bloom of the season, only for Catra.

Catra doesn't even know what to say, she just keeps looking at the flower with surprised eyes and it's only when Adora bumps her shoulder with theirs that she comes back to her senses, choosing to look directly into their eyes and slowly blink at them once, twice. Adora,

cheerful as ever, tries to do the same, blinking as slow and tight as she can right back to Catra who laughs lightly at the funny face. It seems to please Adora anyway because she jumps on her place a few times, pointing at the gate with joyful gestures.

"Race you to the dinner chamber!"

Catra snickers, placing the rose securely inside the pocket of her tunic. "You know I always beat you"

"Uh-hu, because you always cheat!", sings-songs Adora, resting her fists at either side of her hips. But Catra is already running away and Adora sprints right behind her, chasing each other through and outside the garden with bubbly laughter.

Sometimes, some memories are so happy they stay printed on a place. In a moment. Repeating like loops until the right eyes look at them again.

❀

The first time Prince Adora sees Princess C'yra, they are two and hiding behind Mara's legs. The Princess is tiny, basically still a newborn, with small dark ears and chocolate puff of hair. C'yra' nose nibbles in the air when Adora approaches, their thumb in mouth and big round silver eyes curious.

Adora loves her instantly.

The Queens allow Adora to rest baby C'yra in their arms and the little prince's eyes widen with marvel, almost shining by how pretty she is. The baby princess sniffles and chirps in Adora's small arms and Adora spends hours poking gently at the peach fur of her ears and the button of her nose. It takes a while for the Queens and Mara to convince them to let her go.

The second time Adora sees C'yra, they are four and two and Mara talks with Adora seriously.

"You'll be staying here for a while", says her mother and her silver and purple eyes are sad and worried but she hides it all behind kind smiles and sweet hugs, brushing a stray lock of golden hair behind her child's pink ear. "The Queens will take such good care of you and you'll be with princess C'yra, too. And I'll come to visit you very, very often, you won't even notice I'm gone. Do you understand me, baby?"

Adora nods, their tiny ponytail bobbling on their head. "Where are you going, mommy?", their speech is still slurred, milk teeth pronouncing the words as clearly as they can. They hold a tiny blue blanket tight between their arms, hiding their small face behind it to avoid being seen crying.

Mara smiles, hesitant and worried, lowering the fabric just a little bit so she can wipe the tear tracks of their face softly and cup their chin between her fingers. "Mommy has to take care of some little things back at home, sun. But it will all be alright, you'll see"

"Are you going to fight the bad viper?", asks sweet innocent Adora. The Viper, a nickname they had given to Emperor Prime after accidentally hearing a war report on their mother's office. The mention of him gave Adora nightmares for weeks until Mara had decided a time away from Camelot, away from the immediate war, would be the best.

Mara exhales, nodding as she fights back the tears. Her long dark hair shakes in the braid as she moves to hug Adora once more. The slim arms of her child don't even circle her shoulders completely and Mara has to bend a little kneeled on the ground so Adora can reach her with her tippy toes. Mara parts from them gently, placing a kiss on her small cheek and poking the tip of her nose in a playful manner that makes Adora giggle.

Mara stands from the black stones of the group, approaching Empress Ziba and Queen Tlalli with sure steps. Excalibur hangs from her belt, it's deep blue surface reflecting the colors of the vivid vegetation of Halfmoon. They are in the throne room yet there are no courtesans or warriors there, just the three queens and their children. Mara's long dark braid swings behind her back and the golden circle on her forehead catches the light of the blue fire torches. Queen Tlalli walks forward, embracing Mara in a gentle hug. She is beautiful, with long chocolate hair held in dozens of threads of gold, thick dark eyebrows and caramel like skin. Her purple long tunic brushes the ground and the ankle bracelets on her bare feet painted in yellow colors jinggle with each step. Empress Ziba gives Mara a kind smile from the other side. Her clean shaved head is painted with gold serpents, thick earrings hanging from the base of her ears matching the shine of her casual armor and the rings in her silk black tail. Her turquoise piercing eyes are alert as she watches Mara and her wife but also kind and understanding. Is not hard to understand why the people of Halfmoon adore their queens so much.

"Thank you for doing this", says Mara, parting from Queen Tlalli's embrace to look at them both pleny. "I didn't know where else to go"

"Adora will be completely safe here", answers Tlalli, voice soft and calming. Her amber eyes are like honey, regarding the little prince for a second before turning back to Mara. "Our barriers are remarcable safe, they can only be taken down by our own sorceress. There is no way Adora will be in any kind of danger."

Mara nods absently, looking at Adora getting distracted by a fluttering dragonfly flying over their golden hair. Empress Ziba walks forward, embracing her wife as she rests her hand on her shoulder.

"Are you sure you don't want us to help you?", Ziba asks. Her voice is low and strong, everything in her speaks authority and strength but there is no threat on her as she speaks with Mara. "Halfmoon can provide Camelot with enough warriors. You don't need to fight the Horde on your own"

But Mara is already shaking her head, eyes apologetic as she does. "I don't want to risk Halfmoon's security, nor you, nor your people, nor your daughter. For now, the best is for you to remain hidden and out of the radar of everybody, especially the Horde. The Rebellion is slowly joining together again, for the first time since my father's dead. Once the seven kingdoms join, pushing against the attacks of the Empire will be easier. When that happens I'll let you both decide if you wish to publicly join us or not".

Mara exhales, trying to shake herself off the weight over her heart. Adora laughs, still fascinated by small neon bugs crawling on the ground. "You are already doing so much by looking after Adora until everything is settled. I do can't thank you enough "

Ziba and Tlalli look at each other, a silent conversation going between their eyes. Ziba sighs, dropping her shoulders forward. Her white teeth flash brightly when she smiles at Mara though she still looks unsure. "As you wish, Mara. We'll wait until you think it is proper. And Adora will always be welcome and loved here. But please, don't forget that Halfmoon will always be here for Camelot"

Tlalli smiles at Mara too, opening her arms in a comforting gesture. Her tail brushes in the ground swiftly, making the bells in her bracelets jingle. "Anything you need, Camelot will always have a home here"

The three queens keep talking in low voices as Adora follows a small turquoise beetle. The iridescent shine of its fragile wings catches on the light of the night lamps, filling the silver in young Adora's eyes like stained glass. She follows in quick but wobbly steps, jumping every time she tries and fails to catch the little bug. The beetle shakes its wings and runs quickly, hiding among a couple of long, round and deeply green leaves, almost as big as Adora themself. Adora follows, extending a small arm to part the leaves and let them through. There is a sudden movement there, and a tiny dark tail shakes from between the brushes, a pair of gold and sapphire eyes looking right back at Adora in surprising glow. Adora doesn't yell, but she is so surprised that she gasps and trips when she tries to jump back, ending up in falling over her butt with a soft thud. The eyes follow her clumsy movements, blinking slowly a few times before moving too. Out emerges princess C’yra, sitting on the floor right in front of her and mesmerizing Adora more than any bug could be. She is a wild little thing, all two years old and fuzzy hair. She wears a terracotta colored shirt and cotton shorts and her bare feet are a little bit stained with mud from where she was hiding before Adora arrived. Her small tail is barely visible from under the fabric of her clothes but Adora can see it wagging slowly on the stones of the floor as she regards Adora with curiosity. There are small freckles spotting the high of her cheeks, very tiny and hard to see yet but there. Her eyes are gemes, sea stones like the ones embedded in the murals, digging in Adora’s soul and finding their home there forever. She is cupping her hands in front of herself gently, held together as if she were carrying something between them.

Adora straightens on their sitting position, mouth slightly agape. Their eyes shine like liquid pools of silver, a flash of something deep and important and transcend, something none of them will get to understand until much later, passing through them for a second.

“Woah”, whispers Adora, crawling on her knees and palms to get closer to C’yra. Her ears flicker a little when she does, calling Adora’s attention. They scooter closer, extending their hand to brush their small fingers over the rim of one of C’yra’ ears, marveling at the way it flutters like butterflies and presses against her hair. Adora takes her hand back but C’yra doesn’t look uncomfortable or angry, for the contrary, her baby young face is surprised by Adora’s sudden gesture and her eyes are big in the round face. Adora looks at her in silence and then absolutely beams at her, milk teeth crooked and funny looking. “You are so pretty”

They were too young the first time to actually remember each other besides young soft feelings, and so, this is the first time they actually regard each other completely. C'yra' ear flickers again and she seems to consider something a little before she leans towards Adora, pressing her small, cold nose over Adora's cheek and sniffing there gently, taking in the smell of young Adora. Adora bursts into giggles as C'yra' fur tickles them on the face. Adora rests their hand over the princess's shoulders, leaning back to look her in the eyes. C'yra' pupils are big, black overtaking the colors and reflecting the lights of the plants around them, as if she had somehow recognized Adora's smell. Adora feels content, completely happy and more relaxed. They know who she is, Mara talked with Adora about C'yra and the queens on their way to Halfmoon. Adora taps in the floor, making C'yra' ears perk up.

"Hi C- Cy- Cyyda" it's awkward, Adora can't quite pronounce C'yra' name correctly and what comes out is a blurry one kind of confusing version of it. Adora grimaces at themself, frustrated, but C'yra' seems to understand the meaning of their words because her tail shifts excited at Adora's voice. Adora exhales, pointing at themself with a confident gesture. "I'm Adora!"

C'yra tilts her head, her hair falling to the side, hands still pressed together, but she doesn't answer. Adora frowns delicately, considering, but C'yra just keeps looking at her, blinking very slowly.

"Can you say it? A-do-ra"

C'yra' ear flops on her head but that's it, not even a try to speak at all. Instead, C'yra schooches closer, raising her joined hands and pointing with her nose at Adora's. It takes a bit for Adora to get the signal until C'yra grunts very low and pushes Adora's hands with her, coaxing her into raising them too. Adora cups their hands up, keeping them together, much like the huge statues in the gates of the kingdom. They look at C'yra without understanding but the princess looks pleased and she brings her small hands over Adora's and opens them in a swift motion, letting a small thing fall between them. Adora gasps, bringing their palms right before their nose, looking at the blue beetle they had been chasing earlier, scattering gently over their hands.

"Ya caught it!", squeals Adora, high pitched and delighted. C'yra smiles, very gently and hesitating, her milk fangs barely showing through the smirk in her lips. She looks happy at seeing Adora smiling. Adora shows the beetle to her too, giggling at the feeling of its miniature legs brushing over their skin. "Look. It's like your eyes!"

The beetle's wings flip, startling the prince and princess before coming closer again, this time pressed right next to each other right there, in the Halfmoon's floor. The bug shakes a little and then its wigs start shining a bright shade of periwinkle, raising itself out of Adora's cupped hands and into the air. It flies right over Adora's nose and then to C'yra, who huffs as she scooters into Adora's side, hiding her tiny face on their shoulder purposely. Adora lowers their hands in order to pet gently at C'yra' hair, cooing her as the bug gives a flip and buzzes away from them and into the flowers once more.

"It gone now, C- Cara", mutters Adora, still struggling with their words. C'yra hears them but she just shakes her head, small hands snaking around Adora's forearm as a shield. Adora sighs, resting her head over C'yra' gently. "It's okay, I'm here with ya"

There are a couple of bigger steps coming towards them and Mara, Tlalli and Ziba appear from the other side of the thrones, picking at their children pressed together as they sit on the floor below. Tlalli sighs in relief, lowering to her knees next to them. “There you are, sweethearts. Don’t go away just like that, please”

Adora turns her head to the Queen, playing with the hem of C’yra’ shirt. “We were watching the bugs! Right?!”, she states, looking at C’yra with round eyes. C’yra peaks at her mother from between Adora’s neck, nodding shyly. Adora presses their lips a little, a little sad for C’yra lost of words. The Queen sees this because she cooes at them, caressing the back of Adora’s head with warm hands.

“Oh, honey. C’yra doesn’t really speak a lot, don’t worry”

“Hasn’t she spoken at all?”, asks Mara to Ziba, who shakes her head.

“She has. But she is very timid about it for some reason. The physician said there shouldn’t be any need to worry. She’ll talk when she is ready”

Adora looks unsure but she agrees. Mara motions her to come closer for another hug and they softly move away from C’yra, parting from her tiny embrace as gently as they can. Adora is barely two steps towards their mother when they hear a tiny whimper and a rush of air and Adora turns in time to see C’yra raising her small arms in the air, opening and closing her chubby hands in their direction.

"A-Adora", stutters C’yra, to everyone’s surprise. C’yra frowns and then hiccups sadly, wiggling her hands more insistently to them. “Adora. Stay"

Tlalli and Ziba look at each other with high eyebrows and mouths agape, watching as Adora spins in her place and walks right back to C'yra, petting the back of her ears with tiny fingers.

"I'm here, C- C'tra", Adora assures and C'yra beams at them, scooting over the floor until she can wrap herself around Adora once more. Ziba scratches the side of her face, regarding both children with pensive eyes.

"Catra, uh? It's got a nice ring to it". Tlalli snickers, nodding without taking her eyes from the pair who have returned to chase small bugs crawling over the stones. Mara steps forward too, smiling relieved and hopeful at both her child and the queens.

"I think they are going to be alright"

And so, Mara goes to war and Adora remains hidden and safe inside the walls of Halfmoon, hand in hand with C'yra.

They grow together.

They are five and three when Catra scratches Adora for the first time. It's an accident.

Catra is sitting next to a poodle of water, tail biting her teeth as she tries to calm down the itch in her gums at the surge of teeth. There is a festival and so there are lots of noises, so

Catra doesn't actually hear Adora sneaking behind her with a mischievous smirk on her lips. Catra always likes to innocently scare Adora in the night or very early in the morning and as young as she is right now her senses are so acute Adora has never gotten the opportunity to sneak up on her. Until now. The queens are distracted with a few advisors, going in and around the chamber. They know their children are there and as long as they dont leave the room and stay together all the time Catra and Adora are free to roam in the chamber as they please and can.

Adora shifts on her feet lightly, shoes long ago forgotten. Magicats don't use them anyway. Catra's back is facing her, still to absorted on her teeth and tail to pay any attention to her. It 's now or never. Adora takes impulse on her knees and leaps forward like a bunny, jumping over Catra's shoulders and chanting

"Gotcha!" Catra yelps in fear and shock, not used to being startled like that, and her small hand shoots forward viciously, scratching directly on Adora's face as they fall back into the floor with the impulse of the attack.

Adora cries, not for the pain but for the surprise. She feels the little red scratches with the pads of her fingers, they sting a little, and she can't avoid the tears falling from the edge of her eyes. Catra looks at her sobbing, big drops of tears falling from their beautiful eyes and into the grounds. Catra is in shock, small but pointy claws still shred from the surprise. She sees Adora cry and cry and suddenly a hiccup leaves her throat and next thing Catra is crying too, ugly and messy and as painful as a child's cry can be.

They are too far into the chamber's garden so nobody sees them or hears them. Much less when a series of fireworks start exploding on the night sky and next thing Catra is covering her ears with her hands, trying as best as she can to bend them to hide from the acute sound and crying even harder than before. Adora stops a little, sucking in their runny nose and wiping their eyes with a small fist. They see their friend whimper and hide on herself, heart aching as she hears Catra cry next to her.

"Catra, it's okay", they whisper, crawling to the small figure on their knees and palms, petting the base of her ears as if to help alleviate the sounds of outside and the sudden sadness of the inside. "It's okay, look, no bad"

Catra looks at the three red lines in Adora's nose. They are actually very superficial, no scarring. But they are a little bit swollen and Catra just breaks into tears once more. Adora grimaces at her own face, tapping annoyingly on the hurt skin as if to say *Hey, heal already.* Suddenly, the skin glimmers in gold, enveloping the scratches a few seconds until they are completely healed. Adora gasps, delighted, and she taps on Catra's cheek once more to call her attention.

"Catra, look! Look! They gone!", Catra's ears flick, turning a few times to the direction of Adora's voice and peaks at their face once more. Certainly, the scratches are now gone, skin back to only a pink flush and spotted freckles. Her eyes widen, the amber and turquoise shimmering under the crystal lamps of the ceiling and she brings her hand near Adora's skin, tapping it to make sure it's real.

"Woah", whispers Catra, earning a big, goofy smile from her friend. Catra's eyes are still twinkling but the pout on her lips remains. She falls back on her ankles, holding her feet with her hands. She sniffs a little, looking at Adora with big eyes. "S'rry"

Adora shakes her head, resting their weight on their palms. "I am sorry. Shouldn't scare you like that" but Catra's ears are still pressed against her head and young Adora knows she is ashamed, by the accident and by the apology. Adora searches Catra's gaze, all toothy smiles and mud in nose. "Your mom says it's o'kay to ask for sorry, yeah?"

Catra wriggles her shoulders and nods, scrunching her nose a little. Adora shifts onto a more comfortable position on the floor, opening their arms to invite Catra into them. Catra's face lights up and she scoots over until she is right inside her friend's embrace, immediately latching on their earlobe to calm down the itch in her fangs gums. Adora giggles, already used to this way of coping when Catra is upset, knowing well about it after the years they have been together, patting the back of her head until she calms completely.

When they are seven and five, Catra catches a feverish sickness and falls in bed for weeks. The queens are obviously worried and it just grows when Adora refuses by any means to leave the princess' side. Queen Tlalli insists that Adora may get sick too, hoping to convince the child that way. But Adora has already made a barricade around Catra's bed, propping up the other bed right next to hers and hanging high blankets to cocoon them inside the room as if they were in a nest. Catra watches Adora roam around the bedroom with misted eyes, looking at her serving her fresh water and changing the damp towels in her forehead. They are too young yet, so that's as much as Adora can do, only watching with alert eyes when the physicians and the queens hover over the princess.

The first week is the worst. Ziba, Tlalli and Adora watch over Catra the entire day and night, helping her sit so she can breathe better, fluffing her pillows and helping her eat warm stew. Adora's heart lives in her throat, she didn't know this kind of worry until now and watching her best friend struggle makes her completely anxious. Catra falls asleep in pieces, always curling around Adora's middle, her own small figure tight in a soft, sick ball. It helps her feel better and also sleep easier. Somehow, Adora never gets sick.

The second week is better. Catra is still dizzy and with a runny nose but she is now more grumpy than anything else. The queens feel relaxed enough to work for a portion of the day, trusting the children to stay safe in the chamber. Adora practices her reading by picking myths and fairy tale books for Catra, stopping every once in a while when the words start to dance way too much and their eyes hurt. Catra hisses lightly at the physicians when they check over her, not scratching them just for the feeling of Adora's clammy hand on hers. They still cuddle together to sleep.

Neither Catra or Adora notice it, especially because they are sleeping, but the queens see the light golden glow that borns from Adora's chest and surrounds both her and Catra completely, as if they were wrapped in it. And every next morning, Catra looks and feels better, healthier. The queens don't comment on it until Mara comes to visit a few weeks later, but they already have a very good idea of where Adora's magic is going.

By the third week, Catra is basically completely out of bed, chasing Adora around the room and falling inside the cocoon of blankets with sparkling laughter.

When they are eight and six, Light Spinner arrives in their lives.

She has been in Halfmoon for the last decade, limited to the Sorceresses' chambers after arriving as a refugee from the war with Morgana. The Queens had taken her in in kindness but wary anyway from her, so they had kept her in falcon eye all that time. For those years, Light Spinner showed herself as nothing but an extraordinary magician and a hard but smart teacher to the apprentices. When Catra and Adora started to show much more their magic, Queen Tlalli convinced her wife to allow her to become the children's teacher and nanna.

"It will be alright", she says, "We shouldn't fight between ourselves, and we all deserve a second chance". Young Adora carrying Catra around the fruit trees was enough proof of that.

Empress Ziba reluctantly accepted, still wary and uncomfortable to allow her to be so close to their kids but deciding to trust her wife's good heart. And so, Light Spinner was introduced to the toddlers who held each other's hands, battered in dirt and dry leaves from running around the fields all day. Light Spinner regarded them with a stoic face, her stone expression breaking just a little at the sight of princess Catra lightly growling at her. Adora pulled from her hand gently, stepping in a little between their friend and the tall woman with their nose shot up.

"This is Princess C'yra", they say, motioning softly to Catra holding herself to Adora's shoulders, a low menacing growl at Light Spinner when she looks at Adora. "And I'm Prince Adora. We are pleased to meet you Lady Spinner".

Light Spinner stays quiet for a second, watching both kids with calculator stare before bending towards them, expression shifting into a pleased smirk and raised eyebrows, petting Adora's disarrayed ponytail with her long finger.

"Prince Adora, very pleased to *finally* meet you", she says, placing the loose curls of blonde hair behind her pink ears. "Oh, you really are a golden child aren't you?"

Adora flushes, shifting on her feet unsure by the statement. She throws a unsure look at Catra still behind her, trying to give her an encouraging smile. Catra seems to relax a little at her friend's reassurance, peeking to the tall woman with less of a snarl and more of a curious, tense expression. Light Spinner turns now fully to Catra, leaning over so much that she towers darkly over both of them. The woman extends a hand in the princess's direction and every single hair in Adora's and Catra's bodies stands on too with the sizzle of electricity and tension. Neither Catra nor Adora have ever met violence or danger, but for some reason Catra still holds herself tight as if she was waiting for pain to come in her direction. But it doesn't, instead Catra feels warm and they can't really see it but Light Spinner contemplates the way Catra is wrapped in light golden light and Adora is wrapped in soft purple light, unconsciously protecting each other from a danger they have yet to meet.

Light Spinner considers them and then keeps moving her hand, placing it overwhelming it big on Catra's cheek. The touch of skin with skin sizzles like a firecamp and it sting a little on Light Spinner's palm but she makes no comments or expressions, only brushing her thumb over her cheek, cooing with thick sweetness at her.

"Oh Princess C'yra, look at what you've done. You are a mess", she says, a tight sweet look on her face. She straightens up again, holding her hands against her chest as she looks at both heirs. There is something calculating in the back of her expression, so faint no one can see it. "You two go take a bath and then we will start with our first lesson".

The children look at each other, a silent conversation going between their eyes even at such a young age, that doesn't go unseen by Light Spinner. They seem to reach a conclusion later because they turn together at her and nod swiftly once. Catra tugs of Adora's hand softly, walking with muddy feet over the soft carpets of the room, leaving tiny footprints behind.

"Princess C'yra", calls Light Spinner before they can reach the door. She looks back at her, shoulder dropped forward. Adora is looking back too with a confused frown on her face. Light Spinner raises a hand and points with her finger at her, a reprimand hidden behind sugary words. "No more getting Prince Adora in trouble".

Catra's ears press on her head but she nods, walking out of the chamber with Adora following her close behind.

Light Spinner becomes their teacher and their nanna. She is stoic and harsh and firm with them, keeping them in military teaching and unyielding manners. But she is always under the hawk watch of Catra's mothers and so, even if the lessons are sometimes long and hard and not funny, Catra and Adora still run around Halfmoon side by side. There is still laughter and warm motherly hugs by the queens and Mara when she stays to visit for weeks. There are them curled together in the same circle bed and painting on the walls of the shared bedroom. There is happiness and joy and it helps because Light Spinner can't fight against that, so she is calm and quiet, studying the children from close and far. The kids even get to care for her, taking her as their old, a bit sour and grumpy nanna. Is the innocence of two children that know nothing but love.

When they are nine and seven they escape in the dead of the night to climb up the highest point of Halfmoon's palace and watch the shine of the stars blinking gently above them.

"One day, I'm going to put the sky in your room", says Adora in a low voice. Catra snickers, scooting herself tighter next to Adora, foreheads and noses pressed together. Both their knees and ching are scraped and dirty after daily child mischievousness.

"And how are you going to do that, smartie?"

"I dont know", admits Adora, widening her eyes almost comically. She seems to wonder about it for a while while the stars keep twinkling over them. Catra laughs at the way her eyes almost cross on how hard she thinks about it. Finally, Adora shurges, a sloppy content smile appearing on her face. "I'll find a way. So that way, every time you see them you think of me"

Catra is warmed by the feeling but her eyebrows also knit together, suddenly confused. "Why would I need to remind myself? You are here"

Adora grimaces a little, wriggling as she takes her gaze away from Adora. There is a sad look in her eyes when she looks back at the sky. Catra's eyes never leave her face. "My mom said

that I'll have to travel to Camelot sooner or later. Not right now and not forever but I have to live there too. Because I'm the prince and everything".

Adora feels annoyed. She has been feeling annoyed since Mara told her that morning. She has grown here, she has lived inside Halfmoon's hallways almost her entire young life. And most important of all, Catra is there. She doesn't want to go without her, no matter how little time there may be. Adora realizes of the silence that has fallen between them and returns her eyes towards the girl next to her. Catra is looking down at Adora's shoulder, her lip caught in between her little fangs. She isn't crying or anything, because that would be embarrassing, but she is clearly pouting. Her eyelashes reflect long shadows on her freckled cheeks, Adora can see them in the dim light. "Catra?"

"I don't want you to go", whispers Catra, so low Adora can only hear her because she is right next to her. Adoras rolls closer to her friend, petting the base of one of her ears with cold fingers. Catra's tail comes up to wrap around Adora's calf, accepting the embrace.

"Catra, hey. It is not like, it's going to be tomorrow or anything. Mom just talked about it with me today". Catra nods, not doing a very good job of hiding the fact that she is upset. But she is seven years old and she was just told her best and only friend will have to leave at some point. She is allowed to be upset. Adora boops her nose with her finger, earning a scrunched nose and stuck out tongue. Adora laughs and Catra laughs with her, both relaxing.

"I'll always be with you and I'll always be here" Adora assures, as serious as she can. Catra's eyes are bright and alert on her face. "Remember? Nothing bad can really happen…"

"...as long as we have each other", finishes Catra is a whisper. She sighs, interlocking her pinky finger with Adora's. "Promise you'll come back?"

Adora smiles brightly, nodding with certainty and squeezing their pinkies together. "I promise I'll always come back to you"

The stars keep blinking over them in iridescent light, only watchers of a children's promise. Adora looks at the top of Catra's head and giggles, her friend's ears smacking her in the nose when she does.

"What is it?", asks Catra. Adora's hand comes up to brush something in her head, a marveled look on their eyes.

"There are flowers blooming in your hair"

Now, ten and eight, Catra and Adora walk hand in hand in the dinner room. Their hairs are tousled after their race from the Queen's Garden all the way back and they wear matching, bright smiles.

Catra lets herself fall unceremoniously into one of the soft cushions in the floor, crossing her legs under her as she reaches for a piece of flatbread and munches on it with quick bites. Adora sits right next to her, also taking a piece of the flatbread and using it to scoop a piece of baked potatoes and eat it in delighted bites.

When the queens walk in, Ziba, Tlalli and Mara, who is staying for the next weeks, the children are already halfway through their stew and the potatoes are nowhere to be seen. Catra has pushed to Adora all her pieces of roasted chicken and in exchange Adora had given her all her own parts of salmon. The queens sit in front of the kids with knowing smirks, taking their own portions with more elegance and less speed.

"Hello, kids", greets queen Tlalli, looking at Adora devouring her way into the food so they can get to the desserts quicker.

"Hi", say back Catra as only greet, prolonging the "i" a little before keeping through her way on the feast. Adora, always the following the rules one, drops her empty bowl on the floor table and smiles at the three women.

"Good evening queen Tlalli. Good evening empress Ziba", she turns to her mouth, smile widening, a piece of food stuck on her cheek. "Hi, mom"

Mara gives her a warm, loving smile back Catra huffs, coming in to brush the piece of food off her face, her tail smacking her lightly in the leg. "You see my moms everyday, Adora. No need to act like an audience".

"Still,C'yra", interrupts Ziba, giving her daughter a pointing but patient look. "is deeply appreciated. Thank you, Adora and greetings to you two too".

Catra musters a little " *Sorry"* to her mother before gulping down a glass of juice.

The five of them eat in comfortable silence, sometimes broken to ask for trays of food or condiments, or to talk in low murmurs about the calm events of the day. Adora steals the last cranberry bar from the plate and Catra pokes her in the ribs until she gives it up, snorting as discreetly as humanly possible as she surrenders under the magicat's wishes. Catra bites into the bar, victorious, before splitting it into a shoving the second part into Adora's hands, kicking them in the shin when Adora makes puppy eyes at her.

Almost at the end of dinner, Queen Tlalli clears her throat gently, calling the children's attention. The jewels and the gold on her onix hair twinkle every time she moves. Her eyes are kind but with a spark of mischievousness in them and it's clear from where Catra inherited it.

"So, girls", she says, making Ziba and Mara turn their attention to them too, "Lady Spinner has been looking for you two the entire day. Care to say what got you so distracted that you forgot your schedule?"

Catra squirms on her pillow, grimacing as she throws a heavy look to Adora, who just flushes deep red. Tlalli smirks, looking at their kids over the rim of her cup. Ziba and Mara share a look and snicker a little, waiting patiently alongside Tlalli for the children to answer. Catra opens her mouth to start explaining herself when Adora comes forward, beating her to it.

"I wasn't feeling good", they lie, covering Catra's earlier uncertainty. Catra throws her a surprised gaze, eyebrows shot up on her lovely face. Mara looks at Adora with a kind of expression that says *I don't believe you at all* , but she doesn't comment on the lie and keeps

smiling at the kids. Adora catches it, ears flushing deep red, but still keeps going. “Catra went looking for me in the garden and we stayed together for the rest of the day. We didn’t mean to bother, nanna”.

Tlalli and Ziba look at each other and then at Mara, who nods lightly without stopping eating. She will talk with Adora later, about how lying is not good but that she understands she wants to protect Catra’s privacy and that's a high show of honorability. But that will be for later. Now the queens accept the kids' explanation, Ziba and Tlalli also looking at Catra with understanding gazes. They know their daughter, and know how overwhelmed she can get sometimes. She also knows the way Adora is completely, undoubtedly devoted to their daughter.

Ziba sighs, resting her forearms over her knees. “You will still need to apologize to Lady Spinner. Both of you”, she specifies, looking directly at Catra’s pouty face. “Tomorrow”

Catra struggles internally but ends up nodding, shaking her mane and straightening her shoulders back perfectly. She is proud and smart and cunning and every part a future queen to be. Her mothers look satisfied enough with this, dropping the theme in order to finish eating. Adora exhales in relief, wriggling her eyebrows at Catra when she gives her a grateful look just to immediately change into a fake annoyed one, rolling her eyes.

The queens are back to their grown ups chatting when Catra places her plate silently back to the table floor and says with a clear, strong voice. "Mothers, Adora and I will get married when we are older"

Adora chokes on her tart next to her, cheeks and neck and even her forehead turning bright, sweaty red. She looks at Catra with teary eyes, gasping for air as Catra palms her in the back hard once, twice, not taking her own eyes away from her mothers'. Ziba and Tlalli look at them speechless, moving their gazes from Adora, chugging a glass of water, to Catra, shoulders back but tail tapping anxiously on the floor. Adora regains as much control as they can, turning fully to their friend.

"Catra", they wheeze out.

"What? I'm not doing anything", at Adora's exasperated look Catra flushes, pushing them on the shoulder, "It was your idea!"

"Oh, dear", manages to muster out queen Tlalli, resting her hand over her chest. Mara, who has been frozen in place with her cup midair towards her mouth, snorts lightly, breaking the tense spell that had fallen over the room. The queens look at her with raised eyes as she places her cup down, ruffling her bangs a little while the kids keep bantering between themselves.

"Well, can't say we didn't see it coming, can we?", Mara says, looking back at Catra's mothers with a nervous but bright smile. Tlalli blinks at her, still in shock but Ziba sighs, pinching the bridge of her nose between her elegant and strong fingers.

"Yeah, I guess we can't", she turns to the two friends, clearing her throat so their attention is back to her. Adora is still red in the face and Catra's ears are twitching like crazy. "Children,

that's quite of a big decision you are making and you are still very young"

"Can we know what sparked this, darlings?" adds Tlalli, keeping her voice back to calm and sweet. Catra folds her slim arms over her chest stubbornly, inflating her cheeks as she speaks.

"So that way when Adora has to go, we don't have to be away from each other"

"Oh, sweetie", says Mara, reaching over the table with a reassuring gesture. Catra's bright eyes relax, looking at Mara from under her big eyelashes. "There is still time until then and Adora won't be gone forever, darling. She will still be back in summers and winters. She just needs to learn a few things in Camelot"

"What can she learn there that she can't learn here?", pouts Catra, scratching the table with her nail. She hadn't meant to turn the conversation this way but now that it has she realizes how unhappy she still is about the whole matter. Adora presses close to her side, quiet. Mara shares a look with the queens for a few seconds, letting the girls silently comfort each other. Tlalli leans over the table, petting lightly her daughter's ears and then the puff of soft hair in Adora's head.

"Listen kids, nothing we decide as adults is with the goal of separating you. You are still very little and have a lot to live, but you will be in each other's lives no matter what", she pinches her kids cheeks, getting a surprised yelo out of them and a couple of giggles. She has seen these two live and grow together, her daughter doesn't know a life without Adora on it and she cares about the latter like her own child. Tlalli, and Ziba and Mara, they just want the best for both of them. Mara's healed battle scars can tell as much. "And, if when you are older and adults you still want to marry each other then we three will be there right next to you, what about that?"

The kids' eyes shine bright, nodding happily at the queen with matching smiles. They end their dinner in peace, promptly saying goodnight to their mothers before slipping away together, as always, right back into their shared room.

Adora is jumping in the bed, already changed into their long nightgown as they wait for Catra to stop roaming in their toys' basket. Her tail escapes the ruffles of her own nightgown as it wriggles in the ground excited. Adora can see the way her ears twitch before jumping one last time and letting herself fall on her back over the cloud soft circular bed. She can hear Catra's soft foot beans against the carpet of the floor as she approaches the bed and feel the blankets fuffle when she jumps swiftly into it, scooching close to Adora. Adora lifts their old blue blanket, the one they arrived at Halfmoon with and that later became theirs and Catra's, cocooning them both under it. They can see Catra's face thanks to the dim light of the moon light that slips through the blankets and can catch the way she blinks slowly at her with her big, bi-color eyes.

"What were you looking for?", asks Adora in a whisper. Catra has something cupped between her hands and her pretty eyes have a mischievous glint on them.

"I have something for you", murmurs Catra back, like a secret. She brings her hands up and opens them to show Adora the inside. There is a beautiful golden wing pin in them, small and

bright and new. Adora opens her eyes in marvel, brushing it's warm surface with the pads of her fingers.

"Where did you get it?". Catra shrugs, her lazy smirk self satisfied in her face.

"My mom gives this to Halfmoon advisors that she knows are of complete trust. As a symbol". Catra leans a little towards Adora, fastening the pin over the fabric of her nightgown with small fingers, careful of not pinching her in the way. Her sight is better at night after all.

"There. So that way, every time you see it you think of me", she says, repeating the same words Adora said to her that night on the roof.

Adora blushes, watching the little gift on her clothes with teary eyes. Catra presses her button nose in the angle of their jaw, sniffing a little before dragging it up and down her jaw and neck, scenting her friend. A low purr starts to build up in her chest too, rumbling in the nestled space between them. Is a reassuring gesture between both of them that has existed since they were almost babies when they met and Catra started to learn what a purr and a scent were. Adora giggles, laughing at the tickling feeling of Catra's peach fur cheek on their neck. Adora turns their head, attempting to return the gesture over Catra's own cheek as they always do. And as always is a bit awkward and not that good but it makes Catra laugh and sigh, cuddling closer to her best friend's sleepy figure.

"I am gonna marry you one day", slurs out Adora, already halfway asleep. Catra smiles, wrapping her small tail around Adora's skinny ankle.

"Okay". Sleep is already taking over, eyelids falling shut without being able to stop it. Under the ragged blanket is warm and Adora is too comfortable. "G'night 'Dora"

"Night night, C'tra"

These are pillars of Catra and Adora's entire lives. Each other.

❀

"Catra? I don't think we should be here"

“Hush”

They are scrunched behind a tall black stone and the huge green leaves of the brushes that limit the huge gate of Light Spinner's chamber. Peeking from the edge of their hiding spot, both friends can see the dark entrance on the place and a few candles with ruby red flame illuminating dimly the path. Adora and Catra have been here for the last fifteen minutes, studying the entrance and waiting for any movements that indicate that there is someone inside. Catra's ears are perked up, excited to see this forbidden thing in front of her gem eyes. Next to Catra, Adora shifts nervously, holding the ends of Catra's shirt tight between their fist to avoid her to sprint forward.

"I really, *really,* don't think we should be here", insists Adora in a whisper, voice cracking in the middle with nervousness. Catra bats her hand away, turning her head to send her a pointing, harsh look.

"My mom said we needed to apologize, didn't she?". Adora shifts on her feet, grimacing.

"I mean yes", they look back to the dark entrance. It looks menacing and huge. Adora's baby hairs raise on point and goosebumps travel down her entire spine, "but wouldn't it be better if we wait until our actual lesson in the library?"

"Oh, come on. You have always wanted to see this place as much as I have". Catra looks at Adora's face with intent, watching the way her curiosity battles with her fear of doing things right. It's an Adora thing, it always has been. Catra's tail brushes on the floor. "Who is the scary cat now?"

Adora scrunches her nose, not taking the bait, and she scrunches even lower behind the stone. "She said to us to never come here", and then when Catra makes a grunt of impatience, she adds, "it's dark".

"Not to me", sing-songs Catra, wriggling her shoulders proudly. But Adora looks even less convinced than before so Catra takes a different approach. "She is old, and our nanna, what do you think is going to happen?"

Adora shakes her head, now completely hidden in the bushes. "I don't want to go in there", she states, "I have a bad feeling"

Catra rolls her eyes, exasperated. "Fine, dummy. I'll go, so you can see there is nothing to worry about"

Catra sprints to her feet, ignoring Adora's weak pleas to stay, and walks promptly and swiftly into the room. The change of air is instantaneous. From the clear and almost sweet air of Halfmoon's hallways to a thick scent, like burned sugar and rotten lilies. Catra keeps walking but shivers anyway, rubbing her forearms discretely to keep the warmth. They are in the bottom deeps of the palace, in an insulated zone nobody really likes to be around.

"Catra, come back"

"Shush"

The ceilings are huge, at least over thirty feet tall, made of dark polished stone and hanging from them are spider chandeliers with red wax candles, drowning the place in red light and dripping gross wax drops into the equally dark floor. The walls are bare, no bright murals or colorful stones in there. There aren't green or purple or blue of plants, they instead look almost dry, dark toned that scatter over the floor of the chamber or up the corners of the walls. They seem to breathe, throwing to the air thick clouds of reddish pollen that make Catra's nose itch. Thanks to her extraordinary sight she can see the inside as clear as day, catching in the few thick, dusty books thrown carelessly to the ground and the rags of wine like curtains covering the high windows and with them drowning out all possible daylight. There isn't a bed there, or chairs or bookcases, just high stands filled with bottles of every

possible kind of shape, its interiors filled with neon substances, some liquid, some thick as clotted blood, others light as if mist itself had been trapped inside. There are others with little pieces of nature in them, roots and leaves and dry fruits and flowers. Some have powders both dull and colorless or bright and shiny. Catra has seen the Halfmoon's Sorceresses quarters herself and this place doesn't look that different to them, except that here, everything is darkers heavier, nothing like the bright colors of Halfmoon. Here it feels almost evil..

The little girl follows the straight path into the deepers of the chamber, always followed by Adora's hidden sight. There is a swift movement in some of the bottles and Catra walks closer to them to peak inside with perked ears. Inside the crystal bottles are tiny motes of light, fluttering desperately on their clear prison when they see Catra approach. She can hear the acute sound of their voices, like little bells or nails on the glass, and when they crash violently against the bottles trying to escape Catra can see the infinitesimally small of their sharp teeth. Catra gasps, surprised.

"Fairies", she whispers softly.

There is a sudden sharp sound, like metal crashing against the floor, that comes from behind a dark curtain hanging from two marble pillars. A new feeling slips into the chamber, cold and sticky that travels down the kid's spine like buckets of frozen water. Catra stiffens, unmovil and suddenly afraid, pressing her back against the shelves to try and blend with her surroundings. She can see Adora, still by the gate, sending her an urgent and panicked stare just as frozen as she is. Catra eyes the distance between the shelve and Adora, calculating swiftly if she can leap and make a run out of the room but before she can even more a foot the curtain of the pillars bursts open, a rush of rotten air hitting Catra's in the face and then a magicat runs out of the dark place, tripping with their own feet and falling hard in the floor. Their face is contorted in a complete panicked expression, fear dripping from their eyes like the wax from the chandeliers above. All their fine blonde hair is standing on point, tail frizzed and waving behind them in complete anxiety, brushing almost too close to where young Catra is standing with frightened eyes. Their chest raises in quick motions, breathes a mile per hour and the magicat scatters on the floor as if they were trying to escape from something still behind the curtains. The hand of the magicat grasps blindly behind them, accidentally brushing against Catra's little toes behind them. They turn in panic, taking for the first time in the look of their scared little princess. Catra tries to move towards them but the magicat shakes their head vehemently, bringing a trembling finger to their lips to signal her to be quiet and then scattering away and in the complete opposite direction of Catra.

The curtains in the pillars open and out walks Light Spinner. Her long, heavy black hair falls over her waist in limp strands, moving in such a strange way against her body that they look like octopus tentacles more than actual hair. Her skin is a sickening shade of gray, dull and pale that makes her look years older. On her face there are deep wrinkles and creases, dark bags under her usual green eyes that now shine a horrid shade of red, reddish than anything Catra has ever seen. The woman's hands rest at her sides as she walks in slow, rhythmic steps, her nails long, long like werewolves and curved in the tips. They, as everything in the woman right now, look dangerous, menacing and complete letal.

Catra doesn't even bat an eye, looking at the magicat crawling away and it takes her a few long seconds on her young brain to understand it is from Light Spinner, *her nanna,* the

magicat is running from. The magicat raises their hand, presumably to call any kind of magic they can muster right now but all that comes out are weak orange sparks and then the soft light of magic gives away and with it what it seems to be the last of the magicat's strength. Light Spinner hums, low and sweet and terrible under her voice and she leans towards the magicat, not once seeing or realizing about Catra's presence under this low light. She grasps between her monster claws the stained shirt of the magicat, lifting them effortlessly from the ground and close to her face, her eyebrows knitting in disgust and mockery while she regards their trembling form completely.

"If you do this", trembles out the magicat, scratching viciously the skin of her hands even if she doesn't even seem to notice it, "the queens will know, everybody will know. You are doomed witch"

Light Spinner quirks an eyebrow to them, clicking her tone against her sharp teeth. "How would they know? You are nobody", and her voice is calm and self indulgent, clearly proud and satisfied with what she is about to do. "You don't have a living family, or friends, or partners. You are just a poor lonely merchant magicat that nobody will ever notice is gone"

Light Spinner brings them even closer to her face, her other hand coming to grasp the fabric over the center of the magicat's chest, a faint light starting to form in there.

"Nobody will even remember you"

The poor magicat turns their head away, maybe to look at anything but the monster over them, maybe to tell Catra to run. It doesn't matter. Their eyes roll to the back, turning into the white sclera inside their sockets. Their entire body shakes violently, breathing stopping completely as the magicat gradually falls silent. The light in their chest grows brighter and brighter, illuminating Light Spinner's and the evil smile she wears as she tears the light up and towards herself. The magicat's body starts to turn too, into hundreds of little lights, like fireflies, and they look like they were sleeping before turning completely into light itself and being absorbed inside the extended palm of Light Spinner. Just as it happens, the skin of her face and neck starts to tender and smooth, becoming healthier and of a more vibrant shade. Her hair untangle, falling clean and soft behind her back. Now, she looks more like the usual woman Catra and Adora look at everyday.

The light flutters and absorbs completely, leaving nothing behind as if the magicat had never existed to begin with. Light Spinner shakes her shoulder, running a long, now normal hand, through her hair, smothering it back to its usual slik self. She ruffles the long of her dress, cleaning it of any spec of dirt with a stern look on her face.

"Magicats", she says out loud, like an offense, "heirs of Avalon's power and yet they used it for mundane things. So disappointing", she turns her back to the center of the chamber and to Catra, still petrified in pure fear against the shelves. "I will put that magic in better use"

Light Spinner starts to walk very slowly towards the curtains, face sleepy but obviously younger and healthier, fingers frizzling with the stolen magic and power. Catra stands very still in her place, her hands grabbing her own shirt between her fists. This is her moment right now, she needs to sprint, grab Adora from the gate and run with her mothers. She doesn't understand what just happened but she knows it's bad and scary. Catra starts softly stepping

from the shelves to the carpet that leads out, making any sound at all. She is probably just a few meters away from the gate when she sees one of the rings from the victim magicat dropped forgotten in the floor and she makes the mistake to *whimper.*

*****

There is a moment of quiet and silence and then the flames of the candles burst into huge fires, enlightening the chamber from corner to corner in red bright light. Catra jumps in surprise and barely has time to turn around when Light Spinner is already in front of her face, grasping her chin between her long, slender fingers with brutal force.

"C'yra", hisses out Light Spinner, her voice so venomous and ragged that shakes Catra's entire body. "What are you doing here?"

Catra is trembling and speechless, she doesn't even dare to look back at Adora back in the gate for help. Instead Catra just grinds her teeth together and breathes hard through her nose, looking back at what is supposed to be her nanna with wide teary eyes. Light Spinner seems to lose her patience at Catra's loss of words, squeezing harder her chin to an almost bruising point.

"You stupid child, didn't I tell you to never come here?"

Catra whimpers again and sobs without tears. Light Spinner has never talked to her like this, nobody has ever talked to Catra like this in her entire life. There have been scowling and serious words when either Catra or Adora had done wrong things sure, but never this. Never an insult, or a rude word or a harsh touch. Catra doesn't know what to do. Light Spinner scoffs at her, looking around each part of the chamber with a falcon eye to search for any sign of another person. She knows Catra saw her, she is making sure if someone else did.

"Where is Adora?", asks Light Spinner, pronouncing each word slowly and barely contained. Catra gulps, breaking into a cold sweat as she tries to find her voice back.

"I...I don't know", manages out Catra, little voice breaking in the middle. Light Spinner growls and drops Catra's chin just go yank harsh and painful from her soft ear, earning a yelp from the kid.

"Don't lie to me, C'yra. Where is Adora?". Catra bites back her tears. She is so small in Light Spinner's hands. Like a giant spider holding a little kitten between its claws. Catra's mind is overwhelmed with Light Spinner's questions, refusing to look at all at the gate and give away Adora's location. Instead she says,

"She is with her mom", Catra lies. "She doesn't know I'm here, I didn't tell her. She wouldn't have wanted to break the rules"

Light Spinner ponders over Catra's words, searching around once more just in case before releasing Catra from her grasp, letting her fall harshly against the hard floor.

"Of course she wouldn't have wanted", reasons Light Spinner with a condescending tone, "That child is destined for greatness, for something so much bigger. I'm actually glad that you

didn't convinced her to follow one of your idiotic usseles ideas as you always do. There is still hope for her. The most powerful of the Pendragon legacy, we will do great things together"

Catra stands back with shaky feet, refuse to remain thrown in the ground like a ragdoll. As with everything else, Catra's young mind can't understand the true depth of Light Spinner's words but she can understand that whatever it is, is dangerous for Adora. And that Catra is going to protect her. So she doesnt run, even if she could now with Spinner's back to her as she contemplates her obscure thoughts, because that would mean Adora getting out of the brushes and revealing her position. And whatever Light Spinner means with her words, Catra knows that if that would come to happen it would hurt her, one way or another.

"But you? You are nothing but an infectious leech in Adora's life. Always distracting her away from her true path, always holding her back. Always distracting her from being a future king". Light Spinner falls suddenly quickly quiet in the middle of her abuse, looking up at the ceiling and back to Catra. Her mouth is slightly agape, eyebrows shot as if an enlightening thought had just occurred to her. "Though, I wonder how far she could go without you hanging from her back"

Catra's shoulders are shaking like crazy, her tail and ears twitching from the anxiety and the pain of the pull. She sniffs, her nose and the rim of hee eyes red. She wants to go back, she wants to leave and let Adora hug her and rub away the sting in her ear. She wants to go into her moms' embrace and feel safe. She doesn't want to be here.

"Li- Light Spinner, I swear I won't say anything. Just- Just, I'll go. I'll go"

"Silence!", burst out Light Spinner. Her voice echoes in the chamber loudly, like a hundred voices all pulled together in a single yell. The floor sizzles like a lightning or a serpent, crawling over the ground and towards Catra at incredible speed. Catra hears it before it comes, and she manages to step back a few centimeters before the electricity reaches her. It hurts a lot. Catra yelps as tears fall without permission down her eyes, the energy surrounding her completely from head to toe. Catra tries to squirm, to trash away and yell for help but she can't. It feels like a leg cramp but worse, keeping her in place against her own will, pressing out all the air in her lungs. Light Spinner approaches her again, leaning until she is face to face with the princess. Her smile grows again, shaking her head.

"You have always been nothing but a disappointment. I won't let a pathetic stupid child like you ruin everything I've planned", the woman says. The green on her eyes starts to bleed away, bright red slipping in its place. "You are the heir of the most powerful magic and yet you can't do anything at all, just grow stupid flowers. What a waste"

There is a swift movement to their side and Catra can see on the edge of her eyes a shadow cross the hallway and scrunch next to the shelves. Catra can't breathe.

"Always getting into trouble, always disappearing away. No one will even be surprised". The shadow moves again, hidden in the dark spots of the chamber, this time closer. Catra can't break the spell and shout at them to stay away. "Don't worry, princess. I'll make use of that magic. And I'll make sure to do great things to Halfmoon"

Light Spinner reaches for Catra's chest, just as she did with the frightened magicat before. The tug hurts even more than the paralyzing electricity, making tears fall free from Catra's scared face as she feels herself be pulled away. The shadow runs out of their hidden spot, sprinting in almost inhuman speed towards the woman and their friend. Adora crashes against Catra, snatching her away from Light Spinner's hand and turning to face the woman completely, back shielding Catra's tiny figure from her.

"You are hurting her!"Adora yells. Their hands come up, wrapping around Light Spinner's still extended ones towards Catra. "Don't touch her!"

Golden light starts to appear in Adora's chest and hands, traveling out of her body in waves like a small sun inside the room. The rush of magic and fresh, sweet air blows most of the candles away, submerging the red chamber in white glow. Adora's burst of magic twinkles as bells and burns the skin of Light Spinner's hands, turning them into a charred black and red, like lava running through rocks. Light Spinner screams, stepping several feet away from the children with her breath ragged and her hands cupped against her chest.

Adora pants, exhausted by the huge amounts of magic just used. She extends her slim arms to the sides, acting further as a human shield in front of Catra, the sparkling light still surrounding them. Light Spinner turns to look at them, eyes digging holes in Catra's tiny form and the way her slender hands had come to grab the back of Adora's shirt. She is still shivering and she tugs from the fabric a couple times to shift Adora's attention towards her.

"Adora, let 's go". Adora ignores her, all the muscles in her body pulled tight. Up close, Catra can see that she is trembling too.

"Why are you doing this?", demands Adora, voice shaking. Catra pulls from her shoulders with more insistence, trying to push the unyielding forl of her friend towards the gate.

But Light Spinner is already collecting herself, straightening up again as she runs a burnt hand towards her unruled hair to keep it out of her eyes. She laughs, low on her throat, a kind of laugh that echoes in the entire chamber.

"Oh, Adora", says Light Spinner, locking her red eyes with the silver of the child's. "You never should have come in"

Light Spinner throws a hand up and then forward, a wall of dark magic crashing against Catra's small body and sending her flying back and into the shelves, bottles and wood breaking when she is slammed against them hard. Catra falls to the floor, barely managing to catch herself on her palms, skin scratching with the pieces of broken glass. The sudden violence throws Adora off, turning her body towards Catra in a shocked gasp, the golden light blinking and then disappearing completely. Catra blinks slowly and difficulty, looking up in time to see Light Spinner's massive figure towering over her distracted friend. Catra doesn't even have time to muster a weak warning when Light Spinner's long pointy hands grasp either side of Adora's small head, turning her back to look at her.

"Look at what she has made of you. Rebellious, insolent, soft. I will allow it no longer", grumbles Light Spinner. Adora yelps in fear, trashing her foot on the floor to try and free herself from the strong grasp. Her breathing speeds up, kicking blindly everywhere. Catra

tries to stand up but from the shadows that had fallen again after the light died down are born several dark smoky tentacles, grasping Catra's ankles, wrist and waist and holding her down into the floor, knocking her voice out of her throat with a strangled shout.

"Catra"desperately calls Adora, unable to even turn her head and see her. Light Spinner's eyes bare themselves deep on hers, flashing with something evil in them. "No, Light Spinner, what are you doing?"

"Don't worry, Adora", coos Light Spinner in a fake sweet voice. "I'm going to save you from her. Soon you won't have to remember any of this. You will be free from her, of the things she has made you do and see, of how much this girl has tangled herself into you"

Adora's pretty eyes widen in understandment, fighting her even harder than before. Light Spinner presses harder on their temples, lifting them completely off the ground and into eye level. Magic sizzles once again, electrifying the air of the entire chamber, sparks of red coming out of Spinner's charred fingers and into Adora's head.

"No, no", pleads out Adora, tear eyed and frightened.

"This is good Adora, this is merciful. You won't even miss these memories. I saw your ruin in this child's eyes from the very beginning. I shouldn't have let it go for so long, I should have separated you sooner. Allow you to become the perfect soldier you are meant to be. Pendragons and Halfmoon should never be related by affection. It is unnatural. I can't allow you to remember these hurtful things, I can't allow you to go back to Camelot with her". Adora shakes violently, already feeling Catra sleep away from her mind. Her hands twitch, trying to blindly reach for Catra still held down behind her. Light Spinner catches the movement, because she presses even harder. "I'll take care of her after I'm done with you"

Catra pulls hard against the restraints, hissing and clawing at the hard floor until her nails break. "Nanna, please. It 's my fault. Don't hurt her"

"Of course it's your fault. And now *I'm* protecting her from the pain *you* caused her", growls out the woman, tearing her eyes just once off Adora's paines face to focus it on Catra's young, tear stained one. Her voice drops even lower, sounding almost inhuman to the children's ears. "Look what you made me do, C'yra"

Adora whimpers, shooting their eyes close tight, murmuring in a faint whisper and unable to stop what is happening. "Catra, Catra. Please don't, I love her"

"Adora", sobs Catra behind her, clawing at the floor violently.

"Think of her, that's alright", spits out Light Spinner, darkness so thick and heavy it drowns every light in the room. "It will make this so much easier"

Catra feels herself shake so hard her teeth clank against each other loudly and painfully. She sees Adora struggle, trying to reach of Catra's hand who fights to raise her hand and take it too. It doesn't last much, because slow and terrifying Adora falls gradually silent, unconsciousness falling over her as she is ripped away from Catra's arms. Catra feels a tingle in her throat, build strong and strong with each second Adora remains quiet. The bottles in

the shelve, not only behind Catra but in the entire chamber start to jinggle and tremble too, insides boiling up and crashing against its crystal jails viciously. Light Spinner looks up from Adora's limp body and around the commotion, a confused spark in her eyes before her sight lands on Catra and in the way the ground below her little palms shakes and starts to cracks, right across the stone and shining in bright purple light, forming unshaped lines all around Catra and extending across the entire floor.

Light Spinner sprints forward, dropping Adora unceremoniously into the ground as she attempts to grab the back of Catra's hair. But the tight knot in Catra's throat tightens and then, as she sees her best friend dropped on the floor, snaps.

Catra screams and all the bottles around her explode with it.

✾

Mara, Ziba and Tlalli run down the hallways of the bottom of the castle, faces contorted in worry. There is a magic sphere spinning on Ziba's extended palm, a tracking spell with which they have been searching for their children for the last minutes. Their skins are raised in goosebumps and Mara and Tlalli's hairs are in disarray after dropping everything in the meeting room and running out of it to throw themselves in search of their kids. The piercing scream of the little princess had been heard across all of Halfmoon, ringing loud and scared on every corner of the palace and into her mothers' ears. Not a single person in the kingdom dared to move, breaths held as the palace remained quiet and the queen searched for the young heirs on the terrains.

The queens and king stop abruptly at the gate of Lady Spinner's chamber, the tracking spell spinning at full force when its magic finally finds the kids. Ziba looks up, the sphere dissolving in her hand as Tlalli sighs heavily next to her, grabbing tightly the fabric of her tunic. Mara holds her breath, taking on the pieces of glass scattered across the entire entrance and all the way leading inside the room. King Mara steps inside, waving a hand so the broken pieces are pushed aside on the way, their sticky and fluorescent contents staining the dark stones below. Ziba and Tlalli walk right behind her, their bare feet safe from wounds now that the glass has been put away.

They don't have to walk too far inside before they find them, and when they do the three mothers let out a horrified gasp, running at full speed towards their children. Catra is on her knees, little face buried in Adora's hair as she cradles their unconscious figure between her small arms. Her shoulders are shaking, hands grasping Adora’s temple and shoulder tight against her own chest, soft sobs coming from her tiny figure. Several feet away, Light Spinner groans and stands up slowly, head pounding from where it connected against the wall after the burst of magic sent her flying away. The three regents arrive next to the children at the same time, throwing themselves to their knees as they approach them with gentle hands.

"C'yra! C’yra, baby, what happened?", asks Tlalli in a gentle but urgent voice, trying to soften Catra’s grasp away from the fainted Adora. Catra shakes her head vehemently, sobbing so hard her entire little body is shaking with the strength of her cries.

“Adora”, whispers Mara, worry dripping tangible out of her voice. Ziba wraps her arms carefully around her daughter, softly but firmly removing her from her grasp on Adora’s. Catra trashes against the hold of her mother, extending her arms towards Adora again and again, grunting and whimpering. She isn’t speaking at all, from the shock or the fear, a mirror of her speechless time when she was still basically a baby. She is just weakly mumbling Adora’s name as Ziba presses her against her own lap and chest, rocking her side to side to calm her meltdown. Mara cradles Adora in her own strong arms, resting their back on her elbow and their legs over her lap. Her hand comes to cup gently the side of their face, brushing the purple and blue bruise on their temple in soothing circles. “Oh, darling”

“C’yra”, murmurs Tlalli, dragging herself on her knees next to her wife and daughter, smothering her dark hair back in place and the base of her velvet ears. Catra hisses at the motions, curling in herself into a tight ball against her mothers’ arms as she keeps sobbing inside her hands. “Baby. Baby, tell us what happened. I promise it will be alright, just tell us”

Catra opens her mouth several times, trying to push the sounds out, but her jaw is trembling so badly she can’t form any type of coherent sentence at all. Mara looks from her child to Catra with infinite sadness, extending a hand to place it over her small one in a reassuring motion.

"Princess C'yra was toying with the ingredients of my potions", comes suddenly Light Spinner’s voice, now completely recollected. She looks like a mess, hair tangled and dirt all over her face. The Regents snap their heads up, looking at her walking as slowly and calming as always, green eyes completely clean from any trace of red that may have ever lived in there. Tlalli looks at the burns in her hands, a surprised gasp leaving her mouth at the magical charred skin. Catra looks up at the woman too, her multicolored eyes filling with fear, pupils shrinking into mere pinpoints. "She is very young, she couldn’t control her magic, the poor thing, and Prince Adora suffered the consequences"

Mara sighs heavily, turning back to her child so she can press her tighter against her chest, checking her pulse and breathing with frightened fingers. Ziba and Tlalli press their lips in a tight line, looking at the scattered pieces of glass and at the destruction all around them. There are marks of flames up the walls and even the ceiling and red chandeliers crashed in the ground below, candles broken and melted over the carpets. The entire chamber smells like magic and electricity, a mess of unruled spells all over the place. But Catra is listening too and she shutters a bit, pushing out stubbornly a few words into the space between them "No. That's...no. I don't… why are you… please"

Catra hiccups and loses her words again, burying herself in Tlalli's embrace. Next to them, Adora stirs in Mara’s arms, filtering her silver eyes open just a slide. She takes in her surroundings, eyes confused and misted over, not a sign or recognition until she focuses on Mara’s face right above hers.

"Mom?", Adora whispers weakly, twitching as she tries to raise her head.

"Adora!", exclaims Mara, hugging her with renewed force and relief. She cradles the sides of their face, tears spilling out of her silver and purple eyes. Adora tries to smile but fails, looking around her again and again until her confusion turns into anxiety. Her breathing speeds up alarmingly, shoulders shrinking on themselves.

"Where are we?", questions Adora. She locks her eyes with the other four people watching her intently. And she can't recognize any of them."Who- who are these people?"

"Adora", whimpers Catra, leaning over her mothers arms as she tries to reach her friend with exhausted hands. Adora looks at her and looks at her, frowning deep and cautious. As Catra's hand brushes their leg, Adora *flinches* away, making herself as small as she can on Mara's arms.

"Who are you?", gasps out Adora, trembling. Catra stills for a second, eyes widening before breaking into a heart wrenching cry, heavy drops falling on the ground. Tlalli and Ziba lean in again, collecting Catra back into their arms as the girl keeps crying and crying against them. Adora's frightened expression has melted into surprise and then even further into undeniable sadness. Before anyone can even stop and console them, Adora is crying too, ugly and tired mixing with Catra's sobs. It's heartbreaking.

Mara can't handle it much longer. Their kids are in pain, her child is completely distraught. So she rests her palm against the base of Adora's head and pushes a small wave of magic into her, sending her slowly and gently back into a soft but deep sleep. Adora's cries subside as she falls asleep, body going comfortably limp into the secure arms of her mothers. Catra's tears slow down too but she is still whimpering, wrapping her tail tightly on Ziba's forearm to hold herself. Mara snaps her head up with obvious anger in her eyes, looking directly at Light Spinner's face and speaking with the commanding voice of Camelot's King.

"Talk". Light Spinner sighs, tangling her fingers together and straightening her spine. She looks at the sleepy figure of Adora with an unreadable expression, stoic and cold as always. They can't see the slow satisfaction that starts to bleed in too.

"It seems that the accident has erased Adora's memories of Halfmoon". The Regents looks at each other with their hearts in their throats, a new wave of fear washing over the three of them at the Sorceress' words,

"But how is this possible?", gasps Tlalli, looking at Adora with her eyebrows scrunched in sadness.

"I had many ingredients and potions here, some of them extremely dangerous, and all of which got mixed together when the explosion happened. We don't really know what happened. Some spells can work this way, targeting specific memories, memories of places or moments or people. And prince Adora has been nothing but glued to the hip to Princess C'yra. It's possible the explosion targeted her crucial moments with her because of that"

Mara's hold on Adora grows stronger, her thumbs rubbing circles over her forehead in a lovin motion. "Adora has lived here almost her entire life. This, Halfmoon, her life here, *C'yra,* it's all they know. Are you telling me she is going to forget her entire life?!"

Mara's tone grows higher and higher the more freaked out she gets yet Light Spinner remains calm, shaking her head. "She may remember some things, things not immediately related to here. She obviously remembers you, your Majesty. Yet she doesn't remember either the queens, or this place, or the princess. Only time will tell what parts of her life outside of Halfmoon have remained"

"Can't you fix it?"

"I'm afraid that would be an even bigger risk to Adora's health than what already happened. She can lose her entire memory. She can even lose her entire self"

"Goddess", murmurs Ziba, rubbing circles on Catra's back as she looks at the fragile body of Adora held on Mara's arms. "So what do we do?"

"Take her back." States Light Spinner, coldly, freezing everyone in the room. "Go to Camelot and raise her as if nothing had ever happened. Don't talk to her about Halfmoon or the princess."

"Lady Spinner, don't you think it is a bit drastic what you are proposing?", interrupts Queen Tlalli, voice drenched in grief.

"Making prince Adora stay here when she doesn't know where she is or who any of us are can be a traumatic shock for her. She will have to relearn things and it's best if she does them in her own kingdom. She was meant to go back soon anyway"

Mara, Ziba and Tlalli look at each with tears in their eyes, each holding their children with their hearts in their throats. Mara is trembling, brushing the loose blonde hair out of Adora's face so she can see better the softness of her young expression. Then back at Catra, still obviously in shock, her tiny ears twitching like crazy.

"We can't just break them apart like this", says Mara, still looking at Catra.

"Prince Adora doesn't even remember princess C'yra anymore. In all, losing her memory is the best of the worst things that could have happened to her. She was very lucky". At Mara's look of still undecision there is a flash of impatience on Spinner's eyes, which she hides by softening her tone and bending her head towards the King. "It's for the best, your Majesty"

Mara remains silent for a good couple of minutes, considering, before she slowly nods, accepting Light Spinner's words inside her heart. "Alright", Mara whispers, getting a better hold of Adora's sleepy body. "Alright"

Mara shifts hers and Adora's weight, lifting them together from the cracked ground around them. The movement seems to light something in Catra because she wriggles strongly out of the hold of her mothers, throwing herself towards Mara's legs and grasping the fabric of her pants with a strong grip from her small hands

"No!", Catra yells, tugging from the fabric insistly as she tries to bring them both back into the floor, jumping so she can reach and hold from Adora's limp foot. Tlalli and Ziba are already up too, wrapping their arms around their daughter's torso to try and coo her back.

"C'yra-"

"No, no, please don't take her away", pleads Catra, her voice raspy and sloppy after not talking for so long.

"C'yra this is the best thing we can do for Adora right now", explains Mara to the kid in a trembling voice, divides between the weight of her child and the big, teary eyes of this other child she loves.

"But she is my best friend. I love her", insists Catea now fully crying again. She turns her little head to Tlalli, begging with her eyes. "I love her mum please don't take her away"

Tlalli and Ziba try to calm down Catra as her breath speeds up again, dangerously close to a full hyperventilating. They are all so focused on the kids they don't see Light Spinner walking silently behind them until she places her hand on the back of Catra's head, casting the same sleep spell over her as Mara had done over Adora. Catra's cry subsides immediately, her slim body falling limp upwards. Tlalli catches her in an instant, breathing hard as she cheek upon her daughter. Ziba hisses, snarling at Light Spinner with a warning snarl on her face.

"Lady Spinner", the queen warns with a growl.

"I think it would be wise to erase the princess' memories of this too." Light Spinner turns to Ziba, looking her directly in the eyes. “Everything about Prince Adora and King Mara and Camelot”

The statement throws the queen off completely and she blinks a couple times as the words make sense to her. “What?”

“You said it could make them lose themselves, why would you suggest that now?”, adds Tlalli, clenching Catra next to her chest.

“Not if it's done with the utmost care. I'm sure your Majesty could do it, herself.” Tlalli looks completely horrified, looking between Light Spinner and Ziba with alarm in her eyes. Ziba's growl just deepens, a furious look crossing her blue eyes. Light Spinner doesn't even flinch, waving her hand towards the sleeping Catra as she speaks slowly, like she was explaining something to a child.

“Look at her, she is in pain. Do you really want to prision her into an entire life where Adora won’t even remember her? Much less come to *visit her* ? Where she will sooner or later blame herself about what happened? Once her mind truly starts processing the traumatic events they just lived and all the special things that she just lost will sooner or later crush her down. It would be devastating on her fragile psyche and she is just a child” Tlalli and Ziba get sickening pale, looking at each other as a conversation goes between them. In her sleep, Catra twitches harshly every once in a while, as if she were fighting terrible nightmares on her own. Ziba looks down at her daughter and then back at her wife, a pleading look in her eyes.

"She will suffer greatly if you don't", adds Light Spinner, crossing her arms behind her back. She knows she already won. “I understand is hard but we all want nothing but the best for them right now”

Ziba doesn't answer her, still looking at her wife intently, waiting for her answer before anything else. Tlalli's shoulders drop forwards, tears welling on her eyes as she nods.

"I can do it", she says, voice breaking. She turns to see Mara and Adora. "I can make her memories fuzzy, make the one's directly with Adora get locked away. She will remember her childhood as something confusing, blurry, nothing concrete. I can- I think I can do it"

"It's so much, Tlalli. Is her entire life", whispers Mara, tears falling free down her cheeks. Tlalli nods, mirroring her tears.

"It will be so confusing, for both of them. And I'm never going to forgive myself, but Lady Spinner is right. Losing Adora after so much, I wouldn't know how to explain it to her. I can't let her live like that"

"We can't let her live like that", affirms Ziba, stepping closer and resting her hand on her wife's shoulder. "It will be alright, Mara. Trust us"

It takes them another fifteen minutes to regain enough strength to gather their children and walk out of Light Spinner's chamber without another word. Mara carries Adora effortlessly and Tlalli keeps Catra close to her chest, resting her little head on the crook of her shoulder. She is still small enough to be carried like this. There is so much left to say and yet none of them can muster to say it. They are exhausted and devastated. It doesn't seem like only yesterday their kids were proclaiming they were going to be together for the rest of their lives as they played over dinner. Now it all seems like a different life. Now it seems as if life itself had decided that they were maybe too happy.

Mara stops when they reach the throne room, back to being surrounded by the warmth and colors of Halfmoon. She turns to look at the queens and to little Catra, sighing heavily.

"I think it would be best if we parted immediately", she says. Ziba nods, one of her arms wrapped around Tlalli's waist, the other smothering Catra's messy mane.

"I'll ask someone to bring you Adora's things at once", her voice is trembling slightly and as she sees Adora fast asleep she almost looks as if she were to start crying. Mara understands the feeling.

"Thank you", she answers, smiling tiny and fragile. She can barely watch Catra's tiny figure without wanting to tear up too. "I want you both to know that I don't blame you or C'yra, not at all. This was a terrible accident and it hurted them both" Mara hesitates, shifting on the ankles as she thinks well her next words "Maybe we should wait to meet again. When they are older. When we can talk to them about this and they understand it. When they can understand the pain and overcome it together"

"I agree", Tlalli's voice is raspy and quiet, tears stuck in her long eyelashes. She extends one of her arms, softly and lovingly brushing the golden bangs out of Adora's forehead, down to her cheeks and chin. She has seen her laugh and run and grow here. She is going to miss her so much "Maybe we'll be free from the war by then"

"I hope so", Mara's hand comes up to wrap around Tlalli's, squeezing gently. "I'm so sorry this happened"

"We aren't". Ziba walks towards them too, ruffling Adora's long hair and placing her own hand over Mara's shoulder. "Our children loved each other. No matter what happened, they loved each other. And maybe this is a sign, that our kingdoms aren't ready to join, that this wasn't the time. But they are proof that a great future awaits us with them. And that's the greatest hope we could have asked for"

Mara smiles come easily this time and she lets herself melt into the gentle embrace of the five of them. When they part they notice Catra's tail has come to unconsciously wrap around Adora's arm, slipping away when Tlalli steps back. It's the last embrace they'll have in a long time.

The staff of the palace bring to Mara several satchels full of Adora's clothes and personal items. There isn't a single thing left inside of Halfmoon from her, they had explicit orders. They hang it securely on the sides of Mara's trusty horse, Darla, bowing swiftly before walking out of the room again.

"I'll help you go home", says Ziba. Her finger makes a small circle in the air, red sparks twinkling as a single, real arcane circle forms itself under Mara's and her horse's feet. "Please be safe. And if Camelot is ever in need, no matter when or why, come to us. Halfmoon is still and always will be from now on, your friend". Mara nods, unable to speak but grateful.

"We'll meet again. *They* will meet again", afirms Tlalli. They are starting to look a little fuzzy, the arcane circle already working up as it starts to take Mara and Adora away. Mara rubs Adora's back, smiling to the queen and their daughter one last time.

" Yes. Yes, I'm sure of it"

❀

Mara knocks gently on the wood of the door, waiting patiently for a few minutes until she hears a faint *Come in* from the inside. The chamber is dark when she enters, candles blew out or never lit up to begin with, with just small specks of golden light floating gently in the direction of the biggest window. The crystal doors are open, leading to the wide balcony attached to the tower and outside to the calm night in Camelot. The sky is clear, not a cloud in sight, letting show all the stars and comets and constellations above them, showering Etheria in blue light. Adora is sitting on a blanket in the balcony, legs pressed against her chest, arms wrapped around them, chin resting over her knees. Her hair is loose, falling in soft curls down her small back and the fabric of her cotton night clothes.

Mara walks towards them silently, knowing that they know she is there but not wanting to break the fragile quiet of the room. Mara breathes deep a few times, opening and closing her hands nervously before stepping into the balcony too and sitting swiftly next to her child. Adora doesn't speak, too lost in the twinkling stars, but she does lean against her mothers' body chasing the warmth and the comfort. Mara cups the side of her face gently, brushing her thumb over her skin. Her cheek is wet. She 's been crying.

"How do you feel, baby?", asks Mara in a whisper, letting her hand come up towards her hair. The bruises at her temples are wearing down, now more green and yellow than red and

purple.

"Tired", answers Adora. Her voice is worn down, low and exhausted. There are dark bags under her eyes even after sleeping for so long, and her skin almost looks grey. "And I...I feel weird"

"How so?", Mara is gentle but her heart is in her throat, banging harshly against her ribcage. Adora shrugs, looking almost annoyed as she frowns.

"I don't know. I remember some things I guess but it is just so...blurry and confusing, it hurts to think about it", Adora hesitates, looking down at the floor, "I remember you, mom, and talking to you. I remember myself and visiting markets and playing with...playing with kids I think. But I can't remember their faces, I can't remember whole things, whole years. I know I like desserts but I don't know which ones. I know climbing to high places is important but I don't know why. I know I loved people but I don't remember who. I know where we are and who I am but at the same time... I remember nothing at all"

Adora kicks the rocks in the balcony, scoffing. Her hand comes up unconsciously to rub at the base of her earlobe, pulling it gently. It seems to calm her down and the sight is so much Catra, Mara is about to cry all over again. "I don't know mom, it just sucks"

"Of course it sucks. You are in all your right to feeling angry about this". Adora holds herself tighter, turning to see her mom with sad eyes.

"What did you say happened? I can't remember anything at all". Mara gulps, praying for her voice to not to break as she lies.

"You fell from a tree. Knocked that tooth too", Mara pokes her nose but Adora doesn't laugh. "You've been asleep for three days. Really gave us a fright here"

Adora absorbs her mothers words and nods as she accepts them as truth, not once dubbing her. Mara sniffs discreetly, petting down the wild hair in her child's head to keep them and herself grounded. "Don't force yourself, sweetie. You had a pretty bad accident. It will take you time to get used to things again"

"But what if I never get to?", questions Adora, pouting. Her silver eyes shine with tears. "What if I'm broken forever?"

"Adora, don't say that. You are not broken", states firmly Mara, fighting Adora's stubbornly pressed lips with a sure look. Yet she knows it's not completely true, there is something essential missing in Adora's eyes. They may not remember it but their heart has surely not forgotten. This is a weight both Adora and Catra will have to unknowingly carry during their lives.

"I just, I feel that there is something very important I'm forgetting mom. I feel like I failed somehow. It doesn't feel good"

"I know, baby, I know." Mara cups Adora's face with her palms, sweeping off the little tears that had started to fall. "Listen Adora, losing so much of your life is not easy. What happened

to you was tragic and unfair, and I know it hurts. But you will grow and learn from this. Don't take the bad, take the good things from this Adora. All those feelings you can't place? Make them your pillars. Grow from that love and happiness, even if you can't remember it."

Adora exhales, watery, and surges forward to wrap her arms around Mara's middle and hug her tightly. Mara returns the embrace, letting Adora pour out all grief she feels for as long as she wants. The sadness will probably fix itself on their very bones, so they will need as much love as it can be given.

"People look at me as if they haven't seen me in a long time, mom. It's strange"

"Well, you've been living with Razz for a long time now", lies again Mara, looking firmly at the floor of the balcony. "They are just happy to see you back".

"Oh. That's true"

Adora parts from her mother softly, rubbing their eyes with the back of their hand. The movement let's her night coat fall open and Mara can see the glimmer of something golden clasped on their shirt.

"What is that?". Mara points at the little thing and it's only when Adora turns her head down to look at it that she recognizes the little winged pin that belonged to Halfmoon's treasure hall. Probably a gift from Catra. Mara gulps heavily, sweat breaking in her face. She wishes she could run back to the kingdom and allow them to meet again. But she knows she can't, this is the best they can do for their children's sake. And by this point today, princess C'yra doesn't remember Adora anymore. Adora struggles with the pin until it unclasps free from her shirt, letting it fall a bit hesitant on her mother's hand.

"I had it with me when I woke up. I..well, I don't remember where it came from. But I like it", Adora thinks about it for a second longer, nodding as if she had arrived at some kind of conclusion. "I'm supposed to have it always." Her frown deepens, reaching in the very ends of her mind but coming empty handed. "I think I promised it"

Mara looks at her struggle with her thoughts, growing annoyed and then frustrated and then resigned. Mara brushes a strand of hair behind her ear, squeezing her shoulders reassuringly.

“Hey” Adora raises her eyes back to their mother. They are misted and teared still. Mara squeezes her fingers around the winged pin tighter. “Queen Angella and I have been talking. What do you think of Princess Glimmer coming to stay for the summer? You met her when she was very little, about three. And she would come with the Historian's Master's son too. Sounds fun?”

Adora looks conflicted for a little while, torned between turning her mother's offering down but also showing her that she is going to try. At the end her shoulders give up, nodding weakly in affirmation. “Sure, mom”

Mara hugs her a little harder, tucking her head under her chin for a few seconds until the apprehension leaves Adora's body and she relaxes again. She is worried for Adora, but won't let it show too much in front of her. Right now, her priority is to make her child feel like she

belongs again. She has missed her laugh, it almost doesn't seem that she heard, clear and free, it just a few days ago.

"Alright, baby. I'm going to let you sleep. Ten minutes more here and then to bed, alright?"

Adora shakes her head and makes a soft sound of agreement, turning to look at the stars just a little longer. Mara is barely stepping out of the balcony when Adora's voice comes in again, small and unsure.

“Hey mom? Can I have my wing back? Please?”. Mara looks back at them, their big pleading eyes suddenly full of anxiety again. Her hand is halfway extended, as if they weren't sure if Mara would for some reason allow her petition. “I just feel happy with it”

Mara's eyes melt and she smiles kindly to her daughter, letting the trinket fall on Adora's open palm. "Here you go. Take very good care of it”

Adora nods solemnly, more like she was doing a vow. "Thank you" and then in a sweet, honest voice, “Love you mom”

"Love you too, sweetie"

As Mara turns to leave she notices for the first time that the stone rails of the balcony are not bare anymore. Thick, vibrant green brushes have grown alongside the entire length, crawling over the floor and the wall of the tower, up and up until getting lost of sight by the tower's roof. Small iridescent bulbs are scattered across the bushes and when Mara leans to look better the buttons bloom completely, the most beautiful white roses she had ever seen. Their petals are like velvet, fresh dew stuck over its soft surface. They move softly with the warm breeze, like pearls over a sea of green. Mara gasps, taking in the sudden beauty in front and around of her with wide, marveled eyes. She turns to Adora, who is unaware of her mother's astonishment, as she concentrates on fastening the pin right back in her shirt and guarded back behind their soft coat.

"Did you make this grow, sweetie?", asks Mara. Adora follows her sight and Mara can see the way her eyes turn inadvertently soft when they see the blooming roses.

"Yep", they answer, popping the last letter with a newfound cheer. This is the first time since Adora woke and her mother explained to them the memory loss that Mara has seen their face light up like before. "I dreamt of them while I was out. I don't remember if I've made something like this before but it felt, um, natural". And then Adora *smiles*. "They are pretty"

"Yes they are", agrees Mara, looking at Adora with pride and hope in her silver and purple eyes. Maybe they were right. There is still a future for them.

Something to hold onto.

❀

Ziba and Tlalli peek through the open door of Catra's chamber. She is curled in a tight ball by the headboard of the new circular bed, the twin beds gone long before she woke up, her little head nested between her bent knees. The queens step inside carefully, reaching to their daughter as they sit gently next to her.

“Hi, little panther”, whispers Tlalli, wrapping her hand around her little foot. Tlalli's face is still pale and shocked after erasing Catra's memories, so Ziba rests her arm on her shoulders, squeezing lovingly. Catra's ears twitch at the sound of her mother's voice and her body shivers when she starts softly crying behind her hand.

“Oh, oh” hushes Tlalli, wrapping her arms around her and curling Catra’s little body against her chest “why are you crying, baby?”

“I don’t know”, hiccups Catra, dissolving in another fit of sobs. “I’m sad”

“Oh, baby. It’s alright”, says Ziba, placing loving kisses at the top of her daughter's head. Catra wriggles a little, parting just enough from the arms of her mom to look at her mother in the eyes, hey eyes bright and teary and completely.

“Mommy, did I lose something?”

Ziba and Tlalli look at each other with grieving eyes, keeping their breaths as even as possible as their child keeps looking at them. Ziba turns back to Catra, carrying her swiftly into her lap. She rocks her gently from side to side, hushing down her tears as she ruffles her ears. “Why do you ask, little panther?”

“It hurts. Here”, she points at her chest then cries again. “Did my heart get lost?”

Tlalli's breath gets stuck in her throat painfully, gasping at Catra's words. Her eyes well in unshed tears and she has to look away for a second so as to not burst into tears too. Ziba takes the lead with Catra, cupping her head between her large hands adorned with golden rings.

"You had an accident little panther", says Ziba. Catra looks at her without understanding, confusion written in her entire face. "You were taking a lesson with your nanna, Lady Spinner, and your magic went a little off. It seems some memories got...a bit blurry for you after that"

Catra's ears perk in attention and then flop tight against her head, a shiver running down her spine when Zabi explains. "I don't remember anything of that"

"We know", Ziba looks at her wife, who has recovered enough to smile gently at her daughter. She didn't prey inside Catra's memories, just focusing on everything that felt like Adora and locking it away inside her mind, far away where her young mind couldn't reach. "It will get easier, little panther"

As Catra nods sadly with her small head, joining the flat of her feet together in the same way Adora always used to sit, Ziba and Tlalli realize some parts of Adora were woven so deep in Catra they would never go away. They were glad.

“Hey, we have a gift for you”, murmurs Tlalli, reaching to the foot of the bed and lifting something slik and black. Tlalli left the little shadow on Catra's lap, allowing her to see the way the baby cat unruled themself and blinked curiously at Catra with a pair of vibrant blue eyes. “This is Melog. They will be your friend and they will protect you”

The cat stretches, kneading Catra's night clothes with his little paws. Catra's eyes wide with marvel, scratching the back of their ears with her fingers. Melog rubs their head against her palm, purring loudly and happily over their new friend. Catra giggles, a little wet and a little sad, but giggles nonetheless cuddling Melog between her arms and snuggling with them below the warm blankets. Ziba and Tlalli smile at each other, a little bit more relieved, tucking the blankets around Catra and Melog tighter. Tlalli presses a hand on the covers, placing a warming spell in the bed that makes Catra's feet tickle. Her eyes are still raw red from tears and it will take a lot of time before she stops crying at night, mourning the loss of something she doesn't even remember was there before. But Ziba and Tlalli will do it right, and she'll grow surrounded by love no matter what.

"Try to sleep alright, baby?" Tlalli leans to kiss Catra in the forehead, slicking back the wild hairs of her bangs out of her eyes.

"Alright", whispers Catra back, tired and worn out.

"We'll see you in the morning", Ziba leans to and kisses both her ears, ruffling the mount of fur on her collarbones. Catra snickers and nods, curling in the bed around someone that is not there anymore.

Ziba holds Tlalli's hand on their way down, turning down the crystal lamps and blowing out the candles, letting the light of the night moon be the only thing enlightening the chamber. From the shadows next to the bed, a figure shifts and walks out of them, Light Spinner reaching the edge of the bed with burning cold eyes. Catra covers half of her face with the blanket, looking at the shadow with suddenly frightened eyes.

"Nanna Spinner?"

Light Spinner smiles, wide light a blackwidow. Her long fingers tugging at the hems of the blankets, pulling it further over Catra's nose.

"It's alright, Princess C'yra", she slithers out, looking intently at her, searching for any clue that she remembers anything at all. She had stood right next to queen Tlalli when she confused her memories, waiting in the shadows. It didn't matter, she had won. She won from the very beginning. When she is sure there is no recognition or any kind of remembrance from the princess, Light Spinner's smile weaves a little, bringing her face closer to hers to whisper at her. "Don't worry Princess, nothing will hurt you as long as you listen to your mothers, and to *me* . The only monsters you need to worry about outside of Halfmoon's protection, it's the Pendragons"

Catra holds the blanket close to herself, trembling. "The Pendragons?", she asks in a shaky voice.

"Yes. They have done terrible things to the magicats"

Before she can keep going, the powerful voice of Ziba calls from her place in the open door. "Lady Spinner", her eyes are slit as she narrows them, lips pressing in a fine, barely contained line. "I wasn't aware you walked in with us. Please let the princess rest, she has had some rough couple of days"

Light Spinner doesn't turns to see her, but her expression sours at Ziba's words. She leans one more time to whisper to Catra, "I'll tell you the story tomorrow, your Highness" before straightening up and walking with resolute step to the gate.

"Of course, your Majesty". Before Light Spinner can walk away, Ziba sizes her by the elbow, turning her around so she can see her directly in the eyes.

"From tomorrow on I will be present during all of Princess C'yra' magic leassons, Lady Spinner. Is that understood?"

Light Spinner narrows her eyes but she doesno fight it, throwing her hair back and straightening her spine. Ziba doesn't relent, waiting for a verbal answer. "As your Majesty wishes"

Ziba snarls a little but let's go of her elbow, looking at her up and down before reaching for her wife, lost in thought next to the hallways windows. "Very well"

Ziba closes the door behind them, letting Catra bury herself in her bed. It feels too big and too cold, even with her mom's spell over her. Melog wiggles in her grasp, snuggling in the crook of her neck. They are still too small so they fit perfectly in that space and as they start to gently purr against her the cold washes away a little. Catra sighs, rubbing her nose against the pillows. They smell nice, like oranges and roses.

They grow up miles apart until life brings them together again.

❀

Halfmoon, 15 years later

Before the wedding

"Catra, are you like , sure, *sure,* about this?"

Catra sighs, putting the last of her clothes inside the big arcs scattered across her floor. Most of her personal items are already locked and ready to go, walls bare except for the colorful drawings made years ago, witnesses of a childhood she doesn't remember but she also doesn't have the heart to cover down. "I already told you Scorpia. Yes, I'm sure. I'm accepting King Pendragon's proposal."

"But-"

"Scorpia", interrupts Catra, resting her hands on her hips as impatience grows. Her tail brushes the ground nervously and by the edge of her eyes she can see Melog's mane, still perched in the hammock next to the window, turning a pale shade of green. She is already a

nervous wreck, trying to bury it all down behind her strong confidence and royal stand. Having her friend questioning her for the last days isn't helping.

"But, I just don't understand why", insists Scorpia, ignoring Catra's very obvious state. "You swore you hated the Pendragons. That they had been the cause of the magicats almost destruction. And now you are going to marry their last heir and open Halfmoon's gates? Wildcat, this is a very harsh turn of heart".

"My moms always wanted to open Halfmoon again. To join Etheria once more", Catra turns away from Scorpia, fishing her books and paints and throwing them carefully in the arcs. "It 's convenient. If I marry them they will have the obligation to protect Halfmoon too. Kingdoms that join by marriage can't declare the war to each other, it's an Etherian rule"

"But", questions Scorpia again and Catra has to resist the urge to not bang her head on the table "You have never wanted to be with anyone. How are you going to live with someone you don't even know?"

Catra sighs, admitting the importance of Scorpia concern. She looks over at the resthold next to the window, where her wedding gift rests in clear blue water.

"It's just business", says Catra in a distracted whisper. "I'll do what I need for my people"

Scorpia remains quiet for a long while, enough so Catra finishes taking down her things and locking the arcs with a swift of magic. The magicats also waiting in the chamber bow to her and carry her belongings away and out of the castle, meant to be kept safe on the caravan for their travel to Camelot. Scorpia shifts in her feet next to the door, fidgeting with her clothes.

"I still have a sour feeling about this. As if someone were baiting us out of Camelot"

"Scorpia", blurts out Catra, the last of her patience running low. "Please just, trust me alright? If they do anything to us or they betray us we will turn them into ashes, I swear" Scorpia thinks about it for a little, still unsure, but nods. Catra exhales heavily, resting her hand over the table. "Good, now please go fetch Entrapta from whatever thing they are doing right now. We are leaving at five".

Scorpia eyes sparkle and she rushes out of the chamber in a clumsy run, yelling loudly Entrapta's name before closing the chamber's door behind her. Catra exhales heavily amd exhausted, walking towards the window with low steps.

"I don't know why", Catra whispers to the empty room. The beautiful, fresh rose King Pendragon had sent her rested on its crystal base, catching the light of the sun on its white petals. Catra sighs, reaching for the soft and carefully cared for flower hidden in the high perch of the window, miraculously still soft, beautiful and alive after so much time. Catra caresses its petals with gentle fingers, calm and warmth surrounding her as it always does when Catra needs it. She doesn't know where it came from or who gave it to her. Maybe she picked it as a child on a field, maybe it was part of something much more important. Whatever it is, is part of the fuzzy fragments of her childhood. But this little thing she has always had and the gift she just received, is too much of a sign to ignore.

"Who knows what this will bring. To Halfmoon, to Etheria, *to me.* I guess that for the first time ever I just know this is right", murmurs Catra, letting her childhood' rose back into its hidden spot and taking the king's gift with her.

It's a virtuous sign, a good omen, a forgotten promise. Catra won't remember it but her heart will.

"You better make good of your promises, King Pendragon"

End of chapter IX

Chapter End Notes

Fuck Shadow Weaver, am I right?

She really went there and manipulated Catra's mothers into erasing their daughters own memories. I've come to rapidly realize the big bad on this story is mainly Shadow Weaver, even over Horde Prime (tho don't forget about him please, he still has to make an entrance in the story)

Many dots have been connected here, many of the things that makes Catra and Adora who they are inside this story have always been intertwined with each other. I really invite you to read again earlier chapters because I hide lots of foreshadowing in there that probably you will only notice now that you know their past but it's always been there.

Thank you so much for reading! Comments, kudos and bookmarks are always appreciated.

Next update, the last chapter of your second arc, will be in October 15th (may change depending of when I finish the chapter, keep an eye open in my IG aoiveae.art !!!)

Be good!

Chapter 11: A thousand tears

Chapter Summary

> And it's worthy, all the beautiful days and weeks and months and years together, it's worthy because Adora is worthy. And still is not fair.
> Why do they always have to lose each other?

Chapter Notes

> Hello, Hello! Welcome to another chapter of our fairytale!
> I know these are hard times inside the walls of Camelot AU, though fear not, everything will get better sooner than later. But first, things have to happen.
>
> Warnings for this chapter: Grief
>
> Take a deep breath, a glass of water and see you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CHAPTER 10. A thousand tears

WINTER

It feels cruel. Something in me isn’t ready

to let go of summer so easily. To destroy

what I’ve carefully cultivated all these months.

Those pale flowers might still have time to fruit.

— Karina Borowicz, *September Tomatoes*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x

✾

Catra is warm. She is comfortable and surrounded in a golden warmth that slips inside her bones carefully. She is in bed, resting over soft blankets and even softer pillows, the length of her nightgown tangling around her legs lightly after a night of shifting around. She can feel

her baby inside herself, sleepy and calm as everything around them, peaceful. Catra smiles, eyes still closed. She doesn't want this to end just yet.

Catra can feel something solid pressed on her side and below her cheek, on the side she is resting over. Is firm but warm, warmer than the light that slips from the open windows, turning everything white. It's breathing, what Catra is sleeping over, the inhales and exhales of air deep and calm, puffs of air that ruffle Catra's hair at the top of her head. She is more awake now and can distinguish the feeling of a strong, large hand resting over her back, protective even in their sleep, shifting once in a while with twitches of dreams. Catra smiles, content, happy, so happy. She feels their baby shift on their sleep too, sensing the calmness wash over their mother like a shield from the real world.

Time passes. A few minutes, a couple of hours, Catra can't determine the time and she doesn't want to. But in the end, the light flutters her eyes open just a crack, just enough to see the bright white colors and the rumpled creases of a night shirt behind her hand. It moves up and down slowly, lulled by the breathing of the person holding her in her sleep. Catra's heart jumps in her chest, excited, and she gives in tilting her head up and finally, *finally,* opening her eyes completely to take in the sight of her love next to her.

Adora is asleep. Her long hair free from its usuals leather bands, falling in waves of gold over the pillows, like honey over milk, tangling with the own free strands of Catra's chocolate one. Her face is peaceful, a pink flush cradled over her cheeks, periwinkles in her closed eyelids and her eyelashes are so light they look white, little rays of light casting amber shadows over her skin. This is the calmest Catra has ever seen her sleep and she sighs in happiness, heart full and mind numb.

Now that she is basically completely awake, Catra can make sense of the shapes of the chamber. They look foreign, nothing like the ones of their room in Camelot nor even like the forms in her bedroom in Halfmoon. Everything is cream and white, only the bed in the middle of the round room, long columns of marble cradled with white climbing roses and the pouring golden light coming from the open glassless windows. There is no door and somehow no ceiling, though Catra can't make out what exactly is up there. Is silent, not heavy and overwhelming, but calm, kind silence. Somewhere outside Catra can hear the gentle run of water and nothing else. She knows she should be cautious, confused at best, but her heart is quiet inside her chest and her entire heart is laying sleep around her. She doesn't need anything else.

As if startled by Catra's own awakening, Adora stirs, their eyes fluttering below their sockets a few times before opening slowly. The blue of their eyes shine like sapphires under this light and they blink a couple of times before searching quickly for Catra. The hand that rests over her back tightens just a little, lovely calloused pads rubbing circles on the skin that has slipped out of the long nightgown, making Adora smile, still sleepy and soft. The shine in their eyes glimmer when they catch Catra looking back and the smile widens, allowing all the love and belonging and want to sleep free and into Catra's chest.

"Hey, Adora", greets her Catra is a soft whisper because speaking any louder feels like a sin in that white space. Adora's eyes wrinkle in the edges when she smiles, giving her that look that lives within Catra's soul and that leaves no doubt of how much Adora truly loves her.

“Hello, my love”, murmurs Adora in kind, the hand on her back coming to caress her soft ears in slow motions, a low purr growing in Catra’s chest as an answer. Adora’s other hand sneaks up from beneath the blankets, sliding it over Catra’s belly covered by the fabric of her night clothes. Adora sighs when they feel the sweet curve against their palm, red coloring further their cheeks at the way Catra’s eyes melt locked with theirs. There is a beat and then their tiny baby moves sweetly, kicking precious and lovely in the exact place where Adora rests her hand. A movement soft within their mother's belly but sure, as if greeting their other mother's presence with joy. Adora looks at the bump, overjoyed and filled with the deepests of loves, tapping their fingers gently over them in answer. “Hello, my heart”

Catra blinks treacherous tears away, marveled in the way Adora greets their child with already so much love and devotion. She raises to her elbows, brushing golden strands out of Adora’s face, cupping the side of their handsome healthy face with her hand. They are so beautiful. It aches Catra’s heart how much she loves this wonderful, kind person. Adora cradles her hand with hers, keeping them pressed together in the side of their face. They sigh, nuzzling there gently, allowing their eyes to fall close one more time.

"How long have we been sleeping?", questions Adora, blurred in her still sleepy state. And suddenly Catra can’t answer her. She can’t because she doesn’t know, she doesn’t remember how they even got here in the first place. She just knows she is surrounded by light and love and everything that is Adora, and suddenly Catra feels like crying. Because this is a beautiful wish, everything both of them have ever wanted, but a wish nonetheless.

Adora moves both their hands further, cradling Catra's face between their palms, brushing away with their thumbs the tears that had started to fall down her lovely face. It's useless because they keep coming one after the other, flowing down like a river in a storm, carving paths on Catra's cheeks and down her chin. Adora's eyebrows knit together, distraught and worry painted on their face at the sight of their love crying between their fingers.

"Catra, don't cry", they plead to her softly, caressing the skin under her eyes again and again. Their breath is sweet, like oranges, hitting Catra's face with feather touch. But there is also infinite sadness in their eyes and a grieving pout on their pink lips. Adora knows too.

She stays, lulling her loves' sadness with loving fingers, almost waiting for the wish to glitch and dissolve. Yet they remain there, because whatever god that has decided to take pity on them allows them for a moment longer, just a little more of sweetness and calmness in this space. Catra hiccups as the tears subside, burying her face on Adora's hands, tangling her fingers over their white shit, tight, so tight so Adora can't go anywhere without her.

"Where are you?", asks Catra and her voice comes out as a strangled whisper that breaks her love's heart into pieces. Adora shakes her head lightly, brushing with their fingers the bangs out of Catra's eyes.

"I don't know", confesses Adora, broken and fragile, her silver and turquoise eyes filled with crystal tears, falling down the peach of her cheeks in sweet tracks of sadness. Catra wants to speak but she can't, her voice is dormant on her throat, betraying her completely. The baby kicks, Catra feels it and so does Adora, because the tears fall faster, making their eyes look like liquid mercury. Adora's hands press into Catra's face, cupping gently, so gently her jaw and chin, brushing away errand tears that Catra hadn't even noticed had stuck to her

eyelashes. Adora exhales, regaining all their courage again, rubbing soft circles on her cheekbones and giving her the smallest of the smiles, one that speaks of immeasurable love and unyielding reverence and also deep understanding.``My love, I think you need to wake up now"

Catra whimpers, now holding Adora's shirt tightly between her fists, teeth clenched together in grief. She shakes her head vehemently, defying Adora's sad gaze with hers. "I don't want to"

"You need to", and Adora lowers a hand, their thumb brushing delicately the curve of her belly, softening the feeling of another small kick with it. Her touch feels almost ethereal, like butterfly wings against her skin.

Catra gasps back a sob because she knows they are right and yet she grieves. "I just want you here. I just want you to stay"

Adora smiles through her tears, mirroring the feeling with kindness, yet their gaze is deep and wise, an unknown knowledge nesting there. That one that tells them both that even if they belong here, on this peace and quietness, neither can stay.

"So do I", Adora says, smiling just a little. She looks around and seems to consider their surroundings, lost in thought. Their eyebrows furrow, trying to piece things and feelings together, even if the cloud of sleepiness is heavy over them. "Catra, nothing could keep me away from you. I'm not gone, I think-I think you just need to find me"

Catra exhales, feeling the threat of new tears to come. Adora must see it too because she pets down the wild curls on her head, smiling through the shakiness as they motion her back into their chest. "Catra", pleads Adora, still in a whisper "just hug me please".

Catra complies, because she could never deny Adora anything, scooting closer until her nose is pressed in the curve of their jaw, her weight back in their sure arms, their baby resting back over Adora's side. Catra's ear squishies between their neck and her hand comes to rest right over Adora's throat, feeling the raising and falling of their breath under her palm. Adora kisses the crown of her head, wrapping her and the baby in their strong arms. Catra's breathing shakes, eyes locked on the movement of their chest. She doesn't want to close her eyes, not yet.

"I don't know how to do it", Catra murmurs to Adora, maybe to answer Adora's previous statement, maybe for a completely different reason. But Adora understands, because this is Catra and Adora and this is the way they have always loved each other. With understanding and patience and reverence. Adora hums under her breath, rocking Catra infinitesimally slow in her arms. Her soft voice lulls her and Catra can feel the sleep calling for her once more.

"You are the strongest person I know", whispers Adora next to her ear, kissing longingly and softly there. Catra holds her closer to herself, feeling her eyelids heavy, starting to close without her permission. She can feel Adora's hand on her shoulders, the other in the base of her baby bump and waist, their lips on her forehead. "I love you so much, I love them so much."

Catra can feel herself slipping again, white light still enveloping them completely. She clings to Adora as hard as she can, the beating on their heart drumming right below their ear, the most beautiful sound Catra has ever heard.

"Sleep" Adora's voice rings like a bell, just one more time. Catra lets her eyes close completely and the white light goes with her.

The second time Catra opens her eyes she can see the snow falling through the crystals of the closed windows. There are just a few candles and the fireplace lit, illuminating the chamber in amber light. It's so dark outside because of the storm that she can't tell if it is day or night. She rests on her side, her right arm thrown over the mattress, hand clasping the fabric of Adora's pillow. Their side is cold, empty without Adora there, though the smell of oranges still lives in Catra's nose, real and present. Catra sighs, a bit watery, opening and closing her fist over the pillows a few times until she feels brave enough to shift and look around.

She is in her room in Camelot, tucked under the blankets of her bed. Glimmer is asleep horizontally on the foot of the mattress, hair in disarray and one arm crooked in an odd angle over her head after moving around in her sleep. One of her wings is extended towards Catra, covering halfway like a feathered blanket. Melog is also asleep, stretched between Catra's legs and Glimmer's face. Their magic mane flickers in pink and purple.

There is a soft sound on her side, Bow appearing on her camp of vision. He isn't wearing boots or sockets and there are purple bags under his eyes just like everyone else. Catra helps herself up, resting hers and the baby's weight over her arms and hands, pushing herself into a sitting position as Bow comes closer to the bed. Glimmer doesn't even twitch.

"Good morning", whispers Bow, offering to Catra a cup with a warm, steaming liquid on it. "It's milk with honey. It will help you".

Catra accepts the cup without a word, resting her back on the headboard of the bed as she gives it a sip. It's nice and sweet and it calms the cold inside of Catra's heart just a little. She exhales, circling the rim of the cup with the pad of her finger.

"Thank you", she whispers. Her voice is raspy and it hurts in her throat so she keeps drinking the milk until it is done.

Bow's eyes are soft when he sees her and he lets himself fall into the chair next to bed with a long sigh, running his hand over the tight curls of his head. He looks exhausted beyond measure and his hands are trembling without him being able to stop it, even when the chamber is wonderfully warm. Catra looks at him in silence, keeping the cup between her hands to absorb as much of its warmth as she can. Outside, the storm whips against the castle with fury, heavy wind crashing against the roof of the tower viciously.

"What time is it?" murmurs Catra, picking at the loose threads of the blankets. Bow leans forward, resting his forearms on his knees. He pets very gently at Melog's fur, careful not to wake them up.

"Around three in the morning". He looks at the snow, a frown deeply carved on his eyebrows. Catras has never seen him this serious, not even when the Battle of Thaymor happened. His

entire aura is pulled tense and tired, even as he tries as hard as possible to be calm and collected around them. Catra knows the feeling.

"Did you have any sleep at all?", she questions him.

The three of them had found sleep until very late in the night, after more numerous and failed attempts to contact Halfmoon at all, like every night for the last two weeks. Catra had kept it together for the most part but by the end of the night she was angry and desperate, lashing at their friends and slamming the magic scrolls into the ground viciously. Some of them had even caught on fire, saved only by the quick water spells of Glimmer. Anyone would have slipped away from her, wary of her rage. But not Glimmer and Bow, they stayed there, ignoring Catra's hisses and menacing scowls. Glimmer had cooed her into the bed, aware of the way Catra's eyes watered with each growl and how her hands trembled on her sides. She didn't even dare to look at the roses in the balcony, she knew what they would find. So they had stayed, stubbornly, for the last two weeks of wait and distress. They couldn't bear anymore to see Catra passing around the palace alone at unholy hours of the night.

"A little", he answers, coming now to brush some errand hairs away from Glimmer's face. She is snoring lightly, tearing a small smile from both Bow and Catra. Bow turns to Catra, studying her face gently. "Did you?"

Catra looks back at his deep eyes and then at the fireplace, looking at the flames dance and shift over the logs on wood. "Yeah, something"

Here is the thing. Catra does remember. But she has seen Adora so many times inside her dreams lately she doesn't know how to differentiate what is real from what is just a hopeful desire, another desperate dream. She sees the fire consuming the logs, breaking little branches in two, snapping and crackling with mute sounds. She can still feel the warmth on her back and hands, slowly slipping away from her grasp as much as the dream did. She can still smell the roses and the oranges and hear the soft breath around her, like a promise, like a shield.

Bow contemplates her in silence, respectful of her being lost in thought. It hasn't been the first time they had seen her like this in those two weeks and until they have an answer, it won't be the last. Catra returns to herself at slow pace, blinking quickly a couple of times to chase the tears away. She leans to the side, leaving the empty and now cold cup on the table next to the bed, flopping right back into the soft pillows after. She is a king. A queen, a commander, a regent. She is strong and smart and unyielding. But right now, inside this chamber, she is also Catra. Only Catra. A friend and a lover and a mother. Right now, at dawn on a stormy day, she can be just this for one second. Just one second of mourning, and wishing and waiting.

Bow extends his hand towards her, not touching her as to not startle her, just resting it next to her gently. "Catra, you know Adora, you know how strong and hot headed he is. He is probably already marching his way here as we speak and I know that. We all do".

"Do we?", Catra shuffles in the blankets, resting both of her hands over her belly. The baby seems to feel her distress, because they stir and move, kicking softly on the point where her palms connect with the bump. She can feel them sleepy inside of her, curling lightly to their

other side, their little head in the direction of their mother's ribs. Catra smoothers their little kicks with her fingers, breathing deep to calm back down her raising heartbeat and not disturb her baby's peace. Once she feels them lull back into sleep, Catra turns back to Bow, her dark eyebrows knitted together and eyes sharp. "Do we, Beauregard?"

"Catra-"

"It's been two weeks, Bow. Two weeks of waiting and wishing and staying behind and there is nothing. Nothing. Not a letter, not a message, not a smoke signal. Anything at all. You all keep telling me to stay here and wait but I'm so fucking tired of sitting here doing nothing while Adora is out there, missing or wounded or, or-", Catra cuts herself short, panting lightly as she tries to keep her voice low enough to not wake up neither Glimmer or her baby. There are tears in her eyes again and she wipes them off almost violently with the back of her hand, snarling at the few that have managed to slip down. Bow waits for her, exhaling heavily. Catra can see the way his jaw is clenched tightly and his shoulders are tense and she remembers she is not the only one suffering for this. It doesn't make it easier but it makes her feel less alone. "Halfmoon is gone, Bow"

"-you don't know that"

"I do"

Their eyes battle for a second, amber and turquoise against onyx. She can see the way his posture flops forward and his face pales. Catra knows her kingdom is gone, she felt it in her bones, just as she felt the most horrid of shivers, just as she knew Adora was in danger. Catra knows. Adora is her soul after all. And Catra also knows Bow doesn't understand it, that he could never experience what Catra's soul feels right now, but he does seem to believe her. And that is important, that's something.

"I understand what you are feeling. But Catra, you mustn't go out there", Bow's voice is as gentle as his eyes, almost pleading as he speaks.

"Why not", spits out Catra, frustrated and overwhelmed. "I'm not a damn porcelain. I could kill everybody who dared crossed my way, I *would* kill everyone who even tries to keep Adora away"

Bow sighs, not even unfazed by Catra's statement. He knows it's true that Catra would do anything to bring Adora back home, destroy any monster and army and dictator, trade her very soul, go to the very ends of the world. But that's not the point.

"Because you are having a baby, Catra" he says, still calm but firm. Catra's ears flicker and press down her sides, holding onto her baby bump with slightly more urgency. Bow's eyes soften at the edges. "I don't think Adora would ever forgive any of us if we let you both go through that risk. I know you and Adora didn't have the time to talk about it properly before they left, or to even bask on the bliss of having a baby together. But I do know that she knows, and I do know that she would rather throw herself to the pits of hell before letting anything happen to you or the baby. You two are her most important priority. You two are her whole life "

Catra's bottom lip wobbles and she has to snap her head away from him and the fireplace's light so as to not start weeping again. Bow frunces his lips, leaning a little forward to place a calming hand over her shoulder. Catra doesn't startle, she sees him coming, but she does turn her head just a bit in his direction, watching the rise and fall of Melog's little chest as they sleep.

"The squadron we sent to Halfmoon is meant to return any time now. I'm sure they'll have news", Bow squeezes gently, eyes holding hers firm and grounded. "Adora is the most stubborn person I know. Nothing could keep her away from you".

Catra wants to lash out again, growl and tear the bed apart with her claws. But she is also exhausted and tender everywhere, and above, Catra won't do anything that threatens her baby's safety. Bow is right on that too. She lets herself fall deeper inside the mush pillows, looking up and at the enchanted ceiling. The constellations swirl and move in slow tandem as the night falls in, twinkling over her head as if a storm wasn't crashing against the world just outside her window. Bow leans back into the chair, allowing her to snuggle back inside the bed with hooded eyes. He also looks as if he were to fall asleep any minute now. On the other side of the bed, Glimmer shifts and rolls over, cuddling Melog next to her neck as she mumbles unintelligible words.

Catra looks at her friends under the dim, soft light, heartbeat on her throat and sleep on her eyelids. She doesn't want to go back to sleep, she doesn't want to close her eyes and see Adora bright and warm and too far away from them. So she stays looking at the stars for a while more until she can hear Bow starting to snore softly. Inside her, her peanut kicks gently on their sleep, so tiny and already sleep fighting. Catra turns in her side and curls around her bump, sighing heavily as she allows her eyes to fall close again. In a few hours she will have to get up again, clean her face, brush her hair and be a King and a commander and a Queen and everything in between.

"You are the strongest person I know", had said Adora inside her dream. She just hopes it's enough.

❀

It's at noon on that very same day that it happens. Catra is in the King's office going through official papers, scribbling in elegant letters before signing with Adora's royal seal and passing to the next one. Her hair is braided today, the entire dark mass kept away from her face in gentle knots and laces that fall over one of her shoulders. She wears comfortable pants that wrap her belly steady and the long red coat that belongs to Adora and that still smells faintly like them. She likes wearing it, it grounds her down and it makes the baby calm. Her spine is straight and regal, perfect posture never waving as she continues working on the never resting job that is being the regent of a kingdom. Catra is aware of the dark bags under her eyes and the muted bright of her eyes but this is the best she can do right now and honestly, it's the most any other would do in her position. She grew tired rather quickly of the pitiful looks in Camelot's people's eyes every time she walked by. She is still a queen and a king until Adora returns and Catra has done a very good job of reminding everyone of that by being the greatest regent Camelot had ever seen, even in those critical times.

She is going through the second dozen of scrolls on the desk, hand a little bit cramped from all the writing. Melog is curled on her lap, their almost liquid black body flexing around the bump as they purr gently towards the baby, their tail swishing up and down in content each few seconds. There is a swift commotion down in the town. Catra's ears catch the faint sound seconds before the town's bells start resonating loudly and almost violently in the entire kingdom.

Catra is on her feet immediately, knocking off the vials with ink in her way. Melog jumps off her at the same time, paws avoiding the black sticky mess on the carpet, their back is raised in goosebumps as they walk from side to side of the chamber, meowing loud and distressed. Catra doesn't even stop to look at the window or to wait for any knight or guard to call for her, she bursts out of the chamber in quick steps barely holding back to crawling over the walls. The little peanut feels their mother's sudden jolt because they stirr in their little secure space and kick swiftly in the low of Catra's abdomen, as if they were asking something.

"They're back, they're back, they're back", Catra repeats again and again as she navigates the weirdly empty hallways of the castle, rubbing her hand up and down the spot her baby is pressing into.

Catra reaches the main gate in record time, walking out and into the yard with her heart held in her hand. However, there is nobody there. Not a single soul waiting, nor soldier, magician or simple villager. The yard is quiet only broken by the sound of the winter air flopping the Camelot and Halfmoon standards over the buildings. Catra chokes in her break, looking everywhere without finding anything of help. She steps back inside, stomach curling nauseously against itself. Catra walks with determined steps to the throne room, her hands balled into fists so tight her own nails prickle at the skin of her palms and scratch lightly over them. Melog walks behind her in silent steps, their mane turning as black as the depths of the ocean. Everything in Catra is vibrating right now, her own magic aura pulsing out of her in waves that make the windows shake lightly.

The throne room is also empty when she reaches it, no sign of anyone in there except for a few abandoned scrolls and chairs knocked around, as if the people there had walked out in a rush. Catra can feel dread start dripping down her spine, her ears perking up to catch any sound just to flop back to the sides of her head. She stands there for a few minutes until a rush of air comes from the side door of the chamber, accompanied by the rushed steps of people sprinting through the corridor and into the banquet hall. Catra chases after them, legs tangling in the length of Adora's coat as she steps outside of the chamber. She can see the skirts of the maidens disappearing on the banquet' chamber, their voices low enough to be just a whisper barely audible over the sound of silence. Catra holds her breath as she walks over and steps into the chamber. Actually, all of Camelot is holding its breath right now, waiting respectfully for news.

The first thing Catra sees is that the banquet tables have been pulled away and the windows are covered with long white curtains guarding the insides from the sound of the wind and the weak light that had come through after the snowstorm died down. Alongside the entire expanse of the huge chamber, metal beds with mattresses and muted colored blankets have been placed one after the other in organized roads. Magicats, etherians and first ones are resting on them, battered in dust and scratches with their hairs wet from the melted snow

once they entered the heated room. In the beds closer to her there are a myriad of physicians and sorceresses, hovering over the survivors as they tend to minor wounds and sore limbs. Some of them turn to see Catra standing there, frozen in place. The magicats' eyes are big and sad and exhausted but still light up when they see their queen, low murmurs picking up as they take on her presence.

Catra feels cold everywhere as she looks at them, the confirmation of her fallen home washed over her as announced winter rain. Catra inhales deeply, trying to compose herself in front of her people. She knows she should be walking towards them right now, kneeling to check up on them, consoling them, assuring them justice will come for their lost home. But her mind is in overdrive and is fixated on one single selfish thought: finding Adora. Catra looks around again and again, searching desperately between the rows of beds and people. Knowing Adora they must be with the wounded, taking care of their wounded as they help the physicians, jeopardizing their own well being to help others first. They are always like this. But Catra can't wait to find them among all these people, shake their shoulders, scowl. them for being reckless and selfless. Hold them close against her chest, her tail lashing against their calf. She wants to take their big hands and press them in her belly, make them feel their baby kicking joyfully against their calloused palms while she kisses them. Life is hell right now and their world is falling apart but as long as Catra can have Adora by her side, she knows everything will be alright.

Glimmer walks around a few beds on the southeast side of the chamber, resolute steps as she drives closer and closer to her friend. Her hair is a wreck, free from the usual neat style it's always on, falling in picky curves around her lovely face. Her face is broken with worry and sadness, the makeup around her eyes smudged after wiping her face with her hand, lips pressed until they turn white. The sight makes Catra's heart constrict painfully in her chest and she gives an involuntary step back when Glimmer reaches her, partially hiding in the long curtains next to the gate. Glimmer's eyes flash painfully when she sees this and she gulps a few times to hydrate her dry throat before speaking.

"Catra-"

“Survivors from Halfmoon, isn't it? Why wasn’t I informed of this immediately?”, cuts her off Catra, fighting to keep her shaky voice calm.

Glimmer's eyes grow somehow sadder and she looks behind her swiftly before turning back to Catra. Her hands are partially lifted in the air, a half assed calming motion that Catra dismisses completely. Fear is starting to get the best of her and she can't allow it. From the other corner of the chamber, Bow spots them too and walks in long steps towards the friends. His face is as broken as Glimmer's.

“Catra, listen to me darling”

“Where is Adora? Is she injured?”, Catra snaps her head away from Glimmer, ignoring Bow arriving too as she scans the room once more. She is aware more people have turned to look at them and that all of their eyes are defeated and grieving. She can't stand it. "Why hasn't she come to greet me? She wouldn't do that"

“Catra”, Glimmer's voice breaks and she has to press her fist against her mouth to avoid breaking into tears. Bow wraps an arm around her, squeezing her shoulder while he looks at Catra's face. The rim of his eyes are red and sore.

"Catra, just come with us for a minute alright? Just a minute". Catra looks at them in silence, hands opening and closing at her sides. Around her the small stones in the floor start to tremble lightly, outside the skies break open and lightning strikes the earth viciously. Glimmer and Bow flinch at the sound but Catra doesn't move a millimeter. Instead she scowls, hissing low in her throat as she tries to step into the chamber.

“Let me pass”. Glimmer blocks her path immediately, extending her shaky arms to the sides as she shakes her head weakly. Catra snarls at her, long and sharp nails unfolding without realizing it. “Glimmer, what the fuck is wrong with you? Let me pass”

“Catra”, Glimmer denies her, shaking her head resolutely. “No”

Catra is shaking.

“I’m sorry Catra, I’m so sorry”

Her body is spasming on itself so bad her teeth clank together rhythmically, fangs catching on her lip and breaking the fragile skin there. Jolts of adrenaline traveling down her arms and legs without her permission. Spots of black overwhelm her sight and she has to grab into something to avoid her knees to bend down and into the ground. She feels numb. Far away from the world around her, as if she was submerged underwater. There is a rush on her ears and a knot in her throat. She can't even feel her lungs filling with air or the same leaving her body in exhales. There is just nothing. Absently, Catra feels Glimmer taking both her hands between hers. Can feel herself being gently pulled from the chamber and into the hallway, away from the pitiful looks of her people around her.

She is aware Glimmer and Bow are talking to her, rushed words that fall one over the other, like waves crashing against the rocks loudly and at the same time unintelligible. Catra looks at the side, outside the tinted glass of the windows. It's snowing heavily again, by night the entire kingdom will be covered in pearlescent white. She drags a hand from Glimmer's hand and presses it against her heart, but she can't feel her heart in there.

Adora is not there. She is not in the chamber or in the yard or in the castle. It's confusing because Adora is supposed to be there. They are supposed to sprint over the stones of the floor at their feet and reach Catra with their arms open and swing her gently in the air. They are supposed to kiss her and kneel on the floor as they always do because there won't be a day when Adora doesn't fall to their knees for Catra, pressing their ear in Catra's soft bump as they smile, maybe tired and scratched over and deflated but happy, happy. Happy. Is confusing and unfair. It 's so unfair. Adora is not there and she hasn't seen their baby grow in her love outside those precious now far away early months. She hasn't helped Catra walk around or read to the baby outloud or curled around both of them in their sleep. She hasn't even heard their hummingbird heartbeat or feel their tiny, tiny feet against her palms and cheeks and lips. It's so unfair because they didn't even get the chance, it was ripped off before they could even start. It's unfair because Catra hasn't been able to look at her in the eyes and tell her, the words and joy spilling from her mouth like blessings. *Here we are,* she was

supposed to say, *here we are. We are starting a family. Here I am. Here you are. You are never going to be alone again. You're going to be loved every day for the rest of your days,* Catra was supposed to tell her. It's unfair because after everything that has happened, the highs and the lows, the stolen kisses, the sharp looks, the shared moans, the smart schemes, the holds at the dead of night. The way Adora melts under Catra's firm touch and the way Adora touches Catra almost reverently, even when they are surrounded by heat and sweat and heavy words and humid shared air, as if Catra was a goddess and Adora just another mortal brought to their feet for her. After all of that Catra hasn't told her that she loves her. Not like Catra craved to. Not like she was too afraid to. Not like Adora deserved to, even if she insisted day after day, *I don't need the words, I know them, I feel them, I have them.* And Catra would scowl to herself and try to tamper her fears and guilt down, as if the life growing inside of Catra wasn't enough proof of their unyielding love for each other. And now time is over, their clock is broken, and Catra is standing in a hallway with her fears and her love and her promises and her courage pressed close inside of her closed lips. And suddenly she is her own mother, standing in her hidden kingdom, grieving. And Catra knows, and understands. And it's worthy, all the beautiful days and weeks and months and years together, it's worthy because Adora is worthy. And still is not fair.

Why do they always have to lose each other?

There is a small commotion from inside the chamber and out storms Scorpia, tripping with her own feet as she walks into the hallway. Her pants are ripped at the knees, arms scratched and bruised all over. There are smudges of mud and dirt over her face and she looks pale and sick. Even her hair is a mess, short white strands tousled on all sides or sticky and plastered against her skull. She spots Catra in the corridor, still held by Glimmer's and Bow's ready hands, and she walks towards them as quick as she can, a limp on her walk every time she takes a step. There is something on her pincers, red and knotted over that Catra can't make form of because she is still deep into that numb mist and water that is her heart right now.

"Catra-", says Scorpia once she reaches her, her voice hoarse and broken. She seems to take on Catra's figure for the first time because her dark eyes widen, filling with immediate tears once she realizes. "Oh, *oh.* Oh, Wildcat, I'm so sorry. I didn't know. I wouldn't-I didn't. I'm sorry"

"What happened, Scorpia?", blurts out Catra. Her voice sounds strange, foreign to her own ears, gone far away from her and wherever Adora is. Scorpia flinches lightly at her tone, her shoulders shirking on her own body as she looks at the ground.

"The- the barriers of Halfmoon were done. The Horde invaded us so far and we didn't even have time to react" Scorpia chokes on her breath, tears threatening to fall free down her cheeks. "Adora saved us, they saved so many of us, but they-they-"

Scorpia's voice quivers and dies down, her head shaking defeated to chase away the tears. She extends her pincers forward, holding up the red package and handing it to Catra. She takes it mechanically and up close, discovers its actually Adora’s red cape, burnt in places and ripped in others the Pendragon' shield embroidered in one of the corners stained with dark ash and mid. The fabric is wrapped tightly around something and Catra untangles it slowly, almost reverently, revealing piece by piece the blue surface of a blade, the golden

runes snapped in half, the smashed stone that looks like Adora's eyes and finally the gold handle of Excalibur, resting in broken pieces over Catra's steady, cold hands.

"Is this a joke?", Catra looks up from the broken sword, reality washing over her step by step, pulling her back into the present violently and without mercy. When Scorpia pales even further Catra inhales deeply, pressing the pieces closer to her. "Excalibur can't break"

Scorpia hesitates, looking at Glimmer and Bow for help but they look as lost and grieving as she does, holding each other as they try to bite back tears for Catra's sake. Scorpia returns her eyes to her friend, who clunches the handle of Excalibur until her knuckles turn pink with her strength.

"I- she went back. We were in the woods but Adora went back to look for survivors and I-" Scorpia struggles with her words, unknowing how to keep going without breaking her friend's heart, "I came back, after the fire died down. She said that she would meet us here but I just had to come back. And I searched everywhere, on every building and canal but there was no one there" Catra is not looking at her anymore, sight firm in her reflection against the broken sword. "I thought she might have used the arcane circle to return here but when I got to the hill-it was destroyed. The earth was crushed and there were stones everywhere, even the grass burned out. And I- I found the sword's pieces broken around the remains of the circle. It looked like she stabbed the circle for some reason. But I, oh Catra"

Catra closes her eyes for a second, recreating the image in her mind with each of Scorpia's words. She can see them, the broken floors, the vibrant plants crisped and torn, the arcane circle cracked in the middle by the powerful hit of an enchanted sword. The silence heavy, the ragged remains of a red cape in an empty space where her heart used to beat. Catra can see it all.

"Why were the barriers down, Scorpia?". Catra's voice is still empty, calm before the storm, lightning and earthquakes in her soul. She runs her thumb over the runes carved in the smooth surface of Excalibur, fingers wrapped around the cold handle, seeking Adora's warmth in there.

"I- I don't know. I don't know Catra" Scorpia is now openly crying, cleaning her cheeks off the tears gently with her pincers. "I'm so sorry. I didn't know. I didn't know- you are having a baby, wildcat. I had no idea. I would have never let her go back if I had"

"Of course you didn't know" Catra frowns, still looking down, mind reaching finally "It was our secret, mine and Adora's. Before it was everyone else's, it was ours"

Catra's hands lower down, the pieces of the sword falling into the floor with a loud sound. Only the handle remains grasped on Catra's right hand and she spins in place towards a whipping Glimmer. Catra's face is terrible, green over the usual bright tone of her skin, eyes frantic and harsh, ears perked up in alert, dark bags under her beautiful eyes. And yet, the last are dry, no tears welling there or threatening to fall into the world. Catra is not crying.

"Glimmer, listen to me. She is not dead. Adora isn't dead. Something happened, I don't know what but she is somewhere out there. We just need to go find her" Glimmer's eyes grown even sadder and she grips Catra's free hand with hers, trying to calm her down.

"Catra- Catra even if that's true, if Shadow Weaver has them I don't- I don't know how we could even get them back. I don't know if we can". Glimmer gulps trying to escape the way Catra's eyes harden and her hand starts to tremble, sling growing clammy and cold with sweat. "My parents plan- Catra without Adora we can't do anything. We can't face the Horde like this, *you* can't face the Horde like this. I- I loved Adora too, we all did. And we love you, Catra. I can't let you hurt yourself trying to do this"

"I'm not *trying* anything . Adora is alive and she is out there. She is lost out there, somewhere, and we need to find her because she needs to be here".

Catra's tone starts to escalate, higher and more frantic and also angrier. She is frustrated. Why doesn't Glimmer her? Catra knows she is right, she knows Adora is out there and she knows they are alive. She can feel it, in the boil of her blood and the burnt air in her lungs. In the sparkle in her belly and the light curious kicks of her baby. She can feel it in the depths of her soul, something so old, so ancient, it has lived in there for a thousand different lives and will be for a thousand more. In the fact that Adora is not only the love of her life but also the other half of her soul and that they live in Catra as much as Catra lives in them. So she knows. Adora is alive and away and they need to come home to them, they need to be guided back. And yet, and yet, Glimmer is looking at her with that expression that is both merciful and frustrated, pitiful and worried. Catra wants to scream.

“Catra, sweetie-”

"Stop talking to me like that!"

There is a shift in the air, a sudden crisp of energy that rises from the very earth below them and the world all around the four friends reduces to a pinpoint, wrapped in silence until it explodes like hundreds of firecrackers in the night. Outside the day transforms into night, the oranges of the sunset drowned in pitch black, starless and moonless. Not even the breeze against the tree branches nor the soft sing of the birds can be heard anymore.

Glimmer, Bow and Scorpia gasp, stepping back a few feet. Catra's hands bowl into fists at her sides, the veins in the exposed skin of her hands, neck and face lightening in a bright purple glow, as if she was glowing from the inside out, her body surrounded by stardust, pieces of constellations powdered and sprinkled against her. Nebulas and supernovas in her hands. Catra's eyes flash like fire and ice, shimmering in her face as if both the sun and the moon had decided to make their home inside her raged eyes. Her aura vibrates around her, palpably and almost visible, coming out of her in waves of powerful magic. Catra's soft silky hair frees itself from her braid, leather bands snapping in two, waves of dark rocked by non-existent air. She is a cataclysm, an earthquake, a typhoon. Fire rains over dry hay, snow storms against a frozen lake. Catra is a force of nature, powerful, untamed, violent, gentle, magical. She is ferocious and giving. She is letal. Everything in her screams royalty, it always does, a queen, an empress and king, but this is different this is more. She is not a regent with a crown anymore, she has never been only that, she is magic itself, born in the ancestors' old home, blood of legendary blood. Love and life of the golden dragon, King of the Pendragons. The very soul of the Heart of Etheria.

The stone floor cracks in two, long rashes of magic breaking the rocks like damp paper. From the empty spaces, long crooked branches are born out of nothing, twisting and knotting on

themselves, their blue and purple woods creating a small forest inside the corridor. All the glasses in the windows vibrate and explode, sharp tinted pieces turning into sand as they touch the floor where they shift and transform into natural shaped crystals, rising from the limits of the corridors in odd directions, crawling over the floor and walls and ceilings. The entire castle shakes and when the trembles die down, the corridor leading to the banquet hall has transformed completely, looking like the insides of a kaleidoscope, vibrating and bright and chaotic.

Catra is panting, her magic vibrating a couple of seconds more before subduing and returning slowly and torturous back into her own body. She has broken a cold sweat over her forehead, sticking strands of hair to her skin. The insides of her lake eyes still twinkle, rushes and swirls of magic still making carnivals inside of them. She hasn't let go of Excalibur's handle, not even for a second. In fact, she cradles the broken piece close to her chest, finger gripping at the sharp edges and yet it never cuts her or harms her. As of Excalibur itself was simply denying to hurt her in any way.

Glimmer, Scorpia and Bow look at her with mouths agape, taking in the sudden burst of magic still pulsing strong across the entire castle. Not only that, people from inside the banquet hall have peeked outside the chamber, looking at the corridor with marvelous and slightly taken aback eyes. It’s beautiful and terrifying at the same time. No one had been witness of Catra’s true magic, not until now, nor have they seen even a third of its true reach.

Catra steps back, inhaling deeply and sharply, her face falling from frantic and overwhelmingly sad into a stoic, calculating expression before turning in her heels and walking purposely down the corridor, not once looking back. Her steps are quiet over the scrambled stones, avoiding the branches and crystals almost as if they weren’t even there. The golden rings clasped in her tail and ears jingle gently, following her until she reaches the corner of the corridor and disappears at the turn, Adora’s red coat still wrapped around her shoulders. She is visibly shivering, even from so far away, but her spine is straight and proud, raising thoughts crossing her mind. Melog follows her immediately, meowing concerned as they jump over the natural formations scattered around. Their mane is a deep shade of blue and red, looking almost black under the shadows of the corridor.

“Wildcat- " calls Scorpia, extending a hand towards her gone figure. Glimmer steps in too, placing a calming hand over Scorpia’s big pincer and shaking her head.

“Let her go”, Glimmer looks at the destroyed and put-together-again corridor, the glimmering of the crystals and the thick branches. And then looks at the floor at the flowers that had bloomed below Catra's feet just to rot a second later. Glimmer's heart is broken, she can barely start to wrap her mind around the fact that her best friend might be truly gone. That Halfmoon *is* gone. Everything they’ve been fighting to protect for the last almost two years. Innocent people, memories, history. Adora. All lost at the hands of the woman Catra hates and fears the most. She can’t even begin to imagine what is going inside Catra’s heart right now. They can only be there to catch her when it weighs her down. “Let her go. She is suffering.”

Scorpia shifts on her feet, bending so she can pick the fallen pieces of Excalibur and Adora's red cape. Bow wipes his face with the palm of his hand and his voice comes as a raspy

whisper. "What do we do now?"

"We help", states Glimmer, grabbing the skirt of her dress between her fists. Her mind is in overdrive, probably the only reason she isn't breaking down too. "We help her. She is going to need us" Glimmer sighs, watery, turning towards where husband and the open gate of the chamber where more magicats' have gathered, their heads bend down in shared grief. "We promised it to Adora, let's make good of that"



"Serenia!"

Catra yells at the top of her lungs, standing at the edge of the enchanted lake. She had sprinted down the castle, past the bended strange underground corridors and over the rocks of the narrow cavern's entrance. The strange waves of the lake lick the bare soles of her feet reverently, neon blue against the black earth below. Catra tries to walk inside the lake, submerge herself down the surface of water and scream, trash and snarl and claw until the waters hear her cry and bring her love back. But there is a magic barrier around it, soft but strong, impeding Catra from walking more than a few inches away from the shore.

"Serenia, answer me!". Yells again Catra almost ripping her vocal cords apart with the strength of her mourn. The surface remains unbothered, silence heavy on the blue cavern and constricting Catra's lungs. Melog is behind her, their main and all the fur on their back frizzed on point, scowling slightly at the water. Catra gasps, watery, and growls kicking the water with violence

"I am your King!". Nothing. Not even a whisper of a murmur or a bubble. Catra and Melog stand alone in that place that once felt so magic and now feels like a tomb. Catra can't relent, can't give up. This is half of her soul, she won't give up now or never.

"Serenia, please". Catra doesn't plead, she never does, but she is now desperate and alone and doesn't know what to do. Her feet dig into the earth, soft and damp, caverns of cold against her toes. Nothing grows there, not even the smallest of the plants. "Just tell me where she is"

The lake leaps gently at her feet, quiet. Catra can only hear the raggedness of her breath and the harsh beat of her heart against her ribs. Over her head, in Camelot, the world is quiet. The bells of the towers sing sadly, news of the King lost in the war spreading across the entire kingdom quickly. And then the lake shimmers for a second and its smooth surface breaks, Serenia's hair and face appearing through it like a spectre. Her hair is damp and heavy, falling over the water in waves. Her beautiful light blue face is sad, melancholic, the grief of Camelot's people weighing heavy over her. She stands over the water looking at Catra with careful, apologetic eyes, all the apologies and then sad drops of tears pooled in them.

" *King C'yra* "

"Did you know?". Catra grinds her teeth together, fangs catching in her tongue so hard she tastes the copper and salt of her mouth. Behind her, Melog's mane flashes red and they hiss, backtracking behind a couple of rocks. Serenia looks at her in silence. Her eyelashes almost

seem to glow, small pearls stuck under her eyebrows and the bridge of her nose. As the seconds of silence grow, Catra's rage does too and she hisses, voice rising until it echoes across the entire cavern like war trumpets. "Did you know?!"

The water of the lake shivers at the strength of her voice, the edges freezing into thick ice. Serenia doesn't move or acknowledge the sudden drop of temperature but her eyebrows raise up her forehead and she pronounces the words gently and carefully, as if she was talking to a scared dove or a furious lion.

" *Things had to happen for a reason* "

Catra steps back, one of her hands coming to clench the fabric over her heart tightly, nails almost ripping it. Her tails trashes violently across the ground, ears dropping and pressing against her head. When she speaks her voice is shaking uncontrollably, breaking even as it comes as a whisper. "You knew. You knew and you let me send her there"

Catra whimpers, running a hand across her face. Her eyes are dry, her throat sandpaper over her vocal cords. The numb feeling overwhelms her again, her heart breaking into a thousand pieces leaving her breathless. The bracelets on her wrists jinggle against the gold of Excalibur's handle, calling back Catra's attention. She looks at the broken weapon, tongue flat against the back of her teeth, ears rushing as if she were standing in the middle of a hurricane. She turns to the lady of the lake, waving the broken sword with fury in front of her face.

"You said this fucking sword was going to protect her. You said that!"

This time, Serenia does sink a little back into the lake, lips pressing together into a tight line. " *It did"*

"Then why is Adora not here?!" Catra screams at the top of her lungs throwing the sword towards the lake with all her strength. It crashes against the water and breaks the surface with a surprisingly soft splash, sinking right back into the depth of the lake. The caverns shake, debris falling from the ceiling and into the ground. Serenia looks at Catra with sad eyes, never afraid or offended by her anger.

" *It protected Adora when they needed it and then they decided to use it to protect what they love the most"*

An anguish, dry sob rips itself from Catra's throat and she grips the loose strands of her hair, breathing deeply a few times. When she speaks again her voice is raspy, the usual joyful squeak on her tone low and exhausted. She is exhausted.

"Bring her back", Catra says, narrowing her eyes at Serenia.

"I can't do that, King C'yra" . Catra scowls, at the answer or the title, the white of her fangs flashing dangerously.

"You have to. I'm your King, I'm ordering you. You are a ethereal being or whatever the fuck you are, so do it!"

Serenia shakes her head, sinking slowly even further inside the bright blue water and beyond Catra's reach. " *This is destiny, King C'yra* "

"I don't care about destiny! Or duty or obligation or sacrifice! I care for Adora! Bring her back!". Catra tries once again to step into the water but the magic doesn't allow her. It pushes her back with quasi physical strength, water retreating from the edge and into itself. Catra's growl melts into despair and she extends her elegant hand towards Serenia, breathing hard.

"Please, just, please . She is going to be a mom. We are going to have a baby. She hasn't even felt them yet, for fucks sake!"

" *She did* " answers Serenia, for the first time the ghost of a smile dancing in her nebula lips. " *She felt them all the time, King C'yra. She loves them as much as she loves you, that's why she did what she did."*

Catra bites into her lip until teeth break skin, hugging herself while she fights back the thick knot in her throat. She knows it's true, all of it. That's the kind of person Adora has always been, kind and giving above anything else, especially themself. And she knows just how much Adora loves them. They were never afraid or ashamed to let Catra know how deep was their love for her, how much they would do for her. And in the last days and weeks before life tore them apart, Adora already knew what Catra was just finding out. And they were kind and patient and so giving. Loving their child, that little unexpected surprise, with open arms. Adora's heart was always with her, they had left it behind in Catra's hands and in their baby's life.

Catra's ears press even lower in her head, "Just tell me where they are and I'll go. Just that"

" *It's not me who shall answer your questions, King C'yra, I can't break the order of things. I'm not the one who can reach her. You must go through this flow alone* " Serenia sinks all the way up her ears until just her bright blue eyes peek from the surface. The lake keeps freezing, mist raising out of it as the cold worsen. " *I'm sorry, C'yra"*

And then she is gone, back to whatever place she disappears into, leaving only the completely frozen lake behind. Melog walks towards Catra, nuzzling on her legs as they meow sadly at her. Their mane has turned again now a deep blue against the black of their fur. Catra is shivering, looking at the lake with a void expression on her beautiful eyes. She exhales, eyes still dry, heart trembling painful inside her ribcage. Back in the village, the bells resonate across the kingdom. The world turns around and Catra sinks into her knees with a hoarse sigh.

✾

Catra stands alone in the middle of the throne room.

It 's quiet.

Her magic is a trumule, bursting in small sparks that bloom flowers on the floor just to rot a second later. Her black robes tangle on her legs as she paces restlessly on the stone floor. She

isn't supposed to be wearing black. She doesn't wear black. Why is she wearing black. Black is for mourning, for loss. Catra hasn't lost Adora, they ripped them from her embrace, selfish beings using them as a tool, a machine, an unapproachable goddess made for war and legendaries destiny. Adora is nothing of that. They are a friend and a lover and a mother. And the greatest person Catra has ever meet. That's who Adora truly is. And they are lost but not gone. So, why is Catra wearing black.

There is a rumble in her throat, scratching it with force, tearing it apart from the base of her tongue to the depths of her lungs. It feels as strong as the life that grows inside of her.

The weather outside is a disaster, sharp and violent lightning crashing against the far mountains, snow spiraling and covering the entire castle in pristine white, the wind whipping against the stones like a furious animal or a broken heart. The castle is submerged in darkness, dim candles barely illuminating the chambers. Night has fallen over Camelot, being for the natural course of time or because the winter sun got eaten alive by storm clouds. Whatever it is, the people have retreated inside their chambers, their houses, their refugees. Maids, kitchen and castle staff, guards, knights, soldiers. Villagers, royalty. Magicats, etherians and first ones. Everyone grieves. No one grieves like Catra.

She looks at the twin thrones, looks at the thick deep blue coat draped over one of them. Is the same coat Adora used the day they got married for the first time, with the embroidered sleeves and the thock, warm fabric. Catra reaches for it, holding it between her trembling hands. She presses the fabric into her tear stained face, inhaling deeply. It still smells like Adora, oranges and leather and lovely touches.

She doesn't know when she started crying. Somewhere between the then and now and the cracks in her heart, the tears finally, *finally,* pooled in her eyes and down her cheeks and jaw, heavy drops forming spots over her clothes and the stones in the ground. Her cry had been silent until now, no sobs or whimpers or trembles.

But the rumble travels up, up, up. From the middle of Catra's heart, over her chest, to her throat and past her lips. It feels like sorrow, like despair. It feels like complete void and emptiness. It feels like nothing.

Catra screams.

❀

The news of Adora and Halfmoon spread over Etheria like wildfire, the rumors sparking an incedium through the world. *Camelot's King has been taken by the Shadow,* they said. *Halfmoon has fallen,* they would whisper in the dead of night. *She-Ra is gone. She-Ra is gone.* And if Shadow Weaver's horrifying doing wasn't a death sentence, it wasn't a good omen either, or less cruel. Nobody could defeat the Shadow and for so, the souls taken just wouldn't come back. The only hope of the Rebellion, of Etheria, to take her and the Horde Empire down, was now gone, lost among the debris of the war.

Adora Pendragon has been lost at the Horde's hands, they would murmur over rancid wine, *Nobody comes back from that, no matter who it is.* There is not a single village, city, town or

kingdom that doesn't learn about it and the grief falls over them all alongside the winter, cold and unmerciful and unfair.

Camelot goes through twelve days of grief, no one is to work or train unless is completely necessary, silence falling over the streets and corners. The survivors of Halfmoon are taken with arms open inside of Camelot, being guarded inside the castle or the refugee buildings, even the houses of the villagers who take them all in. They are all in this together and they are all one and the same, so a helpful hand is never foreign to them.

The snow falls thicker over the kingdoms, burying the fields and the woods in soft white. The provisions Adora had sent from Halfmoon before it's fall arrive just in time before the paths become impossible to cross, a small mercy for the kingdoms after so much loss.

The day after the survivors arrival, Camelot's people organize a procession in Adora's honor. People gather in the empty, freezing streets, with candles in their hands and garlands in their hands, walking side by side towards the gardens of the castle. There had been a similar procession, many years ago, after Mara, and before her after Arthur. This wasn't new for Camelot's people but it was just as sorrowful.

The sky is dark, obscured by the heavy snow clouds over them, biting cold in the air. As the procession walks through Camelot's town, the voices of the people start to hum together, slowly and quiet at first and then higher, louder, a mournful chorus rising between them that reaches every corner of the kingdom and until the last cloud in the sky. Is sweet and harmonious, painful and heavy. Steam is born from the people's breaths as they sing, melting away the small snowflakes still falling from the sky, their steps marking a path over the white ground. Everyone in Camelot is there, making their way together into the yard, crossing the dead flowers of the garden until they reach its center. There, the magicats have raised a stone sculpture, much like the ones that existed in Halfmoon before it's fall. From white marble, Adora's figure standing in the middle of the yard, with their head bent forward and towards their raised, cupped palms, hair falling over their shoulders and back so smooth and detailed it looks almost real but ethereal. The statue's expression is gentle, peaceful, eyes closed and small smile dancing on their lips, a reminder that Adora was kinder than anyone else, a good king, a good friend. A good person.

The people keep singing, holding to each other gently, magicats with first one, some of them rocking to the sides as they hum under their breath, others closing their eyes and bending their heads in respect. The magicats have changed their face paint and clothes to black and the survivors of Halfmoon stand in the front row, growing small flowers at the base of Adora's statue. Lisianthus and gladiolus, scattered across the ground, the only colors against that merciless white.

There is a small pause in the choir and a rush of heads towards the castle and then the singing picks up slowly, as she walks through the snow with heavy steps. Catra crosses the myriad of people in the yard with her head turned upwards, eyes locked in front of her and towards the white statue. Her hair is loose, falling in gentle waves down her back, catching small snowflakes in the tips. Her robes are black, the kind that under the winter light looks like the deepest shade of blue, like a dragon scale under the moonlight. Over her face and hair, falling down her knees and back there is a black veil, thin enough that the people can clearly see her

lovely face, held in place by a golden crown. The winged pin Adora gave her the day they married because they loved each other rests securely over her heart, catching the light of the candles. Her eyes are red rimmed, testimony of a sleepless night full of a thousand tears. There is a paleness on her usually bright face, something that had nothing to do with morning sickness. Something that has everything to do with her past demon, reaching what she holds dearest to her heart, tearing it apart from her hands. Tears like pearls are stuck on her eyelashes and her expression is voided but lovely, pained but still courageous.

Time seems to stop around her and she is beautiful, even in her grief, the Queen and King of Camelot is beautiful

Glimmer and Bow walk beside her, Glimmer's arm crossed with one of hers and Bow's hand pressed lightly on her back. The touches are gentle and respectful, meant to be there as a support and not a prison. The Brightmoon's regents' eyes are also puffy and red, lips turned down with sorrow.

Catra reaches the statue, standing in front of it with firm feet. Glimmer and Bow step forward, leaving two evergreen garlands over Adora's marble hands, stopping just for a second to see their best friend's calm face forever frozen in time. Then they step behind Catra, allowing her a moment. They can see the way her shoulders are shaking and her tail is fuzzed, and they know it's not because of the cold. In fact, they think she might not feel the cold at all.

Catra stares at the statues, treacherous tears falling without her permission down her face and losing themselves in her chin. She reaches for the statue's jaw, brushing her fingers over the smooth marble and gentle curves that form Adora's face. Making a statue for a regent is an old tradition for the magicats, a humble show of respect and admiration. There were statues scattered across the entirety of Halfmoon, statues like this, of old queens and empresses and regent. Catra wonders absently if they survived too. Standing in front of Adora's, she can't find it in herself to think about it any longer.

Catra retreats her hand, bringing it back below the veil and over her belly. She doesn't want to be here. Adora is not dead, that she knows. She doesn't know anything else, nor what happened inside of Halfmoon, nor why the barriers of her kingdom were down, nor who betrayed them there and here. She knows they are in danger, all of them. Knows that there is someone inside the walls of Camelot seeking to destroy them, someone that maybe is responsible for trying to destroy Adora themself. She knows Glimmer and Bow have her back, even if they are suffering too, they are right there behind her. And with all of this knowledge, Catra is only sure of two things. One, her baby is the most important thing in the entire world right now, they are tiny and vulnerable and they need her and she has to be courageous and strong for them. And two, that Adora is not dead. Because if they were, Catra thinks she might just be dead too.

So Catra cries, because of betrayal and frustration and loss. She cries because after so much running and hiding away, her Shadow still found a way to attack her heart. She cries because even if Adora is still alive and somewhere, they are not there and it's not fair. The cry is silent, just drops falling in the frozen grass, rising small stems of green that turn brown a minute after. She has to close her eyes for a moment, inhaling deeply through her nose, cold

burning her lungs, and exhaling just as slowly, a breathing exercise her mothers had taught her when things got too overwhelming to even breathe. Her fingers toy with the winged pin, pads running over the surface again and again. It grounds her enough, just the right amount to keep her raising heart at bay and her magic back underwater. She is a King, the only King both Camelot and Halfmoon have right now. All these people, they trust her, they rely on her, without Adora there Catra is the only beacon of hope they have. And she is a mother too, the tiny life inside her needs her more than anything. That life that is part Catra and part Adora too. She can't lose control right now, not when the reach of her magic could break the world in half. Witness of it is the deep crack that runs across the floor of the throne room, filled with moss and crystal up the columns and the ceilings.

Catra sighs and steps back, allowing like that, for others to pay their respects to the statue. Catra knows the people need this too. Glimmer approaches her immediately, taking one of her hands in hers and warming it with a spark of magic. She hadn't overreacted after the corridor incident, in fact, Glimmer hadn't even mentioned it to Catra. By the time Catra walked past the banquet's corridor that morning, most of the branches and crystals had been slightly cleaned, just enough to be easy and secure to walk down the hallways without tripping on a loose piece of nature.

"Your hands are freezing", whispers Glimmer and her voice is raspy and tired. She lost a friend too. Catra tilts her head to the side, not even feeling the snow fall.

"Adora is alive ", she says, resolution living in her sad eyes. Glimmer sighs, pressing her forehead against the back of Catra's hands.

"I know" Catra blinks, looking at the beautiful statue and the people leaving small flowers over their hands and feet.

"I'm going to find her". Glimmer's eyes widen with worry but not surprise. It's obvious she saw this coming from Catra and yet her face pales and she grasps tighter her hands, shaking her pink and lilac head. Catra opens her mouth to protest but Glimmer interrupts her before she can start talking.

"I can't let you chase after Shadow Weaver, Catra. I just can't. She might actually kill you" Catra grids her teeth together, eyebrows knitting over her forehead. Glimmer's pressure on her hands grows just a tad, just enough to not make her lash away or growl out loud. Glimmer can feel the frustration pulsing through Catra's veins, the way she wants to get out of the kingdom and run across Etheria, looking for Adora under every rock and hollow tree. Marching right into the Horde Empire and the Emperor's claws, demanding to have her spouse back. Glimmer knows what she wants and what she is capable of and that's what scares her to death.

"Please Catra. I promised Adora I would look after you. You and-", Glimmer looks at Catra's belly swiftly before returning her lilac eyes to her face. Her face is tired but her eyes are alive and aflame, the passion that Glimmer feels for protecting her family keeps her up and strong. "I don't want to lose more of my family. Stay here. Allow us to help you, let us take care of both of you. Brightmoon, me and Bow and my parents, we will look for Adora everywhere. And when the time comes, we will look for Adora together"

Catra's first instinct is to refuse. She is hurt and betrayed. Her home is gone. Her love is lost. It's been so much, so sudden, so violent, it takes everything on Catra to not scowl and push her away.

"They are your friends too", had said Adora one night, under the stars of their bedroom, noses pressed together. *"They care about you, they truly do. I know opening your heart to strangers is never easy, but most of the time it is worth it. Give them a chance, just like you gave one to me"*

Now Glimmer is holding her carefully, respectfully, her expression studying hers with care. Something must change of Catra's face because Glimmer's eyes melt and she steps forwards, wrapping her arms around Catra's shoulder lightly, just for a couple of seconds. Over her shoulder, Catra can see Bow, King Micah and Queen Angella standing at the other side of the garden, regarding the statue with sorrowful expressions. Micah's face is just as exhausted as everyone else's, with dark huge bags under his eyes and his hair somehow even more grey than before. The Queen Mother's wings are dropped down and into the floor, iridescent looking white in the winter's light. There is a melancholic expression on her face, something that is mournful but that is also anger. She is angry. She blames herself too.

Both former regents had stayed close to Catra for the last weeks, supporting her quietly, helping on the kingdom's matters when she needed it. They reminded Catra a little of her own mothers in their time and for those long days it helped. But for some moments Catra couldn't help the bitterness that pooled on her tongue, the doubt, if they were there just because they had a plan to take down the Horde and Adora was the master key. If that was the reason for their concern, just like everyone else's throwing Adora to the sides like a weapon to achieve their plans and wishes. Now Catra sees them standing there and she knows that her fears are not true. They are grieving too.

Catra knows she has to stay in Camelot. She has to protect the people here, she has to protect her baby. She can't just wiggle around the kingdom, with shortness of breath and sporadic sickness. After all, Adora gave themself away just so Catra and their baby could be safe. So Catra gulps, biting the tip of her tongue and nods, sinking in Glimmer's arms. Glimmers rubs her hands up and down her upper arms, trying to bring some warm friction into her cold and numb body.

"Have you talked with Scorpia?", Glimmer asks, lips frunced in concern. Catra shakes her head, the veils brushing her face like a gentle feather.

"I can't right now", Catra's voice is strangled, asking for comprehension. "I will, later. Just not right now. But, I want you to tell her this is not her fault. She did what Adora asked her to do, she led our people here. This is the fault of the person that betrayed us. This is Shadow Weaver's fault, she is the one that took everything from me"

"She hasn't taken everything", states Glimmer, holding her firmer against herself. "And when we find that traitor, they are going to pay for everything they have done. I assure you that"

Catra nods again, looking over Glimmer's shoulder. Light Hope is standing in the entrance of the castle, wearing the same clothes and the same expression as always. Her eyes aren't red, her cheeks aren't hollow. The only thing that betrays her stoic figure are her shoulders,

dropped forward and completely different from her usual upright posture. Catra's eyebrows knit together and she wiggles out of Glimmer's embrace, playing her on the back gently.

"I need to speak with Lady Hope for a moment". Glimmer turns to look at her too, the same concerned expression in her face.

"Do you want me to go with you?". Catra shakes her head, smoothing the fabric of her robes with the palms of her hands.

"No. I need to do this on my own" Catra's loose hair floats gently with the breeze, ebony against ivory. "Do you mind asking Sir Juliet and Sir Azrael into the war room? I must speak with them about something"

Glimmer nods, tilting her head to the side in a quizzical look. "For what?"

"I'll explain to you later. Don't tell about this meeting to anyone else " Glimmer nods again and Catra's ears flicker in recognition. Catra starts walking towards the castle before being stopped by Glimmer's quick warm hands. Catra turns to her, eyes tired, elegant eyebrows shot up. There is a kind of urgency in Glimmer's face as she looks at Catra, her cheeks spotted in red patches and eyes shining with a new wave of tears that take Catra by surprise.

"This isn't your fault either, you know that right Catra?", when Catra's ears drop to the sides Glimmer's eyes just become gentler, her grasp is still firm and her voice sure. "Adora loves you more than anything in this world. And the decisions he took, he took them because you and the baby are the most important things in their whole life. I don't think Adora would ever regret doing it and they would never doubt doing it all over again if that meant to keep you both safe. And I don't think he would want you to blame yourself for it."

Catra's eyes burn and her lip trembles with the threat of tears. She can't speak, knot tight inside her throat. Inside of her, her peanut kicks gently, butterfly feet against her side as if comforting their mother's sore heart. Glimmer slips her hand out of Catra's, understanding, expression caring as she keeps smiling reassuringly to her. Catra exhales hoarsely and turns back to the castle, walking around the people gathered in the yard and towards Light Hope. Some villagers and refugees regard her with silent condolences but most of them allow her to pass in respectful distance. There is no doubt of the sadness that pours from their now King. Catra crosses the snowed paths quickly, she can still feel Glimmer's eyes glued on her back, checking on her.

Light Hope blinks when Catra reaches her, never changing her expression or moving from her actual position. Her hands rest one over the other in front of her, the snow melting in the air before even touching her. Catra’s tail flickers in the ground, breeze catching in her dark veil and swinging it lightly. The snowflakes caught in the fabric almost look like tiny stars twinkling over her face. Light Hope looks at Catra stoically, looking up and down her entire figure before bowing slightly forward. She doesn’t even look like she feels cold.

“My condolences, King C’yra”. Light Hope’s voice is distant, calculated, it almost doesn’t sound human. There is no visible expression on her features but something is burning in the back of her eyes. Catra wonders if it’s anger, or sadness. She wonders if Light Hope feels anything at all. She wonders if she blames Catra for Adora’s loss. Light Hope loved Mara and

she helped raise Adora as her own too. Catra feels now as if the precarious bridge she had built between her and the advisor during the last months had burned away and into ashes. As Catra looks closer into Light Hope's eyes, she thinks she can distinguish that hidden expression as despise. It doesn't surprise Catra, but it does hurt.

Catra squares her shoulders, biting back her tears as she looks at the advisor in all her height. When Catra speaks she does it clearly and unfazed, all the guilt and despair she feels right now pooling into her mouth like venom.

"She was trying to protect me. Me and the baby and Camelot. I shouldn't have let her go alone and I'm sorry you have to live through this again, Light Hope" Catra says and somehow her voice doesn't shake or break or tremble. Light Hope doesn't even react to her words except for the slightest twitch in her eyebrows and frunce of her lips but then the slip is gone and she stares at Catra as coldly as ever.

"It seems now I'm not the only one who led their loved one to their perdition"," answers Light Hope and that flash of despise towards Catra just grows. "There is nothing we can do about that now"

Goosebumps travel down Catra's spine, merciless, her entire aura in high alert. For some reason Catra feels inexplicably angry. She has been a complete mess since Adora's disappearance, she is sad and worried and mad, absolutely furious. But now her soul shakes awake for the first time since Adora parted from her arms in that very same yard. It lightens bright as a full moon and a sun eclipse and every star in the sky falling to the ground in meteors of fire and space dust. It's an almost painful jolt. It reminds her that she is alive, that Adora is alive. They live in her soul. Shadow Weaver and everyone could try and take Adora from her embrace but they could never rip them from her soul. Catra will burn down the world just to get them back again.

Catra growls, very low in her throat, so smooth only Light Hope could hear her. And it works because the woman's frozen expression breaks in the edges a little and she steps back for a second, surprised. Catra walks right past Light Hope and back inside the castle. She is cold, she has a kingdom to run, a love to find, a baby to protect. Behind them, Camelot's requiem reaches the skies.

Catra turns her head one last time towards Light Hope, speaking creaky and private, just for the woman's ears before disappearing in proud steps inside her castle.

"We'll see about that"

✾

The fine but strong threads that join their souls form a gentle bridge between them one more time and Catra dreams again that night. She tries not to fall asleep but exhaustion and sadness weighs too heavily on her and she collapses in bed, cocooned by all the blankets and pillows and even some of Adora's clothes, in a makeshift nest.

When she wakes up she is back into that bright white space, that ethereal chamber that feels safe and warm and lovely. Catra can feel the rise and fall of Adora's chest right below her cheek and the puff of warm air ruffling the hairs atop of her head as Adora sleeps peacefully, unaware, alive, *alive* , of the wishful dream around them. Unlike last time, Catra doesn't make any attempt to stand up or move at all. She stays right there, holding herself into Adora's nightwear, surrounded by love and calmness. Their baby is sleeping too, she can feel the butterfly beat of their tiny heart all the way from her belly up her heart and down her very toes. Is such a strong feeling inside her heart, this tiny life inside of her nestled safely and loved between their two mothers.

Catra knows she should be talking to Adora, shaking him by the shoulders, jolting him awake and demanding to know where they are, how can she find them. Screaming, yowling, growling, crying. But Catra doesn't, she allows herself to bask in the golden light that is Adora's love surrounding them, floating atop that gentle yet powerful sea, over the merciful and peaceful waves that drag her from the shore of reality. After all, Catra doesn't even know if this is real. If it's some kind of magic mercy or miracle or just a simple dream called from the deep desires of her beaten up heart.

So Catra nuzzles further in Adora's chest, the top of her head resting over their shoulder. Catra's fine ears catch the soft noises around them. The rush of gentle water somewhere, Adora's rhythmic breathing, her own beating heart. Everything else is peace and quiet and that unwavering white light around them. It makes Catra doze off for a few times, into dreamless sleep inside this dream.

At some point Adora stirs, sighing as they wake up just for a second. They run their blunt nails lightly over Catra's upper arm, their other hand pressing slightly tighter over the round of Catra's belly. Adora tilts their head, ghosting their lips over Catras forehead in a sleepy kiss before exhaling softly again and nudging their cheek over her head. The errand curls atop Catra's hair tickle their nose and Adora giggles softly, smiling against her ear.

Catra blinks slowly, clear mist filling her eyes as she hears the pace of Adora’s heart speed up against her ear. Her hand tightens even further on Adora’s shirt, pinching the fabric between her black nails. She can feel Adora partially more awake, drifting in and out of their own sleep. Catra closes her damp eyes, pressing them closer to Adora’s side.

“Come back”, whispers Catra very, very low against the skin of their neck, where Adora’s natural scent is stronger. Adora hums, running their hands up and down Catra’s body. She can feel the slow tension slipping over their body, the sudden uncomfortable feeling of remembering something is not exactly as it should be. Catra hugs Adora closer to herself, not wanting them to get up or move or do anything that could break this fragile hope. “Why did you do it?”

Adora sighs once more, heavy on their chest, pressing their lips more firmly against her soft forehead. Embraced by Adora this way it almost feels as everything in the world is as it’s supposed to be.

“My sole purpose on this earth has always been to love you. I would give my life for you”

—

After, Catra sits atop of the pillows, buried in blankets that protects her from the night's cold. The fireplace is on and the chamber is empty except for Catra and Melog, hidden between pillows. She had asked Bow and Glimmer for privacy, just for tonight. This was still hers and Adora's chambers, the one place she felt belonged to them, together. Here is the starry ceiling Adora had enchanted for her, the tinted windows that reflect rainbows in the stone floors when the sun came out, the balcony with the white roses that now were charred bulbs of charcoal against thick snow. Here are Adora's clothes next to hers, their detailed and beautiful maps in the studio, the brushes with which they untangled their honeyed hair, the mush carpets to avoid that Catra's bare feet freezed on the cold ground. Here is Adora's old crib that Micah had fished from the depths of the castle's vault, right next to the huge bed with the little She-Ra rag doll waiting inside and the white paper pegasus on the baby mobile floating softly above.

This is still her home, as Adora always said to her. Camelot is now the only home she has left and her heart grieves painfully for her kingdom and her people but the only thing she can do right now is fiercely protect what she has left.

It's very early again, about one or two in the morning and Catra will probably fall asleep again soon, this time dreamless and another kind of quiet. She holds herself onto the fragile strands of her dreams, running the pads of her fingers up and down her bump. The five months mark came and went during these weeks and by this point it would be practically impossible for her to hide it anymore. The survivors of Halfmoon had found out almost immediately and now, the baby was the most safe kept secret inside the barriers of Camelot. Nobody would risk for other kingdoms to find out outside of them, not after everything that has happened.

Catra softens her fingers over the zones where little, oh so little, feet press into, humming to herself and the tiny peanut. The heaviness in her heart, the worry, the pain, the guilt, is only tampered now for the love that grows inside her stronger each day. Adora had given her the greatest gift before they left. Now it was in Catra to protect this little life and to seek her love back again.

"Adora loves you so much, little one. She loved you years before you even were here. She has always loved, always" Catra murmurs to herself and to her child. Melog stirs in bed and joins her in her gentle purr, mirroring the sound as they knead the most prominent point of her belly with soft paws. Their mane is still deep purple, with sparks of pink and white here and there. Catra inhales and holds her breath when another kick comes, a little bit curious, a little bit sad. It constricts her heart. "I'm going to find your mom. Once you are safe in my arms, wherever she is we will find her and we will bring her back, we will drag her back from that dumb ponytail of hers and right in her place besides us. And we are going to protect you no matter what. Nothing will be able to keep us apart after that"

If Catra is meant to walk alone through burning rocks and freezing waters just to get Adora back, then so be it. After all, it has always been like this. Catra and Adora, Adora and Catra, protecting each other. In this life and in a thousand others.

Catra looks through the closed windows, past the fog in the tinted glass and the biting breeze outside. The snow falls down, unyielding.

"That's a promise"

End of chapter X

End of Arc II

Chapter End Notes

Uf.
So you've made it this far! This chapter marks the end of our second arc and the start of my in-between-arcs-hiatus. I'll be using this time to cool my head, catch up on life things (like actually finishing my thesis lmao) and preparing for our third and last arc: Love, which is our longest and most complex arc. Camelot AU will be back in November! (Keep up on my IG, Twitter and the description here to see the exact date once I decide it)

About the flowers featured by the magicats for Adora: Lisianthus represents appreciation, gratitude and charisma. Gladiolus symbolises one that had strength, courage, victory and pride in their life.

And now for some special shout outs, thank so much to wninx, perfectpxtsch, candycornsnake, simplyabsolute, dianamoongoddess, little_noise, nootnella, casey25, victoria_starlight, onwardsaoshima, bah_felicia, talisands, eldritchgaylord, thedemideity, stephanieeleter, egyx3d, moonth, magicat.comet and every single one of you who has commented, bookmarked and left kudos on this humble story. I truly wouldn't have been able to get where we are now without all of your constant support and lovely messages. Thank you so much from the bottom of my heart.

And now for a last, a very special announcement: White Roses, a Camelot AU Artbook, will come live in digital form only in 2022! Over 40 pages of art environments, concept art, character sheets, exclusive illustrations and q&a about the lore of Etheria inside the Camelot Universe. For more information, check up the post on my IG (aoiveae.art) at 9am CST !

Thank you so much for reading! Kudos, comments and bookmarks are always appreciated. See you in November. Be good!

Chapter 12: Of Golden Dragons

Chapter Summary

Catra walks forward, counting each step after the other until the rusty and puffed wood of the door comes into view. There is a small motion at the bushes in the sides and Catra almost jumps out of her skin but then there is a rustle and out of the leaves walks Razz, carrying an old basket full of berries, humming to herself in a quiet voice. Her back is arched like last time and her broom rests almost comically at the side of the tower, like some kind of cane or sword or both. She doesn't hear Catra or see her, standing there with her dark clothes and her hair free and her red eyes and her sore heart. She doesn't see her but Catra does and what she sees is exactly what she thought she would. And that is someone who has lived a thousand lives, someone who knows more than they thought, someone who can help her.

Chapter Notes

Hello hello! Happy December! So long no see hope all of you are doing well ‘)
As you know things have been crazy lately for me, lots of up and downs and happy and sad moments. Thank you to every single one of you for being patient I really really appreciate it ‘)
So! Without so much more, here I present you the start of our third and last Arc, Love. I was only able to write two chapters in all this time ‘(but! I hope I can keep a one-two weeks schedule so I don’t keep you all hanging for too long (I definitely wish I could post chapter 14 by mid-December so we will see!)
Warning for this chapter: definitely still grief themes, sorry ‘(

Alright! This is a long 20k boi so I’ll see you downstairs!
Ready? Three, two, one, go!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Arc III. Love

CHAPTER 11. Of Golden Dragons

I loved you.

I had infinite faith in you.

And you were kind.

You were kind - so that I felt it without knowing it.

Which is a wonderful thing and goes far.

- Mary Maclane, *1902*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x x x

SPRING

❀

Finn is born at dawn on the first day of spring.

The castle is quiet.

Catra caresses their little ear between her fingers, gently, very careful to not wake up her baby. Is soft, still peach fur, warm and lovely, pressed against the sides of their small, small head. They nuzzle their tiny pinkish nose against Catra's bare breast, kneading it with their tiny, chubby hands and chirping lightly. Curled like this over Catra's chest, with their baby hands and baby feet over her skin, they feel so small, so fragile and vulnerable. So loved.

Catra knew her entire life was going to change. Her entire being was going to change, gravitating around this small creature who had been born of her, who was a part of the person she loved the most. That this beautiful newborn was going to become her heart and breath. But even when she felt them every day inside herself, moving and kicking and sleeping, Catra never understood the true dimension of it. Who would have said having her newborn in her hands would feel like this? Like galaxies being born inside her chest, in the core strings of her very soul, singing loudly like powerful bells across the earth, the air, the skies, reaching up and above and beyond and every corner of existence. Every time they breathe, every time they twitch softly on their sleep or yawn, tiny and sweet, every time feels like the stars fell from the skies and into the ground, into her hands, and formed this tiny being. This little starlight, a small sun in her arms, chasing the shadows away with their hummingbird heartbeat. Catra loves them.

The lady of the lake was right, Catra does have Etheria's greatest treasure. They are sleeping right in her arms.

Finn's nose scrunches lightly, rubbing their cheek over their mother's skin as they make little "mrp" sounds in their sleep. One tiny hand comes up their nose, little legs wiggling for a few seconds before their precious, beautiful face relaxes once again. They sleep-fight when they dream and another rush of tears travels down Catra's cheeks.

Glimmer and Bow are sleeping in a chair across the room, flopped one against the other, their snores filling the chamber softly. They smell like clean soap and calming magic, even in their sleep, clothes ruffled after moving around for the last couple of hours. Their hairs are in disarray, lilac bags below their closed eyes. They are exhausted, she knows, but Catra hadn't

allowed anybody else to assist her with the birth. She needed them here, she needed this small part of Adora here.

Glimmer held her hand the entire time, running a damp cloth over her feverish forehead, murmuring reassuring words as Catra pantted over the soft pillows, held to her friend in almost a death grip. Bow had been sweet and caring and the greatest friend, running across the chamber to bring clean towels and blankets and hot water, sitting next to the bed for hours as he checked Catra's vitals, respecting the limits of her nest, helping her as best as he could.

The room glowed a soft shade of pink from the protection spells King Micah had put up earlier, surrounding the entire tower in protecting magic. He hadn't entered out of respect and Catra was grateful. This was her safe space right now and it mustn't be broken. Angella awaited patiently behind the closed doors, listening, always ready to give a helping hand if it was needed. The members of the Round Table had sat in the banquet room, passing back and forth hot drinks, waiting for any news for hours. The entire kingdom had held its breath too, watching from their houses and shelters up and high towards the Queen's tower, looking at the golden light from the candles inside that poured like waterfalls towards the village, waiting for the sweet and small bells that would announce the birth.

It was easy. It was the easiest, most longed-for thing Catra had ever done, breath held, heart in her throat. It had happened a little bit earlier than expected and it had scared her, but Finn arrived almost swiftly, quickly, precious and perfect. Catra had held them from the damp blankets and into her trembling hands, crying softly and uncontrollably as she scented them with her cheeks, cleaning the damp out of their face, nudging them as she felt their tiny breath against her skin.

"Hey, I know you", she had said, the first thing that came from her mouth, lips ghosting over their small ears. "You are as beautiful as in my dreams"

They smelled beautiful, natural and clean. A little bit like rain and vanilla and, somehow, a little bit like fresh oranges too. In Catra's hands, her baby almost seemed to glow with life. The gentle kisses of their mother had made Finn start meowing instantly, happy and high and without crying once, because if one thing is sure is that this baby had been born in love and want, safely protected from pain and sadness and fear.

"I love you so much Finn", had whispered Catra in a hoarse but loving voice, holding their small head and back with her hands. Her eyes had filled with more tears, spilling down without permission but also without remorse. There couldn't be anything wrong when it came to Finn. "Adora loves you. Your mom loves you so much too, you have to know that. She loves you more than anything in this world"

It was everything Catra had wanted. Almost everything.

Catra never thought she would have this. Never in her life, she thought she might even want this. Falling in love? A baby? After everything that had happened in her life, with Shadow Weaver, with her mothers, with the war, it never once crossed her mind. She prepared to be a queen, a regent, a commander, a lider. It was always politics and study and training. Day after day, rinse and repeat. There was never time for thoughts of love and family, nor did she ever think she wanted them. Not until Adora.

Sweet, caring, beautiful Adora, half of her soul, breath of her heart. Always so kind and brave and giving in everything. Adora who had loved her from the very first moment, who had poured their heart into her hands and feet and allowed her to do with it as she wished. Adora who respected her when she needed and who stood by her side when the time came. Adora who lifted her and supported her and calmed her. Adora, who won her heart by letting her free. Adora, who married her again because they loved her. Adora who somehow deep inside their heart knew when Finn started existing and waited patiently and happily and overjoyed for Catra to be ready. Adora who gave their life for her and for their baby, willingly, bravely. So no, Catra never thought she would be worthy of being loved in this way, until Adora.

And now Catra is here, with her little baby against her, this tiny creature who is now her entire world, rubbing her nose in the fine blonde tuff on their head and forehead, breathing her child in, marveling at the miracle that is their life. Here she is and she can barely grasp the knowledge that Adora loved her so much, so deeply and honest and intense and raw. So powerfully, they created this sweet creature, together.

It fills her heart and breaks it all over again.

Melog curls against her arm, their head resting over the crook of her elbow as they stare at Finn, big, round and soft blue eyes while they watch the newborn's each movement. Every time Finn chirps gently or hiccups softly in their sleep, Melog's ears twitch in their direction, tail wagging over the mattress, their little wet snout coming to press on the sole of their tiny feet. It 's sweet. They love them too.

Catra takes one of Finn's baby hands between her fingers, bringing it gently towards her lips and placing a small kiss in the soft, thin skin there. Finn's fingers are so little, chubby, curled against themselves and towards their even softer palm. Their nose twitches a little when they catch the smell of their mother, rubbing their cheek further in the angle of her collarbones and then settling back again into their first sleep. Oh, how much Catra loves them.

Catra stares at the door and tries to convince herself that Adora is going to walk into the room any moment now, with their golden hair falling everywhere and that dumbstruck expression of theirs. They will climb into the bed, nuzzle both Catra and Finn into their arms and run their strong fingers through the blond fuzz of hair on Finn's head and down the curve of Catra's shoulder. Catra will call them a clotpole and Adora will laugh, eyes shining from unshed tears. They will hold their little family and watch them fall asleep with a soft enamoured smile on their lips.

Catra waits and waits and waits. The dawn comes and goes and the door remains closed.

Adora doesn't come home.

❀

Catra is nursing Finn when she sees them.

Her baby eats slowly, with small happy chirps and soft hiccups, their nose twitching lightly every time they suck. They are still too young to purr, basically only doing chirps and small

meows. They are barely a few hours old after all.

They are beautiful and Catra loves them so, so much. Their little, curled ears are not even unfolded yet, still closed just as their eyes, and their tail is tiny and soft, curled over their small legs. They have a button nose like her and the same soft skin. The puff of golden hair atop their tiny head is almost funny looking, curling up and to the sides in gentle curls that Catra will have to teach them how to tame. Their little hands are tiny, so small and delicate, they barely cover one finger of Catra's own hand but their press is strong as they knead in their mother's chest, mouth slightly covered with missed spots of milk. Finn is small and soft and fits perfectly right into Catra's both hands, their tiny head barely escaping free from their soft cream colored clothes and the blanket Bow knitted for them and that now they are wrapped onto safely and warmly.

Catra looks at them with bright, marveled eyes, cooing and purring to her kitten as she nudges them to eat. She loves them so much, has she said that? She loves them. Her heart feels as if it had burst open and poured into the earth, filled with so much love and devotion for them it fills her throat with honey sweetness. And they look so much like Adora it clenches at her heart sweet and painfully. There is no doubt who this tiny creature's mother is. They did such a beautiful thing, together, a little creature born of their love.

Catra sees the shimmer through the window and immediately catches her attention. She waits patiently for her child to finish eating, palming them softly in the back as she watches the sudden glimmers in the night sky. Her heart thunders inside her chest, suddenly confused, but her feelings are calm and so is the air around her. Whatever this is, is not dangerous or meant to hurt. Catra wraps Finn tight with the blanket, holding them against her chest and neck comfortable and safe.

Catra stands up from the rocking chair next to the bed, fastening the ribbons of her nightgown and the clasps of Adora's nightcoat against herself with one hand, the other one cradling Finn's bottom. Finn shifts against her neck, nuzzling further in the fabric of Adora's clothes, chasing the familiar smell. They meow, happy and a little tired and Catra can feel their little mouth yawning against her skin as she walks with soft steps towards the balcony door. Right now, Finn smells a little like roses and milk and warmth. Is calming. She opens the window and steps out, the chill spring breeze brushing her hair out of her face. Finn wiggles on her arms, protesting weakly against the sudden change, sniffing.

"Shhh, it's okay Finnie", lulls Catra, kissing the top of their small head, lips brushing tenderly over the fine hairs there and down their tiny back. "You can go back to sleep"

Her magic pulses, surrounding Finn in a gentle wave that keeps them warm and comfortable. Her baby wiggles a little more, yawning a little, and then stills again, falling right back to sleep against her chest. Catra sighs, a small content smile in her face, and she turns back to the night.

The roses are dead, but there, floating gently to the sky, are a thousand little lights. Golden balls of pearlescent glimmer that ascend to the night, illuminating Camelot in warmth.

Catra walks over the stones, approaching the edge, and looks down, one hand resting from the balcony railing, the other still holding Finn's sleepy, tiny body against her chest.

Camelot’s people are there. Farmers, blacksmiths, physicians, artists, workers, merchants. Villagers, salineans, magicats and refugees from all of Etheria. Knights and royalty. Elderly, adults, younglings, children, all of them standing there in the yard ground as equals, clothes moved gently by the early spring breeze, the lights born from their extended palms with the kindest of magic and rising to the sky in musicless dances.

It takes a few seconds but when they see Catra appearing over the railing of the balcony, carrying Finn in her arms, the entirety of the people seem to take a collective breath and then, one by one, slow in an infinite second, all of them bow their heads down in respect.

It 's a mourn and it’s a welcoming.

Catra’s breath dies on her throat and she starts crying silently, tears rolling down her cheeks and into the fabric of her nightgown. In her arms, Finn chirps and hiccups, safe inside their dreams, unaware of the love and loyalty they are surrounded by.

Next to them, the roses bloom again.

❀

The stars look down to them and Catra dreams again of Adora that night. It's the first time in months, since that time when Catra made the promise to bring Adora back no matter what. As always, it is bittersweet and beautiful.

She is back into that white space she dreamt about nights ago, standing next to the glassless windows. She is looking at the outside and yet she can't see anything out of white and golden light and mist that surrounds that ethereal place like soft thick clouds. The air is sweet and calm, fresh, filling her lungs and for the first time in weeks she feels as if she can breathe again. There is a soft movement in her arms and when she looks back she realizes she is carrying Finn, lovely and warm and small and so soft against her chest. Their tiny, closed ears barely peek outside of the white blanket they are wrapped into and one of their so, so little hands has curled against their mouth and nose, eyes closed as they sleep soundly against her. Finn chirps in their sleep, their nose twitching lightly as they dream and in the palm of her hand, Catra can feel their little heart beating happily, a precious song filling the calm silence around them.

She is so enamoured with her little baby that she doesn't hear her approach her until a pair of strong, warm arms wrap around her, an even warmer and tall body flushing against her back. Adora nestles their face on the space between Catra's jaw and shoulder, their arms surrounding both her arms and the baby's weight. Their left hand rests above Catra's own, the right cradling Finn's head against their long fingers and like this, it seems as if the sun and the moon were holding a newborn star between their arms.

Catra doesn't even startle, after all this is the place where Adora is always meant to be. Next to them.

Catra can't see Adora's face completely, but she can see the shape of their soft cheek against hers, the strands of hair falling down their shoulders like waterfalls of honey, the fluttering

white eyelashes, the sparkle of silver and blue in the corner of their eyes. Catra sighs, leaning her head over Adora's temple and there it is, oranges and roses. They are so beautiful it aches.

Adora smiles against Catra's cheek, shifting the placement of their hand so they can brush the knuckles of their right hand over Finn’s soft cheek, marveling at the way their skin is warm and tender, in the pink inside their ears, in the soft ash blonde hair atop their tiny head. Adora lets out a shuddering breath, watery and happy, caressing Finn's button nose with the tip of their finger. Finn's nose twitches for a second, sniffing the air as they take in the smell of their mother's hand close to their face. They shift in their sleep, nuzzling further on the fabric of Catra's nightgown, their little hands kneading in the air and towards Adora's direction. Adora hums, holding their baby's tiny hand with two of their long fingers, softly, delicately, so careful of their fragile little fingers.

"Hey, sweetie, I'm your mom" Adora's breath is sweet as she talks, ruffling the loose strands of Catra's hair and the fur at the base of her ears. Next to her, Adora smiles, bright and wide and unabashedly joyful as she looks at their newborn baby with the stars on her eyes. "You are so beautiful. I can't wait for you to be here"

Catra presses her eyes closed, keeping the tears at bay. *Finn is already here* , she thinks, deep in her heart, breathing deep through her nose. Adora doesn't notice, giggling goofy and teary as she watches Finn sleep. Her grip tightens over Catra's hand, head nestling further in the angle of her neck.

“I like this dream”, whispers Adora next to Catra’s ear, pressing a fluttering, sweet kiss on her jaw.

Catra can't answer him because how do you answer to a dream? How do you turn, amber and turquoise against silver and say *It's been almost four months. You've been gone, gone. Gone.* How to cradle peach cheeks and chant *Where are you? Where are you? Tell me where you are. I miss you so much. It's breaking my heart.* Catra doesn't have it in herself to tell her that. She just can't. She wants to, she wants to turn from their embrace and press her forehead to hers and whisper *Please, you have to wake up, for me, for Finn, wake up*. To shake her awake and run to her sides at the ends of the world and bring her back to them. Catra wants to, of how she wants to. But Finn's tiny hand has shifted in their sleep, grabbing unconsciously Adora's pinky and it doesn't even close around the finger yet their little kitten holds themself to their mother with all their strength, bringing it closer to their little snot-wet nose as they sniff and scent on Adora's sweet smell. Catra can't.

She is visibly shivering now and this time Adora does notice because they gasp softly before taking their hands away from them in order to place them gently over Catra's shoulders, squeezing lightly as they quietly try to ground her.

"Catra?", asks Adora and their voice trembles a little, concern and worry dripping out of it loudly. "Love, what's wrong? Are you hurt?". Because of course Adora's first worry would be about Catra above anything else.

“I love you” whispers Catra, still looking at their baby. Her gem eyes are pooling with tears, pouring down her constellation freckled cheeks in gentle rivers of crystal pearls. “I love you

so much, Adora”

Behind her, Adora holds their breath, surprised. This is the first time Catra has said that out loud. Adora always knew, of course, they felt it every single day, every hour and minute and second together and apart, Adora was always able to feel Catra’s love in every thing she did. Catra’s love was always there. And they understood from the very beginning the fear that lived in her bones of saying it out loud, those three words, that for some reason felt like a curse over Catra’s soul. But fear be damned, Adora had been ripped apart from Catra’s side anyway. She didn’t want to keep her love hidden inside herself anymore. She was going to shout it to the wind until every last corner of the universe hears her. Until Adora hears her.

Catra turns around, facing Adora completely. Finn shifts with the movement, meowing softly, still asleep. Adora is beautiful, as always, with their hair falling free at the sides of their face and back, their cheeks pink and healthy, eyes alive with liquid silver. There are tears like honey falling from their wide, surprised eyes, and their bottom lip is trembling as they look at Catra’s eyes. Catra smiles, a bit hesitant and a lot watery, passing Finn’s weight in one of her arms and reaching up to cup Adora’s cheek on her palm.

"I love you and I don't know if you are ever going to remember this, but I need to tell you. I love you" Catra’s voice breaks with emotion, basking in the warmth that comes from Adora’s skin and tears. Catra’s eyes and face are soft in the way they are when she is only looking at Adora and now at Finn too. "I should have said it so long ago but it has always been true. I love you"

Adora is openly crying now, their large hand cradling Catra’s, holding it tighter against their cheek. Adora turns their head a little, pressing a kiss over her palm, warm lips against her skin. There are a hundred emotions running through their eyes, from beautiful sweetness to calm softness to the sudden realization of concern. Catra’s heartbeat picks up, rushing in her ears like ocean waves as Adora frowns, dark eyebrows contrasting against the paleness of their eyelashes.

"Catra" they say, looking at her eyes and then down at Finn's sleepy form. Up and down again, cheeks paling, eyes swimming with even more tears as the seconds pass. The hand that holds Catra’s is shaking, the other one coming to cup Catra’s face between their fingers. "How long have I been sleeping?"

Catra makes a little miserable sound between a whimper and sob that tears itself from her throat without her permission. Adora’s eyes go slightly wider with alarm, bringing now their both hands to the sides of Catra’s face, brushing off the falling tracks of tears with their thumbs. Catra blinks quickly for a few seconds, trying to clear her eyes enough so she can see Adora’s lovely face properly. "I think you are astral projecting, I think your soul is trying to reach to mine" Catra gulps, throat dry. She can feel Finnie’s soft breath against the palm of her hand and she can see the way Adora’s eyes travel down and to their baby, the soft expression that lives in there filled with undoubtedly love and adoration, even in their sadness. The way Adora loves Finn so deeply and completely shakes the strings of Catra’s heart. She loves them so much.

"I'm going to find you”, blurts out Catra, stepping somehow even closer to them. Adora takes a sharp intake of air, nodding, unable to talk. “I promise Adora, I’m going to find you. You

protected us and now I will protect you. Just wait for me a little longer". Catra rises to her tippy toes, nuzzling her nose against Adora’s. “I love you”

Adora crosses the infinitesimal space between them, gently bringing her face forward until their lips meet, tears mingling as one. They have kissed many times in many ways yet this is different. These are their souls kissing. It feels like lighting against damp earth, like meteor showers in the sky, like blue flames licking dark wood. Adora exhales in her mouth, sweet breath traveling down Catra's throat as mist. Catra allows herself to be guided by Adora's sure hands and lips, pressing close to them, holding Finn gently over her chest. They can't stop crying, neither of them, and Catra hiccups around Adora's tongue as it presses softly over hers, fingers caressing over her eyebrows and down the curve of her freckled cheeks and the base of her ears. It's been so long, almost six months without Adora's warmth on her hands, and this sweet touch drives electricity up Catra's arms and down her toes. The way Adora kisses her right now is like being kissed by a summer sun, warm and damp and citric and everything that is good.

Adora parts from her reluctantly and only so they can press a kiss on Catra's cheekbone before leaning down and press an even sweeter kiss at the top of Finn's tiny head. Adora wraps their arms around both of them, nestling their face on Catra's hair. Catra holds them back, sniffing, and for some reason Adora feels a little less solid and more like fog in her arms. She digs her fingers on their back, holding them around her with as much strength as she can before reality reclaims them again.

"Just a little longer. I'm coming, I promise" Catra closes her eyes tightly, burying her nose on Adora's long hair. Adora sighs around her, turning their head just a little so they can whisper very softly to her ear.

"I love you too"

The next time Catra opens her eyes she is in their bed in Camelot, the light of the early day spilling golden through the windows. Finn is deeply asleep on their crib right next to her side of the bed, ears twitching every few seconds as they dream. They are safely tucked in, wrapped by a soft blanket to keep them from rolling on their sleep or accidentally scratching themself with their tiny nails. The ragdoll that looks so much like Adora rests in the far end of the crib, across from Finn's little feet, guarding them in their sleep. Melog is asleep too, head resting on the edge of the crib where they stayed the entire night watching the baby in their sleep.

Catra whimpers, cleaning her eyes swiftly with the palm of her hands before extending her arm towards Finn, the pads of her fingers caressing small circles over her baby's soft cheeks. There is melancholic inside her chest as the day drawns in, sun higher in the sky. She will have to wake up Finn soon to feed them, tuck them over her breast and sing to them as they eat, their tiny pinkish ears flickering like they do when they are full and happy. But right now she can stay here, just for a second longer, breathing in the soft scent that is her baby's smell. Lavenders and roses and, there, oranges in the top of their hair where ethereal lips brushed even from so far away.

In the days to come, Catra doesn't dream with Adora again.

❀

Catra is up and on her feet barely three weeks and a half after the birth. No matter the non-stop Glimmer and Bow's constant pleas of her to stay in her chambers and rest, Catra dismisses them all, going right back into her entire royal duties with a tired but determined expression and her baby wrapped tightly over her chest.

Finn is an angel, they sleep fast and without trouble most of the day, awoken only when it is time to eat or to change into clean clothes. Nobody protests or makes any comment the day Catra marches into the War Room again, with her hair loose and long and her child in her arms. There are no interruptions or unrequired comments, Catra is as always an extraordinary regent and Finn an extraordinarily calm child, no cries or tantrums, just the occasional chirps and soft meows when they dream. The first days the entire Round Table lives in awe over Finn, trying as hard as possible to not hover over Catra to catch a glimpse of the sleepy newborn. Even Mermista, who likes to act like she doesn't care at all, peeks every once in a while at the wrapped kitten next to her, her indifferent expression melting just a little bit when she catches Finn yawning. Scorpia keeps herself at bay in the opposite direction to Catra, sad eyes down towards the table as she plays with her fingers nervously. She doesn't make an attempt to walk close to Catra or the baby. It has been like this for the last months, Scorpia trying to keep herself away from them. It breaks Catra's heart. She has talked with Scorpia several times now, before the birth, assuring her that Adora is not dead and that what happened with Halfmoon was not her fault. They don't know yet what truly happened with the barriers or where the Horde came from, but if Catra is sure of something and is that Scorpia is not guilty of it. Still, Scorpia always drops her shoulders forward, blaming herself. After all, she was the Crown Princess and she promised to look for Adora.

Glimmer and Bow follow Catra almost everywhere when she needs them. Alongside them, Angella and Micah had helped her greatly with the kingdom for the last months of her pregnancy, when she had to secure herself inside her chambers in order to rest as much as she could. She enjoyed the quiet and the feeling of being surrounded by the walls that had come so dear and familiar to her. It was the room she had shared with Adora and she couldn't think of any other place to bring their baby into the world.

Catra walks with proud steps down the length of the banquet corridor. She doesn’t turn her head but she can see out of the corner of her eye the shining crystals and purple branches that had born after her magic outburst. Tourmalines, citrines, chrysocollas, agates, amazonites and apophyllites, all scattered up and down the limits of the corridor with their gentle glows. The branches extend all over the ceiling, as if holding it from collapsing into the ground, blue leafs hanging from them in curtains of color.

Finn is awake, their pretty eyes blinking slowly and closing against the dim light, little wet nose scrunched slightly as they rub their tiny fist against their fist. Their sight and hearing is still not fully developed so they sniff rhythmically the air, taking in the new smells beyond the scent of their mother around them, little hands gripping the fabric of Catra’s clothes to keep her close. Catra caresses their forehead with her finger without stopping walking, cooing at them lightly to keep them calm. Their eyes are still baby blue and it will take a little more for the true color to come through, but Catra can swear she sees the first hints of silver

in them. Catra smiles at them, leaning in so she can place a small kiss on their clean forehead, smoothing down the starts of wild golden curls in their head.

As they approach the gate that leads to the throne room, Finn sneezes suddenly, nuzzling their head in the wrinkled fabric of Adora's blue coat. The golden embroidery in the seams shines with the sun rays when Catra moves to accommodate the blanket around their body, tucking them further in the nest of her arms. They are still so small between her hands, it takes almost no effort to carry them from one arm to the other. Finn meows happily, their golden eyelashes reflecting amber shadows over the skin of their cheekbones and the starts of a hesitant still too young purr begins to rumble on their soft chest.

The guard next to the gate straightens when Catra walks in, with their red uniform glistening with the Halfmoon and Camelot shield, raising their voice to announce her arrival to the people already waiting inside the chamber.

"Presenting! Your Majesty King Regent C'yra, third of her name. Empress of Halfmoon, Queen Mother of Camelot. Countess of the House of Grayskull and Commander of the Dragon's Army"

The guard's voice echoes in every corner of the huge chamber, loud enough to the ears so that everyone turns towards the open gates and the murmurs die into silence immediately. Catra looks swiftly among the present royalty, courtesans and guards, regarding their presence for just one second before continuing her path towards the twin thrones. The deep gash in the stone ground is still there, filled to the brim with hard crustal and flat black roots. Catra's feet are cold against the sterile rocks, flowers never once blooming under her step, not anymore.

"Presenting! Your Highness Finnlay Pendragon of D'riluth, first of their name. Royal Heir to the Throne of Camelot and Sole Heir to the Throne of Halfmoon"

The voice follows her as, one by one, the people start to bow down their heads in respect as Catra and her baby walk the long steps to the end of the room. Glimmer and Bow are waiting at the base of the throne, balancing a bunch of official scrolls in their arms while they wait for Catfa to reach them. Light Hope is nowhere to be seen. In fact, Catra has barely even seen her at all since Adora's disappearance. The thought makes her unease turn uncomfortably in the pit of her stomach.

As she finishes walking the last steps the murmurs start to pick up slowly again. She is supposed to go through the official matters of the kingdom with the court the entire day today. Catra is not looking forward to it. She has barely slept, if the dark bags under her sparkling eyes can say anything, and her shoulders are tired and sore. But she does have an important matter to speak with Sir Juliet so there is no other choice.

Glimmer and Bow throw her a small smile when she stops in front of them and Catra returns the gesture with a tiny of hers, rocking Finn up and down gently so they go back to sleep for a little bit as she works. Glimmers balances her scrolls in one hand so she can hug her with one hand around her shoulders and caressing Finn's head once she leans a little away.

"Good morning, Finnie", sing-songs Glimmer, smiling wider when Finn peaks an eye open and then closes it immediately after, hissing partially on their blanket. Glimmer turns fully to

Catra, smoothening the errands hair over her shoulders with her small hands. She frowns when she catches in Catra's tired eyes, shaking her head disapprovingly. "Hey, you. Did you have *any* sleep last night?"

Catra sighs, scratching her eyebrow with one hand to keep her a little bit more awake than what she feels right now. "A little"

Catra turns to Bow, who passes his own scrolls to Glimmer swiftly before Catra hands him little Finn. He craddlings them with welcoming warm arms, rocking them a little when they wriggle for the change of hands and smiling brightly at them when the baby peaks an eye open towards them. They look so much like Adora already, in the way their eyes are just a little bit almond and a little bit hooded and their eyebrows and nose scrunch when they dream. Glimmer and Bow are both so completely devoted to this little creature that is a part of two people they love dearly, there are no other arms, besides Catra's, where they would be safer.

Catra smiles, rubbing the side of her forearm with her hand as she watches them greet each other. Glimmer and Bow are the only people Catra allows to hold or even breathe near Finn. They have taken the habit of helping her hold them when she has to attend official audiences with the Court like this one, alternating between Glimmer and Bow each time. Catra never loses sight of her baby, not for a single second. There is still a traitor among them and after everything that has happened, Catra won't be taking any chances.

Catra helps Glimmer with the scrolls, sitting on her side of the thrones with a heavy sigh. She just needs to survive the next hours, just a little bit longer until she can go where she needs to. She has been sitting in waiting for far too long.

Catra turns to the Court, clearing her throat as she crosses her ankles together. "Good morning, everyone. Let's get started, shall we?" She opens the first scroll of the day, roaming the long sentences in a few seconds and returning her gaze back at them. "Lady Inasy, status report on the provisions"

A young woman, probably around her early thirties, with pretty round cheeks and vibrant black eyes walks forward with a sprint in her step. Her dreadlocks bounce when she walks, held back with a beautiful crimson and yellow scarf that matches her circle earrings. Her colorful green dress and the swirls of paint over her nose and chin make her look like a blooming summer flower and it makes Catra smile.

"The spring provisions have already arrived at every shelter, house and orphanage around Camelot" says Lady Inasy and her voice is like little bells. "We have also gotten the report that the provisions we sent to Plumeria and the Kingdom of Snows arrived safely and on time to their destinations. The last of the provisions sent last autumn by...um" the young woman hesitates, shifting on her feet and looking at Catra with apologetic eyes. "Umm...the provisions sent last autumn by King Adora were enough to pass through the winter completely and without any problem. I'm certain we will be able to produce enough for this season and the starts of the next"

Catra holds her breath, nodding. She appreciates the way the entire Court has been respectful of Catra's loss without making her feel like a victim. The last thing she has ever been is one.

"What about the orphanages?"

Lady Inasy's expression brightens, almost jumping in excitement. "Both of our orphanages are in their thirty percent capacity, together. The adoption system has been incredibly fast and with the greatest positive reaction since we inaugurated it in January. If we keep at this rate we will be able to close the orphanages by maybe even the end of the month"

Her excitement is contagious because it soon enough spreads across the people of the chamber. The Court leans to whisper one with the others, nodding approvingly and cheering low in their breaths. It's hopeful news, especially in such hard and sad times. Catra smiles, leaning back on the throne with a pleased sigh. She is proud.

The building of the orphanages had been her primary plan once she arrived at Camelot, so many moons ago. It had been the first thing she had firmly stated to Adora that very first week, passionately defending its importance and impact over the welfare of the people. And Adora had accepted immediately, no extra questions, no hesitation in the matter. They had given her complete control over the building, the management, the care of the children and any other decision that needed to be taken. The orphanages were her responsibility and her most personal project in the kingdom, so she was proud and happy to hear about it in such a golden light.

"Thank you, Lady Inasy", says Catra with a small smile. The woman bows gently and sprints back to the Court, her bracelets and earrings jinggling with each other.

Catra tosses a quick glance to Bow, who is currently pulling funny faces as discreetly as he can to try and make Finn laugh. Is of no use Finn is still too young and it will take them still a little bit to smile at all. Glimmer nudges Catra's arm with her hip, extending her a new scroll with a knowing smile in her lips. Still, Catra can see the red rim in her eyes and the way her shoulders are slightly scrunched over herself.

Just a little longer , Catra thinks. *I'm coming.*

"Sir Azrael, progress with our subterranean aqueducts?", calls Catra, nodding towards her royal guard when they walk forward.

Before the knight can even attempt to talk, the sound of a muffled commotion comes from the corridor outside the chamber and suddenly the gate opens with a harsh swing. In come a myriad of guards trailing behind the hard stomps of a woman with gray hair, pale thin skin and a hideous green puffy dress. Her face is beet red with the effort and the tight of her corset and she walks with a stubborn steps towards the thrones, ignoring all the way at the frustrated knights behind.

"Baroness. Baroness you are not allowed to enter the Audience", huffs one of them. The Baroness snaps at them, barong her teeth on warning.

"Nonsense! I'm still a member of Camelot's royalty! I can do whatever I want!"

Besides Catra, Glimmer sighs, dragging a hand across her face with an exasperated groan. "Why?"

"She can't live without attention", whispers back Catra, straightening her shoulders. "I'll get rid of her. Keep an eye on Finn, yes?"

Glimmers nods, crossing behind the throne to stand right next to Bow, who is looking with knitted eyebrows to the newcomer, and Finn, tugging from the ribbons of Bow's shirt. Catra pinches the bridge of her nose between her fingers, closing her eyes for a second to avoid an imminent headache.

"Baroness Diomira", half greets half sighs Catra, looking up with her lips in a thin line. "Your rights on the matters of this Court were revoked months ago. There is no place for you here"

Baroness Diomira's face grows somehow a deeper shade of red, looking around the Court with her hands in fists and her voice high and sharp like a knife over glass. "Are you really going to stand there and allow this to happen. Allow a stranger, an outsider, a...a *creature* to just sit there in our kingdom's throne and rule like nothing?!"

The Court looks at her with clear surprise, shifting in their places uncomfortably and throwing nervous looks to their King. Catra growls, very very quietly, standing up off the throne with her jaw clenched.

"You will leave my presence immediately, madame". But the woman keeps going, ignoring Catra completely even as she starts walking towards the Baroness with the clear intention to take her out of the chamber herself. In fact, the Baroness snaps her hands to the sides, speaking so loudly and harshly drops of her spit fall to the ground and her lips retrieve until her gums peak out.

"Magicats weren't even real a few years ago, you were hide ups, runaways, *lessers.* And now you are ruling *us* ?! How convenient, isn't it?"

Catra's nails dig into the fabric of her gloves, tail lashing over the ground and hair on point. The whole Court takes a step back, looking with wide eyes at this regal lioness hunting down her prey. "Think wisely what you are going to say, madame"

"I say you did this!", shouts the woman, pointing at Catra with her long finger. "Our King leaves to protect *your* kingdom and mysteriously is lost in war making *you* the king? You planned this! But I won't allow it, oh no, it's my duty as royalty of this great kingdom to stop this idiotic decision to hold you as a regent. I won't allow it!"

Cares stops right in front of her, tense as a violin cord, but the woman doesn't step back. In fact, she is so sure of herself she dares to step into Catra's space and dig her finger over her shoulder painfully.

"What do you think gives you the right to wear our crown and call yourself our King, you pathetic child? You are the reason the King is dead!"

The piercing voice of the woman resounds acute and harsh over the chamber. Even Glimmer flinches at the high tone, pressing against her ear as to shield it from the unwelcome sound. Silence and discomfort falls over the chamber, people grimacing and turning their gazes away from the woman with scowls in their faces. And then, like announcing an incoming disaster,

Finn starts to cry. Is loud and heartbreaking and it clenches everyone's hearts in the room with the intensity of it. Finn has cried before, of course, they are a newborn. But not like this, not with their eyes and nose scrunched in discomfort, their little hands covered by the fabric of their romper coming up to rub weakly at their just unfolded ears, pained after the high sound. No with their tiny tail curled against their body and the heavy drops of tears falling off their lovely silver and blue eyes and into the wrinkles of Bow's clothes. It hurt them, the yell, it hurt them enough so any kind of sleep they had been previously falling into is now long forgotten. Bow rocks them to the sides, trying to calm them down as he rubs gently over their chest, but the cries don't die down and Finn just rubs their tiny, tiny face over their blankets as they keep sobbing.

Catra turns her head towards them immediately, ears perked up at the sound of her distraught baby. Outside, the light of the day flickers. The Baroness scoffs, crossing her arms over her jeweled chest, tilting her silver hair over her shoulder with a scowl across her thin lips.

“A child, yes" she says, in a mocking tone, looking up and down at Finn's weeping bundle, her nasty expression deepening with each heartbreaking cry. "A child whose existence was never reclaimed publicly by King Pendragon. A King you knew for barely two years. Are we supposed to believe in the legitimacy of a most possible bastard?”

The entire Court gasps, horrified by the woman's words. Bow grunts, holding their newborn nibbling close to their chest, eyebrows knitted together in a furious look. Glimmer clenches her teeth so hard she feels the tip of her molars chip under the pressure. Her fists close tight, waves of pink magic sparkling out of them, up and ready to strike down. But it is for nothing. It's all for nothing because suddenly, on the beautiful bright spring day outside, the sun seems to *blink* and then dim down, like a candle blown out by strong winds. The entire castle shakes as if hit by an earthquake, fine dust falling from the ceilings to the floor. People in the Court give a strangled yell, holding onto each other as the chamber shakes and seems to almost scrunch. The crack in the chamber shifts and screeches horribly, drowning any other sound outside those walls, extending to the sides by veins of colorful magic. Glimmer gasps, holding herself to Bow's clothes as she looks at the center of the room.

Glimmer calculated wrong. Catra doesn't need saving.

Catra slaps the woman so hard and vicious the baroness face rolls to the side with the intensity of the hit. Her pale face colours from plain white to pink to bright red to the first hints of purple. Catra's nails had caught in skin because there are three sharp scratches running from the base of her ear down her cheek, red and angry and painful. The Baroness gasps, surprised, and she lifts a hand to press it over the sore skin of her skin turning slowly and hesitantly back to Catra's direction. Catra's expression is terrible. Her eyes are narrowed, pupils only pinpoints inside the pools of color, the rims red and angry. Her fangs are bare, picking out of the snarl in her red lips in flashes of white, sharp and ready torn down skin and bone and steel. Her hand prickles by the strength of the hit where it connected with the Baroness' skin. Yet Catra looks serene and composed, spine straight and posture perfect. The only mirrors of her true anger in her eyes. She looks about to kill her. She might. Nobody is going to stop her.

"Kneel ″ says Catra, very slowly, savoring each word, rolling them on her tongue and out into the air as poison. The Baroness gapes at her, still in shock, hesitating even in how to breathe. That won't do. Catra frowns, snarl deepening as she lifts up her chin. The gold in her moon crown catches the sun, blinding and regal. "Kneel before your King"

The dangerous rim in her voice seems to snap the woman out of her stupor because she lowers herself into her knees immediately, eyes frightened under Catra's burning gaze. Like this it doesn't look anymore like the baroness is taller than Catra. She is actually small, she is so small in comparison, small and coward and shaking like a leaf over the turned rocks of the ground. The chamber's temperature has dropped evidently yet the woman is the only one who feels the chill and the freeze. Catra growls, the sound rumbling on her throat making the woman gasp and lower her eyes to the ground.

"It will do you good to remember your place" murmurs Catra, low enough that it almost doesn't seem to perturbe the void air that has fallen into the room but dangerous enough that raises goosebumps in everyone's arms with the threat on her voice. The woman doesn't dare to look up, afraid of the raging gaze she will encounter. "You are nothing, not the dirt on my feet, not the mud on my nails, and you will live like nothing from now on to the rest of your days"

Catra steps back, brushing her long dark hair down her back, ears twitching still alert and focussed on Finn's crying. They have calmed down a little, big sobs now only soft whimpers. Bow is still shushing them as gently as possible, looking up at Catra with a calming reassuring look and then back at the baby again, resting them over his shoulder so he can pet them softly on the back as Finn stops crying completely. Finn lets out a particularly heartbreaking last hiccup and Catra's eyes sour further, snapping her head back to the kneeling woman in front of her feet with a furious scowl. "I am stripping you out of your title, Madame."

"Your Majesty", stutters the former Baroness, eyes wide with shock. Her hand shoots forward, trying to grab a handful of Catra's pants on plead but the latter snaps her legs away, turning to the guards around them.

"Remove her from my sight"

The guards move immediately and at the same time, surrounding them in a matter of seconds. The woman's begging look changes in a snap, lips curling and eyebrows knitting together, sprinting to her feet as she stomps in the ground. She looks at Catra with fury, yelling once again, high enough to make Finn flinch again even though Bow is trying to cover their tiny soft ears with his hand.

"You cannot do this!"

Catra is mere inches in front of her in the blink of an eye. The woman startles so much she falls again into the ground, hands connecting so hard with the rocks below it scratches her. Catra hisses at her, the fur of her shoulders and ears on point, tails swishing back and forward again and again. She can feel her own nails digging into her skin of how hard she is pressing them I to fists. The castle shakes again, clouds swirling outside, hidding the sun completely behind its thick black mist.

"I am the Dragon's Queen" says Catra between clenched teeth, proud and regal and angry and dangerously beautiful. The woman shivers, looking without luck for a way to scatter away. Catra hisses once more, making her snap her frightened eyes back to the regent with her breath held. “And I am your King. I can do whatever I please with you. Whatever you have to say about it? I just *don't care.* " Catra huffs, looking around the room with eyebrows raised and her arms extended, circling just once in her place before turning her sight back down to the woman. "But of course, if the Court has any objection I am more than willing and pleased to listen”

The former Baroness looks around and towards the people with pleading eyes, desperate for any kind of empathy or support. But the entire Court is scoffing down at her, noses scrunched, eyes hard, some of them even turn their back completely, looking to other sides of the room and avoiding at all costs to look at her in the eyes. She is alone. Nobody is going to help her.

Catra notices it too because she smiles, vicious and sharp, placing her hands at her sides as she tilts her head to the side, regarding the woman with something much like satisfaction inside her beautiful mismatched eyes.

"Is that clear to you, *madam* Diomira? Whatever stupid and ridiculous name that may be". The woman nods, so quickly her teeth clank with each other several times, scattering in the ground like a wounded bug. Catra grunts, tone dropping again. "Use your words, madam"

The woman chokes with her tongue, trying and failing several times before finally brokenly mutter out "Yes your Majesty"

Catra bends forward in the woman's direction, grasping her chin between her fingers. The sharp tip of her long, black nails dig lightly on her skin, leaving light traces of red behind. Catra pulls from her face, bringing her inches from her own with force and when Catra speaks is between her clenched teeth, fangs flashing dangerously with the light. The woman shivers, all colors drawn from her face and neck, eyes wide and terrified. Catra eyes her for a second and then smiles, leaning to speak to her in a low whisper, dripping with threat and poison.

“I could cut your throat open right now, with my bare hands, for what you have just said. Do not ever speak against my child again or I swear to you not even the crows will want to pick from your body when I'm done with you"

Catra leans back, dropping the woman's face with a disgusted expression on her lovely, letal face. She looks at her black gloves and snarls, taking them both off in a swift motion and throwing them towards the woman. She will not touch her baby with stained hands. The Court stays silent, standing behind Catra with their chins up and their harsh looks towards the woman.

“Bless your stars I didn’t send you to hang for treason” finishes Catra, turning away from her completely. “Sir Juliet, get her out here”

Sir Juliet nods once, grasping the woman by the arms and bringing her back to her feet in one swift motion. She is limp in the Knight's strong grip, blinking slowly and in shock.

"What do you want me to do with her, your Majesty?"

Catra throws a side look to them, eying up and down at the woman with a newfound boring expression. "Throw her to the dungeon. A night with the rats may teach her some humility". Catra's ankle bracelets twinkle as she starts walking back to the throne and towards Glimmer and Bow, speaking one last time without looking back. "I'll decide what to do with her on the morning"

Sir Juliet nods again and walks out of the chamber, halfway dragging the former Baroness, accompanied by a handful of knights trailing behind them. Glimmer exhales, pressing closer to Bow and Finn, rubbing her own hand over the baby's back in small circles. They are still hiccuping softly over Bow's shoulder, their tail hidden and little ears low over their head, but their heartbeat has calmed down and the tears have stopped, nose twitching one or thrice as they look in the air for their mother's scent. Catra's magic hadn't upset them in the slightest, in fact, it had helped them calm down to be surrounded by it instead of the bothersome sound of the Baroness whines. Outside, the dark clouds grow thinner and dissipate completely in a matter of seconds, the sun shining bright and golden once again over the beautiful spring day in Camelot. The castle doesn't shake anymore, magic veins folding on themselves and disappearing among the cracks of the ground as if nothing had happened at all.

The rest of the Court ruffle their clothes from the dust that had fallen from the ceilings, murmuring among themselves. They look a little shaken, yes, but their expressions are understanding and even impressed. Nothing like this had even happened outside of a battlefield. No other ruler had ever shown such a display of magic and raw power, not like that and certainly not in the middle of an audience. Mara used her magic only in battle and Adora was used to handling people like this with barely contained diplomacy and clenched teeth. But then again, nobody had ever insulted Adora's baby in front of them. Glimmer couldn't imagine how Adora would have reacted in Catra's place but she guessed it wouldn't have been in a kind or gentle manner. She guesses it could have probably been much worse. Nobody had ever seen Adora truly, frightfully, completely angry before.

Catra walks to them quickly, reaching for Finn and taking them from Bow's hands in one swift soft motion. She nestles her baby in the crook of her neck, scent marking the top of their head with a low purr, caressing the base of their ears with the pad of her fingers. Catra's own ears are twitching violently, reflecting just how upset she really is, but her chirps are gentle and sweet as she lulls Finn and soon the little kitten calms down enough to slip into a quick sleep, partially hidden between Catra's hair and the angle of her jaw. Glimmer and Bow rub Catra's upper arms without saying a word, reassuring her until her own heart and mind calms, looking around the chamber to supervise the rest of the people. The Court has fallen into a very quiet murmur, careful of not waking the baby again, and are waiting patiently for their King to reassure her child. She is, after all, not only a regent but also, and first, a mother.

Catra sighs, feeling more composed and serene after having her baby in her arms. There is still rage pooling acidic and boiling in the pit of the gut but she is completely sure now that she is not going to blow the castle in pieces.

Very carefully, Catra changes Finn from their position over her shoulder, cradling their fragile head between her hands and tucking them in the angles of her elbows, rocking them up and down just a few times before returning them softly and partially hesitating back to Bow's sure hands. There is still an audience to run.

Glimmer looks eyes with her before she can climb back to the throne and her purple sparkling irises are full of reassurances and understanding but also of silent questions. Catra just shakes her head, curls bouncing with the movement, murmuring a little "Later" and returning to her seat quickly. Catra ribs a hand over her eyes, allowing herself just one more second to clear her head and bite down the unwanted feelings that had started to rise inside herself.

"Thank you for your patience. This won't happen again, I can assure you that. I won't let *anyone* stain King Adora's nor Prince Finlay's name. ", Catra says out loud, and her voice doesn't shake not even for a single second rolling out of her tongue heavy and dangerous. Catra shakes her shoulders and raises her head back up, sparkling eyes returning to the knight still standing at the foot of the throne. "Now, uncomfortable presences aside, Sir Azrael, the aqueducts"

The knight smiles, a hint of something passing through their eyes when they smile. "They are complete and ready for operation if needed, your Majesty. The entrances were cleared and cleaned last weekend."

Catra's eyes flash with recognition, a lazy smile widening in her face. Besides her, Bow and Glimmer share a knowing look "Good. And our barriers?"

"We have sorceresses and knights guarding every corner every single second of the day. If anything happens we will be let known immediately"

"Great. No matter what, those barriers are not coming down, ever. Doesn't matter what other order you may get and no matter who goes to you and tells you otherwise, not even me, the barriers stay up" Catra drums her fingers over the sides of the throne "We are not taking any risks. I want our entire army displayed across the town and ready to act. If the Horde tries anything at all, we will be ready"

The Knight nods, spine straight. "And about Shadow Weaver, your Majesty?"

"Leave the witch to me" Catra's tone drops, frightening and cold, crossing one of her long elegant legs over the other. Her fangs flash dangerously from under the edge of her crimson red lips, turquoise and amber eyes glowing in volcanic fire. The look on her face could turn the sky itself into stone. "I will kill her myself"

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Catra rocks Finn from side to side, tapping gently over their back after eating so they can slip into their midday sleep, their warmth slipping through her hands and arms and all the way up the center of her chest.

Finn yawns against her cheek, mewling happy and content and their little nuzzle smells like lavender and milk. Her baby nuzzles on the angle of Catra's jaw, seeking the soft comfort of their mother and Catra can feel their tiny tail curling over the fingers that carry them, securely holding themselves to her. Catra smiles, humming under her breath, ghosting her lips over Finn's ears and forehead. She lowers them down with gentle hands, bopping twice at their tiny button nose with her finger before pressing a fluttering butterfly kiss over it. Finn looks back at her with their big, silver eyes, blinking very slowly, their little hands curled over their tail as they yawn again and chirp happily to their mothers.

They are calm and tired, after all the shit show that had happened in the audience. Bow had managed to keep them sleepy and relaxed for the entire rest of the meeting, passing them quickly right back into Catra's restless hands after it was over and the Court started to make their leaves. Glimmer and Bow knew to allow Catra of her private time, nodding in her direction when Catra cradled Finn between her arms and slipped away through the small door in the chamber.

Catra wandered around the empty corridors and quiet gardens for long minutes, speaking to baby Finn in a soft whisper to keep them and herself calm. She liked to do this, speaking out loud to Finn everywhere they went, be it their chambers or the gardens or down to the kitchens when Finn had a restless night and Catra needed to eat something to not crash from exhaustion, Catra spoke to Finn all the time. She would tell them about Halfmoon, about every corner and every mural and every plant and bug and creature and color. She would tell them about their grandmothers, Zina and Tlalli, who didn't get to meet them but who she was sure would have loved them with their entire hearts. Catra would tell Finn about Camelot, about the green gardens they would run in, about the high hills and the stone palace and the soft carpets they would grow in. And she would tell them about Adora. About this tall and strong and kind and loving and goofy person who was also their mother and who loved, they loved them, they loved them so much. About how Adora curled around them in the early stages of their arrival on Catra's body, how their hands were so big in comparison to her belly and how they would be so big in comparison with Finn's tiny head. She would tell them about how Adora could be so brave and so dumb sometimes because their heart was so big and so sweet and so selfless and how yet they had decided to sacrifice themself first than let anything happen to them. She would tell Finn about Adora every day, every hour, every second. There would never go a moment where Catra didn't assure their baby how loved and wanted they were and how much Adora would love them after they were back with them.

And so, wandering around castle Grayskull, she had finally ended up here, in the library, the calmest place in the kingdom, looking intently at the beautiful portraits of the old regents of Camelot hanging from the polished wood walls around them. There was a certain quietness that had fallen over Camelot after Adora's disappearance. The streets were calmer, the people more silent. Even the very rocks seemed to stay still, the unique drum of magic that crossed the kingdom tamed, dormant. Silent.

Catra had gone down to Serenia's lake several times during the months that had passed but not once had she seen the lady of the lake. The neon blue waters were frozen in time, the only movement there was the strange waterfalls in the walls with their wrong flow and their cold stream clouds. After Finn's birth, Catra didn't go back there anymore. Nothing there would help her, that was sure. Right now, maybe there was just one person that could.

Finn stirs in Catra's hands, snapping her back into reality. They are sniffing the air again and again, their eyes scrunched closed in soft confusion as they search insistently in the space around them. Whatever they smell it doesn't seem to satisfy them because Finn wiggles in Catra's hold, upset, chirping sadly as they rub their face with their tiny hands, nose twitching. They extend their small arms up, opening and closing their fists several times as if trying to grab something they can't see or hear or smell. Catra caresses the curve of their cheek with her finger, fluffing the peach fur there with delicate touch, her own elegant eyebrows knitting in concern.

"What are you looking for, sweetie?" she whispers, trying to not break the peace around them. Finn whines lightly, little lips fruncing in a pout that makes them look so much like Adora it swipes the ground behind Catra's feet. Catra exhales, a little shaky, smothering the errands tiny curls at the top of their head with her thumb. "Are you looking for your mamma? Are you looking for Adora?"

As if answering, Finn meows once, rubbing the side of their face on Catra's palm, ears folding towards their head, a gentle purr starting to vibrate right in the middle of their chest. “Oh, Finnie…” Catra feels the strings in her heart pulling painfully and she has to bite the tears back when she leans in, pressing her lips over her baby's cheek and forehead, all the way up the tip of their small pink ears. "Oh, baby. It's alright, we are getting her back I promise"

Finn fumbles gently under her hold, holding the loose strands of her hair between their fingers. They can’t understand her yet but they do seem to sense her trying to reassure them because their wiggling calms down, drooling lightly over the dark curls of hair with their hooded eyes focused on her completely. Catra smiles at them once more, huffing when she tries and fails to rescue the wet pieces of her hair, settling in the end to just press the pads of her fingers over the soft beans of their feet, tickling gently.

There is a rustle outside the library’s door and the doorknob flickers a few times before it finally rolls to the right side and opens. Scorpia stumbles inside, surprise writing all over her face for the sudden opening. Her white hair has gotten longer since their arrival to Camelot and now is held in a floral braid that brushes her shoulders with each movement. Errand strands from her half held bangs fall over her eyes lightly and she smell strongly like tulips and perfume.

Scorpia's eyes dart nervously across the expanse of the library, searching until she takes in Catra's figure standing next to the portraits and looking at her with an amused expression. The princess blushes a soft shade of pink, shifting on her feet and looking up and down a few times. Catra smirk dissolves into a gentle one and she walks toward her friend with quiet steps, stoping right in front of her and tilting her head to the side with a loopy side smile.

"Hey Scorpia", Catra says, very gently, tapping Scorpia right in the middle of the forehead. "Thank you for coming"

Scorpia blinks, taken aback, and she looks at Catra like she didn't really know what to say. In her arms, Finn sneezes, making Scorpia's eyes lower to their little face. There is a very soft look that crosses Scorpia's eyebrows and mouth and she smiles tiny to the baby before returning her gaze to the queen still standing in from of her.

"Err", Scorpia tries and then bites back her tongue, eyes growing sadder and sadder. Catra's face falls too, a crease forming between her eyebrows. Her lips frunce into a grieving pout for a split of a second but Catra tries to keep her face composed, sighing heavily in the back of her throat. She pulls the little smile back up, nudging Scorpia with her hip. She is so tall she can only reach part of her leg.

"Hey, what's with the long face?" attempts to joke Catra. Scorpia bites her lip, looking down at Finn with a mournful expression. When she looks at Catra she does it with tears stuck to her eyelashes, making Catra's heart sink all the way to the soles of her feet.

"I'm so sorry, Catra", blurts out Scorpia. She is fidgeting with her hands nervously and she doesn't seem very much like she knows where to put herself. "I'm sorry. I should have done more. I should have stayed with her. I should…"

"Scorpia", interrupts Catra, softly but firm. Scorpia closes her mouth, pressing her lips together into a stubborn line. Catra's world is spinning in the edges, just like every time it does when anyone mentions Adora. It takes Catra a few seconds and deep breathing but finally she finds her own voice again. She raises her right hand up, supporting Finn's light weight with he left, and placing it gently over Scorpia's shoulder. Scorpia sucks in a breath, eyes wide with the surprise brought by the touch.

"Scorpia, what happened in Halfmoon wasn't your fault. No, don't interrupt me" Scorpia falls quiet again, dropping her try to disagree. Catra locks her eyes with hers, making sure she is listening intently before continuing. "Someone betrayed us, maybe even multiple people did. You couldn't possibly know what they were planning. *I* didn't see it coming and I should have. I'm the one who should have never let Adora go in the first place. I'm the reason she-"

Catra stops, suddenly overwhelmed by emotions. Unconsciously, Catra holds Finn closer to her chest, focusing on the slow rise and fall of their little chest with each breath. Scorpia's expression has changed into a worried one and she looks at Catra's face very closely, ready to step in if Catra needs it. But she manages to keep it all inside herself, locking it inside that space inside her heart where she has kept all her despair and sadness for the last couple of months. Catra grids her teeth together pressing above the pain in her chest to keep going.

"Adora would have gone back anyway, Scorpia. That's just how she is. I don't think there is anything you could have done or said to make her change her mind"

"But Finn-"

"Adora knew about them" assures Catra, voice shaking lightly. Finn is drifting back to sleep but their purr is still strong and constant. "Adora knew and I think that's the reason why she did what she did. She did it out of love. So, if I'm sure of something, is that nothing that happened was, in no way, your fault. I don't want you to beat yourself anymore for a dumb ass thought like that and Adora wouldn't want it either"

Scorpia nods but she still looks unsure and uncomfortable. Catra huffs, slightly frustrated and she nudges Scorpia once more this time with her shoulder, motioning softly at one sleepy Finn. "Hey you, you haven't even carried Finn at all. It's been three weeks it's about time"

Scorpia gasps, giving a huge step back and raising her pincers up, shaking her head from side to side with a nervous smile on her face. "Oh no no no, please. They are so tiny and I have huge pincers!" Scorpia chuckles nervously and looks to the sides, avoiding Catra's sparkling gaze at all costs. "Besides they are asleep! I don't want to wake them up!"

Catra stares at her, surprised at first and then slightly annoyed. She steps closer to her space again, scrunching her nose when Scorpia tries to squirm away again. "Scorpia don't be ridiculous. I've seen you carry the kids at the orphanages a hundred times. I want you to hold them"

"But why?", asks Scorpia in a whisper, her shoulders dropping forward in defeat. Catra looks at her directly in the eyes, extending her arms to carefully, very softly, place little Finn between her pincers.

"Because I trust you" deadpans Catra, not once hesitating. "And you are my friend"

Finn wakes up slightly, confused for a second for the drastic change of hands. Their eyes narrow and close again, relaying on their smell as they move their tiny nose closer to the surface of one of Scorpia's pincers and sniffs. Is not the scent they are looking for but it doesn't agitate them either, so Finn yawns one last time and goes right back to sleep almost immediately, nestled between their blanket and Scorpia's pincers. Scorpia gasps lightly, very very gently bringing Finn up and towards her face to look at them closer, smiling at the sight of the tiny starry freckles scattered over their chubby cheekbones.

Before them, Catra sighs, rubbing the side of her upper arm in a grounding circular motion, the shadow of a smile ghosting over her lips as she watches Scorpia, in all her height and pointy shoulders, look at her tiny tiny baby with huge round and sparkling eyes and a pout in her lips. It's kind of hilarious. Absently, Catra wonders if this is how Finn would look in Adora's hands.

Catra gasps, suddenly out of breath, palming her chest a few times very discreetly for Scorpia to not notice. When she finally recovers herself Catra clears her throat, digging her hands in the pockets of Adora's coat.

"Actually Scorpia, I need you to look out for Finn for a few hours". Scorpia raises her eyes to her, surprised. Finn's golden locks bounce gently when she leans closer to Catra with a concerned look.

"Wait, what?" Scorpia's eyebrows knit together, looking down at Finn and then back at Catra.

"I have to do something, *see* someone actually. But it's at the limits of the kingdom and I don't want to move Finn around and take them out of the castle. They need their sleep" explains Catra, raising on her tippy toes to brush her knuckles over her baby's face.

"See someone? Catra, what-" Scorpia sputters, her tail switching dangerously from side to side behind her, the pointy edge facing the ground the entire time and strictly away from Finn.

"Scorpia" cuts her Catra as softly and patiently as she can, rubbing the bridge of her nose between her fingers "Please, this is important."

Scorpia and Catra lock gazes for a couple of painfully long seconds, Scorpia curious and wondering and Catra sten and unyielding. In the end Scorpia drops her shoulders, sighing.

"Of course I'll help you wildcat", says Scorpia and her voice is still concerned and alert. She looks at Catra with pleading eyes, pressing her lips together as she thinks over her words. "I know you haven't given up. I'll look for Finn while you come back"

Catra exhales, a wave of relief falling over her. She rubs her fingers over the cartilage of one of Finn's little ears, grounding herself on its warmth and softness. "Thank you, Scorpia", Catra smiles softly to her, palming the side of her huge bicep with her hand. "You can wait for me in my chambers. Melog is there, they will keep an eye on Finn too. And if you need help just look for Glimmer or Bow. Finn just ate so they should be asleep until I get back, I won't take long".

Catra leans, placing a gentle kiss over her baby's forehead before letting herself fall back in her ankles and stepping away, allowing Scorpia to hold Finn's entire weight softly and sweetly between her pincers. She starts walking towards the door, her tail tapping softly over Scorpia's tight as to reassure her. Catra hesitates for a second in the way, turning to look back at them once more. Looking at Finn in Scorpia's arms and suddenly so far away sparks an uncomfortable and sour flame of anxiety and fear inside of her. For just a split of a second, the image of Adora standing beautiful and nostalgic in the middle of the yard, heart in their hands and love in their eyes before going away, flashes bright and painful in her mind. And then she blinks and Adora is gone and there is only Finnie's tiny hands wrapped over their mouth and their tiny feet peeking out of the blanket and Catra knows she has to do this. For them.

Catra's mind wanders, to a time not so long ago, in a winter wrapped in blankets next to a glittering queen that explained to her the meaning of a couple of words. There, in the darkness of a studio waiting with her breath held. For some reason Catra always seems to be waiting. She is tired of waiting.

Catra looks at Scorpia and smiles and somehow, in that moment, she feels Adora wrapped in her very bones. "Take care of each other, alright?".

Scorpia smiles and nods, easy. She doesn't understand the weight of those words. And it's alright, she doesn't need to. Catra smiles back at her, grabbing the doorknob between her fingers and opening the door. The warm breeze of spring receives her on the other side, ruffling the strands of her hair even inside the castle. There are sounds of life outside, people walking around, chatting among each other, the unmistakable smells of lunch coming from the kitchens, the sun casting shadows on the corridors and rainbows in the walls when it crosses the tinted glasses of the windows. Camelot is alive, wounded but still strong.

Before she can cross the door, a new thought flashes in Catra's mind, poisonous and festering, and she holds to the door with all her strength, tightening her grasp so much the delicate bones in her hand protest and her knuckles turn white.

"Scorpia?", asks Catra without looking back. Her fine ears catch the sound of Scorpia's head turning towards her once more, a wondering sound coming out of her mouth. "Have you had any new of Double Trouble?"

Scorpia sighs and her hair makes a soft sound when she shakes her head in negative. "Nothing at all since months ago, wildcat" Scorpia hesitates, shifting in her feet, "But I'm sure they are alright, so don't worry. You know how they are, always getting into drama for fun"

Catra's hand shivers, teeth clenching together and for that moment she considers again if she somehow didn't make a critical mistake. "Yes, I guess they do"

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Catra grips the roots of the huge trees that surround the clear and impulses herself, falling gently and elegantly over the lemon grass and the small white flowers scattered around. Catra stands straight, wavering just slightly over her feet. Her body is still out of her axis after Finn's birth, her body still carrying the remains of her pregnancy weight. Now without Finn inside of her, Catra stumbles just a little, limbs accommodating back into place with the sudden return of agility.

Catra huffs, looking at her sides to be sure she is alone and then up, towards the grey and green lonely tower that rises in the middle of the clear. It towers above her, almost overwhelmingly, casting its shadow over her like a cloud over flowers. Catra shivers, goosebumps traveling down her back once, twice, but she shakes her head almost sharply, clearing the fog of anxiety out of her mind and her eyes and her ears. She doesn't know how to do this but she must.

Catra walks forward, counting each step after the other until the rusty and puffed wood of the door comes into view. There is a small motion at the bushes in the sides and Catra almost jumps out of her skin but then there is a rustle and out of the leaves walks Razz, carrying an old basket full of berries, humming to herself in a quiet voice. Her back is arched like last time and her broom rests almost comically at the side of the tower, like some kind of cane or sword or both. She doesn't hear Catra or see her, standing there with her dark clothes and her hair free and her red eyes and her sore heart. She doesn't see her but Catra does and what she sees is exactly what she thought she would. And that is someone who has lived a thousand lives, someone who knows more than they thought, someone who can help her.

Catra bites her lips and steps forward, into the wild garden that grows there with its dozens of flowers and its berries. She does so gently, carefully, because after all this is now her family too and she doesn't want to scare her. Catra clears her throat, waiting but Razz keeps walking completely unaware of her presence. Catra sighs, looking up at the sky and then down, dropping her shoulders forward in surrender.

Catra is afraid. She is afraid to confront her own fear. All those feelings she has buried and locked away, that she doesn't allow to show to Glimmer or Bow or Scorpia and less than all to Finn. The guilt and the pain and the devastation. Catra has been torn into pieces and she hasn't even allowed herself to realize, to feel it. She doesn't want to but she has to because

Razz doesn't know and now Catra has to look at this woman who held her hand just once before and beg her, plead her. *Please, she is lost. Adora, my Adora. Help me bring them back.* Because Catra is lost too even if nobody notices and so just for one moment Catra allows it.

"Razz", cracks out Catra and it comes as a miserable whisper, broken and almost unintelligible. Razz keeps walking. Catra balls her hands into fists, her nails scratching her, asking without the gloves to stop the sharpness. Catra speaks loudly, ragged, desperate "Razz"

Razz does turn this time, frowning, a confusing look crossing her round eyes framed by the crystal glasses balanced in her nose. It takes a beat, then two but then she spots Catra standing there and her entire wrinkled soft face shifts, a delighted smile breaking in her lips.

"Catra!" Razz squeals, throwing her arms to the air. The berries in the basket come flying out, spilling all over behind her back and into the grass below. Catra jolts a little, gasping when Razz wraps her slender arms around her arms and squeezes hard. "My little girl, how pretty you are! Ah and look at you, I knew you would look absolutely radiant!"

Catra huffs, palming Razz in the back softly. She smells strongly like lemons and soap and something that reminds her of Adora. Catra blinks quickly, chasing a few errand tears away. "Hey, Razz. Is good to see you too"

Razz chuckles, parting from Catra's form to pet the top of her head and the base of her soft ears. The expression in her eyes is endearing, taking in Catra's entire face lovingly. Catra tries, she really does, smiling down at Razz with as much kindness as she can. It doesn't fool Razz, she must see something in her face or in the way her back seems to carry the entire weight of the world because her eyebrows knit together and her lips press in a thin line. Razz's thumbs rub circles over her shoulders and she clicks her tongue, narrowing her eyes with a worried look.

"Why are you so sad, my child?", Razz peeks behind her, eyes roaming through the trees that surround the clear. "Where is Adora, uh? I'm sure they will cheer you up!". Catra's breathing stops, air stuck in her lungs under Razz's words. She tries to speak but she can't, tongue tangled behind her teeth. Razz's confused look brightens suddenly and she claps her hands together, smiling from ear to ear. "Oh! They must be looking after your kitten, aren't they? Of course she is, she loves them so much"

Catra breaks. What else can she do? In fact, it is a miracle that she has managed to hold on for this long. The thick barriers that Catra has built around her heart snaps clean in half like dry leaves or thin ice, and Catra sobs. First is a tiny whimper, low, miserable, sad. Then is a full sob, bubbling out of her throat and into the mist that surrounds them both and the sound breaks the peace of the place. Even the birds themselves seem to quiet down. And then comes the full cry, ugly, broken, heart wrenching. The cry shakes her completely, filling the clear with the painful sound. It takes Razz by surprise because her eyes widen almost comically and she steps closer as she holds Catra's hands between hers, old and wrinkled and calloused. Somehow, the warmth coming from them just makes Catra cry further.

"Adora is not- Adora is-" Catra manages to stutter out between sobs, holding herself in Razz's hands with strength. Catra kicks the ground with force, frustrated by herself and the entire

clear shakes. "I lost her" finally spits out Catra and she is angry. Angry with herself, angry with life. Angry. "I lost her. I sent her to war and I lost her. I'm so sorry Razz, I'm sorry, it's my fault. Please help me"

Razz's hold tightens and she pulls gently from their arms to look better at Catra's face. She is tiny, sunk by age and time and the way she looks at Catra, with concern and tenderness, is so much like Adora looks at her that a new wave spills out if Catra's beautiful eyes and down her cheeks again.

"Oh, darling. It's not your fault, it's not your fault" chants Razz gently but Catra is already shaking her head with strength, her ears so low on her head they get lost between the wildness of her hair.

"It is! I shouldn't have let them go. I could have asked them to stay and they would have. They would have and if I had Adora would be here, they would be with Finn". Her baby's name brings a new thought in Catra's head and she takes a shivering breath. "You don't even know Finn. I've been doing all of this wrong and everyone keeps thinking I have it under control but I don't"

"Oh, don't be silly" cuts her out Razz, waving one hand in the air. "Of course I know about Finn, I told you, Adora loves them so much!"

Catra sighs, her fangs biting down in her tongue. She can taste the copper and the salt. A festering part of herself wants to shake Razz from the shoulders and scream but she knows how Razz is, she knows she doesn't always live in the present. Maybe her words are a good sign after all. Maybe not everything is lost.

"Help me" blurts out Catra. There are tears still stuck in her eyelashes and her throat is dry and sore so her voice comes out as a croak. "She is alive. *I know* that she is alive, I can feel it in my blood. I know- I know that Mara was so hard for you but Adora is still out there-"

"Mara?", questions Razz. Her eyebrows knit together and she looks around, suddenly confused. Catra's heartbeat peaks up, feeling how she skips away from her as the seconds pass. "Yes, Mara. My Mara. She is not here, is she?"

Razz looks behind her, down at the berries spilled in the ground. They look almost sad there, tiny and lonely. "She is not here and Adora is not here. *Oh.* This is that time, isn't it?"

Razz keeps muttering to herself, very low and under her breath and Catra can't even maje what she is saying, not even with her ears. Razz turns to the door, seemingly forgetting about Catra's completely, kneeling into the ground to pick the small fruits one by one and into the basket. Catra whimpers, throwing herself into her knees next to Razz. She sizes her delicate wrists as gently as she can, tilting her head to the side so she can see her eyes.

"Razz, listen to me. You are the only one who can help me. You know so many more things that people give you credit for. I *know* who you are. You have to do something"

"Oh my child" says Razz, raising her hand towards Catra's face, her soft and cold thumb running across her damp cheek. "I'm afraid there is nothing I can do."

Madame Razz stands up and turns her back to the Catra, berries forgotten in the grass, holding the rags of her dress and starts to walk towards the stairs that lead to the creaking door. Catra stands as well, her kneels and hands trembling. She let's out a sob. It's a small, quiet, heavy, painful sound. The kind of cry that freezes the blood and makes entire armies hold their breath. Another sob escapes her lips and then another because it's too much. It's too much and it's not fair. It's not fair. They have a whole life together waiting for them, barely even beginning. And they have a baby and Finn is so, so small, they have barely opened their eyes but Catra knows they will be crystal blue and silver, and it's not fair.

And Catra still hasn't told the real Adora, alive and warm and there, *there,* that she loves her back.

Pure raw desperation overwhelms Catra. She can feel her heart aching so deep it takes her breath away. It obligues her to step forward towards the moving figure of Razz, trembling from head to toe, voice raw like a thousand sharp crystals breaking into pieces.

"P- please" but Razz doesn't seem to listen to her and once she's gone through the door of the tower she will be gone for good and Catra will be alone. "Razz, please"

Here lies the truth.

There is a portrait in the library. Is old but not too much, beautifully done and carefully cared for. In the portrait there is a woman. Soft skin, neat dark curls, silver and purple eyes. She is beautiful and young, standing straight and proud. There is a small smile hidden in her lips and certain nostalgia in her almond shaped eyes. The woman is a queen, a regent, with a heavy golden crown in her head, a crown Catra has used before the day she was crowned herself, with Adora kneeled in front of her and a myriad of colors when the rest of their life together started.

Catra has seen that portrait countless times. Every time she walks calmly with a book in hand or when she curls in the seats beside the windows on a frosty night when Adora takes too long to go to bed. There is something about that portrait, something that has spoken to her since the first time she saw it. It reminds her of something, of someone. Someone she knows and loves and someone she didn't get to meet. It was a feeling that awoke the first time she was here in this lonely tower, with Adora's warm hand in hers. A hidden memory, a secret, kept to protect the last remains of older days. In the back of her head, Catra wonders why Adora never told her. She thinks that maybe Adora didn't know.

There is something sacred and sinful in the back of her throat, something that tastes like love and sorrow and rage and it grows tighter and tighter until it explodes.

"Queen Guinevere". Catra's voice resounds in the clear, powerful in her grief. Guinevere, Razz, a name with which Adora came to know her for their entire life, stops in her tracks. She doesn't move, nothing in the clear does. Nor the wind or the trees or the grass. The birds don't sing, the deers don't walk. Razz stays frozen in place, maybe by shock, maybe by memories. It's been a long time since anyone called her that. Not even Mara did and Mara is gone now.

Catra exhales, her breath becoming frost over her nose and cheeks. She hadn't noticed just how cold it had gotten. "Please. I know that you've suffered. I know that you've seen enough

for a thousand lives. I know that you lost your love and your best friend and your daughter. But please, help me" Catra's voice gets stuck on her throat and she gasps a few times before being able to speak again. Her entire body feels like it is shooting down. "I love her. Do you hear me Razz? I *love* her. This is not about Camelot, or Etheria or the war, or the plans everyone has for her. Fuck all of that This is me begging you because I love her and I can't imagine living in a world without them. I can't think of a life where I have to explain to my baby why their mom is not there. I know you barely know me, I know you have no reason to believe me but I speak the truth. I want him here and he deserves to be here. He deserves to be happy and loved too. So please, help me"

Razz turns, lifting the glasses out in order to rub the bridge of her nose and this way Catra can see the silver and purple. Mara's eyes. Suddenly Razz, Queen Guinevere, looks tiny, bent over herself with the weight of long years that don't come to an end. She's been there for everything, Uther's rage, Arthur's glory, Lancelot's death. She has seen her daughter, Mara, standing regal and wonderful, a new king brave and loyal. She saw Adora being born and helped raise them until years got the better of her and she chose to rest. She has seen magic and war, rebirth and destruction.

Razz saw Adora, ten years old, confused and sad, spending hours next to her as they searched without knowing something that they had lost. And now, as Razz places her glasses back, she sees another lost kid in front of her. She is still very young and she has been through so much. She lost her mothers, her kingdom, the person she loves. She is both a queen and a king, yes, and she is brave and magnanimous but she is also just twenty five. She is heartbroken and scared. She has just become a mother. She carries her motherhood as a second skin, as a sweet confort, as an iron strength. It reminds her of her Mara, just as young as when Adora arrived in the world. Just as alone.

Catra is stubborn and unrelenting, if Razz doesn't help her she will find another way no matter how much more pain it brings her. Razz doesn't want that. Razz wants for her family to finally find peace and if there is something she is sure is that they are the key and that they deserve it after everything they have gone through after everything they will go through. Adora can't do it without Catra and Catra can't do it without Adora. It has always been like these and it always will. Now more than ever. Razz knows these things because this is her gift and her curse. She *knows*.

"Of course I know you, dearie" whispers Razz in a thread of a voice and then, "You must find Merlin" she states. Her voice is clear, nothing like the high pitched squeal of delight or the vague murmurs of confusion. She is the present, in the now, looking at Catra with intense vivid eyes.

Catra jolts, surprised by Razz's sudden shift and because she probably didn't think she was going to answer her. Razz walks towards her, taking her cold hands against hers, brushing her wrinkled thumbs over the back of her hands. Catra's nails retract by instinct, holding herself in the woman's fingers with strength. Her heart is pounding inside her chest, so hard she thinks it may flutter out of her ribcage and into the ground, her blood flowing inside her ears in a hard rush. Razz's hands tingle and then the smallest of the sparks flicker between their joined palms, the glimpse of magic traveling up Catra's arms and shoulders. For the tiniest of seconds, Catra feels herself breathing.

"M-Merlin?" Manages to sputter out Catra. Her head is still spinning and her mind feels enveloped in that confused fog that has been menacing to drown her down for months now. Yet Razz nods and her eyes are sure and there, with Catra. "But I thought he was gone"

"Not everything that is gone has been lost. You of all people know that." Razz's eyes dig into Catra's soul and she feels herself bloom with a new hope because Razz believes her and she is helping her and maybe, *maybe* , after everything there is actually a chance to bring Adora back from wherever they are. "Merlin will know what must be done"

Catra nods, slowly, her ears still pressed hard and low at the sides of her head. One of Razz's hands untangles from hers, coming up and cupping Catra's cheek in her palm. Catra sighs in return, eyes still watery, fur on point for the goosebumps. Razz's fingertips are calloused against her cheek yet soft in the palm and her skin is warm. So close she smells strongly like the lemongrass that surrounds her home, a little tad like dust and a little bit like soap. Catra's breath is still cold and it shutters when she speaks past her clenched teeth.

"Tell me how to find him"

Razz presses her lips together and her eyes travel miles away from where they are now, as if she was reminiscing about something. Catra squeezes her hand, her tail nudging gently the side of Razz's old dress. The woman's eyes clear, just a little and when she looks at Catra next there is a wisdom in there that has no match. Her voice is sure and strong when she speaks.

"Follow the path that goes in the wrong direction" instructs Razz, never parting her eyes from Catra's. "It will take you where you must go". Something in Catra's mind clicks. She remembers a warm afternoon not so long ago, hand in hand with Adora is a magical place and suddenly Catra understands. She knows, of course she does. She now knows where to go.

"Thank you. Guinevere, I-" Razz shakes her head gently, wrapping her arms around Catra's shoulders in a soft hug. Is very gentle and sweet, enveloping Catra in a warmth and safety she hasn't really felt in way too many moons.

"Only Razz now, sweetie. Only Razz" Her hold around Catra tightness just a little, tucking the younger woman's face in the crook of her neck. "Bring our Adora back home, Catra dearie".

Catra nods against her shoulder, holding Razz against her in an almost death grip. "I will. I promise I will", she assures in a broken murmur. Razz smiles against the wild curls of her hair, petting gently the loose strands with her hands again and again.

"Fly high, C'yra Pendragon " Razz whispers. "Fly high"

❃

Catra's steps are muffled, the sound absorbed by the rotten wood in the walls and the freezing cold of the stones in the ground. Her tail lashes from side to side, restless but nos afraid. Her fur is on point and her ears twitch with every single sound no matter how little. The small

drops of water falling from the roof and into the ground, the creak of the heavy door when she pushes it open. There are no birds nesting here, no bugs or plants. Nothing grows here, not anymore, is almost as if something keeps life from being born here, as if something was here that wasn't supposed to.

Catra brushes her long braid to the side, careful of not messing it too much. Razz had braided her hair with gentle hands before she parted, keeping the wild curls out of her face, cleaning softly the heavy drops of tears with the sleeve of her old purple dress. And then she gave Catra a kiss on the cheek and patted her goodbye.

"You must go now" Razz had said and her eyes were heavy with years and longing and something that looked almost urgent. "And give that little kitten of yours a kiss from me" she finished and her smile was fond almost as if she was just realizing that that little soul was actually her grandchild.

Catra had returned almost in a haste, drumming her fingers on her sides impatiently. If she went now, who knows what would happen. Camelot was still in the eye of the hurricane. The Horde had been quiet after Halfmoon's Fall for way too long and Catra didn't like it. She hadn't seen Double Trouble or had any news from them and that only meant that there was still a traitor walking on her corridors, sleeping under the safety of Castle Grayskull. And Finn, Finn was so little and fragile yet it broke Catra's heart everyday they had to live without Adora by their side. They didn't deserve it, none of them did.

But there was a hope now, a path, a clue to follow. Razz, with all her riddles and her secrets, had given Catra exactly what she was begging for and she knew what it meant because she had been there. Because without knowing it, Adora may have given her the answers herself. Catra had one chance and there was no way in this life or in another where Catra wouldn't fight to bring them back.

As she kept thinking Catra found herself wandering, her feet following the familiar corridors and stairs of the castle with a mind it it's own. It was the drip in temperature that told her that she was in the lonely tower and Catra could blame it for a mistake but now she was thinking that if she had been right about some things maybe, just maybe, she was also right about others.

Catra circles the empty tower, for the first taking in the details of the chamber without running away. The walls are covered in wood, puffy for the wind and the humidity and the time. The floor is from the same stone as the rest of the castle, cold and biting. There is a ragged cloth dropped over one of the huge windows, partially keeping the wind outside, it's vibrant red now dim and dull. In the ceiling hangs an old chandelier covered in dust and spiderwebs, its blue crystals turned off for a long time now. There is no bed or wardrobe or table, nothing at all that indicates that someone has ever lived there but, if Catra looks closer at the frame of the door, she can see tiny dragons carved in its wood.

Catra sighs, heavily, closing her hands in tight fists at her sides. Her breath comes in visible puffs of steam, nose slightly frosty from the cold. She stands in the middle of the chamber, ears perked up, eyes narrowed as she drags her sight across the entire place.

"You told me to be careful," Catra says out loud. Her voice rings loud in her own ears, echoing in the empty walls of the chamber. No answer comes. "You know things. You know we were in danger, that we *are* in danger"

Again, nothing. Catra swirls in her ankles, her tail swishing in the air, curling and uncurling on its own as uneasiness starts to prickle her soles. She frowns, clicking her tongue against her teeth. "Are you not going to speak now? Is that how it goes? You give weird creepy ass advices but when I'm actually here you say *nothing* "

The tower is so high the calming usual sounds of the village don't reach it. The only thing Catra can hear is the heavy tud of her heart against her ribcage and her quick breathing. The weird feeling starts to rot, becoming sole anger.

"I've talked with Queen Genevieve, I know where I must go". There is a ruffle behind her, very soft, so little that anyone without her sharp ears wouldn't have been able to hear it. Catra holds her breath, worrying the skin of her lip against her front teeth. The ruffle repeats, this time right behind Catra and she can now feel the light presence of something standing there. "So of you have something to say you better do it now"

Catra inhales and then turns around in one swift motion, selling back immediately to take in the presence behind her. All the air in her lungs leaves in one rushed breath, her pretty eyes widening with surprise.

The white orb floats gently above the ground just at the right height to hover over Catra's face. It looks almost like mist, somehow wrapped together in a small ball, light twinkling in its very center. The orb moves, softly from one side to the other, as if addressing Catra's entire presence. It doesn't look threatening or dangerous, in fact it's almost calming, like a drop of rain or a seed of dandelions.

Catra gasps, her hand coming up unconsciously to touch it gently with the pads of her fingers. The orb throbs and pulls away slightly, escaping the touch of her hand quietly. Catra sighs, dropping her hand again. "Who are you?"

The orb stands still, not answering at all. The mist around it curls softly as if considering and then jolts to live, starting to circle Catra in slow motions. It's warm, Catra realizes when it floats closer to her, raising the baby hairs in her forehead and arms.

"I'm going to find Adora" states Catra and her voice doesn't tremble. The orbs' attention perks up, coming to stop in front of Catra once more. Somehow it seems to glow brighter in response. Catra presses her lips in a line, her nails biting her palms with how tense she is. "Tell me why I should be careful. Tell me what you know"

The orbs' light seems to dim just lightly, hovering for a few long, torturous seconds before shaking. It swirls on its own orbit and then crosses the closed door in one swift motion, passing through the wood and steel like it weren't there at all. Catra gapes, completely taken aback, before jolting forward swinging the door open with so much strength the joints protest.

"Hey! Where the hell do you think you are going? Come back!"

The orb is already waiting for her on the other side, floating just above the top of the stairs. Catra steps out in a rush, braid swishing on her back and her expression frankly annoyed. Her lips curl into a snarl, warning whatever this is to stop. But the orb ignores her and starts floating quickly down the stairs. Catra grunts, following the orb down the infinite steps, Catra is fast but the orb is faster and by the time she reaches the end the bright thing is already halfway in the hallway and then up into another set of stairs again.

It goes like this for a good couple of minutes until Catra finds herself at the top of another tower, this one warmer thanks to the torches of bright blue flame scattered across the stone walls. Is not until she is right in front of the door of the only chamber in the tower that she realizes that this is actually her room, with the Pendragon and D'riluth standard hanging from the wood and the rose carving on the frames. The orb hovers there, waiting for Catra to reach the last step. Catra pants, her fur standing on point. The orb swirls once more and then crosses the wood of the door, disappearing on the other side.

With her heart thundering inside her chest Catra grabs the doorknob and yanks it open almost violently, stepping inside her chambers with her heart held. The chamber is pleasantly warm, illuminated by the fireplace and a handful of pink crystals hanging close to the windows, reflecting shadows in the floor with the noon's sun. The chamber is very calm, the sounds of the town slipping through the open windows, completely different to the lonely tower she was just into. There is no trace of the orb, no mist, no sudden twinkle of a bell, no drop of temperature. Catra looks at each corner of the chamber but finds nothing.

Scorpia is sitting in the loveseat next to the balcony, the breeze allowing the smell of the fresh blooming roses there to enter the chamber. She has her knees bend, little Finn carefully placed over her legs so they don't roll or fall over suddenly. Scorpia's face hover over the baby, her expression contorting into funny charades every few seconds. Finn doesn't laugh or smile but their eyes are huge and vibrant, paying attention to each movement that Scorpia makes above them. Next to the door, Catra can see that Scorpia has tucked her own tail among the bushes, keeping the pointy end as far away from the baby as she can and the gesture calms just slightly the raising of her throbbing heart.

Melog, who had been tucked at Scorpia's feet this whole time, raises their head when they hear Catra bursting into the room, its magical mane changing colors from pink to deep blue and purple when they take in her agitated state. They meow softly, greeting her back with their tail waving against the floor rhythmically. The sound calls Scorpia's attention because she also turns her head towards Catra, her entire expression brightening like a candle when she sees her standing there.

"Wildcat! There you are" Scorpia says, cheerful as always but just low enough so her high pitched tone doesn't hurt Finn's ears. Finnie shifts in her legs, nibbling at their own tail as they turn blindly towards their mother's direction, taking immediately in her scent now that she is in the room. Finn chirps, loudly and happy, extending their tiny arms towards her. Catra sighs at the sight of them, extracting herself from the door she has been leaning into and walking towards them, her eyes still wandering in case she catches sight of the orb again.

"Scorpia? Did you see something go inside the chamber right before I arrived?" She asks her friend, trying to keep her voice steady. Scorpia frowns, looking to the sides with a confused glare and then shaking her head.

"No, not at all. It's just been me, Finnie and Melog", Scorpia's eyebrows frunce and one of the pincers comes up to scratch the base of her head, the other one still pressed next to Finn to stop them from slipping down. "Something like that, Wildcat"

Catra sighs, cleaning her Clancy hands against the fabric of her pants as she shakes her head, her shoulders drooping forward with defeat. "Nothing. It's not important".

Finn chirps again, loudly, trying to call their mother's attention right back to them. Catra smiles at them, her eyes and entire posture softening immediately. Catra reaches for them like a magnet, taking them gently from Scorpia's hold when the latter hands them to her. Catra carries them between her knowing hands, bringing them close to her neck and chest as she scent a long mark over their hair. Finn smells clean, with a fresh romper and tucked in Glimmer and Bow's blanket. Their hair is very soft and their hands are curled one over the skin of Catra's neck, the other one around something soft. On closer inspection Catra can see it's actually the small Adora doll she was gifted with so long ago. It's tucked between the wrinkles of the blanket and Finn's other hand, bringing a small nostalgic smile to Catra's face. "Everything good?"

"Oh, yes! Finn is a real angel", answers Scorpia excitedly, cradling her own face between her pincers as her expression melts. Catra nods, pressing her lips against her baby's head.

"How long have they been awake?"

"About twenty minutes? I changed their clothes! They are so little, it's so cute!". Catra hums at the excitement in her friend's voice, smiling down at her very gently while smothering the wild curls in Finnie's head with her hand. "Did you find what you were looking for, wildcat?"

"Something like that", answers Catra, rocking Finn from side to side. Finn yawns at her, clicking their tongue against their gums a few times as they scrunch their nose. They must be starting to get hungry. Catra boops their little nose with her finger, purring softly to her baby. "In fact, do you mind going to fetch Bow and Glimmer? I know Princess Perfuma and Entrapta are in Plumeria today but there is something urgent I want to discuss with you three"

Scorpia's eyes widen just slightly, pointing to herself with her pincer and asking in a small voice. "Me?"

Catra huffs, smirking down at Scorpia. "Yes, you" She pokes Scorpia in the sides, earning an incredulous look from her. When the seconds stretch and Scorpia keeps gaping at her Catra shifts her weight in her ankles, raising her eyebrows expectantly. "Um, Scorpia? So, can you go look for-?"

"Yes, yes!" Scorpia shoots to her feet, clasping her pincers together as she jumps lightly on her feet. Catra steps back on the carpet, allowing the tall frame of her frame to rush from the

balcony to the other side of the chamber. Catra laughs softly, watching Scorpia yank open the door and burst out before peeking her head back to exclaim a quick "I'll be back in a zap!" and then disappearing again. Catra can hear the rush of her feet down the staircase and also the small yelp when Scorpia trips.

Catra shakes her head, partially exasperated but fondly. Melog stands up from their spot in the sun, stretching their back completely before shaking their light blue mane and tippy toeing closer to Catra, rubbing their tiny head against the skin of Catra's bare ankles in a sweet motion. Catra bends a little, petting their head with her fingers in greeting.

"Did you see that orb, Melog?" She asks them. Melog looks back at her, blinking slowly and waving their tail in the air. Other than that, they don't seem to give her any indicator that they know what she is talking about. Catra huffs, ruffling her bangs out of her face, frustrated. "I'm not crazy. That thing is around her, keep an eye open Melog"

Catra picks up a second blanket from the headboard of her bed, draping it over her shoulders and Finn, cuddled in the space between her neck and her jaw. She hums gently to Finn, absently hoping for Scorpia to not take too long in finding Glimmer and Bow. She needs to tell them everything, about Razz, about the orb, about her hopes of finding Adora. She will need their help, looking for Camelot while she is gone because she will go, she and Finn, and she will drag Adora back from whatever self sacrificial void she had gotten themself into.

She is about to take a seat when there is a rustle in the corridor outside and the door opens again. Catra's ears flicker at the sound, turning around in time to watch Scorpia walk frantically back into the chamber. Catra frowns, confused, unconsciously holding Finn closer to herself.

"Scorpia? It hasn't even been ten minutes." Scorpia takes on her figure still next to the window and walks slowly deeper inside the chamber. From closer inspection, Catra can see that she is actually limping slightly, her entire weight hovering onto her right side. Catra's breath hitches in her throat and she steps back even further. She looks around swiftly, considering her options. The balcony is open at her back, the study room's door ajar, the bed at the left and Scorpia at front. Finn is still in her arms. Melog jumps forward, narrowing their eyes as they press their ears to the back of their head, a low hiss starting to form on his throat. Outside, the village has gone frighteningly quiet. Catra gulps, inhaling and exhaling a few times before speaking again. "What 's going on?"

Scorpia stops at the foot of the bed, looking at the ground with hooded eyes and then collapses to the ground, avoiding the hit by holding herself to the bed frame. Catra gasps, unconsciously taking a step in her direction. And then Scorpia's entire body convulses and starts to shift, her expression and limbs changing in a cloud of black dust. The tall frame shrinks just a little, strong arms becoming skinnier and longer ones, white hair growing as it fades into yellow. The pincers disappear into long fingers, red clothes shifting into black and gray, the fair skin turning a soft shade of green. The figure looks back at Catra and they are not Scorpia's eyes anymore, but a pair of reptilian ones narrowed in visible pain and distress.

Catra's breath leaves her lungs in one blow and she approaches the shapeshifter in quick steps, sizing them by the elbow and helping them up in one swift, strong motion. "Double

Trouble" Catra exclaims, holding basically their entire weight with her free hand "What the fuck-?"

Double Trouble groans, holding Catra's hand for support as they torturously slow straighten up. "Scorpia is the main hall. I had to shift into her to pass the guards" they wheeze out, pressing one hand to their sides. "I didn't know where you were but then this- this light appeared and guided me here"

Catra's heart jolts in her chest and her head spins while Double Trouble fights to recover their breath. Catra's emotions jump to every side, conflicted and confused but she pushes it all down with unthinkable strength and she shakes Double Trouble by the arm, suddenly furious.

"Where have you been?!" Finn stirs in her neck, partially awakened by the abrupt change in their mother's tone. "Do you even know what happened?!"

"I know, I was there!" Exclaims Double Trouble, all energy returning to their limbs. They spin in their ankles, grabbing Catra by the upper arms and locking their gazes together with urgency. "Now listen"

"You were there? You were *there?* You knew that Adora-" Catra's voice hitches painfully and she snaps herself away from Double Trouble's grasp, balling her free hand in a tight fist by her sides. "Tell me what happened. Tell me why the fuck did you wait so long to come. Tell me!"

Double Trouble flinches, rubbing the side of the ear, uncomfortable by the sudden yell. They trip a little with their feet. That's not normal. Catra looks at them intently, scrunching her eyebrows together as she takes in their entire figure. It's then the first time Catr realizes the huge bruise that travels from their left eye across their entire cheekbone. The cartilages of their left ear are scratched and they are walking with an obvious limp. Catra looks at their shaking hand and sees raw bruises, purple and red around their wrist. "What happened to you?"

"She got me" exhales Double Trouble, passing a shaken hand over their hair. "She got me before I could even reach the medical bay. I don't know how she knew but she was there and she imprisoned me for months. And then she just- let me go and I knew she had done it"

"She?" Repeats Catra, shaken to the core "Shadow Weaver?"

"No! Catra, you were right, there is a traitor here and that's why I need you to listen to me" Double Trouble grabs Catra by the wrist, firm but not hurtful, spinning on their ankles as they look for something. They seem to find it because they lean, still holding Catra's hand, and grab Adora's satchel, still hanging by the back of the vanity chair. Then they turn again, grabbing a handful of Finn's clean clothes, the little ragdoll and other small things into it. Catra goes still but Double Trouble doesn't pay attention, pulling from her wrist from one side to the other. Catra grunts, planting her ankles on the floor to stop the movement. The sudden stop makes Double Trouble yelp, turning their head towards her in surprise.

"Who?" asks Catra between her teeth. There is bile pooling in the back of her tongue. "Who is it?"

"Catra!" Yells Double Trouble, exasperated. "Pick up your baby, grab a horse and run as far as you can from Camelot."

Catra snaps her wrist out of their grasp almost violently, rubbing Finn's back as she steps back. "Do not give orders to me! Answer what I'm asking you"

"Listen Catra! There is no more time! She must already have done it. You need to get out of here! Now!"

"Do what?!"

Outside an acute sound breaks the air, up and up like a firework. It hovers, just for a second, and then explodes with an empty sound. The wave travels across space, from the very ends of Camelot all the way to the depths of the earth. It crashes against the castle, an invisible force hitting stone and greenery so fast and hard it shakes it to its very pillars. The people inside yell in surprise, falling to their knees, dust falling from the ceilings and showering everyone is white and grey ash. There is a second whistle in the air and then another wave crashes right into the royal tower, cracking with the strength of a thousand lightning bolts

Catra gasps, stumbling with the force of the impact. Double Trouble shots forward, catching her before she can even get near to hit the ground. Catra holds Finn tighter to her chest, her baby whimpering against her neck suddenly wide awake and distraught by the harsh sounds.

"What the fuck?" exhales Catra, holding Double Trouble's hand with vice grip. Her hair and clothes are a mess, painted in gray debris. Melog tangles in her ankles, hissing loudly and menacing to whatever is in the outside of the castle. The sounds and hits have ceased, heavy and sticky silent falling over Camelot.

"Catra, we have to go", urges her Double Trouble, crossing their arm over her waist and tugging her as gently but urgently as they can to the door. Catra nods, ears ringing, heart still in shock, tucking the blanket neatly over Finn's body.

She barely has time to throw a last look to her room, to her and Adora's and Finn's room, before that same sizzling tone fills the air again and then a new sound washes over Camelot like an unstoppable omen of doom.

" *Queen C'yra* " Emperor Prime's voice resonates on the entire castle. " *So good to finally meet you* "

End of chapter XI

Chapter End Notes

OH WE ARE STARTING WITH A BANG!

See you next update December 12th for Ch12 Viper’s Tongue. You can scream at me in the comments. Love ya!

Chapter 13: Viper’s tongue

Chapter Summary

> “ You could leave now, Queen C’yra! You and yours could live in a new world, a purified world free of the plague these false rules represent. Just allow me to get rid of the Pendragon legacy once and for all ”
> ...
> “Though, I now understand that dearest Adora wasn’t the last of them, was she?”

Chapter Notes

> Hello, hello, helloooo and happy Sunday!
> Are you scared? Good. We've come to the real start of the war. Today we will dip into the Horde's plan. Today war knocks on Camelot's door.
> WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER: Mentions of violence, minor wounds, attacks to the city and the castle. Mentions of threats and strong language.
> Gosh! This chapter was both so hard to write and so exciting to post! Many things will be revealed today. So! without much wait, seeee ya downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CHAPTER 12. Viper's tongue

So love is a window halfway open

and begging for geraniums.

So light exists only in her fist,

crammed & mourning in my throat.

— Topaz Winters, *Portrait of My Body as a Crime I'm Still Committing*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x x x

✾

Catra sprints down the staircase at full speed. She jumps elegantly but frantically the steps, three at a time, falling softly over her ankles before resuming her speed. Her tail lashes behind her, from one side to the other, nervously, anxiously, the only give away of her actual

fear. Her hair is a mess, curls freed from the tight braid falling in every side, silk darkness mitted in grey ash and white dust. Her face is smudged in dirt and mud and tiny scratches from where the small rocks of the walls catched in her skin when they shook like flower stems. Adora's wedding coat, still draped over her frame, is dusted and wrinkled, just as her pants and the black shirt underneath. The silver bracelets in her ankles and the round earrings in the cartilages of her ears, twinkle lightly with each movement, too sweet for the time being.

Finn is cradled over her chest, wrapped safely, tightly and expertly with a long piece of Adora's old red cape, the fabric crossing Catra's shoulder and waist and knotted strongly over the base of her spine. They are awake, eyes closed, ears perked. The movement doesn't bother them too much, used to being carried by their mother everywhere even at such a young age. Still, their tail curls over one of their tiny chubby legs and they hide partially their face between their tiny arms, nose buried in the fabric of their mother's shirt.

Melog is running right behind them, their mane a deep shade of red, eyes blue bright against the darkness of their fur. Their back is raised on point, ears pressed on the back of their head, tail lashing in every direction and a low but menacing growl escapes their throat every time another electric punch hits the castle to the core. They brush against the soles of Catras feet when she jumps, following close behind. For some reason, every time Catra looks down to them she thinks they get bigger and bigger.

Double Trouble leads them, pushing through the limp coming from their very obviously twisted ankle. Their yellow hair is drenched in black debris and they hold themself tight against the stone walls as they make their way together across the infinite hallways of the castle. Catra tried to help them, aid them on their wounds but Double Trouble just pushed her aside, hanging the satchel from their shoulders and pulling her forward while they escaped the tower.

The four of them cross a corner and come face to face with the gates of the kitchens. They are empty, pots and plates abandoned in mid use, stoves and fireplaces still on. Outside of the castle Camelot is somehow quiet. There are no screams or steps of people running around, no tells or defensive hits, nothing at all. Even as the hits keep coming, Camelot remains silent, still cocooned inside the protection of the still working barriers and nothing makes sense at all. The group stops, bending over their knees so they can catch their breaths. Catra looks at Double Trouble, leaned over themself with a hand pressed over their side, panting.

"Dee, talk to me" Catra says, panting. Double Trouble looks at her, grinding their teeth together in mild pain. Catra approaches them slowly placing one of her hands over their shoulder, black nails against pale green skin. She focuses, hard, knitting her eyebrows together as she fixates in her own magic, traveling from the center of her chest up her hand and down Double Trouble's shoulder, all the way over their body. The shapeshifter gasps and then relaxes, the bruises and cuts healing further, the twisted ankle getting better. Is not perfect but it's something. Catra gasps, suddenly tired and she squeezes Double Trouble's shoulder tighter, nudging them to look at her face. "Who did this? Who did this to you?"

Double Trouble's eyes are hooded when they turn to look at her. "Uh-" they say and then stop completely.

Their eyes widen inside their sockets, shock and sudden panic drawing over them. They try to speak again but somehow no sound comes up except an overwhelmed gasp and a low whimper. Catra shots forward, grabbing them by the neck to look at them closer, her own eyes frightened. When she brushes her thumb over their jaw she can see that their teeth are locked together, so hard they grid one against the others, chipping the tips painfully. Catra gasps, rubbing the place where their jaw joins their maxillary, nudging it with small bursts of healing magic. It takes a few good couple of minutes but finally their harsh lock breaks and Double Trouble gasps with the rush of breath, panting heavily next to Catra who does her best to support their weight in one of her sides.

"What the fuck was that?" inquiries Catra, filled with concern. Double Shakes their head, rubbing at the base of their throat with one of their long hands.

"I think she cursed me" their eyes turn to her, frantic and scared. "I- I can't say her name. I can't even give you a fucking clue of who she is. I think that might be why she let me go, because she knew I wouldn't be able to say anything any way"

Catra's hands shake, her heartbeat raising impossibly inside her chest. Double Trouble looks at her with apologetic eyes, a frown in their lips, their hair in complete disarray. "I'm sorry Catra, it hurts"

"It's alright. It's not your fault" says Catra, shaking her head. Melog is passing from one side to the other, looking closely at the door.of the kitchen as they wait for them to recover their breaths. When Catra glances at them she can see they reach the edge of the table, big eyes shining so bright it dims the light of the candles around. It confuses Catra so much her head spins. Finn sighs in her neck, falling asleep, miraculously the only calm in the storm. "Tell me what you can, alright? Why were you on Halfmoon, Dee?"

Double Trouble nods, exhaling a few times. They grab the fabric of their pants between their fists, breathing deeply through their nose. Their voice is raspy and sore when they speak. "A letter was sent from Camelot a few weeks before Adora parted. It was marked as an official matter of the kingdom yet it had no royal seal or signature from you or Adora. I was spying on the departures tower at that time. I thought it was a good shot as any other, especially because I hadn't been able to find anything else, and oh it was a good one, darling, it was." Double Trouble passes their hand through their hair, slowly regaining their confidence as they speak. "The letter was directed to Halfmoon's Commerce Minister and it had the label of urgent in it. I didn't get to read it before it left but thought it was suspicious. You and your Adora are glued to the hip and didn't send anything without both signatures. And then, not even a month later, word came that the commercial and trade routes of Halfmoon were going to close under the management of that very same Minister"

"When I heard your Adora had announced they were going to go personally to supervise Halfmoon it was just a matter of me shifting in some skinny blonde haired knight from around here and slipping among the knight's caravan" continues Double Trouble, leaning over the counter of the kitchens. " *Nothing* happened during those two months. Nothing strange, nothing out of the ordinary. I followed the Minister every-fucking-where but he was just- lazing around and doing nothing. I thought I had made such a boring mistake" they clench their jaw, frustrated. "But the day of the attack, Catra, that day the Minister went to the

barriers. He gave the order to take them down under Scorpia's name. He stole her royal seal. And when the sorcerers did it he killed them, Catra, he killed them all. It was him, the- Camelot's traitor, Shadow Weaver, him, they planned it all."

"I think- I think they wanted you, Catra. I don't think they were expecting for Adora to go in your place" Double Trouble gasps, eyes widened and frantic. Their tail tangles over their leg, heavy breathes leaving from the frantic rise and fall of their chest. Double Trouble turns to Catra, their eyes apologetic, seizing her wrist with tight grip. "Adora saved my life. The Horde Soldiers were cornering people for Shadow Weaver to steal them away. One of them almost killed me, I would be dead without Adora. And I- Catra, they healed me. They healed so many and guided them to safety. They fought bravely. I tried to warned them, but I just couldn't reach them on time"

Double Trouble stops, looking at Finn, tiny and vulnerable, sleepy in their mother's arms. Catra's hands are shaking uncontrollably. She presses the heel of one of them over her eyes, physically pushing the tears back. It's one thing knowing and imagining what had happened, it's another hearing it from the mouth of someone who was actually there, so close to her love, so far away. Double Trouble trouble drums their long fingers over the elbow that carries Finn.

"You told them that day, didn't you?" questions Double Trouble on a low voice. Catra's eyebrows shot upwards, surprised.

"How did you know?" Catra doesn't think Adora would have gone around telling people. Not after everything, not after keeping it secret and safe for so long. Double Trouble shrugs lightly.

"There was an expression on their face that day, before everything went to shit. As if the world had just gotten a little bit brighter"

Catra whimpers a little, recoiling from her own feelings and the emotion in Double Trouble's voice. This is unusual, Double Trouble never gets like this, heartbroken. It seems wrong not hearing them being cheerful and sarcastic and dramatic. It shows just how much weight they are carrying with them. There are still bruises in their face and their hair in unruly and Catra feels a rush of rage towards whoever did this to them. Catra surges forward, wrapping her free arm over Double Trouble's shoulders, holding them tight against herself but careful of not crushing Finn's sleepy form against her neck.

"Thank you, for doing all this, for trying to help Adora. For enduring whatever this person made you go through." Catra narrows her eyes, looking at a void point just above Double Trouble's tall shoulder. When she speaks, it is between clenched teeth, rage pouring off her mouth like venom. "Whoever this is, they will pay, I swear. They will pay for everything they have done"

Double Trouble sniffs and nods, rubbing her back in soothing circles. One of their hands comes up and scratches Finn gently behind their tiny, tiny ear, chuckling when the little kitten starts purring almost immediately as they nuzzle further into Catra's neck, their sweet baby breath brushing her skin like butterfly wings. Double Trouble makes a funny sound, something between a laugh and a sob and a little bit of hysteria.

"I can't believe you actually had a baby. What the fuck, Catra?"

Catra laughs too, breathless, picking in their sides with her nails. "I know, I'm pretty amazing". Catra falls silent for a second, considering. "Did you know? That time when I asked you to spy on the Court, did you know?"

Double Trouble huffs with mirth, parting from her embrace reluctantly in order to weep the treacherous tracks of tears off their face. “Of course I did” they poke the side of her cheek with their finger. “You smell different, *sweeter,* and a bit citrusy. I would be surprised if any magicat in Camelot didn’t know about it even before you did”

Catra gaps at them, surprised, and then giggles. It's histerical and stupid and the world is falli g apart under their feet and yet she giggles because her entire life has been so fucked up but this is still her family and she loves them. She loves them all.

A new sizzling sound breaks the air outside the castle, cracking in the sky. Cara and Double Trouble hold themselves from the counter of the kitchen, waiting for the imminent hit. But it doesn't happen. The sizzling stops mid track and then dies down, Camelot falling quiet once more. And then a war horn goes out, right over the castle. The sound is powerful and profound, reverberating all over the kingdom, shaking it's core and it's very pillars, breaking the surface of the frozen abandoned lake down below. Double Trouble gasps, eyes widened, but Catra doesn't even look surprised, something much more like relief washing over her face when another powerful blow goes off. Double Trouble seizes her from the wrist again, tightening their grasp over the stachel.

"We need to get you to the stables" they say, gaze calculating. "I think if we get down the next corridors we can-"

"No we don't", says Catra, cradling Finn closer to her chest. She takes a loose leather strand and wraps back all her hair into a high ponytail, a memory of Adora's signature ones before Catra convinced him to let it loose or try other styles. "We need to get to the main hallway"

Dee looks troubled at her words, impatiently stomping in the ground completely exasperated. "What do you mean? Darling, didn't you just hear what I said? The Horde is here, right now, inside Camelot. You can't be here!"

"I know now shut up and listen". Catra takes the satchel from Double Trouble's grasp, going through the items inside it with quick glances. Calmly she turns around, taking a loaf of bread and cheese from the counter and saving it inside. Double Trouble makes an indignant sound, green spots in their cheeks. Catra rolls her eyes at them, tampering her own fear into fake annoyance. "Do you hear that? The horns?"

"The *war* horns?"

"Listen. They are not war horns. They are giving an announcement. It's letting the knights know they have to mobilize immediately with the people. We need to get to the main hallway because that's where the rest of the castle is going to be. We need to reach the aqueducts"

"The aqueducts" repeats Double Trouble, incredulous. They laugh, nerves on point, eyes going wild. "The aqueducts"

"Dee, Dee" calls Catra, seizing their chin between her fingers and turning their head to look at her eyes. Her eyebrows are raised, a tiny mischievous smirk in her lips tampered by anxiety. "They are not aqueducts, Dee, they are tunnels. Tunnels that go outside of Camelot and into the Whispering Woods in the track that goes to Brightmoon".

Double Trouble looked at her with big incredulous eyes, mouth agape. Outside the horn blew one more time, deep and strong. "How did you do that?"

Catra scoffs, placing her hands at the sides of her hips and crocking her eyebrows, a self-sufficient smirk placenta in her lips. "Because I'm *that* good" then her expression relaxes, into something more honest and also more troubled. "When Salineas fell, and then Halfmoon, I knew it would be just a matter of time before the Horde tried to attack Camelot. The Horde had attacked our main resource points when Salineas gate fell and then they isolated us in fear when they attacked Halfmoon, a direct blow to the heart of the kingdoms, to Camelot, was almost the logical next step. If Camelot fell then the war would be technically over. But Camelot, and Halfmoon, and Salineas, the kingdoms are not places, they are their people, that's what Adora always said. So I made a contingency plan with Brightmoon's regents and a handful of trustworthy knights. A plan to take everyone out before history could repeat itself"

"The Horde has been relaying in surprise attacks. Taking us down when we least expect it. It has worked for them so they would obviously try it again. And when they take us by surprise we can't win. This, this attack happening today, is not a coincidence, Dee. Most members of the Round Table are not here for the first time in weeks. It's a Sunday so everyone is in their houses resting. *I* just had a baby" Catra gulps, her ears pressing low in her head, cheeks spotted in red by rage and indignation. "I hope I would have time to catch this fucking traitor but- it reached us sooner than I thought"

Catra takes a hold of Double Trouble's hand and pulls, through the kitchen and out the next corridor, this time leading the run through the castle. The shapeshifter follows her close behind, eyes still wide with astonishment.

"You see now?" yells Catra over the strong sound of the horns, entering through the tinted crystals of the windows with double force. "This is why we need to get to the main hall right now"

Double Trouble opens their mouth to say something but then their haze drifts towards something beyond the windows and they stop in their tracks, frozen in place. The sudden cease of movement takes Catra by surprise, who yelps when the stop pulls her back by physics. Catra turns towards them, ready to make some snarky pissed off comment and catches their gaze locked in the window, lips now pressed together in a sharp line. Catra follows their eyes almost reluctantly, looking outside too. The windows lead to the main yard. There, standing in long rows, formed tall and menacing are dozens of Horde soldiers. Their clothes are white and neon green, a striking contrast to the black and red of the roads standing even further behind, towards the town. This is the personal army of the Emperor, standing right outside Catra's door. They are all unmoving, spines straight, looks locked to the front

and from this point of view they almost don't look like actual people but like steel soulless armors that have taken a hobby of moving. Yet they don't, they remind in their places, patiently, eagerly. Waiting. They don't carry any visible weapons but Catra knows that they have them. She attended enough wounds in Adora's body to know so. The Horde standard hangs from high poles at their sides and the air doesn't blow but still the artificial fabric moves unnaturally, this way and the other, casting their shadows over Camelot's grounds.

Next to her, Double Trouble gulps, grimacing just a little when one last Camelot horn blows and the soldiers don't even flinch at the sound. "So, the horns-"

"They are not alerting the knights to prepare for battle" finishes Catra without being able to turn her gaze away from the windows of the corridor. "They are to let them know they have to take everyone out"

There is a new sizzle, this time low and menacing, prolonged so much it starts shaking the stones. This one is different, more like the threatening warning of a snake than the crack of a lightning. It digs itself into the very rocks, resounding in every wall ,mad floor and corner of Camelot, echoing like it was right in the room but also miles away. It's a sound that chills to the bone and scratches the muscle. The omen of devastation, of a storm, of tragedy.

“ *Queen C’yra* ” the sizzle turns into a voice and the a hum, sharp and venomous. Self complacent and mocking on its slow cadence.

Double Trouble gasps, holding Catra's waist and pulling her down with urgent tugs. "Fuck, *fuck.* Keep down, keep down"

Catra wraps her hands over her baby's body, scrunching below the beautiful windows and out of the way. Double Trouble places one long finger over their lips, silently asking her to be quiet. From the shadows of the corridor, the big and bright eyes of Melog look at the windows, alert and narrowed. Only their mane and eyes are visible, their long body hidden in the darkness. Catra's breaths are shallow, ragged exhales coming off her throat as she clasps one hand over her mouth, keeping any sound locked away. She and Double Trouble look at each with pale faces, unable to move at all.

" *Queen C'yra, please. Be reasonable* " sizzles again Emperor Prime. The hairs on the back of her neck stand on point, uncomfortably, and she has to double check the corridor with her fine sight to make sure he is not actually there with them. " *There is no need to make of this a tragedy* "

Catra closes her eyes tightly, spots of color flashing behind her eyelashes from the strong shut. Double Trouble's hand is tight in her wrist, breath held, most of their usual charm drained of their face. Outside, inside, around them, Emperor Primer sighs and Catra can almost picture him shaking his head in disapproval like a disappointed parent.

“ *The Pendragons are traitors, Queen C'yra. They claim to be pure and mighty just to keep magic for themselves. Don't let them deceive you* ” Double Trouble pulls gently from Catra's wrist and points to the end of the corridor when she turns to them, motioning her silently to half crawl half sprint out of the windows' view. In her arms, Finn stretches a little and yawns

in Catra's neck, their tiny eyelids closed in a fluttering sleep. “ *I’m sure you and your people are aware of how dangerous the Pendragons can be, isn't it* ”

Catra grids her teeth together, fury slipping in her veins hot and acid. She reaches the end of the corridor swiftly, pressing her back against the wall. Double Trouble scrunches before her, picking at the lock of the continuous door to try and swing it open.

“ *You could leave now, Queen C’yra! You and yours could live in a new world, a purified world free of the plague these false rules represent. A world where magicats aren't hunted down and murdered by the same people that now swear to protect you. You don’t have to pay for the Pendragon’s sins, Queen C'yra, Halfmoon has suffered enough at their hands. Even now, this king you plead so much loyalty to, this beacon of hope, has failed you. Has failed you all* " Catra holds her breath, biting down her tongue so hard she tastes copper and salt. The hand that is not supporting Finnie's weight is gripping the stone of the wall, holding it with so much force the stone crack with the strength of her barely contained magic. Double Trouble grunts and hits the lock a few times " *Just allow me to get rid of the Pendragon legacy once and for all* ”

"Dee hurry the fuck up" whispers Catra, nudging them with her foot. Double Troubles grunts and bats her away, pulling from the lock unceremoniously. The temperature in the corridor drops harshly, from the nice spring weather to the freezing chill of a winter. The war horns don't blow anymore, Camelot drowned in sticky, heavy silence except for the constant sizzling of Emperor Prime's voice, humming contemplative before saying.

“ *Though, I now understand that dearest Adora wasn’t the last of them, was she?”*

Double Trouble drops the lock and stops. Catra freezes in place, the world narrowing into a pin point and upside-down. The rush of blood in her ears hits stronger, making her dizzy and nauseated. The ground below her feet feels like moving sad below her feet, liquidity and almost threatening to swallow her whole. The shadows shift and grow, overtaking the length of the corridor, drowning the light that enters from the windows into darkness. Over her chest, Finn stirs and starts mewing, slowly but surely waking up and starting to go into a series of hiccuped, distressed sobs. Catra returns to reality almost violently, turning to her baby with her ears perked and her senses in high alert. She cooes at them, trying to lull them back to sleep, but Finn grips the strands of her hair and hides their tiny face in the crook of her neck, meowing sadly as they curl impossible tight in her hands

“Shh, it’s alright sweetie" whispers Catra, pressing her lips over their tiny ears. On the floor Double Trouble recovers harshly from their own astonishment and picks at the lock again, hardly but surely tugging from it until the wood starts to crack. Catra looks at them with wide, sudden frightened eyes, rocking Finn from side to side with sweet but almost frantic whispers. "Go back to sleep, my love, please go back to sleep”

" *Just give me the baby, C'yra* "

"Dee!"

"I'm doing it, shut up!" Double Trouble stands in a rush, purposely and directly kicking the door with their entire strength.

In the end of the corridor the shadows give a tug and then *pull* over themselves, rising and bending this way and the other until it looks like one great wall of goo, sticky and overwhelming, advancing towards them quickly. Emperor Prime doesn't speak again but the sizzling transforms into a low laugh, dark and mocking that shakes the stones of the warm as the shadow slowly draws the corridor in silence. Catra gasps, eyes wide open like a deer in a haunt as the shadows stretch like abnormal arms towards her a chilling breeze blowing her hair behind her back and swallowing all other sounds in the reduced space of the corridor. Catra is absently aware of Double Troubles hitting the door with violent force, the wood trembling and slowly but surely giving under the pressure. Finn shifts, their tiny hands curling over the skin of her collarbones, sniffing sadly and confused and suddenly Catra jolts back to life, the air leaving her lungs, her teeth clicking together with a strong thud.

She bends her shoulders forward, covering Finn with her neck and head and hair, baring her teeth and fangs dangerously to the relentless mass of darkness. The ground below Catra's feet shakes violently, small rocks floating gently around her. Catra exhales, dense fog leaving her mouth in a cloudy puff. Her gem-like eyes flash for a second, purple slipping into her irises and scleras like liquid crystal, painting lightning veins of amethyst over her cheekbones and eyelids. The air around her shifts and bends and from the cracks in the ground rises a thick dome of raw magic, casting its light over them as it pushes the shadows again. The shadow seems to hiss, hovering over the dome a few times before crashing against it with so much strength Catra gasps, her knees bending just a little against its force.

Catra grunts, pushing against the invisible force with her own magic as the hinges of the door bend over themselves, the door giving up against its own weight and snapping in half. The shadows crash against them one more time, so violent it catches Catra by surprise and the light shield blinks for one instant, one of the tentacles shooting forward and catching her bare ankle for just one second before retreating again behind the magic shield. Catra shierks against the blinding hot sensation of the tentacle against her skin, biting her lip hard with her teeth to drown out a pained yelp as she keeps pushing with her free hand against the shield. From behind her, by her feet, something shifts against the shadows and then a long figure sprints forward, crossing the magic wall as if it was water. Catra stares with her heart in her throat as Melog lands softly over their feet, staring right back at the black mass with sapphire eyes. A second passes and then, too quickly to even blink, Melog shifts over themselves, their lean form growing and growing, lean legs into powerful paws, elegant face into a strong and wide one, their mane and the waves of magic on their tail shifting from side to side in deep red colors. The panther looks back at the suddenly still darkness, dropping into a defensive position before roaring so high and strong Catra's ears ring with the sound.

The darkness trembles with it retracting on its own track by several feet and shrinking. Catra gasps, barely blinking towards her cat, panther, still scrunched in front of them and their big nuzzle almost seems to flame with purple fire. The shadows shriek high pitched and hurtful, snapping to the sides before rising so high the crystal chandeliers in the high ceilings crack and fall to the floor, the sound drowned among the waves of darkness. The shadow flinches back and then throws itself forward and towards them, its tentacles sharp as knives and swords. Behind them, the door finally gives in, swinging open with the force of one last harsh kick from Double Trouble. The shapeshifter doesn't waste a single second, wrapping their hand on Catra's upper arm and yanking her inside the dim lighted room on the other side. Finn meows softly, shaken by the harsh movement and the shadows outside seems to

convulse violently at the sound of the baby's cry, crashing with force against Catra's magic shield. Melog jumps out of the way just in time, slipping their huge frame inside the room and curling themself around Catra's legs, their head so high it brushes against her elbow. Double Trouble kicks the door back shut just as Catra extends her hand, casting a strong.locking spell against the wood. The door shimmers in purple and golden, shaken by the force of the shadow crashing against it but it doesn't open or crack and after so long minutes it relents completely.

Double Troubled exhales, leaning against a counter and knocking several books in their way. It's then that Catra realizes they have actually gone inside one of the multiple doors of the library and that they have gotten in fact very, very lucky. Catra shifts her attention towards Finn, fumbling with the blankets that wrap them over her chest until their lovely tiny face comes into view. A pair of round, beautiful blue eyes look back at her, blinking very slowly and teary. Their chubby hands have come to curl around their mouth and there is a prominent and obvious pout in their lips, wobbling as if the baby wanted to burst into cry any second now. Catra smiles back at them gently and as reassuring as she can, brushing her knuckles over their peach soft cheek as she mrps and purrs at them, a small smile waving in her lips. Finn blinks, eyes watery and nose scrunching sadly in that way that is so much Adora, and Catra hushes at them softly, lovingly, pressing butterfly lips over the fine golden hair of her baby's head and she can barely believe they are only three weeks old and already running for their life. It boils her blood.

A soft but heavy sound approaches them and when Catra opens her eyes again she sees Melog, in their new huge dark and imponent panther form, walking towards them. Their ears are lowered down and their mane floats gently around their immense head in a soft color. This way, Catra can see them clearly for the first time. This is her cat, the one that has been with her through thick and thin since she was eight years old, in the limits of her memory when her childhood becomes fuzzy and confusing. They may be bigger, yes, but it is still them.

Catra smiles at them, tiny, but the action seems to nudge them forward because Melog's ears perk up and they hop happier next to her placing themself right below her right elbow where Finn's little head rests. Melog sniffs the baby's hair before nudging their nose softly over it, purring loudly. Finn sneezes a little, rubbing their hands over their nose as they sniff right now and the little tears in their blue eyes seem to finally cease. Catra sighs, stretching her hand to scratch the dark fur of Melog's big head, scoffing without ill towards them.

"Any other thing you want me to be aware of?" asks Catra, smirking at her panther. Melog looks at her intently, intense and without blinking, grumbling low in their throat. Catra's eyebrows shot upwards in her forehead, her mouth falling agape. "Melog? Anything else you want me to be aware of?"

Melog's tail bumps in the floor heavily but they remain silent, only their ears flickering every once in a while. Catra is about to insist when Double Trouble's own smacks her softly.in the ankle, calling back her attention without stopping looking at the door.

"We need to get out of here, darling" says the shapeshifter, running their long fingers through the knots of their yellow hair in an attempt to tame the bird nest down. "This is your castle,

which door to the main hall"

"None", answers Catra, pressing one last kiss on Finn's head, basking in their clean smell of roses and lavender before wrapping them back over her chest. Double Trouble throws her an exasperated look as she walks towards the huge portraits of the old and new Camelot regents in the walls, their foot tapping impatiently in the floor.

"None?" repeats Double Troubles, crossing their arms over their chest with a snarl in their lips. Catra approaches Mara's portrait, turning just a little towards the shapeshifter as she fumbles with something in the painting's frame.

"None" Catra finds the small button hidden among the wood and presses it easily, stepping back just a few feet to watch the portrait back. Behind the painting, in the wall, something screeches and then snaps and then the painting's frame moves upfront and to the sides, opening to a passage hidden behind it. It's dark and long, curving a few times until it disappears from sight. The air inside is warm, heated by the few blue torches along the stone wall. Catra smiles, self satisfied, turning with a raised eyebrow to the astonished expression in Double Trouble's face.

"What the-"

"There are secret passages over the entire Castle" explains Catra. "They cross all the main chambers and some rooms, up and down. Nobody has use them since the Great Purge in Uther's time but it seems Entrapta found the blueprints when we first arrived here and had been fixing them for the last two years" Catra extends a hand in front of her, her eyebrows knitting as she cast a small orb of light in her palm, illuminating forward the corridor. "They call them vents, or something like that. I just found out a few months ago when Entrapta freaked me out by walking out of one of the secret corridors during dinner. After that they managed to direct the one in the main hall down the tunnels and outside Camelot"

Catra looks at Double Trouble, ready to step inside the corridor and catches the strange look they are giving her. Something between surprise and maybe even admiration. "What?"

"Did you really do all of this while being pregnant of Finn?" asks Double Troubled, walking with big steps next to her and eyeing the corridor. Catra flushes, her tail smacking them in the back.

"Did you really think I was going to sit there and cry for the rest of my life?"

Double Gives her a curious look, something that is way too close to pity for Catra's liking. "The love of your life died, Catra. Nobody would have judge you for crying"

Catra bites her tongue, swallowing down the bark of Adora being alive. She shakes her head harshly instead, looking at the darkness ahead with pressed lips. "I would have" Catra steps into the corridor, followed closely by Melog. Finn nuzzles in her neck, their tiny tail wrapping over their own belly, soft puffs of sweet breath against her skin. She throws a side glance to the shapeshifter still standing there, crocking an eyebrow. "You coming or not?"

❀

Catra, carrying Finn, Melog and Double Trouble burst out of the hidden door of one of the huge columns in the main hall, after walking down impossible narrow stairs and even colder walls inside the secret passages. There is a flow of people already there, hovering around an even bigger hidden door in the north wall. Their clothes are covered in fine white dust, hairs in disarray, some holding emergency satchels, others still holding random pieces of cutlery after being interrupted by the invasion mid-dinner. But besides this and the occasional missing shoe, the entire Court, castle staff and other villagers are healthy and safe, walking with rushed steps inside the dark passage and out of sight completely.

Catra navigates among the multitude with perked attention, holding Finn with one hand, the other one seized firmly to the wrist of an still limping Double Trouble, Melog still in their huge panther form following the trio close behind. The people gasp when they see the huge animal, moving to the side to allow them pass and gasping even further when they catch sight of their King and Queen, also covered in ceiling debris but as composed and regal as ever, holding in her arms the silhouette of their newborn heir. The people don't make comments or try to stop her to ask her a thousand questions, they have been explained by the knights about the evacuation plan when the Camelot army arrived at their homes and jobs. But they do keep silent, the chattering dying just a little.

Catra scans the sea of people with knitted eyebrows until she catches the characteristic glimpse of a pink glimmering hair and the thick curly bun that sprints right beside it. Glimmer and Bow emerge from in between the rest, gasping when they see Catra standing there and sprinting to her immediately. They bury her in a soft, gentle hug, mindful of Finn sleepy in her neck, but tight in the shoulders. Glimmer is silently sniffing at the side of Catra's head and Bow let's her head and Finn's ears with his big hand again and again. They stay like that for some seconds and then part a little, the two regents of Brightmoon quickly scanning their friend's face and body in search of any kind of wound. When they are sure she is fine, Glimmer sighs, throwing her arms once again around Catra's neck for another close hug.

"We've been looking for you every-fucking-where" Glimmer mutters, sorbing her nose. Catra chuckles nervously, pinching her lightly in the ribs.

"Oh, Sparkles, did you miss me that much? *Ouch"* Glimmer jabs her softly in the ribs, detangling from her embrace and shifting her entire attention towards Finn, soft pink light enveloping them as she checks them. Bow gives them a relieved smile, resting his hand over Catra's shoulder.

"Are you alrig- Holy mother of Etheria! Is that Melog?!" exclaims Bow, his eyes like huge plates as he looks at the previously house cat. Melog meows, strongly satisfied, sitting on the floor with a pleased but also serious expression on their regal panther face. Catra makes a positive noise with her throat, ignoring the myriad of questions about her newfound shapeshifter cat in order to check up the entrance of the passage.

Most of the people have already crossed, families and friends helping each other down the narrow and dark corridors of the so-called before *aqueduct* and over the long path that will finally take them outside of the limits of Camelot and into the Whispering Woods.

"I don't know, Bow, my mothers never told me" answers Catra, frustrated by the rain of questions. She turns fully to her two friends, motioning Bow into helping her carry Dee for the rest of the way. The King seizes the shapeshifter by the waist, supporting their weight with his side to aliviaré the pain in the ankle. "The village?"

"Evacuated, just like Downton and the Upper town. No falls so far" assures her Glimmer, watching too as the very last of the people walking inside the corridor.

"And the Horde? What about Shadow Weaver" Catra tries to ignore the way her voice cracks just a little at the end. Bow eyes are soft and understanding when he answers her.

"She is- she isn't doing anything. I know she has been scanning the kingdom for anybody she could find but we started the evacuation way earlier. By the time she arrived everyone was out"

"How did you know that they were here?" Catra looks as Bow helps Double Trouble to half jump half walk the first steps inside the corridor.

"Because we saw them. The Emperor's Army marched right inside the downtown like nothing. Shadow Weaver took longer to appear. She may not know it but she gave us enough advantage to put the plan in function" Glimmer says. Her hair is in disarray, pink shirt looks falling unceremoniously and curling to the sides. A new thought crosses Catra's mind and she spins towards the opposite direction, suddenly frantic.

"The Arcane Circle-"

"I destroyed it!" yelps Glimmer, stopping Catra in her tracks, when she looks back she sees Glimmer raising her right arm, purple ashes covering it as if she had stuck it inside a fireplace. Glimmer catches the stunned expression in Catra's face and giggles, nervously. "I sent my parents and people from the castle to Brightmoon so they would make preparations and then blow it out. I mean, I know I didn't stab it with a sword but-"

Glimmer trails out, expression suddenly souring. Catra exhales and turns to them completely. She is a bit far away now, closer to the main hall's door than the passage, Melog glued to her ankles as their ears twitch with every sound, alert at any strange movement coming from the door. Catra considers Glimmer in silence for a second, tilting her face to the sides, one eyebrow crooked in amusement. "You had fun didn't you?"

Glimmer turns all the shades of pink, sputtering in self defense before giving in and nodding, her eyes rolling so hard they might just fall away. "Yeah, it was so much freaking fun. I like blowing things"

Catra laughs, a little frantic and a little shaky, dizzy from the absurdity of it all. "How did I not hear the explosion"

"The horns covered it out. By the time the Horde gets there they will find nothing" Glimmer starts walking to the passage, her wings fluttering with the harsh wind. From inside the dark corridor, Double Trouble scoffs, still holding to Bow for dear life.

"If y'all have an Arcane Circle why don't you just use it to take everyone out? Without so much *secret passage* show"

"Because Arcane magic leaves traces. If the right person finds them they could be able to track them. But these passages? You can't track that, you can't track earth paths unless they knew exactly where they begin and finish which is why almost nobody knew about this. And once the last person has gone in they seal up completely" explains Catra. "Besides, I thought you liked some drama"

Double Trouble rolls their eyes and sticks their reptilian tongue out to her, opening their mouth to add something more. Over then the ceiling shakes once. Twice. Dust falling from the stones. And then, with a crack so loud it rings through the entire castle, the ceiling parts in two and falls.

Catra yelps, jumping out of the huge rocks way and outside of the chamber. Finn jolts away by the movement and the sound and starts crying, tiny drops of tears falling off their eyes and into Catra's collarbones. Melog jumps too, covering both of them with their huge body, curling around them as they act like a shield between them and the debris. On the other side, Catra catches sight of Glimmer throwing herself to the open mouth of the passage and the way she turns with an horrified face as she looks at Catra so far away. Bow holds her from the arm, his eyes wide with shock and horror. The last thing Catra sees before the rocks stop falling is Glimmer yelling her name and the passage closing in front of them for good.

By the time the rocks stop falling Catra is out of breath, coughing from the dust as she covers Finn with their blanket to protect them from the destruction. The baby's cry has subsided a little, but they still sob softly over Catra's neck, their ears flat in their head in fear. Melog uncurls from around them when they are sure no more things will fall, allowing Catra to take a proper look. The entire ceiling and the two floors above have collapsed completely, leaving the main hall in pieces. The rocks have crashed the floor, one over the other in an impenetrable wall of marble and stone. By some miracle, the wall that leads to the secret passage seems to have avoided the collision and remains intact.

As the dust settles and the silence falls back in place, Catra starts realizing for the first time that she is completely and utterly alone, with a newborn baby in her arms and a fallen kingdom around her. A shiver runs down her spine, from the very start of her neck to the base of her back, making the soft fur in her limbs stand on point. Melog sniffs the remains, snarling at them before turning around and nudging the side of Catra's face with their big nuzzle, their wet nose smothering the back of Finn's blonde hair. Catra exhales, inhales again, exhales once more, nodding to Melog's insistence as she starts standing from the place in the ground she had fallen into.

"Yes, yes I'm coming, Melog" Catra looks around her, taking in the corridors around her. The left one will lead her back to the library with no possible exits to take. The right one will take her through the throne room and then out into the gardens. There is one more passage there that could lead her out. Put that way, she doesn't really have to consider it too much.

Catra stretches her legs, holding herself into Melog's mane. There is an acute pain that tells her that she definitely rolled her ankle with the fall and every step sends a flame.of.pain up her leg and hip. Catra hisses, biting back a swear. That's not good, she relies strongly on the

strength and agility of her legs. Jumping, sliding, running. Catra huffs, giving a step and then another, ignoring the discomfort as much as she can. One of her hands holds Finn's bottom, the other one cradling their hair. Catra rests her cheek over their tiny head, sighing heavily. Tears are picking at her eyes, threatening to fall at any second and she has to bite hard in the inside of her cheek to stop breaking down. Melog walks beside her, nudging her in her injured leg to help her and motivate her to walk further. Outside the castle, everything remains calm.

Catra can see the start of the huge arc that leads to the throne room. The doors are wide open, most likely after the Court sped out of it when everything started. Melog walks in front of her, keeping the doors out of her way with their back. Catra walks inside the chamber with soft feet, eyes locked in the garden door on the opposite side. It must be this intense focus, or the pain in her ankle, or the attack to her only home left. Or maybe is the feeling of her newborn kitten, soft and vulnerable like a little peach, sleepy in her chest. It must be the way they look so much like Adora, with their blue eyes and their honey hair and their little pout. It must be that Melog is now a panther or that they have suddenly stopped frozen behind Catra, half hidden by the shadows, a snarl in their face and a loud menacing growl from their throat. It must be all of this because Catra's fine ears and her sharp senses fail her for the first time in her life and she doesn't take in the figure sitting on Adora's throne, his sharp and long white nails tapping over the wood as he looks at Catra walk with an amused expression in his cold face.

"What a cute little thing you have there" Emperor Prime states out loud. His voice is grave and strong, echoing in the empty chamber like a war horn.

Catra stops mid track, her heartbeat speeding up so much it feels about to explode inside her chest. She turns, slowly, facing Emperor Prime fully. He is sitting in Adora's place, the throne next to it and that belongs to Catra broken in dozens of ragged wood pieces. His posture is straight, sitting with one leg crossed over the other, his forearms resting on the sides of the King's throne. Everything on him is white. White hair in long dreadlocks held behind his head, white nails on sharp points scratching wood, eyelashes and eyebrows so pale they are almost invisible over his skin. His tunics are also pearl white, longs and flowing, metal pieces on his legs and arms. Is a different kind of white than the beautiful tone Catra has seen in Camelot, this is a white that hurts, a kind of light that if you look too long or too much it blinds you completely. And it's completely different to the kind of white light that accompanies Adora everywhere, that which is warm and loving and that envelopes Catra's heart anywhere she goes. It's the kind of light that Finn carries within, even so tiny and young as they are now, the light their mother inherited them out of raw and completely honest love. It's a light that she loves now threatened by a kind of light she hates.

The only spirit of color inside Prime's white is the bright green that bleeds inside his eyes, with the white pupil solid like a needle. And from Catra's place, a few meters away, she can see the double membrane inside his eyelids when he blinks. The eyes of a serpent.

Almost a hundred years ago, Anilis Kurr, a former loyal follower of Uther Pendragon, betrayed Camelot and broke his own humanity so magic didn't reach him. He knew magic existed within every living thing in Etheria and in his obsession for a clean, *pure* world free of any trace of it, Anilis Kurt almost destroyed himself subjecting himself to the most

torturous of procedures in order to become souless, only his mind surviving. For many years he was on the edge of destruction but his research on the artificial saved him, by making himself a mechanical artificial body devoid of any kind of organic trace that would allow magic to latch itself to it. His machinery was the reason he had kept alive for so long, terrorizing the world for generations. Merlin, as a last act of benevolence before disappearing, built the barrier around Camelot, hiding it away from the now called Prime and any other enemy of magic allowing like this way that only trustworthy members knew the location of the kingdom. By considering magic wild and impure, the self proclaimed Emperor still wants to erase all living things from Etheria, making everything mechanical and cold and dead as him sitting in that hollow throne, looking at Catra like the falcon that got the cat.

Catra steps back, just a little, not so much to run away. She can't go back, she has to cross the chamber and fuck off or she won't have any more chances to escape. To save Finn. The palms of her hands tingle, purple sparks starting to form in the tip of her fingers. Her own back straightens, head high and proud and even though she looks so small compared to the huge frame of the Emperor, for those moments she looks taller and stronger and powerful. Even covered in dust she looks like the Queen and King she is, cradling her child with her hands, her eyes shimmering in purple for the flash of a second. Melong has retreated completely toward the shadows, out of view, only the sound of shifting and grave growl behind her and it sounds so strange but Catra can't turn to them, not now. Catra shifts her hand over Finn's head, trying to hide their little face away from the prying eyes of the serpent usurping her love's rightful place. The movement works but it doesn't go unnoticed by Prime, who's sly smile widens satisfied, one of his hands holding his chin with fake consideration.

"Ah, blonde hair of course. Those Pendragons, always with their golden aura, don't they?"

Catra doesn't answer, lips pressed together in a firm line, so tight they turn white. Her ears are perked up, the golden earring in them twinkling when they twitch, looking for any sound. Finn is weightless in her hands, just a warm bundle of blankets and blonde tufts of hair, sleepy in her arms. Melog is still nowhere to be seen but Catra can hear the sharp scratch of their nails over the white marble in the floor and somehow she thinks it sounds bigger. Her ankle is killing her, waves of sharp pain flashing up her leg and threatening to make her stumble down yet she remains tense and regal like a violin cord, not giving away at any second how scared she really is. Her hands keep tingling, magic building up. Catra breathes deep, slowly, and is then when she throws a quick glance down and she realizes the floor is actually wet.

"Say, Queen C'yra, where is your people?" Catra narrows her eyes, a sour expression falling over her face. Prime tilts his head to the side, resting his forearms over his legs as he leans forward. Somehow he seems to almost cheer up at Catra's defiance. "Oh, you are a very smart young woman, aren't you? I can say that I'm even impressed. Wouldn't have thought that you would go for the smart choice instead of running off to war like everyone else" the Emperor leans back into the rest of the throne, drumming his nails over the wood. "Certainly different to your Adora's approach"

Catra clanks her teeth together so hard she almost feels the chip over the pressure. He is trying to get a rise of her, she reminds herself over and over, she can't allow to lose her nerves

right now. Prime sighs and with the motion, a hidden tube on his shoulder blades that Catra hadn't seen before let's out a puff of hot steam to the air. Prime's joints creak just a little when he moves but his tone is as condescending as before.

"It's a pity I did not get to meet dear Adora in person. My condolences are in order of course, young Majesty" he says, bowing his head towards Catra without stopping smiling. "Though, if I had known that threatening *you* in order for Adora Pendragon to fall was going to work so well I would have listened to Shadow Weaver so much sooner"

This time, Catra does gasp. The air on her lungs leaves on one blow leaving her speechless and shaken. Finn shifts, suddenly distraught, one tiny and sad meow leaving their mouth as their little nails knead in their mom's neck for comfort. Catra rubs their neck and head, rocking them very softly from side to side to lull them back, wrapping them well over her chest to hide them away from the serpent's gaze.

Emperor Prime's eyes flash dangerously when they see them, something poisonous and letal boiling in them. Catra is trembling, cold sweat stuck to her forehead as she holds her baby closer and locks eyes, defiant, with his.

"You Etherians are so *predictable"* mutters out Prime, savoring the world on his silver tongue, chewing them and spitting them out to the air around them. A sour, metallic smell hits Catra's nose and she has to hold her breath to not convulse in revolt. Prime never looks away from her and Finn, looking up and down her figure, his tone light and almost cheerful as he keeps explaining himself. "Oh, yes. She told me everything about you two. How the Golden King fell to his knees for you in the beat of a second. How he was loyal to you to the very end. How you sent him off to his perdition" Prime smiles "How you two were glued to the hip, how you used to follow young Adora as a shadow across Halfmoon when you were kids"

Catra's world narrows to a pinpoint. She can feel the weight of Finn in her arms, the drum of magic coming from Melog behind her, somehow immense and impotent. She can smell smoke and far away she can hear the Horde Soldiers setting the town and the castle on fire, green flames consuming wood and rock and steel the same. She can see the barrier of Camelot, still up but failing. She can hear and feel it all and yet her world has been reduced to that simple and cruel sentence and she can't move anymore.

"Ah, of course. You don't remember anything of that. Your mother made good work of that" continues Prime and his tongue drips venom.

"You are lying" Catra hears someone say and it takes her a second to understand it's her and a second more of pride to hear how her tone doesn't shake and doesn't show just how much she wants to scream.

"Am I? You always felt that things were missing , didn't it? Always a lonely child even when surrended by people who adored you. Always chasing something you couldn't see or understand. Is so tragic"

Catra hears him like under the water, hearing his words in swirls and tornados. Her heart and soul is a natural disaster, hurricans and incendios. But it doesn't hurt and it doesn't despair

her. Somehow, this new knowledge, this new true, it fills her with a feeling that Catra only felt until she held Finn in her arms, warm and beautiful and just born at the dawn of that spring day. Hope. Because this thing Prime has just thrown at her to hurt her, has healed that sore part on her that she didn't knew it was hurting. That after so much pain and uncertainty, life found a way to bring them right back in the place where they were always supposed to be. That every low and high and path in her life always in the end led to Adora. And that she was always loved, that Adora always loved her, even when Catra felt and thought she was underserved of it, Catra was loved. And Catra loved her back.

So Catra keeps running Finnie's hand, small circles of magic that lull them back into a soft sleep. She stands tall and pride and beautiful, baring her teeth to the false Emperor. Her magic cracks in the air, dangerous, like a lightning storm and with it the sun outside blinks, the branches of the purple trees shifting and bending toward the castle, climbing the destroyed stone, catching on fire but without stop moving until they surround the castle like a dome, purple and blue and green and yellow leaves draping over the windows. Melog growls, hard, a rumble so powerful the pillars of the castle tremble and the water boils.

"I don't know how you fooled our barriers but it doesn't matter. What you came to get here, you won't have" states Catra, her voice resounds loud inside the chamber. Prime chuckles, he actually fully fucking chuckles, running his hand over his hair and when the sunlight catches over it, Catra can see the dreadlocks seems to also be steel.

"I walked right across the main gate, your Majesty," he says, his own white teeth flashing with his grin. "My greatest thanks to your advisor for that by the way. It's a way so much civilized that so much unnecessary destruction"

Catra hisses, low in her throat, trying as best as she can to ignore the pan of betrayal his words bring. She doesn't even give herself the time to process it. She grinds her teeth together tasting metal in the base of her tongue. Behind Prime, a sizzling sound starts to rise again, strange and loud.

"You can sit in Adora's throne all you want but will never be Camelot's true king" spits out Catra.

"Oh, I don't want to rule Camelot, young girl. I want to destroy it", Horde Prime stands from the throne, folding his hands behind his back. "Your homes are in ruins, C'yra, you don't need to fight anymore." He gives a step further.

Catra doesn't step back. She stays, rooted in place, looking at the emperor on his entire height. The sizzling sound turns louder and louder until Catra realizes it is not a sizzling but the unmistakable sound of electricity building up. Electricity and the floor is wet and her feet are damped and if she doesn't move away she is going to die. She doesn't look away but her mind wonders for a second, thinking how much distraction she has to make to bolt to the door on the other side.

"Camelot will survive and so will Halfmoon and so will Etheria. We will survive and we will do it without you." One of Catra's hand falls from Finnie's body, holding them with the other safe and loving over her chest, balling it in a fist at her side. In her eyes, the blue and golden

burns and bleeds out, swirls of deep purple drawing in them like two amethyst shining in the shadows of the chamber.

Prime hums, considering her. His feet stay in the throne's platform, his soles not once touching the water. "So, I take you have thought of my offer your Majesty"

Catra smirks, small, devious, mocking, and then a loud chuckle straight up leaves her mouth as she laughs at his face. "I have, and kindly, go fuck yourself"

Prime's expression sours immediately, something much like rage crossing his eyes at Catra's insolence. "Disappointing. Well, I suppose you don't leave me another option. You Etherians are always so emotional," Prime steps away, holding a small device in his hand. The electricity in the ground picks up, raising the fur on Catra's arms and neck. Emperor Prime smiles. "Are you scared, Queen C'yra?"

Prime holds his hand up and drops the small object, a tiny pearl that shimmers green with energy and crashes unceremoniously against the water with a tiny *pop.* And when it touches the electricity picks up and then blows out completely, like a firecracker, like if someone had pulled the lightning of a storm from the sky and brought it inside the chamber. The sound is terrible, a thousand poisonous snakes attacking all at once, so loud Catra's ears ring painfully and she can't hear anything besides it. The light is too bright, too artificial, it hurts to see even from sideways or narrowed eyes, illuminating the chamber in neon green and white. The electricity sizzles, cracks and then takes form, long arms of green energy spinning, twisting and snapping against each other and then forward, like branches of a dead tree, lashing violently against the floor and the walls and even the ceiling, rising into a huge wall that throws itself to Catra and Finn at full speed.

Catra exhales, breathes in. She feels the warmth of her and Adora's baby in her hand, the soft feeling of Adora's red cape wrapping them both. And into the crack of mortal energy, she hears Adora's dumb laugh and their soft breathing in her ear, past memories that come to her at full speed. The lightning shifts, turns and throws itself to her, ready to snap the killing blow. Over the blinding light, Emperor Prime looks with his hands behind his back and a maniac smile in his mouth. Catra raises her free hand.

The sun dims, the golden light of the afternoon flickering like a candle just about to die. The day moon shimmers and then blinks, covering Camelot in purple light, entering through the tinted crystals of the chamber's windows and forming rainbows on the shapes of moons over the floor. The charged water in the floor shivers, like a sentient thing, illuminating bright blue for a millisecond and then stops moving all at once, completely frozen. The lightning doesn't stop, crashing violently in the place Catra stands, sizzling like the burning still of a new sword against water. The sound of the crash is so loud and penetrating the windows tremble and then explode to the inside of the chamber, small pieces of glass flying across the room in a rain of multicolor.

Prime grunts, covering his face with his arm as he walks back, sheltering himself from the sharp glass with the back of Adora's throne. He looks from above his raised arm, watching as the lightning bends violently from side to side in the other corner of the room. His sour expression brightens, just a little, satisfaction drawing in his mouth as he catches the

characteristic smell of burnt electricity. He doesn't usually stain his hands in combat but this one, he is proud of after so many headaches caused by just one little magicat girl.

He stands from the place he had cowardly scrunched over, looking with wide eyes as the lightning shrinks and starts to fade out. He looks among the white smoke, waiting to see charred and ash skin for himself. But instead, the smoke parts the side, like an ocean or a sea, and he sees queen C'yra still standing there in the exact same way she was just a second ago, with her baby still held in her chest and her wild hair that shines like liquid copper in the inexistent breeze of the chamber. Her eyes shine in purple tornados, two bright gems among the settling shadows of the room. Her face has changed, just slightly. Her eyes look larger, bigger, the white of her scleras bleeding out into black, tiny spots like stars shimmering inside them like galaxies. The fine fur in her forehead starts shifting into feather-like scales, iridescent and soft to the touch, glimmering in bright colors against the soft brown of her skin. Her fangs grow just a bit, more pointy and dangerous, baring themselves into a rage snarl. Swirls of magic form in her skin, from her temples, down her cheekbones and the large column of her neck, traveling in lines and rivers of magic down her arms, palms and fingers. One of her hands, the one that is not holding her baby, swirls in the air, elegantly, softly, like one would swirl their hand if caressing the surface of a calm lake in an even calmer boat. Her fingers move like water, shifting and bending the air and the same lighting Prime had used against her at her own will. The lethal electricity moves through her fingers like silk, not once hurting her or the baby, cracking in the breeze around her like a thousand whips. Below her bare feet, scratched and bruised after running for so long, the white stone turns dark and then illuminates in a thousand little points that look like fireflies, cracking in pieces as the glass shattered around the chamber. Small pieces of rock trembling and lifting into the air as if they were mere feathers. There is a small wound in her face, right below her right eye, in the freckled cheekbone. Is bleeding, dripping down her cheek and into the collar of her coat but the blood is not crimson red but golden ichor, shimmering in melted gold and making her freckles shine like a hundred little stars in constellations over her skin. Queen C'yra tilts her head, and this time it's her who considers Prime, tiny glass stuck on his tunic, a ridiculous surprised look, tall frame suddenly shrunken in shock and yes, completely and utterly for the first time in his endless life, fear. Catra's fangs flash when she speaks.

"I'm not scared, Emperor Prime" And Catra's voice are harps and jingle bells and waterfalls hitting polished rocks, and she smiles right back at him. "But you should"

Catra's hand twirls in front of her, the lighting around her shrinking and shrinking inside her extended palm until the violent arms of energy transform into a sfere, not much bigger than a peach, swirling in starry nebulas. It's a protostar in her fingers, absorbing the artificial light and transforming it, singing as dozens of little bells with magic energy. Catra takes one last deep breath and then releases all the air in her lungs in one long silent scream, throwing herself into the ground, knees connecting painfully with the stone as she slams her hand and the bright star in it against the floor. A magic dome rises from the ground, nebulas of purple, red, pink, green and yellow spinning around Catra like planets to the sun or the moons to Etheria. It grows bigger and bigger and bigger, building up tense and vibrant, and then opens to the ceiling like a blooming rose, swirls of white magic filling the chamber in silk clothes of silver and gold. The ground parts in the middle, rising to the sides in walls of stone and water, cracking the floor from corner to corner of the castle. From the center of the crack rise a hundred tree branches, thick roots splaying over the floor like limbless arms. Crystals of all

forms, origins and colors crawl over the living wood, attaching themselves to every piece of wall and ground that they can find. Veins of green burst across the glassless windows, growing in mere seconds over the ceilings and chandeliers, hundreds of roses blooming from their buttons, submerging the throne room in a multicolor tornado of the sweetest smells and colors, dangerous sharp thorns bursting from the space around Prime's feet, making him jump several feet back to avoid the sting.. Adora's throne shakes, the wood that forms it returning to life, bending in odd shapes until it's armrest are swirled branches with newborn evergreen leaves, its seat is covered in soft moss and the backrest is blooming with tiny white flowers and beautiful ripped oranges that sprout, grow and fall to the ground in glorious colorful pieces.

"Don't you get it? You are never going to win!" yells Catra over the rush of wind, loud enough for him to hear her clearly. "You will never get Camelot, you will never get my people, you will never get Adora. And you will *never* get your hands on my child!"

Catra lifts her hand from the ground, as if carrying something very heavy or maybe very light, and with her movement also moves every single thing that has just grown and sprouts to life in those couple of seconds since she kneels on the floor of a place she once called home. Dark and light moves with her, around her, through her, born from her hand and the center of her chest until she herself looks like a supernova at foreign eyes. Catra exhales, slow and deep, and then throws her hand forward, sending one last wave of magic and one last yell, charged with all the pain and fear and sadness and love she has been carrying inside herself for months now, strong and unyielding towards the north of the chamber and at full strength towards Prime. The weight of the wave hits the windows first, blowing in millions of pieces the beautiful tinted glass behind the thrones, its.golden dragons and white roses and beautiful half moon now just little pieces of crystal and sand and gold and silver falling tiny and insignificantly out of the castle and into the grass below it. And then, it hits Prime so hard he screams in pain and rage, sent flying by the relentless magic through the now destroyed windows and out of the castle, several meters down into the ground.

Catra grunts and growls, closing her hand in the air and with it swirling all the magic back into one place, holding it together all by herself as she sees it bend and tame down back into the roots of Etheria. It is almost done when Finn wakes up out of nowhere, letting out a heartbreaking loud and surprising cry of confusion, their tiny nose twitching frantically and uncomfortable against the smell of burnt electricity. Catra loses focus, distracted by the sound of her baby in distress and when she turns her eyes, just for a second, towards them she slips and the magic goes swirling free again and out of her grasp. Catra gasps, barely in time to turn her body towards her baby, sheltering Finn with her arms and head as her own magic whips against her and hits her with full force, sending her tethering to the opposite side of the room. The wall and the door that leads to the gardens, Catra's last exit, collapses on itself at the same time forming an impossible wall of huge debris and dozens of sharp rocks too dangerous to climb anymore. Catra has only time to surround Finn and only Finn with a shield of magic before the back of her head hits the wall of the outside corridor and the world goes black.

Finnie's cry snaps her back to consciousness almost violently. She inhales, freezing cold air drawing into her lungs and shaking her awake in mere seconds. She has slumped against a corner of a corridor. There are pieces of balcony thrown to each side of the corridor, tinted glass in the floor, chandeliers and sharp debris of the high ceilings falling all around her. Somehow, miraculously, none of these pieces has reached her, forming an arc around the place she is scrunched over into a tight ball.

Finnie is still crying, loud and heartbreaking, their tiny paws kneading over her chest as they seek the comfort of their mother, their cheek nuzzling over her neck again and again and this way she can feel the delicate drops of tears over her skin. Catra untangles herself from her own limbs, fumbling with Finn's blanket as she checks them up as thoughtful as possible. The frantic shield she had managed to throw over them has worked because outside of tousled honey hair, tiny ears pressed to the back of their head and the saddest of the faces, Finnies is safe and sound, rubbing their nose over the fabric of Adora's cape, chasing the familiar smell they have lived surrounded of the first weeks of their short life. Catra sighs in relief, smothering the back of their hair with her shaky hand as she shushes gently and lovingly their cry down. Now that the dust has started to set, Catra can feel every single bone in her body throbbing, each nerve ending on fire. The back of her head pulses painfully from where she hit it against the stone and she can feel the small drip of blood falling down her nape from where the rock scratched the skin open just a little. Her ankle has picked up again, swirls of pain traveling up her knee and hip. Her lower back flares with discomfort, pain sticking to every single of her muscles viciously. She can sense the deep scratch in her right cheekbone, pulling the skin as it starts to cloth and close.

Castle Grayskull is burning around her, the high towers consumed by green fire, stone crashing against the floor, gardens swirled by wind and ash. And Catra can't see it, but the tower she shared for so many long days and nights with Adora cracks in the middle and comes crumbling down with a sound so strong and distraught it shakes the very trees of the Whispering Woods, petals of white roses scattered in the ground below, falling like angels wings in the red sunset.

Above her head, the windows crack under the pressure of the heat and then blow out, sending pieces of wood frame and more glass flying in every direction. Catra gives a strangled yell, shielding herself and Finn with her arm and hand. She crawls over the floor, avoiding broken branches and rock all the same, following the thin breeze of air she can still sniff among all the smoke until it leads her to a turn, entering a chamber blacked by consumed fire, the walls black, the floor grey, the ceiling in pieces with holes that let the air enter and through which Catra can see the red sky and the start of the night, blending together in a twisted dance.

Catra stands in wobbly feet, straightening as best as she can as she tries to make sense of where she is. But the fire has been merciless and where before there was furniture and beautiful standards there is now just destruction. She coughs, dizzy by the smoke, her magic weak and spent, focused just enough in covering Finn from their surroundings. They are still still sobbing over her chest, low and exhausted, and Catra's heart breaks all over again.

She leans to the ground for a second, grasping the end of a long and sharp piece of glass, holding it in front of her as a makeshift sword or knife and ignoring the way its sharp edges cut the superficial skin of her palms. Catra turns in her place, walking over broken pieces of

wood that dig in her soles painfully, her fine and sensitive eyes back to their normal colors but dry by the smoke and the heat of the fire far away.

"Melog?" Catra calls, as quiet as possible and it still resounds loud like a morning bell inside the chamber. Catra grimaces, her face painted in grey and paths of damp from where silent tears have started to fall. "Melog? Where are you?"

"Why do you always have to make everything so complicated?" Catra's blood freeze inside her veins. She is not surprised, after all, Prime said it himself, but the rain cold of betrayal falls over her in waterfalls, slipping into the center of her bones. She turns to the direction of the voice, making the shape of the figure that walks slowly from inside the shadows.

Light Hope's face is like carved ice. The usual veil she uses over her head has fallen, letting her short hair shimmer under the light of the fire and the green tones makes her look like an iceberg surface under northern lights. Her hands are at her front, rested one over the other like she usually has them, the black and deep blue of her dress and tunic absorbing the colors around her in a dark void. She looks like her usual self, clean and posture straight, free of the stain of ash and dirt. But her eyes, her eyes tell another story completely, pupils mere pinpoints among the electric blue and if you look way too close you can see the edges of her lips are turned in the slightest of snarls, taking in Catra's figure among the destruction.

Catra steps back, away from the walls that could corner her and further into the dim light that enters through the ceilings holes. Her hands curl tighter and former over Finnie's baby body, thumbs circling over their romper as their cries subdue just enough to be a tiny whimpering and sad meows.

A high pitched sound breaks the air around them and mere milliseconds later a ball of pure green fire crashes against the side of the castle, bending it to the side, right in the place where the banquet hall and the kitchens used to be before. Catra gasps, holding to thin air to remain up, ankle flaring with pain. She looks up when the shaking calms just a little, amber and turquoise genes digging into storms of blue, rage against rage.

"What did you do," says Catra, very slowly, rolling each word over her tongue and out through her fangs. Another blow hits and the entire castle shakes with it. Catra's voice rises to a yell, gripping Finn against her chest in a dead like grip. "Light Hope! What. Did. You. Do?!"

"They wanted you", answers Light Hope in a whisper. Her voice is void, miles away from them and her eyes have turned frantic, fanatic, red veins in her scleras and dry from not blinking for so long. "They wanted you and your kingdom. It was too easy, Adora has never backed away from the desire to repair what is damaged".

Catra whimpers, walking backwards until her back connects with a pillar, nowhere else to go. Light Hope follows her movements and when she steps into the sunlights entering through the ceiling Catra sees her hands are electric blue too, white veins popping like the lightning that breaks the sky outside.

"Why would you do it?", asks Catra, her voice trembling uncontrollably. "Why would you do something like this?"

Light Hope's frown turns into a full snarl in a matter of seconds and then dissolves into something frantic and desperate, the edge of her eyes watering with tears. She balls her hands in tight fists, nails breaking the skin as her tears shift into anger and desperation, raising her voice.

"She said that if I did this, she would bring me my Mara back," she says and then chuckles, running her hand over her face. Light Hope's eyes seem to almost vibrate from one side to the other, looking at something nobody else can see but her. "She said she would".

Catra whimpers, pressing herself against the pillar as she tries and fails to call her magic back. "Light Hope, nobody can bring the dead back", she says, as calm as the tethering of her teeth allows her. "No matter what Shadow Weaver might have told you, not even she can. Is just not possible-"

"What would you know!" yells Light Hope, the surprise of her scream making Catra shut her mouth so quickly her jaw hurts. "You have caused nothing but problems from the very beginning, since that day Adora returned to Camelot broken and without a childhood for something *you* caused."

Catra shrinks in her place, slapped by the weight of Light Hope's words. Her heart is drumming strongly in her chest, blood rushing in her ears like a storm. She doesn't remember, she doesn't remember anything and now the thing that gave her hope just a few minutes ago is also scaring her. She looks to every side, trying to find a way out and failing, she has been trapped. Light Hope stops walking just a few seconds away from her. The lighting in her hands shifts violently.

"The only reason why I agreed with Weaver's idea of bringing you back into Adora's life was so you could serve for something greater", spits out Light Hope charged in venom. "Adora was to be the once and future king, the one who would lead the First Ones into victory. It was their destiny, it always was. You were just a tool for that, only that just a rock in the path, and still you dared tangle them in your webs and to sit in their throne and call yourself king"

"I didn't put myself there, Adora did", exclaims Catra, covering Finn's ears with her hand to shelter them from the noise. Around them, the castle continues to crumble down in dust. "Adora did, because he loves me and because he knew I loved them, more than anything. He did it because he knew he could trust me in the same way I trusted him with Halfmoon. He did it because they wanted to protect me. He did it because they knew we were having a baby. He did it out of love. Love! You could never understand that"

"How dare you? Mara-"

"You don't know what love is!" Catra swirls her arm to the side, motioning the burning kingdom with fury. "Look at what you have done! You left Prime to walk into our home. Prime! You say you will take him that but at what cost?! At the cost of everything Adora loves? Everything they believe and defend? Everything they sacrificed themselves for? How can you not see what you have done?!" Catra's voice rises so high it breaks in the middle, hoarse from the smoke and the abuse. "Shadow Weaver is *using* you. She used you to get to me, she used you to get to Adora and she used to get all of Etheria's magic for herself".

"No, Shadow Weaver promised to me. There is nobody else that could do it but her. She is going to betray Prime. Once she has enough making she will destroy him and bring Mara back and everything will be exactly as it always should have been"

" *Listen* to you! You know exactly what they are doing and you are helping her! You betrayed our people, you betrayed Camelot, you betrayed Etheria. You betrayed Adora!"

"Shut up, this is your fault!" Light Hope's face contorts horrible, snarl growing until she has her white teeth bared completely, eyebrows knitted tight together, shaking from head to toe from how tense she holds herself as she leans towards Catra's space, the air cracking with magic. "It was all planned, all carefully designed. I talked for months with that disgusting little man you called the Minister to convince him to take down the barriers, I even had to propose the idea of how to do it because he was too stupid to think about it for himself. I gave him the idea to close the commercial route to lure you back. It would have been just another unfortunate demise caused by war, just that and everything would be over already. Months, years of planning since I convinced *you* to let us into Halfmoon until you were supposed to go back to sink with it. It was all so perfect, Adora wasn't supposed to go to Halfmoon at all. But she did anyway. She did, because she *loved* you. Because you *made* her love you. You are the only guilty one here. You killed her!" she yells, her spits falling in tiny drops of acid into the floor below them. "It was *you* who was supposed to fall into that battle. You!"

Catra remembers one of Adora's letters, from months ago, guarded in what before was their chamber and that now is just ash. " *Did you know it was your Commerce Minister the one that had the idea of closing the routes?"*

Catra exhales, tears unavoidably falling free from her eyes and down her cheeks, carving damp paths in the ash that covers her skin. "Oh goddess," she whispers, covering her mouth with her hand as all the pieces start to click into place. It had all been a trap, from the very beginning, Catra was destined to fall at their hands. She and Adora, they both had been manipulated into a marriage together just so Halfmoon joined the rest of the kingdoms and Avalon finally lowered its barriers to the rest of the world. Shadow Weaver had managed to make Light Hope side with her because she knew things about them, she knew things about Catra and Adora that they didn't remember and she knew they would fall in love at the end, as it always should have and will be, and she had known how to use that against them. Shadow Weaver had probably planned it all, every single thing to the very last detail, even Adora taking Catra's place in Halfmoon. Having the Heart of Etheria and the Heir of Avalon, all in just one long planned shot. Everything, carefully crafted.

Everything except one thing.

Finn whimpers softly, nuzzling their tiny head on their mother's chest, their little tail wrapping itself around Catra's pinky tight, keeping her hand in place. Catra presses them closer to her chest, feeling their peach thin fur brush against her skin and their fluttering heartbeat in her fingers so much like the sensation she felt all the months she carried them inside herself, when their tiny feet would press against her belly every time Adora came to conversation or the hiccups of life at midnight when she knew they were dreaming, secure and healthy inside their mother.

A growl is born in Catra's throat, dangerous and warning, directed to the traitor in front of her. Light Hope follows the movement of her arms, nose scrunched with a disarray of feelings and then her face melts into something too close to boredom. She extends her hand towards Catra, palm open.

"Give me the baby C'yra"

"Fuck you"

"You can't take care of them" Light Hope says, her voice condescending and fake calm. She gives one step closer, motioning to her unruly her and the scratches and bruises that scatter her body. "Look at you, you couldn't take care of Camelot, you can't even take care of yourself. How are you going to look out for them?" Light Hope tries to give one more step further but the ground between them shakes and collapses, creating a wide crate so deep not even the end can be glimpse. Catra gasps, exhausted by the burst of magic, by this point holding herself up only by the pillar. Light Hope's eyes sour, closing her hand in a fist that trembles as she throws it back to her side. The looks she sends to Catra is lethal and full of resentment.

"They are a First One too and they must be raised only by a First One. That's the way the world has always worked, the way of the Pendragons before you and your magicat blood came to stain its bloodline" Light Hope tilts her head to the side, smiling in something that seems to be a try of calm. "And Shadow Weaver say she won't hurt them"

"Fuck. You" repeats Catra with more strength and rage. Her ears are going crazy, catching a hundred different sounds around her and not letting her focus. "Stay away from us or I'll swear only the stones will carry your remains"

“That baby shouldn’t even have been born. It was your mistake, you just had to go and make her fall in love with you, you ungrateful stupid child. I will not lose Mara for you”

The inside of the crack shifts and trembles, hundreds of crystal growing on its irregular walls and crawling out and into the floor, surrounding Light Hope in a circle of amethyst and quartz. All around them the stones in the wall start to melt, colored in red by internal heat. Catra's eyes have changed again, now two pools of black, tears of black ooze dripping from the edges of her eyes and down her cheeks and neck. Her fangs haves prolonged almost impossibly, a myriad of black and red iridescent tiny feathers over her forehead and temples shining like rubies and onyx under the fires light.

"You didn't love Mara" spats Catra, stars reflecting in her dark eyes. "You betrayed her, you betrayed her child, her grandchild. You betrayed her kingdom. You are not doing some noble act. You are a traitor and Mara would be disgusted by you"

Outside the castle the earth trembles, one long and powerful hit over the ground that makes the very trees bend with the strength of the wind that comes with it. There is a best and then another hit comes and then another and another, closer and closer with each second and from so close it can be distinguished as steps. Something big and powerful walking towards the castle. Light Hope gasps against the sound, lines of white electrical power creeping in her

face making her look like a broken porcelain. Catra doesn't even startles by the sound, maybe not hearing it, maybe to caring at all, her black eyes digging holes inside Light Hope's soul.

“Finn wasn’t a mistake. They were a gift. Adora gave me the most precious thing before she left. And I'm going to protect them.”

The hits are now right above the castle, shaking the ceiling that starts to come down in long pieces of wood and rock into the ground, breaking the crystal and stones when they fall. The walls are shaking by the pressure of some new kind of heat, completely different and a thousand times more powerful than the green fire of the Horde. Outside, the Horde Army starts to yells, loud unintelligible shouts and stomps as they start running on every side, panic palpable through the walls. Light Hope's eyes widen in sudden fear, looking at the chamber starting to come down around them and the turning her eyes towards Catra. Where she was like a kaleidoscope against Prime, she is now the night sky as the starts collapse into themselves. Magic free and raw and unfiltered and completely exhausted but full of rage.

"It's too late already. Shadow Weaver has Camelot" screams Light Hope above the tempest. In the ceiling, something comes crashing against the fragile branches, long dark claws, as long as houses, digging into the wood and tearing it apart with one swing. A terrifying sound fills the air of Camelot, accute like a million sword's against glass, making everyone in Etheria cover their ears in shock. The last of the windows come blowing up, pillars bending against a mighty weight. "C'yra!"

The last thing they both see is a pair of huge sapphire be eyes, deep purple scales over the magnanimous head, neck and huge arms. The dragon's tail flickers against the side of the castle, their wings flapping and causing hurricanes with the strength of the wind that swirls below the bright purple membranes. The dragon bursts into the chamber, blue fire leaving in puff from their nostrils and the space between their sharp teeth.

The wooden beams break and the ceiling collapses over their heads.

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x

End of chapter XII

Chapter End Notes

Aren't I the queen of cliffhanger? Don't worry, I also hate myself for it (and that considering I already know what the next chapter brings!)
Congratulations! Many of you were right. Light Hope IS the traitor. For some it comes as no surprise at all for others still with doubt everything is now cleared. To be honest, it was never done to be a surprise, it was the reason "why" the important thing.
Also! writing Catra yeeting Prime out of Castle Grayskull was extremely fun
Btw, don't worry, I would never harm neither Catra or Finn, they are just fine, they have

a strong and big ally on their side after all ')
FUN FACT: you might have noticed the description on Catra's features. That is because, on this story, Catra is part fae! (about 1/3 on Tlalli's side) which makes her a hundred percent more dangerous than you thought before.

I really hope you enjoyed this chapter, it was tricky to write but I really liked it. As always, kudos, comments and bookmarks are deeply appreciated.

Next chapter, "The last rose of Camelot", comes up on December 19th, see you then! ')

Chapter 14: The last rose of Camelot

Chapter Summary

The soldiers hear a dissaray of sound approaching and from the collapsed pillars of the main gate, the same through which they walked earlier sorted by Camelot's Advisor, bursts out Emperor Prime, his face contorted in raw undeniable rage. His artificial hair is a mess, chunks of steel hanging broken from a few cords that crisp and die with electricity. His white, pure, tunics are broken and stained in dark ash and greens moss. There is a very notorious stain in the middle of his chest, veins of blue and purple and golden light that creeps from it up to the steel on his neck and chin. His expression is raged, a snarl on his face so angry and frantic the soldiers feel the pull of step back and away from him. And his voice is worse, hoarse and irate, as he looks to every side of the gate and into the few trees at the starts of the forest that had crisped on fire.

"Where is she?!," Emperor Prime screams, loud and terrible. When nobody answers, Prime marches to the rows if soldiers, kicking a piece of fallen wood so hard the thick piece breaks in half. "Where is that magicat girl?!"

Chapter Notes

Hellooooooo. This is the spirit of past Christmas, or more like the Ginny of Saturday writing this 'D The week went so fast! I want to thank everybody that commented on last chapter! I read every single one if them and I promise to come back and answer them shortly, I just had some errands to run and lost track of time because ADHD you know ') But thank you so so much nonetheless you really made my day and warmed my heart!
🤍
WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER: Descriptions of minor wounds

Won't have you here much longer, hope you enjoy the chapter and see ya downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 13 Part I. The last rose of Camelot

Freedom from the stone or not,

whether I can show it or not,

I promise that my heart

will always hold love for you.

— Diana Pinguicha, *A Curse of Roses*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x

✾

Camelot burns.

The Upper Town and Downtown are drowned in green flames, wood and steel breaking and melting away. The beautiful tinted crystals are broken, scattered in the floor in colorful stains, a mirror of the yellows and blues and reds powders still staining Halfmoon's abandoned streets. The yards and main squares are lonely, not a single soul in sight, footprints of an unyielding army left across their pass. The gardens are burnt, covered in grey ash, its evergreen and purple grass gone, flowers rotten, trees cracked.

Castle Grayskull is falling apart. High towers crumbling like the sea against sand castles. The royal tower fell first, hit by so many fire cannons it collapsed against its own pillars, a thousand white petals falling over the destruction like snow. The people of Camelot saw the throne room blow up in a sphere of magic and from their point of view, hidden among the thickest part of the Whispering Woods, they can still see magic branches shifting and bending into odd shapes, crystals forming over their roots, huge leaves covering the destroyed bits. It's a firecracker of color among all of the destruction, making Castle Grayskull look like some kind of magical ruin taken from a fairy tales' book.

The villagers, the knights and the court are all together, mingling among the bushes and tall trees that surround them. They are just on the outsides of Camelot, protected by individual magic barriers as they regroup. Nobody will be able to find them here, at least not for just enough time for Camelot to reorganize and the sorceress to create new Arcane Circles that will send them into Brightmoon, already waiting readily to receive the newly formed refugees. Everyone is there, absolutely everyone. Every magicat and salinean and first one and etherians. Every adult and child and elderly and young. They were all there, covered in ashes from head to toe, wild hairs and distraught expressions but there, there, not lost at the hands of their own shadows. There. No loss had been reported, outside for the occasional knight that had thought themself too brave and that had been maybe too close of a call, the Horde and Shadow Weaver had taken no one and nothing. Yes, they were all there, except for the whole reason why they had made it out safe and alive, the king and her newborn baby.

Camelot's people had heard the Horde Army march over their home, their kingdom, their steps heavy and destructive as they set everything in raged fire after failing in finding them all. They saw the main hall collapse, barely avoiding crushing the last path towards the woods, rising clouds of smoke from the fallen remains. And then they watched a figure emerge from in between the smoke and the fire. Their wings flapped against the wind, making the smoke swirl into small tornados, drowning the fires in the towns with just one powerful flap. The creature was immense, bigger than the entire downtown together, it’s head big enough to compare with the diameter of the castle towers. The red sunset reflected over their scales, purples and deep blues making it look iridescent, like a living crystal creature,

extracted from a legend itself. The dragon roared, loud, angry, shaking the earth from one point of the planet to the other. It was a sound so menacing that everyone's heart, Horde and Etherian alike, shrinked inside their chests, their ears ringing with the powerful growl. The dragon raised above the clouds of smoke, closer to the top of the magic dome around the king dome, spearing their wings from side to side as they fly over the kingdom and towards the castle. Their long spiky tail curled behind them, intercepting the incoming fire balls midair and sending them back to the place they had come from, making dozens of hundreds of Horde soldiers run away in frantic panic. From their mouth and nostrils raised puffs of turquoise steam, flames of bright blue fire leaving their mouth in a trail of magic. The dragon hovered just for a few seconds over the side of the castle, their claws grasping the roof and then tearing it apart with violent efficiency, growling all the way until they broke a hole big enough to crash against. Camelot's people saw them entering the castle, their immense figure disappearing among an even bigger column of smoke and ashes and then nothing else but the sound of wings against the wind, emerging from the castle with full force and flying over the highest of clouds in the sky crossing the magic barrier as if it wasn't there at all.

That had been over an hour ago. Now, everyone is regrouping on small bunches, waiting patiently for the etherians and magicats sorceresses to draw individual circles in the ground and sending them quickly to Brightmoon, disappearing in a burst of colorful sparks and light, rinse and repeat. The night is falling, the red sun and its red sky dissolving into the liquid blue of the night sky. The moons are shining, pretty purples and pinks maybe too bright among the smoke of the fires. The Horde Army has started to retreat from Camelot, chased away by the fear caused by the sudden appearance of a supposedly exiting dragon. They have tripped against their own feet, dragging heavy weapons against the grass in their frantic run away. However, they won't take long to start searching around the woods, jumping the treacherous roots and brushes as they look for anything and anyone their anger over failure can reach. Camelot doesn't have much time to disappear, they don't have time to sit and mourn their home, they don't have time to try and reach for their things. They don't have the time to look for anyone else.

Queen Glimmer is walking among the people, checking up the arcane circles with hawk eye, holding up the small barriers around them with the other. Her wings are ruffled impossibly, shimmering with tiny crystals, her pink magic twirling around her in a lilac halo. Her expression is calm and regal when she talks to people but the moment she turns away her eyebrows knit together, lips pressed into a thin line, storms of deep worry inside her eyes. There is a terrible expression on her face, in those few seconds she is away from the rest, sadness and rage yes, but also a deep rotten worry that makes her look pale and sick. She has been looking for her friends for so long she feels like she knows this patch in the woods personally.

Another group disappears in a swirl of colors and it's then that she sees Bow, frantically looking among the people too. They had divided to help the people a while ago and he looks exactly as how everyone feels, with his thick hair covered in ashes, his clothes crumpled and torn in the edges, his eyes worried and his hand trembling. Glimmer walks towards him with resolution, her feet crushing small burnt leaves that have been falling all around them for the last hours. Bow must catch the sound of steps approaching because he raises his head immediately, rushing to his wife and enveloping her in a tight hug in one swift motion.

“Glimmer!” he exclaims, squeezing her gently once and then parting from her a few inches, looking at her face.

“Bow," breathes out Glimmer, relieved to be back in her best friend's arms. She looks behind him and then around, the same worry that had been chasing her falling over her again with double force than before. “Did you find them? Did you find Catra and Finn?”

“No. I thought they might be with you", gasps Bow,looking now too around them as if the woods would part at his will and spit out his friends. His voice is hoarse from the smoke and there is a rash on the side of his face after running around the castle collecting people to bring down the passages.

"Goddess", whispers Glimmer, her eyes welling in tears. "We have to go back. I know we don't have time but we can send the rest of the people and then go looking for them. We can't just- we can't just leave them there. What if the Horde got them? What if Shadow Weaver got them?" Glimmer's voice rises higher along with her panic, echoing in the woods and making a few people turn to them with worried faces. Bow shushes her gently, rubbing his hands over her upper arms in soothing motions as he nods firmly.

"Yes, yes absolutely. Let's help the people and we'll go back" he smiles at his wife, a hint of fear and a try of hope on his handsome face. "She is so smart and she loves Finn more than anything. I'm sure they found a way to get out or protect them. You saw that magic. That was all Catra's"

"You are right," agrees Glimmer after a few beats, shaking her head up and down in trembling agreement. "Yes, of course. You are right. Let's go do that, come on"

They make it barely three steps forward before a piercing shriek shakes the air above their heads. The silhouette of a dragon bursts from the clouds in the sky, their immense wings hiding the moons from sight as their flight obscures them for a moment before folding them down in one swift flap. The dragon hovers still for a few milliseconds in the sky and then throws themself at full speed towards the thickest part of the woods, a few miles away from them, mingling with the fog of the night until it's form blurs and then goes away completely.

The people give a strangled yell, scrunching over the ground and pressing their hands over their mouths in an attempt to keep as quiet as possible. Bow and Glimmer lower to their ankles, joining the rest of the group and moving their hands up and down in a silent sign to remain calm. They wait for some good couple of minutes but no more signs of the dragon or the Horde come and they all slowly start to straighten up again, the sorceresses rushing to finish the last couple of arcane circles needed. Glimmer turns to Bow, opening her mouth to say something when he rushes forward and covers her mouth with his hand, bringing his other finger over his lips.

There it is. From the dark smoke that covers the woods around them, the unmistakable sound of hoofs against the leaves calls their attention.

The knights surround the rest of the villagers and sorceresses, forming a tight circle around them with their swords shining bright blue with defensive magic. Glimmer and Bow stand in front of the circle, serving as a first barrier of defense before whatever is riding towards them.

Glimmer raises her hands, pink and lilac magic circles appearing around them, and Bow his arc, hanging loose from his shoulder all this time the tip of the arrows shining in pearlescent shimmer, ready to take down whoever is coming. The leaves of the brushes around them shake a little, disturbed by the incomer's presence and a shadow's silhouette can be made of among the darkness, circling the small barrier over the clear. Bow leans towards Glimmer, pressing his mouth close to her ear to whisper as low as possible.

"Do you think it can see us?". Glimmer shakes her head in negative, her knuckles white for how tight she holds them.

"Is not possible. The barrier should look like a wall of rocks for them".

Everyone stands still, breathes held as they wait for the shadows to hit the barrier and walk away. The shadow keeps coming and coming, hoofs against grass one step after the other until it is right in front of the barrier and hesitates. For one victorious second, Glimmer smiles, lowering her fists just a little.

But the shadow doesn't stop. The smoke around them parts, crossing the limits of the magic barrier like nothing and from it comes the figure of a dark horse, grey from where the ashes had covered them, spots of turquoise blue over their neck and nuzzle as they keep walking into the patch of the woods. Riding over them is a person covered in all black clothes. The figure wears a long black cape draped over the shoulders, with the ends torn and burnt, something one would find abandoned in the ground and would pick up and wrap around themself to stop the ash from falling over them, and its hood is raised to cover the head and face. Their pants are torn in a few places, knees bloody and scratched over, and they are barefoot, soles and fingers blackened after walking over the dark ash. The figure holds the reins of the horse with one gloved hand, the other pressed against the chest and hiding from sight among the waves of their cape. They say nothing, riding the black horse in silence, head bent forward just a little, making it impossible to distinguish their face.

Bow tightens his arc, arrow aimed and ready to be sent flying any second. Glimmer brings her fists up again, magic shimmering brighter and more dangerous. She is about to shoot them down when the horse stops mid track and the figure snaps their head up, Catra’s ash and tear stained face coming into view.

Glimmer and Bow gasp at the same time, Glimmer's magic dissolving immediately in a puff of shine, Bow's arc and arrow dropping into the ground. They move like one, giving steps so wide they are next to Catra in barely a few seconds. Bow holds the horse's face to keep it calm, jumping back a little when the turquoise eyes of Melog look at him right back. Melog rumples, rubbing their equine face against his side in recognition and Bow has been around them for so long he absently expects them to start purring. Glimmer grabs Catra's hand, helping her slip down Melog, who bends their legs a little to help her out. Catra steps into the grass with wobbly feet, her knees giving up immediately as she halfway collapses down. She holds herself up with one hand in Melog's neck, the other still firmly pressed over the cape in her chest. Glimmer and Bow shot forward instantly, catching Catra between their arms and holding her upwards, their backs sheltering her from the worried looks of the villagers and knights still behind them.

Catra is trembling, badly. Her ankle is circled in a rim of red and swollen, battered in scratches and bruises over her arms and face. Her eyes are narrowed, lips pressed together as she most probably bites down a pained yelp, and her shoulders are bent as she curls over herself. Glimmer brushes her hand over her hair, smoothing the sweat and dirt matted locks behind her lowered ears. She checks on her as swiftly and softly as she can, heart beating painfully in her throat when she curls her hand over the piece Catra's cape still draped over her hand and chest, peeling it gently from her as she peaks inside.

Finn wriggles sleepy on their mother’s strong hold, wrapped in a red piece of fabric that Glimmer recognizes as a torn piece of Adora’s cape, holding them against Catra's chest and wrapping their little limbs and tiny body and then down across Catra's waist. Their fine blonde hair and soft cream romper are a bit grey from ash, small button nose scrunched, little ears pressed to either side of their soft head and they hold to their mother’s wrist with all the strength their little tail can, but they are safe and untouched otherwise.

Glimmer sighs in relief, enveloping both Catra and Finn in a soft hug, holding them both against herself. Bow comes to meet them too, resting his chin atop of Catra's dirty hair, circling her shoulders and Glimmer's head with his arms. Catra stiffens for a second, body in high alert, but slowly she starts to loosen up a strangled heartbreaking little sobs leaving her mouth as she sobs in Glimmer's shoulder. She lets herself sink into her knees, still holding Finn against her very gently, careful of not disturbing their fragile sleep after going through so much. Glimmer and Bow, and even Melog, follow her down the grass, wrapping both mother and baby inside a warm and familiar embrace, allowing her enough privacy and safety to cry.

The knights turn to the people. They call the villagers' attention away from the three regents, gathering them a bit away as they start the last preparations to travel, one eye to the limits of the barrier in case anyone else comes or reaches close through. The sorceresses drop to their knees, painting the arcane circles with colorful powders and kicking them off with the last bits of magic they have after such a long evening.

Glimmer's dress is damp with Catra's silent tears, petting her hair gently a few times as her magic reaches for her friend, slipping inside her chest and bones and helping her settle and calm down. Bow untangles from their shared embrace, holding Catra's ankle between his hands. The skin is swollen and tinted in red and light purple but it doesn't look bent in award sizes, which is a good sign. He holds the joint between his palms and lap, pressing the warmth from their hands over the sore skin. A bright orange light illuminates the space between both palms, surrounding Catra's foot, leg and up in swirled curves, wrapping over each bruised bone and sore skin until it reaches the wound over her cheekbone. The skin knits together swiftly, gently, open cuts healing, bruising taming down, the pull in her ankle tingling until the pain and the discomfort disappears completely. Catra sighs in relief over Glimmer's shoulder, her tears subduing as the pain washes away. Bow mirrors her sigh, opening his hand to inspect the now completely normal skin, checking up and down for anything that might have escaped him. Catra is still sore, still bone tired and shaking like a leaf to the wind but her wounds are mostly gone, just a light uncomfortable pull in her ankle and a pink rough scar in the skin between her eye and her cheekbone remaining. An external giveaway of all the pain she and Camelot had gone in just a matter of hours.

Bow finishes checking upon his friend, falling back over his ankles as he passes a hand over his face. Adora had been the one that taught him how to use healing magic, many moons ago when they were still young and reckless and Adora and Glimmer would run risky and fun adventures around the limits of Camelot and the three would come back with scraped knees and splinters in their hands. Memories and learnings that had prepared them without know it for this time in their lives, where Bow looks over his best friend's wife and baby safety because he loves them and they are his family too.

Catra shifts inside Glimmer's embrace, slipping one hand from her strong hold over her baby's body and placing it over one of Bow's own hands in his lap. Catra's hand looks so small in comparison to his, fine and delicate bones against his wider fingers as she tangles their hands together and squeezes them once. A silent *thank you* that makes Bow smile impossibly softly to her.

Glimmer presses small kisses over Catra's temples, brushing her bangs out of her eyes, cleaning as best as she can the ashes off her face. "You are alright, you are alright," she whispers again and again, running the pads of her fingers over Finnie's head. The baby's little hand comes up, curling over one of Glimmer's fingers, eyes still closed. "You are *both* alright. It 's over now."

Catra's shaking stills after a while and she parts from in between her friend's arms to weep a hand over her face, her palm pressing against sore and puffy eyes to clean away the sticky tears from them. There are remains of golden ichor and black ooze stuck on her eyelashes and they stain the back of her embroidered sleeves when she runs it over them. Catra looks around them, taking in the safety that the temporary barrier brings them, the people gathered in the center, disappearing inside the soft light of the arcane circles all the way to Brightmoon, the thickness of the purple and blue forest around them, the dense smell of smoke and the fire of Camelot still burning a trail of green against the dark night sky. Catra exhales, sorbing her nose and brushing her fingers over the top of Finnie's soft hair.

"Did it work?," she asks. Her voice is completely raspy, hoarse from smoke and tears and yelling. The tip of her ears flicker, lowering down towards the back of her head when a particularly nasty explosion goes off inside Camelot. Glimmer nods next to her, cleaning her own twinkling tears with her fingers.

"It did. It so did, Catra. You are a freaking genius" Glimmer answers, giving her a tiny hesitant smile. "Both Upper and Downtown as well as the castle were completely cleared. No losses as far as we have counted. Your plan worked"

Catra exhales, nodding. Glimmer and Bow help her stand up, bringing her close to a fallen log where she can sit down. She is still shaking sporadically, the fur in her tail frizzed and on point. Glimmer summons a warm and damp cloth on her right hand, cleaning out traces of tears, sweat, ooze and ash off her face. Bow hovers over her for a second, checking over the knots of Catra's wrap around Finn when she asks him for it, rubbing his hand over their little back loving and sweet.

"I need to feed them, we skipped feed time a while ago," she explains to both of them in a whisper, exhaustion obviously hanging from her eyelids and tongue, and yet she says it so casually, as if it was just another early night in Camelot sitting in the rocking chair next to the

crib and below the dim light of the roof constellations and nothing like she had just fought for her life no more than a couple hours ago.

Melog comes behind her, dropping in the grass still in their horse form, serving her as a backrest to take away some tension from her body. Their big head rests over the ground, their eyes never leaving Catra's arms, accommodating Finn softly. Glimmer and Bow help her wrap her coat and cloak better around her as she nudges Finn slightly awake and cooes them to start eating, letting out a heavy sigh as she allows herself to relax over Melog. Glimmer and Bow look at each other above her head, an obvious worried stare nestled in their eyes. She is so calm after her tearful breakdown, it's scary. They stay around her as discreetly as they can, which is not much, ready to step in case her calm is being held in pure crystal shock, just waiting to come collapsing down. But Catra remains tranquil, chirping and purring towards Finn while they eat in sleepy, kitten-tiny sucks, scenting the top of their head with the angle of her jaw a few times and kissing the back of their tiny ears again and again.

"Where is Scorpia?," asks Catra once Finn has settled over her chest, eating almost half asleep. Bow sits in front of them, resting his hand over Catra's knee, his forehead against his hand. Glimmer drops in the grass with a heavy sigh, legs crossed below the ruffles of her torn dress. Her wings shake themselves off ashes, coming up and to the sides to cover them all from the rest of the people still going off, the pink feathers ruffling the top of Catra's hair. This way, they don't look only like regents of powerful kingdoms but also like the three simple young friends they are, still battered on ash and dirt and bruised on body and soul but together and safe.

"I sent her first" assures Glimmer, running her fingers through the knots in her pinky hair. "She wanted to stay and wait for you but the magicats seemed to feel safer with her. I thought it would be good that she was the one that welcomed them to Brightmoon. My parents are going to help her out"

"Alright, that's good," accepts Catra, nodding. Finn finishes eating quickly, giving happy little chirps and nuzzling their nose in her skin as they knead on her. Catra changes them from position, nestling them over her shoulder and palming their back softly. "And- and Double Trouble?"

Glimmer and Bow share a look, lips frunced into a displeased pout. "They went with Scorpia and Entrapta. They- they tried to tell us about the traitor and the curse. My- my dad is going to help them get rid of it I'm sure. And-" Glimmer gulps, strangely out of words. "They told us the traitor had imprisoned them. That the traitor was the one who helped Prime get in. Catra-"

"It was Light Hope" deadpans Catra, her sight miles away from them. There is a frown forming in her eyebrows and a snarl in her lips. "I think- I think she was going to kill me. Or hand me to Shadow Weaver. And- And she tried to take Finn. All along, it was her"

New-form hot tears start falling down her cheeks again, this time bornt out of rage instead of sadness. She bites her lips hard, fang almost breaking the skin, the corners of her lips turned down in displeasure. Finnie burps softly on her shoulder and she nestles them there, between her neck and jaw, rocking from side to side a few times to reassure them and herself. There is a purr growing in her chest that sounds more like a self soothing motions than a happy one.

Bow wraps his hand over Catra's forearm, squeezing gently as he searches for her eyes with his.

"Catra, what happened after we got separated?". Catra looks at him with bright eyes, the saddest of expressions in them. She really is beautiful, even bruised and tired, Queen C'yra shines bright in the night, a living moon carrying her child.

"Prime was there, in the throne room," Glimmer and Bow barely contain a gasp, tightening their hold over Catra's arms in an attempt to calm her. "He has some kind of weapon, like he could control lighting at his will. He used the electricity against me, he tried to kill me and-" Catra cuts herself short, a distraught and furious look washing over her face. "I throw him out of the castle"

"You *throw* him?" repeats Glimmer, incredulous.

"I don't think he is dead. I'm not even sure if he is alive at all," Catra huffs, upset. Her ears are pressed against her head, dark spots of red in her cheekbones. "And when we managed to get away, Light Hope was there" Catra turns to look at Bow and Glimmer. "It was a plan, all of this, from the very beginning. She allowed the Horde to walk inside Camelot like nothing. She brought me here to marry Adora and lure the magicats out. And when she had communication access to Halfmoon, she convinced my Minister to close the commerce paths so I would have to go back. She convinced him to betray us and take the barriers down, to allow the Horde in."

"But- but why would she do that?" answers Glimmer, betrayal slipping sour and raw in her mouth. "She raised Adora, she knew how much Adora loves you. Why would she do it?"

"Shadow Weaver promised her to bring Mara back from the dead if she handed me and Halfmoon to her" Glimmer and Bow's eyebrows shoot up to their foreheads, mouths open in shock.

"But that can't be done"

"I don't think she knows that or even if she cares. She is desperate to have Mara back"

"Goddess," whispers Glimmer, running her hand over her face. Bow is frowning, chewing on the inside of his cheek as he thinks.

"It doesn't make sense. It's been two years since you married Adora. Why wait so long? You opened Halfmoon's limits to the rest of the Kingdoms almost immediately and you would have gone back any time if the paths were closed"

"Because of Adora," Catra exhales, eyes troubled. Finn is sucking in her earlobe, halfway sleep, kneading on her neck. "Because Adora fell in love with me. All this time, Adora's love protected me and Halfmoon, even without knowing it" her voice waves a little, eyes rimmed in red. "I think Light Hope expected us to be away from each other as many arranged marriages before us. And that way she could isolate me the moment Shadow Weaver ordered and try to take me down. But Adora kept me like his equal all the time, from the very start.

They were always by my side, they refused to leave me alone. And I don't think Light Hope was expecting that. The way Adora was so willing to give up everything so quickly for me"

Catra stops for a second, rubbing her forehead with her hand, evading her friends' troubled gazes. "Neither Light Hope or Shadow Weaver could take us down as long as we were together. And after Thaymor's failure, Prime should have punished Shadow Weaver somehow. He said he should have listened to her much sooner than he did. So they waited. And when we were relaxed and we least expected it, Shadow Weaver attacked Salineas. She planted fear on us and used that fear to move forward and go ahead with Halfmoon's plan. She weaved us to move exactly how she wanted us to"

"With the exception that Adora went in your place," adds Glimmer, realization sinking in. Catra hesitates, searching for the right words to word what she has deduced in so little time.

"Light Hope was mad. She was so angry when Adora went to Halfmoon. I didn't understand why, I thought it was out of worry or reminiscent of Mara's. But it was because once again, Adora's love frustrated her plans. Love for me. Love for Halfmoon. Love for Finn-" Melog raises their equine head from the ground, sensing Catra's distress. They rub the top of their head on the low of her back, their motions just the same as when they were just a little cat. "Even if Light Hope didn't think that was going to happen, I believe Shadow Weaver did. In fact, I think that was her plan all along, using our love against us to take us down one by one. She was sure she could take Adora and then me. Hand us to Prime maybe, using our magic, destroying us" Catra stops for a second, feeling the weight of her baby in her hands. "Finn changed everything. Suddenly we weren't as important. Suddenly they had a new goal, a new jewel crown to fetch. The- the Lady of the Lake, Serenia, said that as long as the Heart of Etheria was safe the magic would have a chance. But she didn't mean Adora, I see that now. Because Adora wasn't the Heart of Etheria anymore, the magic balance of our world. They were the last Pendragon no more. It was Finn."

Bow gulps, dizzy by all of this information. Glimmer is looking at Catra with a terrible expression, fear and rage and indignation and desperation. Her wings are ruffled top to bottom, the air around her sizzling dangerously with charged magic. "They want Finn? The Horde wants Finn?"

"Look at who they are, Glimmer" Catra gets a hold of Glimmer's arm, her eyes frantic. "They are the child of the last Pendragon, of Adora, the heir of Camelot. They are *my* baby, Glimmer, they are going to inherit Avalon's power, Halfmoon's throne, and my mother's heritage. Everything. If Etheria's hope resides in anything, it's on Finn." Catra gulps, her eyes drenched in black. "I don't want Finn to live like this, like us, in fear and running away. It was the reason I never thought of having children until Adora. I want them to live in a free world, where they can be happy and laugh and dream and use their magic freely. That's all I want"

The air cracks in two over their heads, swirls of dark clouds closing in the night sky, the ground trembling just a little under their feet. Glimmer slips her hand under Catra's elbow, holding her gently but firm. "We are not going to let them. Do you listen, Catra? We are not going to let the Horde get near them. We are here with you and they are going to go down and burn into ashes before they even go and try to place a finger over Finn. Alright?"

Catra's eyes finally focus Glimmer's, striking blue and gold against crystal purple. Slowly, Catra nods, starting to believe her friend's words. Bow doesn't add to it, choosing to tangle his fingers with Catra's, his other hand resting over his wife's back.

"How did you get out?" asks Bow, softly. Behind them, the last of the villagers are grouping in the Arcane Circles. "That dragon- damnit, they aren't even supposed to exist anymore and they- they crashed against the castle. The entire left wing collapsed"

"Melog took us out" Catra says it so simply, resting her weight over her shapeshifter friend. Bow frowns, not really understanding.

"And the dragon-"

"Melog took us out" repeats Catra, slowly, pronouncing every word with meaning. Bow looks at her and she to him, eyes locked for some heavy confusing seconds until comprehend falls into his face.

"Oh," says Glimmer, in a whisper, and then higher, her eyebrows up on her forehead and her eyes and mouth so wide it's almost funny. A few knights turn to look at her with curious and amused looks. " *Oh* ! What the *hell* ?! Why did you never tell us?!"

"I obviously didn't know, Sparkles" musters out Catra, rolling her eyes. Her sudden annoyance is so much hers, Glimmer and Bow shared a tiny victorious smile. "This is on my mothers. They gave me Melog to protect me when I was little past a toddler. They must have known exactly what was going on"

"I didn't know dragons could shapeshift," Bow adds, looking at Melog up and down with clinical gaze. Melog turns their head towards him and huffs soft in recognition, hot puffs of blue smoke leaving their nostrils, a low rumble in their belly that sounds strangely like a purr. Bow giggles at them, caressing the top of their head with his hand. Catra smiles, very tiny, at both of them, shifting in her place over the log to sit better as she tucks Finn back into their blanket, cleaning their little mouth from errand drops of milk still stuck on their peachie fur. The change of position makes her foot fall into the ground a little bit harsher than wanted, a mild painful pull raising on it. So, definitely still not a hundred percent well.

"In your defense- *ouch* - nobody knows a lot about dragons." Catra turns a little towards Melog, one of her elegant eyebrows crooked. "You and I will have a talk about this later." Melog blows a gentle puff of smoke to her face in answer.

Catra searches around them with her sight, miraculously finding the satchel Double Troubles had prepared for her before they started running, resting a few feet away from them. Bow fetches it for her, handing it to her before turning to the rest of the knights and sorceresses forming around the arcane circles. Catra peaks inside the satchel as they speak, finding a fresh change of clothes for her, a couple tiny more for Finn, milk bottles, changers, Bow's blanket and the little ragdoll inside, along with some packages of fresh bread and cheese. She smiles, grateful, making a mental note to thank the shapeshifter and have a serious talk with them the next time they see each other. Goddess knows just exactly what Light Hope made them go through. Glimmer stands from the floor, ruffling her skirt and feathers off rests of

dust and ashes still scattered in the ground. One of the knights parts from the circle in the side, looking at the two queens with an apologetic look on their face.

"We are ready for you, your majesties"

"The rest of the people?," asks Glimmer.

"Already in Brightmoon, your Majesty"

"Good," Glimmer turns to Catra, Finn and Melog, placing her hands on her hips. She tries to put on some kind of snarky, sarcastic face but there is worry still etched in the edge of her lips. "So, Melog is a dragon, the Horde wants Finn, Camelot is burning- anything else I have to process in the next five minutes?"

Catra blinks up at her, unmoving, and then says. "I'm not going with you to Brightmoon"

A beat passes. Then two. Then comes Glimmer high pitched alarmed squeal. " *What?!"*

Catra squirms in her place, a blush raising in her cheeks before the pointing incredulous looks of her friend. She sighs, tipping her head up, nose to the sky, her eyes hardening as her resolution comes through too. "I think I found a way to bring Adora back"

"A way- what way?," Bow approaches both queens slowly, his face contorted in confusion. Glimmer spins towards him when she sees him coming, throwing her hands forwards to signal to Catra with a wide movement. "Are you hearing this?!"

Bow places a calming hand over Glimmer's shoulder, squeezing the skin there softly as he approaches Catra with a much calmer voice. "What way, Catra?"

"I'm not sure yet," she admits, "But I know I have to find Merlin for it"

Glimmer makes a snotty sound, incredulity mixed with clear anger and worry. "Merlin?! Like, actual Merlin? Catra, this is insane, you can't just go searching for him blind! Nobody has seen him in decades!"

"I do have a clue how to find him" bites back Catra. She catches herself mid-snarl and backs down, relaxing her posture once more. When she speaks again her voice is much quieter and calm. "Look, do you want to know how Melog and I found the way here, even with the magic barrier? There is a place below Camelot, a magic lake where Excalibur was safekeep for years. Adora showed it to me. It's- empty, now, frozen in place but I think that's where everything started for Etheria. That's the place where magic was born millennia ago. And in that place the water didn't work like it should, instead of going down into the lake it went up, away and traveling out of the cavern. Melog took us down there when the castle collapsed and we followed the flow all the way through the woods and, how much of a coincidence it must be that it crosses exactly the place where we decided the passages should end?" She breathes in, shaking her shoulders. "I have to go. If I follow this flow until the end I might be able to find Merlin and he should know how to bring Adora back, or maybe she is with him, I don't know. But I have to do it, is my only choice"

Glimmer is speechless, red spots marked in her cheeks. Bow tilts his head to the side. "Who told you all of this?"

"Razz did"

"Adora's nana?," questions Bow with a frown. Catra sighs, crossing her arms to nestle Finn inside them.

"She is not only her nana, Bow, she is her grandmother"

Bow muffles a nervous chuckle, scratching the back of his neck. "Mhm, no? Queen Guinevere is Adora's- *Oh, shit* "

Catra looks up and towards Bow, an amused smirk appearing in her lips. "What a mouth, Arrows. Sparkles and I have been teaching you well" she jokes, but her expression falls almost immediately. One of Finnie's little hands comes blindly to grapes an errand lock of her dark hair, Catra interlock her pinky with the tiny hand of her baby, booping their nose with her finger. "I have to do this. There is no other way"

Glimmer shakes her head from side to side, displeasure written all over her face. "This is madness. This is pure madness. You just had a baby, the Horde attacked us. You are just in shock, that's it, shock. See? Tell her, Bow" she elbows her husband in the ribs, calling for his attention. When he remains quiet, Glimmers turns to him, eyes wide. "Bow?"

"I mean," starts Bow, gently, "-if Razz was the one with the idea-" he trails off, not daring to finish the sentence. Glimmer opens her mouth in shock, looking between Catra and Bow with clear indignation.

"Are you serious?!"

"Glimmer, I think that if anyone were to know Merlin's exact location it would be Queen Guenievire" Bow holds his hand, reassuring her. "They were friends after all"

"And we are Catra's friends, which means we get to tell her this is a horrible idea!" she throws back, kicking the grass with her foot.

"Glim, even if that is true, I don't think there is nothing you and I can say that would make her change her mind" Bow looks back at Catra, his expression melancholic and sad. "You already made your decision, didn't you?"

Catra looks at both her friends, quietly. She literally cannot stand them. They are loud and sticky, always hugging each other and others, always laughing too hard and sprinkling everywhere. She loves them so much. They were there when Adora was gone, they were by her side when she had to carry her kingdom and her pregnancy alone, they held her hand when Finn was born. They were *there* and she loves them. And now she has to leave them too.

"Listen both, I- Adora and I made a vow to each other and- They never gave up on me, ever. So I'm not going to give up on her now" Catra folds and unfolds her claws softly, her ears

flicking nervously. She looks down at Finn, watching them drift into a peaceful sleep. "I need her, we need her. She deserves to be Finnie's mother. She deserves to see them grow. And Finn deserves to have her in their life. This is- I know.how this is going to sound, but this is not only about the war anymore. This is about my family, so I will do whatever I need to achieve so."

The three friends look at each other heavily, tension tight between them ready to snap any second. After a few long couple of seconds, Glimmer sighs, her shoulders dropping forward in defeat. "How are you even going to go?"

"Melog will go with us" says Catra, smirking as she nudges her dragon-now-horse in the side. "I think having a dragon under the sleeve will keep us very well protected".

"The Horde is going to try to hunt you down, you know that?"

"The Horde will think I went with the rest of the people. You said it yourself Sparkles, this is insane, thinking I will go in separated paths is the last thing they are going to look forward to," Catra shrugs, successfully tempering down the shiver that runs down her spine. Glimmer looks at her intently.

"Alright. Alright, fine. But you need to promise that you will stay next to Melog all the time. And if you are in *any* kind of danger, no matter where you are, you will send an emergency firelight and we will go where you are" Glimmer taps the floor with her feet, anxious. "And one more thing. If you don't find anything by the third day, you will come back to Brightmoon immediately".

"Sparkles, I'm not a child"

"Just promise it, Catra!". Catra looks at the alarmed expression in Glimmer's face, worry etched in all her factions, and sighs.

"I promise it". Catra stands in wobbly feet, ignoring the still tension in her ankle as she rewraps Finn inside Adora's cape and hangs the satchel on Melog's back. The fire in Camelot has started to subdue, which means it will not take long for the Horde to start searching through the woods. They have to move now.

The last of the sorceresses starts to prepare the last arcane circle, ready to take themselves and Brightmoon's regents back to their kingdom. Melog stands up from the grass, shaking their equine mane, blue hot steam still spiraling out of their nose, waiting patiently as Glimmer and Blow approach Catra one more time. Glimmer exhales, standing on her tippy toes and wraps her arms around Catra's neck in a loose hug. Bow steps in too, circling both of them between his long arms, squeezing them gently. Finn wriggles between the three of them, meowing sleepily, their little nose scrunched in confusion by the sudden movement. Glimmer and Bow turn their heads towards them, leaning down. Glimmer places one small kiss over Finnie's forehead, brushing the baby hairs back as she brushes her lips over their forehead. Bow leans in to place one tiny kiss too, exactly over the same place. Like this, they can actually see how tiny Finn actually is, barely three weeks old, beautiful blue eyes peeking up at them when they kiss them goodbye. Over Finnie's forehead, right in the place where their godparents have kissed them, a tiny light starts to form shining brighter and brighter in blue

light and then dimming back down, absorbing into the skin and sending swirls of sparkling magic across their cheeks. Over the exact same place the light was born, a small mark shines pretty and sweet on their forehead, shaped like a seven arms star and not much bigger than a fingernail, it shimmers against the light of the noon like a winter star. Catra gasps softly, running her finger pad over the star. It doesn't feel like a scar at all, the skin smooth and soft under her finger with just the slightest drum of magic coming from it.

"It's a protection spell," says Glimmer, fidgeting with her hands. "It will keep them safe."

Catra looks at both of them, the softest of expressions drawing in her face. Yes, she loves them very much. What a strange thing, gaining a family.

Melog lowers to the ground once more, waiting patiently as Catra accommodates herself over their back, one hand grabbing the magic mane on their neck, the other supporting Finn's head. Melog turns to look at them sideways, making sure they are securely sitting before straightening up. They are really an intimidating animal, even in this equine form. His head raises above Bow's head, long and powerful legs and a wide head. Catra looks small over them, clothed in her black cloak and her wild hair. Melog walks slowly to the limit of the barrier, on the side where their dragon sight saw the neon flow of the magic lake when they were flying on the sky. Bow guides Glimmer towards the sorceresses and knights, softly walking her until she is inside the circle. He knows about the pull of worry on his wife's soul right now, he feels it too, this is Catra and Finn after all, this is part of his family too. But for some reason, something deep inside.of him tells him this is a journey for Catra alone.

"We can still go with you," exclaims Glimmer to Catra, shaking with nervousness. But Catra shakes her head in denial, her expression as calm as possible.

"You need to be in Brightmoon and protect the people. We don't know what the Horde's next move might be. They attacked us, yes, but they didn't manage anything with it," then, Catra turns to the knights, her expression solemn and magnificent. She has changed in a second, the knights can see the regal and strong figure of not only a mother but of their Queen and King, standing straight and lethal over her magical horse. The knights gulp, straightening in their positions as the Queen addresses them. "To the people of Camelot, tell them this. The Horde Empire might have attacked us. Threatened our homes and our peace. But they achieved nothing. They took nothing and they will never take anything ever again."

The knights' eyes glisten a little but they nodding nonetheless and step into the arcane circle too. Melog waits patiently next to the barrier limits, their ears twitching as they supervise the woods around them. Catra holds herself tight over their huge back and not for the first time she feels glad that she indulged Adora with those riding lessons all those months ago.

Glimmer and Bow hold hands, the circle starting to shimmer with pink energy, the edges of the vision around them starting to get blurry. At the same time, the magic dome above them trembles a little, ready to drop the moment Glimmer transports into Brightmoon. Catra looks at her friends, feeling strangely familiar. Absently, she wonders if this is how Adora felt before leaving for Halfmoon. Finn kicks a little on their sleep and she thinks that no, it must have felt worse.

"Be careful, alright?" says Bow to her, his eyes hooded with sadness. Glimmer worries her lip with her front teeth, tiny drops of tears starting to form in the edges of her eyes. She smiles at Catra, worry hanging from it.

"Take care of them, kitty cat."

Catra smiles back at her, eyes soft and teary. "That's the plan Sparkles" and then, in a flash of nostalgia she adds. "Take care of each other"

The arcane circle takes them away alongside the safety of the magic dome. Catra turns on Melog's heels, bursting into the woods at full speed.

✾

The Horde Army stand straight one next to the other in the outskirts of Camelot. Their white armors are scratched on parts, helmets bent after heavy rocks hit them, throats sore and closed for the dense smoke that keeps rising from the beautiful blue and golden buildings that form the Downtown. Some of the soldiers' hairs are burnt, sticking a harsh stink on their skins and underclothes. The burns, however, hadn't come from the green fires they themselves had raised. It came from the blue fire of an ancient creature, bigger than Castle Grayskull, purple scales shining under the light of the sunset, fire so hit it had melted the steel of their swords and weapons. This creature didn't smell like powder or plastic, it smelled like thick clouds of storm and fresh cut grass and burnt meat and something electric, but not artificial like the weapons of their leader, something real and heavy with magic. The soldiers tremble before their memory, pieces or armor clanking against each other as they try to subdue the shakes. They can't allow themselves to show vulnerability or fear, not before the Emperor. These people had given up many things to below in the rows of his army, family, friends, magic itself, fear was not acceptable in the perfect world of his master.

The soldiers hear a dissaray of sound approaching and from the collapsed pillars of the main gate, the same through which they walked earlier sorted by Camelot's Advisor, bursts out Emperor Prime, his face contorted in raw undeniable rage. His artificial hair is a mess, chunks of steel hanging broken from a few cords that crisp and die with electricity. His white, pure, tunics are broken and stained in dark ash and greens moss. There is a very notorious stain in the middle of his chest, veins of blue and purple and golden light that creeps from it up to the steel on his neck and chin. His expression is raged, a snarl on his face so angry and frantic the soldiers feel the pull of step back and away from him. And his voice is worse, hoarse and irate, as he looks to every side of the gate and into the few trees at the starts of the forest that had crisped on fire.

"Where is she?!," Emperor Prime screams, loud and terrible. When nobody answers, Prime marches to the rows if soldiers, kicking a piece of fallen wood so hard the thick piece breaks in half. "Where is that magicat girl?!"

"We have searched everywhere, my Lord," speaks up one of the Generals of the main rows, holding a burnt white sword on his left hand. His expression is harsh and cold, though is still slightly weary of his Emperor standing right in from of him with a furious growl on his lips. "There is no track of her or the child or the- creature anywhere inside the kingdom. They

must have run away" he says, referring last of the huge dragon that had bursted out of the castle and lost themself among the clouds.

Emperor Prime regards the General's words in silence. He finally straightens, running his hand over his broken cords of hair, face hardening. He grasps the handle of the soldier's sword, snatching it out of his hold, turning it around just to stab it deep and merciless inside the General's chest. The general only has time to gasp before his white figure collapses into the ground, black ooze slipping out of the wound. Prime let's go of the sword, a disgusting look on his face as he sees the tiny drops of black that have managed to stain his steel skin. The Emperor turns back to the rest of the soldier's, still unmoving in their places.

"Where is the witch?!"

"I am here, my Lord," the shadows of the tress next to him shift and part, out walking Shadow Weaver, her hair floating behind her like black tentacles, her porcelain white and red mask up in her face, expressionless and cold. Prime snarls at her.

"Seems that your *carefully thought plan* didn't work out, witch. That girl smarted you out," he scoffs at her, mocking, slowly satisfaction slipping into his tone as he humiliates her. "Two years of waiting, wasted, all because on *one, single, magicat* that you made me think was too weak or stupid to achieve anything. How does it feel to be bested by the same little girl that banished you from your own world, *Shadow Weaver?* "

Shadow Weaver stands in place, so still it almost doesn't feel like she is moving. She sighs, crossing her hands over her dark red skirt. "She indeed outsmarted *us*, my Lord. She must have suspected something about our spy and keep her contingency plans for herself."

"And, care to says witch, who's fault is that?" Prime stands in all his height, looking down at her with disgust. "I should have know anything good would come from trusting Etherians and their magic. Where is the Advisor?"

"We still haven't found her, my Lord," chews out Shadow Weaver, biting her tongue against his tone of voice towards her.

"Then you better do it quickly, witch. I want a word with her," he points directly at Shadow Weaver's face, a menacing threat on his voice and posture, venom and rage pouring out of him like a venomous viper. "And I want you to put a bounty for that girl. I don't care how, find her and bring her to me, or it will be your head the one that I use as warning for the rest of *your* kind."

Prime walks further, pushing Shadow Weaver out of the way with his shoulder as he steps into the forest and back into his steel caravan. The army straightens up and marches behind him, always obedient. Nobody sees Shadow Weaver's expression below the mask, angry and cold and ready to hunt down.

❀

Catra has been riding a little bit over six hours. Her back is sore, her feet numb and cold, the tip of her ears lowered all the way down towards her head. There are lilac bags on her eyes and she has been catching herself blinking more and more sleepy as the minutes and hours pass but she holds herself with nails and tooth to her consciousness, not allowing herself to sleep. She's had to stop a few times, mostly to feed and change Finn and allow Melog to rest their legs and maybe to chew a few pieces of bread and cheese for herself. They've been following the neon flow of water, up and down hills and too soft patches of grass and moss and dirt. Following the flow had been almost too easy thanks to Catra's excellent night sight. It draped itself around rocks and patches of earth, something getting as wider as a small river, sometimes turning tinner like a single cord. It didn't make a sound as it moved over the ground and the earth didn't feel damp around it. It lived on its own space, guiding Catra across the woods of Etheria.

She had started her journey at night, leaving the remains of the kingdom Adora had gifted her behind, thick clouds of smoke obscuring the starry night. Now, the sun is almost coming up again, the night moon going down slowly, drenching the world on lilacs and dark blues. The early spring breeze is chilly and Catra nuzzles herself tighter inside her dark cloak. She has changed her torn clothes for the change Double Trouble had packed for her, everything except Adora's coat, which is still draped around her shoulders, arms and torso. Finn hangs from her chest inside their wrap, deep asleep and nestled in the folds of their baby blanket, warm and unfazed by the rhythmic walk of Melog's steps. Their warmth slips into the bones of Catra's chest, cooing her further and further into her own sleep. Truth is that she hasn't slept a notch in a little more than twenty four hours and she really is exhausted.

The third time she catches herself closing her eyes a little too long she shakes herself awake, patting Melog gently on the neck. "Hey, Melog? Let's stop here a little bit"

Melog stops immediately, finding a well tucked piece of grass where they let themself lower down, allowing Catra to step softly down their back without waking up Finn from their sleep. Once Catra is safely sitting in a soft patch of moss, Melog stands again, shaking their hair from side to side. They start neighing, walking in the circles on their place as their entire body starts shining in soft purple light. Their figure shrinks and shrinks until they are about Catra's height.

"Melog?" asks Catra, as long legs turn into powerful wide ones and Melog transforms into their panther form, huge figure walking towards her and letting themself fall into the ground behind her, their body curling around her back until their big head is resting right next to her knee. Catra sighs, letting her back rest fully over Melog's, warmth slowly slipping back into her bones from the heat they radiate. She doesn't dare to light a fire, no matter how cold the breeze is, not with the Horde probably already looking for her. Instead, Catra guides her magic to the center of her chest, keeping Finn warm inside their blanket as the cold dawn starts to draw over them.

Catra sighs, looking up at the deep blue and orange and red sky, fighting back the treacherous sting of new tears forming in her eyes. Camelot's smoke still lives in her lungs and even if she breathes easier knowing its people are, for now, safe inside Brightmoon, it doesn't make any better the nasty, rotten feeling of having failed them all. The tears fall down her cheeks without warning, leaving paths of cold over her skin, still covered slightly in ashes and dirt

and blood. In this small space inside the woods of Etheria, following a magic flow like a lifeline, Catra feels small and alone. She is, after all, still so young, barely twenty six and just became a mother of a kitten so small and beautiful and perfect it turned her world around her heart and changed everything. Catra bites her lip, thinking in the place she learned to call home, now under the destruction of a madman, a witch who seeks to destroy her and the woman who betrayed them all. She should have seen it coming, she repeats herself over and over refusing to give in to the sleep that calls her, she should have, everything was there, every clue and strange behavior and uncalled hostility. Cara should have known Light Hope was betraying them and had no doubt in taking her down, but Catra's time with Adora had given her something she didn't have in all her years before. Hope, hope for something better. Hope that better people exist in the world. Hope for a brighter future. Hope for an undying love. Hope for a family, hope for someone to stay.

Everything was gone and yet, *and yet,* Catra would do it all again exactly the same if that meant having the weight of her child and the bright of her winged pin in her chest. It was a thought so selfish it made her soft to her stomach.

"It's all my fault," says Catra, and then in a lower, angrier voice, she repeats. "It's all my fault."

"It's not"

Catra is on her feet in an instant. She holds Finn's head safely on the dip of her collarbones, the other one extended forward in a defensive stand. She is still exhausted so her magic doesn't light like it uses to but the temperature still drops even lowers, puffs of steam leaving her mouth when she speaks.

"Who is there?"

" *It's me, Catra"*

Catra turns from side to side, until her sight drops on Melog, still sitting calmly on the ground. She look at them and then actually *looks* at them, her mouth widening in surprise and mild shock, stepping closer to them.

"Melog?"

"Indeed." answers Melog, amused. Catra gasps, lowering back to the grass and leaning towards them. She regards them for a few seconds and then her eyebrows crook and frown.

"What, the hell Melog?"

There is a rumble, like a laugh, deep and vibrating. The voice is neutral, neither old or young, and it resounds inside Catra's head like bells, loud and clear. Catra looks around them, suddenly hyperaware of the silence and quiet of the woods. Melog shakes their mane, their panther head pushing softly against Catra's knee.

" *Do not worry. Only you can hear me. And Finn, but they can't really understand me yet"*

Cayra gapes at the panther, shifting in the grass. Her heartbeat thundering inside her ribcage and the rush of her ears hitting inside the delicate bones of her head. "What do you mean by that?," she asks, as composed as possible.

It doesn't seem to fool Melog, because their torso starts to vibrate with a low and comforting purr as they speak. " *Only members of Halfmoon's Royal Family can understand the language of dragons. Kind of being able to do Foresight. Empress Ziba and I held long conversations pretty often."*

Catra looks at them and then some more, and then she sniffs, cleaning the mist out of her eyes with the back of her hand, absently rocking Finn from side to side.

"You've been able to speak with me this whole time? And you never told me?"

"The right time never came"

"It's been over ten years, Melog," deadpans Catra, numb. Melog doesn't answer, only flipping their tail over the grass in amusement. Catra gulps, brushing her hair out of her face. "Alright, alright"

"Don't freak out"

"I am not"

"You are. I can feel you"

Catra huffs, mildly annoyed by the smugness. She has always known that Melog had a temper of their own but it was one thing to see a small cat hiss and sway their tail away and another to hear them inside her head.

"How come you never told me about this?" Melog blinks slowly at her, regal and calm.

"It was one of the most important secrets in Halfmoon, only the Queens knew about it", Melog sniffs the air, leaning towards Catra's chest to smell softly Finn's hair. " *It was supposed to be passed from generation to generation at the time of the coming of age. But your mothers died when you were only sixteen and there was never time before it"*

"Why didn't *you* tell me then? You've been with me since I was eight," annoyance starts to grow on her heart. She doesn't like to be lied to. "If my mothers weren't there anymore, you could have told me. I was already the queen, I was your friend."

Melog seems to actually feel her displeasure because they crawl in the grass closer to her, nudging her with their big head in the side of her arms. *"I'm sorry"*

Catra inhales, holds, exhales. She nods with her head, dropping her shoulders forward. She isn't angry with them, she doesn't want to be angrier than she already is with the world. She just feels tired that everyone and everything seems to be keeping things from her all the time. A couple of long minutes pass. Melog remains silent, inky their purr filling the air. The cold breeze starts to subside as the sun and the day moon come up, filling the woods with golden light. They will have to restart their journey soon.

"If it's such a big secret, then- maybe- are they-"

"It's only me now" answers Melog, closing their blue eyes. " *There is no one else. Not after Uther. Not after Prime."*

Catra holds her breath, biting back a swear. Anger and hate pools inside her belly, hot and poisonous, slipping into her tongue and the tears stinging her eyes. Melog raises their head towards her, pressing their forehead to her temple in a reassuring motion. *"It's all alright",* and then in a very careful whisper, *"I know you've suffered too."*

Catra fumbles with the edge of Finn's blanket, the one Bow knitted for them, rolling the fabric around her fingers. Her head swims with a hundred things at a time, thoughts crashing one against the others and ringing in her head. She had escaped from the hell Camelot had become into no less than a day ago. Saw the last place she could call home fall into crumbles so easily, saw her people, Adora's people, their people, run away and hide, alive, but unfair. Saw memories buried among white stones and green fire. She had been shaken by betrayal and threat and danger, and still, one thing stuck out of everything else. A secret, or a truth or both, coming out to the surface after years of waiting, used to break her or made her anew. Still, she needed to know.

"There is something Prime said," Catra starts. Melog's ears perk up in attention but they don't speak, allowing her time to think at her own rhythm. "He said to mock me and hurt me, but then Light Hope mentioned it too." Catra closed her mouth, fighting against a whimper. "They said that Adora and I grew up together. That we spent part of our childhood, together, in Halfmoon. And they said- they said that I hurted Adora, that it was me the reason why she didn't remember it" Catra's breathe trembles, her hands balling into tight fists, nail pickling into the skin of her palms. "They said my mother took my memories away from me."

Melog doesn't speak for a long time, or maybe a couple of seconds. When they do, however, their tone is melancholic and apologetic.

"It is true. Adora and you were together for almost six years. And you loved each other every second of them"

Catra turns slightly towards Melog, her eyebrows shot up in her forehead and her eyes teary but resoluted. "You were there?"

Melog nods, their big head up and down before resting it in Catra's lap. *"I'm far older than you think, Catra. And I used to walk around the castle like this all the time,"* they stop, as if to reminisce about something. *"But I wasn't there, that day, nobody was. Nobody but Adora, you and Light Spinner"*

Catra's blood freezes in her veins. "Shadow Weaver was there"

"Indeed" Melog's sapphire eyes turn cold as icebergs at the memory. *"I remember your scream resounded across the entire castle. It was terrible and scared the entire kingdom to the bone. And by the time your mothers got down the chambers where you two were, Light Spinner's arms were burnt by magic and Adora didn't remember anything of their life in Halfmoon. Nothing and anyone"* Melog blinks at Catra, the saddest of expressions melting

away the cold and Catra feels herself shiver under the dragon's gaze. *"It's true Catra, Queen Tlalli did take your memories, but she did it out of love and to save you from pain. You were too young to suffer like that and too carry a weight you shouldn't"*

Catra thinks about it, again and again swirling in the oceans in her mind. Her shoulders drop forward deeper as sadness and guilt start to sink deeper inside her chest, crushing her lungs slightly and making her heart ache. "So, it was my fault"

"Nobody knows that. We only ever knew what Light Spinner told and I would never believe that" Melog's tone is calm and understanding, not once judging her or pitying her, she appreciates that, especially with this new knowledge weighing over her shoulders. *"I never trusted in Light Spinner's story and know for sure that Empress Ziba never believe it fully either"*

Catra thinks of her mothers, Tlalli, beautiful and kind and strong, always with honey words and wisdom dripping from her hands. Careful, so careful and loving with Catta. Tlalli who carried the weight of what had happened to two kids she loved, who carried the weight of her own daughter's memories, locked and erased and hidden away. Tlalli who got weaker and then faded away by the treacherous poison of a woman that had come to infiltrate inside their lives and turn it all dark and burnt and sad. And Ziba, tall and regal and snarky and full of mercy, always sharp in mind and body but at the same time sweet and loving and comprehensive and just. Ziba who lost Tlalli slowly and unfairly, who's heart was broken so deep she also faded away.

Melog feels Catra's distraught because their purr grows stronger, pressed between her ribs and the bottom of Finn's blanket.

"If something is sure, it is that Adora loved you and you loved her. Always. That never changed no matter how long or far away you were" Catra takes a shaky breath that Melog hears, their tail drumming over the grass. Finn shifts in their dream, their tiny legs kicking softly inside the blanket as they sleep-fight, their little ears twitching gently while they dream. *"There has always been traces of each other in both of you"*

Catra exhales all the air in her lungs. One of her hands comes off the baby's blanket, stretching so she can scratch the back of Melog's ears with retracted nails. Their head is so obviously bigger but the caress reminds her of all those nights when she felt strangely sad and deeply alone, sitting on the edge of her window as she looked up at the huge starry sky. She thinks she understands now what that feeling actually was.

"What do you think happened?," she asks the dragon, cleaning her running nose quietly.

"Me? I think you two saw something you shouldn't and she made sure you wouldn't remember or that no one would believe you. She saw the opportunity to pull you apart and she took it"

"We were just children. What could two children do to her?"

" *You said it yourself Catra, Adora and you are both much stronger when you are together. You compliment and lift each other. Look how powerful you are now, can you imagine what would you two be if you had actually grown together? She wouldn't have stand a chance"*

Melog huffs, blue smoke traveling out their nostrils in swirls. *"I think she is jealous, but most of all, she is scared"*

"Of what?"

"You"

Catra doesn't say anything else, thinking about Melog's words inside her head. Her head is slightly lowered towards her chest and her eyelids and shoulders are scrunched forward with the heaviness of sleep. Melog stands and curls around both Cayra and Finn once more, draping them inside their own natural warmth and now it makes sense why Catra's once-cat was so warm all the time.

"You should sleep"

"I can't" denies Catra, "We have to keep moving"

"We don't know what we will find once we reach the end of the flow. You need to keep your strength," when Catra opens her mouth to protest, Melog adds, *"You can't look after Finn like this. You are their mother, you need to rest too".*

Catra closes her mouth so fast her fangs clank with each other. She knows Melog is right and still, she can't keep away the horrible feeling that she is running out of time and that if she doesn't find Adora now, she might never get another chance. But then Finn snuggles further in her chest and sighs and any thought of fight off sleep any second longer goes flying into the morning sky. Melog is right, she can't take care of Finn if she doesn't look after herself a little bit too. Is the one thing she always insists on to Adora and now she is doing it too.

The top of the trees around them is thick enough to protect them from the early sun lights and from undesired sights, at least for now. Maybe she could allow herself an hour of sleep or so after all.

"Sleep," insists Melog, their purr deepening. *"I'll keep guard. We can keep going until the end after all"*

Catra sighs and nods, placing Finn higher towards her chest, letting their tiny nose rest right besides her pulse point so they can feel her purr against their cheek. Then she lowers down in the grass, resting her entire side over Melog's back and own side, her legs crossed behind her and tail curled around her body. She lets her eyes fall closed, still loosely gripping to the faint remains of her consciousness. She can see Camelot behind her closed eyelids, and next to it, Halfmoon. Sorrow grips in her heart and throat, crawling uncomfortable and terrible into her.

"Everything is really gone, isn't Melog?"

She doesn't need them to answer, she saw it. The roofs bursting into flames, the pillars collapsing on themselves, the beautiful carpets crisped, the white marble covered in ashes. She saw her tower, the one she shared with Adora for so many days and nights, broken in places, the balcony gone, white petals falling down like rain. That was the place that had become her safety and security. In that place she got to meet Adora, not the bright knight or

the golden king, but Adora. Where they joked and laughed and talked for long nights about whatever. Their laughter filled every corner and wall. Adora's stars illuminated the darkest of nights. That was the place where Adora allowed themself to be vulnerable, where Catra answered in kind, inside those cotton blankets with the headboard full of flowers. There Adora had made love to her again and again, their sweetness pressed against her as they drank on each other's honey. And the place where Adora had gifted her of their own heated moans. It was the place where they said hello and goodbye, where Catra waited for cold, long nights, with her heart in pieces and her hope in her fist. It had been the place where Finn had been born, surrounded in the warmth and love of the place their mothers had made off their home. It was theirs and now it was gone.

"I lost Camelot, Melog. I lost it all." Melog blows a comforting warm puff of breath on her neck, nuzzling their nose against the back of her head reassuringly.

" *You didn't. You saved them, all of them"*

Cayra shakes her head, eyes still closed, sleep quickly and surely wrapping over her bones. "That was Adora's home, Melog"

The answer takes a time to come, maybe because Catra slips into a deep sleep, maybe because Melog thinks about their words for a while. When they come, however, they are clear in Catra's head, the last thing she hears before falling completely asleep.

" *You are Adora's home"*

✾

At the end of that same day, the neon flow of Serenia's lake grows thinner and thinner over the purple moss of the ground. Catra follows it with soft, careful steps, stepping over slippery rocks and down soft patches of deep blue earth. Melog walks beside her, helping her up and down when her twisted ankle starts to act up or when they have to stop momentanelly for Finn to eat.

At some point in the start of the sunset, barely twenty four hours after Catra's visit to Razz and the fall of Camelot, the flow slips into a certain point of the ground, growing so small and thin until the wide river-like flow become merely a bright blue threat that slithers among the damp grass and then loses itself below a small group of smooth looking black stones and completely out of sight. Cayra stops, shaken and confused by the abrupt end of the path. She looks to the sides, up and down, scanning the place with her sharp eyes but everything around them is just thick roads of deep woods and the uncharacteristically silent of its creatures.

"Oh, no," says Catra, stepping right above the place where the flow disappeared out of sight. She lowers to her knees swiftly, scratching the earth and the moss and the rocks around them with frantic urgency

"No, no, no. This can't be it. We are in the middle of nowhere!"

"Catra"

"What?!" exclaims Catra, turning to look back at Melog. Their nuzzle is up in the air, sniffing the breeze around them with their bright blue eyes narrowed.

"Do you smell that?" another sniff and if Melog had eyebrows, Catra would be sure they would be scrunched in concentration. *"It smells like magic".*

Catra's ears perked up in attention, her own nose leaning towards the sky and, there it is, the characteristic smell of something fresh and tingling, like petrichor and sparks of fire. "You are right"

" *There is something around here"* Melon steps in front of Catra and Finn, curling their tail around her waist. *"I think we something is close"*

They wait for a few seconds. There is a soft sound in front of them, twinkling like little bells. The leaves of the dark blue brushes ruffle gently and then more insisting, something crossing and pushing the branches aside. Melog scrunches in front of Catra, a deep and menacing growl rumbling on their chest. Their back shifts like liquid form and a few sharp scales are born on them, their body transforming in something between a panther and a small dragon, sharp and dangerous tail instead of wings, blue hot fire from their mouth, eyes glistening with magic. Catra closes her fist at her side, her ankles well put in the earth ignoring the pull on one of them, her tail lashing from side to side as they wait.

The bushes shake and then, from in between them, comes the bright white shape of an orb, floating gently a few meters over the ground. Catra gasps her defensive posture dropping immediately in her surprise. The same orb that lived in Camelot's tower hovers in the air for a few beats and then softly but surely starts floating towards them. Melog growls, warningly, but Catra places a hand over their back, petting them reassuringly.

"Melog, wait," she says. The orb doesn't stop or hesitates, floating until it's right in front of Catra's face and above Melog's head.

"How did it get here?", asks Melog, fur and scales still on point.

"I don't know," answers back Catra, almost in a whisper, her eyes locked with the white light of the orb which seems to be actually *looking* at her. "Have you been following us?" The orbs shivers, in excitement or recognition Catra can't tell, but it starts moving floating around Catra's head a few times before falling still again in front of her. And then, it seems to lean a little bit more towards her, peaking at the bundle of blankets in her chest where Finn is currently sleeping. The kitten chirps in their sleep and the orb jumps a little in surprise, it's magic aura ruffling like feathers with excitement. Catra exhales, holding Finn closer to her chest.

"Do you know where do we have to go now?" The orb stands there, considers her. Time tics until the orb shakes back and starts moving once again, floating this time away from them and into a new group of bushes and trees, in the same direction the flow worn down. Night is starting to fall and Catra has to rely on her eyes and ears to following the shimmering trail the orb let's behind. Catra rubs her finger behind Melog's ears, giving a step forward. "Come on"

" *Are you sure about this?"* questions Melog, following her behind nonetheless. Catra frowns and bites her lip, ears twitching in her head.

"We don't have another choice"

Cayra and Melog walk inside the woods, following the stele of the orb for so long the sun sets completely and the night starts twinkling above them, moons casting its purple light over the place. At some point, the orb gives a turn and dissapears among a thick group of trees, leaving Catra and Melog in between the silence and the dark. Catra freezes in place, her fur frizzed and her ears twitching like crazy. She looks from side to side but even with her magicat gaze and Melog's sharp dragon eyes, none of them can see anything past the circle of trees around them.

"Shit, where did it go?"

There is a movement in front of them and with it comes the unmistakable sound of branches breaking under solid, real weight. Catra tenses, adrenaline pumping into her veins but she doesn't even have time to react, to sprint back or climb one of the huge trees or jump over Melog's back and get out of there, because the trees part like they were mere hays or weren't even there and from behind them walks a real person.

He is young, probably around Catra's age, with raven hair and blue crystal eyes and skin so pale it looks like snow over rocks. He is also tall, probably as tall as Adora, and skinny but with strong arms. His clothes are old but we'll take care, pants and boots and a brown jacket and red handkerchief knotted around his neck. When he looks at Catra there is no surprise on his face, just calm and mild amusement at Catra's tight expression. The earth shakes a little under his feet, Catra's skin picking with magic and he raises his hands in a surrounding motion.

"It's alright Queen C'yra. I will not hurt you or your baby," his voice is soothing and low, looking to reassure Catra. But she doesn't relax, baring her teeth at him while she takes a step back.

Is in that moment that Mekog moves, brushing their back over Catra's side and when she looks down swiftly at them she sees the dragon has shifted back completely into a panther form and their posture has relaxed, their eyes heavy in Catra's when they speak to her. *"Catra, it's alright. He is safe."*

Cayra narrows her eyes at them, hissing under her breath. "You know him?"

"I do"

"Who is he, then?"

Mekog hesitates, *"I don't think that's on me to tell."*

Catra open her mouth, ready to protest, when the young man beats her to it. "I'm Emrys" he says, "I'm some kind of a druid and some kind of a fae and some kind of a human too"

Catra huffs, incredulous, her eyebrows frunced so hard there is a spark of pain on her temples. "Druids and faes don't exist anymore"

"And yet, here we are. You and I" throws back Emrys, shrugging. Catra breathes in and out hard, unmoving and ignoring Melog's insistent eyes. Emrys blinks at her, unfazed, and adds. "I know you are looking for Merlin."

That takes Catra aback, her tight posture wavering a little. "How did you know that?"

Before Emrys has the chance to answer, the same orb from the castle that they have been following for the last hours floats swiftly from behind his back, approaching Catra and circling her excitingly and charming before settling down again. Emrys looks at the orb with bright eyes, not stepping closer but signaling to a point behind him.

"I know you lost the path a while ago. That's alright, is how it's meant to be," he says, cheerfully. "I can take you where you need to be".

Catra narrows her eyes at him. She knows the power of words and how they can't be bent to someone's benefit. And this? This seems maybe too good to be true, no matter what Melog says. "With Merlin?"

"With Adora"

All the air leaves Catra's lungs and she half gasps half whimpers in surprise, her eyes welling with tears. Emrys sees her and his expression softens, posture relaxing. When he speaks, is even gentler than before.

"I know you've suffered, Queen C'yra. Allow me to help you," he says, apologetic, nostalgic. There is a tone in his voice, something that tells Catra that he understands the storm in her heart and her soul, that he has lived it in flesh and bone, is a kind of sincerity that craves itself in Catra's chest and makes her heart squirm with emotion.

"Why would you do that?"

Emrys turns around, stepping inside the woods. This way, Catra can see the trees actually shift and part to allow him to pass. Emrys sighs, looking at Catra from above his shoulder before starting walking. "I owe it to an old friend".

Catra's knees shake, rooted in place and heart in her mouth. Melog stretches beside her and starts walking on the same path Emrys went, nudging her on the low.of her back with their tail. *"Let's go"*

Together, they follow Emrys inside the woods and down the small hill they seemed to have been standing on. There, the ground stretches and thins, leading to the wide mouth of a cavern. The air is humid there, drops of water falling from the roof and into the stones in the ground. When Catra looks closely, she can see the water is sweet and neon blue, the flow of the magic lake suddenly reappearing from in between the rocks and inside the cavern. The moss around is soft and blue, small blooms of white blooming here and there. The earth rises around them like walls, cocooning the cavern among them and providing it from safety and

hiding it from anyone that would try to look for it without knowing the way in. Catra gulps, giving the first steps inside the caverns. Emrys and Melig are already a couple of steps before her, walking inside the depth of the dark place without hesitation. The air is humid and heavy here, she notices. However, warm air swirls from the insides of the cavern to the cooler outside, forming clouds of low mist over the ground and around the entrance.

Catra looks inside the darkness, her heart thundering inside her ribcage. Finn sneezes in their sleep, nuzzling deeper in Catra's neck, their tiny honey eyelashes fluttering over her skin. Catra sighs, shaking herself off the tension and the fear and straightening her back, her tail curling over her calf and her hands holding Finn closer to herself. Her steps rise echoes inside the cavern, resounding maybe too close or too far away as she walks deeper and deeper over the damp stones and soft earth, her toes digging into it leaving soft footprints behind. There is a narrow space between a couple of heavy looking rocks from which s faint but bright light pours out. Emrys walks inside, Melog close behind him and at least Catra. When she sees the true inside of the cavern, her breath dies in her throat.

It's Camelot's lake. The same irregular dark rocks, the same crystals embedded in the ceiling and the walls, the same black earth soft by the same neon blue water coming in gentle laps from the perfect circular lake in the center of the cavern. The only difference is the direction of the water falling from the roof and into the rocks, raising steam from the earth when it crashes against the water-smoothed crystals. Catra hesitates in the entrance, taking in the appearance of the cavern around her, the painful similarity digging in her bones.

"This cannot be," she whispers, craddling Finnie's head on her hand.

“This lake and Camelot’s lake are twins," explains Emrys. He is standing at the edge of the lake, watching Catra with bright eyes and under the soft blue light they somehow seem to shine in golden shimmer. The orb hovers above his head and the lake, passing back and forward almost anxiously, it's twinkle like tiny bells inside the cavern. Emrys smiles at Catra, softly, pouting at the lake calmly as he explains. "You'll, your Majesty, when the star that brought magic to Etheria fell, it's head crashed into what now is Camelot. But its stele? That fell here, miles away from its counterpart. The river flow was born from the fine trail the start left between its two parts, always connecting each other".

Catra looks at the water, its gentle waves licking the earth around it. It's truly beautiful. Catra blinks and huffs, stepping firmly into the cavern with her head held upwards and her shoulders thrown back. She looks at the young man from in between her dark eyelashes, a frown in her lips.

"That's very nice and everything but, in case you don't notice it, Adora isn't here"

Emrys stares at her, completely surprised by Catra's strong posture and then he starts giggling, short and nervous chuckles that make his big ears move on his head. He squirms a little and stops when Catra's gaze turns sharper, having the decency to turn a few shades of shameful red. He clears his throat, softening again his expression.

"They are" Catra's face sours deeply, nails unfolding. "Are you making fun of me?."

Emrys shakes his head, eyes suddenly growing serious. He points gently at the lake, right on the place where the orb floats without touching the water. "Please, look"

He steps aside and towards the side of the cavern, allowing Catra enough space. Catra looks at him incredulously and then at the edge of the lake, hesitating. She feels a gentle push on her side and turns her sight down to look at Melog, still in their panther form, nudging her shoulder with their nose.

"It's alright, trust me," they say, eyes soft. Catra bites the inside of her cheek, looking at them with a pull of emotions in the base of her throat. She doesn't know what to trust. She is cold and tired and sore. She is trembling from head to toes and her head spins. She is a young mom and a queen who has lost too much. And this seems too good, like too much hope suddenly put on her hands. Melog presses against her again, feeling her distress, their purr calming her just slightly. " *I'm here with you."*

Catra exhales and nods, looking back at the lake. She fumbles with the knots if the baby wraps around her waist, unfastening it with quick and expert fingers, holding Finn's weight betweens both hands. Then she leans towards Melog, motioning them to sit down in the ground, huge paws in front of them, joined in a semicircle. She rests her baby in between their big but soft beans, knotting the red cape that serves Finn as a wrap around Melog's neck, making sure they are well secure on the dragon's hold.

"If something happens, I want you to take Finn and get out of here immediately, alright? Don't stop until you arrive to Brightmoon," she whispers to Melog, caressing Finn's forehead with the pads of her fingers. Melog doesn't answer out loud but they do nod, one single movement with their big head. They lean in and nuzzle Catra's cheek with their nuzzling, lowering down right after and letting their head rest next to Finn's sleepy body.

Catra leans in and presses her lips over Finnie's soft head, kissing the top of their tiny ears before standing back up and approaching the lake. She ignores the blue and gold gaze of Emrys still standing there and steps right in the edge, taking a deep breath and leaning to look right at the center of the lake.

There she is and she is beautiful.

Adora is inside the lake, under the surface of the sparkling blue water that moves in soft waves around their body. His beautiful, handsome face is precious, clean and peaceful with their silver eyes closed to the rest of the world. Their honey hair is loose, floating like butterfly wings around their head. He wears the soft white shirt and gray pants that go below their armor, the pieces of steel and gold missing and nowhere to be seen and like this Catra can see the movement of their abdomen and shoulders as he breathes, even underwater, softly and gentle and slow. She seems to shimmer surrounded by the water, tiny sparks of light sticking to her cheeks and collarbones like starry constellations. There is the scar over the nose and the sun freckles over the cheekbones and the crooked half burnt dark eyebrow and the long, strong hand. There is the soft curve of their waist and the strength of their shoulders and it’s been an entire life since Catra saw her but they are beautiful and Catra loves her more than anything and just as much as the precious baby they made together.

Catra’s knees give up under her and she sinks inside the lake, splashing water everywhere as she makes her way on the water, her limbs heavy and her throat sore and closed, stuttering when she tries to gasp out Adora’s name. Catra extends her arms, sinking them into the water to try and grab Adora and yank them out of the lake. But when she wraps her hands over Adora’s beautiful face, they go right through them as if Adora didn’t exist there at all. Catra grunts and whimpers, confusing falling over her cold and mercilessness. She tries again, running her finger over Adora’s forehead and she can feel her there, the warmth of her skin inside the water, the softness of her eyelashes against her skin, but as much as she tries, her hands keep failing, leaving the water empty and miserable.

Catra looks at her hands, palm scratched, nails broken, the sparkling water dripping out of them heavy like sand, Adora still there, beautiful and ethereal and loved and *there* and somehow still beyond Catra's reach. Catra turns full of rage towards the raven hair man, snarling at him so vicious and dangerous her fangs and molars flash.

"What's the meaning of this?! Where the hell is he?!" Next to the lake, Finn stirs and whimpers softly in their sleep. Melog's purr deepens, their nuzzle nudging Finn's head softly to calm them down. Emrys exhales, his expression growing sad.

"He *is* here and at the same time in another place completely," Catra opens her mouth, ready to yell at him, but he raises his hand in a calming motion, stepping a little bit closer to the water. "Please let me explain. Adora is- stuck. Between the fine veil of our world and the ethereal one"

"What? Why-?"

"What Shadow Weaver tried to do to them, it wasn't meant to absorb their soul and their power, it was meant to kill them." Catra's expression falls, grief falling over her cold like a winter storm and hot like a volcano. Emrys kneels in the ground, right next to where Catra is still standing inside the magic water. "Shadow Weaver is scared. Of them, of you, of both of you together. Adora's power is too great for her, to try and take it for herself would literally tear her apart and she knows it. So instead she seeked to destroy it for good. But she failed" he extends his hand towards Catra, palm upwards. "Do you recognize this?"

There, over the palm of his hand, is a small object. A tiny circle, silver and rose gold, the shimmer of the water making the half moon stone spark with light. Catra gasps, snatching the ring out of his hand and cradling it between her fingers, her ears pressed down in her forehead. "This is my mother's ring. Why would you have this?"

"It saved her life, C'yra," states Emrys, smiling soft and a little bit watery at her. "The protection spell you put in there stopped Shadow Weaver's magic and the last bit of Excalibur's power brought her body and soul here, where she could be strained but safe. She would be dead without this. She would be dead without you."

Catra gives a strangled sob, placing one of her hands on the side of her face and weeping quietly over it. A few seconds of silence happened, only the sound of Melog's purr and the splash of water ringing inside the cavern. Catra feels the weight of the world inside her heart and over her shoulders.

She takes her hand off, shaking herself alert and turning to look at the water and the treasure it keeps locked beneath its sparkling surface.

"Alright," says Catra, brushing the bangs out of her face just for them to fall into her eyes again. "Alright. Tell me what to do."

The shadow of something terribly sad crosses Emrys' eyes and his expression turns grave. He looks down at the water, the bright light reflecting fleck of gold inside his eyes. "I'm afraid it is not going to be easy," he gulps, avoiding Catra's sharp gaze. "The thing is that, this thing Shadow Weaver did, it made the Fates to mark another soul inside their book and they are not ones to listen or to change their mind. Adora might not be dead, she might be protected by the lake's magic now, but sooner or later the Fates will demand for a soul. For them to free her from their grasp, a member of the royal family has to take her place and cross to the other side."

Catra's heart stops beating, like any other time where shock and adrenaline has frozen her blood inside her body. Faintly, she can hear the strong fall of the water from the roof of the cavern down to the lake, she can hear the laps of water against the tiny rocks and the black earth in the edge and the echo of natural sounds around the expanse of that glittering magic space. She can hear Me log stop purring and their head rising from the ground, turning to look sharp and alarmed at the young man still next to Catra. She can hear Me log *talking* to her but she can't make sense of the words, just static and mist, static and mist inside her ears and throat. And she can hear the faint breathing of her baby, sleeping, lost inside their golden innocent dreams, their tiny ears pressed down, those bangs of blonde hair that curl sweetly over their forehead and the chubby side of their face. She can hear the brush if the fabric of their romper against the blanket their uncle knitted them, the way their little nose sniffs the air and they yawn and stretch, their tail wrapped around their own small, warm body. She can smell the clean soap and the lavenders and oranges on their skin. She can feel how much she loves them, this little kitten she carried inside herself for long months, that she has loved since even longer before. The baby Adora loves too and longed for too and gave their life, completely and bravely, for. This kitten that deserves to have both their mothers but that, after this, might just have one.

Someone has to go in for Adora to go out. A soul for a soul, cruel as it may be. And there is nobody else here.

Right now, Catra understands Adora more than ever. About making self sacrificing decisions out of love.

"Alright," Catra says, running her wet hands over the wild locks of her hair. "Fine"

"Catra," calls out Melog, suddenly alarmed. Their eyes are jumping from Catra to Emrys, something very close to fear shining inside the dragon's bright eyes. They don't stand up, their big paws still cradling Finn between them, but their back is arched with tension and their tails lashes in the ground violently. *"Catra, hold on a minute."*

"Stay with Finn," says Catra, hard, firm, a strong command painted with selfless love and bravery. "Listen to me, Melog, stay with Finn. Don't part from their side until Adora is here."

"Catra-"

"It's alright, Melog," Catra smiles, trying to hide her shaking. She doesn't dare to look down at Finn. She can't, she can't see their button nose or their peachy cheeks or their soft head and she loves them so much, she has loved them so much every second, every night and day and step of the way, she has loved them she loves them but she doesn't dare to see them because she will break down and she needs to do this because there is nobody else. It's just Catta and Adora, always has been and always will be. They have each other's backs. "It's alright. I need to get Adora back, Melog, you know I have to. Finn needs them too."

"Catra," now is a full growl, harsh and scared and angry.

"Think very well what you are going to do, Queen C'yra" interrupts Emrys, and he has been so quiet these few minutes it's almost as if he had become just another shadow or crystal in the wall. Behind him, the white orb is moving faster, spinning from one side to the other violently, desperately, its glimmering trail nudging Emrys in the shoulder, crashing against him with all its magic aura. "She was protecting you, C'yra"

“We swore to protect each other,” Catra says, voice shaking but strong, heart breaking but warm, full of love. She stands in the center of the lake, right above the place where Adora is sleeping. She looks at their beautiful face, ready to submerge herself into the magic, merciless water, ready to do anything to bring them back. Besides her, Emrys turns towards the orb. “It’s time I make good of my promise”

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X

It's cold

Adora feels like she is floating in freezing cold water, calm, numb. There are no sounds around. It's just her, the water and the silence.

It's frightening.

Adora can feel the gentle waves licking her back, urging her to submerge themself. To let go.

Yet Adora can't

There is something inside their chest, inside their mind, something that she can't turn away. There is a reason they are still floating in water, it's important, it's the most important thing in Adora's life. She can leave them alone, not now.

Who's them, thinks Adora or maybe says it out loud.

Nobody seems to say the water ***There is nobody else. You can let go now.***

Adora frowns without frowning because she knows her expression is shifting yet her face feels like nothing. As if somehow her soul and her body had been locked, frozen in one

single momentum.

There is nothing here, nothing but the cold merciless water and herself. She can't remember how she got here or how long ago. She doesn't remember ever waking up or going to sleep. If she has been here all along or if her soul was somewhere else, free from the water's prison arms, floating and swirling in the astral paths across Etheria. Searching, always searching. Adora is always searching for something, even floating along the flow of this water. She doesn't remember. She just knows she is here right now and that's it, that should be enough, but it isn't.

How long have I been here?, she asks and she doesn't hear her own voice but she knows it is hollow and sad and exhausted. The water shifts, feeling her, bending in swift motions up and downs and left and right and circling waves, as a detached adult trying to sooth quiet a baby. *Answer to me. How long have I been here?*

Enough, answers the water or the breeze, but there is no air, lapping over her back, holding her scarred hands and the silk of her golden hair. ***You've been here enough. There is nothing else, you can let go now.***

Adora sighs, her chest not moving. They are tired, they are so, so tired. She feels like she has been sleeping for so long but in a kind of sleep that, when you wake up, it has your bones sore and your muscles pulled tight. Or maybe she hasn't been sleeping at all. Maybe if she lets herself sleep she will dream and dreams are good, that she knows, dreams are filled with white light and warmth and the weight of something, something, *something,* that Adora loves dearly.

The water is so cold up here. Maybe Adora can allow herself a few moments. Just a little second under the water. They are tired. So tired.

Maybe if they let go of the rope just for one second...

"Adora!"

There is another voice, there in the silence. It seems far away and it still resounds in Adora's mind like a thousand bells, strong and beautiful and beloved.

"Adora! You have to wake up!"

Adora knows this voice. It's low and rough and a little bit squeaky and so beautiful and dear. It's drenched in desperation and sadness. That 's wrong. That should not be.

"You have never given up on anything in your life. Not even on me, not when I was scared and pushed you away. Not when everything tried to tear us apart. So don't you dare to stay now!"

The beloved voice is scared, terrified, and it shakes Adora to the core. This voice is not supposed to be scared, ever. Is meant only to laugh, loud, free and incandescent. It's meant only for sneaky smiles and squeaky giggles and squeals of joy. Adora's hand twitches over the water, reaching. Always reaching for her.

"Please, I need you. Finn needs you, they need you so, so much"

Who is Finn? Adora asks himself. The strings of his heart give a painful tug at the thought. Finn is important, is scencial. Adora is supposed to protect them. *Who is Finn*

No one answers the water, biting, violent. The waves reach up to her arms, grasping them like tentacles or arms, slowly starting to bring Adora down.

" *They have your eyes. They have your hair and they sleep-fight just like you do. They are so tiny they could fit in the palm of your hand. They hold onto me when I'm wearing your dumb shirts with all their strength, they look for your smell in every corner, every room. They know who you are. They love you Adora, they love you so much. You are so loved, Adora, do you hear me?"*

Adora loves Finn. She is sure of this. There is a huge piece of her heart with Finn's name on it. Like the beating organ has grown twice its size. Big, big, big. Bigger than the water, bigger than a kingdom, bigger than a planet. It's a newborn star, a sun, a moon, an entire galaxy. Stardust floating in the void, collapsing, forming, bending, creating new life, a new love. That 's Finn.

The water is rumbling, suddenly boiling hot, washing Adora's face, spilling inside her mouth and ears, trying to drown her down. But Adora is fighting too, pulling from its limbs with all the strength of her bones and heart and soul, trying to open the eyes she didn't realize she had closed.

" *Don't you get it Adora?"*

Catra . This is Catra, it's Catra's voice. It's Adora's whole world. Catra, oh how much she adores her, how much Adora loves her, she was willing to give her life for her no questions answer no hesitation, no self doubt. Her perfect selfishness. Catra.

The water screams below her but it doesn't matter. Adora's heart has been set aflame. Behind are left the false guilt, the duty, the fear, the self doubt. Behind are left forgotten the ideas of unworthiness, the belief that maybe Adora doesn't deserve all the love she has been given. She deserved them, she knows that now. She fought for them, and now, someone is fighting for her too. She loves and she is loved in return.

She gives a shuddering breath.

"I love you too. I always have"

Adora opens her eyes.

End of chapter XIII part I

Chapter End Notes

Adora Is back but at what cost o.o

(at no cost at all, really, who do you think I am. The happy ending tag is right there. Sheesh)

Which leaves us with the question, who will come to Catra's and Adora's rescue now? We will find out very soon!

Next Chapter: The Lake of Memory will come up on December 25th! (hopefully 'D)

As always comments, kudos and bookmarks are deeply appreciated. Love you all!

Chapter 15: The lake of memory

Chapter Summary

Adora comes to her senses with a long gasp. They feel the jolt on their body when it breaks the surface of the water and the hit of cold air against their damp skin, sending shivers down their back and arms and she has never felt so alive.

Chapter Notes

Hello and surprise! I decided to post the chapter earlier as a surprise gift! (if you celebrate, or maybe celebrate something before or later or even if you don't celebrate anything at all!

Hope you are having a great weekend and that you enjoy this chapter!

Warnings: mentions of a past death

See you at the end! 3,2,1 ho, ho ho!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 13 Part II . The lake of memory

'Take me with you,' she cried in her heart.

'Take me! Drag me down like you did the others!'

But the lady in the lake was different now.

The lady in the lake was also Dani.

And Dani wouldn't. Dani would never.

— The Haunting of Bly Manor

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x

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"Wait"

The voice stops Catra immediately, cold replaced by sudden warmth. That voice, is familiar and strange all at the same time. New and old, here and away. Catra looks at her reflection on the surface of the water, the lilac bags under her tired eyes, the unruly hair, the sadness melting away and replaced by surprise. She still can see Adora below the water and somehow Catra recognizes that voice that speaks now to her inside a voice that she knows dearly. Catra blinks and then raises her head, looking at the direction from which the voice now speaks to her.

The woman's eyes are infinitely kind, silver and purple swirling in magic mist. Her clothes are loose and a little bit old fashioned, the high boots and pants making her look tall and the embroidery on her shirt drawing Camelot's dragons on the fabric. Her hair is long and wavy, held in thick dark braids aways from her face, which is soft but mature and scattered with small scars here and there. A strong jaw and curved nose and the way her cheekbones arch and her lips curve in a soft smile is so much Adora, Catra has to take a sharp breath.

"Mara," gasps out Catra, her hands breaking the surface of the water and her mouth open wide in shock.

Mara smiles at her, gently and loving, so loving is swirls Catra's head completely. Mara is standing right at the edge of the lake, her feet touching the start of the water which seems to swirl in a sudden spark of magic and then melt itself into Mara's body, giving her form an incandescent radiance. She doesn't look *real* . She looks like a memory, her body waving here and there, no solid but as if the steam of the water had taken a shape of its own, glowing like the crystals when the water's light touches them. Catra can see slightly through her and it reminds her of watching the world through the golden glass and crystal of the chandeliers in Camelot, making everything shine in rose golden light. Her hair floats softly behind her, by some inexistent breeze inside the claustrophobic cavern, and her shoulders don't move when she breathes.

Emrys is standing behind her with one of his pale hands resting over her left shoulder, blue light shining out of his palm before he drops it and moves a few feet away. His expression is as calm and collected as it has been the entire time though it softens just a little when he turns to look at Mara's side, whispering low enough that is respectful if the quietness that has fallen over the place but loud enough that Catra can hear it clearly.

"You have a couple of minutes, can't hold it for much," Mara turns towards him, holding his hand between her ethereal ones and nodding.

" *Thank you,"* then she returns to the edge of the lake and kneels into the black, damp earth.

She searches Catra's eyes with her and extends her hand towards her, waiting a few minutes in case Catra were to pull away before placing it on the side of her cheek and stroking her cheek. Is a strange feeling, Catra thinks absently, not entirely real but also firm, like dragonfly wings against the skin and peach fur of her skin. Her hands are short but wide, a strong grip in the way her fingers curl over Catra's jaw. Catra blinks once again and it's until then that she realizes the wet tracks of tears falling from her own eyes and into the lake, forming drops of gold once they mix with the turquoise blue of the water. Mara following the direction of her tears with her eyes, her smile somehow growing gentler and more loving than before, her free hand hovering just above the water to hold Catra's and squeeze softly.

"It's alright, C'yra," says Mars to her. Her voice sounds like a clear bell, low but firm at the same time. There is a ring on it that Catra recognizes, the same one she sometimes hears when Adora is specially soft and vulnerable and that shows how much they are like their mother. The tears in Catra's eyes keep coming, her voice still stuck inside her throat, and Mara rubs the pad of her thumb over her cheekbone, cleaning the tears away with feather touch. " *It's fine, you've been so brave and strong. You've done enough, you don't need to do this."*

Catra whimpers a little, nuzzling her face further inside Mara's hand as she takes in the lines of edge that frame her eyes and the edges of her mouth. In the cavern, Melog has settled down again, resting their big head next to Finnie's sleeping body, but their ears remain up and alert, ready to jump into action if needed. Emrys, on his side, has basically blended back with the wall, watching with silent but respectful golden eyes the scene in front of him. Mara pats Catra's cheek, her knees brushing deeper water as the waves start stretching further towards her. Catra studies her with teary eyes, looking at the mist white halo that clings around her and then back at the cavern, realizing there is something else that has changed.

"It was you," says Catra, leaning back just a little. Her feet don't touch the bottom of the lake, in fact, she doesn't know if there is a bottom at all, instead floating inside the cold water, making her clothes and her light fur stick to her body. Mara's eyes flash with recognition at the statement and the pleased, proud smile on her face prompts Catra to continue. "In the tower, the voice, and then that orb. You took me back to Finn minutes before the Horde attacked Camelot, you guided Double Trouble. You- you warned me. You *tried* to warn me all those times. All this time, it was you."

Mara's dimpled deepen the further she smiles and she nods. There is a pause and then Mara sighs, her shoulders and chest loving but no air coming out of her nose or mouth. The swirls of magic in her hair and face shift a little, getting blurry before coming back into focus. *"It was me"*

"But- you are-"

" *I am dead"* assures Mara with sad eyes. Catra bites her lip, her fang catching in bruised skin. Absently, she can feel her hair drenching uncomfortably by the second but she pays no attention to it.

"I don't understand" she confesses, her ears dropping. The ethereal hand that holds hers squeezes a tach stronger. Mara's sight seems to lose itself somewhere, years and miles far away from them, in a time not so different to this.

"The day I died- it was ordinary. There was sun in the sky, and orange clouds and the day moon. The air was still warm enough to be autumn and the town I was in was at peace" Mara hesitates for a second her face contorting into something much like anger and grief. *"It happened very fast, you must understand this by now, they came out of nothing and whipped away everything in their path. By the time it was almost over, Anillis Kurr and Shadow Weaver had cornered me into the highest cliff. It was just me and them and the void below our feet",* she frowns, " *By that time, Kurr already made himself call Emperor Prime and he offered me the same thing he offered you, peace for my people in exchange for my life and, in my time, in exchange for Excalibur".*

"He had seen Excalibur's wonders at the hands of my father," Mara continues, " *And he was afraid of what it might cause against him, but as I said to Adora once, the sword is just a sword, a beacon of hope for the people of Etheria, a symbol of legend. My father, Arthur, he made many wonderful things, and terrible too, but all that magic was his and Merlin's. It always was like that"* she stops for a second, throwing a swift glance over her shoulder and in the place where the young man is still standing before turning it back to Catra. The gesture doesn't go unnoticed by the last. *"When I denied, Shadow Weaver tried to take me as a prisoner, as a powerhouse, and use the power inside of me to destroy everything else. I couldn't- I couldn't stand that. I was alone, I was surrounded, I was exhausted, I was wounded and I was scared C'yra, I was scared to the very center of my bones. And yet, yet with all of that, I would not let the Horde win so easily and I would never allow them to use me to bring harm to the things I loved so dearly. I saw what they would do, the deaths that would follow and I was willing to fight against it with everything I had left, just to stop it, just to stretch us a second more. I love Etheria, how old and weird and beautiful it is and I love its people, its animals, its plants, the sky, the oceans, the moons and the sun. I would have died protecting it a thousand times"*

Mara pauses, seemingly to catch a breath she doesn't need anymore. Her eyes are bright and hard, boring themselves into Catra's and drilling into the very center of her soul. She doesn't dare to move, no matter how numb the freezing cold water makes her limbs feel. Mara's voice and story have enchanted her, rooting her inside the lake as she feels the woman's words take shape inside her mind, playing the scenes like illustrations of an old, well worn book. With her beautiful face slightly contorted in the grief of a weight so heavy it almost bent her in half, Catra can see just how much alike Adora and Mara truly are.

"I knew they would be alright. Without me. Adora has just turned eighteen and they were brilliant from their young age, and kind and food and the people loved them, all of the Kingdoms. So I knew they would be fine, eventually. And still, inside of me I hoped my sacrifice would make some kind of difference, as selfish that might sound, that it would change the direction of the war or maybe even end it. So, I saw the monsters in front of me, yelling, screaming, trying to tear me apart, and then I saw below, down and down and down into the freezing water of the river passing by. The flow was strong, crashing against the stones with untamed fury, breaking lonely branches in half like nothing. The cliff was high, hovering above the rest of the woods, almost touching the clouds, painted in the oranges and reds and greens of Prime's fire and the witch's magic and the sunset. And I knew I wouldn't survive, that it would be over and still, I had to try."

Mara chokes with her words, overwhelmed by emotion. This time, it is Catra the one that reaches towards her, lacing her fingers with the spectral ones of Adora's mother, helping her as a lifesaver or a rock, keeping her afloat.

"I'm sorry, Mara" murmurs Catra, her own voice raspy and tired. Mara shakes her head, the misted look on her eyes going away and bringing the silver and amethyst back to the present.

"It didn't hurt", she assures. *"I knew I was falling but it didn't feel like that, it felt like flying. And when I touched the water it wasn't harsh and merciless, it was soft, like silk and then everything went dark and I wasn't scared anymore."* Mara worries her lip between her front teeth, turning her sight from Catra's face down to the lake, in the spot where Adora lays, tied

up by invisible hands of the Fates. " *Something happened, between then and the time I was supposed to cross to the other world. I couldn't stop thinking about Adora. She was my child, after all, first than a prince or my heir, she was, is, my child. I kept thinking and thinking about it, and when I opened my eyes again, I was somehow back in my tower, in Camelot, but nobody could hear me or see me, not even Adora locked inside her studio as grief overtook her with the notice of my loss. With time, Adora's heart settled and I retrieved more and more inside my tower until I didn't have a body or a voice, but from where I could watch over Adora and look at her become the wonderful person I always knew she was"*

"I think- I think that's why I got stuck in this world. For Adora. Even if I was sure they would be fine with time, I didn't want to leave them alone. There were still so many things to say, so many things to live. I owe her a lot. A life at peace, a safe home." Her eyes come back to Catra's, honesty and love swimming inside the ghosts of her tears. Catra's guts turn on themselves and she half knows what she is going to say, anxiety and adrenaline pumping out of the atriums of her heart and into her veins. *"I owe her you, C'yra. What Light Hope told you about your childhood, it was true in part, you must know this by now. When my father died, Adora was very small and suddenly not only I had been named king, Prime had heard about my father's death and raged his war against Etheria with all his strength. Even with Merlin's magical barrier, Camelot was too dangerous, I needed to find a place where to keep them safe. I spoke with Razz, by that time my mother had retired herself inside her tower in the woods, and she was the one who talked to me about Halfmoon."*

"You- you really did meet my mothers", says Catra in wonder, a spark of pain pulling inside the cords of her heart.

"I did. They were kind and understanding and they accepted Adora among yours so easily and lovingly. There is no other place I would have sent Adora to. Your moms and your kingdom probably saved Adora's life just by being kind enough to love my child," Mara's hand slips out of Catra's, rising so she can caress the tip of her ears and the top of her unruly hair. *"Whatever happened that day C'yra, I know it wasn't your fault. Look at what you are now, look at what Adora is, look at what you both are together. There were always parts of you on Adora, I saw them as I saw her grow up and I'm sure your mothers saw it too in you. You are worth of everything good that has every happen in your life C'yra, everything."*

Catra whimpers, tiny hiccups and choked sobs leaving her mouth, tears falling free from her eyes. She didn't notice herself start crying again but now that she has she feels the lukewarm drop travel free. "But I haven't done anything," she chokes out, shaken. "I lost my Kingdom, I lost Camelot, *your* kingdom. I didn't know how to win the war, I didn't know how to protect Adora. I didn't know how to save my mothers, I didn't know how to make anything to stay. I've done nothing to deserve it."

"You've done everything C'yra, don't you see? You are so very young and you have truly become an extraordinary woman, a brilliant queen, a brave king. You survive the grief and the pain. You protected our people by being smart and cunning, not violent and sharp. You gave people faith where there were no reasons to believe in anything else. And you are a wonderful mother, C'yra, look at them, look at your child. Look at everything good you have done", Mara's eyes slip towards the place where Melog is sitting, down into the blanket that

keeps Catra and Adora's little baby warm and Catra can see the shape of their clothed little first rubbing their nose on their sleep.

"I don't know if I can protect them," Catra is trembling violently now, the self doubt and pain and anger and grief. The dark, sticky venomous thoughts and the guilt and the sorrow are leaving her body, slipping out of her soul and into the magical water of the lake, leaving her forever, washer away by the gentle words of a woman that seems to have loved her as a daughter too. "I don't know how"

"You love them. That is enough" Mara rests both of her hands over her lap, misted tears also falling down her eyes. "*You've carried them and loved them and protected them this entire time. And you have held my child in your love when they needed it the most. Even now, you were willing to give yourself away just so your child would have their mother back. And you still think you don't deserve having a happy life?"*

Catra looks down, at Mara's ghostly hand tangled with hers. She feels her eyes red rimmed and her heart heavy and sore as the words of Adora's mother sink slowly but deep inside her.

" *What happened to Adora, to Camelot, to Halfmoon, it wasn't your fault C'yra. You are not a failure, nor a villain. You've done the best you could and you did it splendidly. You should be as proud of yourself as I know your mothers are",* Mara brushes a rebel lock behind Catra's soft ear, sad eyes against sad eyes. " *Even with so much pain, you did it all amazing. And I thought I could make it a little bit easier for you still, so I gave you the dreams, so you wouldn't lose hope"*

Catra leans forward inside the water, her ears suddenly perked up and her eyes bright and wide. She holds herself into Mara's hand and the fabric of her clothes, eyes searching and set aflame, alive. "It was you? You did that?"

Mara tilts her head to the side, a tiny amused smile dancing in the dark of her lips and she nods, " *Adora never told you what my magic was focused on, did they?"* Mara laughs under her breath, shaking her head softly amused. *"It wasn't all war, it was also dreams. I'm a Dream Weaver. I can look inside people's dreams, walk on them, settle and change them. But I can also join people, through their minds and the eyes of their souls. I knew Adora wasn't dead as much as you did, even if I didn't know where they were or how to bring them back, I could reach for them and nudge them gently to you. She never saw me but I knew that in those important moments, they were with you. It's the least I could have done. "*

Catra hiccups a little but her tears have subsided enough so she can see the world around her less blurry and watery. She brings one of her hands up, trying and failing to clean the wet paths with her even wetter hand. Mara sizes her forearm and pulls off her gently, bringing her into a soft, slightly angled awkward hug. It's strange, like hugging a cloud, not quite unreal but also not solid enough. Catra can feel the solid press of Mara's arm around her shoulder and of her jaw and nose against the top of her hair, but at the same time she feels her own hands hovering as she rests them on the woman's back, a little bit wavy, as if there were to fall through any second now. And still, Catra allows herself these few seconds of unreality to embrace back her mother-in-law, partially hiding her face in the waves of her dark hair.

After a couple of seconds, a new thought crosses Catra's mind and she leans back from Mara's hug to look at her still, calm face. "Mara, there is something you should know. Something about Light Hope"

"Oh, darling," whispers Mara and in her face the shadow of sadness, and also, of raw betrayal. *"I know, I saw her. I saw her reunite with Shadow Weaver at the limits of Camelot and I saw her plan it all and there was nothing I could do to stop her"* Mara closes her eyes, maybe to try and keep the memories and the pain away. When she speaks next her voice is barely controlled, coming out from in between her teeth in an almost hiss. *"That's not my Light Hope, that's not the woman I knew."*

She doesn't say anything else, but Catra can see the pull of her heart inside of her and the way her love for the Light Hope she used to know and her anger towards the woman who has betrayed them all are fighting tooth and nail against each other. Catra opens her mouth and tries to reassure her, to try and tell her Light Hope did it out of love and desperation and she knows Mara knows this, that she saw it herself, trapped in her own stranded space, watching someone she loved dearly sold out and betray her family. Catra tries, but the betrayal weighs heavier.

"It's not on me to forgive her anymore," Mara establishes after a short while. *"But, if there is something I'm grateful for, it is that inside all the treason and the darkness, Adora and you managed to find each other again. Seeing you as you are now, after watching you stick your fingers in Adora's tooth gaps as they tried and failed to catch your little tail, seeing you now as mothers, that's the best thing I could have ever asked for. And I'm at peace for that."*

Mara stands up, brushing her hair out of her shoulders. She leans a little towards the side and pets Melog on the top of their head, ruffling the fine fur there before facing the lake. The neon blue reflects on the purple and silver of her eyes, making them look like two glowing stones in the middle of the mist light around her body and the shadows of the cavern. Gently, very, very gently, Mara steps inside the lake. She doesn't make a comment about the cold, probably because she doesn't feel it at all, and her face remains calm as she sinks further and further until the waves lick her waist. The water shifts immediately when she enters, the neon stilling for a second before shifting completely. Like a pin dropped onto shaky water, swirls of magic are born from the place where Mara stands, turning the water into pearl white and golden glow. Catra leans towards her immediately, grabbing her hands between hers as Mara half swims and half walks to her. By the time they settle, both of them are half inside the water, one facing the other with their hands tangled and Adora's form between and below them, glimmering inside his golden aura.

"What- what are you going to do?," asks Catra, voice squeaky with emotion. Mara squeezes her fingers, smiling with her entire face.

"My time here is long over, C'yra. I got myself more time to watch over my child and now it's time to do for them what I did for Etheria" she looks at Adora's sleeping face, tears falling into the water. *"I never wanted to die, but I sacrificed myself so Adora would never have to. And yet, they did it anyway, because their heart is good, because it was worth falling for the things they loved. If someone deserves to live in this world it's her, it's you."*

Mara starts to sink even lower and Catra holds her with her entire force, trying to keep her afloat in a spark of sudden panic. "Wait, wait no, what is going to happen to you?"

"I'll be alright, I'll pass to the next world as I should have done years ago, as we all do sooner or later. And one day, dozens of years in the future, we will all meet again" Mara's head starts to sink under the surface of the waters, gently guiding Catra below too. *"It's alright, I'm not scared anymore"* Catra's head breaks the surface's tension and she blinks. When she opens her eyes again, both of them are inside the lake. *"Thank you for loving my child, C'yra"*

Below the water, Mara looks so tangible and real Catra let's a gasp of surprise. She quickly brings a hand to her mouth and nose, trying to keep the air inside her lungs as she waits for the inevitable burn of cold water slipping into her nose and throat. But the feeling doesn't come, it doesn't burn or hurt and, most important of all, Catra doesn't feel out of breath. She takes her hand away, watching as Mara looks at her patiently while she places the pieces slowly together. Catra waits, let's a heartbeat pass, and then closes her hand in fists as she gives a deep breath inside the water. Nothing, like breathing fresh air on a sunny day, Catra isn't drowning.

Mara's smile makes the wrinkles around her eyes to pop but she doesn't stop, diving deeper inside the lake and pulling from Catra's hand until both of them are right in the place where Adora is. Mara slips her arms behind Adora's arms, resting their back in her chest. Adora's hair swirls in the water, her eyelids lilac under the golden light that shines around them. Catra swims by their side too, bringing her hands up to cradle the sides of their face and, this time, she can *feel* them, real and solid and warm under her touch and Catra almost sobs in relief and love.

Catra looks up at Mara, tearing her sight reluctantly from the beauty of the love of her life and admitting with a shaky voice. "I don't know what should I do"

Her voice sounds clear in the water. Mara holds Adora tighter against herself, her golden light shifting, melting with Adora's own golden aura. The woman speaks in a whisper, like a secret only shared by the three of them.

" *Give her a reason to live* "

Catra sighs, rising bubbles inside the water, and then leans towards Adora, pressing her forehead against their softly, reverently, lovingly, their nose bumping together almost playfully and their lips brushing each other infinitesimally close. When Catra speaks, it is in the quietest of whispers, as a secret, meant only for Adora to hear, a light only for Adora to follow.

"Adora," she starts and her voice breaks just a little with emotion, "Adora, you have to wake up"

Around them, the water starts to change, swirling, waving, curving against itself. Mara starts to shine brighter, never letting go of Adora.

"You have never given up on anything in your life. Not even on me, not when I was scared and pushed you away. Not when everything tried to tear us apart." Catra remembers all those days she spent angry, plagued by the prejudice a monster put over head, something that was meant to make her resent the only love in her life. She remembers Adora, bright and clumsy and dorky, such a clotpole, respecting her, admiring her, loving her from away. She remembers the way Adora loves everything around him, selfless, openly, his heart on his sleeve. She remembers the way Adora noticed Catra was changing, so early in her pregnancy, even before she noticed it herself. She remembers the way Adora held their child inside dreams that weren't dreams after all, the bright expression in his eyes, the raw love. She remembers it all, she doesn't want to let go of it ever again. "So don't you dare to start now"

The water is shining brighter, so bright Catra presses her eyelids close and Adora even closer, speaking through clenched teeth and an exploding heart.

"Please. I need you" And then, "Finn needs you, they need you so, so much" She can see the shape of their baby, as clear as daylight, and she smiles against the swirling water.

"They have your eyes. They have your hair and they sleep-fight just like you do. They are so tiny they could fit in the palm of your hand. They hold onto me when I’m wearing your dumb shirts with all their strength, they look for your smell in every corner, every room. They know who you are. They love you Adora, they love you so much. You are so loved, Adora, do you hear me?"

The water is shaking immensely, which makes both no sense and complete sense at all. The bubbles are rising bigger, stronger, popping around Catra's head and hands, like boiling water. Yet Catra can't feel not cold, no warmth at all, just the feeling of Adora's dear, scarred skin against her palms.

"Don't you get it, Adora?" Catra's voice comes as a gasp. She repeats the words she said, many nights ago, surrounded by white light and warmth and love and the undying hope that it wasn't a dream at all. On the side of her face, just above the skin of her cheekbones, Catra can feel the butterfly touch of Adora's fluttering breath. "I love you too, I always have"

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Adora comes to her senses with a long gasp. They feel the jolt on their body when it breaks the surface of the water and the hit of cold air against their damp skin, sending shivers down their back and arms and she has never felt so alive.

He is staring up, his head lolled backwards over the cervical joints of their neck. Absently, Adora registers in their mind that this is some kind of cave, if the rocky and crystal surface of the ceiling has anything to say about it. His breath is coming in tiny gasps, delighted in the feeling of fresh breeze in and out of his lungs and throat, the length of his hair dropped behind his shoulders and half into the water still cradling his waist and legs.

It takes one second, just one little beat if time, for Adora to realize they are partially lifted in the air, their torso and head held away from the water by a pair of slender but strong arms, wrapped around their body tight, almost desperate. Adora can feel slim fingers in the base of

their head, running once, twice, undoing golden knots done by the swirls of water and pressing their head against a warm pulse point. The cheek of the person holding them is soft and gentle, nuzzling against their cheekbones again and again, a button nose pressed insistently against the angle where Adora's jaw and ear connect. Softly, almost by accident, the velvet softness of a furry ear tickles the tip of Adora's crooked nose and Adora's brain, finally, catches up with their body.

"I got you, I got you Adora, I'm not letting go," whispers a sweet voice against his ear, again and again until is everything Adora can hear.

Adora raises her hands, pressing them against angular shoulder blades and the length of a curved spine, peaks and creases Adora has run her fingers over for innumerable nights, paths that Adora knows as well as the words of a sunny day's oath. Adora tilts her head a little, bumping her dry lips against lavender skin and whispers a greeting.

"Hey, Catra"

Catra chokes into a sob, something amused, relieved and at the same time so distressed it breaks Adora's heart completely, into a million sharp pieces, glass and crystal scattered inside their chest. Catra's breath is sweet, some strange faint shadow of smoke clinging in the strands of her butter soft hair and the freckles of her skin. Catra leans back, looking directly at Adora's eyes with annoyance and a hint of anger and whole sadness.

"You are such a fucking idiot"

Adora sighs, tangling their fingers on a curled damp strand of Catra's hair and placing it gently behind her dropped ears. It's strange, how Adora feels like she has missed those words, that voice, for so long and yet she also feels like she was just sleeping for just a few hours. She knows it's not true. She knows she wasn't here when she went to sleep and, shaken as it is, she knows that Catra has changed on this time. There is a pinkish new-form scar on Catra's cheekbone that wasn't there the last time she kissed her. Her hair is longer, way longer, well past her waist, curling over the water like earth on a river. There are lilac prints below the soft curve of her feline eyes and a newfound roundness in the sides of her jaw, her neck and the swell of her breaths against Adora's side.

Slowly, Adora starts to remember things. Moments and places. What happened before and after. He remembers saying goodbye in Camelot and taking care of Halfmoon. He remembers the attack, the betrayal, Shadow Weaver. Pain and pain as his soul was ripped apart and then bright light consumed it all and floating in water. He remembers white and golden dreams. He remembers a letter, read moments before the world crashed around them, and remembers the fluttering heartbeat of someone small inside the person he holds dearest of them all. And there is something else Adora remembers, slowly and fuzzy at the beginning and the solid and real on full force inside their mind, the shadow and light of memories running inside their head, of a childhood shaped in roses and colored powders and high statues and the feeling of a small girl they love above anything else.

Adora closes his eyes to the world for a second, grief and also overwhelmed joy occupying every cell inside his body. Then he opens them again, looking at those pools of gold and sky that Adora has missed so deeply.

"You are even more beautiful than the last time I saw you," they say, delighting in the way red flush climbs to their wife's cheeks, just like the first time Adora said that to her and every time since then. "I love you, too. Catra, I *love* you"

Catra gives a watery laugh, eyebrows raised, laugh lines around her eyes, the softest expression washing over her face. "I know," then her face shifts into something much more serious, watching Adora with resolution, saying each word with *meaning,* as if she wanted Adora to absorb every single of her words inside their thick skull and soft heart. "I love you back. I always have and always will"

Adora giggles, feelings drops of water run down their cheek and forehead and into their head and absently they wonder themself if it's the water if the lake they are still floating into ir Catra's tears as she sobs gently against the side of their face.

The water moves strongly for a moment, making both Catra and Adora raise their heads and look at the place the splash sound has come from. Mara is standing there, so translucent she looks almost like only a trick if the light. Her hands are pressed together over her heart, watching with loving eyes at two younglings she never thought she would see again. Adora gapes at her, her bear giving a painful jolt of surprise and grief and longing at the sight of her mother, just as she saw her their last time together in Camelot. Mara's smile is the kindest it has ever been, shining like starlight as she sees her child with teary eyes.

"M- mom?" asks Adora, her voice breaking. She holds herself inside the circle of Catra's arms tightly, leaning over the water, one hand weakly extended towards their mother. Adora's fingers are shaking uncontrollably. Mara leans back, pressing her palm over Adora's palm, skin to skin, and the touch feels so real free tears fall down Adora's bright silver eyes, marking golden paths over their cheeks.

"Hello, my dear," greets them Mara, bending to place a single kiss over Adora's extended palm. Adora tries to speak around a sob, following her and leaning even further in the water. Catra's arms slip away from her body, letting her go, but Adora holds onto her forearm, grasping it as a lifeline.

"Mom? Are you really here?"

Mara looks at her with a sad expression, full of love yes, but also full of nostalgia and resignation. *"Something like that, darling. I don't have much time but I am here for now."* Mara's eyes travel to Catra, still pressing her face over Adora's drenched hair, and nods. *"Catra guided me here and we brought you back."*

Adora gasps quietly, looking up at Catra with wide, reverend eyes. Catra flushes even further, shrugging as she tries to take importance off Mara's statement. "I didn't do much"

"You did everything, C'yra," Mara interrupts her, gently, as she starts moving towards the edge of the lake.

When Adora's eyes focus beyond the water, they can make the shape of a huge panther, black and purple skin and fur, a mane of blue magic and turquoise eyes looking deeply at Adora's face. Adora starts feeling a nervous cold sweat pool in the limits of their hair until the

panther's tail starts waving, lazy but happy, something much more like recognition shining inside their intelligent eyes. Adora's eyes widen, suddenly pinpointing who this big magical animal remembers them of. Mara leans over the lake and towards the panther, her long, wavy hair partially hiding the space between them. Adora feels Catra tense around her, tight like a violin cord, as she looks with sharp eyes at Mara's figure. Adora tries to turn and ask her if she is well but it is then that Mara turns back again, holding something small in the nestle of her ethereal arms.

For a second, or third, or a hundred times since Adora woke up again, she feels her breath dying in her throat, her heartbeat coming to a full stop, living now inside the fragile, tiny chest of the baby held in her mother's arms. Catra squeezes her arms around them strongly and Adora can feel her beautiful face fixated on them the entire time, and the way her light fur is standing on point with goosebumps and her breath hitches with sudden anxiety in her throat. But Adora is holding her hand, Adora is holding her hard and without waving, nervous and excited and devastated and now they are holding each other like they always do and the world starts spinning again, just a little.

Adora knows, of course she does. She held them in a dream, when their eyes and their ears were still closed and they were warm and soft after being just born and Catra was beautiful, beautiful, as beautiful as she is right now, resplendent with the light of having just become a mom. Still, Adora secretly hoped. That it was that, a dream, a beautiful wish. That she would make it back on time.

But now her own mother, somehow bright and there, just for a second, *there* , is walking inside the water like it wasn't even there and towards both mothers, holding her own grandchild in her arms by some powerful, merciful magic and it's the single most peaceful moment in the story of Etheria in thousands of years. People who love each other, reunited again. And after so much pain and waiting and loving from afar, Adora wouldn't do a single thing different, nothing, just so she could extend her arms like she is doing right now, in awe, and let her mother place her child inside them. Feeling the warmth of Catra's hands guiding gently her own in the places where they must be, one supporting the baby's head, the other around their wrapped up body and their kitten is so small, it does fits perfectly inside Adora's palms like it was the pace they were always meant to be and the only mission they were always meant to accomplish.

Their baby, Catra's baby, *Adora's baby,* peaks an eye open, suddenly awakened by the soft movement, and stares in all their young age at their mother, all honey hair just like them and blue in their irises. They stare at Adora, and then stare some more and everyone inside the cavern holds their breath, waiting for the outcome. Adora worries that they might cry, that they might not know who she is and wriggle and whimper their way out of her hands but that sour thought doesn't even get to fully develop because the next thing they know, their baby is sniffing the air around them, purposely, curiously, catching the scent that comes from Adora's skin and hair. They inhale, deeply, not once losing Adora's beautiful face from their sight and then, *and then,* Finn starts to purr, loud and happy, nuzzling their little nose on Adora's hand excitedly, wriggling further inside their blanket and towards Adora's chest until she catches the hint and places them softly next to her chest, feeling the way they sigh, giving a big, sweet yawn and falling right back into sleep, not once stopping their little, adorable purr. Adora hiccups a sobs, sniffing softly as she looks down at his tiny baby.

"Hey, Finn" whispers Adora, their voice breaking unavoidably around the name. She knows it by heart, it's carved inside the strings of their heart. She brushes gently their golden curls off their forehead, watching how their tiny nose, that looks so much like Catra's, twitches in their sleep. Caressing the tip of their soft ears with her finger, feeling the way the purr deepens, content, happy. Recognizing, Finn knows who she is, finally, *finally* she is with them and they love her. Adora is crying now, freely, untamed, a warm rainstorm falling down and making her voice crack completely with the love that fulfills it. "I'm your mom"

Adora bends their head to press a tiny, fluttering kiss at the top of Finnie's head. Behind them, with Adora's back still pressed over her chest, Catra squeezes Adora's forearms with extra strength, resting her forehead in the crook between their jaw and neck as she looks at them holding their child for the first time. She is crying too, Adora can feel the drip of her tears falling into the curves of their collarbones and Adora loves her so much. She loves her so much their chest is about to explode with emotion because there she is, she is small against Adora's huge height but so much braver and stronger. She is smart and cunning and sharp with her mind and her senses and she knows how to run two kingdoms with the tip of her fingers and yet there is this softness inside if her that only Adora gets to see sometimes and that speaks miles how beautiful her heart is. Catra is stubborn and unrelenting and she never gave up on getting Adora back and Adora doesn't even know yet how much shit she had to go through yet here she is. And she gave them Finn. She carried them and bore them and gave birth to them. She nurses them and loves them. She made a whole new life all by herself and that it's almost like magic itself. How is Adora not going to love her more than anything?

"Oh, look at you, you're so beautiful. You look so much like your mamma," cooes Adora to their baby, in the softest of whispers. "I love you so much Finn, you know that right? I love you. I'm so sorry, I'm here now. I love you."

Catra's breath hitches at her side and her arms twitch as if she wanted to say something but she can't, overwhelmed by everything that is going on right now. In the end, she doesn't need to say anything because Mara places her hand over Adora's, the other one cradling their chin and tipping their head up to look at them in the eyes, silver blue against silver and amethyst.

" *I already said this to C'yra but I say it to you now. Nothing bad that happened is your fault. No, don't fight me on it, I'm your mom and I'm right,"* she says, placing her thumb over Adora's lips when they pout and tries to fight back. Mara's eyes are kind but charged with that motherhood resolution so Adora gives in into the truth of her words, slumping their shoulders forward in surrender. Mara smiles even more brightly, cradling Adora's entire cheek with hers. " *I'm so sorry there were things I kept from you in the past, important things, I wanted to keep you safe. But know this. I'm so proud of you Adora. I'm so, so proud of you. I love you"*

Mara starts to slip away, floating towards the center of the lake like mist. Adora tries to get a hold of their mother again, but her hand passes across Mara's forearm like she was trying to grab a cloud, leaving only drops of water behind.

"Wait. Wait, please don't go."

"Adora," whispers Catra in her ears and she sounds so sad and apologetic Adora *knows* what is about to happen before it does. Still, Adora reaches again, grasping and failing a strand of light of her mothers aura.

"Don't go. I don't- I don't understand"

"C'yra will explain it to you and you will be alright Adora, I know that now," assures Mara, booping Adora's crooked nose once. Adora exhales, cold breath becoming steam against the breeze.

"But why can't you stay?"

" *This is not my world anymore, my darling."* Mara sighs, watery, tears also falling off her cheeks. The water seem to be rising gently, wrapping over her body as a second skin or a blanket, making her look so bright Adora has to squint to see her face, covering the side of Finn's head to protect their eyes from the blinding light. *"But I'm glad, Adora. I'm so very, very glad that me staying for a bit longer gave us this. That I could do this one thing for you, the three of you. I'm glad this time we can have a proper goodbye."*

Adora bites her lip, so hard she can feel the fragile skin there breaking a little. She is trying, but she can't avoid feeling like she is losing her mother all over again. "Will I ever see you again?"

" *You will and I will always be with you"* answers Mara and her voice drops with certainty and calm, so much it falls into the water of the lake and travels towards Adora, surrounding them in the tangible twinkle of love. *"Never forget the love you are worth of"*

Catra tightens her hold on Adora's, keeping them in place gently but also leaning forwards a little bit and towards Mara. Her eyes are red and the edges of her cheekbones are puffy after crying so much, but there is also a light of calm inside of her and, most than all, raw indiscutible gratitude. "Thank you, Mara, for bringing my family back together. Thank you so much"

Mara's eyes wrinkled when she smiles at her, warmth spreading inside Adora's heart as they watch the way their mother looks at the love of their life. Then, Mara's eyes drop to Adora's arms, where baby Finn is deeply asleep and so much like Adora and Mara's face becomes something so impossible love and full of love both Catra and Adora shiver under the magic that gaze carries.

"You too have done something so beautiful. So, so beautiful. You've given Etheria hope, yes, but most important than all, you've given ***each other*** *hope"* The water is swirling around her even faster, climbing up her arms and face, making her look like a spirit made of water and starlight. " *Take you for this extra time. I love you, the three of you. I love you so very much"*

The water shivers and on the surface, the reflection of a beautiful face can be made of, staring up at Mara with a mysterious smile and gentle eyes.

" *Mara,"* says Serenia, extending her arm and hand from under the water and touching with the blue pads of her fingers just below the surface. " *It is time"*

Mara reaches for the water, placing her hand over Serenia's softly, fusing with the water. Adora is crying openly, heavy tears falling and she can hear the twinkling sound of Catra

quietly sobbing next to her. Over her chest, Finn sighs, grabbing a bunch of the fabric of Adora's shirt inside their tiny fist.

"Mom?" calls Adora, hesitantly. Mara returns her eyes to her one last time, silver and purple slipping inside their heart and making a home in it. "I love you"

Mara beams at her, smiling so wide her teeth flash like suns. *"I love you too, little dragon. "* Her body starts to sink into the water, pulled gently by Serenia's hold, the last ribbons of Mara's presence on this world, and then with a happy, grateful smile she adds. *"Take care of each other and always, always live happy."*

The light of the lake shines even brighter as Mara sinks lower, so golden that even if Adora tries to catch until the last second of her mother's presence, she has to close her eyes tight in the end. Catra closes her eyes to, protecting the side of Adora's face with her hand and partially hiding her own head in the damp strands of their hair. The light shines and shines and shines and then, like a supernova and a black hole, shrinks in itself and disappears completely, leaving only the dim light of the cavern's crystals and the tamed waves of the blue lake behind.

Adora breaks around a sob, holding Finn against their chest, letting their weight rest on Catra's sure arms as they cry. Catra rocks them from side to side gently, whispering with sweet words and tear stained cheeks on the side of their ears.

"I'm sorry. I'm so sorry, Adora," and then, "We love you, all of us, we love you so much," and then, "You are here now."

Adora can barely hear her over the sound of her own watery hiccups. Absently, Adora can feel Finnie's tiny, impossibly soft tail curling and wrapping itself tight over her wrist, as if the little kitten was being aware of their mother's distress and was trying to reassure her. The little tail doesn't even grass fully around the delicate bones and Adora just wonders hoe infinitesimally small they are right now.

It takes them several minutes inside the lake but finally, Adora calms enough to allow Catra to guide them gently towards the edge and then completely out. Their hairs and clothes dry almost instantly, as if it hadn't been wet at all to start, and they collapse together into the soft, mush earth of the cave, a few feet away from the water and closer to where the huge panther awaits.

Adora flops against the side of the panthers back, taking a huge breath of cold air. It feels marvelous, life running down her lungs, inside her veins and across all the organs of her body. Adora feels incredibly sad and yet, as she caresses Finn's little head with the pads of her fingers, Adora hasn't felt more alive.

Catra falls against them, curling on the side of Adora's body, her ears brushing the side of their cheek softly. Her hair is so long that it curls over the ground in lazy twirls. She is shaking badly and Adora reaches for her hand blindly, lacing their fingers together, grounding each other. The panther is rumbling softly, soft vibrations that make the muscles in Adora's body start relaxing one by one. Adora sighs, warmth starting to slip inside her bones.

She croons her head upwards, locking her eyes with the bright blue ones of the panther, who nudges the side of her face with their big nuzzle, leaving a trail of wet mucus on her temple.

"Melog?," rasps out Adora. The panther's rumble deepens, nuzzling her again, Adora's hair sticking in odd directions by their big nose. It's all the confirmation she needs. "Alright. Good. That's just great"

Catra snorts softly at her side, eyes pressed closed with her arms wrapped tight around their chest and underneath Finnie's body. Adora tilts her head just slightly to press a fluttering kiss on her cheek, allowing their body to feel the oh, so familiar and so longed missed softness that she brings.

A ruffling sound takes them out of their stupor and they raise their heads to look at a young man who Adora hadn't even seen there, walking near the edge of the lake and squatting down the ground, looking at Adora with an amused smirk but kind golden eyes.

"I'm glad to see you back, Adora" he says, his voice grave and at the same time cheerful. Adora stumbles a bit in their place in the ground, straightening themself up while holding both Catra and Finn closer to them.

"Who are you?" Adora asks, frowning. The young man smiles sideways, looking at the water with a mysterious expression in his eyes.

"An old tale," he says with no explanation at all. Then he leans even deeper towards the lake, sinking his entire firearm inside the water as he seems to be looking for something. "Before you go, I would like you to take something back"

The man pulls from inside the water and, with to resistance at all, his hand comes out wrapped around the golden handle of a blue bladed sword, the gem and deep runs carved in the middle catching the light that comes from the water and reflecting tiny bright spots across the entire cavern. Catra gasps, holding her breath as she looks at the sword holding herself to a speechless Adora as both of them look at this young, skinny man holding it in his hand as if it weighed nothing.

"That's not possible-" whispers Catra.

"Excalibur."

The blade of the sword seems to shine swiftly in answer, the steel vibrating just enough for both Adora and Catra to see it. The man shrugs, standing up to approach them.

"I know a sword is just a sword," he starts, spinning the sword so he can offer the handle to Catra, who takes it with a steady hand but cold sweat cheeks, letting the heavy weapon rest next to her over the ground. "But give it some credit, I made this sword out of a dragon's breath after all. And believe me, it did not smell nice"

An invisible clock seems to tick for way too long until Adora wheezes, a combination of a strangled laugh and a nervous breakdown, their bangs sticking to their forehead with sweat.

"Merlin"

The young man, Merlin, bows his head towards them in recognition, his smile widening as he greets back. "Adora"

Catra stills next to them, her tail lashing into the ground hard as her expression sours and her beautiful eyes narrow, looking at the man with nothing but sudden anger. "You son of a b-"

"Hello again, C'yra," cuts her out Merlin, stepping back so he can see them all. Catra's fine fur ruffles with indignation, her fangs flashing in displeasure as she addresses him.

"You said your name was Emrys"

"The druids knew me with that name, yes" he clears out. "I also had you to know my mother was an extraordinary woman".

"Why didn't you say who you were from the very beginning? Did you thrive in misery?" lashes out Catra, cheeks bright red with her anger. Adora and Melog just stay there, looking at the exchange in silence.

"My mission was only to guide you and Mara where you were meant to be, queen C'yra," he says, sticking his hand Ms inside the pockets of his pants. "Both of you did all the hard work"

"You knew it was Mara?" inquiries Catra, the hand that cradles Adora tightening. Merlin sighs, nodding.

"Mara's love for you, Adora, managed to keep her inside of Camelot for a long time. I knew she was there but there wasn't anything really I could have done,"he nudges the earth with the tip of his shoe, seemingly lost in thought. "It was her decision to go, after all"

"You haven't done shit at all. There is a war still going on and this is the first time you appear. Aren't you oh, mighty, powerful Merlin who put up the barrier around Camelot and helped free the magic?" bites back Catra in a snarky, annoyed growl. Adora feels nervous for a second but Merlin cracks into a loud laugh, kind of strangled with emotion. When he calms down, Catra is fuming but Merlin has regained his calm expression.

"I am very old, Queen C'yra, I'm not what I used to be. This is not my story anymore, it's yours. You are the future of Etheria."

Catra falls back against Adora's side, not convinced at all. Adora is absently caressing Finnie's ears between her fingers, considering the sorcerer's words. "Why did you help us then?" she asks, frowning.

Merlin's eyes are very blue when he answers them. "As I said to C'yra before, I owned it to a friend," he takes a deep breath, considering, and adds. "I loved your grandfather. He did terrible mistakes, yes, but he also did wonderful things for Camelot, and for Etheria. I loved the people, the trees, the rivers, the magic. Many things were lost and many things were

found thanks to your mother and thanks to you two, peace will finally find its rightful way on our lands. But above all, I owed it to Guenievire. I owe her happiness for her children."

Adora frowns deepen, her mind working as fast as it can to comprehend. "But my grandmother-"

"She is closer than you think," Merlin says, looking directly at Catra with kind of an amused look. Adora turns to her too, for explanation, but she just exhales from very deep in her lungs, shaking her head with deliberation.

"Later," and then, when she feels Adora's nervous hesitation, she adds. "I promise"

Merlin contemplates them in silence with a sly smile on his lips and the sighs loudly, cleaning his old pants from inexistent dust as he starts walking towards the end of the cavern.

"I think it's time for me to go. And it's also time for you two to go where you must." He turns to look at them, bowing softly with his head. "Remember, as long as you are both together, everything will be better"

"What's with the stupid rhyme," scoffs Catra under her breath, clenching her teeth.

Adora leans over to look at him in the eyes, one eyebrow crooked in curiosity. "Where are you going to go?"

Merlin shrugs indifferently. "Here, there, somewhere where I'm needed" his entire body starts to shine in electric blue light. He turns his sight to Melog, winking. "Keep an eye on them, Melog"

Melog purr stops and they rumble in a maybe too vocal answer. Catra snaps her head towards them with an indignated gasp. "You can talk to him, you little traitor-"

As Catra continues her ramble, Adora locks eyes with the sorcerer's, who give them one last tiny smile. "Give my greetings to Razz." The blue light envelopes him completely and with a silent thunder, his body shifts and changes, only a deep blue butterfly left flying in circles in his place. The butterfly spins around their head a few times and then speeds out if the cavern and off sight completely, lost back into the woods.

Adora breathes the fresh air, blinking slowly as they wake up from the fuzziness of their brain. They look to the side, catching the pretty, regal profile of Catra's face. Catra feels Adora's sight on her and turns her, her eyebrows skyrocketing on her forehead. Adora smiles back at her, goofy and dumb and full of overflowing love.

"Hi," Adora says, giggling softly.

Catra looks at them, and then *looks at them* , her eyebrows falling and her cheeks flushing of a red so deep Adora can feel the heat coming off of her skin. Catra's ears flutter and then press at her sides and her fangs flash when she snarls and Adora knows she has problems and yet still has the nerve to *laugh* again.

"You are so fucking stupid," growls Catra, with no real bite but a whole lot of anger, "How dare you? Don't you ever do anything like that again." Adora looks at her and the way her nose actually seems to be twitching and she can't help but let out another loud laugh, heavy with nervousness and sadness and completely joy. Catra's growl deepens and she actually smacks the side of Adora's arm, hard. "Stop laughing at me you idiot! This is serious!"

Adora let's her head roll over Melog's back, looking at Catra with hooded eyes. The weight of Finn's little body in her hands is so precious, Adora has to fight back crystal happy tears to fall down. "I love you so much" then takes a breathe and continues with her heart on her throat. "Thank you so much. For coming, for saving me. For never give up faith in me. For loving me. For Finn." Adora's voice dies a little, drowned by tears.

Catra is looking at them in such a way. She is panting, her cheeks are flushed, her eyes are raw red and watery. The lilac bags under her eyes look almost deep purple and there is a frown in her lips that some people may mistake with anger but that Adora knows it's actually sadness. For the first time.on this short time since they are back together, Adora can see how utterly exhausted she is and it breaks their heart all over again.

"You were gone," gasps Catra, voice raspy. Adora flinches at the words painfully and Catra rushes to tangle their hands together, reassuring them with her eyes. "No, no, listen. It wasn't your fault. It never was. You were gone but I understood why and I never blamed you. Nobody ever did, none of us," her gaze drops down at Finn, purposely, before returning her gaze back to them.

Adora starts to relax, heartbeat calming down. Catra sighs in relief but then her own heart starts to speed out, breathing hard from her nose as she holds Adora with all the strength she can, never wanting to let her go again.

"I wanted to find you" her voice is shaking and her lips are bubbling. Adora wants to hold her in his arms but Catra tightens her grip on his hand, running the other over the unruly curls of her hair. Her voice is starting to get frantic, desperate to get every word out as fast as she can. "I wanted to find you so bad, so much sooner but I- I couldn't leave until Finn. It took me so long and it was *so near,* you were always so near and I- I begged Razz to help me, I knew she could but I didn't go until after Finn was here because I was *scared* Adora because what if she told me you were *gon* e? Even if I knew you weren't, what if I was wrong?"

"Catra," tries to interrupt her Adora, softly. But Catra keeps going, tripping with her own words. Adora has never seen her like this, so raw and wild. She loves her so much, she always finds herself falling in love with her, again and again and again, in all her versions, in all her emotions, in everything. Even now, wild and shaken, when Adora doesn't want to do anything else but hold her inside her chest and never leave her alone again.

"I want to apologize. For everything, Adora, I'm sorry for everything. I should have told you how much I love you from the very beginning. I love you so much, I swear I do. I should have gone with you. I know how impossible that sounds, but I should have gone with you, *be* with you. I should, I should-"

"Catra"

"I should have seen it before it was all a trap, all of it. But, but I would do it all the same way over and over again because coming to Camelot was a trap but it gave me you and it gave me Finn and you both are my whole life. And-"

"Catra"

"What?!"

And then, in a sweet mirror of their first kiss, all those months ago, in the aftermath of a carnival and a battle and laughter and a golden laurel crown over mud matted blonde hair and white flowers in dark hair, Adora pronounces in a whisper the same words Catra said to them before gifting them her heart. "Catra, be quiet for a moment"

Adora leans in, their free hand cradling the side of Catra's face gently, softly, brushing off unstoppable yearning tears with their thumb, Catra's hand curling over their heart. Their mouths press together almost reverently, Adora's lips opening along Catra's, taking in her breath and the scent of her throat, holding her close, so close their heartbeats jump and then melt together, fusing as one.

Holding their sleepy, tiny baby between their hands, Adora kisses her and all is well.

End of chapter XIII part II

Chapter End Notes

Adora love of my life welcome back! Finally, finally, after so many chapters Adora is back with his family
And yes, it was Mara! I think one of you might have guessed it at some point but the whole true is finally out. Now, it’s time for the journey back.
Can you believe we are so close to the end? It’s both amazing and sad! I’m going to miss this story so much once is over. Btw, I’ve updated the number of chapters to include the Epilogue!
There will be no new chapter next week, I’m taking a little holiday, but I’ll see you all next year will the las stretch of this fairytale.
Happy holidays, love you all!

Chapter 16: Dragonheart

Chapter Summary

"I thought we had time, I've always thought we had time."

Finn chirps, opening their tiny eyes to look right into their mothers enamoured faves looking downs at them. Catra smiles, stretching her fingers to hold Finnie's other hand in hers.

"We have time now"

Chapter Notes

I'M ALIVE!!!!

Gosh I've missed posting so much! Thank you all for all your patient and if you have followed and waited for this story until this point thank you, thank you from the bottom of my heart. It's been a while couple of months for me but I've got a fantastic new job and I'm in a better place that last year :3

However, I hope this 27.5k long chapter can make it up for the time waiting ')

WARNINGS: Adora is tired to be nice, she just wants to go apeshit (Adora loses her shit oh fuck oh shit. Disclaimer, some people may die but like, they are VERY BAD people so don't feel bad. Marked with •••••)
As always, explicit scenes are marked with ***** in case you would like to jump them over

Without more delay! *drums* To the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CHAPTER 14. Dragonheart

What is honor compared to a woman's love?

What is duty against the feel of a newborn son in your arms

or the memory of a brother's smile?

Wind and words. Wind and words.

We are only human, and the gods have fashioned us for love.

That is our great glory, and our great tragedy."

— George R.R. Martin, *A Game of Thrones*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x x x x

❀

Reality starts to draw over Adora very slowly.

Catra and Melog help them walk out of the cavern with wobbly feet, Catra's hand wrapped tight around Adora's forearm as she guides them through the angled spins and curves of the path out. Adora is still holding Finn, tight over their chest. They can feel the way their little feet press against their ribs and the butterfly soft of their sweet little breath over their collarbones. The feeling of their tiny weight on Adora's hands starts fireworks inside Adora's heart and she has to hold on very tight onto Catra because her mind is catching up that she is *here,* she is not dead, she is back with Catra, the woman she loves more than her own life, and that Adora is holding her baby, *their baby* inside her hands and that they are so small, to tiny and fragile and loved, Adora doesn't know what to do with so much love welling inside her chest at the sight of them. She has to blink again, searching the soft curve of the baby's chubby cheeks, convincing herself that yes, this is real, this is happening. She is a mom.

It's already night when they walk out together from the cave. Adora looks around them, inside the little cocoon the woods have made to hide the cavern. There are no fallen autumn leaves on the ground or puffy white snow on the stones. So, spring then. Or course it's spring, Adora tracked the date when she was in Halfmoon, she knew the season Finn was to arrive in. She read the books, visited the nurseries as discreetly as possible. She had a plan, everything carefully detailed to make everything as happy and comfortable for Catra as she could.

But Catra was alone. Adora wasn't there. Something sour and bitter pools in the back of Adora's tongue. Obviously, nothing went as it should have.

Catra sighs once they are completely out of the dark, humid cavern, stretching lightly and taking a deep breath of fresh air as her joints pop a little. She is numb from the cavern's coldness and even though her ears are up and alert, her eyes are half lidded with exhaustion and her tail lashes softly, lazy behind her. Catra takes in the darkened words around them and bites her lip, hesitating. Before she can speak, Adora beats her to it.

"Catra," Adora calls, placing a hand softly and lovingly over her shoulder, "I think we should rest here for tonight"

Catra turns her beautiful eyes towards them, shifting in her feet a little with uncertainty. Her eyes shift back and forward from the entrance of the cavern to Adora's face. "I-"

"Not inside the cavern, we can make a little fire and sleep right here until the day clears again. The woods have us very well hidden," and then Adora adds very gently, careful if not pointing out Catra's obviously exhausted face because she knows it will only make her snarl without bite and stubbornly hop into the woods. "I just- I want to hold you both in my arms before start traveling"

Catra's eyes melt immediately at Adora's words, looking at them with so much love and adoration Adora stumbles back with the force of it all. Catra nods, giving in, curling herself around Adora's side into a tight hug, her face partially hidden between the ruffles of their shirt. Adora's breath hitches on their throat and they exhale heavily, looking up and into the thickly starry sky above their heads. They remember them from their chamber in Camelot and it is until then that Adora realizes how much they want to just go home.

Melog, the big panther that now is Melog, finds a comfortable place near the center of the clear, padded with soft moss and dry grass. They turn their head towards them, blue eyes deep in Adora's and start rumbling, loud and grave meows that undeniably call their attention. Catra sighs against Adora's neck and nods, turning back as she cleans her damp, puffy red eyes with the back of her hand.

"Yes I'm coming, I'm coming," Catra slips her hand inside Adora's and guides them together to the place Melog is standing, directing them down the ground with soft but insistent hands. "Sit down, I'll make a fire"

"Catra," Adora stops her softly, not letting go of her hand. She can see the way Catra is swinging in her own feet and how her ears are lowered down further and further. Adidas eyebrows knit together in concern, her eyes narrowing with heavy worry. "Please rest too"

Catra's tired eyes flash with mild annoyance and she pulls softly but without bite from Adora's hold on her without success. "I'm perfectly capable of doing a fire by myself"

"I know," agrees Adora, pulling once again from her hand, "But you don't have to do everything on your own"

Catra recognizes her own words on Adora's mouth and the furry in her neck ruffles, taken aback. Their eyes fight for a bit, stubborn against pleading ones but in the end Catra also gives in to this. She rolls her eyes, scoffing, but her shoulders drop and her tail flicks once, reflecting her real feelings. She lowers herself in front of Adora with the very same elegance that has always characterized her, muscles sore and slow with the exhaustion. She hugs her knees close to her chest, looking with half hooded eyes at Adora and Finn. Adora catches her tired sight and smiles, big and sincere and full of love and any annoyance or pain Catra may have been carrying goes away from her heart as she returns their smile. Adora's smile just widens even further, without tearing her sight away from her. In fact, Adora can't stop looking at her, with those enamoured soft eyes and that expression, clear and open and free only for Catra to see.

Melog walks around them, rolling a few rocks and dry logs in the center with their nuzzle. Adora flicks her sight to them, confusion jolting into clear surprise when Melog opens their mouth and breathes a boiling hot blue flame from in between their teeth and nose, lighting up

the wood into a warm, cozy blue fire. Melog huffes, satisfied, and let's themself fall unceremoniously behind Catra, licking their huge paws clean from the moss.

Adora gapes at them, looks at Catra, back at Melog. His expression must be something because Catra snorts, tapping softly his forehead with her pointer finger.

"Just ask, dummie," she says, rolling her eyes.

"What the fuck, Melog?" gasps out Adora, sincere, and then their eyes widen in sudden horror, snapping his eyes down to a very wriggly Finn, covering their tiny ears with his hand. Catra's laugh erupts once more, this once louder but just as affectionate.

"Don't worry, Adora. I really don't think our baby is going to start swearing suddenly," she says but then her eyebrows furrow in contemplation, humming to herself. "Though, maybe we should actually stop swearing so much. I don't want their first word to be one. Can you imagine?"

Adora stopped paying attention a little ago, looking in awe and love at Catra, giggling to herself. *Our baby* , she had said. *Our baby. Our.* Wow.

Catra notices Adora fond look, her ears flickering with a blush. Her tail curls and unfolds again pleasantly in the air, a shiver running down her spine. It's shocking, how easy it is to fall back into a life with Adora in there, as if it hadn't even passed a day away. She knows it's not true, and she knows the butterflies in her stomach will never go away every time she looks at him as well as she knows they have to actually talk about it. And it will hurt.

Adora leans in, maybe catching Catra's eyes, maybe following her thoughts, but she squeezes her hand softly, soothing. *I'm here,* say his eyes and Catra can breathe again.

"Hey you," croaks out Catra, trying to disperse the sudden tension. She nudges Melog on the side, calling the dragon's attention. "Answer to Adora, come on. Show her your new trick"

Melog gives her the blankest, deadpan stare, flipping their tail to smack Catra softly in the face. Catra sputters, betrayed, but Melog is already up, shaking their mane from side to side. With each movement their body restarts to shift, just the slightest amount, waves of mane into sharp blue and iridescent scales, back contorting elongated, slick like a serpent, their paws powerful with knife cutting dark claws. Their tail snaps in the air and grows too, thin but large like a wip, with the ends open as hand fans. A set of long wings burst into the air, raising a cloud of dust around them, long and magnificent. A smaller version of the huge dragon they truly are. And the goddess knows they are showing off and Catra can only chuckle at the silliness if it all. Adora's eyes are wide, mouth agape with shock without saying a word and suddenly it makes Catra nervous how they might react. She is still processing it and it's been a couple of days. But then Catra turns to look at him and, of course, Adora is completely beaming.

"Melog," he breathes out, shock transforming into wonder, "Holy shit, Melog that is so fucking cool"

Melog straight up purrs, giving tiny, silly little jumps and with each one they shrink back past their panther form and into their usual house carol one, the one they have come to know and that is just as familiar. They slip next to Adora and rub their head against their side, purring even deeper before turning back and curling into Catra's lap.

"Wow," repeats Adora because it's the only word that seems to truly convey everything they are feeling right now. "A dragon. That makes so much more sense than a highly intelligent cat"

Catra gasps, mildly offended and throws Finnie's baby blanket to Adora's head, huffing. "How dare you?"

"I'm joking, I'm joking," gasps out Adora, surrendering. They are still giggling when Adora locks their eyes once again with Catra's, tilting their head to the side. "You didn't know"

It's not a question, it's an affirmation. And Adora is not angry or scared, not even shocked anymore, Catra's sudden fear that Adora might have thought she was keeping something so important off them and they might take it badly, evaporates into thin air. Catra relaxes her shoulders and shakes her head from side to side.

"Melog says my mother was supposed to tell me when I came of age, but she died before she could"

Adora blinks at her. "Melog… says. You understand them"

Catra shrugs, flustered by Adora's marveled expression. "It's also new. Some royalty shit that they didn't consider really important to tell until now" Melog bites her playfully in the hand, scolding her lightly. Catra can feel the ends of her ears hot and her cheeks burning under Adora's heavy gaze but she raises her chin and crosses her arms over her chest. "What?"

"You are amazing," says Adora, so simple.

Finn makes an awake sound in Adora's arms and their attention shifts completely into their baby. They don't ask anything else, easily accepting the fact that Melog is a dragon as if they had always known. Catra loves this part of Adora, as every other single part of them. Loves the way they are capable of being so deeply amazed by everything around them, how they are curious and marveled by all things, even if they might be new and scary. How they are able to look at them in the face and just *accept* them into their life. Easy. Lovingly. Honest. It's the very same thing she saw her first weeks in Camelot, how Adora would bring the magicats into their secret kingdom with open arms, without hesitation, with joy.

Catra can see that same quality right now. In the way Adora just came back from the limbo and they seem so marveled at the fact of being *alive.* In the way they saw Melog, with big eyes, with amaze and innocent wonder and they didn't even think they might have been lied to, they just accepted it for what it was. Catra can see it now, in the way Adora's eyes shimmer with undeniable love towards them as they look at their tiny, barely awake baby face. In the way Adora is happy, *happy,* ready to be a mom alongside Catra and relieved of being here and happy.

Catra starts crying. It may be the sight of Adora's profile, handsome, sweet and healthy. Alive, alive. It may be the cold breeze. It may be the hard floor, the mush moss, the stars above. It may be exhaustion or the smell of Camelot's smoke still stuck in her lungs. But in reality, she knows it is nothing of that.

It's the sight of Finn's bare foot against Adora's palm. It's so small, so tiny and fragile against Adora's big hand. Small toe beans tickling Adora's skin and making her laugh. And Adora holds their child with such care, like she has been waiting her entire life for this exact moment. Finn's head is nestled in the crook of Adora's elbow, their even smaller hands kneading at the air, soft peach nose sniffing the air gently all around them. Their eyes flutter open for a second, just a small jar to peak at the exterior. They seem to take a little to get used to the dim light of the blue fire but once they do, their sight focuses on Adora smiling above them. There is a beat. And then, for the first time in their short life, Finn smiles.

"Oh, hey there my love", whispers Adora and her face is in love. "I'm happy to see you too"

Finn's fragile smile dissolves into a content hum and they sneeze suddenly, nuzzling into Adora's heart to chase the warmth and smell of their mother. Catra bites her lips and sniffs as quiet as she can,not even bothering to clean off the tracks of tears running down her ashed cheeks. This is everything she has ever wanted even before she knew she wanted it. Adora. Finn. *Her* family, a family that loved her. And she looks at Adora, and they are crying too because their baby's face and feet and beans are so small and being a mother is such a marvelous, scary thing, and Catra feels pride and relief being born in her chest. Because Adora chose Finn over the very same death. Adora chose *her*.

Again and again.

Adora chose to die to protect them. And then she chose to live to love them. What better declaration of love could there be.

Finn hiccups softly and suddenly, awakening again, and starts to knead on Adora’s chest, right between the open ruffles of their cream colored shirt. They look at Adora, scrunching their little nose as they stretch in the limited space inside their blanket and start meowing, insistently. Adora gasps, marveled by her tiny baby, brushing her big hand over their head gently, smothering the golden baby hairs there.

“What are you doing, honey?”

Finn answers with another tiny meow, nudging over her skin again and again. Adora blinks at them, completely black, confused eyes and scratching with blunt nails behind their tiny ears. Catra stiffens a laugh as she watches Adora's face, cleaning her runny nose with the back of her hand. She knows Adora knows she is crying and they are letting her be because Catra needs the cry and she appreciates that, so much. But Catra doesn't want to cry anymore. There is so much left to say still, but right now she has them there. Catra leans a little towards Adora's space, opening her arms welcomingly as she points at them with her chin.

“They are hungry," Catra explains, smiling, "Here, let me”

Adora coos softly at Finn as they pass them towards Catra, placing them gently inside her hands. Catra hums, taking Adora's hand for a fraction of a second to place a fluttering kiss over their palm before shifting Finn into a much more comfortable position inside her arms. She untangles them from their baby blanket, the butter soft wool tickling them in the nose and making them giggle. Catra looks fascinated by it, eyes wide and bright, giggling right back.

Adora watches her every move, how she wiggles an arm outside her coat -Adora's coat, the one Adora used on their wedding, they realize- and unfastens the laces of her black shirt, opening them completely. Then she takes the back of Finnie's head between her hands, guiding them until they latch excitedly onto her, starting to eat with all the eagerness that a baby kitten can have. Catra chuckles, cleaning with soft fingers the errand drops of milk from their nose and chubby cheeks.

Adora watches Catra nurse Finn with their heart in their throat, the way she leans in to nuzzle her cheek over their forehead, cooing them to eat with reassuring purrs and quiet meows. Watches the crease and valleys of Catra's breast and the way her breathing is rhythmic and at peace as she feeds them and Adora loves every single change in her, loves them so, so much. Adora sighs clenching the fabric of their shirt with their fist. Adora is crying again, slipping down their cheeks, pooling in their chin and dripping over their lap but Adora lets it be. It's a good cry, a rightful cry and they won't stop crying for a long time. One day, but not now.

"Bow knitted this for Finn before they were born," whispers Catra, running the white blanket between her fingers. Her gaze is down but soft, so soft, and she smiles when she reminisces. "And you see this wonky hole here? That's Sparkles doing. She really is bad at this" Catra raises her head to meet Adora's eyes and her eyebrows lift when she sees them crying but she doesn't ask them to stop. Her expression shifts, very gently, a tiny, shy smile forming on her lips. “Why are you looking at me like that, dummy?”

“You are so natural at this,” bursts out Adora. Catra's eyes widen, surprised and Adora can feel themself flush but they keep going, words pouring one after the other, emotions wide and open. “You feed them, change them, hold them. You know what to do. I- I know nothing” Adora gulps, cleaning an errant tear of their cheek. "I know nothing. I don't know how to be good. For them"

Catra looks at her without saying a word, as if considering. Adora feels her lip wobble with sudden sadness and lowers her head, sobbing her runny nose in the way. There is a soft, brushing sound beside them and then Catra's hand comes into view, placing it over Adora's and interlocking their fingers together. Catra squeezes two times and pulls, softly and wordlessly asking Adora to look at her again.

“Hold us," whispers Catra, and her eyes are full and bright.

Adora gulps again, running the tip of her tongue over her chapped dry lips. “What?”

“Hold us” repeats Catra. Her hand is warm and firm and her eyes trusting, overflowing with love. “You don't need to become good, you are their *mother*, you gave your life for them, for us. You are already good. And you’ll learn, all those things, you'll learn. I promise. But for now you just need to hold us”

They look at each other, eyes swimming in tears, until Adora nods. She breathes deeply a few times, Catra waiting patiently for her without letting go from her hand once. Adora scrambles out of her position in the moss, crawling ratter clumsily towards Catra and Finn. She sits right behind Catra, cradling Catra's waist and legs with her own, letting her wife's weight rest over her chest. Catra's purr grows louder as she snuggles into her, nuzzling her head on Adora's neck.

Adora brushes her bangs out of her face, placing their hand behind Finnie's head to support them as they eat. Little by little, the anxious tremor inside Adoras chest starts to wash away, replaced by the warmth their baby, happy and healthy, brings.

"I remember this," says Adora, humming, their voice still watery with tears. Finn chirps as they eat, content on their mothers' arms. Catra turns her head towards Adora, her ear flicking them in the face softly.

"You do?," her voice trembles, just a little, *hopeful*.

"I do," assures Adora, nodding. "It's- like a dream. I remember holding you, and you were still expecting Finn there but I could feel them kick. They kicked so much, it was like they were doing a little dance inside you," Adora chuckles, placing a kiss behind her ear, a little bit congested. "And then I remember another dream and- and holding you just like this and Finn was so tiny," Adora exhales, overwhelmed, another wave of pearl tears falling off their eyes. They run their fingers softly over their baby's cheek, cleaning traces of milk from their short fur. "I remember I thought they could fit inside my palm, curl inside and remain there. With that soft fur and their curls, they were so pretty. And prunny, like a little peach."

Catra chuckles too but she remains quiet, pensive and calm, listening to each of Adora's words. In the silence, only the crack of the fire and the sounds of Finn eating can be heard. Adora doesn't push, content to nuzzle on Catra's temple and watch them just being together, holding to each other, Melog rumbling behind the three of them, their natural warmth reassuring on the fresh night.

"They had just been born," says Catra after a while. Her voice is still a whisper, so quiet only being pressed this close to her Adora can hear her. Adora blinks at her, feeling their throat turn into a tight knot. Catra must feel their rising heartbeat because she holds Adora's hand tight on hers, rubbing tight circles over their skin. That dream, it was the day they were born, the very first day of spring. I fell asleep and you were there. With us"

Catra can feel Adora hold her breathe, her arms tightening around her. "How-"

"Mara did it" Catra looks at Finnie's face, slowly but surely slipping back into a peaceful slumber, giving tired sucks with their little hands still kneading softly over her chest.

Adora is breathing very deeply through her nose. Catra knows this is a vulnerable theme for her but she doesn't ask her to stop. In fact, Adora squeezes her forearm, nudging her jaw with her nose. "Tell me"

"She talked to me in the lake, before bringing you back. She said it was one good thing she wanted to do, for us," Catra bites her lip, not fighting back her own tears. "She explained to

me what she could do, with dreams. I think she used the little energy she had left to do that for us. To allow you to be there. Because you were there, Adora, you were *there"*

Catra can hear Adora crying quietly behind her, hiding her face in Catra's hair. Catra let's her cry and she lets herself cry too, her shoulders shaking with it. "I didn't know if you were going to remember it," admits Catra, closing her eyes. "I wouldn't have love you less if you didn't and neither would have Finn. But I did hoped, just a little"

"I remember it," assures Adora, nodding in her hair "I remember it all."

Catra inhales, exhales. One, two, four times, until her thundering heartbeat calms down and she feels her head stop spinning. There is something else she wants to say, a truth that is good but sad. So much was taken from them without them even knowing and it hurts and it's unfair but Catra wants to share it with her. Catra wants to share everything, past, present and future, with her.

"Mara also said-" Catra starts, pressing the flat of her tongue behind her fang as she tries to find the right words. "She said that we had been together. In Halfmoon. That we grew together and- something happened, and our memories- they went away. But she said that she knew my mothers, that you knew them too. And me. And I knew you" Catra wiggles just slightly, but Adora's arms are firm and gentle around her, rooting her in place, in reality. Catra lets out a harsh sigh, digging her ankle, painfully, in the ground. "She said we had each other"

"I know"

"She said it wasn't my fault" gasps Catra, barely making sense of their words.

"It wasn't" Adora presses their face further inside the crook of her neck, speaking softly. "I remember"

"Wait," Catra's eyebrows knit together, words starting to sink into her brain. She turns just a little, careful of not disturbing Finn, to look Adora directly in the eyes. "Wait. What?"

And Adora is *looking* at her right back, with all the love and patience and nostalgia that could there be. They don't laugh it off or make a joke, Adora knows this is important for both of them. So they take a deep breath and start to speak. "I didn't remember before. Any of it. Shadow Weaver- she told me before doing whatever she did to me" Adora frowns for a moment, obviously upset. But then her expression relaxes and she smiles, tiny. "And then, when I woke up just now, it was all there. All the days and night by your side. Climbing trees, falling off them," Adora giggles, "Chasing each other in flower fields, watching the stars on the roof of your room. Roses, white roses that reminded me of you. Is like- it's like the lake healed me in some way. Like it gave me something back for all the time I was away"

Catra is shaking in her arms, Adora can feel her. So they start rocking her swiftly from side to side, helping her work out the sadness pouring out of her now. Adora brushes their mouth against Catra's ear, speaking softly. "You never were gone from my mind, I just had to remember you"

Catra laughs, watery and shaky but honest. Adora rests his chin on her shoulder, looking down at Finn with soft eyes. "I'll tell you about it. Once we get to Camelot, you'll know everything about it. Every detail."

Catra stiffens suddenly on her arms, her trembling stopping. Her ears press flat against the base of her head and her tail frizzles, anxious and sick. Adora feels the change immediately and so does Finn because they whimper softly, still eating slowly but jolted by their mother's sudden change of emotions. Behind them, Melog rumbles, raising their head to watch them with alert eyes. Adora's own breath hitches on his throat, a sense of dread washing over him as his head starts to work out some points.

“Catra?” No answer. Catra's shoulders fall forward and her lips press into a trembling pout. Her eyes are rimmed red and her expression is immensely sad. Ashamed. Adora blinks at her, and then blinks again, starting to make sense of some things. Like why the woman they love smells like smoke. Why does she look like she has been running away, her clothes dirty, her heart matted, her face pale and exhausted. Why is there a scar under her eyes that Adora knows it wasn't there and why does she seem so out of balance on her own feet. Why are there no flowers blooming under her feet and why does she look so sad. Without words, Adora understands, she knows. She thinks that since the very first second back, she knew. “Oh”

Catra's ears lower even further, her lip wobbling. Adora panics, realizing that their loss of words may be having the wrong effect on their wife. Before Adora can start saying anything Catra is already speaking, words running one after the other.

"It happened a few days ago. I knew it was coming, that without you the Horde was going to try to take Camelot down, I just didn't know how they were going to do it. I could have prepared the army but I didn't want more blood spilled, I knew how battles were against the Horde. How they used our own barriers like cages. And I couldn't- no more loss after everything. So I made this ridiculous efficient plan and we took everyone out. Everybody is alive and in Brightmoon but Camelot-" she is trembling, eyes looking down at Finn's little nose, reminiscing horrors just lived, fresh on her mind. "I couldn't protect Camelot. I failed them"

"You didn't," cuts her off Adora. There are tears stuck on their eyelashes, yes, but also pride blooming there, pride for their wife who is a newly mother and a queen and still managed to avoid a carnage by being smart and compassionate. "You protected Finn. You protected our people. You took them *out.* A place is just a place, Catra. Kingdoms are made of its people and you protected that. You are a brilliant queen, a brace king, and you should be proud of yourself for that"

Catra looks at her and nods but she still doesn't look convinced at all. Adora sighs, caressing Finn's head with their hand, over the tiny bridge of their nose and down their cheeks. "Do you blame me for the fall of Halfmoon?"

Catra snaps her head towards him, frowning deeply. "Of course not"

"Then what makes you think I would ever blame you for Camelot's?" Catra looks at them, hard, tension deflating from her shoulders little by little. "It wasn't our fault, we protected

what we loved, we protected our people and our home. And we protected each other" Catra's eyes fill with tears and spill down. Adora's own eyes tear up too and they lean towards her, softly pressing their forehead on Catra's, brushing their noses together. "I would let Camelot fall a hundred more times if that meant having you and Finn safe, you need to know that"

Catra's eyes widen and then soften completely and she curls inside Adora's arms even more, her tail coming up to curl around Adora's forearm, keeping them close.

A few more minutes pass until they start hearing a soft hiccup and tiny chirps. They turn their heads down to look at their baby, looking at both of their mothers faces with sleepy eyes, mouth splashed slightly with milk. Catra hums, changing Finn of position until they are cuddled over her shoulder, palming gently their back until they burp, tiny and amusing. The change of position makes Catra shift her feet over the moss, her ankle dragging in the soft earth. It's very tiny but Adora catches it on flight, the way Catra flinches with pain with the movement. Adora bites back a gasp, detangling from Catra's waist to lean over her injured leg, frowning deeply.

"Your ankle"

"Hmm? Oh yes" Catra wiggles on the place she is sitting in, rubbing Finn's back after they burp. A blush creeps over her cheeks making her ears flick. "I rolled my feet when I was- when we got out. Bow took a look to it but I think it is still a bit bruised"

Adora kneels in front of her, taking her ankles between her hands with feather like touch. Her eyebrows are knitted together in concern, touching with careful fingers certain spots around her feet. Wherever she touches, the skin there glows a little bit brighter, like liquid gold, washing away the pain and discomfort and making Catra sigh in relief.

"That feels good," purrs Catra, smiling. But the frown doesn't go away, Adora turns her head up to look at Catra with her lips pressed together.

"You had a fracture"

Catra blinks at her, letting out a single "Oh"

Adora pouts, cradling her ankle between her hands. "You walked out with a fracture, Catra, goddess. What happened?" Catra shifts, biting her lip. Adora catches the way her heart raises.with anxiety and she shakes her head, leaning over until she can place a loving kiss over the joint. "It's alright. You can tell me when you are ready. I can fix this, don't worry"

Adora starts working immediately, even brighter golden light being born between her hands and into Catra's ankle. The bruised bone comes to full life, etching itself together until it's fully healed, though still slightly vulnerable. Catra exhales, feeling a hundred times better than the last days. She has been chewing the pain back for days, even after Bow made the best of himself to help her out. She raises her hand, cradling the nape of Adora's head with her palm, rubbing soothing circles over the skin of their head.

"I'm going to tell you. All of it," says Catra, strangled but sure. Adora locks eyes with her, open trust and love written all over their face. Catra presses her thumb over Adora's soft lips,

tickling the tip of their nose until Adora giggles. "Tomorrow. I'm really tired today"

Adora gives her a sweet smile, kissing the palm of her hand. "Whenever you are ready. I'll follow you anywhere"

Adora stands up, taking the satchel Catra had brought up with her. There is a dark cape thrown in there that Adora takes, draping it over Catras frame as a makeshift blanket. The moss is dry and comfortable enough and Melog is warm behind their heads, so Adora lowers herself back besides Catra, resting her back on Melog's side and cradling Catra between her arms. Catra makes herself comfortable on her side, placing Finn gently over Adora's chest, laughing at the stunned expression on her face. Finn is already halfway sleep and they curl over Adora's collarbones infinitesimally small, their tiny nose pressed over Adora's pulse point until the heartbeat lulls the little kitten completely into a peaceful sleep.

Melog, back in their panther form, lets their huge head rest in the moss next to Catra's hip, their tail flicking playfully over Adora's face before stilling too. It's late and they are all tired. Their little family deserves some rest before the long journey back to Brightmoon tomorrow.

Catra hides her face partially on Adora's neck, nibbling softly at her earlobe and Adora tries to not weep at the memory that flashes inside her head, of high statues and blue trees and a little magicat girl nibbling into her ear when she felt too much at once. Adora wonders how she lived her entire life without those memories and wishes she could take them out and put them into Catra's mind and tell her *This was us. This is us. Have it all.*

But Adora can't do that for her. So instead Adora waits for Catra to finish and tilts her head towards her, pressing a single kind kiss on her lips. She tastes like honey and something deep and Adora hums against Catra's mouth, leaving tiny kisses around her mouth and the bridge of her nose again and again. Catra huffs, laughs softly, bumping her forehead against Adora's with a bright glint in her tired eyes. There is raw honesty in her voice, longing and nostalgia and also, amazingly, hope.

"I love you, Adora," and her voice is full of love.

Adora smiles, tracing Catra's cheeks with her fingers, "I love you too, Catra," rubbing the warm back of her sleepy baby with her other hand, "I love you, Finn. So much" Adora exhales, heavy but alive. "Sleep, I'm not going anywhere"

Night falls over them, sleep taking over Catra and Finn almost as quickly as Adora speaks. Outside the magic cavern, protected by a sleeping dragon, the spring night moon shines over and they rest.

❀

Adora stays awake the entire night. She doesn't get tired, not at all, she has never felt as healthy and alive as she does now. Her eyelids don't fall with exhaustion, her muscles aren't sore, her head is miraculously not foggy. No. There is nothing but clearness and the feeling of her family in her arms and that's enough to keep her awake as the starry hours pass by.

Catra sighs next to her, snuggling closer into Adora's side as she sleeps peacefully over the soft moss that surrounds the cavern's entrance. She crashed so fast once they got into the most comfortable position they could, even after she slurry assured Adora that she wasn't tired at all, already half asleep, Adora could see the weight of exhaustion over her and they exhaled in relief when she slipped into sleep. Goddess knows how many hours awake she had gone, running in the woods and barely eating or resting at all.

Her ears are pressed in the sides of her head, nose twitching lightly as she dreams, hair spilling free like waterfalls over her back and the ground. Adora runs their fingers over the locks but they are tangled painfully, stuck with mud and leaves and coal, so Adora ends up just resting their hand on the nape of her neck, rubbing tight circles there as she rests. Catra's eyelids look like moonlight, fragile skin precious to Adora's eyes, lilac prints below the red skin of her closed eyes. She must have been crying so much and for so long. It breaks Adora's soul.

But right now, on those long hours of rest, she looks happy and peaceful. Her cheeks are rosy and her eyelids twinkling with sparks of magic. This is probably the best sleep she has gotten in months and being able to do that for her tames the hammer beat of Adora's heart.

Adora had to wake her up around two in the morning, when the night moon was further away in the sky. Catra had looked around with half opened eyes, letting Adora guide her as she sat up, much more sleep than awake. Adora had put Finnie's sleepy but hungry little body inside her arms, cradling them both against their chest as Catra nursed Finn quietly, basically still asleep, only her purr and sleepy chirps as she coed their baby to eat at such early hours of the morning. Adora was quiet the entire time, letting Catra's weight fall against their chest, just looking at both of them. Catra sighed, her head rolling slightly with sleep, cuddling it against Adora's neck as the latter pressed loving kisses of encouragement over her temples, her soft ears and the sides of her cheeks. After, Catra had gently placed Finn back in Adora's hands, letting them pat their little back and fix them back into sleep, Adora's hand hovering over her too to help her lace her shirt back together and curl back on Adora's side.

Adora holds Finn the entire night, even after Catra has fed them, strong arms never getting tired of circling their almost weightless baby and their beautiful wife in them. Finn is cuddled right above Adora's sternum, between their mother's collarbones and the curve of their neck, tiny drops of drool slipping from their little mouth. Adora's shirt is halfway open, skin against their baby's skin letting them learn the feeling of Adora's embrace and their smell, even in their sleep. Their precious little head is nestled over her chest, their eyes closed and ears down against their head. One of their little hands has come up to their nose, resting lightly between Adora's skin and their button nose. They are so beautiful, so much like Catra who is her entire soul. With the loose but thick curls and the beautiful skin and the tiny freckles on their cheeks. And so much like her too. Blonde hair just like hers and the striking blue and silver in their newborn's eyes. What a beauty, what an honor.

They don't know about sadness or fear or pain. Catra has fought nails and teeth to protect them from it. Adora would torn themself apart again just to keep them safe.

Adora looks up, to the sky. Life feels surreal and yet so right. Melog, their friend, their cat, their dragon. *Wow.* Sleeping behind them like a self heated blanket. Finn chirping in their

sleep, barely even a newborn, held in Adora's hands, tiny and loved. Catra is dreaming, quiet and calm, for the first time in months she feels at peace. She feels happy.

Adora watches the moon night pass by, from one side to the other, the colors of the sky changing and turning around and around, stars twinkling bright and beautiful, the warmth of the spring breeze and the blue fireplace keeping them cozy and secure. The edges of the world paint itself in goldens and rose, new life coming with a new day.

❀

Catra blinks to the light of the early morning. The pinks and lilacs and baby blues make the field and woods around her to look ethereal, early signs of the wood's life coming back to life. Birds chirping, the heavy sound of steps of big animals off to eat and walk. Catra's hand curls in the soft moss, her brain making sense of where she is and what has happened. Her body feels sore, the kind of heaviness one has after a long exhausted sleep.

Catra rubs her hand over her eyes, cleaning the sleeping mist. The air smells like fire and fresh water and oranges. Catra's ears perk and flicker, snapping her head to the sides, memories of the last day coming to her in full force. Her hands grab the empty space around her, panic starting to swell inside her chest with a confused low whimper. That's it, until a long, strong hand comes into view, cradling the side of her face with infinite gentleness. Catra looks up, her eyes meeting silver and blue and finally Catra can make sense of Adora, sitting right next to her with Finn propped over her shoulder, their little tail curled around their mother's waist as they chirp and meow, happy and wide awake.

"I'm here," says Adora, softly. Her mouth is curled into a gentle smile, rocking Finn softly from side to side. Catra takes in all her brightness and love, feeling the warmth of her hand in hers and the brush of Adora's golden hair loose over her shoulders. Catra exhales, relief running through her veins and she smiles back at her, tiny and fragile. Adora beams, holding her hand up to place a kiss in the skin there, her lips ghosting against the pads of her fingers. "Good morning"

"Hey. Morning" answers back Catra, voice slightly raspy with sleep. She eyes Adora, slowly more and more awake as the minutes go by. Her eyes are a little bit red and there are small bruises of lilac under her blue eyes. Catra doesn't need to think too much to realize she has probably been awake for hours or maybe didn't even go to sleep at all.

She frowns, opening her mouth to say something when she realizes Finn. Their little romper has been changed for a cream colored one, with the neckline and the sleeves embroidered with tiny flowers and even tinier dragons. Their hands and little feet are covered with comfortable mittens laced by small ribbons hidden away from their curious mouth. And they smell clean, their golden hair brushed back and perfectly wrapped by the fluffy white blanket.

"Did you change them?" asks Catra, in awe. Adora flushes an adorable shade of pink, shrugging slightly as they rub the back of their neck.

"Just a little. I used the clean clothes in your satchel," they answer, restating its importance.

"When did you learn how to do that?" keeps going, however, Catra, pointing with her chin at the well done knots of the blankets. If possible, Adora's blush only deepens.

"I read a lot on Halfmoon," they mutter, looking down at Finn. The baby chirps loudly in return, kneading over Adora's neck, scenting the skin there. Catra raises an eyebrow, a smirk forming on her lips. Adora catches her expression because the tip of their ears shine bright red, their nose scrunching adorably like always when they get flushed. "And maybe practiced a little, with the parents of the castle's nursery," they add, between their teeth. Catra's smile widens and she can't help the loud laugh that escapes her lips. Adora smiles and then melts into giggles too, shaking their head as they rub their baby's back. "Now that I think about it, I wasn't really that discreet, was I?"

Catra looks at them with the softest expression, without answering. Besides her, Melog stirs, their big tail tapping over the ground heavily.

" *She is sweet"*

Catra hums, nodding very lightly. "Yes, she is"

Adora's eyebrows shot to her big forehead, a cheeky look on her eyes. "What are you both talking about?"

"You and what a wonderful mother you are." Adiras eyes widen, surprised and Catra can't do anything else but to giggle again, poking them in the middle of the forehead with the tip of her nail.

Absently, Adora passes Finn towards Catra's ready hands. Catra smiles at their baby, nuzzling their little head with her jaw as she makes little "mrps" sounds and low purrs.

"Hello, my baby. Hello" she sing-songs, running her hands over their clean clothes with absolute tenderness. Knowing that Adora had taken the time during their time apart to learn as much as they could, to be ready for Catra and for Finn, it feels Catra with untamed joy. Even if she giggles at their heartwarming kindness, Catra's heart is melting inside her chest, filled to the brim with all these feelings brought back to life.

It feels so natural, being a mother, being a mother *with Adora.* They have been together for just a couple of hours and yet Catra feels as if not a single day separated had gone by. Adora may have not lived their pregnancy but the way Adora loves Finn is undeniable and deep.

Catra smiles, ruffling Finnie's soft cheek with her finger. She can feel Adora's soft eyes on her and Catra turns her head up to look at her, surprised at the sight of lukewarm tears falling from Adora's eyes and cheeks.

“Adora?” Catra calls for her attention, placing her hand over Adora's, rubbing circles on her skin. Adora's lip wobbles, eyes turning even more watery as more and more tears keep coming. Catra's ears perk up in alert, sudden panic rising in her chest “Adora. Oh no no no no no no, sun, don’t cry"

“You had a baby,” says Adora between a sob. “You had a baby”

Catra can feel her own eyes sting, tears threatening to slip out from in between her eyelashes as little traitors. Catra swallows a sob, choking a little in her words when she speaks as softly and gently as she is capable of. “ *We* had a baby, Adora”

Adora shakes her head, playing absently with the edge of Finn's tiny blanket, tangled over Catra's knees. “I wasn’t there” Adora is gasping, fighting to find their breath with each word. Catra moves her hand towards their face, rubbing circles on their cheeks in a quiet attempt to soothe them. Adora grimaces. Their eyes are still locked in Finn's face but their mind is a thousand miles away, spiraling beyond their reach and into dark, treacherous waters. “I wasn't there to hug you and support you. I wasn’t there to hold them when they were born” Adora takes a ragged breath and when they exhale is like a dragon breathing fire, deep and furious. “She took it away from me”

Catra knows who they are talking about and she can't avoid the anger that flows free and burning cold inside the cavities of her heart. But she can't do that now. Catra has lived enough time with resentment and anger in her soul and she doesn't want s day more if it. Not now that she has her entire heart back once again. Catra guides Adora's face towards hers, cooing her gently to focus their sight back into hers. “You are here now," she says, firm, bumping her forehead against theirs. “You are holding them now. Finn needs you now, more than ever”

Ador worries their lip with their white teeth, grabbing their little hand with their fingers. They press the pad of their thumb over their tiny fingers, marveling in the way they barely wrap around their pinky. Adora sighs, tears falling and falling down. “They are so small”

Catra giggles very softly, passing Finn's back to Adora's hands. “Well, it’s only been three weeks”

Adora's eyes soften, moved by the reminder of their time away. Catra brushes their wild bangs out of their eyes, caressing the slightly crooked bridge of their nose. She nudges Finn closer to Adora's chest, nuzzling her cheek against Adora's as her scent starts to calm them further down.

“Look at them loving you” Catra whispers, fondling Finnie's fine hair that has curled around their ears. “Even when you were gone, Finn always reached for your letters. They would kick so much any time they heard your name and I could feel how happy and excited they got every single time. Even after they were born, they could cry the entire night unless they had your smell near. Your clothes, your pillows. They slept in your old crib and nuzzled against the ragdoll that looks like you. They had never, ever smiled until you. Ever. You've been there Adora, you've been there the entire time, every single day, hour and second. They are *your* child. You are *their* mother. And you are here now. Can you see that?”

Adora is looking at her, eyes big and starry, reflecting the kind sun rays, making them look almost golden under the sunrise. Her cheeks are wet with tears, curling down her chin and dripping in the fabric of Finnie's blanket. The little baby stirs awake a little, a gentle purr rumbling on their chest, traveling down Adora's hands and right inside her heart. Catra suppresses a sob, leaning until her nose bumps against the point where Adora's pulse is stronger. When she speaks, her voice is soft, shaky. Adora holds her breath, catching every

word with unbreakable attention. She knows how hard is for Catra to be this vulnerable and she wants to give her the attention her emotions deserve. She wants to give her everything.

"I regret not telling you," whispers Catra and it's so soft it's almost as if it wasn't suppose to be heard. Not by other ears that aren't Adora's. "Before you left"

Adora shakes their head, turning infinitesimally to press a butterfly kiss on her forehead, calming the thundering on her blood. "I didn't let you either, Catra" Adora holds her breath, so much and deep it aches. "I thought we had time, I've always thought we had time."

Finn chirps, opening their tiny eyes to look right into their mothers enamoured faves looking downs at them. Catra smiles, stretching her fingers to hold Finnie's other hand in hers.

"We have time now"

❀

The trip to Brightmoon feels lighter now that Adora is next to her. Before, her limbs felt heavy, her breath ragged, her mind exhausted. Now Catra goes with a sprint in her soul and a smile on her face. Melog had transformed back into the huge dark horse of before and Adora had insisted for her to ride over their back so she could rest her feet.

It's midday, the sun shining golden and warm over their heads. Adora walks over the green grass, inhaling deeply the fresh smell of the woods in spring, hearing the lovely trin of the birds in the branches and other animals eating and walking all around them. Catra's tail is draped over Melog's back and around Adora's forearm, her ears twitching with each sound in the forest. The thick cape is thrown over her shoulders, warding her from the sudden chill breezes. Finn is awake in her arms, meowing softly at her as they play with a lock of her dark, silked hair. Adora can feel Catra's beautiful eyes on them and they know she is study them, making sure they are actually alright after walking for so long.

Catra makes a clicking sound with her tongue, something like disapproval mixed with actual worry, and she clears her throat before speaking.

"Aren't your feet like, killing you, clotpole?" There it is. Adora smiles, chuckling at the fondness that the nickname brings. They meet Catra's bright sight and shakes their golden hair, tiny strands curling above their ears.

"Honestly? I feel like I was powered by a thousand suns. I could walk another thousand miles while carrying you in my back and barely break a sweat"

Catra rolls her eyes, the tip of her tail curling and smacking Adora softly on the face. "Please, don't be so modest" she says, huffing with sarcasm but there is a matching smile on her lips when she does. "Seriously, I didn't know your nap would not only give you memories but also hubris"

Adora shrugs, a cheeky smirk on their mouth as they try their head back. "Not my fault I'm so strong"

"You are so full of shit," her tail smacks Adora in the head again, this time harder. "I know you didn't sleep last night"

"I wasn't tired" Adora assures her, rubbing the palm of their hand over Catra's calf. "Watching over both if you was all I needed"

"Mmm" Catra hums, palming Melog in the back of their neck, "We should stop"

Melog rumbles and comes to a stop almost immediately, standing in the middle of a clear, mildly small field. Adora turns towards them fully, caressing the sides of their big, large face with her hands. It's not a secret how much Adora likes horses, and she already loves Melog. She is just having a great time with this. "Is Finn hungry again?"

Catra shakes her head in negation, taking Adora's extended hand to help her climb down swiftly from Melog's back. "No, but I could use a snack"

Adora helps her on her feet and wriggles her eyebrows to her, grinning big. "Well-"

"Don't"

"You've got me right here"

Catra groans, loudly, pushing Adora's shoulder with increasing but fond annoyance. "You are insufferable"

"You like it"

"I don't," bites back Catra, nudging her side with Adora's. Then her expression changes, from annoyed to something softer, creating kind wrinkles around her eyes and the lines of her mouth. "But I do love you"

Adora's mouth goes dry, heartbeat peaking up almost impossibly. He gave Catra all the time she needed to feel comfortable with expressing her feelings, and he would do it again all over again for as long as she needed. But Adora will never grow tired of hearing Catra pronounce those three words. It felt natural and right and it filled him with reassurance and happiness. Adora had opened his eyes to a world he knew and to a new world too, a world where Finn existed and Catra was safe and it made Adora be sure that he would do everything in Halfmoon exactly the same. Still, there was so much to know.

Adora folds the cape and rests it over the ground, guiding Catra with tender hands to sit over it. Catra grumbles the entire time, muttering about how she can do it very well herself but makes herself comfortable over the fabric, tugging from Adora's sleeve until he is sitting next to her. She passes him Finn, resting their little head well and secured on the crook of his elbow before roaming inside the satchel for a piece of bread.

"Hey there, my baby. You had a good sleep?" coos Adora at them, nibbling at their little nose.

Melog neighs, their body shifting and transforming into a wide panther, coming close to them to bump their big forehead softly on the side of Finn's face. They turn to look at Catra,

blinking slowly to her in a silent conversation.

"Alright," says Catra, nodding, "just be careful"

Melog rumbles, nuzzling their head on Adora's side before leaping inside the woods with wide jumps, sprinting in between the branches and disappearing among the leaves. Adoras watches them go with raised eyebrows, a question stuck on their tongue.

"They are going to check around us" explains Catra, taking an errand strand of their golden hair and placing it behind their ear. "To see everything it's okay and that we are going in the right direction".

Adora untangles a hand from around Finn's body to cradle Catra's, pressing her warm palm on the side of their face gently. "Do you think someone could be looking for us?"

Catra sighs, heavy and hoarse on her chest. Her thumb brushes over Adora's skin, crossing over the sun freckles that live there. "Emperor Prime must be furious. He probably sent people looking after me," she bites her lip, worrying the red skin with her teeth a bit, "But nothing is going to prepare anyone for you"

"Why so?"

"Everybody thinks you are dead, Adora," Catra can't help the shake of her voice when she says it. Adora tightens her hold on her hand, skin against skin, reassuring her that she is here, with them.

"I want to know"

Catra blinks at her, confused. "About what?"

"Everything. Everything that happened. I want to know"

Catra's eyes water and she exhales. "It's a long story"

Adora smiles at her, tiny, tilting her head so she can press a kiss over her palm. "I'm not going anywhere"

The sun is lower on the sky and her throat is hoarse and tired by the time Catra stops speaking. Adora's hand is on hers, tight and a little bit sweaty but never waving in the strength of their grip. Finn is tugging from Adora's hair, putting it in their mouth and drooling all over it as they watch the profile of their mother above them with wide, bright blue eyes.

Adora's sight it's focused on a point over Catra's shoulder, retinas glassy as their mind travels far away from them. Their lips are white and dry of how hard they are pressing them together and there is a faint cold sweat shining on their forehead. Yet their touch remains gentle and their breathe even, deep inhales and exhales making their chest rise and fall rythimically.

Catra's voice thins and dies down, cutting herself away when she speaks about Camelot's traitor. She has said everything else. The arrival of Halfmoon's survivors, the long months waiting for Finn, the plan of the aqueducts, the attack from the Horde Empire, Melog, Bow

and Glimmer by her side. Everything except this part, a dark bruise on the story Catra is nervous to touch. Her silence must be louder than her words because Adora blinks and focuses back into her. The line of her lips turns into a snarl, baring her teeth just enough for Catra to jump slightly in surprise.

"It was Light Hope" It's not a question. Adora's voice is dispassionate and far away. Catra bites the inside of her cheek and her voice comes as a very low murmur

"Yes

Something in Adora's chest rumbles, a growl that intensifies and then lowers down again and dies completely. Their shoulders drop down and the edges of her eyes soften. Adora leans in, still carrying Finn with one of her arms, to caress the side of Catra's ear with the pads of her fingers. "Did she hurt you?"

"She couldn't," Catra hesitates, looking at the side of Finn's face as she speaks again. "She tried to take Finn"

Adora's demeanor changes immediately again. Her back and shoulders tense, her mouth transforms into an unsatisfied grimace, the edges turning down. There is an electric storm inside her silver eyes and, if Catra looks closer, she swears she can see thunder cracking inside her irises. Catra opens her mouth, ready to say something, *anything* .

"Adora-"

"You really are the bravest person I know," says Adora, even in between the electricity running inside her body. Catra gasps, a tiny hiccup leaving her mouth with the emotions at seeing Adora’s eyes puffed and rimmed red. "You've been through so much and yet you saved our people, you protected Finn, you gave them birth and loved them and nurtured them. You saved me. You did all of those things. Since I was a kid I knew I was going to love you always. I knew it then and I know it now," Adora takes a ragged breath, holding back a watery sigh. "You should have never suffered like that. You should have been safe and secure inside of Camelot, not attacked and betrayed by someone I trusted. I knew something was wrong, I should have seen it. I shouldn't have left you alone"

Catra's eyebrows scrunch in worry, her heart beating inside her throat. One of her hands comes up and hovers over Adora's forearm, feather-like touch over the fine hairy skin there. "Adora-"

"I'm going to pick up more wood," says Adora, suddenly, passing Finn back into Catra's arms with gentle movements. She stands up from her place in the ground, brushing fallen leaves off her dark pants. Then she leans towards Catra and kisses her head, caressing Finn's cheek with her knuckles in the way. "Don't worry, I won't be far"

Catra's voice stays tangled in her vocal cords as Adora spins and walks into the woods, the sound of dry leaves cracking under her weight the only giveaway of her presence as she goes further and further away. Catra stays there, without moving, watching the point where she has gone into until she can't hear her anymore. Her mind spirals in worry, dark places forming

there rotten and nasty. Catra obligates herself to breathe, closing her eyes to stop the dizziness in her head.

She knew this wasn't going to be easy for Adora. Light Hope was an ever present figure in her life, she had watched Adora grow into what she was and stood by Mara's sides many years before and during that. Even if Light Hope wasn't their mother, Adora knew Light Hope loved her mother and cared for her. And Adora's heart was too good, too kind, she had loved Light Hope in return too. She had trusted her, named her royal advisor and trusted her with the kingdom, trusting her with their people, with Catra's safety. Being betrayed like this was a harsh blow and it was always going to be hard to process it and move from it. Catra knows all of this.

Still, she can't help the pang of anxiety that stabs into her chest as she looks at herself, alone again, with her baby and nothing else. She knows Melog is circling the perimeter, she knows Adora will come back sooner than the panic will subside and die, but Catra has already lost her once and now she only wants to sprint to her feet and make her walk back to her side.. Catra is aware Adora needs to work the betrayal, she herself still has to work it out, but it doesn't mean they have to do it alone, no when they have each other. Adora has a tendency to chew their feelings out, to hide their pain and exhaustion and even anger. Catra doesn't want that, Catra wants for Adora to feel and be free, free of the weights they have out all over themself. And Catra will be there to catch them just as she knows Adora will be there to catch her. That's what love is.

So, Catra stands up, almost without realizing, huffing as she fixes her clothes and drapes the baby blanket around her chest better. Finn is drooling all over her shirt and it makes her chuckle a little, placing a sweet little kiss in the crown of their head. She stretches from head to toes, chasing the sore feeling in her muscles away.

••••

There is a ruffling of leaves at her left and then the sound of a branch breaking. Her ears perk up and her tail frizzles. It takes her brain just a second to understand the weight and the cracks are definitely not Adora before a new smell comes to her nose. Sour and heavy, like racind sweat and dirty, heavy breathings all around her. Catra's pupils shrink into pinpoints and she spins around quickly enough to watch four people walk from among the shadows of the trees and into the small field. They are huge, two with big pointy horns that are born from their temples and curl behind their heads, big arms and rotten yellow teeth as they smile. The other two are a little bit smaller but quicker, closer to a magicat with big dark claws and iridescent scales up and down their faces and arms, their eyes slit in yellow and green.

Catra gasps, baring her teeth into a horrid dangerous snarl as she growls, loud and menacing, a warning of not step any closer. She curses her head for driving away from her senses, exhaustion taking a tool of her. Catra looks all around her, ankles digging in the soft ground below her feet. She thinks of screaming, of calling Adora's name and sprints inside the woods where she went, heart racing as she half waits for Melog to burst back into the field. Catra looks at the four men and then back to the woods, spotting a perfect window through which she can jump and sprint into. She is about to make a run for it when one of the bull-like men snarls, threatening, the sound resounding in the air as a hundred thunders. On her arms, Finn

jolts awake, their little ears dropping to the sides of her head and their face scrunching for the painful sound. Finnie's little eyes well with tears and Catra looks at them, alarmed, for just a fraction of a second before they break into a loud, heartbreaking cry. Catra gasps, focusing on them immediately, and she makes the small mistake of slip.

She knows she has lost her chance to run almost as quickly as the four men because they jump into action immediately. The two ones with claws rush to her side, baring their claws raw towards her. Catra jumps to the side, covering Finn's little head with her hand as she avoids the hit, only to fall right into the harsh hold of the tallest bull one. He wraps one of his arms around her collarbones and shoulders, the other one raising as he points something long and sharp and threatening next to her neck. The blade of the knife doesn't dig but Catra can feel its ever present presence too close to her throat and way too close to Finn. She freezes in place, eyes wide, her voice stuck on her tongue. Her nose flares with the man's smell, that same sour sweat and rotten saliva and dry blood on his clothes.

"Where are you going little girl? After all the trouble it took us to find you" he says, dragging the vocals, his accent thick and heavy. "The Horde has a bounty, ya know? For a pretty magicat and her baby kitten and so happens that you are right here. And you are all alone"

The other three surround them, their mouths split into mocking smiles as they chuckle. One of them kicks into the dirt, blowing out the dim light of the fire and drenching the field back into shadows, only the errands sun rays among the trees' leaves illuminating it. Catra kicks in the floor, her fangs prolonging inside her mouth, colorful fae feathers burning and turning into a deep shade of red. Still, she doesn't dare to move, not with her hands around her baby who is crying over her chest and the man's knife close. So close.

"Take your fucking hands away from me," she spits, growling. "This is an order from your Queen. Stay away"

The men laugh, outloud, their long faces cracking into noisy chuckles. When they move, Catra can see the Horde symbol embroidered sloppily on their ripped capes.

"We obey no Queen, woman," laughs one of them on her face. Then he leans and actually spits next to her bare feet, his face scrunching into a nasty expression. "And certainly not a pathetic magicat like you"

Catra huffs, her face pale with indignation and rage. "I am warning you one more time, stay away. Or neither of you will walk away from here alive"

The grip on the man's hold tightens and Cayra chokes just slightly, alarmed. "Ya should have gone back to the hole ya crawled out of when ya had the chance, magicat," he says, dragging the point of the knife ever so slightly up the column of her neck and jaw. "But the Horde will give us good money for ya two, so ya are in luck tonight"

Catra holds her breath, her heartbeat speeding up. Her magic cracks on the tips of her fingers, sending tiny shivers up her arms and hands. Finn wriggles in her hands, hiccuping sadly and the sparks die again. She can't risk it, not with Finn so close and her magic still so drained out. Her breath is coming out in heavy puffs of steam, her nerves screaming inside her body.

"Don't put that face, pretty. Smile. Girls always look prettier smiling," the nasty breath of the man hits the side of Catra's head, making her stomach clench. The other three are now hovering over her, one of them extending his hand, fingers curling over the baby blanket to take Finn away. Catra feels a scream in the base of her throat. "Don't ya worry, I will take very good care of ya"

It happens very quickly, over the thunder of her heart, Catra doesn't even hear her come.

Catra blinks and suddenly two of the three men are scrunched in the ground, grabbing their knees as they yelp in pain. The third one is frozen in place, fingers still curling over Finn's blanket but now loose, his neon yellow eyes open in raw panic. The sunlight in the field flickers like a candle and dims, drowning the reduced space into darkness. The ground below their feet shakes, hard, and the temperature drops completely, the warm evening turning into the coldest of nights. Catra exhales, her multicolor eyes widening as she catches sight of the strong and familiar hand wrapped around the man's throat in front of her. She follows the path of familiar scars and beloved skin, up the fine blonde hairs of a scarred arm and the cream cotton shirt, into the bright silver eyes of Adora, that flash with untamed rage.

She looks at Catra and then down, towards Finn, who is openly crying, their little face scrunched sadly, tears falling from their eyes as they try to hide their little face with their hands and the angle of Catra's shoulder, loud sobs in the middle of the woods like tower's bells. Adora's eyes are swimming with concern, eyebrows knit together over her beautiful eyes, looking back and forward from her wife to their little baby, distraught in her arms. Catra holds her breath and locks eyes with her, wide and without blinking, trying to speak without words as she doesn't dare to move a single millimeter. She can feel as the sharp point of the knife drags closer to her face when the bounty hunter panics, prickling the skin there in faint lines of red.

Adora follows the movement and her pupils shrink, electric blue overtaking the silver. Her entire face changes, the soft lines around her eyes and mouth hardening into something cold, like a marble statue, eyes as crystal cut sapphires. Her lips retrieve back, baring her white teeth menacingly. Her loose golden hair floats around her face like a halo and she looks grave and angry. Completely and absolutely angry.

"Let go," says Adora, slowly. Her grip in the man's throat tightens, making him gasp. The skin of his neck and jaw are quickly coloring in red and purple. Below them, the other two are groaning, too shocked by the pain to speak or help. When the man that is holding Catra doesn't move Adora clicks her tongue, annoyed.

"Let go," she repeats, this time slower. The arm that is wrapped around Catra's shoulders shakes and the man snaps the knife away of Catra's neck to swing it recklessly towards Adora, his voice high pitched. There is a sudden flash inside her eyes, something sharp and white that twinkles like a newborn star. Catra holds her breath.

"Who the fuck are you?!" the man yells, the sharp sound is too close and it makes Finn whimper on Catra's hold. Adora's eyes narrow, her grip tight over the man, making the joints of his vertebra shackle. Her voice is raspy and slow, pronouncing each word with purpose

"I'm going to give you three seconds and you are going to let go and step away from my wife and my baby or I'm going to rip your companion's neck in two," Adora moves her hand up and with it the man she is gripping raises in his feet, up and up until his toes are dangling a couple of feet on the air. The eyes of the bounty hunter that is holding Catra widen in terror by he doesn't move. Adora makes a disapproval sound with her tongue and starts counting low between her teeth. "One"

"Your- your what?"

"Two"

"Wait, hold on"

"Three"

"Alright! Alright! There, there"

The bounty hunter lowers his arm, grasping Catra's wrist hard enough to make her bones crunch. He yanks Catra towards the front as if she weighed nothing to him, not quite letting go of her completely, the knife dangling in the air until it catches lightly in Catra's cheek, marking an angry red line there. Adora clenches her teeth together, the tips chipping with its force, and a low, angry growl escapes their mouth, resounding through the entire field as war horns.

Here lies the truth. Adora is angry.

Adora may be good and kind and brave and patient, she is all of those things. She has always been and always will. But right now, she is angry. Completely, undeniable, fucking angry.

She wasn't with Catra. She didn't live her pregnancy, didn't see her soft and kind and beautiful as she carried their baby for months. She didn't make her laugh when she was having a hard day, didn't bring her foot when she craved a snack, didn't get to wake up next to her every single morning as she changed and grew and became beautiful, so much beautiful. She didn't hold her hand or tame her pain or pressed her lips against her temple and nor helped her through it when the moment came. She didn't hold Finn when they were born. She wasn't there because people conspired against them. Because people they loved, Adora loved, betrayed them, turned against them. They took Adora away from Catra's side and then threatened her and their little baby. Catra had to go through so much and she had to do it alone and Adora missed it all even after she promised she would not.

Adora is angry.

And now, there is a man who thought he was too smart. A man waving a sharp blade too close to Catra's neck, too close to their baby's precious face. And Finn is crying. Distressed and confused and as painful as a million blades digging in Adora's body. Catra shelters them as best as she can, bending her shoulders forward, keeping their face partially hidden between the waves of their blanket, rocking them lightly to subdue their crying. Catra is standing tall and proud but Adora can see the hint of fear in her eyes and that she doesn't even dare to move right now. And Adora just got them back.

Adora is angry.

The dim light of the sunset blinks and then dies completely. The branches of the trees start cracking, twisting and bending over themselves until the wood gives away and the roots make a horrible, loud and terrifying sound. A silver, humid sound starts rise inside field. Drip, drip, drip. Until golden drops start to run and pool drown the leaves and thick logs and into the ground. Golden rivers start traveling in the grass, slick and long like serpents, making a silver sound as a high pitched bell. The golden light curves on itself and then circles, circling around Adora's feet again and again until it touches her soles. Then, the light starts craddling it's way up, around Adora's leg and inside her very skin, digging it's place among the cells of her arms, hand and collarbones, extending as spiderwebs over her neck and cheeks and in the escaleras of her bright blue eyes, making them look as twin suns, sharp and alert and somehow, a little bit more than human. More than Etherian. More than First One. Her second hand twitches by her side and with it the light swirls and bends, cracking in the air with thunder and lightning, as if Adora was holding the very light with her bare hands.

It all happens very fast, lightning parting a tree into a column of blue and golden fire. The light shoots forward, suddenly crashing against the silver blade of the man’s knife, making him yell in surprise and drop the weapon into the ground. Adora seizes Catra by the waist and yanks her as softly but quickly as she can from the man's grasp. Catra huffs, surprised, grabbing into Adora's shirt with one hand, the other holding securely Finn's little head. The movement is so smooth and swift Catra barely has time to inhale for a second because at the next she is standing behind Adora, shielded by their body which seems to be glowing in pure white and gold bright. Adora’s loose hair brushes her face gently, a wave of warmth slipping into the cold numbness that had overcome over her body and chasing it all away.

Catra tries to fix her sight in Adora but she can’t even glimpse at them and the way their body seems to be glowing with so much strength as if the sun had disappeared from the sky and crawled inside Adora’s skin, a very sun in the middle of the woods, sheltering Catra and their baby with their fulgor.

Adora let’s go of the man on her hand with a displeased huff, throwing him in the ground unceremoniously as she focuses her raged eyes on the man in front of them, still paralyzed with surprise and shock. One of the men laying on the grass next to them seems to recover his breath for a second and raises to his feet as Adora is distracted, getting a hold of something in his back before launching himself over Catra. The least has barely time to jump back and away from the swing of a second blade directed to her face, growling. The blade reaches such a fraction away from his face before Adora’s arm snaps to the side, their elbow connecting hard and painful against the man’s nose with a loud, distinguishing wet crack. The man stumbles back with a strangled yell, confused and in pain as he cradles his broken nose with his hands. The second man in the ground tries to make a move for it, jumping towards them to try and get a hold of Finn’s blanket. Adora sees it from the edge of her vision, spinning Catra away to face the man, placing the palm of their hand over the man’s throat and sending him flying several feet away with a muted thud.

The bounty hunter in front of them looks around him with a stunned expression, taking on his companions crawling on the ground to get as far away. Thin but strong roots burst from inside the earth and tangle on their limbs, keeping them stuck in place, twisting around their

ankles and wrists and mouths, keeping them shut. The bounty hunter growls, grinding his canines together as he snaps his eyes back to Adora and Catra. Finn lets out a particular loud sob, resounding in the field stronger than the thunder. Adora gasps, turning her eyes for just a second to their direction. The bounty hunter sees it, seizing the opportunity to launch himself to the side and towards Catra and Finn, his fist raised with long and sharp nails unfolded.

Adora it’s faster.

Her extended palm grabs the man by the face, holding him up and several feet over the ground with just the forcer of her arm. Her eyes are overflowing, drops of golden sunlight falling down her cheeks and chin, making the pearl shine of her teeth flash when she snarls. Her hand tightens, making the bones protest painfully and menacingly. The man opens his mouth, a silent yell leaving his mouth in one long breath. Adora clicks her tongue against the back of her teeth, flexing her arm until the man's face is right in front of hers, speaking with the softest but most ragged tone.

"You should have stayed away"

And it's like a hundred voices, all of them Adora but also as if the ground and the trees and the sun and the very sky were echoing them inside that field, opening the dark sky with a long electric white line. The light inside Adora starts shining more and more until their warm waves become boiling hot, unbearable and unstoppable. It shines and shines and shines until it overcomes the entire field, drowning the greens and blues and lilacs into gold. The sun's light slips inside the man's chest, his bloodstream, the marrow of his bones, the connections of his nerves, the air on his lungs, turning him into light itself, making his skeleton shine through his skin and then dissolve into thin air, disappearing forever into a void scream.

Catra holds herself into Adora's shirt, partially hiding her face between their shoulder blades. The light doesn't hurt her or bother her. It's like standing below the sea in a hot summer midday, but being able to breathe under it. She doesn't look up, not until the bright sun in front of her, surrounding her, holding her, protecting her, starts to lower down its bright, more like a candle than a star. Catra blinks, noticing for the first time the light tears that have stuck to her long eyelashes, until her sight clears completely and she is able to peak from over her love's shoulder.

The field is back to normal, the trees on their usual shapes, the grass calm and evergreen. The golden rivers have retreated over themselves and up, climbing to the sky until the clouds shake and the weak light of the sun starts illuminating over them again. As if nothing had happened at all, the remaining bounty hunters are splayed into the ground, looking with wide, frightened eyes up and towards the person in front of her. Adora is panting, their shoulders going up and down in frantic rhythm, but their posture is straight and unyielding, looking down at the men from below their chin, grimacing at their presence still there.

"Go," demands Adora, hoarse. The men don't wait, not even a beat. They scramble on their feet and rush inside the woods, tripping over their feet and among themselves before getting loose of sight.

••••

Catra releases a shaky sigh, resting her cheek over Adora's back with heavy relief. Finn is still crying, heavy drops on their silver and blue eyes, button nose red and damp with snot, little hands wiggling in the air as they search blindly for their mother's warmth. Catra shushes them gently, rocking their tiny body in her arms. Adora is there immediately, spinning over their ankles and cradling Finn's little head between her huge hands and the heavy remains of magic still hanging around them drop instantly.

"Shh, it's alright Finn. It's alright. We are here", Adora chants, running their fingers gently over the delicate skin of their face. It doesn't even look like those hands just bent the world to their will. Finn hiccups, searching for the warmth of their mothers as their cry starts to subside further and further.

Adora runs her hands over the base of her baby´s little head,shushing softly at them. She doesn't dare to look up and into Catra´s eyes, afraid of what she will find inside them. Shock, probably. Disbelief, maybe. Fear? Anger? Disgust? Adora had just obliterated a man out of existence with her bare hands. A horrible man that would have most sure delivered her family into the hands of people that wanted nothing but to hurt them beyond measure, yes. And just for a few coins in return, yes. But Adora had done it, still and, maybe worse of all, she didn't feel remorse at all.

she had been in battle, in the middle of war. She had seen people fall and be the cause of it all, but never like this. it had cost her nothing, just a single lift of her arm and the release of something powerful, something she had always felt in there but had never allowed herself to set free completely. Raw power and strength and the knowledge that she could carry the sun inside her back and move the world from its position in the universe and barely even break a sweat. But

Adora had always been taught to keep it all inside, under control. *Don't step out of the line. Don´t go beyond what you must. Focus on your mission, don't let your feelings mix with the work you must do.* It had all been taught and repeated over and over again since very early in her childhood and all the way into her adulthood. Told and told until protocol was all Adora knew. All taught by Light Hope.

Well, damn Light Hope. Damn it all. She had betrayed Mara, betrayed Adora, betrayed the very morals she held so high and important. She had searched for the return of a love and ignored the possibility of a new family to love. Damn it all again and a thousand times after. Adora wasn't going to hold themself back anymore.

Yet, there is that fear. Of what Catra will say. They have a kid and Adora just finished a man in front of them both. She can't help the terrified shiver that travels down her spine as she waits with held breath.

Adora is swimming on these thoughts, spinning in freezing cold water and drowning herself until her lungs scream and her fingers are frozen in one single momentum when an elegant hand comes into view. The loved and familiar dark skin of the woman she loves approaches their face, taking on her lukewarm palm their cheek and rubbing soothing circles there. Catra guides them softly, tilting Adora´s head until their eyes meet in the middle. There is no fear or anger or disgust in there. There is no disappointment. There is worry, yes, but also relief and somehow also something that looks so much like pride and reassurance. Adora chokes

around a sob, one time and then two and before they know it they are crying, big and wet and messy down their tanned cheeks and making splats of tears in the fabric of their shirt. Catra presses her lips together, the blue and gold in her eyes soft and sad too and she moves very tenderly as she passes Finn from her hands to Adora, trusting them wordlessly with their newborn baby´s safety. Adora understands because that´s the way Adora and Catra understand each other, and their crying only crescends, somehow making Finn calm further and further down now that they are closer to their mom´s natural warmth. Catra sobs too, the dam free, the emotions and all the weight they had both carried during the last months spilling in waterfalls or tsunamis, letting it all out.

“It's alright, Adora. It's all right,” chants Catra against her broken voice, circling Adora´s neck with her arms and bringing them closer to her chest, cradling them over her collarbones and the beating of her heart. She hides her face at the top of their hair, right over the spot where some of the shorter blond strands always curl in a funny, puffy way, pressing her fingers on the nape of their neck as she rocks the three of them side by side. “You saved us. Are you listening to me? You saved us”

And Adora knows she doesn't only mean now. Adora exhales, with all the air on their lungs, resting their nose on Catra´s pulse point as their fingers hold onto Finnie´s tiny hands.

“I´m not afraid of you,” continues Catra, because it's true and because she knows Adora and because she knows they need to hear it. “ *We* are not afraid of you. You are wonderful and I love you” and then in a broken whisper, something she has been meaning to say for a long time now and couldn't, “You are not alone Adora, you are never going to be alone ever again. You are going to be loved, always. If you change or if you don’t, I will love you, all of you”

There is not much to say after that. Melog will come back, purple fur ruffled with anxiety after seeing the show of light and rushing to come back. They will find the tiny family cradled together over the grass and the remains of magic bursting the field alive. They will go near them and surround them with their warmth too, joining the loving embrace for several monigotes until their heartbeat has calmed back down and they are able to breathe again. And much later they will leave their improvised camp and hop back into the path and they will talk about it all, they way Adora held back for so long until it hurted, they way sometimes it was too much and they rather drown in work than embraced. The Catra had come to their life with balance and turned their entire life upside down for the good. And Catra will speak too, about why she kept quiet for so long, about how much she feels and how much she fears and how hard it’s too be vulnerable. And they will walk on the woods, carrying their child and their entire future between their arms, sheltered by the trees and the leaves and eventually also the night. And it all will shine bright with the moonlight, illuminating their steps as fire flights until the limits of Brightmoon greet them.

And under Catra's bare and tired feet, tiny flowers will bloom again.

❀

The dawn is washing over Etheria by the time they reach Brightmoon. The soft pinks and lilacs that come with the day moon make everything look a little bit more tender, a little bit

more round on the edges.

Adora is riding on Melog's equine back, Catra sitting behind them with a sloppy arm thrown around Adora's middle and her cheek resting over their back, halfway asleep. Adora holds themself into Melog's neck, carrying Finn on their other arm as the little baby sleeps peacefully on their hold.

The huge garden walls that mark the beginning of the Brightmoon's kingdom come into view and with it the pulse of the magic barriers that surround it. Adora blinks away the mist of their eyes, looking swiftly to the sides before motioning Melog to walk out of the purple woods. The dragon's, now transformed into their horse form, steps are muted over the damp moss, leaves cracking silently under their joined weight. The drum of magic is stronger now, caressing against their cheeks with warmth and familiarity.

Adora's exhales, puffs of steam leaving their mouth against the cold of the dawn. Adora wraps the cape closer against themself and Finn, covering their face with the hood completely to keep the warmth as much as they can, their fingers numb and eyes tired. As much as Adora had felt healthy and strong after waking up from the lake, Adora had also used a strong deal of magic yesterday and they had been walking without stopping the entire night, watching over a completely tired Catra as she slipped back and forward of sleep or had to stop to nurse Finn. After being awake two nights in a row, Adora was exhausted.

The huge torii gate is closer now. Adora can see its wide red and black columns rising above their heads with their entire might. Unlike Camelot, Brightmoon doesn't remain hidden but it is protected by large and powerful barriers, making everything look as if it was floating over soft white clouds. Adora guides Melog to approach the gate, making a gentle reverence before stepping closer. The ruffle of the trees it's the only warning they get before a rush of lilacs passes in front of them, surrounding the horse and their companions into a tight circle made of magic and weapons. The sharp point of a spear points directly in front of Adora's face, still hiding inside the hood, another twelve or so spears all around them, pointed to Melog's side and Catra's back, unmoving from their position. Adora holds her breath, narrowing her eyes to focus on the figures that hold the spears and biting into her tongue hard enough to contain her own magic response in defense. One of the figures steps forward and finally Adora can make out the deep purple of her armor and helmet, and the soft lilac that comes out of her weapon in visible waves. The black eyes of Brightmoon's General look back at them, not recognizing Adora under the cape, as she bares her white teeth and frowns in warning.

"Who dares to set foot in the sacred lands of Brightmoon?" says the General, loud enough to resound inside the very woods at their backs. The rest of the soldier's are unyielding, waiting for any signal to attack from their General, who growls at receiving no answer. "Does Horde scum though you could just walk inside our refugee without a problem?"

Adora is about to answer, mouth hanging open with surprise, when Catra stirs behind her, awakened by the jolt as she sits straight and takes her hood back, just enough so everyone gathered around the gate can see her face fully.

"General," speaks Catra, with calm but also firmness, somehow even more powerful than the general's voice. The general gasps out loud, losing grip of her spear for just a second before

taking it back completely and away from them.

"King C'yra! Goddess above!" the General makes a deep reverence, looking up just to shoot a sharp glance to her soldiers besides them. "What are you all doing, salute to King C'yra and don't point at her with your weapons!"

The soldiers hurry to do so, some actually dropping their spears into the ground as they mutter shocked apologies to her majesty. Catra chuckles under her breath, exhaustion visible in her tone as she rests her cheek on Adora's clothed shoulder.

"Don't apologize. I would have done the very same thing or worse," Catra clears her throat, ever so slightly, rubbing her nose on the base of Adora's neck. "Please tell Queen Glimmer and King Bow that we have arrived"

The General nods, giving one and then two and three reverence before sprinting back to the gate. She is about halfway there when she hesitates, looking behind her with raised eyebrows as she searches for Catra's companion's face. She frunces her lips, unsure of how to proceed before asking. "Who are *we,* your Majesty?"

Catra laughs softly, tugging from Adora's elbow to motion her back into motion. Adora sniffs from the cold of the dawn, running a hand through her hair to let the hood fall back down, careful of not exposing Finn to any kind of cold. Adora's hair looks ashed under the mist of the new day, curling softly around their temples and making their eyes look impossibly grey. They can see the way the General's, and everybody else, eyes widen with sudden surprise and then complete shock. The poor soldiers left that hadn't dropped their spears now do, the clanking sound funnily in tune. Catra laughs, a breath behind Adora's neck as they smile brightly at Brightmoon's people, pointing swiftly behind them with a gentle shrug.

"Hello," Adora says, brightly, making the soldiers and the general gasp when the realization of who is actually in front of them starts to set in, "Do you mind finding a blanket for my wife, please?"

What happens in the next half hour of Adora's life happens as many things do. In a rush. It reminds her of the morning of their wedding, when Adora was going from chamber to chamber, followed by the smell of fresh roses and perfumes and people fixing their hair and pampering them before the great event.

Now Adora is passed from chamber to chamber inside of Brightmoon, a stella of pink and purple anywhere they go. She knows someone takes the cape away at some point. Somebody else hands them warm cups filled with a sweet and hot drink that warms Adora and Catra to the core. And someone else wraps a heavy blanket around Catra's shoulders and another one over Adora's wide back, the fluffy material like a cloud against their skin. At some point, Adora hears a few guards telling each other to give word to the Regents of their arrival and another that says that it will have to wait until after the war meeting that is just going on. It doesn't really matter, honestly. Most people hold themselves from the columns of the palace, light headed with the shock of seeing a ghost walking, very much alive and breathing, among them. Adora it's mildly conscient that some people are openly crying, sobbing inside their hands and running around the palace as they shout Adora's name. After all, Adora had been taken for a lot of the war for a long time now. Some others are fumbling over Catra, taking a

curious peak at the little baby nestled on her arms and they gasp in marvel and adoration, making Adora remember that Finn's existence had remained a secret outside of the barriers of Camelot up until now.

So, it takes a little while, but they finally make it, inside the wide space of a royal chamber, Adora's arm always wrapped around Catra's waist, not a single second away from her or their baby, pressed over their mother's chest with all the sleepiness of a young kitten. Adora can feel Catra's anxiety increasing as the sea of people doesn't seem to wave down and, honestly, as much as Adora themself is grateful for the warm welcome, they only want to shut the door and lock it with a key for a while.

Melog slips inside the chamber too, pushing the heavy and tall door with their head until the lock clanks in place and the room is drowned in blessed silence. Adora sighs, tangling his arms around Catra's waist and bringing her and Finn into a soft hug. Catra answers the hug in kind, letting herself melt inside the warmth of Adora's arms.

She has missed this, being able to circle back into Adora's embrace and let the weight of the world slip away from her shoulders. It still seems all like a dream, just a beautiful, wonderful dream from which she is going to inevitably wake up again. Maybe Adora feels the same, the way he feels like if he opens his eyes he will be back inside the cold water, floating further and further away from the people he loves the most. It's a fear that will take a little bit to conquer.

Catra exhales, heavy, painful, nuzzling her nose in Adora's collarbone as she basks on his scent. "Do you remember, Adora?" she asks, in a tiny, fragile voice and Adora knows exactly what she is talking about.

"I remember you," Adora answers, biting the inside of his cheek, images playing like paintings inside his head. "I remember seeing you and seeing Finn. So small, wrinkled and pink, like a little peach. And you were glowing even though you were exhausted, you were beautiful. I remember it like all, like a dream but better. I remember feeling completely incandescently happy" Adora chokes slightly with his words, tears welling down yet again. "It was real, wasn't it? It happened"

"I think it did," assures Catra. There is a purr rising on her chest, filling the huge chamber with its calmness. "It was the day Finn was born, after, when we went to sleep. You were there" Catra feels the way Adora's shoulders shake with the tears and she lets them be, pouring it all out and on the open so it can stop festering and it allows them to heal. She lets herself do the same. "Mara helped"

Adora nods, sinking in Catra's long, matted hair. There is a jostle outside the castle as the news of Catra, and *Adora's* , return starts to spread like green wildfire. The royal spouses part just slightly, helping each other on their feet as they look around them. The chamber it's almost ridiculously humongous, pink and purple and glitter everywhere. In the fluffy carpets in the ground and the curtains around the large bed that brushes the floor, and even the furniture, adorned with sparks of golden here and there. The walls are thankfully mute tone and there is a shoji of a translucent pink that guides to a wide window and down to the garden of the palace. Over the vanity, someone has already left several pairs of clean clothes, soft like butter and of a very light grey and white. And in the far end, right next to the side of

the bed, there is a crib of cherry wood, waiting patiently with a new set of sheets and even more changes of tiny clothes.

Adora is swiftly confused at first but then she realizes it must have been placed there by Glimmer and Bow for Catra's and Finn's return and the thought of her best friends loving her family so deeply and honestly makes her heart grow twice its size all over again.

They move together, almost as if rehearsed. Catra gravitates towards the crib, placing Finn over the bed as she grabs a change of baby clothes. Adora goes towards the vanity, taking two changes of clothes and a bowl with warm water and walking next to Catra. They wash their hands and then change and clean Finn, working together in harmonious silence. Catra helps Adora learn, guiding their hands silently where they must go and how they should do it, helping when Adora struggles with the knots of the diapers and placing a tiny kiss over their biceps when they are done and Finn is back nestled over Adora's shoulder. Adora smiles on return, big and goofy and proud of doing a good work together, nudging Catra with their hip until she rolls her eyes and laughs.

Finn hiccups on their sleep and nuzzles further in Adora's neck, their tiny, tiny nose pressing against her pulse point. Adora's hand is huge against Finn's body as she cradles them closer to her and rocks them gently from side to side to lull them, walking towards the crib their friends had placed for them and placing them there with the gentlest of cares.

Catra has walked towards the end of the bed, face towards Finn and Adora, scrambling among the things inside the vanity just to let herself fall into the plush mattress, scratching Melog's tiny house-cat head in the way. Adora watches her back with the softest of eyes, the fall of her shoulders and the long, elegant column of her neck. Adora can't stop the longing sigh leaving their mouth as they watch her. One of Catra's ears flip, catching the sound with her sensitive hearing and Catra turns towards them, just slightly, dangling something weirdly shaped and silver between her fingers.

"Adora"

"Yes, my love?"

A tiny smile spreads in Catra's lips at the nickname, her tail curling in Adora's direction. Then she still, posting towards her head with a flip of her hand, almost indifferent. "Cut it"

Adora blinks, frozen on their place behind Catra, their hand hovering one over her shoulder the other over the silver scissors. "What-"

"My hair," explains Catra, shurgging. "Just- just the worst of it. I think my shoulders will be alright"

Adora looks down at Catra's head, mildly horrified, running their fingers over the offended as gently as they can. It's kind of a lost battle, the beautiful dark locks are completely matted with mud, sweat and dirt, tangled along each other with tiny pieces of leaves and sticks hanging from where Catra had slept in the woods. Adora gulps, rubbing the base of his neck as he tries to keep ignoring the scissors mere centimeters from his hand. "Darling, I'm sure we can wash it. Glimmer must have like a thousand things here for that-"

"Yeah I'm sure," Catra sighs, nibbling at her lip with her fang nervously. She takes Adora's hand on hers, lacing their fingers together tightly. "Don't get me wrong, Adora, I love my hair, I'm not dumb. There is a reason I've never cut it before. But I'm sure it's a lost cause and I'm right pretty much all the time. It gets in my way of fighting and Finn likes to chew into it a little bit too much." Adora chuckles, the giggle escaping their lips shaky. Catra joins her, breathy laughter making her shoulders shake. She drops her weight resting her back on Adora's front fully, flopping against them like a feather. "I want to try it out. And I would like for you to do it"

"You are trusting *me?* With scissors?," jokes lightly Adora, trying to lighten the mood and his own spiked nerves. Catra pokes him on the side with her elbow, bumping the back of her head against his collarbones.

"I wouldn't trust anyone else with this clotpole. Do your best"

Adora laughs, halfway mocking Catra's cheeky comment, halfway having a breakdown. Finn is deeply asleep, their breath deep and slow as they swim in the sea of their starry dreams. Adora runs his fingers over Catra's hair, placing the open scissors just below Catra's shoulders, fingers trembling just a little.

This is important for Catra. Some kind of liberation. From the time past, from the ghosts, from the nightmares, from the nights on her own and the days waiting and enduring. And she has asked Adora to do it, placing her trust on them. Adora knows this isn't only about the hair. This is about trust, to each other.

Adora takes a deep breath, holds it on their lungs until it hurts and then gives a wide *chunk* . Long, heavy but dirty strands fall over the pink blankets, curling like tree roots and laying there, unmoving. Adora gulps, inhaling, and closes the scissors again. One, two, three, until the roots grow and grow and the back of Catra's head is free. The shoulder length locks of hair curl softly over the skin in Catra's shoulders and neck, caressing her pulse point and the dimples of her collarbones, surrounding Catra's face like a halo. Catra sighs when the last strand falls off, running her fingers through the newly short locks. It's still messy and sweaty but it's lighter. She likes it.

Adora presses a kiss on her temple, brushing her bangs off her face to pepper her forehead with ghost kisses. "You are beautiful," they say, honestly, lovingly.

Adora let's the scissors safely on the side of the bed and returns to Catra's side, enveloping her in the warmth of their arms once again. They remain there, in comfortable silence for a long while, only the sound of their breathing and the soft purr of their newborn sleeping accompanying them.

The lock on the door shakes for a few seconds and that is all the warning they get before the heavy door bursts open and in appear Bow and Glimmer, both of them messy and with heavy bags under their eyes, frantic and hopeful faces as they search in the dim light of the chamber until they spot the little family on the bed, looking back at them with shock.

Bow starts crying, almost immediately, hiding his face in his hands. Glimmer's eyes are soft and full of wonder, and she opens her mouth in a half smile seemingly about to greet them

when she spots the dark chaos of Catra's hair all over the bed and the offended short strands sticking in odd directions over her friend's shoulders. Her lilac eyes travel to Adora and then far over their head, onto the side of the bed where scissors rest. Glimmer opens her mouth again and this time it's not a greeting that comes out.

"Adora! What in the seven hells?!"

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As it turns out, the whole Round Table is on Brightmoon. In fact, they were just finishing a meeting about future resources, among the chaos of Camelot's evacuation, when a soldier had burst into the war room and given word of Catra's, Finn's *and* Adora's return.

So now, a new meeting is happening, even more rushed than before, to welcome the Pendragon family back. Catra and Adora are walking through the corridors, Adora carrying Finn on her arms, playing with the tip of their ears as their baby is back awake, purring and chirping happily at their mother and playing with a long strand that has escaped their golden ponytail. Catra is hanging from Adora's arm, her hands around their bicep, nose pointing to the sky and ears perked up, a tiny and proud but also tired smile on her lips as the people around them whisper and chatter marveled among themselves. Bow is by Catra's side, his hand between her shoulder blades, not in a hovering but more like a comforting way as he guides them gently around the twists and turns of the beautiful palace. Glimmer is on Adora's other side, so excited on her feet that her wings flip and her feet hover a few inches over the ground, floating over the floors without even notice it. She is speaking at full speed, from teasing but compliment Catra's newly short hair to making funny faces to her nibbling to searching Adora's face with some kind of soft and completely nostalgic and overjoyed expression. There is something heavy hanging from her eyes, and from Bow's too, something Adora's has seen in Catra's eyes too and that speaks of months of war and lose and sadness. And yet here they are, all together again. All of them and little one more.

The war room is boiling with life when they come in. A mouthful of smelly flowers crash against Adora's face when Perfuma surges to her feet and slams herself on Adora's side, careful of not jolting Finn with the abrupt hug. She is saying something, something loud and happy and much like babbling that Adoras can't even begin to make sense of when another pair of strong arms wrap around their middle and lift them up. Adora yelps, holding Finn against their neck for dear life as Scorpia rocks them from side to side, big drops of tears dripping from her watery eyes. She places Adora and Finn safely and softly back to the ground just to turn around and drown Catra into an equally emotional and big hug. After them, it's one after the other. Frosta with her young adult face and Mermista, with her deep blue hair loose and adorned with gold and her indifferent posture but her kind and relieved eyes. Adora doesn't miss the way she and Catra share an quiet, understanding smile. Entrapta is there too, fumbling with some trinket that looks mildly too flamable, and they raise their head to wave their hand to Adora before returning with newfound excitement to it. It goes like this until the crowd finally parts and Queen Angela and King Micah step into the warm space, welcoming the royal family with open arms.

"Adora, you can't begin to understand how glad we are to have you back," says Angela, giving him a soft hug. King Micah gives Catra an equal gentle embrace, letting his hand rest over Adora's shoulder when he turns toward him.

"We feared the worst for so long. Well, all of us, except Catra. She never lost hope to find you again," Micah gives Catra a proudly fathery look that makes her blush, her ears flicking and giving away her true feelings. Adora looks at Catra too, just as tender and soft and Catra only rolls her eyes avoiding the matter by smacking Adora's back with her tail.

"Thank you, everybody. Truly," says Adora, cradling Finn's head with his hand, smiling brightly at everyone in the room and getting a smile right back. They walk towards the huge table, looking over the maps and notes as the chattering picks up again. There are a lot of frantic scribbles, blueprints and other documents all over it. Adora hums, drumming their fingers over the wood in a known grounding motion. It's enough to call everyone's attention, gravitating back around the table with wondering gazes.

"Catra told me about the plan you made before Halfmoon's fall and my- dissapearing," says Adora, looking back at Angela and Micah with rised eyebrows. The Regents hesitate, looking at each other with silent gazes before turning their attentions back to them.

"Wouldn't you- prefer to rest first?" asks Micah, carefully.

"You've been walking for a long time, you must be completely exhausted," adds Angela, holding her hands against her chest. Catra comes to stand next to Adora, resting her hand over the small of his waist. Adora turns to her, handing her Finn with the utmost care so they can press a kiss to the side of her face.

"We are. But we are also Kings and this comes first too" Catra adds, nodding towards the papers in the table. "Talk us through it"

Angela locks eyes with Glimmer, still unsure, but her daughter gives her an approving nod with an encouraging smile. Micah nods back and her flicks towards the table with his wrist. Dozen of purple arcane circles appear over the table, floating over the papers and forming physical small maps there. It's a map of the Valley of the Sand, the huge fields that make as an entrance to the Scorpion Kingdom and that once were a huge forest, before the Horde's invasion. Small dots signal the Horde soldiers camps a bigger one marking the place where Emperor Prime had made of his castle. A single blue dot floats over the far end of the valley, a place if ruins where the old capital of the kingdom used to be. Micah points at that place and the map grows in size, showing the sketched imagery of a houses in ruins and abandonded streets.

"The old palace used to be here and the rest of the capital. Emperor Prime destroyed it and buried it all when he invaded them, but the primary structures remain still," he tilts his head a little, salt and pepper long hair moving softly when he points to the place Scorpia is standing in, on the far end of the table. "Princess Scorpia was able to give us vital information of this particular place"

The entire Round Table's eyes turn to Scorpia who flush deeply under the attention. Catra looks at her too, sending her an encouraging smile and a nod, her short softly curly hair

jumping over her shoulders. Scorpia breathes deeply, approaching the table until she can pinpoint the places by herself.

"The main market and the capital's village was right there and the oficial castle was all the way where Emperor Prime established his castle," she starts, a bit shaky. She throws her shoulders back and keeps going. "But the fact is that the real Throne Room was never in the castle it was below."Scorpia drags her fingers over the map, down the streets and into the kingdom's library. "My great grandfather built the King's and Queen's Chamber here, subterranean to the capital. There is a whole system of corridors that run in the ground below all this place. It was a way for the Royal Family to move around the Kingdom quickly and easy and also a way to get out of the kingdom if needed. Through those corridors it was that I- when Emperor Prime attacked-", Scorpia grimaces, held back by her memories. Perfuma places her hand over her back and collarbone, grounding her for a few seconds. "My mothers and I separated in the run but I used to play there all the time. There is one exit of the corridors that leads to the oasis in the Crimson Waste' Desert. I don't think Prime has ever even find those corridors. If we get to cross through the entrance in the Waste we could infiltrate inside of his lands without they even notice"

"The Throne Chamber is huge and the village wide enough to hide an entire army without the Horde taking notice. It's a place Prime didn't even thought worthy of giving a second look and for that it is the weak point inside his kingdom," finishes Angella, resting her hands over her hips. Adora is nodding, frown forming and calculating gaze as their brain makes the calculations.

"Thank you, Scorpia. I know this must be hard for you," answers Adora, sending Scorpia a grateful smile. Then they turn back to the map and up to Angella, voice firm and sure.

"What do you want me to do?"

*We need you to heal the land, Adora" Angella points at the empty valley, only dirt and void in there where before there was life and green. "The Black Garnet Shadow Weaver is using to harvest Etheria's magic it's also poisoning the land. By taking Etheria's people's soul she also steals Etheria's core magic. This is very dark magic and it's going to slowly kill our home until there is nothing else to take from it."

"We think that, if we manage to destroy the Garnet we could be able to free the souls trapped in there and magic would come back to the places it was stolen from," Micah adds, tapping over the map and smiling at Adora. "That's where you come into Adora. You could heal Etheria, with your power you could return the magic stolen to our world and heal what has been broken".

"You've been a healer for many years," Bow adds, squeezing Adora's shoulder with an encouraging smile. There is something raw and honest there too and Adora can't look away. "When we thought we had lost you, it wasn't the plan that we were mourning. It was you. You are not a tool for a plan Adora, you are our friend, our King. All of us could try, and we would, but there is nobody else we could trust with the future of our land than you."

Adora chews on their lips, anxiety starting to bloom on their chest. The kings and queens around the table distract their attention for a little, approaching the table to inspect the

entrance in the map and letting Adora drown in their thoughts. Catra feels them, of course she does, because she rests forehead over Adora's neck and her free hand over Adora's forearm, squeezing their skin softly as she nudges them with her hip.

"Catra-"

"It's so much magic," says Catra, very softly, only for Adora's ears. There is an edge of undeniable worry and tiresomeness in her voice, the way she is so exhausted and angry that everyone needs Adora to fight a war, but there is also that unbreakable trust Catra has on her "And it's scary and it's unfair. I fucking hate it. I fucking hate that it's a weight that is being placed over your shoulders again. But I'll be there with you, on every step, and I'll help you carry it all." Catra looks around them, on the people that stuck by their sides even when there wasn't a reason or a hope to keep fighting. "I think we all will. You are not doing this alone, not again. Not anymore".

Adora exhales, watery eyes as they nod. Finn is nibbling on Catras ears, their little tail content as they ignore the dangers of the world around them. They only know about love. It brings Adora the sudden memory of someone, a girl who used to nibble on her ear too and that is now standing besides her, that is now the mother of their child and the king of their kingdom and the world is fucked up and still, somehow, it all comes back to this. Them.

"As long as we are together," says Adora and it's full of meaning. Catra smiles, ignoring the way tiny sprouts of life bloom over the wood of the table. Her smile turns into a smirk when she says.

"You are not going anywhere without me anymore, clotpole"

Adora chuckles, running their fingers through Catra's hair to guide her head into a quick but meaningful kiss. Then she turns to the table again, studying the maps. Catra can see in her eyes. The way she is already planning and strategizing inside her mind, placing knights here and there, studying the best way to take the only chance they have and finish with the Horde once and for all. It's the last piece remaining, that tells her that Adora is actually back for good. That she is herself and free. That they have hope.

Adora shakes her shoulders and straightens her back, long and golden ponytail shimmering under the pink light of the lamps. "Very well. Let's do it," she says, calling for everyone's attention back to very, regal and tired and *alive* next to the table. Adora smirks, tapping at the light that marks Prime's castle with the pad of her finger with some kind of deep satisfaction. "He will never see us come."

There it is. That thing that is different in Adora. No, not different. Anew, stronger, brighter. A flame that before was a spark and now is an incendio. Adora has always been confident and kind but this, this is Adora full in her splendor. She is handsome and strong and smart and she knows she is. She could lift a caravan over her head and raise the ocean with a look from her eyes and break the earth with her own hands and she knows she can. Whatever barrier or wall Adora had built around themself over the years was gone and now there was only Adora, not only a king but a powerfully being driven by love, golden and bright, towering above them all like the very sun.

The muscles in Adora's arms pop when she crosses her arms above her chest, her waist narrow accentuated by the soft and clean grey shirt Brightmoon had given them when they arrived. It has a short sleeve and a "v" cut with leather ribbons Adora barely bothered to lace together. The cut allows all their scars to show, glistening under the pink and lilac lights of the crystal lamps and the chandelier in the war room. There is a huge white one that crosses their deltoid, from the start of the shoulder down to the crook of their elbow. It was done in a fight years before Catra arrived, and even though it has already healed it still looks painful. Several others are scattered all over their hands and arms, pink and white and reddish. There are a few that are foreign to Catra and she supposes they got them during the fight for Halfmoon. It's the only logical explanation to those because Catra knows the map of Adora's scars like her own hands and she knows these ones weren't there before. One over their fingers in the right hand from the tip of the thumb all over the joints of the rest of the fingers as if the blade of a sword had caught the skin there and miraculously not chopping something away. There are the ones on their face, Thaymor's over the bridge of their nose, ragged lines against their angular jaw, their eyebrow sliced in half by one that barely missed the start of their eyelid. Adora is covered in scars and Catra loves every single one of them.

"How can you love them?" had asked Adora once, many moons ago. They were naked and sweaty in each other's arms, basking in the warmth that expelled their bodies, curling around the other. The words had slipped out of Catra's mouth minutes ago, when she was lost in heat and steam and firecrackers exploding on her body. *I love them* , she had panted, brushing her fingers over the deeps and creases of the scars scattered over Adora's body. Another one of her infinite silent I love you's.

"What do you mean?" asked Catra in a thread of a voice, spots of red blooming in her cheeks. Adora shrugged, not letting go from their grip over her waist. Catra couldn't see their face but she could feel the way they had hidden in the crook of her neck, the tip of their ears pink in embarrassment.

"They are ugly" muttered Adora, not raising their head. Catra had held her breath, biting the protest away. It was hard for Adora to accept compliments, it would be a lost battle to try and convince them otherwise. Catra wriggled in her place, her hand trailing over the strands of blonde hair draped over her chest, chasing the damp knots away until it felt like silk on her fingers.

"I have plenty of scars too, Adora. And many of them can't even be seen but they are there and they are terrible", she said in a whisper, like sharing a secret. Adora exhaled, nodding softly over her skin.

"I know"

"And yet you love them"

"Of course I do"

"Why?". Catra could feel Adora frown in her neck and the gesture brought a small, fond smile to her lips.

"Because they are a part of you", answered Adora immediately as if it was the most obvious thing in the world. Catra's smile widened, victorious, proud.

"Exactly"

Now, from this angle, Catra can see the way her shoulder blades shift, her strong back straight as she looks up at the glittering symbols above the maps. Her entire presence screams leadership but not in an overwhelming way. Is a kind of command that is trustworthy and kind all at the same time. A kind of command that everyone wants to follow.

It 's hot.

Warmth creeps up Catra's cheeks, coloring bright red. She coughs, looking everywhere but at Adora's figure and the way their smile is kind and confident and beautiful. She can feel their burning silver gaze on the side of her face, Adora's attention immediately driven over Catra's small gasp. Adora's eyes flash with quick concern, traveling from Catra's face to Finn still nestled in her arms. They are awake, chewing a strand of Catra's hair between their gums. They will be devious once their milk teeth and tiny fangs start to actually grow.

Once Adora is sure Finn is alright they raise back their eyes, silver locked in turquoise and amber. Whatever Adora sees in them, it surprises them greatly because Adora lifts an eyebrow and a cocky, self satisfied smile starts to spread in their lips. The heat just spreads over Catra's face, down her neck and shoulders and she is grateful that Finn's blanket is drapped over her because otherwise the way she has gone flushed and blushing in front of the entire Etheria's Court would be extremely mortifying. Adora hums, searching for Catra's eyes and when they meet again Catra realizes the blue in their eyes is almost completely consumed by black, pupils blown up like a solar eclipse.

They are mothers and they are kings, yes. But they are also young and in love and they have missed each other deeply.

Glimmer crashes against Adora's side with full force, expelling the air on their lungs in one long blow, her lilac eyes dripping with excited tears down her cheeks, leaving sparkling paths of glitter behind. "I missed you and your brain and your way to be so disgustingly in love with your wife! It's so freaking awkward! Never do that again, do you hear me? Or this time it will be me the one that kicks your ass back to life. "

Adora cracks into a loud laugh, snorting endearingly with surprise as she wraps her arms around Glimmer's shoulder and lifts her partially from the ground, Glimmer's big wings partially reaching Adora's huge height. The people around the table start laughing too, exhausted relief washing over them as they scramble around the room, palming each other in the back, offering each other food and water, cracking a joke or two between friends. Bow hugs Adora from the back, giggling as Angella and Micah rest their heads together, the remaining members of the Round Table getting closer to Catra to catch a glimpse of the wiggling kitten in her arms, purring loudly. Finn chirps, nuzzling in the hollow of Catra’s chest, looking with wide silver eyes at the world around them.

Adora looks at it all like a dream, pieces of wishes and happiness scattered, a bit rough and broken in the edges but ever present. Catra carries a newborn Finn in her arms and this time

Adora knows they are not going to suddenly wake up into cold water. This time they are here.

“Hope”, she says, outloud, to the air. "This is how we are going to win this war. With hope".

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"We can watch over Finn for a bit. You two go have a bath, you need it," Glimmer wraps her arms around Finn, rocking them up and down as she learned to do when they were barely days old. The baby hiccups and starts slipping into a peaceful sleep, nuzzling on their aunt's arm and still drowsy after eating.

Adora's hands hover over Finn's form, hesitating on letting them go for over a second. Catra chuckles, nudging Adora with her hip, but she also has a kind of nervous frown and her hands open and close with the quiet need of snatching her baby back, curling around them and never letting go.

Glimmer notices, of course she does. She passes Finn into Bow's ready hands, the Brightmoon's king already cooing and making soft and funny faces at the baby, his eyes melting and watery as every time he sees them. Glimmer rests her hands over Catra's and Adora's shoulder, watching them firmly but gently.

"You two have spent months away from each other. You need a few moments alone. And nothing is going to happen to Finn here," she looks towards the table, where Melog had made an appearance to curl over some documents and follow Finn's movements with their eyes, not even moving. "Melog will be here too. Goddess knows no one is going to try anything funny with a dragon by their side."

Melog's ears perk at their mention and a puff of blue smoke leaves their small cat mouth, proudly and sneaky. Glimmer hums at them, approvingly and then nods towards Adora and Catra, a cheeky smile spreading on her lips as she rests her hands on the sides of her hips.

"Go on," she says, wiggling her eyebrows. "If the tension between you two keeps going I think I might just barf. Go"

Catra and Adora walk through the curved corridors of Brightmoon hand in hand, in silence. It's beautiful, tall and bright and calm but also so different from Camelot and Halfmoon. The memory of their homes burns bright under eyelids, warm but heavy and their hold on each other tightness just a little.

Their new chamber in Brightmoon feels strangely empty without Finn there. They hesitate for a moment at the entrance, looking at the spacious place before walking in with muted steps, locking the door behind them. The room is neatly made, their old clothes thrown without care in one of the far ends of the room, all except Adora's wedding coat that Catra brought with her and that is carefully folded over the wooden chair of the vanity. It has fire holes in the sleeves and the golden embroidery is black with coal, probably beyond salvation but Catra refuses to throw it away.

On the side of the room, close to the open window, there is a waterfall, not too big but wide enough to create a calming water sound, crashing over the pool below with white sparkles. Catra approaches the waterfall, dripping the tip of her finger in the running water to test the temperature. It's mildly warm but not enough to dip inside of it and take a bath. Catra grimaces, confused and trunks around to find Adora fumbling with a smaller door on the wall.

"This can't be the bath, can it?"

Adora shakes her head and finally wins with the lock, opening the heavy door and peaky inside.

"Wow," says Adora, triunfally and surprised. pointing inside the room. "Found it"

Catra walks over there too, peeking inside with raised eyebrows. Turns out, there is a second waterfall inside of the bathroom, occupying almost the entire right side of the room and running in a never ending stream and raising thick clouds of steam off the ground. The deliciously warm water falls inside a beautiful pool, long enough to swim inside of it but deep enough so the water only licks up to Catra's calves. The pool is blue, smooth lake rocks stuck in the bottom and making it look like a resplendent sea under the light of the lamps, two steps on one side to guide them down.

Catra stares down at the bath, halfway in awe halfway rolling her eyes for the absurd glimmer of it all. She feels the warmth of Adora's body as she approaches her from behind and shivers when her calloused fingers brush against the short strands of her hair, down her shoulders, hooking her thumbs around the ribbons of the shirt and pulling them off and then down. Adora presses a kiss on the side of her temple, helping Catra out of her clothes very gently and slowly. The air is warm with the steam of the water so when the last cloth falls to the tilted ground Catra is not cold at all.

She turns in Adora's arms, helping her out of her own clothes and rising to her tippy toes to press a kiss on their scarred eyebrow and then pull from their earlobe playfully, giggling when Adora's face goes from the outermost adoration into plain shock. Adora's lips turn from perfect "o" to a sneaky smile and Catra squeals in surprise when Adora throws her carefully but unceremoniously over her shoulder, walking towards the waterfall bath with wide and goofy steps, flexing her arms out of sole show and making her wife laugh even louder, squeaky laughs echoing in the pearl like walls and the waves of the water in the pool.

The splash of water doesn't come as a surprise but the perfect warmth of it does. Adora places Catra back on her feet softly, helping her submerge inside the water slowly, allowing the numb cold skin of her limbs to starts to get used to the feeling of the perfumed water and the steam, the waterfall falling like rain over their backs, their shoulders and necks, drenching their hairs and sticking them over their faces and backs as silk.

Catra brushes Adora's heavily damp bangs out of their face, massaging tight circles over their scalps and washing all the dirt and sweat away, undoing harsh knots, caressing their strong neck and the dip of their eyebrows. She rubs clean soap over their shoulders and chest, down the swell of Adora's breasts and over their ribs, feeling the strength of their muscles under her fingers, the way their back towers over her protective but kind, soft but wide, strong enough

to hold the world over it. Catra's cheeks flush red, as if she hadn't done and seen this a hundred times before. It still makes her pleasantly nervous, being so openly in Adora's presence and having Adora so vulnerable and open in her own arms. She had missed them dearly.

And Catra is soft on Adora's arms. The curves on her body are some familiar and some new, but all of them dearly. The wide softness of her thighs, the stretch marks on the inside of her legs and the sides of her belly, gentle rolls and soft skin that makes her look beautiful and bright and resilient as the new mom she is now. Adora presses their face on the angle between her neck and shoulder, cleaning Catra's skin and soft peach-like fur there, leaving sloppy open mouthed kisses along the way. Adora travels down, brushing their thumbs over the creases of Catra's ribs and then down, over each depth and rise of the vertebrae of her spine. Catra sighs, running her fingers across Adora's hair and her spouse let's themself fall into the bath, dragging their palms over her sides and down her thighs, not raising their head from its place over her abdomen, their nose against her belly button and their lips above her skin.

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Catra chuckles nervously, cheeks bright red against the steam "What are you doing?"

Adora sinks to their knees, looking at Catra through their eyelashes, silver eyes bright under the warm water of the waterfall.

"Allow me"

Adora places a soft, loving kiss over Catra's abdomen, right below her sternum. They move slowly, down her side, across her belly button, over the curves of her hips. Catra smiles, a bit nervous, tangling one hand on Adora's golden locks.

"My body has changed", she whispers, brushing the wet strands out of Adora's eyes. She shifts in her feet, focusing her sight on her lover's face. She knows who she is and she knows her body will never be the same after Finn and she will never regret it, not even once. But still, she can't help the spark of anxiety that rises on her chest at the sight of Adora kneeling in front of her, hot and steamy, and even if she knows Adora loves her she also knows the body Adora now worships is not the same they knew before leaving.

Adora sighs, looking right past her, blowing warm air over Catra's skin with their strong hands gripping the sides of her thighs gently but firmly. Their thumbs rub tight circles over the stretch marks there, massaging the skin lovingly. They look up, resting their chin over Catra's belly, right above the curly hair that travels below. Their eyes are completely enamoured, full of desire and love, pale eyelashes like stars stuck inside their eyes.

"You are beautiful". Adora nuzzles over her skin, changing the position of their hands to brush their fingers over the fresh stretch marks around Catra's middle, marveling at the newfound weight her pregnancy brought with it. "You carried our baby here, how am I not going to think you are the most beautiful creature I've ever seen?"

Catra flushes, bright pink across her freckled cheeks. Adora smiles at her shyness, pressing tiny, butterfly-like kisses over her tummy and the mount of hair between her tights, traveling all the way down the inside of her legs, close, so close but not touching yet just letting her nose rest in warm and wet freckled skin. Adora looks at Catra from in between her eyelashes, gently, ignoring the drops of water falling from the waterfall gently over her face.

"Are you sure Melog is looking after Finn?," they say, blowing a breath of warm air over her center.

Catra flushes even further but nods, answering in a hoarse murmur. "Yeah"

"Alright", whispers Adora before sinking on Catra, their lips meeting another kind of lips, ripping a breathy moan from Catra's parted mouth.

Adora is gentle with her, sweet and loving, even when Catra grips their hair tighter and buckles her hips down frantically, gasps and whimpers filling the spacious bathroom, Adora is gentle. They are mindful of both her body and her pleasure, never losing sight of the fact that Catra has basically just become a mother and that her body needs the care and patience. Adora would never hurt her, ever.

Adora's tongue roams her sweetly, slowly, rubbing tight circles over her hooded pearl and then traveling down, down, down and then *in,* bringing goosebumps down Catra's spine and the ends of her tail, ears twitching frantically on her head. The water of the waterfall is warm as it falls over her face and hair, mouth slightly open, watching the steam rise towards the crystal ceilings with half opened eyes. Her breath hitches in her throat when Adora curves her damp tongue inside her, boiling hot against the lava in her bones, and she absently worries about Adora's knees over the hard marble floor before Adora does a swirl and her mind goes pleasantly numb.

They are silent, both of them, Catra's palm tight over her mouth, Adora's lips kissing her intimately again and again. Adora's hands grip firmly the sides of her hips, strong fingers digging in her skin with such passionate force Catra knows they will leave purple marks for the morning and the thought makes her gasp softly. Adora's hand travels down, seizing one of her ankles softly but firmly and pulling it up until Catra's leg is resting over their shoulder, making her open more for them with the movement. Catra feels the change immediately, stronger, deeper, and she bites her lip hard as she starts to feel fireworks lighting up inside her chest and belly, her heartbeat speeding up so much she is sure Adora can hear it through her skin. She can feel the familiar pull and tug inside herself, something that has been foreign to her since Adora left and that now crashes against her with all the force of time missing. Adora is working relentlessly, never once waving, mind and body completely entranced with Catra's. And when she looks down she can see the proof of Adora's own pleasure, the way that giving to Catra like they are doing right now is doing it for them, not touching even necessary, and the realization that Catra can do this to them, *for* them is what makes her trip over the edge and fall freely.

The pull breaks and Catra shudders, feeling herself fall down deliciously in Adora's mouth and hands. She tries to keep her eyes open, locked in the way Adora's eyes are half opened and fixed in her face, their eyebrows curled in pleasure as they feel her break and remade in their mouth. But it has been too long and is so much and Catra ends up rolling her head back,

eyes shut closed tight as white spark go off inside her eyelids and body, strong and slow and undoing.

Adora helps her through it all because it will be damned the day Adora is not completely attuned with Catra's needs, bringing her to another bright peak before letting her fall down back into stability once more, shooting her pulsing skin with the flat of their tongue. Catra is boneless over them by the time she can breath again but her blood is still boiling hot, flooding her ears and head and every inch on her body and when Adora parts away from her, the slimmest cord of slick that still joins them makes her heart do a leap inside her chest and run and maybe she still has a lot inside her still and, if the dark that drowns the blue in her lover's eyes has anything to say about it, Adora does too.

Adora stands up, cupping Catra's cheeks with one hand, their fingers digging on her skin until she opens her mouth. Catra is breathing heavily, steam surrounding them from the warm waterfall and their own bodies pressed together tightly. Adora contemplates her for a few seconds, humming, before leaning forward. Their tongue shouts out, pink and wet, licking a straight line from the base of Catra's teeth, up her tongue and over the roof of her mouth, slick and hot.

Catra moans, gripping to Adora's forearms to avoid slipping on the floor, her knees buckling and shaking with shock and adrenaline. Adora has rarely ever been like this, they were always patient and soft and delicate with her, even in their most heated moments. And she is still right now, in the way they eye her to check her up, in the reassuring words on her ears, in the soft caress over her hips, smoothing down the sharp aftershocks with gentle, loving fingers. But there is also a fire inside of them, stronger than before, as if coming back had set aflame something deep inside Adora and now they are free, a golden dragon, awoken and breathing fire over the naked skin of Catra's collarbones.

It's enough proof. That Adora desires her. That Adora *wants* her.

Catra's knees give up but she remains up and straight, held in place by Adora's sure hands around her waist and back. They press each other together even closer, skin against skin and it is exhilarating. Adora's core slips against hers and she has to bite down on her tongue hard to keep at bay the loud whimper that tries to escape her lips. Adora's eyebrows knit together and she cups Catra's face with her hand, brushing softly their thumb over her lip until Catra let's go of it, the skin red and tender after biting down in it.

"Down hold back," whispers Adora. Her voice is raspy and heavy with heat, there is softness on it but also firm, their pretty eyes pleading and loving. " I've missed you so much, I want to hear you. I want you"

Catra blinks at her and then blinks again, face in awe. She wants to say something, throw back a snarky comment but her voice is tangled on her vocal cords and the only thing that comes out is a strangled whimper and a harsh take of breath. Adora smiles at her, gentle but also sneaky, and slips their leg between her damp thighs, pressing them even closer than before. The slip of Adora's core against hers sets Catra in fire once again, stealing a long sigh from her lips. Catra presses down, hard, chasing the silk feeling with everything she has. Adora presses the palms of their hands over her shoulder blades and the narrow of her waist, smoothing down her skin with soft caresses.

"Easy" whispers Adora against her shoulder, not an order but a gentle concern. "I don't want you to hurt yourself, either."

Catra grunts, her teeth grasping and biting just slightly and annoyed over the skin of Adora's neck. "I'm not crystal, Adora. I fought my way out of battle merely days ago"

"I know" agrees Adora, scattering tender kisses over her shoulders and the column of her neck. "But I don't want to push you too far. Your body needs to rest"

Catra groans unpleasantly, wriggling in Adora's hold to try and push down hard again. But Adora's hold is too strong and she doesn't really feel like fighting back right now, still boneless and warm. Adora can feel her frustration because they turn their head to look at her right in the eyes, silver boring inside gold and blue and when they speak is low and musky for Catra's ears.

"Listen, songbird, I would take you right now on these waterfall titles until you can't talk or breathe or stand" Catra's eyes widen at Adora's sudden intensity, her tail lashing back and forward over the waterfall floor, pupils blown fully. Adora smirks at her, hints of shyness and care still itched in their expression. They lean in just a little, pressing a fluttering kiss over the bridge of her nose. "But I'm not going hard in you right now. You just had a baby, Catra, our baby. And as much as I want to press you down and break you, we need to wait a little more, give your body time to rest."

Catra's ears twitch as she processes Adora's words, any sound hard to hear over the rush of her blood inside her ears. Then the words actually start to make sense and she looks at Adora with new eyes, breathing hard.

"You've been the one holding back all this time, haven't you", accuses Catra, narrowing her eyes. Adora smiles, a heavy look falling in an instant and replaced with a nervous, crooked grin.

"It's difficult to let go when I can bend the world in half"

"Oh, modest much, uh?" Catra nudges them with her hip, smiling devilishly under the spray of the waterfall. "What makes you think I couldn't?"

"Bend it or take it?"

"Bet" Adora laughs, hiding their face on her neck. Catra wriggles her eyes, laughter also born in her throat and lips and escapes her in a bubbly giggle, breaking just a little the silk lustful air inside the giant bathroom. Catra runs her fingers through the long strands of Adora's hair, rubbing the pads of her fingers on her nape.

*****

"I missed you, too" says Catra back, as if she hadn't said it with her eyes and her body the entire time since Adora came back. Adora embraces her tighter, letting her keep going but without letting go once. "I missed you every day, every hour, every second it felt as if I was burning from the inside out without you. Like my cells couldn't understand a life where you

weren't there and would freeze and die. And I knew I wasn't alone, that I had our friends and our kingdom but- but it was Finn, Finn was the only thing that kept me going and the knowledge, the hope, the madness of believing you were still out there, waiting" Catra strangles on her own breathe and she takes a second to exhale. Her eyelashes are damp and she doesn't know if it's the waterfall or her own tears, making tracks over her cheeks. Adora's fingers press strong against her skin, her breath against her neck. "You always said you would find your way back to me, no matter what. I held into that. No matter how it happened or who tried to use us or why, you chose me and I chose you. And I don't regret it, Adora. I don't regret *you* "

Adora is crying, open and strong against Catra's neck, and it's until then that Adora realizes how much he needed to hear those words, to hear them from Catra, that Adora wasn't a mistake or a burden. Is the last weight that lifts from Adora's shoulders, forever. Catra feels him cry and let's him, rocking his big, built body against hers from side to side gently, allowing the warm water to wash away the pain and the sadness, from both of them. She doesn't want it anymore. She has everything she loves and even if the journey to recover is long and hard, she knows Adora will be there for her and she for him.

It takes them a little. Adora helps Catra wash the newly short strands of her hair and Catra rinses the last bits of soap off his body. With each movement, their skins brush against each other, never letting their bodies stand too much or too long from each other. Catra sighs, resting her cheek over Adora's sun freckled shoulder, arms around each other.

"I know you don't want to be *hard* on me," starts Catra, pronouncing the words almost with a fond roll of eyes. Adora chuckles softly and nods. "But, I think we need each other right now"

Adora sighs, rubbing circles on the low of her back, right over the place where her tail starts sending shots of white pleasure down her legs, pooling in the bottom of her belly. Adora must sense the way her body shifts and their own body reacts in answer because they nod and press one more kiss on her cheek before walking them together outside of the waterfall. They help each other dry off with the clean, fluffy towels of Brightmoon's castle, letting their hairs hang free and still damp over their shoulder blades.

They don't bother in dressing up, Adora slips her hands below Catra's thighs and pulls upwards, letting her wife tangle over her chest and waist safely. Adora carries Catra outside the bathroom and back into the lilac room. The light of the early night fills the place with soft pinkish light, catching in the pink crystal lamps in the roof and casting beautiful forms against the floor. The bedroom is empty and quiet, in calm.

Adora trips a little when they get near the huge bed and Catra laughs in the crook of their neck, her arms crossed across their nape and hair. Adora huffs a giggle too, resting Catra over the plush mattress gently, tickling Catra's sides and gaining even more and louder snorts of laughter before leaning back to look at her fully in the face. Catra stretches over the feather soft bed, arching her back under her spouse's hands as she looks up at them. Adoras cheeks are flushed, pink against the tan of their skin making the freckles under their eyes pop out. The red in their ears is so deep Catra's heart skips a beat in fondness, her hand caressing the side of their jaw with tender fingers.

"Hey"

"Hey," whispers back Adora, smiling adoringly. Adora leans over her, her damp hair making a curtain of gold, hiding their faces from the rest of the world.

They are beautiful. Catra blinks away strained tears, curling a hand over her own heart, feeling it beat at the rhythm of Adora's own.

She is beautiful. Adora brushes her bangs out of her lovely face and leans to press a kiss on the side of her temple, breathing in the warmth and the smell of her skin.

Catra presses her finger on the tip of Adora's nose, curling her other hand over Adora's cheek, arching until their chests press flush together. Her hand lowers down, and down and down again, until her warm palm cups Adora's warmth, guiding them to her with gentle care.
"Don't be afraid, Adora"

Adora smiles, tiny, following Catra as they always do. "How could I?" they say, resting their lips against hers. "You are here with me".

❀

They take a second bath, mostly just standing below the waterfall, embracing each other as the warm water washes away their sweat. They slip into even more comfortable clothes and Adora changes the damped sheets of the bed for a new pair of clean ones. Catra curls below the puffy blankets per Adora's insistence, drifting into a peaceful nap while Adora tippy toes outside of the chamber to find Finn and Melog.

She has taken the small ragdoll with her, pulling from the almost yellow and grey strands of wool that make up its hair and smiling. She may not have Catra's wonderful sense of smell but she can grasp the sparks of roses and lavender and a little bit of the oranges in there. And something else, something that is definitely Finn, like warmth and milk and clean soup.

There is a sprint in Adora's step as he walks through the corridors peeking inside the huge chambers as he looks for their child. The world has gone to hell and yet Adora can't help the flutter that lives inside his heart. He doesn't want it to stop, Adora wants to live inside of it forever.

The echo of voices guide him to where he should go, walking inside the chamber that leads to the kingdom's gardens. The doors are closed, encapsulating the room in warmth but letting the shadows of the trees and fountains show through the paper of the windows. Glimmer and Bow are sitting in matching loveseats beside a chimney, shoes off, with their feet tucked below the pillows of the seats. Melog is napping deeply right besides the magic fire, also exhausted after such a long journey. Glimmer is hovering slightly over Bow, who holds Finn against his lap as both of them coo at the sleepy baby, attempting to shush them to sleep.

Glimmer hears Adora come because she lifts her head and looks at her, clear love drawn over her entire face. "Hello you, how are you feeling?"

Adora tip toes towards their friends, peeking at their baby with tender eyes and smiling widely. "My baby, hello my baby. Mamma is back Finnie."

The little kitten blinks at her and then starts purring, loudly, lifting their tiny chubby arms and opening and closing their even smaller fists in her direction, wordlessly asking to be held. Asks obeys, taking Finn carefully from Bow's lap and carrying them over her chest, rubbing soothing circles on their back and humming softly at them when they start chirping. Adora turns to look at her two friends, eyes watering with treacherous but happy tears.

"Better. Both of us," she says, answering Glimmer's question. "Thank you for looking after Finn, guys, really"

"Of course, they are my nibbling after all," assures Glimmer, crossing her arms over her chest in a proud manner. Then she relaxes again, looking at both baby and mother with sparkled teary eyes. "I'm so glad that you are here Adora, so, so glad. You have no idea just how much we have missed you".

"I don't think you realize just how important you are to us," adds Bow from his position, "Not because you are a king or because you rule Camelot, but because you are *Adora* and nothing is ever the same without you".

Adora cries, again, just nodding when the words fail them to work. Bow stands and Glimmer does too, both of them surrounding Adora and the baby with their arms. It almost feels like a late first time, that day of spring when Finn was born, Glimmer and Bow hugging a new mother at the change of the night, a new mother that is their friend and their sibling and their family. It feels gentle and drenched in love and they will remember it forever.

When Adora walks back into their chamber the night moon is higher in the sky, the constellations making everything sparkle in twinkling white light. Adora walks towards the bed, finding Catra already awake with the covers drawn back for Adora to climb right into them.

They fumble a little bit but finally Adora rests their back over the soft surface of the mattress, resting Finn's tiny and sleepy body over their chest, feeling their deep breathing against their neck and the tickle of their tiny ears under their chin.

Catra snuggles close to them, her cheek on Adora's shoulder, watching her baby sleeping over the person she loves the most in well deserved peace.

"Tell me about it," Adora says, in a whisper, looking into Catra's eyes. Finnie breathes slowly and warm over her chest, their little cheek pressed against the fabric of Adora's shirt, little hands curled over the ruffles of the collar. "Tell me how it was. Tell me everything"

Catra hums, looking at Adora with hooded eyes, the golden and turquoise bright under the stars. "They were very calm most of the time" she whispers back, caressing the outside of Finn's ears with her finger. "But- Finn would kick like crazy every time someone mentioned you. No matter if it was your name, your smell, or just a passing reference, they would always kick happily at me."

Catra tells Adora about it, about the months apart and Finn growing inside of her, until the moon is high in the night sky and the peaceful sounds of the woods are the only music accompanying them, the festivities of the people after finding out about Adora's return echoing in the air. She talks and talks and keeps talking about it until her eyelids are heavy and her chest tired and Finn is deeply asleep between them.

"It was good. I was at peace" murmurs Catra, eyes half closed. She chuckles at the end, rolling her eyes fondly at the memory. "My lower back hurted a fucking lot on the last months, though"

Adora is quiet, absorbing every word, every sentence and murmur, trying to fuse themself with the memories Catra pours out, trying to somehow be there. Their eyebrows are slightly crossed, their chin tight and tense. Catra presses her lips in a line, tapping the skin of their jaw to try and relax them out.

"When they were born- I wasn't scared. And- and It was beautiful Adora, it was so beautiful. You were there with us every second, you were in Finnie's skin. You made us a home and we were safe on it"

Adora gulps, their neck relaxing just a little, just enough. They can feel Finn breathing against her skin and when they turn their head they see Catra's bright and beautiful eyes looking at them with everything she has to give.

"You used to look at me like this too, when we were kids," says Adora out of nowhere. Catra's eyes widen in surprise and her cheeks color pink again, ears flattening against the sides of her head.

"Look at you like what?"

"Like you love me," Adora shrugs, as if it was the one single more important and groundbreaking thing in her entire life, as if Catra loving her didn't mark her beginning and her end and the core of her universe.

Catra softness, somehow even more, and she pokes Adora's forehead with her index. "Of course I love you, dummy"

Adora returns her gaze, enamoured and bright and lovely. Adora wants to give her everything, the sun and the stars. She wants to give her back the ponds of Halfmoon, full of lilies and bright fishes where they used to dip their feet into. She wants to bring her home and give her back the place "Yeah, you do"

Catra hums but she can see the exhaustion taking its toll on Adora, the drop on her eyelids and the fact that she hasn't slept in days since she came back. Catra wriggles under the blankets, throwing her arm around Adora's chest and a little below Finnie's little feet, encapsulating her family between her arms. "You need to sleep, 'Dora"

"I don't want to," confesses Adora, into the air, a strangled whisper. "I never want to take my eyes away from either of you again. Ever"

Catra's eyes well with tears, dripping through her eyelashes and into Adora's skin. She lets them be.

"We will be here when you wake up, just as you will be here"

Adora chews on her own lip, unsure, but exhaustion it's already dragging her into a gentle sleep. She keeps her eyes open as long as she can, fighting it off until Catra is blurry and soft and beautiful in front of her and Finn is tiny and warm over her chest and somehow, just for today, everything is well in the world

"Sleep"

End of chapter XIV

Chapter End Notes

You have no idea how amazing is to write about the Pendragon family as it should be ;.; writing about Adora with their baby makes me all gooey inside

Can you believe? There is only two chapters + epilogue left! I'm so sad but also really happy of being able to tell his story.

I can't tell when will I post the next chapter but be completely sure I will! Check my IG or Twitter for any updates.

Thank you so much reading and for being here. I'm sorry I couldn't answer all the comments but I read every single one of them and, believe, they were my fuel and spirit to write this story to the very end.

See you soon! Be good!

Chapter 17: Tales of War

Chapter Summary

Queen C'yra exhales, resting her hand on the side of Swift Wind's strong neck, grounding herself. Her voice carries across the entire kingdom like the echo of the bell, sounding so far away but also so close, almost right neck to the Horde's neck and it's so much more scarier.

"There will be no negotiations today," she says. "You will die tonight, Emperor Prime."

Chapter Notes

Jesus take the wheel

Hello, hello! Welcome back after such a long time! Rake you so much for everyone that has keep supporting this little story of mine even with such long hiatus! You are all wonderful and the very reason I'm here, writing this.

This chapter is... A monster. 30k words of battle and it's probably the hardest chapter I've had to write ever. But here it is, finally, the war of all wars. The culmination of a fight. Neck and neck against the Horde.

WARNINGS: War, mentions of battle, mentions of mild injuries, mentions of lethal injuries, descriptions of wounds, descriptions of blood, minor characters death, curses, physiological abuse. Please proceed with care, this is a very heavy chapter, please put yourself and your health first.

DISCLAIMER: different to the show, all the members of the Horde are truly bad people that willingly word for the empire. Don't feel bad for them.

Hope I can get the next and last chapter in time for Camelot's Au first anniversary! How exciting! But right now, to businesses. I won't see you downstairs this time, I want to let you enjoy the chapter's end aftertaste (or not) >:3

You ready? 3. 2. 1. To war!

CHAPTER 15. Tales of War

You sat beside me, finding new

ways to look away,

You kissed me. It was lighter fuel.

It burnt the night away.

— Kae Tempest, *On Clapton Pond at dawn*

Music that inspired this chapter

x x x x x x x x

✾

The night before the war, Catra and Adora walk into Brightmoon's royal chambers with their baby in their arms.

The royal family is there, Glimmer, Bow, Angella, Micah, gathered together to enjoy one more calm tea time before everything goes down. Many moons have been put into the plan they have now and after a month of careful planning, they are finally ready. They will act now, before the Horde can even breathe a plan of their own. Before Emperor Prime can recover from the injuries queen Catra had inflicted on him, or worse than all, before Shadow Weaver can realize someone vital is back. After tomorrow, Etheria's fate will be decided and either they will come back victorious or they will not come back home at all. It's a frightening thought, too frightening, so they had all taken the time to be together with their families and hope for the best.

There is pleasant surprise on Bow's face when their friends enter the chamber until he catches the expression on their eyes and the world feels a little bit heavier on its edge.

"What is it?" he asks, calling the attention of everybody else in the room. Catra and Adora approach them, their steps heavy but determined. Adora has a deep frown on her face, drowning in thoughts with one hand placed in the small of her wife's back and Catra's lips are halfway bare with a snarl, holding Finn against her chest tight, so tight, but they are composed and firm when they speak to their friends.

"We have a favor to ask," says Adora, tightening their grip on Catra's lower back, their eyebrows knitted together so hard their head must be hurting badly. Catra takes a breath, like she has been repeating the words over and over in her head and still can't find it in herself to say them. She locks eyes with each one of them, serious, making sure they all are hearing her and hearing her well.

"We want you to take care of Finn, if we don't make it back"

✾

The army is silent as it advances through the subterranean corridors. Their chests and backs shine with the dim lights that enter from the rotten ceilings, making the metal clasps shine lightly against the natural darkness. They are all here. Halfmoon warriors with their golden bracelets on arms and tails and their faces painted in vivid war paint colors. Camelot knights and first ones, with their blood red capes and their silver chainmail and their golden dragons embroidered on their clothes. Brightmoon soldiers, with their high top helmets and their lilac armors and bright spears. Warriors from the Kingdom of Snows with swords made of ice and diamond blue shields. Fighters from Plumeria, with their fierce looking faces, usually so calm and kind, and their poisonous arrows and bows hanging from their backs. Here are them all, led by their kings and queens and regents, following their steps with proud faces and determined faces.

It's enough, their eyes say. *No more.*

Crown Princess of Halfmoon, Scorpia, leads them at the head, walking through the passages like a ghost from the past, muscle memory and faded memories guiding her in the remains of what once was her own home, stepping over the dust of her ancestors and the promises of her future. She wears no jewels but the heavy crown that circles her head, spikes of obsidian making it look like black thorns resting over the snow white of her hairs. Her armor is red and black, tight around her neck and armpits and legs and heart, her tail shining in dangerous sharp edges as it swings from side to side. Her usual kind and sweet face is contorted in fierce determination, concentrated in the step she gives silently as they advance right below the nose of their enemies.

The air is different down below, here where she used to spend so much of her time, hiding naughtily of her mothers and her grandfather. Back then, the air was fresher, easier, lighter. Now her nose tickles with the dust that has settled over the walls and the carpets and her eyes burn a little with the faint smell of something long ago burnt.

Queen Glimmer, Queen Perfuma, King Bow and all the rest of the Round Table march behind her, dressed in their own armors, looking like what they truly are, regents of a world that craves to be free. Queen Glimmer's wings are fully unfolded, the etherian opal of her feathers shimmering with the magic light that accompanies her. King Bow's beautiful golden artisanal arch hangs from his back, the reds and oranges of his own armor sparkling besides his wife.

There is someone else, leading at the head of the people, right next to Princess Scorpia. Her shoulder length dark hair is held in tight braids against her head, clasped with golden rings so the rebel waves stay in place. Unlike the heavy armors of Camelot's knights, her armor is light, made for speed and sharp movements. Clothed in purple and reddish tones, the same colors of the Halfmoon's flags that hang from side to side from some warriors spears, Queen *and* King C'yra wears a crowned helmet, made to protect the back of her head, her temples and forehead, cradling the sides of her face and making her look like a ferocious lioness marching towards battle. Her face is painted in war colors, golden over the dark of her skin, swirls of patterns that make crescent moons over her forehead and curved lines over her nose, down her chin and spotting the skin over her cheeks. Her vest is tight, several layers of thick and strong leather, a fine chainmail below it that protects her chest, arms and neck. Her leather pants are held up with a crossed belt, dark and thick gloves protecting her hands and

wrapping her wrists. Her feet aren't their usual bare, wrapped too in leather strips to protect her soles from slipping or unwanted cuts. She bears no weapons except for a single whip of exquisite taste hanging from the side of her hips and that is all. It's simple, really, there are no jeweled heavy crowns or heavy capes, yet she breathes a different air among them. Something that somehow it's *more*.

Riding over Swift Wind, King C'yra knocks her shoulder softly against Princess Scorpia's and smiles at her once before a trembling ray of light illuminates the side of her beautiful face when the long path of the treacherous corridors finally come to its end. Kong C'yra breathes on, hard, holding all the air inside her lungs until she turns her head slightly to the side, locking her eyes with King Bow's and Queen Glimmer's, who come further up to stand to her sides, squeezing her hands gently.

The red light of the destroyed Scorpion Kingdom washes over them as they walk out of the underground corridors and the war to end all wars begins.

❀

The words hang in the air, heavy, sticky, scared. A plea of two mothers that are about to throw themselves to the mouth of hell to fight for a free future, a better one. Glimmer trembles, she can't avoid it. Even Micah and Angella freeze in their places, looking at each other with worried faces and pale cheeks. Micah stands from his place, his hands laced in front of his chest, voice calm and careful as he approaches Camelot's regents.

"Adora, Catra, listen-"

"We are serious," interrupts Adora. His own shoulders are thrown back, spine straight. But his hands are shaking and he is biting down his lip with so much strength the skin is already red and angry. "If we don't make it, we want you to take Finn and run as far away on Etheria as you can," he looks at Micah with intent and then back at Bow and Glimmer, eyes pleading. "We know you will raise our baby with love, so please, stay alive and save them".

Glimmer gasps around a sob and stands up in a swirl of pinks, throws her arms around her friends, carefully nesting her face on Catra's neck, mindful of not crushing little Finn between them. Bow walks towards them too, surrounding the three of them with his large arms into a soft embrace. There are also tears running down his face but he is calmer. Adora raises his free arm, draping it around Bow's shoulders, lightly caressing the curve of Glimmer's back.

Suddenly Angella and Micah are there too. They won't be going to war as the rest of them. They will stay here, in the precarious safety of Brightmoon, waiting for the outcome whatever it may be with a baby in their arms and their heart in their throats.

Carta feels like she can barely talk, and when she does, it's around the tight knot on her throat and lips. She is angry and she is scared and she is tired but she is a mother too and she will never stop trying to create a better world for her child to live in.

"Just take care of them, please," she says, closing her eyes tightly. "Just make sure they know how much we love them."

✾

The war camps in Emperor Prime's stolen kingdom are divided. Which is both more practical but also infinitimal more stupid. A clear notice of a man's hubris who never thought someone would ever dare to attack him on his own territory.

The generals of the army are gathered in one of the makeshift white tents, gathered around heavy alcohol and self pleased laughter as they brag around about the terrible crimes they have committed to the people of Etheria. The destruction of homes, the burnt of their places, colonizers thinking they can just take and take and take anything they want and wish just because they placed their eyes over it. Awful creatures, sweaty and smelling of dry blood and iron and everything that is wrong and selfish and evil in the world. These are mercenaries, simply enjoying the freedom of destroying, soulless creatures that have exchanged their magic and the core of their very souls for money and pain. They are unaware that their emperor doesn't care for them and considers them disposable, or maybe they don't care, as long as they can get what they want for as long as they can.

Maybe, it is this clouded haze that makes them not notice the sound, or maybe it is that the arrow is so silent that over the sound of alcohol and the hum of Prime's machines around them they don't even hear it.

A golden arrow breaks in the air, sparkling just a little under the rays of the sun against the red of the sky and the heavy clouds of smoke in the air. It hovers, just a little, and then travels down on an almost elegant curve, crashing its sharp point against the ground just next to the generals. They look at it for half a second, eyebrows raised, drinks halfway, trying to piece it together. There is a soft sound coming from it, tick, tick, like a clock and by the time the generals understand what is happening at all the arrow goes off and half of the camp bursts into fire.

✾

When they come back to their chamber, much later in the night, they are swinging on their feet with exhaustion. They ignore the chamber's bed. It's huge and comfortable and beautiful but it still feels foreign to them, too soft, too bright. It doesn’t feel like home.

Instead, they walk towards the huge cushion on the side of the chamber, far from the window and the slightly chill air of the night. Glimmer appeared it there for Melog and it had quickly become a favorite sun spot for the little family to spend their evenings, when life was closing a bit too tight over their chests and they needed the grounding, the safety, the quiet.

It’s been hard, for everyone, and it has been especially hard for Adora. She has missed so much, things so important, the core of so many memories that it had taken her a while to feel like she was a part of this story, that she belonged, actually belonged with her own family. Even with Catra’s reassuring words, the feeling of sadness and guilt still found its way inside Adora’s chest, often at late hours of the night, when Adora tucked Finn inside their crib and spent many more minutes with her hand placed softly over their chest, feeling the rise and fall of their little body as they breathed peacefully on their sleep, as their little nose twitched

gently and their even smaller ears folded over themselves. It had become a grounding motion for Adora, something that made her feel anchored to reality, to the sense that she was actually here, watching her baby dream, and not stuck inside a void that had saved her but that had also kept her away from them.

It got better as the days passed by. Adora stopped waking up in the middle of the night, forehead sweaty and dreams of being underwater starting to wash away. Catra's nightmares started to die down, the images of the towers of Camelot burning in flames still printed behind her eyelids but less menacing now. The dreams of waking up in a bed alone, *alone,* going away as she would wake up every day and Adora would be there, never leaving her side, their chest below their cheek, Finn nestled on the crook of their neck fast asleep from where Adora picked them up at some time in the night so they could feel them sleeping close to them.

Finn had recognized Adora immediately, from the very first second when their baby eyes saw her and heard her for the first time since they were inside Catra and it had become really obvious to anyone how much they adored their mom. When they would cry, long and tired and loud it was only Adora who could calm them down, gently, just by nestling them between her arms. Finn would seek her warmth almost every time and they liked to sleep deeply on their chest after Catra had nursed them. It had filled Catra with the utmost relief and happiness and, little by little, it had helped Adora to feel more like herself, more not only like Camelot's king but also Catra's spouse and love and Finn's mother.

It was the reason it made everything so much harder right. They had barely start feeling like they had their family back and now they had to be separated again, Finn away and them to the mouth of the very hell.

It's an understatement that, when Adora offered, very tiny and swiftly, to Catra to stay with Finn and let them go on their own, she had quieted down almost immediately, silenced by Catra's sharp, angry gaze. They were going to do this together or they wouldn't do it at all.

By the time they come back to the chamber, Melog is already curled over the huge pillow on their panther form, not sleeping but sensing that their family would need the comfort when they came back. Adora guides Catra softly over there, letting themself fall carefully over the free side, back resting on Melog before gently cooing Catra inside the space of their arms. Carta sits in the cushion too, careful of not moving Finn too much, throwing her legs over Adora's lap and curling over her chest.

Finn moves just a little, starting to knead very slowly and softly the side of Catra's breast, still mostly asleep. Catra chuckles, letting the sleeve of her clothes fall down her shoulder, guiding Finn's small head towards her, coaxing them to eat with gentle chirps that Adora has memorized in the very cores of their mind.

Adora gathers her family on her arms, pressing tiny loving kisses over Catra's cheeks and forehead and then over Finnie's nose, caressing the sides of their baby cheeks with her hand, softly brushing away stray drops of milk. Her heart jumps and then constricts almost painfully when Finnie's little fingers, still mostly asleep as they eat, come up and curl around Adora's pinky, holding her close to them. They are a little bit past four months now, they have started to babble more and they will start teething in just a few more months and they are the

most beautiful thing Adora has ever seen. Carta rests her temple on Adora's cheek, looking at her spouse and her baby holding each other.

"We are coming back," says Catra in a hoarse whisper without taking her eyes from Finn. Her hand, the one that is not supporting Finnie's weight, scatters upwards holding Adora's own free hand with steel grip. Catra rocks Finn softly, to her calm baby unaware of the storm crashing against them. "We are coming back Finnie and the world will be kinder for you than it was for us, we promise."

The last part comes in a shaky breathe. Adora turns their head, placing a kiss on Catra's temple, holding. They have their whole world in their hands and it's such an overwhelming feeling. How do you part from this?

"Of course we are coming back," assures Adora, a trembling smile forming on their lips. When Catra turns to see them, the world turns just a little bit brighter. "We are good on keeping our promises."

✾

The red fire consumes the tents like flaming mouths of monsters. Horde soldiers run around, yelling, screaming at each other to get in position, gathering their weapons against the surprising but imminent attack that surrounds them.

Is sunset but the sun doesn't come down, in fact, the sun doesn't move from its position at all. The light trembles just a little and then, in the far end of the sky, right next to the blazing sun, the clouds part like a halo and the full night moon shines upon them all, casting the fields of the taken Scorpion Kingdom in golden and lilac lights. The soldiers look at this like a moth to the flame, standing in the middle of destruction but unable to go look away. After all, this is impossible, the moon and the sun don't shine together in the sky, much less one right next to the other yet here they are, bright sky twinkling with the stars that start to appear behind.

On the field, over a middle creased portion of the earth, the ground trembles. First very softly, undetectable over the yells and the heavy steps of Prime's army, and then stronger, louder. A horn resounds across the entire kingdom, making the little rocks in the earth tremble with the sound. It hovers for a second and then quiets for one more just to be followed by another horn, and another and then another. What sounds like dozens of horns blast over the space with the strength of a thousand explosions, the ground shaking in kind as the sound of hundreds of footsteps march over the dead earth.

From the top of the small hill, between the swirls of sudden freezing cold mist comes out a figure. She rides in a white horse with a red and golden flag draped over the animal's back, his breath coming out in a warm puff of steam against the cold. Over him, she sits proud and unmoving, the light of the moon catching in the shapes of her moon crown and the golden details of her armor.

Even from this far, almost at the foot of the stairs of what has come to become Emperor's Prime palace, even as she stands alone in that hill, she looks otherworldly, regal. A true regent, coming to reclaim back what was stolen from her people.

She looks down to the field with a stoic expression, watching the Horde soldier's camp drowned in flames from under her nose, her ears perked up, her eyebrows high in her forehead, unimpressed. She is not feeling remorse or guilt over it, she isn't feeling anything besides a heavy sense of *enough.* After all, this is her strategy, this is her plan of action. She is the true Queen of Albion.

Self proclaimed Emperor Primer bursts out of his palace in disarray. His usually perfectly tailored and neat clothes are wrinkled and ragged. There is a scar on his face, born from the side of his forehead, across his eyelid and down his almost skull like nose and lips, blinding him from that eye in a sea of mist, done by a powerful spell done by the very same person that now stands before him.

Prime snarls, clenching his teeth together tight, sharp, violent. His hands shake from rage just for a second. Eyes, blind and the good one, reflecting the red light of the flames below the palace. He stills his hand, trying to keep his cool facade over the anger on his artificial blood.

"Finally come to beg for your people, *your majesty* ?" he says, outloud, even over the sound of the raging fire. His soldiers have abandoned trying to suffocate the flames or save their companions, forming in tight rows with ready, sharp spears and swords, charged with electric power. They chuckle under their breaths, mocking the standing queen, still alone in the hill.

Queen C'yra exhales, resting her hand on the side of Swift Wind's strong neck, grounding herself before speaking too just that, at difference of Prime, she does not yell or shout, her voice carries across the entire kingdom like the echo of the bell, sounding so far away but also so close, almost right neck to the Horde's neck and it's so much more scarier.

"There will be no negotiations today," she says. "You *will* die tonight, Emperor Prime."

The horns blow out again, this time much more louder, much more closer. The thick clouds of mist surrounding Queen C'yra shift, bending over themselves and then retracting. Several other figures join her on that hill. A beautiful woman with pearlescent wings at her right, a crown princess with red pincers and red rubies at her left. A king with a golden bow, a queen of a broken kingdom with a deep blue trident, a queen holding the very roots of the trees on her hands, a younger one with ice in her palms.

One by one, the rulers of Etheria's kingdoms join Queen C'yra in a tight and unbreakable line of resistance. The horns sing so loud any other sound is drowned completely and out of existence. Emperor Prime clashes his teeth together, spinning on his ankles to look at his soldiers, now shifting on their feet unsure and hesitant at the sight of the Etheria's Regents.

"What are you waiting for?!" Prime screams at them, ripping his throats apart.

Among the Horde army, someone resounds a horn too, this one higher, a sound that makes the ears vibrate painfully and bleed with its strength. The soldiers carry high their shields, hitting their surfaces with the back of their heavy weapons, raising an intimidating sound across the huge fields of the kingdoms. Prime scoffs, mildly satisfied, turning back to look at the Queen with a self-sufficient smirk on his porcelain face.

Queen C'yra hums, unimpressed, unscarred, turning her head just the bare minimum to lock eyes with King Regent Beauregard, a silent agreement passing between them. King Beauregard nods, raising his hand with the palm extended, looking down at the battlefield with hooded eyes. On the other side, the Horde army has started to advance, marching with heavy steps over the dry ground, uncaring and stoppable.

King Beauregard narrows his eyes, gaze controlled and calculating. He holds his breath, just a moment, seemingly waiting for something. Whatever it is, he sees it because suddenly he exhales, steam against fog, and closes his raised hand into a tight fist, no need for words to come out of him.

It happens immediately. The sound of a thousand lightning cuts through the air, parting the sky like broken glass. Hundreds of arrows fly, first quietly, then loud like birds, creating an elegant curve before falling at full speed towards the Horde. The generals and soldiers see them come this time, someone yells a command, not everyone hears it.

Most of the shoulders bend towards the ground, holding their shields over their heads, clenching their teeth as the arrows crash, bend and dig inside the hard metal. Most of them remain unscathed but the fair end of the brigades isn't that lucky because when the arrow dig against the ground they go off in contained flaming explosions. The wave of the explosion travels far, crashing against Emperor Prime and sending him flying backwards and then down, falling unceremoniously into the marble floors of his castle. He shouts in rabid rage, fighting against the swirls of his robes and batting the hesitating helpful hands of some generals that try to help him up. He stands back on his feet with newfound anger, spitting a gush of machine oil and neon green substance before turning to the shaken army, snarling at them like a beast.

"Kill them, kill them all!" The soldiers scramble back up, charging towards the hill at full speed. Prime's face is terrible, contorted horribly in anger and madness, the metallic hair and multiple eyes almost pulsing on his outburst. "There will be no prisoners today. I want them all dead!"

The army charges forward, jumping over the fallen bodies of their companions, screaming at the top of their lungs. Queen C’yra motions her horse backwards and with it the rest of the regents, all but one, the Queen of Plumeria who advances in front of them all, kneeling on the floor, palms over the dry earth. She closes her eyes, calming, almost as if she was meditating and not in the middle of a battlefield. Her flower crown shimmers under the moonlight and then her palms press deeper, coating her hands in sudden moist black earth. Queen Perfuma hitches her breath and then opens her eyes, emerald green flashing as new sprouts from the earth at the same time she presses down the earth with more strength. The hill trembles, badly, yet the horses and regents remain calm. The Horde army hesitates before getting engulfed by a cloud of heavy dust at the same time that the hills creeks and bends, falling flat over the ground with a muted tud, dozens of giant rocks rolling down at every side.

The Horde army blinks open their eyes once more, cleaning the sand and dust with the back or their armored hands, coughing and when their sights focus again the earth is flat, the hill gone, just smooth earth expanding the field of the kingdom to every side, a natural cage keeping the enemies gathered inside. Another royalty steps up, pink and silver in her hair and

when she swirls her hands the clouds raise and sopéese with a tornado of wind, clearing the battlefield, painted now in the red and golden light of the sun and the iridescent blues of the night moon, making look the battle like a scene looked through a tinted glass.

With the thick clouds of dust gone, the true length of Etheria's army can be actually seen. Roads and roads and roads of knights and warriors, standing in lines one next to the other, all so different yet having each other's backs. First Ones, Salineans, Plumerians, Brightmoons, Magicats. Etherians. One next to the other dressed in so many shapes and colors of armor, looking with sour expressions, like hundreds of gems sparkling under the light. Another horn goes off but this one is different. It's high pitched, loud and groundbreaking. Just as the Horde's one, it slips inside the ears and into the very bones except that is so much worse. It's like thousands of crows crying all the very same time. Like dozens of ghouls, screaming, ripping themselves out of the ground and back among the living, howling so loud it makes the skin of every single mercenary and Horde soldier shiver with goosebumps. The death whistle screams once more and the Etherian army start marching forward, all as one.

Behind Prime's green bloodshot eyes, the red lightning of the Black Garnet, held with heavy magical chains to the main yard, sparks with life. The energy travels down the ground, below the rock and dead plants, swirling like serpents until it reaches the arched feet of its rightful heir, red pinchers and white hair, Crown Princess Scorpia still standing next to Halfmoon's queen, greeting her back home.

Prime scowls at the Black Garnet, focusing his sight across the battlefield and right into Queen C'yra's bright eyes, unbothered and rebellious that bore themselves inside his brains like blazing flames.

"Bring that magicat's head to me," he speaks to the shadows, starting to retreat back inside the security of his white palace as his army charges with full force against the etherians. "I will hand it from the gates of this kingdom as a lesson".

The shadows crawl over his feet and then forward, as thick, dark oil, recoiling over themselves and throwing themselves inside the cracks of the battle too.

" *It will be my pleasure,"* she speaks.

On the other side of the battlefield, Queen Glimmer rises up into the sky, her wings fully extended, casting rays of pearlescent light over their army. She holds a scepter in front of her, as tall as her with silver and white hold, embedded in precious stones that resembles the light casting from the moon stone back in her own home, spinning it in her hands so fast it becomes a mere brush of color against the sunset. Energy starts to form between her hands, an arcane circle boring from it as an omen, bigger and bigger as the seconds pass by. The Black Garnet shakes, obligated by a foreign force to shoot a spear of dark magic against the winged queen. It crashed against the arcane spell, ringing like screams when the arcane magic absorbs it and disperses it into the nothing. Queen Glimmer inhales, hard, fixing her eyes towards the high, marble towers of the castle with a profound rage burning in the back of her throat. She bares her teeth, extending her arms completely to her sides, hands trembling as if she was carrying something very heavy, the scepter still floating before her, letting go of the contained magic in the arcane spell with a soundless yell.

A white column of powerful magic is born from the arcane circle, crossing the entire battlefield with one single shot until it crashes against the white castle, breaking it like a simple paper in hundreds of pieces. The broken towers hover for a second and then collapse into the ground with an earthquake, white fire born from the seams of the hit, mirroring for an instant the destroyed gate of Salineas, the burnt down streets of Halfmoon, the ash covered paths of Camelot.

Queen Glimmer breathes deeply, observing as the castle starts to burn down, chaos at her feet from the still running soldiers and the ones that desperately try to run away from the crumble. Queen C'yra advances right below her, the soft breeze that comes from Glimmer's wings caressing the baby curls of her head almost too gently for this moment. Her face shifts, her eyes just a little bit bigger, colorful colors bleeding into deep black, drowning her scleras and pupils into mero pools of starry void. From her head, between the moon crown and the tight helmet, ethereal horns appear, tangling with the strands of her hair, curving over themselves and creating a gentle fall that swirls around her ears, sparkling with jeweled gold. Tiny feathers sprout around the ethereal horns too, this time not only colorful but also dark, black and red mixed against the bright yellows and blues until those spill out completely. The war paint over on her face seems to shimmer and glow, outlining her eyelids, the high if her cheekbones, the fall of her chin and curve of her lips, glistening against the white of her bare fangs, bared and raw against the dark light of the night clashing against the day.

Slowly, deliberately, Queen C'yra rises her arms above her head, palms extended to the sky. The air around her changes, frost too light then heavy then up, as a storm, charged with a kind of electricity completely different at the one Prime bends and manipulates with his hellish machines. This one is born from the lightning and the earth, cracking around her head as a second grown and then up and up into the sky, losing itself among the swirls of nocturne darkness melted against the pouring gold from the sunset. Over her head, beyond the figure of Queen Glimmer still floating in the air, beyond clouds of black and the fog, the night sky illuminates in a sudden flash of color. First in the very center, then another just below, then another, and another, and another, until the entire sky is blinking with blinding light.

The Horde army turns their heads towards it, hypnotized by the color, the sky trembling and then breaking into pieces with a boreal aureole, colors painting the nocturne dome. With an incandescent bright, like the fallen tears of a mourning Queen, one by one, the stars start falling from the sky.

❀

At dawn, before parting for the battlefield, Queen C’yra of Halfmoon holds her baby between her hands and bends to place a gentle kiss over their forehead. The small star in their peach soft skin glimmers, a kindred gift from their godfathers that now shifts and changes. The protection doesn’t go away but it strengthens, soft caresses of magic tangling with their mother’s and when she turns apart just a moment the star has become a waning crescent moon, shimmering silver like their own eyes under the moonlight.

Then, there is a change of arms, a different hold, just as strong and loving and careful. Just, different. The person who now holds them smells like oranges and roses and leather and

when they also bend to place a second kiss over the baby's forehead their lips are chapped with old healed scars, but never less soft and gentle. King Adora of Camelot rubs her slightly crooked nose on the side of her baby's face, a gesture that has become *theirs* and that now grounds her as she gives her own blessing before going away yet again. Over the baby's forehead, just above the moon, a new shape glistens and forms, a tiny shape that at first looks like just another star and then settles into a small sun, bright golden over their skin inside the crescent arms of the moon.

The Queen and King embrace their baby one more time, warm and snuggle up and safe between their arms and then hand them over to the former regents of Brightmoon kingdom, ready and waiting until the sign comes if the sky turns red and they must run away as far as possible or not. Either way, the Heart of Etheria will always have this, the blessing of their family and the memory of their arms holding them.

❀

The stars crash against the ground as fireballs, multicolor light balls of purple and silver and incandescent white and many other colors not Etherian eyes have ever even seen before. They break the earth and shatter the stone cold of the rocks around it, lighting the field in silver fire that doesn't burn but that it still devours everything around it.

The Horde and the Etherian army are entangled in battle, crashing against each other furious and angry and unstoppable. There are strangled screams echoing in the field, white and green armors falling on the ground like fallen leaves, a trail of bodies behind the Etherian army's steps. This isn't a bargain or a negotiation, not anymore.

Golden and lilac and silver armors glimmer as they advance under the exploding sky. The astral dome above them has melted into one, stars flashing bright, their light swirling and then flying down in a spiral of fire. Goldens and deep blues and purples are mixing all together, no longer the day nor the night anymore. As if the atmosphere had burned out from its very foundations, leaving them exposed to the very universe around them.

The Regents are fighting by foot, knee deep in the mud, sweat sticking their hairs across their foreheads. Queen Glimmer swings her specter to the side, sending a dozen of Horde mercenaries flying backwards with the wave of her magic. Her wings keep her slightly up over the bland, mush earth, helping her teleport from one side of the battlefield to the other in an elegant full speed swirl. King Beauregard twirls below her, sending four arrows flying at sharp speed and frightening aim towards the soldiers in front of them. There is a bruise below his chin and a scratch over his forehead and as well as everybody else, he is fighting with everything he has.

In the far end of the battlefield, Queen Mermista rises a wall of sea water as tall as the now destroyed towers of Prime's pristine White Castle, sending it with full force against the machine cannons there, drowning their arterial lethal electricity, unable to fight against the real force of nature. Princess Frosta and her own army advances behind her, pressing her palms in the ground and making the water then freeze into sharp fangs of ice, as tall as buildings, destroying that wing of the Horde army with just one swing.

Glimmer teleports to the center of the battlefield scanning the place quickly with sharp lilac eyes. Queen Perfuma is up front, green tentacles being born from beneath her fingers, covered in sharp poisonous thorns that whip against the army mercilessly. Behind her, Crown Princess Scorpia fights the few mercenaries that have managed to escape at bare fist, sending them teetering against each other with the strength of her muscles, clawing her way slowly but surely towards the the center of the castle where Black Garnet spikes and whips with reddish dark magic. Glimmer narrows her eyes, trying to find the stoic figure of Emperor Prime, cowardly observing everything in the still secure limits of his castle. Though not for much longer. And there he is, behind one of the huge picture windows shaped as a fan in the northern part of the castle. His hair is tousled, some of the metal, strands hanging broken, sparks of cut energy shooting from it every once in a while. Even from so far away, Glimmer can see the deep scratch over his face, splitting it in half, making his multiple eyes look furious under the silver light of the falling stars.

“Glimmer, watch out!” yells Bow from some point behind her, warning her. Glimmer turns around, pulled out from her own mind just in time to catch sight of the ground trembling below her, charged with artificial electricity just about to fully blow out the place she is standing in. Glimmer drowns a scream, batting her wings as strongly as she can, trying to get away in time.

A flash of movement passes just next to her, making the loose strands of her hair fly around her face. The electrified ground below her shines and then breaks like the frozen surface of a lake, silver veins like liquid mercury infiltrating there. The ground explodes with a soundless motion, spikes of multicolored crystals bursting through the earth and towards the sky, tangling and absorbing the strikes of lighting inside their cores, keeping their lethality far away from Glimmer. Sodalites, quartz, citrines, obsidians, amazonites, agates, labradorites and lapis lazulis, forming a deadly sharp line from limit to limit of the battlefield, breaking away the fight in several points at the same time. Catra keeps her hand partially buried into the black earth, eyebrows knitted together, fangs clicking against each other. Her colorful eyes have melted into liquid gold, dripping down her cheekbones and chin and into the ground, sprouting small flowers that melt into rivers of raw magic, filtering inside the very core of the death land. In the castle, the Black Garnet shakes, the shadow of a golden strike just barely visible on its polished surface before fading away. Glimmer sees it and so does Catra because both gasp in surprise, turning to look at each other with wide eyes.

Catra’s golden eyes flicker and turn back to normal, taking her hands away from the ground and up, as if carrying something very heavy and then to the sides in one swift motion. The line of huge, sharp crystals tremble and then crumble over themselves, leaving only small pieces of gems scattered across the ground alongside even smaller sprouts of life. At the White Castle, the tall metal gates open up again and a new wave of soldiers and mercenaries March out of it, charging with all their force against them. Glimmer grunts, fists and specter already up, swirling arcane circles floating around her as omens, charged with magic energy.

"Where do they keep coming from?!" Shouts Glimmer over the deafening sound of the wind and the war. At their right, Lady Spinnerella creates a tornado out of her bare hands, throwing a pile of mercenaries straight to the ready spears of the magicats warriors.

"The castle!” Screams back Catra, pressing her palms against the empty air. An arcane circle appears there and then splits, transforming into nine small figures resembling the lunar phases. Above her head, the clouds crack with thunder, opening above the gate of the castle and pouring down heavy drizzle and hailstones the side of oranges over the heads of the mercenaries there. “The castle needs to go down completely! Only then we’ll be able to approach the Garnet!"

Glimmer groans as she shoots another wave of magic towards some mercenaries near them, her makeup and hair still perfectly still. “I don’t like this, Catra! I can feel the Garnet from here, it’s not different from the Moonstone!”

“So!?”, growls Catra, guiding a shooting star directly towards the castle, thunder still breaking the sky around them.

“It feels wrong, Catra! It feels evil!” Catra barely dodges an incoming arrow, swirling over her ankles and then twisting up, catching it midair with her bare hands. She turns her head to the side, fangs bright against the silver light, fixing her sharp gaze on the Horde archer pointing at her. She closes her fist, metal arrow breaking under the strength of her hold. Then she reaches behind her, grasping the smooth surface of the whip held to her belt and swiping it forward, barely even aiming at all. The whip catches the arch from the mercenary’s hands, snatching it away in the split of a second. The mercenary gapes, eyes wide alternating between the place where his weapon used to be and his hands. Catra clicks her tongue, casting her whip back to her. In the blink of an eye, she is suddenly right in front of the mercenary’s face, the scales and feathers of her face ruffling with her anger.

In a very low whisper, she mutters under her breath. “Get out of my way.” The mercenary shivers from head to toe and turns on their feet, tripping all the way as they scatter as far away from the field as they can as fast as they are able to. Catra turns back towards Glimmer, panting. She is already looking back at her, wide eyed, before getting driving distracted by the fight again.

"Where is she?!" questions Glimmer, eyeing the field with a frown. “We are gaining terrain very quickly, shouldn’t she have appeared by now?!”

Catra turns her head to look at the archer run away, the broken metal in the ground. "She is waiting for something! Maybe an opening or a dist-" Catra’s pupils narrows are she looks at the weak attempt of the arrow and realizes it at the same time she finds her.

The wave of shadows crashes against Catra with full force, washing her away several yards away. Catra gasps, fighting against the sudden ocean, clawing and kicking against the sticky liquid the threats to drown her down completely. It’s cold, in the shadows, freezing cold, numbing Catra’s extremities, catching her throat in a tight hold, robbing her of the air in her lungs with one single punch. She can hear Glimmer scream her name, somewhere every second further and further away as the shadows keep driving her away, twisting her body among its cold dark tentacles, shocking a striking lightning down her spine. In its place there is another voice taking the lead, one she knows far too well by now. That has haunted her dreams as a youngling and her nightmares as an adult and of which she is frankly getting way too sick of.

"Came to die, lover girl?"

Catra tries to scream, only for the shadows to slip their way inside her mouth, past her chapped lips, filling her nose and ears, sticking to her head and armor and driving her down and down and down.

“ *You are pathetic, always an insolent child”*

This is all so very much familiar to Catra. Something she lived so many years ago but never could really escape from. The shadows seize her ankles and wrists, holding her down its painful grip.

“Look at what you did. You are going to get everyone you’ve ever cared for death”

Catra fights against the flow, sinking her nails into the shadows until they stop feeling like fog and more like bare, unnatural flesh. Around her, the shadows hesitate, just enough for the darkness to free Catra’s nose and mouth, allowing her to final keep her head above the shadows for once. All around her is darkness, back and forth inside a tsunami. Her nails dig even deeper, ripping a furious hiss from it.

" *You are alone, C'yra"* the shadows growl, seizing her by the head and pinning her down. *"You've escaped your fate for far too long. First thanks to your mothers and then thank to your Adora. But there is nobody that can save you now, not anymore"*

Catra takes a hoarse, desperate breath, trying to keep her head afloat and falling again and again, dark slipping into her eyes.

"You- ah" The black liquid slips its way into her nose and mouth, trying to reach her lungs with every wave. She is inside the magic she fears the most, she can feel it, how it's charged with the ágil of thousands of souls stolen, ripped in pain, and she can't focus for a single second to fight for her life. She can’t fight back. "You are- you are wrong"

A sinister chuckle borns from the water, surrounding her. *"And why is that? Who is going to save you this time?"*

Until she does.

"I'm not alone" Carta grinds her teeth together, opening her eyes under the freezing dark ocean, turquoise and gold bright as guiding lights. When she speaks next, it's around a growl even louder than the storm around her. "And I don't need anyone to save me."

Catra twists her hands and pulls down, gripping the shadows’ arms until it burns. From Catra’s hands a light begins to flicker and then grows, slipping into the grey, charred ones that tried to drown her down. Shadow Weaver screams in pain, the circle of shadows she has created around herself and Catra weakening and falling apart, dissolving among the fog with the blink of an eye. The light’s pressure grows and grows and grows, ripping the skin of the witch’s arms, up the unruled fabric of her dress, past her neck and chin, cracking the porcelain mask above her face in half, the rubies exploiting around her eyes, falling apart in pieces of porcelain, marble and glass, turning into ashes as it touched the ground. Shadow

Weaver wails, struggling in Catra's hold. The weak grass around their feet burns and dies, electricity trying to crash at Catra's sides and neck, snake bites that aim to kill her. Catra shakes her head, focusing, the black on her eyes spilling down her face, mixing with the paths of gold on her cheeks, reflecting the falling stars and the night sky. The spikes bite but can't hurt her, the shadows crawling over themselves, trying to eat her out alive once more.

Catra fixes her eyes on Shadow Weaver's, starry black against the split grey pupils, spotted in red, cracking under the pressure of so many lives taken for herself.

"You don't know who I am," spits out Catra, gripping at her arms even harder, making her yell in fury. "You never wanted to see it, what I'm capable of"

Catra pulls and then lets go, sending Shadow Weaver several feet back, panting and enraged, her onyx black hair dripping with shadows. Back in the castle, the Black Garnet trembles and cracks, a sound so intense coming from it that almost sounds like desperate screaming. Shadow Weaver bends her limbs, like a twisted wood puppet, snatching bones back into place, Catra's magic still craving scars on her skin. She grunts, never taking her eyes from the Queen in front of her, recovering her breath just a little before she shouts in rage towards her. Catra steps back, just one step, her arms dropped almost lazy at her sides. Inside the black of her eyes her irises are swirling in silver, two voids eating a star.

"I am not the scared child you used to frighten behind my mothers' backs. I am not the girl you thought you could use, nor the adult you tried to destroy. I'm nothing of those things" Catra's frown deepens and with it, the sky dome grows somehow even darker, shaking over Etheria. Next to the bright sun, the night moon flickers for a moment. "I am the Empress of Avalon, heir of the magicat royalty, last of the face. I serve to no one and you will bow to *me* "

The moon turns and shakes and suddenly it disappears completely from the sky. Etherian And Horde soldiers alike turn their gazes up, the entire battlefield pausing in one second on shock. From the windows of the castle, Emperor Prime watches as the moon goes again completely and he steps back over the mosaics of his spotless floor, fists closed so tight his own metal nails break into his palms, green liquid dripping down. And for the first time in his unnatural long life, he feels afraid.

In the battlefield, Catra fixes her eyes with Shadow Weaver's blinking until the black drips down and the swirls in the centers come to a stop, the very moon shining on them from the inside out. Silver light starts pouring from her palms, extending over her elbows and upper arms, drawing swirling lines over her collarbones and the center of her chest, just that, unlike Weaver, it doesn't break her or hurt her. It belong to her.

Catra takes a deep breath, air slipping through her fangs as a whistle. She takes her time, one beat, then another. Shadow Weaver not able to look away for a single moment, her broken eyes open in shock and anger. Catra looks inside of them and sees her mothers, her Adora, her baby, something hot and cold at the same time pooling on her chest. Catra moves like moonlight, raising her hands up in the hair, claws fully out cutting in the air. Below Shadow Weaver's feet the earth trembles, breaking apart. From its core, roots burst out, dark as onyx and even stronger, tangling themselves around Shadow Weaver's limbs, her ankles and wrists, torso and waist, holdin her down with iron grip.

Shadow Weaver yowls, bursts of dark magic exploding out of her, trying to burn down her imprisonment, kicking, yelling and spitting out, cursing out at Catra with everything she has. Catra clicks her teeth together, holding her breath as she closes one of her fists, keeping her there, the other hand shooting to the side, motioning to the earth around them both. The earth opens once more and out pours water, traveling at full speed and submerging Shadow Weaver inside its coldness. Catra pushes her hand up and the water shifts once more, sparkling with natural minerals and transforming into tall spikes of ice and quartz, surrounding Weaver inside a natural prision, their sharp edges pointing at her face and neck.

Carta presses down her hand, the roots squeezing on Shadow Weaver's bones, making them crack slightly in protest. Shadow Weaver yells, her dark magic lipping down in rivers of thick incandescent lava, starting to heat up the onyx roots and crystals. Carta grunts and smirks, the crystals shimmering with silver magic. The moons inside Catra's eyes glimmer and blink, the spark of a small victory shining inside them.

“Gotcha”

Carta raises her hand towards the sky, a single small silver fireball shooting up, up and up and up several meters until it hovers a little and then explodes with sparkling golden fireworks, the light and sound traveling far away, illuminating the night moonless sky with a thousand colors.

❀

At the limits of the Scorpion Kingdom, a black horse runs at full speed towards the battlefield, their blue mane shifting colors back and forward, warm breath raising thick clouds of steam up around them. The person that guides them pants over there back, following the trail of light the firework sign has left behind. Their long golden ponytail lashes behind them like a golden light, holding themself to the strong muscles of the horse with their thick leather gauntlets, a deep blue sword that seems to vibrate with magic hanging from the belt on their side.

Horse and jockey burst from behind the twisted tree trunks at the limits of the field, scaling with heavy steps one of the curved hills. The king lowers their head closer to the horse's ears, holding for the life of them to their sides, voice hoarse against the bite of the wind.

"You ready!?"

The horse neighs deeply, not once slowing down, closer and closer to the top of the hill and then to the drop below. The king holds their breath, closing their eyes just before the black horse takes impulse and jumps off the cliff.

❀

One of the onyx roots heats up and melts out, allowing Shadow Weaver to free her hand just enough to reach towards the crystals, grabbing them with her bare, charred palm. The sharp points break out the skin there, smearing traces of black blood over its smooth surface. Carta

grunts, pressing down even further with her hands, keeping the rest of the trap intact. Shadow Weaver looks at her, all crazy wild hair and green greyish skin and bloodshot eyes. She snarls, spit and clots gushing of her mouth, all of her teeth drenched in black and pointed like a shark. The trap heats up even further, melting away the crystals like nothing, the roots cracking menacingly under the heat's pressure. The lava meets the water below, sizzling when they touch and turning each other into hard rock.

Shadow Weaver pulls her hand up and then to the sides, twisting it in a way that should be able, cracking and reconstructing itself until her left arm is fully free. Catra gasps, clenching her teeth together, holding her hands in front of her at the same time Shadow Weaver lashes against her, a thick wave of black magic thrown directly to her face. The ground around Catra's feet shakes, little rocks floating softly in the air, the air around her charging and lighting up, the ghost of a magical dome as a bell surrounding her completely. The wall of darkness crashes against the silver dome with the sound of a thousand bells, resounding in the battlefield as an explosion.

Catra exhales harshly, frowning deeply as her arms remain extended in front of her, holding the magical shield around her with everything she has. From the ground around Shadow Weaver new roots sprout out, twisting themselves tighter around Weaver's necks and arms. She screams, the darkness crashing again and again around Catra like a furious animal, rabid, howling like the air inside a tornado.

"Agh!" yells Shadow Weaver, extending once more shadow arm towards Catra, clawing over the surface of her protection spell. "I am going to shred you to pieces!"

From the edges of the battlefield a new sound arises. This one is different, like nothing that has ever been heard before. Except that it has, once. The Horde soldiers and mercenaries recognize it from weeks before, something so huge and terrifying it haunts their dreams. The battlefield pauses again, a second a little too long, suspended in a moment of time with held breath. The sound comes again, this time higher, closer. From the far end of the battlefield, among the thick clouds of fog that hover over the ground, thick columns of blue smoke start to swirl to the sky, a bright blue and golden light following behind. The light blinks, the smoke shifts and for just one intake of air more, the strange sound quiets completely.

Over their heads, the sun turns over itself and trembles, making the light over the field to cast colorful reflections over the ground and the armies, like sunrise through tinted glasses. On the dry ground at their feet, bright light starts to pour from the very inside, rising as hot steam throughout the earth and towards the sky, trying to reach the very sun with its iridescent hands. The sun seems to grow somehow bigger, brighter, casting the battlefield in golden light against the darks of the night sky that nestle it. And then, as if looking for its nocturnal companion, the sun explodes in thousands of sparkles, disappearing too from the sky.

From the blue smoke a figure emerges in a swirl of heat. Huge as a castle, their wings cast shadows of purple over the battle as the dragon crosses the sunless and moonless sky. Their head is the size of a dozen of horses, purple and blue pearlescent scale shimmering with power and blue fire, their teeth bigger than towers, eyes as sapphires, sharp and cutting and intelligent, scanning the field with unyielding focus. The Horde army below them screams, some of the scattering away and into the ready spears of the magicat's warriors, others

somehow angrier, stupider, who grab their arches and try to shoot metal towards them. It's useless. Some arrows don't even make it all the way and the ones that does break in pieces the moment they come in contact against the dragon's side, falling back to the ground in vivid red for the heat of the fire inside them.

The dragon growls, a sound so intense the very hills around the fiel shake, and then opens their immense mouth roaring at the top of their lungs. The sound travels across the Scorpion Kingdom, outside of its invaded limits and across the entirety of Etheria. From the lonely remains of Salineas, past the empty streets of Halfmoon and the still smoking paths of Camelot, into the walls of Brightmoon's castle, down the caves inside the earth and up the highest misty mountains at the north. The sound is so strong, most of those who hear it have to scrunch down for a second, covering their ears and closing their eyes as the roar vibrates inside their very souls.

The dragon growls low on their throat, lowering their eyes until they see what they are looking for, letting out one more intense roar before speeding up again this time down.

In the ground, Shadow Weaver is frozen in place, her shadows standing still around her, frozen in sudden shock. The dragon lowers their wings, the air dragged by them hitting biting cold against Shadow Weaver's and Catra's face before extending their powerful paw in front of them before falling with an intense hit on the ground behind Carta, surrounding her as a second shield. The dragon's spear sharp tail curls around Catra's left side, swiping back and forward, creating deep grooves in the earth with their tail and claws. Their wings, as big as lakes, rise over Catra's head, casting blue shadows over her as the light of the still falling stars shines through their membrane limbs. The dragon growls, lowering their head next to Catra's right side, looking at Shadow Weaver's face before roaring directly at her face.

Carta exhales, the dome of light around her blinking and disappearing, exhausted from keeping it and the trap around the witch up. Shadow Weaver must have been excepting for it because the bites into the air, the shadows retracting into themselves and inside her chest before exploding and with them Catra's entire trap. Catra yells, covering her face with her arms to protect it from the sharp pieces of crystals exploding everywhere. Shadow Weaver sees the distraction and takes it, sending one more shot lethal of darkness and blood red electricity towards Catra, lashing over the earth and air, killing the weak grass there with its touch.

The dragon lowers their neck and torso to the side at the same time, and it's there and only then that Shadow Weaver catches the sight of someone else riding on the dragon's back.

A shot of pure, golden sunbeam slams against Weaver's dark spell, not only pushing it back but burning it from the inside out, leaving only dark smoke behind. Shadow Weaver wails in anger and charges completely and physically against Catra, her long, dagger fingers unshed and towards Catra's chest at the same time the figure moves in a flash of gold. Carta feels a rush of air, the curls of her hair hitting the side of her face as the Dragon's Rider throws themself in front of her, raising their deep blue sword in time, the magical steel clashing against the dark nails of the witch with soundless waves.

The strength of the crash sends the witch teetering back, sputtering as the air leaves her lungs. She coughs, looking up and into the blinding sun before her. And behind its golden light, a

ghost greets her back.

Adora returns her gaze with golden eyes, much as Catra's, liquid gold dripping from her pale eyelashes and down her chin and neck, sliding off the plate of her rose gold armor and into the earth, shaking it back to life with its touch. Adora's winged helmet shines with its own light, reflecting rainbows over the deep blue surface of Excalibur, held in front of her and pointed towards Shadow Weaver in a threatening gesture. Adora frowns down at her, dark eyebrows accentuating the lightness of her face, shadows casted over her nose under the crown resting over her forehead. There is magicat war paint in her face, a line from side to side across her cheekbones and down her chin, eyelids winged with golden and a half moon with a sun painted over her forehead. The expression on her face is deadly as she looks at the witch, all the scars on their face glistening under the bright light.

Shadow Weaver gasps, choking with her own air and spit. She crawls over the dark earth, blood red dress in disarray, torn in pieces in the seams.

"That- That's not-" she stutters, taken aback. "That's not possible!" she screams at the top of her lungs, shadows lashing violently at her sides. "You are dead! I took you away! I destroyed you!"

Behind Adora, Catra chuckles, recovering on her feet. She straightens up, brushing her bangs off of her face with her palm, turning her scratched up face towards Shadow Weaver with a sly smirk on her face, ears perked up. Even wounded and exhausted she looks like the cat that got the cream, the golden figure of Adora still sheltering from Weaver's shadows. The witch gapes at her, the gears inside her head turning around until it barely clicks inside her brain.

"You pathetic child, what did you do?!" Red lightning is born from Weaver's hands, spinning over themselves and towards Catra once more. Adora clicks their tongue against their teeth, cutting in the air with Excalibur twice and then forward with a deep almost feral grunt. White light spins out of the sword's surface, pushing against Weaver's shadows and once again making them disappear like a bubble under the rays of the sun. The light reaches the witch, who hisses painfully at the touch of the sunlight against her face, raising her arms to protect herself and avoid being blinded by it.

Adora lowers Excalibur, almost spitting the words towards the newly coward witch, still scrambling inside the safety of her own shadows. "She saved me. She saved me in more ways that you can ever imagine. You wouldn't understand it," says Adora, snarling at her. "Now be quiet for once".

Adora turns around, stone cold expression melting into a much softer one as they look at Catra, caked in mud and sweat after fighting her way across the battlefield. Adora hums, approaching Catra with soft steps until they are in front of her, caressing the side of her face with gloved fingers and an enchanted expression on their face. "Hello, my beautiful, beautiful, love"

Catra huffs, rolling her eyes as she feels her cheeks turning bright pink under the helmet. "What took you so long?"

Adora grins, shrugging. "Emotional scarring entrance?"

Catra pokes them in the forehead, shaking her head to the sides, their usual banter ever present as if they were in the backyard at home and not in the middle of a war. " *You* are a show off. Did you only asked to ride over my dragon for *drama* ?"

The battlefield around them has gone quiet, looking in amaze, shock and what is clearly close as terror at the supposedly dead king of Camelot and the huge dragon behind them, scanning the field with smoking nostrils and lethal teeth. The dragon growls at a specific group of mercenaries falling directly at them, dangling a couple of sharp dragon killer tools between their useless hands. The mercenaries shierk, running away and directly into the east wing of the Etherian army.

"Melog," murmurs Catra softly, endearing, holding the dragon's humongous head between her hands and scratching the side of their steel hard face with her sharp nails. Adora rubs the side of their reptilian nose too, eyes still locked with an enamoured gaze towards her wife. Catra looks up and towards the still standing marble castle. Prime has disappeared from the window, only darkness left of the place he used to stand to watch the battle play out. Carta frowns, throwing her shoulders back. "Let's get this over with"

Melog puffs a gentle cloud of steam towards both before growling again, low on their throat, rising over the ground and the sky once again. Their wings swing against the celestial vault, sparkling the battlefield back to life with the sound of a new roar before flying up and forward, unstoppable as they charge against Emperor Prime's once impenetrable castle.

Adora steps forward too, casting a swift, almost boring look towards Shadow Weaver, still fighting against the sunlight. She takes the handle of Excalibur with both hands, raising slightly above her head, sharp edge looking to the ground in a scene so much familiar to the last time she fought against the Horde with Excalibur. Just that, this time, Adora knows the sword doesn't control her magic. She controls the sword.

Adora yells, bringing her hands down with force, embedding the sword inside the rock hard surface of the earth. The ground cracks against the sword, breaking in a rooted line across the battlefield, shaking the very foundations of the kingdom. Then, from the insides of the gash, the center of the ground starts to heat up in bright light, up and up and up until it pours out and into the surface, traveling among the grass and slipping into the grooves of the dark earth, around feet of warriors and mercenaries fighting each other and fallen Horde soldiers until it reaches the limits of the kingdom with the woods. As if reaching a barrier of magic, the flow stops. Adora extends a hand to the side and towards the flow, whispering in ancient First One language to the liquid. It shivers and then sparks up, lighting up. Walls of golden fire burst off it, reaching the limits of the battlefield and the castle, guarding them inside an impenetrable circle of fire. Adora exhales, hot steams leaving her mouth, eyes golden under the dark night. She closes her hand and the fire follows it, bending into itself and swirling until a fireball shoots out of the fire walls, followed by another and then dozens, casting their luminated trail over the sky and hovering there. The fireballs spin on themselves and then blink, extending their own fire wings until dozens of fire dragons the size of horses are flying in the sky, following the lead of Melog as they charge against the castle.

Shadow Weaver stands up then, whipping a red lighting towards Adora that catches them in the shoulder. Adora hisses in pain, grabbing the handle of the sword with both hands and

bending forward, allowing Catra to take an impulse on their back as she jumps over Adora, charging against Shadow Weaver with bare fangs and a snarl. Adora straightens up on time to see Catra enter Shadow Weaver's space, right fist closed tightly. The earth trembles and Adora must be too distracted by the pain on their shoulder because they see the blow of magic coming but they don't see the fist coming too. Catra grabs Shadow Weaver by the neck of her dress, magic be damn, and pinches her square in the face, knuckles connecting against skin so hard Adora can hear the audible crack of the witch's nose after the blow.

Shadow Weaver stumbles back as Catra jumps backwards bending just slightly to grab a handful of earth and then pull her arms up and forward. The earth obeys her because the ground starts trembling even more and from the crack done by Adora's sword, a wall of rock rises, throwing itself against Shadow Weaver's form with so much strength she flies away several feet and Adora is sure more than one bone is broken by now. Carta turns, looking at Adora with wild, dark eyes and fae feathers on her face and horns on her temples and fangs on her mouth and Adora is blushing so hard she may as well either marry her right here all over again or pass out.

Melog roars, flying above the castle in circles, almost like choosing the prefect spot, before they breathe in deeply and exhaling one more time. Melog's neck starts to light up from the inside, first at the level of their torso and neck until it reaches the base of their mouth and illuminates their teeth and tongue, shining through the steel hard scaled skin. The dragon opens their mouth and a wide column of blue fire bursts out of Melog's throat, colliding against the huge towers of Prime's marble castle with a blinding white explosion. The fire dragons Adora had casted throw themselves at the castle too, not blowing fire at it like Melog but crashing against the walls and windows with an eruption of golden light. The White Castle starts crumbling under the unbearable heat, enveloped in blue and golden flames that consume everything behind them, leaving nothing behind but ashes. The thick glasses of the windows crack and then explode, sharp pieces falling to the floor and breaking the mosaics of the floors. The walls break in two, towers falling off and into the yards with an earthquake, a just mirror of the Camelot towers burning down weeks ago. And when Melog lashes their spiked tails against it, the base of the castle trembles and crumbles like wet sand, mourning across the fire just as the Halfmoon’s town and the people of Salineas, devouring everything behind. From inside the castle waves and waves of Horde soldiers and mercenaries rush out, cowering against the fall of their castle and straight into the hell that is the battle as the Etherian army swallows them whole.

Adora pulls the sword out of the ground, swinging it to an incoming wing of bloodlust mercenaries. Their skeletons start heating up from the inside out, melting in a hollow scream before being driven away by the wind in a cloud of ashes. On Adora’s back, Catra turns her gaze towards a group of metal cannons over one of the hills, pointing directly at the spot Glimmer and Bow are fighting their way to clear the center of the battlefield. Rage pools in Catra’s belly and she *growls* , loud enough to cast an echo across the kingdom. From below the hill, dozens of Halfmoon’s panthers jump towards the cannons, tearing the metal machines into parts with their teeth and claws. Catra digs her ankles in the ground, speaking to the panthers even from miles away in a low and hoarse voice, fae tongue rolling off her mouth, ancient words that echo through the battlefield like multiple voices, as if all her ancestors were talking to Etheria at the same time. Tree branches burst out of the ground of the hills, lashing against the army with all their might, gripping themselves around the

mercenaries limbs and necks. Catra looks to the crumbling castle, looking at Melog crash against it and reduce it to mere pieces of stone.

Shadow Weaver rips the beams of light off her face, the skin around her eyes red and partially scratched by her own nails. She throws a look at them and then to the castle, snarling when she sees the flaming destruction over it. She snarls, surrounding herself with shadows and back to Catra's direction.

"Do you really think you can defeat me like this? With magic tricks in the sky and fire?" The shadows crack with red lightning and thunder, menacingly. "I have so much more power than you are aware of. I'll be sure to regard your dragon the same way I regarded every single other dragon Uther asked me slay in pieces"

Catra extends her arms in front of her, palms up, breathing hard. Her eyes are focused, pools of darkness circled in silver, her ears lowered to the sides, crowned helmet shining under the light of the starry night.

"Go on then" the witch scoffs, mockingly. "You wanted me here, didn't you? Then do it already, come for me. This time I'll make sure to burn every single memory you have of each other before I kill you". Shadow Weaver scowls at her deeply, shadows ready, until she realizes Carta is not pointing at her but at something beyond, held in chains in the middle of the white castle' yard.

Adora approaches Catra from behind, as if they were to embrace her, her back against their torso, raising their arms too alongside hers as well as their hands. Adora tangles their scrapped fingers together, the palm of Adora's hands against the back of Catra's, fingers against fingers, nestling their chin against Catra's neck and shoulder, holding each other, pointing together. Adora locks their golden eyes against Shadow Weaver's, the tip of their crooked nose brushing against Catra's cheek when they speak.

"You don't have power over us anymore," Adora says, gold against silver. "And we are not here for you"

Above the kings' heads, the sky flickers and with a flash of light the night moon and the sun reappear in the celestial vault, no long far away but together, embracing each other. The eclipse scintillantes, casting a beam of light directly towards the regents, enveloping them in bright golden and silver light. Sparkles like fireflies are born of their joined hands, surrounding their wrists and arms, reaching each other as magnets onto a single fireball of bright magic light.

Shadow Weaver looks at them with wide, terrified eyes, alternating between the magic in the hands and their faces that glow with the magic, dark against light not fighting but completing each other. That's what they are, two sides of the same coin. Two phases of the moon. The set and the rise of the sun.

Shadow Weaver exhales in shaking fear, throwing a look behind her, where their hands are directed, past the stunned Horde soldiers, into the limits of the white castle burning in white flames and inside the yard, where Princess Scorpia has managed to arrive, breaking the Black Garnet's chain with her bare pincers. It's until then that it clicks for the witch, and she snaps

her head back towards the kings, scrambling on shaky legs to her feet, one last hoarse, painful scream.

"No!"

The light on Carta and Adora's hands shines as bright as the two luminaries that hover over their heads, going off in a single, most powerful beam of silver and golden light, across the battlefield, past the remains of the castle and directly into de Black Garnet. The bean grown wider and wider and wider, slipping into the hard surface of the garnet, heating it up and freezing it at the same time, illuminating the entire kingdom like they were all inside a supernova, just about to blow up.

The world has stopped moving, the battle stops its curse just so they can turn their eyes towards the beam of light that makes the entire ground tremble. Behind their feet and everyone else's, tiny sprouts of life begin to grow, the trees beyond the circle of fire shake themselves from their dead leaves and grow back again, lilacs and deep greens and pinks, glistening with life.

It's so much. Catra grunts, biting the inside of her cheek with so much force she tastes copper on her tongue. Adora, trembles behind her, clenching their teeth together, sweating but never breaking their hold on Catra or the magic between their arms. The beam of light crashes against the Garnet, slashing deep cuts over it until the dark crystal shines from the inside out, pouring the light from in between the cuts into pools of gold and silver in the ground. Carta and Adora give a silent scream at the same time, the beam as bright and powerful as it could be, the eclipse above them spinning on its own axis. The garnet trembles and cracks in the middle, breaking into pieces held precariously by the base. Adora guides Catra's fingers and theirs heavily but gently, closing into fists, the beam of light flickering and dying down behind their fingers.

Both of them exhale, exhausted. Adora tangles their arms around Catra's middle at the same time she flops forward, stopping her from falling into the ground. Catra grabs Adora's upper arms, raising her head towards the castle. Her sharp catch sight of Scorpia, running as fast as she can towards the garnet, sheltered by Perfuma's root shields behind her. Carta gulps, rising her voice above the ringing tone inside her ears, her voice traveling across the silent battlefield.

"Scorpia, now!"

Scorpia turns her eyes towards her, understating passing between both friends even from so far away, before she swings forward and directly towards the Garnet, spinning in her feet. Her tail smashes against the crystal, the sharp point of its end digging directly in the middle of the crack. The strength of the hit travels through the giant crystal, remaining still for a second more before it breaks completely. A sound so high breaks into the battlefield, a banshee scream that chills everyone to their very bones.. It's barely dying down when it's followed by another and another and suddenly a hundred and more screams fill the air. Carta scrunches to the ground, shielded by Adora's body around her as they hover over her and cover her ears with their hands, protecting her from the high, chilling sound. As the screams keep coming, the garnet starts glowing this time red, so red it looks like blood and from its inside, white orbs of mist start to shoot out, traveling to the sky and then away as shooting

stars, losing themselves among the sky. It goes like this for a minute that feels like centuries until the screams stop coming and the garnet blinks its light away.

One more red lighting leaves the now destroyed garnet, hitting Scorpia in the chest and sending her teetering back several feet before collapsing near Perfuma's feet, who yells and throws herself over her. The fallen pieces of the garnet start crumbling down one by one, the destroyed crystal breaking to the ground like sand until there is nothing else where once the dark prison of so many souls used to be but a burnt dark mark in the marble and silence behind.

Adora and Catra look up, panting heavily, taking in the remains of the crystal being washed away by the hot air of the fire. Catra's sharp eyes scan the place, visibly relaxing when she sees Perfuma helping Scorpia stand up in wobbling feet. Carta sighs, letting herself relax for just a second inside the security of Adora's arms. Adora brushes back her bangs from her forehead, placing a shaky kiss in the damp sweat skin there, burying their nose on her shoulder as they exhale.

Several feet besides them, Shadow Weaver stands up from the ground, looking with an unreadable face towards the place where the Black Garnet used to be. Around them, the grass has started to sprout completely again and the clouds have started to condense, letting a soft drizzle fall over the battlefield like gentle kisses. Shadow Weaver's limbs are trembling and she looks so much older than she did just mere minutes ago. Her arms look somehow longer and skinnier, the skin of her face pulled down in worn lines, greenish and grey, the angles of her skull deeply marked around her cheekbones and eyes. She stands there, just looking, before she turns around and towards the kings with a blank expression.

Carta and Adora look at her too, hands tangled together, still basically kneeling over the newly greenland below. Shadow Weaver watches them, wind blown hairs and arms around each other, two children that she had tried to tear apart and that still had found their way back together. A ghost that shouldn't be alive anymore and a magicat she underestimated had set her inside a trap to destroy what gave her power, what she had used against Etheria for so many years, it was gone in a matter of seconds at their hands. They had used her own hate and resentment against herself and blinded her just enough to take her down. Shadow Weaver had tried to turn their own love against themselves and it had been exactly that what had been her final doom.

Carta and Adora look at her, gold against silver and the anger inside Shadow Weaver's old, dry chest bursts out. She screams at them, loud, angry, so intense the grass around her feet blackens and dies down. The shadows around her arise once more, much more weaker than before, surrounding her in a makeshift dark cocoon and engulfing her completely. Adora and Catra flinch, watching as the shadows seems to eat Weaver straight up and then disappear, scattering across the field like a tiny, scared serpent, running away and towards the castle.

Carta watches her go and stands up immediately, absently helped by Adora, still recovering her breath. She looks at Shadow Weaver slider away and growls. She mutters a low *Fuck* , grabbing Adora’s hand between hers out of sheer habit, sweaty palms brushing against each other and fingers tangling together. On the sky, the respaldescent orbs keep shooting to every corner of the planet, shifting the curse of Etheria into what it had always supposed to be. The

sight is breaktaking, thousands of thousands of souls finally free from their crystal prisiong, rushing back home.

Maybe it’s the gorgeous sight that distracts them. Or the eclipse still spinning in the night and day sky, the celestial sky changing. Or the feeling of their hands joined. Or the adrenaline still rushing on her veins. Or the weight of taking a second, just one, to breathe and look at the stars above them hand in hand, It must be some of these things because neither of them notice it until it's already done.

There is a weird sound in the air. Like a violin cord snapping in too, whipping the air around it with the charged electricity of thunder, and then, lighting.

Catra's ears twitch, catching the sound seconds before it approaches her at full speed, direction straight and unwavering, sent to kill. She barely has time, after everything. She catches the sound and then spins into place, trying to make sense of its origin, of its end but by the time she understands it it's too late.

Catra looks at the metallic arrow breaking the air against the dark of the sunless sky, cracking with artificial unnatural energy, and she knows she doesn't have time to move away. So instead, she thinks.

Barely, on the back of her mind, she catches the sight of Emperor Prime standing in the field, still too far away, disheveled and covered in the ashes of his own castle, a small taste of the horrors he had ordered against her people, with a mechanical bow on his hands and a terrible expression on his unnatural face and now she knows where the lethal weapon came from, but she pays no more mind to it. She thinks of Adora, shining, the very sun on that death battlefield and how much Catra loves her. Catra loves her to pieces and she is so proud of her, so proud of her not wanting to die for them but wanting to live for them and Catra couldn't be more happy for her. She is beautiful and strong and she is going to be such a wonderful mother to Finn. Their little kitten, with the sun on their hair and the moon on their eyes and the soft feeling of their tiny cheeks against the skin of her collarbones. Catra loves them and she is so grateful to be their mom. Catra thinks of how lucky she has been. She found her best friend and she loved them and was loved by them and they created something, *someone,* so beautiful together.

She thinks of Scorpia, who got her back all these years, who supported her as a queen and in every decision Catra took even when they seemed crazy. She thinks of Glimmer and Bow, those two dumbasses she somehow now adores, with their sparkling energy and their pink and golden and lilac colors and the way they make her part of their family. The way they gave her baby a family they could rely on. Catra thinks of Entrapta, and the rest of the round table, of Mara who helped them live, of her mothers who she hopes she will see again. Catra thinks of it all, in the matter of just a second, with the arrow piercing the mist towards her heart.

Many things happen all at the same time. Catra sees the arrow coming and suddenly, the temperature drops, harsh and biting, burning the skin of Catra's feet when the moss in the ground becomes tiny drops of ice. Someone gasps behind her and it's until then that Catra realizes Adora next to her has realized it too, the sweet breeze of her breath hitting her nose when Adora catches sight of the arrow. Catra feels Adora move, feels the rush of warm air

against her back and the metallic softness of two armored arms circling her waist and pulling back *hard.* Still, she knows it's too slow. She wants to scream at her, *Get away, get away, live!* And then, Catra also sees a rush of color. A deep blue shadow crosses the field, almost as quickly as the arrow getting closer and closer, throwing itself in front of Catra. Everything happens and everything ends with a loud click and their small space in the middle of the battlefield falls into heavy silence.

Catra gasps, exhales, sweat making the curls on her forehead stick uncomfortably against her skin. Absently she registers that she is leaning back, her ankles digging into the ground, her back resting against a solid body. Adora has her arms crossed against Catra's torso, holding her tightly against their front, curled over Catra's back like a protective shield. Catra's hands come up, gripping Adora's hands with as much strength as she can, eyes fixed in front of them with the pupils shrunk to mere pinpoints. The sharp tip of the arrow hovers a few inches from Catra's chest, barely missing her at all. It's made of metal, still cracking with energy, dripping slightly to the ground, drip, drip and drip, forming splashes of red over the moss.

Catra looks at the bloodied arrow, Adora's face next to her own, frozen in place just as her as their eyes try to make sense of the scene before them. Catra exhales again, all the air leaving her lungs and it's until then that she understands that the arrow has dug its way through a body, metal against fabric and fragile skin, the lethal hit catching her right through the heart from where she threw herself between Catra and death itself.

Light Hope breathes in, one shuddering, unsure breath and then all out before stumbling back against the swirls of her skirt, falling back with almost slow motion. Adora and Catra move at the same time, arms extended just in time to catch Light Hope between them, the three of them lowering to the ground impossibly slow. Neither of them see it but back in the remains of the burning castle, Emperor Prime scowls, making his way inside the battlefield with his weapon held between his iron claws.

Carta nestles Light Hope's face on her lap, breath stuck on her throat and shivering violently, holding her head in place as Adora hovers over Light Hope, hands brushing the arrow from several angles, unsure how to touch it or take it or even act next.

"No, no, no, no," repeats Adora again and again in a thread of a voice. Her face is pale, red spots over her cheeks and nose, golden eyes rimmed in red and panic, dripping down her cheekbones in small tears that pool on her chin. Catra looks at them and then back at Light Hope’s face, feeling the way the tears start to pour out of her own eyes, making her eyelashes stick together and her sight to mist.

Light Hope's eyes are unfocused as she looks at the sky above them, the eclipse hovering directly in front of them, shooting stars like fireworks, painting the sky in multiple beautiful colors. Her breathing is ragged, forceful, inhaling and exhaling more and more irregularly as the seconds pass by. Blood drops from the place where the arrow has made its way inside her chest, pooling down her collarbones and the dip of her neck, staining Catra's hands as she brushes away the ruffles of Hope's veil off her face. The iron of the arrow reflects the colors of the battlefield around them, a mock of a mirror. The numbness inside Catra's chest has given place to freezing shock, adrenaline shooting up and down her arms as she holds Light Hope still, unable to look away from her face.

"Why did you do it?" asks Catra around a sob, stumbling on her own words, clenching her teeth to try and make the words make sense over the sound of her own fast beating heart. Light sighs, choking slightly when she does. Her body is slack between Catra's arms, hands to either side of her body and into the newly alive earth. But her eyes are still focused, smart as always, looking at Catra with clarity and something else, something Carta had never thought she would ever see inside Light Hope's face. Regret.

"You were right," Light Hope says, hoarse, voice almost gone as the blood keeps dripping out of her body and inside the ground and it shocks Catra because that should be her, the one fallen to the earth with an iron arrow to the heart, it should be her but it isn't because of Light Hope. Because Light Hope had saved her.

"What you- what you said to me in Camelot. You were right." Light Hope is crying, actual tears falling from her eyes and running down the sides of her face. "After everyone left, I came back to Camelot, to what was left of it and I saw what I had done. I betrayed you, I betrayed both of you. I betrayed Mara, I did, I did-"

Light Hope's voice runs thin and she closes her eyes for a second, breathing almost gone completely. Adora looks up and towards Carta, tears falling down one after the other. Adora's expression is broken, their own tears falling as starlight down their face. The gold on her eyes have dimmed down, the bright blue of her pupils shining with unshed tears. Adora's eyes are unfocused, wide and frightened, looking in every direction around them. Across Light Hope's body and down to the ground back to the arrow, again and again and again. She is muttering under her breath, scratching the side of her neck as she tries and fails to find a way to fix the unfixable. She is spiraling down, lost on her own thoughts in a way Catra knows is too close to dangerous.

Adora wraps one of her hands on the side of the arrow that stands out of Light Hope's chest, frowning deeply as she collects enough bravery to pull it out. Catra shoots her hand forward, enveloping Adora's hand with her own, rubbing the back of their knuckles with her thumb in soothing circles.

"Adora-"

"Don't touch it! Don't touch it. It's iron, it will burn you," almost yells Adora, wrapping her other hand over Catra's and taking it away from the arrow, still not looking at her at all. Even between all that it’s happening, the gesture fills Catra with tenderness.

"Adora" repeats Catra, raising her hand to cradle Adora's face on her palm. "Adora, look at me." Adora is breathing hard, but they blink, guided back to reality by Catra's voice. Reluctantly, Adora tears their gaze from the arrow, locking their alarmed eyes with Catra's teary ones. Catra shakes her head, caressing Adora's face with her thumb again and again. "Adora, no. No"

Adora's face falls. Catra can feel their tears dripping inside her palm and she shakes her head again, softly.

"She is right," Light Hope whispers. Catra and Adora turn to her, eyebrows knitted in worry. Light Hope's eyes are fogged as she looks at them, tears trapped on her dark eyelashes.

Adora's face contracts in sadness, stuttering.

"But- but I can save you"

"I don't want you to, Adora" murmurs Light Hope, her breathing coming with more and more difficulty. Adora's face crumbles, tears running down their neck and chin as another sob rips out of her chest. They see the wound, how deep it dug its way inside Light Hope's chest. They know they could repair it, they could, but if Hope doesn't allow them to then there is nothing else Adora can do. And they also know that the arrow wasn't supposed to be there. That arrow had been sent towards Catra's heart, their Catra, and it would be her, the one bleeding out on the ground if it wasn't for Hope right now. Adora knows all of this and understands none of it and the only thing they can do is kneel in the cold earth and cry. Light Hope blinks, locking her dark eyes with theirs, and even now, her expression is serene but urgent, telling Adora all the things she meant to say before the world collapsed under their feet. "Mara asked me to look after you and instead I almost destroyed what you loved the most, Adora. And I'm sorry. I'm so sorry, for everything" she trails off for a second, overwhelmed by tears and mourning. "If I had stopped your mother from going to that battle she would have lived. You would still have a mother, you wouldn't have to shoulder this war as a second skin. It was my responsibility, because she was my king and my friend and my family and I- and I loved her. I loved her so much."

Light Hope dissolves into a fit of cough, face scrunched in pain. Adora and Catra's hands shoot forward at the same time, holding each one of Light Hope's hands between theirs. Around them, the war is raging in, Horde soldiers and mercenaries crashing against the merciless strength of Etheria's magic and its people, maybe to push back before the exhaustion of etherians that have suffered enough. The castle keeps burning, Melog and the fire dragons bursting the Horde quarters with blue fire, the eclipse still casting shadows across the entire planet. Yet here they remain, Catra and Adora, holding Light Hope's almost lifeless body inside a bubble of makeshift quietness.

"I went too far," continues Hope, shivering. "After you- after you *died* Adora, I knew that I had made a mistake and still I kept helping them. Helping *her*. I destroyed Camelot. I almost have them Finn, I was going to do it Adora, I was going to- If C'yra hadn't been there, if she hadn't stop me, I don't know what else I would have done and I'm sorry-" Adora closes her eyes, overwhelmed too by another kind of pain. The pressure of Catra's hand on theirs increases just a little, just enough to let them know she is there. "It was C'yra's words what woke me up. Your words," this time, Light Hope turns her eyes to Catra's, and the intensity and honesty inside them takes her breath away. "I'm sorry, C'yra. For what I did to you, for what I did to your people and your home. For what I tried to do to your family, to your baby."

Catra whimpers but nods, unable to mutter a single word but "Yes" and then another trembling one "Yes."

Light Hope smiles softly at her, lips painted in red. Her eyes are further and further away, as if she were starting to see things that aren't there. She squeezes Catra's hand between hers, blinking slowly. "It was always you, always. Thank you for saving, Adora." Then she turns her sight back to them, broken with mourning. "I'm sorry I took you away from them".

Adora shakes their head, speaking against the sob ripping from their throat. "She was the one that tried to kill me-"

"But I helped her," Light Hope gives Adora the saddest of the looks, something that is charged with mourning but also acceptance. "I don't deserve your forgiveness, Adora."

Adora shakes their head again, this time harder, making the small strands of hair that have escaped from their helmet to curl around their eyes like golden feathers. “You raised me too. You were my mother too” they say against the knot on their throat, barely avoiding breaking down into pieces. "I was angry at you for so long. And I blamed you, for the time that I lost. I didn't even want to know about what had happened to you." Adora turns to Catra, her eyes already turned towards them. There is understanding and patience in them and they give the reassurance Adora needs so desperately right now. "But I understand now. And I'm here now, and I forgive you." Adora closes their eyes tightly, letting the tears fall free from their face and onto Hope’s ragged dress. "I do. I do forgive you, Light Hope,"

Light Hope gasps, undoing herself in tears. The skin of her hands it's getting frighteningly cold, the shivers on her body lowering down more and more, limbs slack at her sides. Adora exhales, letting go of the hand that holds Hope's to place it closer to her chest. Light Hope frowns, trying and failing to move away, somehow still trying to scowl her, even now.

"Adora-"

"If you are not going to let me help you," says Adora, shaken. "Then at least let me take away the pain. Nobody deserves to suffer like this, no matter what you believe, not even you."

Their eyes fight for a second but at the end Light Hope gives in, letting her head fall back on Catra's hands. Adora's presses over her chest, gently, careful of not touching the wound or the arrow. Golden light pours out of their hand, slipping inside Lights Hope's skin and bones. The tension inside Hope's body starts to wash and she sighs in relief, searching for Adora and Catra's eyes with newfound clarity, grasping their wrists with her cold long fingers to make sure they are listening to her.

"She is not going to stop," she says, hoarse, urgent. "It doesn't matter that you destroyed de garnet, she will find another way to come back. She still can do a lot of hurt” Light Hope frowns, eyes sparking with the last strand of energy she can find inside herself. “I heard her plans, I know what she wants to do. She is obsessed with Finn, she knows that having them she can control the magic of the entire planet, doesn’t even need to recover all those souls that just got away. You need to finish this." Hope's voice is sharp, angry, but her eyes grow sad, losing their focus from them back to the stars above. "Mara never wanted you to carry this. She loved you, both of you. I could see it on her face, how much she missed you both, together. She died trying to create a better world for you, where you could be happy. And it's the weight you must bear now, for your child. I’m sorry it has to be like this.”

The shooting stars in the sky cast a silver light over Light Hope’s face, making her look carved in stone, even now. Slowly, almost gently, the light on her eyes starts to fade out, reflecting the light of the sky inside them, tears into shooting stars. The hold between Adora and Catra’s hands becomes impossibly tighter as they start to feel Light Hope’s body start to

relax. Between them, Hope inhales, shaky, one last time, her eyes widening just a little as she looks at the stars, blinking down to her.

“There she is. Look at her,” whispers Light Hope, a tiny smile spreading on her lips. Adora and Catra can’t see what she can but they can see the way her body starts to lighten up, shining, like millions of stars sparkling inside of her, making her swift like a feather. Light Hope gasps, eyelids heavy, the ghost of her smile dissolving alongside her. “Mara.”

Light Hope exhales, her body turning see through and then disappearing, becoming into a thousands of small golden sparks that float gently on the air, flying up and up with the breeze towards the sky, beyond the clouds and into the stars, making her home there forever. And for just a second, the stars seem to blink back in return, a new one born and nestled between the brightest of them all, right besides the eclipse shining incandescent in the sky.

Adora and Catra watch her go, breathless, tears pouring out of their eyes in rivers and waterfalls. Adora whimpers, sobs, bending over themself with a pained sobs, tearing its way from the inside of Adora’s mouth to the air. Catra holds them between her arms, nestling their face between the space on her neck and collarbones, rocking them slightly from side to side to calm them. The war keeps burning around them but Catra doesn’t talk or asks them to stop mourning, instead she buries her head too on the base on Adora’s neck, where their skin is warm against the metal of their armor and their hair is soft, and cries too. They stay like this, maybe for far too long, until Adora sighs, shaken and spent. She is still gripping the sides of Catra’s armor with force, breathing deeply in the smell of their wife before raising their head to her. Catra is already looking back, fond, and she smiles at Adora gently before leaning towards them and placing a sweet, ash tasting kiss over their mouth. Adora exhales against her lips, sounds finally catching up to them.

The heat of Melog’s fire is heating up the entire battlefield as they lighten up a Horde wing in the far end of the south. Glimmer is on the ground, punching with bare fist to a mercenary’s face as her magic burst arcane circle off the ground, eating up Horde soldier after soldier. Bow is beside her, leading the archers into battle with firm steps. On the castle, Scorpia has woken up, stirring in Perfuma’s hold. Her eyes are rimmed in red and when she straightens up completely, red lightning whips out of her pincers at will, sending a dozen mercenaries coming her way flying back with only one hit.

On the other end of the battlefield, making his way across the field leaving a trail of Etherian warriors behind, Emperor Prime marches towards them with his mechanical bow held at the level of his eyes, getting rid of everything that crosses his way, either Etherian, Horde or mercenary, he doesn’t care anymore. The look on his eyes is maddening, neon green blood dripping from the side of his head and into his usually pristine robes. Adora looks at him walk from the corner of their eye, pupils and scleras bleeding back into golden, biting the inside of their cheek so hard she can taste the blood in the base of her tongue as she w@y he’s him shot arrow behind arrow, steal burning the skin of fae and wounding etherian, salinean, first one and magicat alike. Adora doesn’t hate, it’s not in her nature. But right now, she does. She feels the dark void of rage and hate boiling on their blood and traveling all the way across their body, every single muscle and limb and organ. She can still feel the faint traces of Light Hope’s soul rising to the stars, her blood still staining the palms of their hands

and the surface of the armor. Adora can feel Catra breathing besides them and her mind spirals, because Prime tried to kill Catra and he is still coming towards them and Adora hates.

Catra cradles Adora's face between both of her hands, returning their sight towards her. Her eyes are still teary but her face has recovered the fierce determination that Adora loves so much. Catra rests her forehead against Adora's, the metal of their helmets clanking together lightly.

"I want to go home," whispers Catra, her sweet breath hitting Adora's nose softly. Adora inhales, nodding, the boiling inside her blood tampering down with Catra's touch. Adora moves, taking Catra's hand between hers, rubbing her knuckles with their thumbs a few times before letting go of them, reaching for the handle of Excalibur, fallen unceremoniously in the moss next to their feet.

"We are," assures Adora, voice low and tense, helping Catra back on her feet. Adora cradles Catra's face between their hand, messing the short now free strands of curly hair there. Adora presses their foreheads together again, sweetly but almost desperately too, slick skin with sweat and dirt and traces of blood. Both of them close their eyes again for a second, breathing in each other's heavy scent, fingers digging into skin as they hold each other just one second longer. "We are. I promised it. For Finn"

They turn towards the castle hand in hand, watching Prime approach even closer, weapon in hand and high, blowing hits and kicks towards the knights and soldiers and warriors that try to slow his march, dodging him as best as they can after Adora gave the explicit order to not confront him. And as best as their warriors are, even when he is isolated and under unyielding attack, Prime is still big and imposing. One piece of huge machinery, iron instead of skin, daggers instead of fingers. He doesn't need to recover his breath, or mend his wounds, at least not in the state he is right now. If they truly want to beat him for good, they also need to take him off from the root, from the very base of his rotten soul.

Near the place where Prime it's walking, a patch of the ground darkens and dies when an arcane circle burns itself over the ground, from the very inside out. From it, like crawling its way out of the very pits of hell, multiple long arms of dark liquid burst out in lava flows, rising themselves from the earth in an unrecognizable form. The shadow lifts its weight from the ground with its unnatural long arms, dripping long drops of sticky substance into the ground, killing everything that it touches, sizzling as oil against fire. The shadow raises its shapeless head, just a void of darkness and despair looking straight into Catra and Adora's direction, multiple limbs crawling and clawing and dragging themselves over the field in a slow but sure motion. From inside the shadows' head, two flames float, red dots that crave their way inside the regents minds and of everyone that looks at it directly for more than a couple seconds, turning their chests into ice and stone, bearing themselves inside their skins and rising violent goosebumps down everyone's spines. It's a shape torn from the most horrifying nightmares, those where your body hasn't caught up with your mind and you are exposed and vulnerable, lying there unable to move as the witch climbs its way over your chest and sits there to watch you scream inside your head for hours to end. The shadow gives a step, if it can be called that, and then another, making the newly alive ground burn and die and shake, the very rocks melting into shapeless forms. The witch raises it's voided head

towards the luminous sky and *screeches,* a scream without mouth or throat that rips its way across the entire kingdom, making the very stars to shiver and dim for just a second.

A shiver travels down Catra’s back but she holds her ground, squeezing Adora’s long fingers between hers one last time before letting go completely from their hand. When they turn towards her, eyebrows shoot up in confusion, she just nods towards Prime, lips pressed together tightly.

“You go for Prime,” and then lower, told between clenched teeth. “I’ll take care of the witch.”

Adora’s eyebrows lower into a deep frown almost immediately, considering her for some long seconds before they lean forward, catching her chin between their fingers and placing one long, exasperated kiss over her mouth, breathing hard. It doesn’t last long but the meaning of it it’s heavy behind the bruising brush of their lips.

"Be careful," whispers Adora around a growl, making the fine fur on Catra's neck stand on point.

"Always am," she murmurs back, breathless.

Adora lets go of her completely, hesitantly, turning partially their body in time to catch with their bare hand another arrow coming directly to their head. Catra inhales sharply, eyes widening as Adora considers the sharp point of the arrow mere inches from their face, still sizzling with electricity. Adora grunts, squeezing the arrow between their hand until it breaks into pieces for the pressure alone, iron bending like mere paper. Adora locks eyes with its origin, the golden of her eyes into the neon green of Prime, who just clenches his teeth, hard, and reloads the weapon without breaking eye contact.

The shadow demon screeches horribly again, one of its multiple arms coming up to tear at its own beads, pouring free big drops of darkness from the exposed wound that shift into their own shapeless figures, abominations that crawl in the ground as parasites, wrapping themselves over everything they comes across, suffocating them between their shadow arms without a second thought. They approach swiftly towards them, tearing apart both Hordians and Etherians all the same.

Catra growls at the sight of this, digging her ankles deep in the rich, once alive earth at her feet, conjuring the night once more and all the stars she commands. Behind her, beyond the battlefield scattered with magical and horde blood and sweat, past the woods the surround the stolen kingdom and the ruins of countless others, destroyed for hubris and ambition, into the biting cold of the north, the Northern Mountains exhale. Their rocks tremble, first gently then harder, then a devastating earthquake, shaking the white snow from their shoulders before the mountains stir and open their eyes, stone cold and yet somehow so alive. The heavy rocks shiver and move and then *breathe* , and then just as the shadows that threaten to tear the whole battlefield apart, stone arms come across the thick bases of the Whispering Woods and push themselves up.

Catra's eyes darken, bleeding back into the night. She opens her mouth again, fae words spilling out of it as she speaks to the mountains, bringing them back alive as they were at the very beginning of the times, before they fell into their deep slumber. Adora looks at her, eyes

wide. She can't make sense of the words, they sound like rumbles and purrs and somehow like songs too. As if a siren had made her way out of the sea and become her wife, commanding the mountains into breathing giants. Catra growls, the words crawling out of her mouth as sliders as she points towards the witch's shadow and the battlefield around them. Even from so far away, the mountains look at her, quietly and then raise their humongous heads towards the Horde and back at her, nodding once, slow but powerful and leaning slightly, hovering above the planet as they bow towards Catra respectfully before giving one sure, violent step forward.

On the battlefield someone shouts. And then another and another, a trail of screams coming from the Horde army as they watch the mountains approach them closer and closer, over fields and the hills and lakes and rivers and remains of fallen kingdoms and the sands of the Crimson, somehow careful of not hurting anything else on their wake but fierce still as they arrive.

"Giants!" somehow screams close to Adora's head, or maybe far away, it's difficult saying with so many Horde soldiers suddenly screaming and tripping over themselves as they away for their lives.

Catra snaps her head again from the giants's direction, carving into Adora's chest as she speaks in a low, harsh tone. "Go"

Adora's amazement remains but she falls back into the cold minded of a warrior almost instantly, nodding to his wife before turning back to Prime. Adora holds Excalibur between his hands and gives a harsh swing sending most of the Horde standing between him and Prime flying away in a mess of white and green chainmail. Prime grinds his teeth, shooting electric arrow behind electric arrow towards Adora in a violent frenzy. Adora covers his face with the surface of the sword, dodging the arrow with expert ease as they make their way to Prime swiftly.

In the battlefield, spark of strong lilac light illuminate the field, in different directions and Adora can barely make the shape of Glimmer as she teleports from one side to the other, somehow collecting knight after knight of their own army and taking them to different points. It all seems chaotic until the earthquakes in the earth finally reach them and with them the imposing figure of the giants. It all clicks into place when the giants step inside the battlefield and bend, swiping handfuls of Horde soldiers between their rock hands like mere ants.

The giants presence is suffocating, the temperature drooling almost immediately into a freezing point that makes the dew of the grass to freeze and crack. On the sky, Melog surrounds the heads of the giants with a fierce roar, following their steps as the dragon inflamates rows and rows of fields full of Horde into blue flames, cold against burning heat.

Catra focus her sight back into the shadow creature, moving as a shadow herself until she is almost invisible under the eclipse's light. The witch turns her shapeless head to the sides, bending it in unnatural ways, looking for Catra among the shadows with bright red eyes. A silver beam of moonlight bursts from between the shadows casted over the field and crashes against the witch, burning her side with a devious blast. The witch screams again, this time lashing its multiple hands towards the once the beam came from, barely missing Catra at all when she jumps out of the way, rolling towards the front and casting another beam in the

creature's direction. This time a shit of sharp crystals crash directly against the creature's face, hitting with so much force that bursts of black blood fall in splashes to the ground, accompanied by an acute scream and a shiver.

Around her, the smaller shadows charge against Catra, grabbing her ankles and legs with their sharp hands and making her and the beam stumble. Sharp pain shoots up Catra's right leg and she yells, drops of blood falling down her ankle from the scratches the shadows' nails dig into her skin. The help calls Melog's attention even so far away because the dragon turns their head to her and charges forward, blowing fireballs towards the shadows all around Cats and extinguishing them mercilessly between the fire. Catra covers her face but the blue fire never touches her, dancing and licking at her feet but not burning her at all.

Catra takes a moment while the witch screams in rage to recover her breath and send a grateful look towards her winged friend before clasping her palms together, sending another blast of silver and purple and colorful light directly to the witch's chest, fighting to break in pieces the thick armor of nightmare shadows she had surrounded herself with.

On the other side of the middle of the field, Adora grabs the sword with one hand, scrunching a little while she is running to brush the other one against the dark earth. At her touch the ground bubbles up and opens, blossoming in small cocoons of bright light that pour out with gentle force just to burst out in almost violent beauty towards the sky. Golden trees are born from the bare earth with an explosion, rising higher and higher up as their branches unfold and bloom, beautiful gold leaves sprouting from them and casting sunbeams into the battlefield. The trees grow higher, twisting and bending over themselves until their branches seem to be holding each other in a golden braid, surrounding the space around Adora and Prime and encapsulating them there from the rest of the battlefield. From in between the trunks, their figures can still be seen by the rest of the field, circling each other in a slow dance

Adora narrows her eyes, her winged headpiece casting shadows over her cheekbones, making her look regal and sharp and dangerous. The light of the golden trees reflects in her white armor, shining with a blinding light that makes Prime squint against his will. Prime scoffs, dropping the arch to reach behind him, where a long, white sword hangs from the swirls of his robes. The blade is huge, longer than Excalibur and massive on Prime pristine hands, the blade dangerously sharp. He dangles the weapon between his iron fingers. Iron against iron. And he smiles at Adora, pearl teeth flashing with the magic light too.

"Guess we will need to introduce ourselves on these conditions after all, King Pendragon" Prime tilts his head, a mocking salute towards Adora that lacks any honest emotions behind it besides anger.

The last of the White Castle crumbles into dust, raising clouds of sand and dirt that blow the leaves of the golden trees lightly. Prime doesn't turn back but his false expression falls, replaced by grave disgust before lightening up again, reaching towards the blade of his sword to scratch his nails against its surface, clicking his tongue.

"Iron, of the highest quality," he says, tapping the sword before turning his none eyes to Adora. The deep wound Catra made on the side of his face sizzles with energy and Adora can see the anger behind the blind eyes there. She grips tighter her sword. "I heard a rumor, your

beautiful wife and her kind have certain- *reaction* to iron, don't they?" Adora bites the inside of her own cheek, rabid, the sharpness of her teeth making golden ichor spill inside her tongue. Prime must see the twitch on her face because his smile is sly and genuine as he runs the pad of his metal finger over the point. "It would be a real pity, that a blade as magnificent as this one, would burn the skin of someone as beautiful."

Adora's heart is thundering inside his chest, adrenaline running inside his veins like lava, pooling in the low of his stomach and pouring inside their dry mouth in acid. Adora knows what he is doing, trying to make him lose it so Adoea can be distracted enough by the obvious threat to charge against him mindlessly. Instead, Adora exhales, hot steam leaving their mouth again, a mirror of Melog as they breathe fire at some point above their heads.

Adora's eyes are shining below the headpiece, golden and blue. She scowls at Prime, basically hissing at him, white teeth stained in the gold of her own blood as she puts a stop on their circular dance, her heavy red cape floating softly behind her. Adora straightens up in all their height, never once losing track of Prime when they speak out loud, their voice echoing like a thousand other ones across the field.

"You know? I'm getting really sick of you."

Adora charges against Prime with no warning, throwing her entire weight in the swing of Excalibur this face. Prime pristine blade meets her half way, barely stopping her sudden attack with clenched teeth. Adora huffs, throwing her arms forwards to unstabilize him. Prime steps back, the metal on his hair and arms and legs stretching and steaming as if recharging themselves before throwing himself this time over Adora. Adora catches the sword with the back of Excalibur's, twisting it and with it Prime's arm, keeping him for a few seconds in a locked position.

Prime yelps, wrapping his other hand around Adora's uncovered neck and squeezing hard. Adora gasps, letting go of Excalibur's handle with one hand to reach behind her back, grabbing the smooth surface of a smaller handle, white gold shimmering on the dagger as she flips it out of its hidden container on her waist and brings it up and forward, stabbing Prime in the side with all her strength, exactly where his right lung should be. Prime screams, letting go of Adora's neck and stumbling back to grasp at the dagger, pulling it out unceremoniously and without care. Neon green blood starts dripping out of the wound, the scarred metal of his his and jarred material of his robes quickly staining in green and then blacks too as the blood starts mixing with black liquid, oozing of the opening and splashing into the moss. Adora huffs, bringing absently her hand towards her neck to feel the tender skin of her neck before slamming the same arm in front of her, punching Prime in the face with her bare hand. Something else must break because Prime yowls in anger and when he turns his face back to Adora, the deformity on his metal face is stained in fury. Some of his eyes have cracked under the strength of Adora's hit and the skin like layer that makes his mouth has ripped in half, making the structures of his teeth and gums to show from the angle of the mouth all the way to the earlobe. Inside the gap, small spark are going off, short circuiting where Adora made the connections snap in two and hang on there miserably.

Adora's breath hitches, mildly horrified, but hey grab the sword again with both hands, holding it at the level of their eyes as they wait for Prime to move. He seems to be regaining

himself again because his knuckles screech with how hard he holds his own sword, this time also dangling Adora's dagger with the other hand, considering Adora as well. His fingers switch over the dagger at the same time something snaps next to Adora's ear and they turn in time to watch Prime crush a small green sphere between his fingers, unleashing a string of lighting that hits Adora's directly in the side of their face.

Adora tries to dodge it by jumping to the side only to fall straight into Prime's trap as he swings his sword, smashing it on the side of Adora's head. The small ring hanging from a chain hidden between Adora's underclothes vibrates and shines, covering Adora in a swift blanket of silver light, so the irrational sharp blade of Prime's sword doesn't cut, even if it was meant to. But it does knock of the helmet from Adora's head, the golden winged headpiece clanking in the ground and away from their feet. Prime growls in anger, swinging the other arm with Adora's blade toward them. Adora raises their arm towards their face, covering it as best as they can while they fight the sudden dizziness the hit with the electricity has brought them, ears clogged making everything sound like under water. This time, the dagger does catches them slightly, cutting the back of Adora's hand and their glove and slashing the downhill of their cheek with the sharp end.

Adora exhales and growls, kicking Prime in the chest to push him away from her. Golden blood drops off the open wound on her cheek and hand, dripping down her neck and staining her armor. Her ears are slowly stopping from ringing and the nausea and acid that had pooled on their throat is lowering down. She doesn't have much time to recover herself because Prime attacks her almost immediately, dropping the dagger and motioning the sword this time directly to Adora's neck.

Adora presses their free hand against the charged air around them, closing their fist and then shooting it towards Prime. Above them, the light of the eclipse shivers and bright tentacles burst from it, traveling above the battlefield and to the place where Adora is standing, surrounding them completely like ropes of gold. Adora twirls Excalibur and with it the ropes twirl to, dissolving in dozens of small fireflies that fly to Prime, placing themselves over his body. Prime growls, trying to smashing them away with the palm of his hand. The iron sizzles against them, heating up more and more the more he keep hitting them until they still suddenly and explote, small bombs of sun light setting Prime on golden fire.

Feet away, the shadow creature listens to Prime scream at the top of his lungs, turning its dark head to him and watching him scramble inside the space between the golden trees, trying to drown out the fire. The creature hisses, another deformed arm cracking and twisting outside of its body and reaching towards Adora's direction. Catra hisses, dangerously, still holding the moon beam with one hand and stretching the other to the golden trees, her voice coming out in tight pants between her prolonged sharp teeth.

"Oh no, you won't," Catra motions at the golden trees and then forward, calling out to them in her fae tongue. Golden roots blowout of the earth the the moss, lashing like whips to the shadow creature and wrapping themselves around its limbs and unnatural neck, chaining it down to the ground in a vice grip. Catra exhales, the tip of her fae horns twisting on her own hair when she turns back to the witch. "You bitch."

On Catra's free hand, a silver spear forms itself out of nothing, long, so long, with a sword cutting point that shimmers with runes carved over it. Catra drives her hand back and throws the ethereal spear towards the shadow creature, stabbing it across the neck and pinning it too to the ground. The creature screams and fights against its restraints without victory, the roots only holding it deeper and deeper down as Catra's moon beam slowly but surely starts to crack it away.

On the golden circle, Prime slams himself against the trees, the continuous hits and the steam escaping from the seams of his limbs somehow successfully extinguishing the flames. Adora is resting against one of the trees, panting as they try to recover their breath and look at Prime with held breath. They are exhausted, drained after using so much magic in such amounts. The slash on their cheek has stopped bleeding but still sting on their skin painfully, too focused on the battle to take the time and magic energy to repair it. Prime stops screaming and when he turns back to them, Adora's heart stops a beat, cold running down their spine. The fire has burnt most of Prime's outer robes and made its way inside his metal limbs. The once white and pristine metal of his body is now charred, darkened by the heat of the fire and the smoke. Nobody should be able to survive as much as he has, burnt, with an open wound over his lung and his face ripped. But then again, he is not etherian, nor first one, not anything anymore. Adora isn't even sure if he is *alive* at all.

Prime scrunches and grabs his fallen sword, oscillating it from side to side, limbs still smoking with heat. He brings the sword up and then down but instead of going towards Adora he turns behind him, digging it inside the golden trees behind him with twisted anger. Adora gasps, surprised, the pull inside the magic twisting her stomach when the blade digs deeper inside the trees, darkening them and making its light dim. Adora clenches her teeth, separating herself from the trees she is leaning into, to meet Prime in the middle of the circle as he advances too, the clasp of metal against metal resonating across the entire field like church bells.

Prime twists his sword from one hand to the other, hitting Adora in the shoulder with the surface of the sword while his other hand turns to wrap on Adora's long ponytail, yanking their head back harshly. Adora yells, both from the pain on their head and for the pain in their shoulder as the sword cuts a deep gash, past the gold and steel of Adora's armor and the silver of their chainmail, across the shoulder blade and down to their collarbones. Ador whimpers against their closed lips, refusing to give Prime the satisfaction and scream. Horrified, Adora looks as part of Prime's burnt face gives up and crumbles down, leaving behind only the ghost of an iron skeleton and green wires poking from the cavity.

"That's enough of your tricks, Pendragon" says Prime, still gripping the base of Adora's head, exposing their neck into a vulnerable position as he raises his sword once more. Adora's eyes widen and she inhales, sharply, warding all the air inside her lungs before exhaling long and lethal, breathing fire from her mouth directly into Prime's face.

Prime growls, stumbling back as he bates the flames away, clenching over the ground. Adora gasps, throat and lungs scratched and weary from the magic fire, muscles screaming with exhaustion, bending as she holds herself against one of the trees, pressing her free hand against the part of the wound she can reach, dampening almost immediately, sticky and stained with gold blood. Adora hears Prime stir and she tries to straighten up a second too

late, when a handful of earth Prime had managed to scrape out of the ground hits her in the face when he throws it at her, a dirty trick that makes the dirt inside her eyes itch and burn.

Prime spins, elbowing Adora straight in the mouth and making her lose balance for a precious, valuable second. She hears the sizzle again before it comes but her body fails her to react on time and Prime grips the chest of her armor with his knife cutting nails, sending a shock of raw, painful electricity across Adora's entire body. Adora screams, even though she tries not to, her consciousness blacking in and out as she bends over herself, the shocks of being electrocuted making her muscles spasm painfully against themselves. Prime takes advantage of it and knocks Excalibur out of Adora's twitching hand, sending it flying several feet away, landing with a soft thud among the rocks, who seem to take life of their own because they shift and twist, encapsulating the blade of the sword among them. Above Adora and Prime, the golden trees shiver and disappear into hundreds of golden moths, flying weekly around them and scattering across the field quickly.

The scream reaches Catra's ears and she snaps her head towards Adora, losing focus as the silver light on her hands hesitates. The witch sees the flicker and she takes it, one of her ungodly hands shooting forwards and catching Catra directly on her side. The dark nails dig into Catra's skin, slightly below her rips, ripping the armor like nothing and slashing long lines of red in there.

It's not too deep but it hurts just the same. Catra gasps, a drowned scream escaping her lips and ripping her throat as her knees buckle and she collapses in the ground, grasping handfuls of earth to keep herself grounded. Her vision swims, blacking out for a couple moments as she tries to recover her breath. The golden roots have disappeared with the trees and the creature stands up again, gripping the spear with one of its hands and taking it off slowly and deliberately, crushing the silver between its crooked fingers once it's completely out. The shadow creature advances towards her, neck bending in a strange angle, dripping gushes of dark blood. The witch hovers over Catra's form as it scrunches and wraps the same hand, dripping with black liquid and Catra's blood around her throat, pinning her down the ground with all its weight. All the air leaves Catra's lungs as her back slams against the rocks and she grunts, whimpering. Catra twists in the witch's hold and tries to drag herself away as much as she can, crawling deep grooves with her nails, her tail lashing from side to side violently.

Catra turns her head towards Adora, tears slipping out of her eyes. One of her hands comes up, wrapping around the creature's own arm, ripping lines of dark blood as she struggles to breath and to break up. Her other hand stretches over the earth towards Adora's direction, watching with watery eyes as Prime hovers over her wife, shocking them with another wave of merciless lightning.

"A- Adora," gasps Catra in a threat of a voice, inhaling painfully as she tries to breathe. " -dora"

" *You won't be able to protect her,"* slithers out the creature, Shadow Weaver's voice distorted from inside of it, dripping rage and hate and a hint of victory on it. Around them, the battle is raging on, everybody containing the Horde at some point of the battlefield. Even Melog and the giants as they take off huge cannons stationed on the hills around. Nobody can truly help them right now and Weaver knows it. " *Your Adora will die now and as always you will be*

useless in saving her. You will have brought her again to her destruction and this time there will be no coming back for them. For neither of you."

Catra grunts, lowering the hand that tries and fails to reach Adora from so far away, struggling with her legs and feet around the oozing shadows around her dripping over her face and chest and making her fight for air. Catra huffs, mumbling under her breath as she manages to hover her hand around her ankle. The shadow cradles over her, lowering its face as close towards Catra's as it can.

"What was that, kitty?"

Without the shadow noticing it, Catra finds what she was looking for, wrapping her hand over the smooth handle of a white gold dagger, twin of Adora's own, hidden on the belts of her leg. Catra swings it out of her leg, holding it in front of her with a vicious scowl, allowing the creature for just a second more to understand what it's happening before it can even pretend to stop it. Catra exhales, repeating her words.

"Fuck off"

Catra stabs the creature's face with the dagger, deep, as deep as she can reach, the blade breaking tense shadows and tendrils of darkness, pouring dark blood from the wound as Catra keeps it in place with all that she has. The creature *screams,* letting go from Catra's throat to try and wrap around her arms, only to stumble when its limbs flick and start to dissolve, magic draining from the wound. The draining spell Catra had carved into the dagger starts to work out, ripping the witch out of the remains of her magic. It's slow and it *hurts* , making her black magic hiss when it touches the ground and then disappear completely into clouds of thick smoke. Catra locks eyes with the red ones of the witch, a scream making its way out of Catra's mouth and into the air, ripping across her ribcage with all the pain and the anger and the suffering she has inside, letting it all out in one yell that resounds across the entire kingdom, breaking glass into sand, bending the top of the trees and throwing the Horde soldiers into the ground in fear.

Adora rolls their head to the side to look in Catra's direction, called by her scream. They watch with clenched teeth as Catra confronts her abuser's abomination, staining her face in darkness as the witch's black magic starts to drift away. Prime turns his head toward them too, still holding Adora's side in a vice grip, clicking his tongue against his teeth with mild amusement.

"The witch was going to die soon, anyway," he says, no remorse at all as he sees Shadow Weaver deflating more and more, the abomination trembling and wearing away. He almost sounds like he finds the entire situation funny. Maybe he does. "Her rotten magic had no place in the purified world I will create once you are all gone. I don't need her anymore. You all brought yourselves to me already and I'll find a way to transfer to a newer vessel myself."

Prime lets go of Adora's armor, dropping them to the ground only to place his knee above their chest, wrapping both of his hands back into his sword, lazyly, almost enjoying the moment.

"The great Pendragon legacy, finally kneeling before me in the dirt where you belong" he says, mockingly, his broken face stretching into a false smirk. "Don't worry, you won't be able to see it, but one way or another, all things in this precious world of yours will be cleansed. I'll make sure to pay your wife and your precious, precious little bsby a visit once we are done here."

Something clicks inside Adora, something vile and nasty and boiling, untamed and savage, primordial, creeping its way through Adora's body all the way from the tip of their fingers to the center of their chest, still and somehow, washing a cold wave of sharpness inside their mind, washing any other thought away. She knows what she had to do, Light Hope said it herself before dying by the very same men that now threatens to stab her to death. Adora knows what she has to do and she is tired and there will be no going back. That's alright, Adora won't regret it once it's done.

Adora is not afraid to die. She already did it once.

Prime made two critical mistakes. Threatening her family and thinking Adora would be too afraid of dying to not fight back.

Before Prime can even begin to lower his blade down, Adora shoots forward, sinking almost her entire hand inside the open wound on Prime's rib cage. It feels strange, wet and soft but also harsh, the edges of broken metal and wires scratching Adora's fingers, green blood-like liquid pooling on her palm and sliding down the steel of her arm, dripping into the grass in a puddle. Prime's body it's not real but it must be connected to him in some way because he absolutely yowls in pain, the remaining of his eyes widening in absolute shock as he drops the sword, moving his body away from Adora's hand, the sharp of the weapon barely missing Adora's side at all.

Prime rages on, slapping Adora so hard her nose starts bleeding right away, trying to throw himself over her away. But Adora doesn't even give him the chance, gobbing out a gush of spit and blood and throwing her hands in front of her, holding Prime's head away from her as he wrestles against her, trying to get a hold of her neck. Adora growls, moving one of her hands towards the deep wound on his cheek, slipping her fingers inside his mouth and pulling down, *hard.*

Metal can't stretch and yet it does, ripping like mere fabric as Adora pulls from Prime's mouth, wiring and artificial layers of skin giving up, the metal that replaces bone cracking under the stress and breaking down in sharp pieces as it gives up and falls completely, dangling in Adora's hand miserably as Prime jolts up and away, stumbling on his own feet while he feels in almost a confused motion inside the cavity where half of his face is now missing.

Adora stands up too, regarding the metal jaw between her fingers with a cold, inexpressive face before blindly throwing it aside at some point of the grass. Prime's knees buckle and give out, kneeling in the moss stained in golden and neon green in irregular patches. The wires that connect the pain sensores must have finally go off because he has stabilized slightly, unavoidably panting as he tries to regain his focus. He looks up, to Adora, bloodied and brusie , hair battered and ruffled from the fight, armor bent and scratched and still shinning like a bright sun above him. She approaches him slowly, almost gently, watching as

Prime places his eyes on his sword and tries to reach it just to kick it away easily and without a second thought, out of his reach. He scoffs, a sound between a mockery and a gush of spit, dropping his head backwards to look at her directly in the eyes.

"I thought you were supposed to be the kind one," he says, clear and loud even without a mouth anymore, the voice just slightly distorted, like a music box that has been placed underwater but that it's still running. Adora tilts her head slightly to the side, like considering, their hair forming a halo of gold around their head.

"There is no kindness for monsters like you."

Prime chuckles, actually fucking chuckles, leaning his head to the side as he regards Adora with almost pity on his eyes.

"Because I got rid of a few weeds in the path? For destroying your precious kingdoms? Banishing your forsaken magic?" Prime scoffs, opening his arms to the sides. If he had still a mouth, he would be smiling. "My mission is sacred, I am holy among all of you. You can't put a stop to what it's meant to happen." His eyes are insane, artificial pupils retracted in mere pinpoints, making the green inside of them pop of unnaturally as everything else on him. "Do you think you are better that me? Look at what you have done to me. You are ruthless, violent. How long will it be untim all that rabid magic turns against those you swore to love? You are just like me and you are just like your great grandfather."

The words hang in the air, heavy, meant to cut and rip and hurt deeply. But they don't, they crash against Adora and slip off like nothing, voided against the thundering of their own heart on their ears. Their hands are steady, stopping mere inches in front of Prime so he has to really stretch his neck to look at their face as Adora shakes their head.

"I am not" she negates, voice firm, not once waving with uncertainty of fear. "I'm nothing like Uther or Arthur. Nothing even like my mother. I am my own person, and you will not take my family from me ever again." They grab Prime's cheekbones, not letting him look away for even a second as they lean over him, frowning, blinking slowly and lazy. There is acid on Adora's mouth when they speak again, the field suddenly drop death quiet around them. "Who is the one kneeling now?"

Prime chokes, feeling the actual strength behind Adora's home on his face. His arms twitch at his sides, wanting to move, but the injuries on his artificial body are too wide, many fuel already loose and still spilling down. So he just looks at her, cheeks widening as he gives another deformed smile in return.

"Go on then, make dispose of this body. Your ancestors have tried many times to do the same and I will return, always."

Adora hums, sweetly, almost like the dissaproved coo of a mother as she shakes her head again, moving her hands so she can wrap them over Prime's metal hair, holding his eyes up towards her face. "I am not going to do that, I know it would be useless" Adora narrows their eyes, cold expression breaking for a moment to let through how truly angry they are. "You know, you pick up a thing or two when your should is ripped out of your body. For someone who praises himself of wanting to clenease the world from any kind of magic, you certainly

use lot of it to transfer your sould from body to body." Prime's breath stops, and for the first time on his life, an actual shiver runs down his spine. "I imagine it was hard, at the beginning. How many fae creatures did you hurt to help you survive? And then, Shadow Weaver, she must have taught you how to do it yourself, into this silly tincans you call an Emperor's body. You'll see, I also had *a lot* of time to think."

Adora leans over him, hovering, like a white and golden owl over their pry, gripping Prime's chest with her blunt nails, right in the middle where his heart should have been.

"I'm sure you tried to rip yourself apart to get rid of your own magic and fullfil this *holy mission* you have going on, but the truth is, you don't understand magic at all. It lives inside all of us, inside every rock and tree and sea and animal. It lives inside of you, even if you don't want it, it does." The grip inside Prime's chest becomes vicious, until Adora's hand passes through . Not across metal and wiring, no. *Through* . Between the layers of dark magic until she wraps it around a small, cold thing, so harsh and frozen it might had just been a tiny rock at the side of the lake at home. Prime trembles violently, feeling, actually really feeling Adora's hand wrapping around his soul. "So no, Anilis Khur. I am not going to kill you. I am going to burn the soul out of you so you can never, ever come back again."

Adora's hand around Prime's frozen soul starts to warm up, something he take that feels like a thousand hell flames for Prime, sending him on a spiral of desperated yelps, wrestling uselessly on Adora's grip and slaying against her arms, trying to hurt her enough that she lets go and he can slip free. But Adora doesn't relent, the iron nails of Prime's hand cutting deep wounds that illuminate and heal instantly. Actually, Adora's entire arm starts to glow again, up tl her shoulder and spreading down her chest and his and legs, up to her neck and face, bright like a giant star, brighter than anything on that battlefield except for the moon shinning on her back. On Adora's forehead, above the war paint, an actual sun starts to carve in the skin there, never once painful, an omen of magic and Adora's true power and nature as the golden magic travels in an out of Prime's soul, burning away all the shadows and the cold with her touch.

Prime starts screaming, this rime for real, leaving the other yells on the battle like mere jokes in comparison. He can feel the way the golden magic flods his entire soul, illuminating it with unyielding peace and quiet and he rejects it, he rejects it all, struggling like a mad man on Adora's soft and lethal touch.

The magic keeps spreading and spreading, cracking the ethereal surface of his soul like glass under pressure, pouring out beams of sunlight that make the cavities.on his android body to light up and shine. Adora can feel his frustration, his hate, his rejection towards the magic, all the way to the tip of her toes as she conduces the magic inside instead of away. Adora can feel it too, the small thread, threatening to snaps away any moment now and wash it all away. Before it can happen, Adora leans towards him, locking their eyes together, making sure that Prime looks at her and only her as his soul starts to give away, returned to the order of things in the universe and far away from where it can do harm again.

"You have no destiny," says Adora, furious under the whisper that is their voice but calm all the same, sure of themself and what they can and will do. Free at least of the chains they had put over themself. "We make our own future. You have no mission, no kingdom, no army.

You don't know the touch of friends, or companions," Adora's voice lowers into a growl, rivaling the dragon's roaring in the sky, a very dragon herself, made of flesh and gold and sunlight and sudden absolute hate. "You don't know the love of a family and you tried to take *mine* . My wife, my *baby* . There lies your biggest mistake. I would have given you mercy but you tried to hurt those who make my heart. You only earned pity and hate, and you will depart this universe and the next with nothing else but that. That and the magic you so much hate."

Prime yells, making Adora's ears ring, but it doesn't matter. His soul is cracking, bending and swelling, like a volcano just about to burst out from inside his chest. Adora forces his head up, grip so strong he can't even begin to try to look away.

"It's sad you won't get to see the world, me and my family will create, and for that, I have nothing but pity for you." In Adora's hand, actual darkness starts to drip down, broken and dissolved by the golden light born from her fingers.

Adora has become pure light, a column of luminiferous light traveling from the sky to the place they are standing, the very sun fallen from the sky and into the field, shining even more as the moonlight creates a halo like a crown around their head. Prime screams again, out of anger and rage and frustration, trashing on Adora's hold without managing anything out of it, cursing and threatening her until the box of his voice is worn out and harsh.

"I am going to kill you! I will rise again and I'm going to kill you and everything you love in front of you and you won't be able to do anything to stop it!" It's a horrifying scene, Prime's eyes out, half of his face missing, green liquid and spit-like substance dripping and staining Adora's face as he struggles and spits at her, his green serpent tongue hanging free down his neck now that his entire jaw is gone. There is nothing on his face but hate. Adora exhales, the fury on their expression falling into calm, the boiling rage on her veins tampering as she sees this pathetic creature grip himself to the last strands of his hate to survive. She is not like him, or like her grandfather. She won't let hate drive her mad too.

"No," Adora says in a murmur, gentle, sure. She can feel how loved she is, inside her worn out bones and aching joints and thundering heart. This is what makes her better than him, this is what makes her know Prime has no place there anymore. "You've been here for far too long, it's time for you to go." Adora closes her hand against the ethereal energy, grasping the last rotten magic strands still loving in there and keeping it alive, pulling from the soul and then taming it down, fluttering it out like a candle against the winds of a tornado, like thick darkness breaking apart by the sunrise, until the soul dims and consumes completely and with it, everything that makes Prime, leaving only one more piercing and bloodshot scream behind.

Adora's light explodes like a supernova, washing all the shadows away with the power of its blast. The deep night illuminates back to sunrise, all the remaining Horde soldiers dropping their weapons immediately and trying to scatter away. Even the giants and Melog stop, frozen for one suspended moment to look at the bright golden light covering it all. In the creature's direction, where Catra still has the white dagger stabbed deeply inside their face, the sun rays reach them as gold arms, piercing the shadow creature like a thousand swords, illuminating it from the inside destroying the last weak remains of its carcass for good. The abomination

gives one last piercing scream, lashing one of its already disappearing claws towards Catra, marking three superficial scratches on her face before folding over itself and bursting in oozing pieces across the entire field.

Catra lets go of the dagger, covering her face with her arms to avoid the boiling hot shadows to burn her as they sizzle and suffocate. A few feet in front of where she is laying, the heavy thud of a hit lets her know something has fallen from inside the shadow creature, hitting against the ground unceremoniously and heavy.

The light remains strong for a couple more minutes and then starts to die down, slowly, leaving golden sparks floating gently over the entire battlefield, justo hovering there like fireflies, not moving. Adora exhales and lets go of Prime's chest, stepping back. She is panting as she sees what it's left of Prime's artificial body, only a carcass of iron and destroyed wires, still kneeling in the ground that starts to bloom all around him, tiny sprouts of green and pink that start to climb over the soulless body's limbs. Prime's head, or what remains of it falls forward and towards his chest, hanging there with no strength at all. The eyes that aren't scratched off or broken are dull, numb grey behind their crystal surface. It looks like a doll, a void puppet, with the black magic strings that held it cut clean off.

Adora pants, fighting to recover as they watch the small blooms wrap themselves in Prime's body, surrounding him until he is nothing more than metal consumed by moss and flowers, rotting the iron away. The carcass yields upon the pressure and crumbles down, falling in irregular and unrecognizable pieces into the ground, remaining there to rust be forever forgotten.

Adora tries to straighten up, not being able to look away from the place where Prime has fallen, turning down their eyes to look at their hands, shivering violently in front of her. The skin of her hands and forearms is stained, not quite as if it was burnt and more as if Adora had dipped her arms inside golden paint. Adora huffs, confused, trying to shake her head off the numbness, pushing herself upwards with her hands. As soon as Adora stands up, a rush of dizziness crashes against them, rising bile on the back of their throat. Adora's head is throbbing painfully and the wounds on their body are starting to make their muscles scream. Adora's vision swims, eyelids heavy, shutting close without their consent. Adora tries to move, turn towards Catra, do anything at all, but she is truly fucking exhausted and her body gives up, blacking out. Adora's knees buckle and she passes out over the newly born flower field.

Catra gives a shuddering breath when the light consumes, taking her hands away from her face and rolling on her side in time to watch Adora collapse against the soft moss and blooms on the field, their golden hair spilling down the blue grass, the armor making them look like a fallen Angel in the middle of a battlefield that has been set on fire.

It's deadly quiet in the kingdom but Catra doesn't pay mind to it. She rests her weight over her forearms, dragging herself over the ground and towards Adora as best as she can. It's slow and torturous. Catra's face stings with the scratches, one traveling from her right eyebrow to the beginning of her eyelid, the second one crossing her nose bob ridge down the curve of her left cheek, the last one parting her lip in an uncomfortable gash. None of them

are deep enough to be serious but it does makes Catra’s face itch and her breathing to shudder in frustration.

Suddenly, behind her, something cracks. It sounds like a tree branch cracking but not quite right. More like something heavier, thicker, much more solid. The sound cracks again and it's with a shudder that Catra realizes it's actually bone. The sound of bones cracking, bending and placing themselves together all over again.

Catra turns her head back, looking through the ruffled strands of her hair at the point where the sound is coming from. Shadow Weaver is pushing herself up, her arms and legs bent in unnatural angles as they try to put themselves in their right place again. She is like a porcelain doll, making a weird, clicking sound as she straightens up. The porcelain mask has long ago been lost, her scarred gray face in full display, strands of her disheveled black hair falling over face in a curtain of black, still moving lightly like ink tentacles underwater. Shadow Weaver's red eyes lock with Catra's and the expression inside of them sends goosebumps through her entire body. Her bloodshot escleras are throbbing, almost pulsing, pupils slit, slashes of red crossing her eyes like open wounds.

Shadow Weaver smiles when Catra looks at her, wide, gums and fangs showing behind her pulled lips. She is battered and broken after battle but still has the nerve to scoff down at Catra, tilting her head to the side.

"Getting tired?" Her voice sounds deep, loud, like a thousand broken glasses making friction against each other making Catra want to cover her ears and grimace at the sound.

Instead Catra rushes to her feet, the elegant agility in her body allowing her to only get mildly dizzy when the blood rushes to her head suddenly. Shadow Weaver's shadows throb around her, but it's weakly, not lasting very much before dying down again, leaving only the woman to stand there, magic spent after the breaking of the Black Garnet and the fight. Catra winces, pressing the palm of her hand against her side where Shadow Weaver's creature had dug its nail against her ribs. Her hand quickly damos with golden ichor, making Catra nauseated for an entirely different reason. Her magic is worn out, too, after so much, only enough to keep her on her own feet and definitely not enough to face another creature again.

Catra is closer to Weaver than to Adora. She can see them with the corner of her eye, unconscious over the flower field. Their breathing is heavy and fast, chest moving quickly up and down with pain. Even from her current position, Catra can see the deep gash of Prime's sword on Adora's shoulder blade and Catra's belly twists in worry and urgency, wanting to do nothing more but to spring forward and hold them in her arms.

Weaver follows her eyesight, huffing as she places her eyes over Adora too. She gives a step forward, forceful, leaving a trail of dark liquid behind the shreds of her dress. Catra catches the movement and sprints forward, limping, putting herself between the witch and Adora's direction, arms extended to the sides in a makeshift protection.

Shadow Weaver throws her head back, laughing. Her chuckle resonates in the entire field, hurtful. "What? Do you think this is it? That you can stop me, even like this?" the witch shakes her head, stepping to the side purposely. "I'm far older than you. I've seen and done things you can't even begin to imagine. I will find the way-"

"Oh please," Carts interrupts her, finding enough strength to roll her eyes, annoyed. "Save me the discourse."

Shadow Weaver snaps her mouth shut, sharp teeth clicking together and chipping with the force of it, anger and frustration boiling inside her red eyes. Catra smirks at her, the muscles of her face trembling as she can't keep the smile up much longer. Her throat is burning from where the witch held her down and she is also very sure she has a few bruised bones. Shadow Weaver scowls at her, still walking sideways, apparently without a proper direction, raging Catra on. Catra starts walking too, towards her instead of away, further and further away from Adora with every step. It tug on the core of Catra's heart but she keeps walking to the witch, Light Hope's last words ringing inside her head on a loop.

Shadow Weaver is tall, even taller than Adora, hunching towards Catra like a cursed gargoyle, watching her every moment with hawk eyes and prolonged claws. Even so, this may as well be the only time she is this vulnerable in a long time, tied and powerless. This is the only chance Catra will have at all.

Weaver throws her head back again, neck cracking and placing back in piece, lines of broken porcelain traveling over her chin and neck in angry black lines.

"So," Weaver says, regaining her smile. "Which trick are you going to use now?"

Catra scrunches lightly, dropping the hand pressed on her side to balance herself, her tail lashing from side to side threatening, clenching her teeth until the joint of her jaw hurts. "This one."

Catra leaps, throwing herself against Shadow Weaver with her claws unfolded, swinging her arm towards her face. Her claws catch against Weaver's pointy ear, slashing it clean in half with the razor sharp of her nails. Black blood starts to pour out from the wound, making Weaver Yelp in pain and shock and anger. The witch throws her hands forwards, catching Catra's shoulders when she raises her arm to give another hit and pulling, swinging Catra's entire weight with no problem at all and throwing her to the ground, falling alongside her too into the grass, rolling into dirt and mud. Catra gasp when her spine and the wound in her ribs connects against the hard surface of the rocks in there, fogging her sight with sudden, shocking pain. Shadow Weaver pulls from the short strands of her heair, ripping a drowned whimper from Catra as she holds her chin with her other hand, making the bones of Catra's face to protest on her hold. Shadow Weaver lowers herself over Catra, her putrid breathe hitting the queen's nose when she speaks to her directly into her face.

"Say it. Say that you're alone"

Catra grunts, bringing her legs up and kicking Shadow Weaver square on the chest, pushing her back just enough to punch her once more directly into her face, the cheekbone cracking against Catrad knuckles. Weaver doesn't even have it on herself to scream anymore. She scrambles back, letting to from Catra's hair and face to bring a black, charred hand against her palm, breathing deeply. She spitd into the ground, a gush of dark blood and loose teeth falling off from Catra's hit. Weaver's eyes are on flames, burning inside the sockets if her skull as she looks at Catra with so much fury the ground give in for a second and trembles. Catra stands up again, bawling her hands into tight fists as she looks at the witch.

"You're wrong" Catra says, low but clear, approaching her calmly, her wounded hands glowing lightly with small swirls of magic. "I'm not alone. I've never been. I have people who trust me and respect me, who stand by my side, I have friends." Weaver yowls, walking backwards the more Catra approaches her. "I have a spouse and I have a baby. I have a family. I am loved." Weaver lowers her hands too, digging her nails into her own skin, ribbons of darkness spilling ou of them frightenly. Catra grimaces slightly but doesn't stop, her tone reaching a lethal edge on it. "But you? You have nothing. You're the only one alone. And no one will mourn you once you are gone."

Catra throws one last blast of magic towards Weaver, spending the last of her magic into it. But the witch was already expecting it because she lowers down in the last second, pressing her own hand into the ground and dodging the attack completely. The ground sizzles and electrifies almost instantly and took quickly for Catrad to even begin to try and avoid it. The electricity travels like light and catches into Catra's bare feet electrocuting her with violent red magic.

Catra collapses into the rocks again, knees connecting with the sharp edges there. She tries to recover her breath as best that she can, wheezing and gasping while the red lightning makes her muscles twitch violently, turning her stomach into knots. Shadow Weaver stands on unsure knees, clicking her tongue against her teeth unapprovingly, like the mock of dissapointed teacher with her student.

"You have learned nothing of me," she says, pointing at Catra's bended and in pain form with her chin, making fun of her and her pain as she always did when Catra was a child and unknown forgotten fears grasped at her heart, making her tremble in terror for hours to end. Catra's claws at the earth, biting the inside of her cheek as she looks back at her.

"Oh no," chuckles Catra, closing her fingers and bringing them into her chest in one swing, watching as the witch places herself exactly where Catra wanted her to. "I've learnt everything of you."

Catra pulls from the invisible string of her spell, bringing back the moonbeam at full speed and towards Weaver back, catching her in the shoulder as the magic arrow stabs into her clavicle. Weaver howls, grasping her hand around the surface of the arrow, hovering over it for a second before wrapping her claws entirely over it a pulling it out, splinters leaving ragged wounds on her porcelained skin.

The witch straight up roars, standing up and throwing herself to the side, to a crumble of stones Catra hadn't pay attention to before. When she does, thought, it finally clicks to her why Weaver was walking sideways, stealing the air if her lung as dread pools into her bones.

Shadow Weaver's long, burnt fingers wrap over the surface of Excalibur's handle, embedded deeply inside the stones in the ground, its polished deep blue surface shinning with the light of Adora's magic remains still floating in the mist of the field. Weaver's voice is a tearing, bloodied scream when she speaks, holding the handle with so much force the skin of the knuckles breaks. "I won't loose everything I've work for so long just for the stupid dreams of friendship and love of a stupid girl like you!"

Shadow Weaver pulls from the sword, looking to set it free.

Nothing happens.

Weaver victorious and insane face falls instantly and she snaps her head back to the sword, pulling from it more insistently. Nothing. Nothing at all. The sword doesn't move, not even an inch. Weaver's hisses, bending her hand and pulling again until the the joints of her wrist start to crack too, but the sword doesn't give in, held tight on its own magic.

Catra rises to her feet, trembling. She passes her hand against her bangs, brushing them out of the way. "Don't force yourself. You already know the gig," she says to Shadow Weaver, shrugging when the witch turns her angry eyes back to her. "Only a true king of Camelot can pull the sword of the stone. Turns out some legends have more truth on them than you thought."

Catra jumps again, spinning on her ankles so she can kick Shadow Weaver again and away from the sword. She catches her straight into the chest, managing to to make her stumble back a little at the same time Weaver catches that very same leg, using Catra's own impulse to roll her over herself and slam her against the stones that the sword. Flashes of white spark behind her eyelids when the edge of the rocks smash against the back of her head, making her ears ring.

Catra pushes past the pain as her hands smash against the witch's chest, still at the reach of her arm, pressing with all her forve over her black rotten heart. Her magic sparks and grows, hitting into Weaver's chest and making her gasp in shock. Catra helps herself with the stones to stand up, still keeping her hand in front of her, watching Weaver closely as she grabs into her own chest, face contorted in shock.

"I trusted you, I *trusted* you. And you poisoned my mother, you attacked my family, my home," says Catra, feeling the surface of the irregular stone behind her with her scrapped bloodied hand, sensing the start of treacherous tears on the corner if her eyes. "You took Adora away from me so many times. You burned my kingdom down. You tried to defeat me, again and again. But you lost. You lost because I survived you, because here I am."

The broken lines of Weaver's neck start to expand down her throat, losing themselves from sight among the neck of her dress. She looks down at Catra with hate and resentment, stringing her vocal cords impossibly so. "You are just like me. That's what you are, nothing less."

"I am more than you, I have always been much more than you," years fall free from Catra's eyes, showering her cheeks in silver rivers, gem eyes shinning behind the tears. "You underestimate me and that was your biggest and your last mistake"

Catra's held arm starts to tremble from the effort to keep Weaver at bay and she has to give in, snapping her hand away and letting it fall back into the stone behind her, panting. Shadow Weaver inhales sharply too, unfolding her nails again, catching sight on the exposed skin of Catra's neck below the armor.

Behind her, Catra's other hand finds what she was looking for and she shudders a shaky breath, mind clogged and tired but still clear enough to speak again, her tone calm and collected, the peace of it making Weaver go furious.

"I will forgive you, one day. It won't be today or tomorrow, but I will. I will forgive you for myself." Catra straightens up, chin up, blinking slowly and surely at her. On the fields, several feet away, Adora stirs awake. "And one day I will forget you too. There will be a day where you will be nothing to me but a distant nightmare of the past. And I promise you, I will never, *ever,* think of you again. And I am very good at keeping my promises."

Shadow Weaver's teeth click together in rage as she lashes one last time, throwing herself to Catra with her nails held high to try and gash her throat open for once. Catra inhales and pulls, the hand held behind her swinging free and forward too, embedding inside fabric and porcelain and rotten flesh. The point of the blade peaks out of Weaver's chest, dripping dark, heavy drops down the red of her dress.

Weaver coughs, lowering her hands in order to grip them on Catra's upper arms, looking down at where Excalibur has made its way across her darkened heart, piercing in half completely. Then she looks up again, to Catra's eyes and down at her hands, both of them elegant and wounded, wrapped around the golden handle of the sword.

"H- how?"

" *I* am a king of Camelot," Catra spins the sword to the side, digging it deeper inside the witch's heart, her own heartbeat thundering inside her chest. "You have stolen time from death enough, Light Spinner, I will not let you touch my family ever again."

From the wound on Shadow Weaver's chest, the dark shattered lines start to light up in silver light, consuming the porcelain in her body and washing all remains of her dark magic away. Shadow Weaver's starts to thin, cheeks hollow, skin green to grey, red eyes becoming dull and skin pulled down as the time she stole starts to be called back, all the years she actually has returning back for her. And for the first time in her long life, Weaver looks scared, helpless at the hands of this woman she never considered an actual danger at all. This woman who commanded the night and held the stars on her hands and that now has shattered her rotten heart with a sword forged for kings and legends only.

Catra cries, emotions getting the best of her, silently. Behind Shadow Weaver, the earth trembles and cracks open, a deep wound inside the ground that forms a cliff, so deep inside the world there is no visible end to it, only darkness and void inside its open mouth.

Catra holds the sword firmer, hearing the click and crack of the rusted heart as it finally gives in and breaks, dissolving into black sand. "This is where I bid you goodbye, Shadow Weaver."

With the heart, Weaver's skin thins impossibly too, stickying into her bones, like paper into stone. Her hair bleeds out of all color, dark to grey to translucent whites, spots of age staining her entire face and hands as she covers her head with her arms, wrestling to move away. Catra pulls the sword out, dropping it in the grass besides her, watching as Shadow Weaver worns out and shatters, elder body dissolving into the frame of a clothed skeleton and then into dust, tripping at her last moments and falling down the cliff with a quiet yell that drowns out among the shadows that had once ruled her life.

And so, Shadow Weaver is no more.

Catra watches her fall, her head pounding from the point where her neck crashed against the stones. Her limbs are heavy, too heavy, weighing her completely. There is pain everywhere, everytime she breaths and moves, even slightly. Dark spots start to appear on her vision, first small and then wider and it takes a when fkr Catra to understand that it's her own body shutting down and not tears staining her eyes. It also takes her way too long to realize she is rocking hesitantly too close to the cliff and that she doesn't even have the strength to move away.

Somewhere behind her, the rustle of butter soft leaves and open flowers makes her ears twitch with the gentle sound, soft steps approaching her with gentle care, careful of not scaring her or jolt her away.

"Catra" comes Adora's sweet, exhausted voice. Catra turns to them, swinging dangerously on her ankles. Adora is limping slightly, one of her hands pressed against their wounded collarbone, the other hugging themself by the waist. They search for Catra's face, a honest and beautiful smile spreading on their lips as they take sight of her. "My love." Their eyelids are halfway open, signal of how truly tired they really are. Yet, they still look at Catra with so much devotion, it brings a hesitant smile to Catra's dry, chapped lips.

"Catra?," calls again Adora's voice, this time a little bit more worried, a tad more urgent.

Catra opens her mouth and she thinks she tries to speak, to say something, anything to keep Adora's natural, annoying and endearing worry away, but no sound comes from her mouth. Darkness slips completely into her eyes and she feels so, *so* tired, she lets go for just a moment, just a second of quietness, her body giving up the rope of consciousness and blacking out.

"Catra? Catra! No, no, no, no, no. Catra!

The last thing Catra sees is Adora's beautiful dirt-stained face approaching hers before she falls too over the edge of the cliff. Then all is darkness.

End of chapter XV

Chapter 18: Something good

Chapter Summary

"Look at them" whispers Catra, the tip of her nose brushing in the curve of Adora's ear. "Look at our people, Adora." Catra tilts her head and presses a sweet kiss on Adora's cheek, lips warm and happy against her skin. "They are free."

Chapter Notes

Hello! And welcome to our last update of Camelot AU ") I'm not going to lie, I cried writing these two chapters and it's probably why it took so much to update. Camelot AU is my baby, my spoiled child. I started writing it during a very hard moment of my life and it's been with me through every single change I've gone through the last year (I can't believe it's already a year old!). I'm going to miss it dearly.

I want to thank every single one of you for being with me through this journey, through this silly little fairytale that became a whole legend. To all of you that have supported me in high and lows and in long hiatus. I am so, so grateful for every single one of you and I couldn't ask for a best audience than what I have now. I love you all and I'm very proud of you ")

And now, let's go to the last chapter, the closure of our story. I will see you until the end of the epilogue. Take your time and I hope you enjoy.

Ready to go one last time? 3, 2, 1.. go ♡

CHAPTER 16. Something good

The words ‘I’ll always love you’

impulsively appear in the dark sky

and we are happy and stick by them

—Frank O’Hara, *To You*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x x

❀

Catra looks back at her reflection in the mirror.

It’s around midday and the light that enters the chamber warms her skin pleasantly. The sky is blue, so blue it rivals the crystal surface of the calm sea that laps against the shore of Camelot's Downtown limits' softly, gently, the sound of the waves calming, traveling in the soft breeze all the way inside the chamber, salt and light tickling Catra's nose.

Catra exhales, holding herself to the white wood of the dresser, looking at her own face with lifted eyebrows, somehow breathless. Her hair is up in a ponytail, long again and curlier than it has ever been before, the soft twirls bouncing against her face, escaping the jeweled tie that keeps it together. After so many days and weeks and years of making innocent fun of Adora for their ever present tight ponytails, Catra had ended up giving in too. Who could have known that baby hands could be so devious and curious, especially with locks of silked hair.

But this Catra doesn't know that now. This Catra knows only what she sees, hazed in awe and confusion. Her clothes are loose and soft, a white shirt that hangs loose from her elbows tucked into even softer honey pants. Adora's golden wing is pinned safely right above her heart, matching the delicate moon crown on her forehead. The scar she got under her eye after a long fought battle it's still there but somehow it also looks softer, peach against the dark of her skin. There are gentle lines around her eyes and mouth from years of laughter and her turquoise and gold eyes shimmer with mischief and joy. The face that looks back at her on the polished surface of the mirror looks softer, less sharp around the edges, happier.

Catra blinks at herself and her heart thunders, but it's not bad. It's something good, something welcomed.

There is a soft whimper coming from behind her, sweet as a bell, the sound of a sleepy kitten slowly awakening. Catra turns immediately, smiling brightly, walking towards the sound immediately. All the sudden confusion washes away as she reaches the white wooden crib, her movements and chirps knowing and gentle and suddenly she can't even remember what she was confused about in the first place. She knows, she just *knows* , as she leans over the crib, her smile even softer, cooing sweetly at her daughter.

"Hey, hey," Catra says in a sing-songy whisper, holding her in her arms with sure hands to bring her near her chest. She nestles securely her small head in the crook of her arm, the other caressing gently the baby’s small feet, fond of the way her tiny tail wraps around her wrist. She is warm and small, her hair is soft, as dark as Catra’s and her eyes are barely open against the bright light, light eyelashes casting honey shadows over her skin. "Good morning, my love."

Catra nuzzles her nose against her daughter’s, lovingly and endearing, and that brings a fit of small "mrrps" and purrs as her small fingers raise to play with the loose strands of her mother’s hair, making Catra chuckle. She smells clean, a mix between lavenders and roses, and something that is Catra and something that is definitely Adora’s.

Catra hums, happy. She is so happy right now, she knows she is happy, she knows her baby is happy. Everything is good. When she turns back a little she can see the baby has now almost

completely opened her eyes, peeking at her mother's face. They are steel blue, with a purple flower around her big pupils. They have the same eyes as Mara’s and Razz's. She has the same eyes as the people that love her deeply, that are her family.

Adora cried when they saw their baby's eyes for the first time. It was roughly two weeks after the birth and they were holding her between their strong arms, rocking in the armchair across the chamber when it happened. There was a small gasp and the next thing Catra knew, Adora was sobbing silently, a big goofy smile on her face, placing joyful kisses over their daughter's tiny, tiny head.

Catra smiles at her daughter now, delighting in the way her tiny nose scrunches and relaxes again and then yawns, big, rubbing her sleepy face with her small hands, covered in the fabric of her romper. She looks so much like Adora, Catra knows from the small baby portraits they had found once in Mara’s old things, especially in the mornings when she is sleepy like this. She is so precious, she is perfect. Catra stays like this for what feels like hours but it’s really just a couple of seconds, just looking, contemplating the rise and fall of her baby’s chest as she kneads in the air and squints her tiny eyes, smiling at her mother happily, innocently. Free.

Catra hears the sound before it reaches them. It’s rhythmic, sure, not once doubting its pass. It’s the undeniable sounds of tiny feet over the stones they sprint in at full speed. If Catra twitches her ears enough, she can hear the barely contained laugh of a tiny child. There is already a smile on Catra’s face before the doors swing open and a swirl of joy burts inside the chamber with the entire excitement of a three year old kitten.

“Mommy!”

Finn's bright face greets her and they run towards Catra, hugging her legs and holding to her pants with wet hands. They look up at her with the biggest smile, little voided spots where milk teeth are already missing and the same dimples they share with their mother's. Their honey hair is ruffled by the wind and the race, curly and wild over their ears, almond eyes silver and blue bright, so bright as they look at Carta with happiness and adoration. Catra's face softens in love at the sight of them and she lowers one of her hands to caress the side of her child's face, poking them in the nose where a spot of dirt has smudged itself there.

"Hey, baby." If possible, Finnie's face brightens even more, rubbing the side of their face on their mother's palm, purring very softly.

"Hey, mommy," Finn's fondess starts to wash away, replaced by bubbling excitement again as they jump up and down on their tippy toes, feet bare against the floor's stones, their ears twitching. "Mommy, mommy. Mamma and I caught a frog. In pond!," they are somehow trying to scream and whisper at the same time as to not disturb their still sleepy sister, still drowsy in Catra's arms. "Wanted to bring it to Yali, but mamma said I had to let it go home."

Catra hums, lovingly, ruffling Finnie's hair out of their eyes. Adora enters the chamber at that moment, making the air hitch in Catra's throat and her heartbeat to speed up faster, just as it did years and years ago, when they first fell in love.

Adora's pants are wet at the knees and their long hair is loose and messy for the air, held in place only by the thin braids behind their ears. They look softer too, just as Catra, with tender lines around their eyes and errand silver hairs tangled on the golden of their hair and that perpetual mirth stitched on their lips.

Adora smiles, bright and beautiful to their wife when they see her, eyes twinkling as they approach her and their children with soft steps.

"Hello, my love," they say, voice husky, older, beautiful. It makes Catra's fine fur on the base of her neck stand up, pupils blown up. Adora leans, ruffling Finnie's hair with one of their large hands as they lean towards Catra, placing a long, sweet kiss on the bridge of her nose.

"Hey, Adora," answers Catra, her expression fond, so fond, rubbing their cheeks together before returning to their toddler, looking up at both of them with sparkling baby blue eyes. This is what they know. They know about love and protection and loyalty and devotion. They don't know about sadness or pain or fear. Neither of her children does. This is the world they get to grow into. "Mamma is right, Finnie. I'm glad you listened to them, I'm very proud of you."

Finn beams at their mother, hugging her with their small arms, the four of them held into a tight embrace. Outside of their window, the natural sounds of their kingdom enter like bells. There is music, quick and happy, and singing too, melodious and sometimes a little bit off tune too but just as endearing. Children and adults alike are laughing in the town below, gentle chirps of animals going in and around in the woods around them. The sky is bright, the world at peace.

It must be a sunday. Catra loves sundays. Her children were born on sunday. She married Adora on a sunday. Everything is always better when it's a sunday.

Adora moves, gently, changing their hold to cradle Yali's little face between her hands and place a kind kiss over her tiny, barely awake face. The baby stretches her tiny arms towards her, kneading in the air with even tinier chirps. Catra hums, happy, softly placing their baby daughter into Adora's ready hands, letting her hold her as she approaches back to the vanity and grabs the small feeding bottle there. Swiftly, she catches her reflection in the mirror again, all softness and sparkling eyes. Something in the back of her mind is tugging, bothering her with the feeling that she is somehow forgetting something. Her baby chirps behind her and she turns again, doubt forgotten.

Adora has made herself comfortable in the long sit beside the window, rocking their baby gently as the sunbeams shower them in gentle golden light. Adora takes the bottle from Catra's hand with a gentle, thankful smile, lowering to the baby's mouth and feeding her with loving patience, letting the tip of her braids brush against her cheeks with a tiny giggle. Finn is there too, cuddled on Adora's side as they look down at their little sister, caressing with their little fingers the soft peach fur of her ears. They tell her out loud about their morning, chatting in a low but happy voice. She can't understand them yet, but her silver and purple baby eyes are focused on her sibling, holding their fingers with her smaller ones. They love each other.

Carta stands there, in the middle of their sunny chamber, looking at her little precious family with watery eyes. They stay like this for a little bit or maybe longer than that, Catra can't really make sense of the passage of time, she doesn't want to.

There is a soft sound behind her, like a sigh and a giggle. Catra turns back to find the origin of the sound, ears perked up. There is someone standing in the door, two people actually, holding each other as they look at the family with soft eyes. Catra tilts her head to the side, pupils dilating when she recognizes them, deep inside her memories.

"Moms?"

Tlalli smiles at her, big and sparkling as she always does. *Did.* Her hair is loose and dark and her clothes colorful, embroidered in beautiful swirls of color and flowers and birds, the gold of her earrings twinkles with the sunbeams entering through the door. Somehow Catra can't see the corridor beyond it, just white light and warmth. It's not like she is paying too much attention to it. Ziba is behind Tlalli, holding her waist with one hand, the other slipping treacherous tears off her face. Her hair is as short as always, armor and the silk of her clothes just as soft and regal, with a matching smile that she throws towards her daughter without hesitation. They look the same as the last time Catra saw them together, before sickness and sadness that Catra can't remember right now. Young and in love and kind.

Catra sobs, walking until she is running across the chamber to throw herself to the already open embrace of her mothers's arms, surrounding them with her own tight against herself. There is laughter, that she knows. She doesn't know if it's from herself or her mothers' or the three of them but it doesn't matter. They hug her back with so much strength and longing. Tlalli buries her face on Catra's shoulder as Ziba leans and places a soft kiss on her daughter's forehead, rocking her from side to side gently.

"Hey there, little panther," says Ziba, smiling. Catra doesn't want to let go, she holds herself to her mothers clothes and arms as further as she can, a death grip that makes her knuckles protest a little and still she doesn't let go.

They go like this for a while, just holding each other, until Tlalli steps back a little, rubbing Catra's shoulders with her hands so they can take a better look at her face, wet with running tears.

"You are wonderful, *oselotl,* " Tlalli says with tears on her face. "You are so brave and so strong. We are so, *so* proud of you."

Carta smiles between her own tears, rubbing her mother's knuckles with her hand, the other one still tangled on Ziba's hand who is still looking at her with that kind of deeply proud expression she had always given to her. Catra's heart is flying inside her chest, happiness and melancholy mixing and making a home in there.

"I didn't know you were coming. Did Adora message you? Or-" Carta tilts her head to the side, her smile slowly dissolving into a confused frown, heartbeat picking up again this time for a completely different reason. "Did you-? When did you arrive? I don't-I don't remember-" Her mothers don't answer. They are only looking at her with the same sad, patient expression they've had since the very beginning. Catra can see that now. "I don't remember

when we spoke last. I just remember-" Carts cuts herself short, memories flowing her mind once again. She remembers now, when she saw them last. It was a long time ago, a whole life behind, when Catra was younger, more innocent, sadder. Carta exhales, shaky and mournful, understanding washing over her like a cold blanket, like snow over the sun in her heart. "You are not really here, are you?”

Tlalli presses her lips together, unable to speak, but she shakes her head to the sides sending her an apologetic sweet smile. Ziba pets the fur of Catra's ears with her big, strong hand, her own ears flicking and lowering down with an unspoken apology, voice a mere whisper. "None of us are really here, little one"

Catra's ears press to the sides and she looks at the chamber around her, taking in the blurry edges and the dreamy colors and suddenly she is scared, she is scared to even ask or question it. She can’t hear the sound of Camelot anymore, or the laughter of her children, or the musky tone of Adora’s voice. She is on her own inside this deep white brightness, held in one piece by the grip of her moms’ hands on hers. Her bottom lip wobbles, gulping against the tight knot of her throat.”Am I dead?"

"No," states Tlalli, quick and firm, shaking her head. She caresses the side of Catra's face with her finger, smothering away the lines of worry from her forehead. "You needed us so we came."

A sparkling laugh vibrates across the chamber again, louder than anything else, shattering the brightness into pieces around them and calling the three queens' attention. In the seat of the window, Adora is rubbing baby Yali's back gently, rocking her softly from side to side, pressing tiny kisses on the back of her soft head with their eyes closed and a smile on their lips. Finn is next to them, flipping their ears and crossing their eyes in mirth, making their little sister babble baby nonsense and laugh with fun, kneading in the air towards her sibling with an errand strand of Adora's hair on her mouth and her tail wrapped on her mom's wrist. Catra sighs, eyes soft and swimming with tears at the sight of her little family enveloped in golden light, like a dream. A beautiful dream.

Tlalli rubs Catra’s upper arms, smiling brightly when the last turns to her. She catches an errand curl from Catra’s ponytail, tilting her head towards the little family. “They are beautiful”, Tlalli says, voice breaking with emotions. “All of them.”

Catra returns her smile, proud, tender. “They are.”

Ziba tangles her fingers with her daughter’s, squeezing them together softly on their hold. Her deeply colorful eyes Brightmoon heavy with that wisdom and strength that always characterized her. "You need to go back to them."

Catra snaps her head back to her, alarm and fear running down her spine. She feels suddenly sixteen again, lost and alone and confused, tethering dangerously on a fine line. She grabs herself to her mothers’ tighter, looking between both pairs of kind eyes with urgent desperation. "But- but what if I need you again?"

Ziba raises her other hand, brushing over Catra’s cheekbone lovingly, cradling her daughter's face on her palm. "You won’t, at least not like this. You have everything you’ll ever need

right there" Ziba points towards Adora and the kids, letting go from Catra’s face so she can lean and place a kiss over Catra's forehead. It feels ethereal, like mist against her skin, but it is warm at the touch and full of that love Catra had always known growing up.

"Why can't you just stay?" whimpers Catra, not even bothering to stop the constant stream of tests from her eyes.

"Our time is long gone, little panther," explains Ziba, eyes golden under the bright light. "This time is for you, for what you have, for what is coming. For what you have built and fought for." Catra returns her gaze with sorrowful eyes, leaning to hold her mother's hand between hers, the other one still wrapped around her mom's.

"I'm going to miss you both so much," says Catra, squeaky and broken.

"We are going to miss you too, baby." Tlalli smiles through her tears, cradling her hands around Catra's neck and bringing her close into a hug, rocking her from side to side like she used to do when Catra was merely a toddler on her arms, sharp teeth and always held to Adora's hand. Ziba joins in the embrace too, burying her own little family between her arms.

Tlalli places tiny kisses across Catra's temples, tracing circles with the soft pads of her fingers on the skin there, down the bridge of her nose and the angle of her jaw, purring softly against Catra's body.

"There is something else, baby," says Tlalli, without letting go of Catra. The hold of her hands tightens just a little bit more, pressing against her forehead firmly. A shiver runs down Catra's forehead, cool and sudden, making her mind feel heavy and foggy like cotton or thick clouds. "It belongs to you, it always did. I thought it would save you the pain and maybe I was right or maybe I wasn't. But Adora and you managed to find each other anyway, as it always should have been. There is no reason for not returning them to you now." Catra's head feel heavier with each second, making her drowsy and sleep on her mothers' hold.

"Mom-"

"They were always with you, C'yra, you just had to remember them." Tlalli presses one last kiss to Catra's forehead, caressing her face with the tips of her fingers and stepping back completely. Ziba leans in too, ruffling Catra's hair and also pressing one last kiss on her head, still numb and foggy. Catra's tongue feels heavy, tired, so she blinks at her mothers' very slowly, hoping they will understand.

Of course they do. Both of them blink slowly back at her, stepping backwards and into the bright light of the corridor again. Catra finds herself giving a wobbly step forward, following her moms hesitantly. "Will I ever see you again?"

"Of course you will, *oselotl* ." Tlalli joins her hands over her chest, giving Catra her softest look. "But not too soon alright? We want you to live, C'yra. *Live.* Live for you, live for your family, live for the life that you deserve, C'yra. You deserve so much, you deserve all the love that has been given to you."

Ziba wraps her arms around her wife's waist, nuzzling the side of her face lovingly. The light around them grows brighter, not hurtful but stronger, warmer. Behind them, Catra catches sight of two other silhouettes, contemplating Catra in silence. It takes Catra a little, narrowing her eyes, but finally she can make sense of them, standing hand in hand inside the golden light. Mara smiles at her, silver and purple eyes shimmering, bright like the last time Catra saw her -truly, really saw her, all those years ago in Halfmoon before everything turned around-. Besides her, Light Hope stands very tall, free of her perpetual black ropes, all blue and lilacs. Her gaze is sad but also full of gratefulness. Both of them look at Catra with soft smiles and then beyond her, to a spot on Catra's future that she knows they can see too, that it will give them peace. There is no room for more resentment, not anymore.

“We are proud of you, C’yra, we’ve always been and always will be,” Ziba grins at her daughter, the flash of her fangs cheeky and familiar. Catra can feel her eyes heavier, harder to maintain open with each blink. She can still feel the warmth of her mothers all around her, under her skin and inside her heart. “It’s time to wake up now, little one.”

Catra blinks one more time, soaking on the sight of her moms in front of her, surrounded by light. Wherever they are going, Catra can’t follow but she knows they will be alright. She allows herself one last look, her mothers embracing, Mara’s silver eyes in the background, and then lets her eyes close fully, letting herself be surrounded by the same bright white light.

The ring of child laughter follows her right behind.

✾

Catra opens her eyes again to golden light and warmth. It takes her a moment to understand what is happening, surrounded by a myriad of sensations and feelings all around her. The numbness doesn't last long, reality crashing against her like a cold winter breeze through an open window.

It's with a deep take of breath that she realizes two things. One, that her arms are wrapped around something both soft and hard, her hands tangled in silk from which the golden light pours out in waves, her face nestled in softness that smell of oranges and roses and exhaustion. The second, that her feet and the rest of her body are quite definitely not touching the ground.

She is hanging from the edge of the cliff, the earth opened in half all the way to the very core of the world, only darkness and void in there, her feet dangling, hovering above that empty space. Adora has barely caught her on her fall after losing consciousness and it's carrying her up, avoiding her to fall inside that darkness below with all the strength she has left to give.

"I got you," Adora is saying, grunting, face smudged in dirt and blood partially hidden in Catra's matted hair. They have Catra's arms wrapped tightly around their neck, carrying her entire weight with only their back and shoulders, holding them both for dear life with their hands gripped to the harsh stones at the edge of the cliff and their body and ankles digging holes in the soft moss. "I've got you, it's alright," Adora grinds her teeth and pushes them

both up, lowering a hand to cradle Catra's back and help her on levering her above the edge and away from the fall. "I'm not letting go."

Catra shakes herself awake, trying to help Adora out and impulses herself too, digging her soles on the cliff just to slip away against the smooth stone. Adora grunts, tugging one last time as hard as she can, finally managing to bring Catra completely above the edge. She doesn't stop there, dragging herself and Catra over the ground and several feet away from the fall.

Adora falls into the ground harshly and gasps, a wet and squeaky hiccup, cradling Catra against her chest. Adora brushes the short strands of hair from Catra's face desperately, smudging mud over her cheeks as she props up her head against her arms.

"Catra?" Adora's face is a mess, splotches of dirt on her nose,purple bruises on her jaw and golden ichor that has finally stopped dripping from the scratches on her temples and the side of her face. Her tears mark tracks down her cheeks, run across the curve of her chin and splash into Catra's cheeks, tracing their own paths over her skin.

There is a long second of silence with Adora's heart hammering inside their ribcage so quickly it almost hurts and Catra's still body in their arms. Catra's body twitches and stirs a little, turning her head to the side to cough hoarsely a little. She opens her eyes fully, her own heart fluttering inside her chest as the world around her stills completely, looking directly at the bright silver and blue of Adora's eyes, damp with running tears and worry. Catra smirks at them, crooked, charged with mirth but also relief, resting the side of her face and her curled up ear against the hard surface of their breastplate.

"Hey, Adora." Catra's voice comes as a raspy whisper, raw against her vocal cords with the smoke of the explosions. Every bone on her body aches, muscles pulling on her limbs with exhaustion. And she feels *disgusting* too, covered in dirt and blood and other sticky things she doesn't even want to start questioning about. She is also sure she is partially covered in Shadow Weaver's ashes which makes it extra gross. It makes Catra want to crawl out of her skin or sink into a lake until all of it washes again.

But Adora doesn't mind it -or course she doesn't-, wrapping Catra inside their arms and against their chest tight until their heartbeats crash against each other, synchronizing in one. Adora leans to her, brushing the tip of their nose over Catra's eyelids and down her cheeks, pressing tiny kisses across her entire face. Her lips are dry, chapped and obviously busted, but they feel cool over Catra's feverish skin, rising goosebumps on their travel across her face. Catra lifts her hand, absently realizing she is shaking, just so she can run her fingers across the knots on Adora's hair and the small curls on her nape, rubbing her thumb up and down in the skin there.

Adora's hands shift, traveling over the expanse of Catra's arms -the pulsing wounds there, the scratched armor- until she places them one over Catra's throat and jaw, the other one over her hip, pressing down softly. Catra feels the magic before it starts shining through, warm and tickling over every inch of her body, dancing its way from her very toes to the middle of her heart, washing away the worst of it all. It's obviously exhausted, worn out after long hours of battle, but it's enough to knit Catra's skin together, the wound on her side, the scratch on her face, her trembling shoulders. It feels like a new breath of life, shaking Catra with a wet gasp,

tears she hadn't known were slipping off her eyes running faster down her cheeks. Catra's hand moved too, almost with a mind of its own, running the rough pad from Adora's collarbone all the way across the length of her shoulder and down her shoulder plates, cooing the raw skin there to heal too, golden ichor stopping from dripping and leaving behind only pink and raised skin. Catra's other hand places itself over Adora's ribs, doing exactly the same, deep, purple light enveloping Adora like the sun at dawn.

Adora pants and shakes, overwhelmed by emotions or by their own slowly healing body, Catra doesn't know. He leans away, just a little, just enough to look at Catra's mismatched and bright eyes with his own doe ones, the hint of a smirk attached on his lips when he considers her in silence, still rubbing caresses on her skin.

"Hey," Adora whispers and it's full of light-hearted reproach. " *I'm* supposed to be the healing part of this relationship."

Catra huffs a chuckle, rolling her eyes without letting go of him. "Sorry, hot stuff, not today."

Adora's shit eating grin grows in size but the corners of his eyes soften a little, tender in all the right -and bad- spots. "Aw, do you still think I'm hot?" Adora's grin turns into a halfway apologetic smirk, shrugging a little around his words. The small gesture lets through to Catra just how truly and suddenly self conscious they have gotten. "I think I lost a few teeth out there."

"Lost them while fighting an asshole immortal dictator?" Catra tilts her head to the side, smiling at Adora with a glint in her eyes that speaks of several things wildly different to any kind of disgust. "That's so attractive of you."

"Mm," Adora runs their fingers over Catra's bangs, combing the curls around their knuckles. Catra just knows the humidity is going to make a mess of it all in the morning. "I'm sorry, handsome. I'm married."

Catra bursts into an inelegant laughter, much more a snort than anything else, pushing Adora's sweaty face away from hers with her hands. "Oh really now?"

"Yes. And she is really beautiful and would totally kick my ass so it just can't be"

"Wow", Catra pulls off Adora's earlobe, bringing their face close to hers. "You really are a dummy."

Adora's lips press against her tenderly, robbing her of all the fresh air inside her lungs once again. It’s painfully awkward and it tastes horribly and it’s perfect. Catra inhales Adora’s scent and holds her breath, cradling their face with her hands and holding them in place. The tip of Adora's tongue soothes the raw skin of Catra's bottom lip as Catra sucks on their upper one, letting go from each other just mere millimeters before gravitating together again. Catra can hear the brush of their lips together over the ring inside her ears, familiar and constant, making her blush from head to toe. When she opens her eyes -just a peek to stare swiftly at Adora's face-, she can see their face is peach flushed too, eyes scrunched together, mouth and eyebrows relaxed and nose wrinkled in that persistent focused expression Adora always has when they are kissing Catra.

Catra closes her eyes again, letting herself drift away inside Adora's embrace until wetness starts dampening her face making her eyelids flutter open to look at the origin of it. She leans back from Adora's kisses with a mildly worried look, brushing her thumb under their eye to catch the tears that may be coming from it. Just that it doesn't. The wetness just keeps coming, over Catra's forehead and arms and Adora's hair and shoulders, growing in intensity until they both realize it is actually raining, a constant drizzle that showers over their bodies and the battlefield around them.

Adora helps Catra into a better sitting position over the grass, finally taking a good look at the world around them, still suspended in motion. They are quite away and secluded from the rest of the battle but from this direction they can see the Etherian army standing with their faces towards the sky and their palms open, welcoming the fresh rain over their own bruises and wounds, washing the pain and the blood away. The Horde soldiers and mercenaries are either fallen in the ground or scattering around into the woods, running for their lives to get as far away from the destruction and defeat as possible. Nobody bothers to follow them, the time for that will come. Right now, the rain comes as an omen, of finished battles and rammed pains and rebirth.

There is a rumbling next to them, deep and loud that makes Catra's ears flap suddenly with the sound. Both of them turn around, catching the origins of the sounds with eyes widening as plates.

"Oh, shit."

The humongous mountains Catra had raised into life are standing around them, casting mist and light snow over the field around them. They are looking down, staring without eyes at Catra and Adora, just there. Awaiting. From behind them, a screech comes out and the purple and blue shimmer of Melog's silhouette bursts out, flying from behind the fog, gliding in circles until they land in the ground beside them. Their scales shake and glimmer, their huge frame enveloping in iridescent light before shrinking completely, shifting once again into their big panther form. Melog trots towards them, their tail high and proud behind them as they speed up, rubbing their head against Adora's face when they finally reach them.

"Hey, you" Adora greets them, giggling. She pets them right behind their ears, laughing louder when Melog starts purring happily, their tail lashing lazyingly over the ground and wrapping around Catra's wrist, their big blue dragon eyes looking at Catra with something she can only describe as pride.

The mountains shift from their place, straightening up, snow falling from their heads in cool breezes of white. Catra chuckles, softly, looking up at them with a glint in her eyes as she nods, grateful.

"*You can rest now*," she says, eyes serious beyond her smile and she knows the tongue she is speaking in isn't Etherian or First One but fae, slipping of her mouth as easy as breathing.

The mountains makeshift shoulders and body shift and bend, the sound like stones ripping off the earth when they bow towards Catra, towering on their inmensity over her and the entire battlefield before straightening up again, turning on their mighty feet and walking away with earthquakes over the earth, strong yet still gentle as they cross the battlefield and the woods

and towards the north where they will lay still once again and rest. And below their granite feet they don't leave behind destruction but paths over the ground, tiny sprouts of multicolor flowers and blooms of butter roses that curl from the earth and towards the sky, blue and lilac grass that cover the footprints in a soft blanket. It tugs something inside Catra's mind, strong enough to make her gasp.

It's the silhouettes of two children, running hand in hand across a flower field much like this one, blooming with colors. The echo of laughter, paint in the walls, climbing to the highest point of Halfmoon's palace, sleeping under the twinkling light of the stars. Running around the mud of a garden, barefoot over the onyx stones, sick days and fallen teeth spent together. Stealing each other's clothes and foods, tripping over the seams of queens' robes. Kids growing together hand in hand. It's all of it, inside Catra's mind, springing like waterfalls on her memories, bright and clear and there, after so many years locked away.

Catra chuckles, wet and shaky, tearing her gaze from the now far away moving mountains and towards Adora, contemplating their profile, her entire body shaking. Adora's crowned helmet has fallen somewhere, making their golden hair stick in all directions with sweat and dirt. The fresh scars are pink, their skin damp with the rain and the tears. Her silver eyes spark with wonder as they look at the mountains go, lips open a little without losing strength on their hold around Catra.

Catra smiles, tiny, tears stick on her eyelashes, pressing her hand on Adora's cheek to guide their face towards her again, brushing her thumb over their temple. Adora's eyes have this awestruck look on them, pale skin pink in a tender brush as they grin at Catra.

"That's amazing, Catra," they say and Catra knows they mean the mountains but she pays no mind to it right now. Instead she smiles widens, resting her other hand over Adora's neck where their pulse flutters as a butterfly against their skin.

"I remember you," whispers Catra, catching her own bottom lip with her fang in a nervous but giddy smile. Adora's eyebrows twitch in adorable confusion, still returning Catra's smile with a half cocky half worried grin.

"Well, you better." Catra shakes her head, smothering Adora's nervous smile with her fingers.

"No, Adora. I *remember* you." Catra cradles Adora's face with both of her hands and presses their foreheads together, their noses booping and lips brushing slightly against each other. "Two left feet, face full of mud. Always losing our races to the throne room. And that ridiculous tooth gap." Cards laughs again, letting the tears run free. She feels so soft right now, sharp edges softened completely. Adora is looking at her in that way that makes falling stars look dim against Adora's light, and Catra's insides to flutter like millions of paper butterflies. "I remember."

Adora's lips cut her short, crashing on hers again with all the enthusiasm of someone who has lived death starved of the love of their life and not someone who is holding that very same love between their arms right now. Catra gasp in a surprised shriek, melting into a pleasant hum around Adora's lips, a treacherous but honest purr starting to rumble on her chest making Adora giggle with it.

"How?" asks Adora, eyes half opened and heavy.

"I-"

"You!"

The yell it's the only warning both of them get before a swirl of lilac fabric and sparkles crashes against them with the entire force of a pink tornado, followed by the red and goldens of a second person also throwing himself over his friends like a twelve years old. Catra shrieks, this time for a complete different reason than before, slapping her friend's arm without real bite behind it but full of honest annoyance, squirming and trying to make her way out of the tangled embrace.

"Seriously, Sparkles?! Get off! Get! Off!"

"Oh my stars. That was the scariest, most amazing shit I have ever seen!"

"Did you never learn what reading the room meant?!"

"Aww, you want me to smother you in kisses, too? Of course yes, come here. Come here" Glimmer stretches her neck towards Catra, trying to reach with an obviously exaggerated frunce of lips to her cheek.

"No! No, absolutely not!" Catra groans loudly, smashing her palm against Glimmer's face and pushing her away with a disgusted frown.

Adora and Bow throw their arms around each other in a tight hug and laugh at their wives, knees scraped and covered in moss and mud and rain. Catra exchanges a look with Adora, still pushing Glimmer away by the face, and smiles. She will tell Adora later, about everything. They have time. They have all the time in the world.

"-and then those fucking *mountains* , who thinks about that? You are mad" Glimmer is saying, or something like that, Catra doesn't care. She rolls her eyes at the sparkling woman and brings her into a rough, awkward hug. Glimmer effectively shuts up, her mouth hanging open in awe, pink hair absolutely gross and mated below Catra's chin.

"Guys, guys she is hugging me," Glimmer basically shouts, her wings flapping in the wind. Catra closes her eyes tightly and snarls at her, a growl and a purr rising on her chest.

"I am going to kick your ass, Sparkles. Shut the fuck up."

Adora and Bow just snicker and join the embrace, throwing themselves towards their friends and positively knocking the four of them into the softened earth. They all laugh out loud, snorts and giggles mixing between each other with happiness and relief. Melog also joins them, surrounding the four of them with their huge belly and flopping in the ground with their belly up, rubbing the side of his face against Bow's side.

"Of course yes, you are the star of this plan Melog," he says, laughing as he rubs the dark fur on their belly. Melog turns his bright blue eyes to Catra, blinking slowly at her.

"You did great, kiddo. All of you," Melog says only for Catra, a mere rumble for anyone else. Catra smiles at them, her ears pressing down in the sides of her head, blushing lightly in pride.

Adora's hand squirms somewhere between the mess of limbs and tangles with Catra's, eyes never leaving her, not for one instant. The field around them I'd slowly come back to life, people laughing, others shouting orders, weapons thrown to the ground, no longer needed. The rain helps the blue fire from the castle to die down, the golden dragons and the circle of fire Adora had risen now just puffs of steam in the air, the grass intact where it had been born.

A new sound calls Catra's and the rest attention, footsteps against the wet earth approaching them in a hurry. From among the mist, Scorpia's silhouette appears, running as fast as her long legs and tail can give towards them, her pincers cupped in front of her chest. Catra stumbles and trips, wobbling in her feet as she stands up like a panther's cub. Adora rushes to her feet too, grabbing Catra by the elbows to help her steady herself before slipping in the mud and falling again with a huff. Glimmer snorts, crawling over the ground to help Adora up, followed by Bow and Melog as Catra gives the three of them the most infuriated look possible, soaking wet from head to toe. Scorpia finally reaches them, panting heavily.

"Wildcat! I- uff! I really made the run, uh? Uff!" Scorpia giggles, holding to her own knees, trying to catch her breath. Catra's tail lashes from side to side, grinning despite her best effort at the sight of her friend. She is definitely also covered in bruises and scratches and there is a gooey substance sticking on her hair but otherwise she is intact, still the tall and buff dork Catra has always known.

"That was great, Scorpia," says Catra, flushing when Scorpia snaps her sight at her with clear surprise and softness written over it. Behind Catra, the dumbass trio is still figuring out how to stand up without falling back in a fit of laughter. Catra kicks blindly behind her, catching Adora in the forehead with a snorting *ouch.*

"Thank you, Catra," Scorpia straightens up, cleaning tears from her dark eyes with the back of her free pincer. "You really did it."

"We really did it," corrects Catra, palming Scorpia's shoulders, making a motion to the expanse of the kingdom around them. Like all the others, it's broken and dissolved and needs a lot of care, but it's hers. "This is *your* home, Scorpia."

Scorpia's bottom lip wobbles and she seems not able to hold herself back anymore because she buries Catra inside a huge hug, rising her above the ground a little with the force and enthusiasm of it.

"Uff, careful there big girl. Fragile bones, remember?"

"Oh! I'm sorry, I'm sorry!" Scorpia sets her softly down in the ground, not real shame behind it, at all. She ruffles Catra's already messed up hair with her pincer, smiling softly at her. "I love you, wildcat."

Catra returns the smile, wider, her cheek already sore from so much laughter. "I love you too, big girl." They grin at each other, standing below the cool rain until the thing in Scorpia's pincer starts ringing urgently with a high ding.

"Oh! Oh! Catra, Catra! Listen!" yells again Scorpia, basically shoving the thing on Catra's face. Up close, she realizes it is a magic sphere, orange and bright with magic, very similar to the messenger's sphere Adora uses in battle. Catra gasps, looking from it to Scorpia without understanding.

"Scorpia, what-"

"Listen!"

Static comes off the little sphere, making its misted surface tremble slightly. After a few long seconds of nothing but the rambling static and white noise, the sphere seems to shine brighter, enlightened by a voice coming from it in a hurry.

"-pia? Scorpia?" The voice comes in, shaky and fuzzy first, clear and loud at the end. "Scorpia? Are you still there?"

Adora sprints to her feet suddenly, all goofiness and awkwardness forgotten. She peeks from behind Catra's shoulder, looking down at the sphere with eyes big, her pupils shrinking into pinpoints.

"Lonnie?!" Calls out Adora, gripping Catra's shoulders so hard it makes her stumble a little. "Lonnie, is that you?"

"Sir Lonnie?" asks Catra too, her heartbeat speeding up impossibly. There are a few heart wrenching seconds of more static and then Lonnie's voices raises again, loud and ringing with a laughter that she can't fight back.

"Adora! Queen C'yra! Ha!" There is more noise in the background. Nonsense ringing and muted voices all around Lonnie, barely understandable over the sound of the Knight's delighted yet slightly frantic cackle. "You absolute motherfuckers! You did it! I can't believe it!"

Catra leans to the sphere, holding to Adora's hand for dear life, forgetting even Scorpia's presence in front of them. "Sir Lonnie, where the fuck are you?"

"In Halfmoon!" yells Lonnie, chuckling brightly. Catra feels like the ground has been swept out of her feet. "Right in the place where Shadow Weaver attacked us! I remember everything went black and then it was like a tired, long sleep and suddenly poof! Right back here! We are all back here!"

"We-?" Catra's voice breaks in the middle. Adora holds her tighter.

"The magicats! The refugees! They are all back! Listen!" There is ruffle on Lonnie's side of the call when she moves, static and something dragging and then the sounds explode inside the sphere, clear and beautiful as the sky. Drums and trumpets, the sound of joyous, victory

magicat's music, people laughing, steps over the stones with dancing, rumbling in every corner of Catra's kingdom. Alive. *Alive.*

Catra is crying again, heavy drops that fall into the moss below her feet, sprouting flowers from it. Adora's arms surround her shoulders and chest completely, holding her close as she cries out the last of the pain away. Catra's people are alive. They are back and fine and celebrating, miles aways in a kingdom she didn't know if it would ever be able to recover. All those that had been lost, they are back, freed by the Round Table's hand, with all their lives ahead of them. They are truly, absolutely free. Adora is crying too, Catra notices, their face buried between Catra's shoulder blades and nape, breathing deep and relieved as they listen, too, to the sounds of the people and the music. Adora lost them too, after all. After everything, hearing that it worked -it *worked*- makes the last of that unfair guilt they are carrying to fall and wash away forever.

Around them, more magical spheres start to pop out, to the kings and queens and regents, letting them know of entire villages that are back again. Telling tales about dreams of shadows and the bright light of an eclipse that they followed and waking up safe and sound and confused but free from the horror and the fear and the danger. Queen Mermista is basically shouting over a sphere, tears clear on her hard face, still trying to maintain any kind of stoic facade as she hears the news of Salineans, worn out and ashed but full of its resplendent people too.

The kingdom around them is scattered in patches of moss and flowers and grass, but there is also destruction and smoke. It looks like shit. Glimmer and Bow approach Scorpia, hugging her and speaking to Lonnie and the rest in excited voices. Catra spins in Adora's arms, reaching for her face with her hands so she can press a kiss on her mouth. Adora tastes like salt from the tears and she laughs against Catra's lips, gripping her waist tightly so she can dip her into a much deep kiss, earning a surprise squeak from her wife's mouth.

They straighten up again as Catra raises to her tippy toes so she can press small kisses all over Adora's face, levering in their strong shoulders to not lose her balance. She can feel the way Adora also takes a look at the world around them, eyes half lidded and gaze pinked, and the way their back tenses and their shoulders drop inmensity, taking in the columns of smoke spiraling to the sky where the battle made its print in the already stolen ground of Scorpia's kingdom, in the deep gashes in the earth, the broken rocks and burnt patches of grass. Catra knows what she is thinking. That now she is supposed to make everything even better. That somehow, after everything, she still may not be *enough* for it.

Catra presses one last kiss over Adora's eyelid, tangling her hand with theirs and guiding them both down, kneeling on the damp earth with firm but gentle grip.

"I know how much you love Etheria, Adora," says Catra, locking her eyes with Adora's, bright blue and shimmering. "How much you adore how weird it is. With its strange plants and animals and everything that makes it what it is. I know it hurted you watching it get poisoned and die, even if it wasn't your fault. It wasn't your fault, Adora" Adora closes her mouth against the protest, just looking at Catra speaking to her with the softest of tones.

"I know you carry weights you shouldn't. And I also know you are a healer. I saw you out there. I *saw* you" Catra guides Adora's hand, pressing it over the earth tenderly. "Magic is not

something you contain or depend on Adora, magic just *is.* You are the magic. So don't contain it, don't hold it back anymore," Adora's eyes flash quickly towards Scorpia, anxiety clear on their factions. Catra returns their eyes to hers with a soft squeeze, shaking her head. "Stop thinking about what everyone wants from you, Adora. Think about what you want."

Adora is shaking -Catra is too- but she is starting to shine too, like stardust or a candle or a shooting star, golden light spilling out of her body and into the ground in rivulets of liquid gold that slip into the earth and make a home there. Catra leans against Adora's side, kissing the corner of her mouth with butterfly touch. Adora searches for Catra’s eyes, gems against the impossible shine of Adora’s golden pupils. All in her is shining like a supernova, blinding everybody around the entire battlefield, all of them but Catra.

“Stay with me,” whispers Adora, tangling their fingers together tightly, almost urgently. Below their feet and hands, small rocks start to float in the air, the ground shaking first softly then harder until it feels as if the mountains had awakened again, making everybody in the field gasp and stumble. Catra leans her forehead against hers, closing her eyes.

“I’m not going anywhere.” The ground stops shaking suddenly and all together, heavy silence falling over. And then, much like the very rain falling steadily over their heads, the earth bursts open and the light explodes all around them.

The dark night becomes daylight, illuminated by the light that flourishes out of the earth, ropes of golden dust and mist born from the very stones and into the sky, lacing the stars together in bright light. Thick tree trunks burst from the ground, rising taller and taller and taller until they rival the very same mountains at the north, enveloped in dense branches and hundreds and hundreds of colorful leafs. Golden, bright green, turquoise, purple and lilac, pink, an iridescent rainbow of colors sprouting across the entire battlefield, turning the deserted field into a wood, light shining through the crowns of the trees and casting kaleidoscope reflections over the grass, which trembles, as rocked by a cool breeze, and grows too, higher until it brushes their knees and licks softly their ankles healthy once again. Long vines climb over the trunks like longs arms, enveloping the wood in a tight embrace, tiny purple flowers flourishing in tiny puffs of pollen.

Besides them, the deep gash in the earth starts to knit back together, roots and stones fishing and closing, holding to each other like hanging bridges. The walls of the opening in the earth cracks and water explodes out of it, filling the opening with fresh, bright blue water, almost neon under the golden light pouring out of Adora and every single other hit in the ground, washing all remains of war and conquer away. The water forms a wide river, traveling from one edge to the other and slipping into the ground, boosting fungi and moss and so many other plants to grow out if with little pops.

Moss and roots and bushes start crawling over the burnt remains of the White Castle, enveloping it in blankets of greenery and color, making the last of the fire to suffocate, turning its ash walls into stone and stone into mountains, burying forever everything Prime had constructed and destroyed over the stolen land of Scorpia's home. The burst of life climbs over the abandoned roofs of the town, bringing back to life its streets and watercourse, the planting fields filling with huge and healthy vegetables and seeds and fruits, animals slowly making their way inside the living woods. Over their heads, the rain opens up, the drops

forming tiny blooms of white roses everywhere they touch -a small gift for Adora's heart- and the magic reaches far beyond the scorpion kingdom, over the valleys and cliffs, across the oceans and shore of Salineas, over the no longer smoking remains of castle Grayskull, inside the flourishing gardens of Halfmoon and the door of Brightmoon and into every corner of Etheria, bringing back to life what years of war had threatened to kill.

Adora gasps, taking her hand off the ground with eyes welling in tears. She flops forward, definitely exhausted, caught between Catra's ready arms softly. The armor clanks a little when Adora curls around Catra's chest, making herself as a tight ball against her. Catra holds her through, the last tremors of magic leaving Adora's body slowly. It's not painful but it worns Adora to the core. Catra buries her face over Adora's hair, rubbing circles over her upperarms, feeling the way her body pulls and relaxes finally with a deep sigh.

The sun has hidden again, departed of her nocturne lover and leaving only the night moons to shine their lilac shimmer over them. Around them, golden orbs float gently in the air, casting warmth light over the entire field. The rebellion is looking at every way with wide eyes and open mouths, touching the sugar glass, the thick trunks, the butterflies fluttering neon across the flower fields, marveling in the crystal beauty that Adora's spell had casted over the planet. This is what Adora wants. Magic in balance once again, a place to live freely with the people they love. A world where their child can live without fear. Adora exhales, shifting in Catra's arms so she can look at her face, golden with light.

"Hey, Catra" calls Adora, smiling crooked at her. Catra chuckles, brushing Adora's bangs out of her face. Out of all the beauties Adora had just healed and created around them, she is the only one Catra can't tear her eyes from.

"Hey, clotpole." Adora huffs with mirth, nuzzling her cheek over Catra's collarbone.

"Can we go with Finn now?"

Catra laughs, watery, nodding at her spouse with sparkling eyes. "Yes. Yes let's go home."

❀

Queen Mother Angella walks around the wing soft the castle with her hands behind her back, her long link wings dragging over the polished surface of the floors as she goes from one corner to the other, eyes deep in thought and brow furrowed.

The balcony is open, a clear sight to the horizon beyond the whispering woods. The sky is back to normal, lilac and blue with the night shimmer, both moons hanging high and huge in the sky. The midnight sun has disappeared, leaving behind only swirls of colors, aurora borealis in the night sky that mark glimmering paths in the direction of the scorpion kingdom, so close that it feels that if you can stretch enough, you may just touch the ethereal forms with your fingers. Still, the sky remains quiet, no signal coming, nothing at all.

King Father Micah is sitting in a rocking chair in the balcony, his salt pepper hair held loosely in a bun over his head, a cozy wool blanket draped over his chest where the tiny Camelot's prince is sleeping soundly. It reminds Micah from his own time as a new father,

holding his newborn daughter between his arms, Glimmer pink and soft between his arms. And he has known Adora since she was little and known Catra fairly recently, he can see how much of them exists in Finn. How much and deeply they love them and how much they have suffered to protect their baby. It makes Micah's hands tremble a little.

A clear sound breaks the quiet, bright light rising in the horizon, parting the sky in two like the arrow of a goddess shot into the night, turning it back into dawn. It hovers in the air a little, rising higher and higher and higher until it almost touches the auroras and the very stars.

"Angella," calls out Micah, with a gasp, careful not to wake up the magicat baby when he stands up abruptly. "Angella, darling, look."

Angella walks out of of the chamber with wide steps, wrapping her arms around Micah's waist as she looks over the railing of the balcony and towards the sky. They wait together with their breaths held, the arrow of light reaching the highest point in the sky and exploding in a swirl of color, a soundless firecracker that turns night into day. Gold and purple and blue, the colors of the kingdoms,the colors of victory. The colors of returning home.

Angella laces her fingers in front of her face, leaning over her joined hands with a deeply relieved sigh. Micah leans against her tall frame, laughing without containing it, loud and delighted. The baby on his arms blinks awake slowly, baby blue eyes shimmering with the bright of the sparkles above them, the paths of light that will lead their mothers back home.

❀

The sky is pink and golden above them as Camelot's caravan makes their way through the woods. Horses draped in twinkling red and purple fabrics walks over the soft ground of the familiar paths with no rush. Everything is new around them, with evergreen trees and bushes bursting with flowers and fruits and beautiful animals like torn from the very constellations walking and feeding among them, no fear, no need to hide. But also the same, same crooked stone bridges -covered in blankets of moss-, same hills and the watercourse of rivers -fresh, healthy, splashing with colorful animals-. The same hidden paths that will guide them home.

Brightmoon insisted that there was no rush, no need to speed up and return to the kingdom if they weren't ready yet. But if the people of Camelot are something that is resilient and brave, eager to go back and rebuild. So here they are now, walking side by side First Ones and Magicats alike, chatting and joking and even dancing across the paths, the sound of their laughter echoing in the woods with a bell ring, making the little magical specks around them twirl and spin in the air.

It's a long, colorful caravan, spilling music and happiness as they go, not even bothered about walking the long roads back. In the lead, king Adora rides his white horse at a calm pace, side by side with the black steed Queen Catra. He looks around them with wandering eyes, quiet, smiling at the sound of laughter and music behind them but with his eyes lost in thought. It's been way too long since Adora was last in Camelot. It was cold, back then, the first whispers of autumn crawling over the pumpkin's fields and orange trees. Catra was pregnant back there, soft in all the way someone can be, happy and hopeful in Adora’s arms.

Now she rides over Melog, holding a very sleepy Finn tight against her chest and shaking her head softly, her ears flapping gently when yet another tiny butterfly rests over her hair, making Adora giggle under her breath at the sight of her.

Catra rolls her eyes with mirth, grinning at Adora with a mischievous glimmer in her eyes. “This is the tenth godforsaken butterfly, Adora, please tell them to stop.”

The offended winged bugs just shake their wings softly over Catra’s curls, nesting around her forehead like a makeshift crown. Adora’s eyes are soft in the corners as they look at her, one of the little butterflies fluttering a little above Finnie’s little feet, making them laugh cheerfully even in their sleep.

“They love you,” says Adora, tilting their head towards the butterflies, flying around their little family as they make their way across the woods. They are, after all, just a reflection of Adora’s love for them. “Both of you.”

Catra smiles but her eyes are thoughtful. She leans towards Adora, lacing her fingers with theirs. “Hey, are you sure you want to do this?” asks Catra with only the slightest tremor in her voice. “You don’t have to do this if you don’t want to.”

Behind them, the sparkles of harmless ethereal firecrackers go off, rising giggles from a couple of magicat children gathered over one of the chariots. “Our people are happy to come back.”

Catra’s hold tightness, squeezing Adora’s fingers. “You know that’s not what I’m talking about, don’t you?”

“I do,” assure Adora, returning Catra’s strong hold. “I want this too, Catra. I want to come home, it doesn't matter how it is right now, I want *this*. I promise.” Catra’s eyes long in theirs for a few seconds, searching for any kind of uncertainty in Adora. There is none. "Are *you* sure you don't want to go to Halfmoon first? We can totally do it-"

Catra is already her head, rocking Finn softly and absently from side to side. "Halfmoon isn't nearly as blown out as Camelot and the magicats are very resourceful. They can manage without us for a few months. *After* that we will go."

Adora wrinkles her nose, pouting slightly but nods anyway, tilting their head until it rests precariously over Catra's shoulder. She smells like sandalwood and moss from traveling across the woods for the last day and her nose twinkles a little in gold with the spell Adora casted over her to avoid her allergies of acting up with *so many* new flowers. The fabric of her red dress is soft against Adora's cheek and it smells a little bit like lavender baby powder. On her arms, Finn stirs awake a little, turning their baby eyes towards Adora, their little nose twitching as they catch her smell close to them. Finn's blue eyes sparkle when they see her, smiling mere inches from them, and they laugh at their mom, that kind of baby giggle that makes everyone in the caravan turn their heads for a second and grin.

The woods finally open up into a golden field, clear and empty. Adora can feel the familiar trum of Camelot's barriers right in front of their face, rolling out in pleasant heat waves. Adora sighs, cooing Swift Wind into walking inside the iridescent waves, crossing the barrier.

The beautiful stone arch of Camelot's main entrance is destroyed, heavy pieces of stone have fallen in the ground. Beyond it, the houses of the Upper Town peek over newly grown trees, their roofs and walls collapsed over themselves. Moss and wildflowers have crawled over them, making them look like tiny hills scattered over the curled paths that lead to the castle. Half of the castle is wip out, the main hall, the throne room, kitchens and main chambers of the staff demolished after the attack. There is no more fire or smoke coming from the destroyed towers, just marble and stone piled against each other. Adora and Catra's entire tower is in pieces, covered in a blanket of white ash and bluegrass, white roses climbing over the broken columns. The kingdom is calm and quiet, animals with huge, swirled antlers tangled in with flowers and vibes walking around the stone streets and down the still remains of the village. There are leaves fallen on the path, making a makeshift carpet at their feet as the caravan advances through the town.

They stop near the base of the castle, right beside the now collapsed and abandoned orphanage and the main road that connects the Upper Town with the Down Town. Both towns look the same, quiet and covered in life but destroyed, the sound of the sea waves in the Downtown's shore traveling all the way there with the wind. The music of the caravan lowers a little when they stop, chariots, horses and panthers coming to rest at the sides of the path so the people can jump off and start taking things down, laughter still echoing through the crumbled walls. Even with the remains of their homes around them, the enthusiasm doesn't wave. It's midday already and they have camp tents to rise and food to eat before they can really take a look around and start organizing to begin the reconstructions.

It's with the sound of music that Adora dismounts Swift Wind, walking around the horse to help Catra and Finn down Melog. Catra's open skirt tangles around her black leggings, making her fumble under her breath as Adora laughs softly, smothering the fabric with their hands before straightening up again. Swift Wind wanders off and towards the tall grass in the corners, wagging his tail happily. Melog stretches besides them, nuzzling their big head over Catra’s waist and Adora’s ankles before jumping inside the crown, pampering in the greeting and scratches in the head as they walk by, probably looking for Glimmer or Scorpia somewhere in the way.

Adora’s eyes roam the destroyed towns and castle, the moss cushioning their steps as they walk. Catra looks at her in silence, carrying Finn as Adora runs her palm over the softened edges of the stones. There is a huge one right in the base of the castle, silver and white and grey of what once was the top of their tower, just laying there, irregular and tall.

There is sadness in Adora’s heart, of course. Everything looks ethereal and everlasting yet she can still see the rough corners where fireballs hit the walls and the towers. Her heart aches for the homes of her people, looking so much more like ancient remains than what before were actual houses, paths where children played and people walked and danced and lived. Scratches in the floor are still visible below the grass, the fire long gone but its print left in there still. Adora’s chest constricts at the thought of Catra and Finn, barely a few weeks old, running down these very stones for their life. Catra was strong and brave and fierce and they had Melog, but still. Adora wasn’t there. It will take Adora many years to overcome that thought. Years of walking around the newly constructed Camelot and the flourishing gardens, contemplating the statue the magicats had risen once for her and the statue of Catra that will match it. Years of looking at their kids run across those very same

gardens and very same corridors, chasing each other, climbing the columns and tall trees, playing in the flowers, laughing and growing in them. It will take time but Adora will get there.

“I found a table!” shouts someone cheerfully somewhere behind them. Adora turns on her ankles, watching a villager waggle from one of the fallen houses carrying a pink wooden table, placing it in the middle of the main road with a pleased smile.

"We found some too!" yell back a few villagers and magicats, bringing out several tables too.

"And here!"

"Here too!"

Surely, several people started to walk out of the remains with tables, all of them different between each other. Some tall and long, others shorter, others round. Some with limping legs, some covered in white ashes. Hand painted in pink, yellow, blue, red and white, some with swirls others carved in intricate forms others straight and simple, most of the chipped and a little burnt out. It doesn't matter. The people start gathering them in the main road, placing one next to the other until the oath becomes one long table, reaching from the base of the castle to the very entrance of the kingdom, the people helping each other collect the various food from the caravan they had brought with them. After everything, after so much, they deserve a feast like this. Sitting next to each other like friends, like family, like equals.

Catra approaches Adora, slipping her hand inside theirs and pressing a kiss on their cheek, this time resting her cheek over their shoulder. Adora sighs, smiling, errand tears falling from their pale eyelashes as they turn their head just enough to press a single kiss over Catra's forehead before pulling away slightly, grabbing the handle of Excalibur still hanging in the belt on their hip. Adora unsheathes the sword, walking towards the biggest stone, running her hand again ver the soft green surface before raising Excalibur over their head. The points hovers in the air for a few seconds, cutting the air in half when Adora lowers it in one blow, digging inside the hard stone. A single sunbeam shoots from the sword in the stone and towards the sky, sizzling in golden sparks when it crashes against the barrier.

The magic dome that makes a barrier between Camelot and the rest of the world dissolves in thousands of silent golden fireworks, burning out until all that is left is its clear blue sky and the sunlight washing over the newly grown trees and lakes. The villagers and rest of the caravan have stopped moving for a moment, looking in awe at the spectacle if lights above them, breathing in the fresh breeze of the woods as Camelot becomes visible, for the first time in a hundred years, for the rest of the world, broken but still strong and full of life.

Catra's ears twitch as she looks from the sword up to the sparkling sky, eyes watering with emotions as turns back to her spouse, standing still in front of the stone.

"Adora-"

"We don't need it anymore" Adora turns fully to her, smiling brightly. There are tears running free down her eyes, sparkling under the light of the sun and the day look above their heads.

Adora walks to Catra, lacing again their fingers together. "There is no more reasons to be afraid."

Catra returns her smile, rising to her tippy toes so she can press a kiss on Adora's lips, Finnie laughing between them when the tip of Adora's ponytail tickles them in the face. Adora giggles against Catra's mouth, leaning to their tiny baby to press a butterfly kiss over their little nose, her heart fluttering inside her chest when Finn's baby hands come up to palm at her strong chin.

The little family parts a little, turning in time to watch Bow and Glimmer march towards them with a spring in their steps, hands laced together. There is a peach blush in Glimmer's cheeks and Brow is laughing openly, swinging at the sound of the loud music all around them.

"Hey there," greets them Catra, her own tail lashing swiftly from side to side with the same rythmn. "Tired already of walking?"

"Oh, give Bow a break. Not all of us have wings," jokes back Adora, grinning mischievously at their friends.

"Hey," protests Bow weakly at the same time Glimmer makes a little piruette in the air, her wings sparkling.

"It's just part of my charming personality."

The three friends snicker, wrapping their arms against each other in a warm hug. Finnie squished softly between them. Glimmer flutters to the baby, rubbing the tip of her nose against their peach soft cheek. The sparkles on her hair tickle the baby's face, making their little nose wrinkle and twitch before sneeze once in a small but powerful rush of golden magic, hitting Glimmer straight on the face.

Adora and Bow gasp, the first hiding their face behind their hands, the second trying to hold back a loud snort with a strangled cough. Catra just bites her bottom lip, hard, carrying Finn against her chest as she waits patiently for Glimmer to react. The last is still in the same position, eyebrows raised and eyes closed as she seems to count inside her head, taking deep inhales of air.

"I felt an imbalance in the magic" Glimmer straightens up, turning to Bow's direction with her eyes still closed. "Bow, darling, what color is my hair now?"

A little bit of the snort scapes Bow's lips who just presses his hands tighter over his mouth, muttering a tiny "Oh, dear" before Adora breaks down, laughing loudly, snorts and all. Glimmer snarls blindly at them as Catra chuckles, fighting back her own loud laugh.

"I must say Sparkles" Catra says, huffing. "Orange is a real statement for you. Oh, it's changing to blue! I didn't know Finn could do that"

Finn laughs at their mother as if they had understood her, bringing their little foot towards their mouth, their tail wiggling happily behind them. Glimmer opens her eyes and catches

one strand of her hair in time to see it blend from neon orange to turquoise blue, almost matching Catra's eye tone, bright and definitely *there.* Glimmer's lip wobbles a little and her shoulders tense just to relax completely a moment after, blowing off the strand from her face with a shrug, an amused smile already peeking in her smile.

"Well then, Mermista and Frosta can't be the only queens with amazing blue hairs."

Catra nods in agreement, already laughing loud and squeaky, Finn following her, more accute and even squeakier, wiggling happily on her hold. Glimmer dissolves in the same fit of laughter, all of them giggling at the absurdity of it all.

As they laugh, Scorpia -newly renamed Crown Queen of the Scorpion Kingdom- and Perfuma approach them, there arms thrown against each other's waists, holding to each other tightly with their cheeks bright red and joyous. Catra sees them coming with the corner of her eyes and smiles at them, nudging Glimmer on the side.

"I'll be right back. Check up on her, alright?" Catra says, pointing at Adora's direction, still giggling next to Bow, with her head. Glimmer nods, palming Catra softly in the back.

"Of course yes, kitty cat"

"Oh, shut the f-"

"Language, darling, you are a mom".

"Fuck you"

"That's going to come back and bite you in the ass sooner or later, mark my words."

Catra kicks her in the shin, barely reaching her before she slips away from her reach, laughing. Adora locks her eyes with Catra then, tilting her head to the side in a silent question. Catra points again, this time to Scorpia and Perfuma, smiling reassuring before walking towards them, shushing softly Finn's giggles. Finn laughs a lot lately. Adora loves it.

"How are you feeling, Adora?" asks Bow to them, rubbing their upperarm once the fit of laughter finally washes down. Adora looks at him with a slight roll of her eyes, a flush still spreading over her cheeks with the question.

"Why does everyone keeps asking me that?"

"Because we know this is difficult for you," says Glimmer, enveloping Adora in a swift, sparkling hug.

Adora looks around them. People carrying tables, joining them together in the one single, long and mismatched banquet one, and chairs, some burnt, others with wooden legs broken that get held with thick branches of magic. There are people everywhere, in and around the main yard of the town, laughing hard and bright and loud. Magicats, first ones, etherians, people gathered together to celebrate the end of a long war, too long, joy and excitement and happiness dripping from each of them and making the spring evening look golden and bright and warm. The destroyed castle nor the crumbled town matters. They are alive, they are safe

Perfect, it is perfect.

There is a squeaky giggle to their side and Adora turns to that direction, looking with bright blue eyes at the owner of that beloved laughter. Catra is standing there over the smooth stones of the yard and soft evergreen moss. Her red dress is flowy against the warm breeze, tangling around her legs and tail and just below the seam Adora can see the peak of her bare feet, painted in a splash of multicolor powders that magicat children had been playing around the grass with. The air moves her short hair gently, brushing just below her shoulders in soft dark waves of silk, bangs and curls that frame her face perfectly. Catra is laughing, openly, freely, rocking Finn in her arms. Her smile makes the soft roundness of her face and the freckles in her cheeks pop, scattering her skin in dozens of stars. One of her hands is playing absently with the little toes on her baby's left foot, pressing the pads over the velvet soft beans as she leans and kisses them swiftly in the forehead. The sight makes Adora's heart melt and set aflame all over again.

Scorpia and Perfuma are standing in from of Catra, chatting excitedly with her as the people around then start bringing vegetables, soups, breads and desserts. Fruits and candies and stew, all over the length of the tables, jars and glasses of wine, water and juice being passed back and forth, music loud and cheerful.

"No way," exclaims Catra suddenly, her eyes wide with delighted surprise. "No fucking way"

"We are!" exclaims Scorpia on return, barely able to hold back her own excitement. "We are thinking a late spring-early summer wedding would be good"

"And the flowers are in full bloom by then!" adds Perfuma, bright with happiness.

Adora sighs, returning Glimmer and Bow's embrace with a tight hug, nestling her head over their shoulders. "I am alright," reassures them Adora, without saying anything else. "I love you guys, so much."

Bow and Glimmer smile, petting the slightly puffy too of Adora's ponytail at the same time. "We love you too, Adora."

They hold each other a little more, until Glimmer and Bow both walk back, squeezing both of Adora's hands before marching back with the people, allowing them of some privacy when Catra says her goodbyes to Scorpia and Perfuma and returns to Adora's side with a slight jump in her walk.

"Hey"

"Hey," greets her back Adora, her eyes soft, so soft, as if she hadn't seen her in years and no mere seconds. Adora will never get tired of looking at her, ever. Catra blushes under her gaze and looks down and up a few times. Then she smiles again, the edges with a hint of *something* as she points behind her and towards the place Scorpia and Perfuma are giving the good news to Glimmer and Bow.

"Did you hear that?," asks Catra, bright.

"I did," affirms Adora, grasping a rebel lock of Catra's hair between their fingers and placing it softly behind her ear. "It was about time they got married."

"Oh hush. As if I didn't know you are deaf tone for these things"

"Not to you" protests Adora, earning another furious blush from her. "Do you think Finn will have someone close to their age to play with soon?"

"Oh, they are definitely going to jump right into it and they are totally going to use Finn as babysitter practice until then," Catra giggles, cradling the side of Adora's face with her hand "Are you alright?"

"Yes," Adora chuckles a little at question but tilts her head towards her, nuzzling on her palm. "I'm happy"

"Good" Catra smiles, caressing the bridge of her nose with the pads of her fingers. "I'm happy too"

When Finn turns ten months old, the reconstruction of castle Grayskull will be done. Adora and Catra will be nestling Finn between their arms, laughing at their little happy babbles until a particular one. Finn will palm both of their cheeks and giggle, whispering a very slurred and baby-like *"mamas"* . It will bring both Adora and Catra to tears. A month after, the three of them will be sitting in the plush carpets of their chambers on Halfmoon, bright and colorful as always. Adora will help Finn be steady on their feet, hovering her hands around their little body as they try to find their balance. Finn will wobble and curl their little tail on her fingers but eventually the little baby will give a step, and then another and then one more into the ready arms of Catra, who will be sitting cross legged right in front of them. Catra will envelope them in her arms and hug them into her chest, laughing out loud. And Adora will cover her face with her own hands and cry, because their baby just gave their first steps and she was *there* and life will be good.

Today, however, today Adora leans over Finn still tiny body and blows a raspberry on their tummy, marveling in their sweet purr against her face and Catra's squeaky laughter ringing in her ears. Today they will sleep in tents across the fluffy moss fields and eat bread and cheese and spiced fish. And they will laugh too, for different reasons but still, it will be good.

"Yohooo!" comes suddenly an old voice from the edge of the woods, calling out for Adora and Catra's attention. Adora narrows her eyes, their mouth falling open in surprise when she catches sight of its owner.

"Razz?" Adora calls back, voice strained. "Razz!"

Adora rushes to Razz's side, taking sight of her completely. She is still the same as Adora remembers her, with her old pink dress and her grey hair. Razz is holding several baskets in her arms and hands, all of them filled to the brim with warm, just baked berry pies. Melog trots behind her happily, carrying even more baskets with pies between their teeth, their mane and tail swinging pink around them with joy. Behind Adora, Catra throws a meaningful look at the dragon, raising her eyebrows with an amused expression.

"Razz! What are you doing here?" Adora asks, arms moving everywhere, hesitant and clumsy. Razz blinks back at her from behind her round glasses, as if she had only know realized they were there at all.

"Oh, hello Adora dearie. I brought the pie!" Razz shakes the baskets in front of Adora's face, excited. "Many, many pies. I've been baking them all day!"

"I thought-" Adora's lip is wobbling like crazy, barely containing the tears from falling down again. "I thought-"

"What? That some ugly men could take an old lady like me? No way darling." Razz scoffs, nose up to the sky in a cockt gesture that is so much Mara and so much Adora that robs the last from her breath. Adora wonders how she never noticed it before. "Besides, I last saw you like an hour ago, when you brought Catra to eat pies with you. We were baking the pies exactly for this!"

Adora's eyes soften, tilting her head a little to look at Razz with the softest expression. "We did, didn't we?" Adora shifts on his feet, unsure how to speak next. Catra told her, of course she did, about what she had figured out that Adora never could by himself. It filled Adora with immense tenderness but also melancholy. He understands now, why it was so hard for Razz to lose Mara. "Um, Razz, about my mom-"

"She is at peace now, Adora dearie" Razz changes her hold from some of the baskets to caress softly at Adora's cheek, cleaning the little tears that had started to fall there with her thumb. "There is no need to cry anymore, just to celebrate what you have now."

She looks at Catra and Finn, a knowing smile on her old lips. Catra returns the smile.

"Besides, Finn loves my pies" adds Razz, palming Adora gently in the cheek, looking at their feet and the ground around them with a wondering hum. "And speaking of, where may your other bunny be? I don't see her anywhere."

Adora blinks deeply confused at Razz, looking around too without understanding. "Who-?"

"She is not here yet, Razz" interrupts Catra, walking until she is also standing next to her, giving her a meaningful and sweet look, filled with wisdom and knowledge. Razz looks at her with wide eyes, looking at the bundle that is baby Finn on her arms, wobbling their tiny arms happily towards her.

"Oh, I see. It's not that time yet, is it?" whispers Razz, eyes tender, taking Finn's little fingers between her old ones, brushing the peach skin of their palm lovingly, just to shrug immediately after, cheering up completely again. "Well, she loves my pies too so it doesn't matter".

"She?" repeats Adora, a little bit shaken, looking between Catra and Razz.

"Of course she likes them! You think I don't know my own great grandchildren? Now come on! Let's eat!"

Adora's eyes widen like eclipses, snapping her head at Catra. She hasn't told them, not yet. She told them about what she saw about her moms, about her childhood memories being restored, but not about the foresight. Not about the other love of their lives. Catra wasn't sure if guarding the secret or not, doesn't matter now. Adora will probably figure it out on their own, they always do. So Catra just returns their sight with a small nod, smiling reassuringly at them. Adora's shoulder's relax, tears picking at the corners of their eyes without really falling again, just making their silver eyes look soft and dear.

Catra stretches her hand towards her and Adora takes it, she will always take it, following her as they walk slowly and side by side to the tables, smiling brightly. Steam rises from the warm food scattered across the tables, glass full of water and juice passed back and forth, people already sitting laughing, telling stories and jokes. Children are running around below the legs of the tables, playing with the panthers and the butterflies, tearing a smile from their parents. The building of the orphanage is empty and destroyed on the sides, no longer needed, not anymore. Adora catches Catra's proud and thoughtful look in her eyes as she looks at the children and then the building, happiness falling over their wife at the thought that no other children will have to live a life alone anymore. Catra clicks her tongue against her teeth, letting her weight fall partially on Adora's side as they wrap an arm around her waist.

"I've been thinking we could build a school," says Catra, that characteristic glint of a plan already shining in her eyes. "We would teach magic, of course. But also science. And arts and literature. A place where everyone can go and learn." Catra nudges Adora with her hip, grinning at her. "You could teach cartography there, dummy. But the science part you definitely leave it to me."

Adora grins back, tickling Catra playfully in the ribs, smiling wider at her laugh. Adora loves Catra's laugh. "Duh"

"Duh"

"I think it's a wonderful idea," and then, in a softer tone, Adora adds. "I'm really proud of you."

Catra blushes but doesn't look away, just huffing in fake annoyance as they reach the chairs. Razz is passing the pies to the people with Melog's help, excitingly calling everyone to the table.

"Pass them through, darling, go on. There is plenty for everyone." Razz looks at Catra and Adora arriving and signals them two empty chairs, waving her arms in the air as if they weren't mere feet away. "Come on, sweeties, it's time to eat! We have a long road ahead of us!"

Adora wraps an arm around Catra, leaning to look at Finn's curious face, their nose twitching as they catch the smell of the fresh baked pies. Their romper is so tiny on them, Adora had to clean her face from tears that morning when she changed them into it. Adora rests her chin on Catra's shoulder, looking at them tenderly.

"Let's have another"

Catra crackles, delighted, her tails tangling around Adora's thigh. "Oh, we are definitely having another"

Everybody sits around the huge tables. Glimmer and Bow next to Catra, Razz, Scorpia and Perfuma next to Adora, chit chatting among themselves with wide smiles, passing each other plates full of food, chatting and telling tales and stories. Magicats and First Ones hand in hand, after so many years of war and hiding, free of calling each other family and friends. Most of the kids are hands deep in the pies, moss and petals on their unruly hairs, multicolor powders smeared on their cheeks and clothes. Scorpia laughs loudly at something Razz says, Perfuma following behind with a persistent blush in her cheeks. Glimmer leans towards Bow and places a soft kiss over his lips, smiling dreamingly at him. Music drums across Camelot, from the far shore of the Downtown, though the castle and the main gate, some people up and dancing joyous and rhythmic around the table, unceremoniously, tripping and laughing and doing it all again. There are ribbons of colors and iridescent magic bubbles floating above their heads, popping in sparkles that fall gently over them. It reminds Adora a little of that first day of the rest of her life, when the air smelled like roses and her clothes were dark and Catra was dressed in red and Adora loved her, she had loved her their entire lives, souls meeting again.

"Look at them" whispers Catra, the tip of her nose brushing in the curve of Adora's ear. "Look at our people, Adora." Catra tilts her head and presses a sweet kiss on Adora's cheek, lips warm and happy against her skin. "They are free."

It's an *I love you* , and an *I'm proud of you,* all of it at once, porting inside Adora's heart as sunlight. Adora turns to look at her, her long eyelashes and starry freckles and it's right there and then that Adora know she would do it all, everything, exactly the same just so they could be right in this place now, holding their baby between their arms, eating Razz's pies, having a life together. A future. Long weeks of rebuilding will be coming their way, of fixing what has been broken, but Adora knows they will be alright.

For the first time, the future is bright.

End of chapter XVI

Chapter 19: Epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Epilogue

My love for you is the sun, the sky, and the moon. It's the air I breathe.

It lives in everything I do.

It's better than good. It 's everlasting.

- Gabby Rivera, *Juliet Takes a Breath*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x

Into the future…

Adora opens their eyes into the purple darkness of the chamber. Something is weird, is the first thing they notice. Is not uncommon for Adora to wake up in the middle of the night. Being by dreams or by a loose foot in the knee, Adora is used to waking up early and going back to sleep almost immediately.

But tonight is weird. There is something odd in the air. Adora blinks quickly a few times, chasing the sleepiness away. Their blue eyes scan the chamber quickly, taking in every aspect of it with their breath held, looking for what made them jolt awake at this hour.

First of all, it is late. Not even dawn, more like deep in the night if the dark blue sky outside has something to say about it. The light of the night moon shines inside their chamber in Halfmoon, showering it gently in purple light. When Adora pays close attention, she realizes it is actually raining, a mildly strong pace that crashes against the roof of the palace, creating a natural lullaby inside the chamber. On the ceiling, the magic constellations twinkle gently, covering the room in a cozy, familiar feeling. It’s warm too, more spring than winter now, even with the rain falling outside.

On their arms, Catra shifts closer to their chest, mumbling a little in her sleep. She’s snuggled as close to Adora as she can, head nestled in their shoulder and extended arm, her arms thrown tightly around Adora’s middle, pressing her body against theirs. Her legs are a bit folded, tangled with Adora’s, and her tail is curled around their right foot so intertwined with Adora that they are almost one breath away from becoming one being. Catra has gotten a liking to sleep like this lately. She likes to rest her growing bump against Adora’s stomach, finding comfort in the feeling of her and the new coming baby being surrounded by Adora’s warm presence and protection. They arrived at Halfmoon a few months ago, determined to relax and enjoy the pregnancy as much as they couldn't do it the last time, spending long hours walking over the bright streets, feet inside the crystalline waters. Catra has been

sleeping a lot lately too, curling in sun spots around the chamber over the day and sleeping tight for the entire night, calm and relaxed, her body slowly accommodating around their new coming baby. Six months into her new pregnancy it's understandable. So, Adora moves as quietly as possible, detangling her arms from her gently so she can lean into her elbows and take a better look of the room.

There is a ruffle sound by Catra's side of the bed and then a tiny voice comes in from the same place, shaky and unsure and dear to Adora's ears.

"Mommy?"

Adora is immediately completely awake, leaning over Catra's sleeping figure to take a better look. Finn is standing on the soft carpet next to the bed, small barefoot feet fidgeting as they ruffle the fabric of their night clothes with their tiny fingers. Their hair is a golden soft mess, sticking into odd angles from where they were lying over before getting up. They are so precious, so little still, almost three years but still the small newborn baby Adora held over their chest for endless weeks after being away for so long. And they look so much like Catra, with soft looking ears pressed against their head, the button-like nose, the soft skin and their fluffy tail held between their little hands. But they have so much of Adora too, like the honey locks falling in soft waves, the pale eyelashes and the blue eyes and that habit of scrunching their nose when they are nervous. Adora loves them so much.

"Finnie?", whispers Adora, unconsciously extending their hand towards them. "What's wrong baby?"

"Mommy", repeats Finn, letting go of both tail and clothes to extend an arm back. Catra's folded ear flickers, taking in the sound of her child's voice right away. She stirs almost a second later, turning from Adora's side a little to peak over her shoulder.

"What happened sweetie?", she asks, speech a bit slurred with sleep. Adora is already up and out of bed, stepping close to Finn and scrunching next to them. Their soft face is a bit red, and there are little tears trapped against their eyelashes. Adora's senses are on high alert, getting closer to their baby's face to take a closer look at them.

"It's alright, darling. We are here", Adora runs her thumbs gently over Finn's face, wiping away the wet tracks of tears from their cheeks. Finn's hands come to hold into Adora's forearms and hand, barely wrapping Adora's finger with how tiny they are.

"Can't sleep" whimpers their child with a low voice, gaze locked into the carpet. Their lip wobbles with contained cry. "Rain"

Adora looks outside of the window and into the restless rain, comprehension drawing inside of their chest. Adora sighs, the kind of relief after seeing her child is scared but fine, completely unharmed. Behind them Catra has rolled towards them, leaning enough so she can boop Finn's nose with her finger.

"Rain won't hurt you, peanut." she says, smiling. When Finn pouts even more, leaning their little head on their mother's hand, she sighs, mismatched eyes flashing on the night light with a loving gaze. "Do you want to sleep with us today?"

Finn nods immediately. Adora shifts her hands down to hold them from the sides and it's then that they realize Finn is carrying that old She-Ra ragdoll below their armpit, the old fabric of its cape a bit worn with time. It has gone through so much, just like them.

"Alright, little *oselotl* . Hop, hop", Adora picks them up swiftly, getting to her feet in one quick motion. Finn snuggles into her side, their weight held over her hip, wrapping their arms around Adora's neck and their little legs around her chest, and they are still so small they don't even circle it completely. They turn together towards the bed, climbing carefully into the mattress and back under the lukewarm blankets.

Adora places Finn gently on the bed and into Catra's extended arms, tucking them with the blankets before slipping inside the bed too. She ruffles Finnie's hair out of their face, tickling their sides with mirth before blowing a raspberry between her child's ears. It works. Finn bursts out in a cheerful laughter, rolling over the mattress as their little honey tail swings from side to side happily, fearful tears long forgotten. Adora giggles with them, burying them into a tight, sticky-sweet hug until Finn starts wiggling impatiently inside her arms, laughing loudly.

"Bunny!" exclaims Finn, still giggling, cuddling around their mom's grown belly and pressing their small ears there. “Bunny, mommy?”

“Asleep” Catra whispers back, caressing the wild curls behind Finn's ears with gentle fingers. Finn buries their face on the side of Catra's baby bump, closing their eyes tightly and concentrating, trying to catch any sound coming from their baby sister. Catra hums a laugh, cradling Finnie's little face between her hands and leaning towards them, brushing a small butterfly kiss over their nose. " *Ni mitz tlazohtla, oselotl."*

Finn giggles, palming lovingly their mom's cheek with their hands, still stained with the paint Adora and them had been playing with in the evening. "I love you too, mommy." Finn hasn't learned how to pronounce the "L's" yet so it comes out rounded and "w" sounded. It makes Catra laugh gently, pressing several tiny kisses all over Finn's little face, throwing them in another fit of laughter.

Finn stretches in the bed like a little kitten and rolls onto their other side, wrapping their little arms around Adora's neck and hugging them close, cuddling against their neck. "I love you, mommy."

Adora hums, hugging back Finn tightly. "And I love you, peanut." Adora starts rubbing circles over their baby's back, soothing away the last remains of tension and nightmares off them. "Now let's go back to sleep. We are going swimming tomorrow, remember?"

"Yes! And bunny! Bunny makes hop hop," mumbles Finn happily, basically already asleep. Adora laughs against their hair, nodding.

"Yes, bunny too. She makes hop hop inside mommy."

They stay in silence for a few, quiet moments, the rain still falling over the rooftop, the magic constellations twinkling, until Finn's breathing evens and they sigh, a clear sign for their moms that they are deeply asleep.

Catra wraps her arm over Finn's little legs and Adora's waist, curling around them with a peaceful hum. Adora looks at her, face calm, partially illuminated by the sparkling stars and the moon light, her golden eye open, staring at Adora with the same lovestruck expression as years before. Adora takes one hand off Finn's sleepy body, running their pale knuckles over Catra's soft cheek.

"How are you two feeling?" Adora whispers, the hint of an everlasting smile on their lips. Catra grins against the pillows, running her other hand gently over the dear curve of her belly.

"We are fine," answers Catra in the same thread of a voice, resting her cheek over Finn's warm back, the fabric of the nightwear tickling her face. "She's been an absolute angel. Except certain someone hugs her," adds Catra, lifting one of her elegant eyebrows in mirth. "that's where the bunny nickname comes up "

Adora grins at her, shrugging innocently. "Guilty of all charges." Adora's hand shifts from Catra's cheek to the base of her nape, rubbing the muscles there. Catra starts purring almost immediately, the calming sound making Adora smile wider and happier, eyes half closed. "Can you tell me her name now?"

"Pff, no way in hell 'Dora, you will have to wait," Catra huffs, rolling her eyes with a cheeky grin. Adora pouts back at her, whining

"It 's too long."

"It's just three months, Adora."

"Exactly," Adora presses their forehead together, Finn and the baby nestled between them. "Not even a little clue?"

"Mmm," Catra hums, nuzzling their noses against each other. "Happiness." Adora's eyes sparkle with life. Catra can see the wheels inside their brain already turning with ideas and thoughts. It makes Catra giggle again.

"I'll figure it out," says Adora, shaking their shoulders happily. Catra rolls her eyes and nestles her head below their chin, closing her eyes.

"I'm sure you will, clotpole."

Adora holds all the loves of their life close, sleep already crawling back under their skin. They are warm and dear and safe and Adora is here, cradling them all between her arms. It's all she has ever wanted. It's the one true, real thing Adora wanted. “No matter what it is, it will be perfect," whispers Adora against the base of Catra's ear, Finn snoring softly in their neck.

“Yes." Catra smiles, letting her eyes fall completely closed. The room smells like roses and lavenders, water flowing outside, the trace of a golden dream in the edges of Catra's mind. "Yes it will.”

Finn sleeps soundly on their mothers' embrace, a gentle, young purr rising on their chest, the sweetest of smiles on their lips. Finn's dreams are filled with multicolored powders, walks over blue moss held to their moms' hands, exploring an amazing secret garden guarded by two old, smiling and wise looking magicat knights. Their dreams are their mommy's laughter and love, raspberries on their belly, lullabies to sleep, excitement to meet their new sister. They are happy.

Adora's dreams are also filled with golden love. There are bad nights, of thrashing around and heavy breathing and nightmares of green arrows cutting the air and black shadows devouring what she loves. But they are fewer now, almost forgotten in the back of her mind. She wakes up every day surrounded by Catra's warmth, the baby moving happily when Adora lowers to press a kiss over Catra's belly, baby Finn draped like a little kitten over Adora's chest. There is no more need for nightmares and self doubt, not with them here.

Catra boops mostly-asleep Adora's nose with her finger, shaking her awake once more softly. "Hey, Adora," she sings songs, smiling.

"Yes, my love?"

"I want chicken"

Adora laughs, crystal clear and free.

❀

This time, when it happens, they are together.

Just as her sibling, she comes early, as if she couldn't wait a second more to be born and live in this world. It catches them off guard at midday, with the sun shining golden and warm through the high windows. Catra thinks it's fitting, that her first child was born under the moon and her second under the sun.

Unlike Finn's birth, which took long beautiful but exhausting hours, she is born quickly, almost as quickly as it started, the sun barely moving over the sky.

Adora is there, of course she is. For the beginning and the middle and the end and the forever. Glimmer and Bow are there too, this time in a different wing of the palace, doing their best to distract a very excited two years old kitten, who is jumping around with their little ears perked up, waiting and waiting with little to none patience to finally meet their sister.

Adora stays with Catra the entire time, just the two of them in their shared room in Halfmoon. She has been reading *a lot,* going on and around mothers and parents in Halfmoon, doing their best to be as prepared as possible. She has the warm water, the clean blankets, the nervous shake that makes her tremble in uncontaminated excitement. Still, nothing really prepares Adora for it. In the end, it becomes instinct driven by love.

Now, Adora is holding a baby in her arms.

She is warm and precious, still damp after the birth, with her tiny, *tiny* ears folded and her even tinier tail curled. She is just like Catra, a little version of the love of Adora's life, with a tuft of dark curly hair peeking out off her blanket and her baby cheeks scattered in starry freckles. The little princess yawns, safe on her mother's arms, born into a softer world, a gentler one. Surrounded by love and devotion.

Adora's eyes mist and her sight swims for a little and it's until she blinks and the gentle tears fall from her cheeks, that she realizes she is crying. In all truth, she has been crying for a while. She cried with Catra, when she started breathing deeply, holding Adora's hand like a life line. She cried when the quietness of the room that had been their safe place as children filled with the sweet sounds of a newborn kitten, chirping from the cotton blankets and Catra's ready hands she had been born into. She cried when Catra cleaned her face and scented her, shushing her lovingly over her sweat damped chest. She cried when Catra handed their daughter to her, all sure hands and loving gazes, her own tears falling from her mismatched eyes. She cried when her baby, *their baby* , settled immediately on her hands, nuzzling into the skin of her collarbones, recognizing the smell of their mother. Adora has been crying for a while.

They sniff, tearing their face from their baby a little and just enough to watch over their wife, resting in the newly changed and fresh blankets and pillows the midwives had carefully and quietly changed her into, looking over both of them with a drowsy and enamoured gaze of her own.

Catra's eyes shimmer when Adora notices her looking and she blinks, slowly, a gentle smile stretching on her lips. She looks beautiful, soft and bright and exhausted too, warmed pleasantly by the sunbeams entering the colorful windows. Adora cradles the side of Catra's cheek, smiling through the crystal tears, still holding the swift weight of their daughter against their neck. Catra tangles their fingers together, squeezing softly, an unspoken *I love you* between them, and *I'm here, we are finally here,* and *I'm not going anywhere.*

Finn will burst in the room any time now, hopping over the stones excitedly, climbing the side of the bed next to Catra's face gently, careful even as young as they are of not jumping over their mom, leaning over the edge to take a long, joyous look at their sister's face.

They will be together.

They will have their entire life ahead of them.

…And ever after

x x

Adora stands in front of the long rows of *Avalon's Trinkets and Library* , scanning with her eyes the names of the beautiful titled books, tucked one after the other in the long wooden rows across the place.

The library is huge, with tinted windows and high, oh so high ceilings of stone and an open dome to the sky in the middle, drawing a perfect circle of light exactly over a worn out

circular wood table, untouched by time, quiet, keeper of secrets, the reminder of a story and a legend long ago forgotten by time. Like this, roads and roads of books aside, it almost looks like the remains of a castle, preserved in a bubble of time by the books that live inside its walls.

Adora's ponytail swings from side to side as she reads the long and beautiful written titles of the books, looking without really searching for something. She has been here countless times since she arrived in the old town, back at the beginning of the month, drawn to its stone walls like a magnet. At the start, she used the excuse of wanting to look for search material for her class, but with time she stopped putting an excuse for herself to swing every evening here and spent a good amount of hours of the sunset just reading and watching.

Many people didn't understand Adora when she announced she wanted to move down here, away from the shining city, even when Adora had talked about the town without stopping since she found out about its existence when she was barely a teen. After all, why would a young and promising architect graduate decide to drop off any expensive and luxurious opportunity to move all the way here to become a cartography and history teacher.

Adora scoffs a little at the memory, shaking her golden head from side to side. She had lived full of doubts and the overwhelming sense of guilt over her shoulders because of it, no matter how supportive her friends and family could be. She was afraid of making a mistake, always, that they were right and she was wasting her life and her degree in nothing. That's it, until she set foot for the first time in the long paths of Avalon's streets, until she placed her eyes over the old but well loved houses and ancient trees, until she entered the heavy doors of Camelot University of Arts, Science and Literature and Adora's heart bursted alive with the sense of familiarity and happiness. Like an old friend, like spending years apart from home and suddenly thinking *I'm here.* And from that day on, Adora knew she had made the right choice.

Adora blinks the away mist of her daydreaming, caressing the back of a beautiful red book. It's nestled between many other books and unlike the others, it's much more simple, without swirls of gold in the spine or golden rimmed pages. It looks old, maybe the oldest thing in the entire place, with fragile looking pages, yellowed by time and by many reads. It's a simple thing and yet Adora feels a pull from the bottom of her heart, as strong as the feeling of coming to the town and of every other decision she has taken just to be here, right on this point in her life.

Adora exhales, taking the book between her fingers and towards her chest. The cover is a bit bent in the edges, with a single panther and a dragon carved in the material by a fine and expert hand. It has no title, no letters that may say what it is about yet Adora is absolutely and completely sure that, once she opens it, it will tell her the greatest story that there may be.

On the inside of her red cardigan, her phone vibrates once and dings with a sweet *ping,* the answer to the message she had sent to her mom earlier before entering the library. She has plans to go have breakfast with Mara and Hope next Saturday, when they come downtown to visit Adora and her new small house close to the strawberry and roses fields.

Adora is completely absorbed by the book, mind gone white and numb and far away, to a time her mind doesn't remember but her soul does, as she stares at it, her fingers hovering

just a little in the corners, gathering some kind of strange courage to open it. Adora is so distracted by it, she doesn’t even hear her arriving.

"There you are"

Adora turns her head to the side, surprised. The voice is clear and loud, a little bit squeaky in the edges and it rings happily and almost relieved. Adora squints behind the delicate golden frame of her glasses, catching sight of the person walking towards her. Adora gasps

The owner of the voice fits it perfectly. She is a young woman, around Adora's age, with a wild mane of dark locks and the softest skin. She is wearing high waisted black cargo pants and a red crop top without sleeves and her movements are like watching a panther, silk and elegant. And her eyes, her eyes are mesmerizing, turquoise and golden digging themselves inside Adora's and making a home on her heart.

Adora holds her breath, unable to speak or even breath, just looking as this beautiful apparition stops right before her, no sense of personal space on sight, raising to her tippy toes so she can see Adora right in the eyes. The woman studies Adora for a second, eyes serious and then something in her expression shifts and brightens, a beautiful, crooked smile widening in her red lips, robbing Adora of their heart completely.

"Well, hello there" says the young woman, chuckling under her breath, as if they were sharing some kind of private joke. Adora blinks at her, head void of any thought. There are tiny drops of multicolor paint on the girl's pants. Maybe she is a painter. But then again, there is also a tiny guitar pin in her belt. So, a musician. And if the NASA badge with a star embroidered in the pocket of her pants has anything to say, maybe she is an astronomer. Maybe she is all of them. How amazing is each one of those? How amazing must she be, in anything she does?

"Hi," finally gasps out Adora, her cheeks turning pink, she doesn’t even notice she has dropped the book into the soft carpeted floor. The woman laughs again, her own face warming in a pretty flush, and she extends one of her hands, catching a loose strand of Adora's ponytail and placing it gently behind Adora's red ear.

Adora looks at her, they can't stop looking at her. She looks so *familiar* in a way Adora can't even begin to describe. Her heart is going crazy inside her chest as if the organ had been parted in two and was just now meeting, finally, its other half.

"I'm sorry, have we met before?" The woman smiles, wide and happy, she looks so happy, it's warming every single cell and organ and spark inside Adora's body.

"Maybe we have," answers the woman, shrugging, like it was the easiest thing. "Maybe, in another time. In another life."

Adora just keeps looking at her and finally, nods. Yes, they have. It's logical. It's destiny. And yet-

"I don't know if that's possible," says Adora, already falling in love.

"Why?" asks the beautiful woman, a little sadly, her eyes watering just a bit.

"Because I would never be able to forget you, no matter what."

The woman's eyes widen in pleasant surprise and she laughs out loud, her eyes wrinkling adorably. "Then I guess you just need to remember me, dummy"

The woman moves a little and it makes the light of the sun entering the high windows to catch in her collarbones, making something twinkle. Adora notices a delicate golden necklace around her neck and, hanging from it, the silver surface of a beautiful ring with the stone shaped as a half moon sparkling. Adora has seen it before, it was displayed on the counter of the library some weeks ago, on the same wooden box right next to a beautiful golden pin that the owner insisted for Adora to have and that since then has been held securely on her clothes, right above her chest.

"Free of charge," the old man had said, smiling. "It's yours"

The young woman should have gotten it there too, maybe in the same strange but right way.

The latter catches the direction of Adora's eyes and hums, bringing her hand towards her neck to fumble with the chain's lock. Adora opens her mouth, wanting to ask what is she doing but she bats her hand towards her and finishes untangling the necklace from her neck, taking the delicate ring from it and leaning once again towards Adora.

"I think this is yours," she says before taking Adora's hand in hers. Her skin is warm, and again, so much familiar Adora immediately tightens their hold, never wanting to let her go. The woman smiles up at her and then focuses again, slipping the ring right in Adora's finger. It fits perfectly.

She hums, satisfied, turning her attention back to Adora's face. One of her hands comes up, the one that is not holding Adora's, and taps over the surface of the golden pin twice, her lips turning in cheekily.

"And I think this is mine"

Adora sighs, tangling blindly their fingers together. "Yes," and then a little louder with more conviction. "Yes"

Adora lets go of her hand -it's hard- and tears her eyes from hers -even harder- to fumble clumsily with the clasp of the pin. Their hands are trembling making them feel slightly embarrassed but the woman just giggles, wholeheartedly and any apprehension leaves Adora's body. Adora leans towards her chest and clasps the little wing over her shirt, right above her heart, and Adora tries to tamper down the way this beautiful woman's heartbeat seems to peek up, fast as a hummingbird, mirroring Adora's own.

Adora leans back, letting their hands fall back on their sides, fingers twitching, wanting only to go back and embrace her in her arms. The pretty girl taps the warm surface of the pin, smiling softly and happily, and returns her eyes back to Adora's face, sighing.

"I'm-"

"Catra," interrupts Adora and, yes, *yes,* she knows it's right. She *knows* it, it's carved in the strings of her heart. Of course Adora knows her, she is her entire heart. Adora's eyes welled up with tears, falling freely over her cheeks and her voice trembles with the emotions overflowing her heart. " *Catra.* My Catra"

Catra smiles once again, her own tears falling down her stunning eyes. She is beautiful. "Adora"

Of course she knows their name too, is the only thing Catra has ever been sure of. Just Adora.

Adora laughs, wet and happy, not even bothering to clean the drops from their face before stepping into Catra's space, their arms coming up to rest over Catra's hips, the motion sure but respectful, arms barely brushing the skin of her sides. Catra turns even redder, moving her own hands up so they can cradle Adora's face, rubbing circles over their cheeks. Adora tilts their head just a little to the side, pressing a single fluttering kiss over Catra's palm before nuzzling inside her embrace, looking at Catra with silver and blue eyes swimming in love.

"May I kiss you?"

Catra's pupils blow up but she chuckles, stepping even closer to Adora. "So formal," she says, rolling her eyes softly, without a bite. Then she looks at Adora again, from between her eyelashes and nibbles at her lip shyly before nodding, booping their noses together. Her voice is barely a whisper, only meant for Adora to hear. "You may"

Adora presses their lips against Catra's without a single more doubt. She is warm. Her lips taste like cherry chapstick and early morning coffee and Adora has to swallow back a happy whimper when she sighs against their lips. She feels small on Adora's hands, a head or less shorter, but at the same time Adora feels her everywhere from the roots of their hair to the tips of their toes. The hands that hold her face shift, making her head tilt just a little to the side and it's the perfect angle for Catra to soothe the skin of her lip with her tongue. Adora's breath dies, given away entirely for this amazing girl in their arms. Everything. Anything for her.

And *wow.* Adora loves her. She loves her. She loves her. She loves her. Adora will say it, scream it, sing it to the world again and again. Adora is in love and she loves her.

And Catra loves her too.

They part from each other with a sigh, bumping their foreheads together as they recover their breaths. Catra looks at her from behind her eyelashes and Adora can see the twinkle of joyful tears stuck on them. When Catra brushes her thumbs over Adora's cheekbones, she feels the run of tears on her own face.

Catra leans to press one more butterfly kiss on Adora's lips and then tangles their fingers together, pulling them along.

"Come on," she says and her voice is carved with laughter.

Adora giggles in return, letting herself be guided by her heart. They sprint together across the rows and rows of books and towards the end of the library, the book Adora had grasped lying forgotten on the carpet floor. That's alright. They will come back later, together, and Adora will pick up the book again. There they will find the copies of beautiful maps and illustrations, done by an expert hand that knew those passages by memory. There will be letters, written by regents that loved each other more than anything. And there will be stories, done by their children and the children of their children, bringing back to life a Kingdom that is now only a fairytale. But it was real, it had been real for them. And they will remember.

But not today. Today is for them as it will be from now on until the world stops spinning and the stars fall from the sky and even then, they will love each other, souls in stardust.

They pass the counter in the main room in a rush and Adora has barely time to turn her head to the side and exclaim a goodbye to the owner.

"Bye, Mr. Emrys!"

The old man looks at them from behind his glasses, his hair long and very, very white, wrinkles all over his face. He smiles, a little bit mysterious and a little bit sneaky and nods, waving them seemingly uninterested with his hand.

"See you later, majesties"

Adora gapes at him, confused, but Catra is pulling from her hand again, more insisting than before, tugging until they are both in front of the crystal door. Catra grabs the copper door knob and turns it, without opening, spinning to look at Adora with happiness written all over her face.

"Where are we going?" asks Adora, out of raw habit, a habit that she doesn't remember having but that is there. It doesn't matter anyway, Adora would follow her anywhere, to the ends of the very earth.

Catra beams at her, smile crooked. Adora wants to kiss her again.

"To the rest of our life, Adora"

Adora smiles back, the edges of their silver eyes scrunched with joy. "I think I will like that"

Catra snorts, laughs, raises to her tippy toes and kisses Adora in the mouth again. The future is bright.

"Of course you will, clotpole"

Catra opens the door of the library and they step together outside, into the golden light of the spring afternoon. It's a sunday. The air is warm, the sky clear, their love great.

It feels like magic.

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one last song x

Chapter End Notes

And that's it. Thank you, thank you, thank you so much for being here. Thank you for your support, being quiet or loud. Thank you for all your comments, I read them all even if sometimes I can't answer them all, they are all always with me.

I hope this little story helped you and helps you in. I hope you feel you have a place to go, a place where you belong. Even if you don't think you do, you'll always have a place here, inside the woods of Camelot AU. Remember that even if you feel like it, you are not lost and you are not alone and you are loved. You will always be loved, you will always deserve be loved and you will be worth it ")

Translation:
Ni mitz tlazohtla, oselotl (from the Nahuatl): "I love you, jaguar"
Oselotl (from the Nahuatl): "Jaguar"

Adora and Catra's second baby name is Yali Ameli (Ameyaltzin as a reverential form). From the Nahua tongue, Yali means "happiness" while "Ameli" means "spring of water"

Got a questions without answer? Leave it below! I'm thinking of doing a Q&A chapter with all the questions left you may have, so don't be shy to ask!

Love you all ") Be good!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!